How to fly

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How to fly

by LLSwrites

Summary

Midoriya Izuku has seen a lot of awful shit. But when he stumbles across a Pro Hero trying to assault a woman, he discovers that he doesn't have to simply watch as the bad things in the world pass him by. He can prevent it, and he will, if it's the last thing he does.

or

Deku becomes a vigilante who doesn't always do what's right, but what's necessary.

Notes

THIS FIC IS INSPIRED BY: Viridian, the green guide. (If you know the author's name, please comment so I can make sure they get the proper credit for their beautiful work!)

The tags contain spoilers down the line

TW warnings in advance: Mentions of SA (not written but heavily mentioned), mentions of assault and abuse (explicitly written), gore, suicidal behavior/ideation, child abuse, emotional abuse, light homophobia.

The plot for this fic loosely follows the anime, and I plan to write it to intertwine with the anime at certain points. It might feel a little on the nose, and that's very much intended! Also, this fic is set in Japan with Japanese characters, so please assume that they are speaking Japanese even if I can't write in Japanese. Honest feedback is welcome :) my writing is pretty rusty... lol anyway.

Chapter 1: Not all men are created equal

The cracking of his mother's jaw is a sound so visceral that he is certain he'd hear its echo even in death. For weeks, it was her screams, the sound of wet gasps, or the jangle of a key. But today—today it's the sound of her jaw shattering.

He pushes both hands against the closet door, eyes darting to the metal keys Mama had dropped just a few inches from the door crack. She always locks him in here, always assumes the folding doors shut properly, always assumes that he can't see through the small sliver in the door. But if Mama has endure the torture, then he has to see it, has to remember it.

He decides right then and there, with his small fingers sticking through the gap of the door, eager to grasp those keys. He decides right then and there, as thuds sound against the wall, as his mom tries not to scream or cry so he won't hear her. He decides right then and there, as sirens sound down the road from the neighbors calling the cops yet again. He decides then and there, that from this point forward, nobody is going to hurt Mama again.

He never reaches the keys.

It takes an hour before the closet doors gingerly squeak open. He counted every second, quietly pushing against the closet door, silently pleading to get out. But it opens then, and his small body tumbles from inside, his fingers rimmed red and useless. He never hits the floor. Despite her injuries, Mama catches him against her chest, tugs him close.

He wastes no time at all. "I don't want to be here anymore."

Mama tenses, stroking a hand through his dark hair.

"Let's go away. Let's go away, Mama." He grips her shirt, eyes wet. "I don't like when he hurts you."

Mama is usually quiet, but she talks today in a soft whisper despite her ruined jaw. "Okay, baby. Let's go away."

It takes no time to pack their things. They don't have much to begin with. He is tasked with it, stuffing his and Mama's clothes into garbage bags. He ransacks the kitchen for scraps of food, he steals their thick blankets and paper plates. And when he stands in his parents' bedroom, facing the bedside table on his dad's side, he makes sure he is just as quiet as Mama taught him to be when he creaks the drawers open.

He takes his dad's watch, his black tie. He takes his glasses, his ring. He takes his wallet, his car keys, he takes every trace of his dad out of this apartment and stuffs it into the garbage bag. One thought later, and he pulls it all out, filling his pockets instead. Only then does he leave the room, guilt eating away at him, but not an ounce of regret.

Mama is on the landline, whispering into the plastic. He catches only vague hints at where they're going, small pleas for help. He sits and waits until Mama hangs up, and when she turns to him, it's with a lopsided smile.

"What's your favorite color?" she asks him.

He thinks for a moment, watching as she walks to the oven, flips the nobs aimlessly until they click over and over again.

"Green," he says.

Mama smiles. "Midoriya. That means green in Japanese."

She reaches into a drawer, pulls out a wad of aluminum foil. She crumples it, tosses it into the microwave. Then she approaches, crouches down in front of him and strokes a hand down his face.

"I always loved the name Izuku. Do you like it?" she asks. Her jaw moves all wrong, but she talks anyway.

He nods.

"Then that's your name." Mama's eyes turn hard, dark. "If anyone ever asks you what your name is, you tell them that, do you understand me?"

"Yes, Mama."

"And I'll be…" she combs a hand through his hair. "Inko. We'll be the Midoriyas, do you like that?"

Midoriya nods eagerly, and Mama frowns at the curls that bounce wildly.

"We need to go before he comes back." Mama stands, grabs a bag, and hoists it over her shoulder. "We're going to stay with an old friend of mine."

She ushers him to the front door, telling him to stay in the hall while she runs back for something. Midoriya does, tapping his feet to the sound of his Mama pushing buttons on the microwave. She appears a moment later, grabs his hand, and all but sprints down the concrete stairwell.

"Keys?" she asks, catching them when Midoriya tosses them her way. "Don't ever do what I just did, you understand me?"

"Yes, Mama."

She pushes open the front door, tucks a strand of thick hair behind her ear. "You will be smart, smarter than I ever was. You understand?"

"Yes, Mama."

She unlocks Dad's car, helps him inside, and buckles his car seat. There’s a moment of pure silence when she shuts the car door. He’s unaware it will be the last silent moment he has for a very long time. Mama tugs her door open, slips inside. Their eyes lock in the rearview mirror for only a moment, a tear running down her face before she looks away and turns the ignition.

They peel out of the rundown apartment complex quickly, cars honking when Mama jerks in front of them. She keeps driving, only glancing at him for a moment before clicking on the radio. It’s not quick enough.

A loud, window-shattering explosion erupts. Midoriya doesn’t scream; he’s quiet as he turns around in his booster seat. He stares out the back window, bright eyes watching their apartment complex. Smoke fills the air, hot fire raging from the windows. Police sirens rage down the road, fire trucks blare their horns.

Mama turns the radio up. Midoriya turns forward again, and when their eyes lock once more, he smiles. No one will ever hurt Mama again.

Chapter 2: A promise

Chapter Summary

Midoriya does what he can to survice

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya grunts as he shoves a trash can, ignoring the sound of shouting coming from behind him. Trash clatters in the alleyway, blocking his pursuers long enough to get a lead on them. Tourists aren't usually as vigilant as these ones were, so enamored by Tokyo's flashing lights or large Hero population. Typically, it's easier to pickpocket.

"Get back here, you fucking cock sucker!" English is such an expressive language; it's a shame Americans use it for so much hate.

Midoriya whips around a corner, one of the tourists still hot on his heels. He pushes through crowds of people, shouting apologies as they glare or murmur. Cars honk when he dashes across the street. He puts his hand against the hood of one, slides across the metal, and pushes off the frame for a chance at more speed. He's scrawny, but the perks of being scrawny are speed. He might get whooped in fights, but only when he's cornered. So he makes sure he's never cornered.

His backpack rattles with the handful of new wallets he's stolen, bouncing alongside watches, rings, priceless necklaces, and a few phones. He even managed to nab a passport off a red-faced American woman who had a bit too much of an attitude on the bullet train.

Still, the angry tourist pursues.

Not all men are created equal, a hard lesson Midoriya learned at the ripe age of four. It's not his fault that everyone else had to learn it far later than he did. Everyone gets a shitty hand at some point. For example, Midoriya got dealt the Quirkless card, effectively costing him any ounce of humanity or kindness from the world. One stolen wallet or cellphone doesn't equate to a lifetime of doing everything in his power to blend into the background, but it's still an unfortunate situation for the man chasing him. Can you imagine a fate worse than that? Losing your wallet on a multi-thousand-dollar vacation to an overpopulated country with your obnoxious wife and small children who won't even remember the racist comments thrown around the entire trip?

Oh, the terror of it. Poor guy.

Midoriya shoves past a couple enjoying a date, ignoring the pang of jealousy it sparks within him. You'd think he'd be used to seeing lives so different than his own, but he isn't. Try as he

might to ignore it, he knows better than anyone that he is different; he doesn't align with the values of the world.

"Get back here!" The tourist screams at him, huffing and puffing.

Midoriya laughs out, "No thanks!"

He comes across an alleyway and quickly realizes he's pinned himself between a chain link fence and the angry man. Without a thought, he slings his backpack off, tosses it over the fence, and begins to scramble up. He makes his halfway before the man tugs on his red shoe, shouting profanities.

"Sorry, man." Midoriya swings his other leg free, bashes it against the man's shoulder, and scampers up the remaining prongs. He throws himself over the other side, and scoops up his yellow backpack before he takes off again.

He feels guilty, he really does. But he doesn't regret it. Not even a little bit.

Tokyo is a big city, notorious for its tourism and general appeal. It's where the Hero's Commission is based, where yearly Hero stats are released to the world based on performance. Growing up, Midoriya had always dreamed of coming to Tokyo from his small, little apartment miles away from here. He had always wanted to be a Hero, shooting through the sky and taking on bad guys.

And, despite his situation, he's going to achieve that dream. One way or another. He made a promise to protect Mama, and it's one he intends to keep.

It takes several hours to get back home. A few stolen bus passes lead him to a neighboring town, one that doesn't pay much attention to wandering strangers. Midoriya is small, able to blend in, to keep a low profile. He tugs his hood over his curls, tightens a black face mask over his mouth. A spare pair of sweatpants hides the remainder of his middle school uniform. Just like that, he blends into the crowd. His backpack is so dirty with muck from the chase that it's nearly black. It leaves only his shoes as a blinding eyesore, but one glance at them reveals they're nothing special. The only Quirkless shoe makers left, specifically made to accommodate the extra joint in his toe that hints at his fate. Even then, if you didn't know or care about people like him, you'd rarely notice at all.

He slips through the bus stop, moving along a sidewalk until coming across a pawn shop. Midoriya pushes the door open slowly, peering inside to ensure it's empty of customers. Only then does he enter, tugging his bag off once again.

The pawn shop is full of random pieces and objects. The owner's got eclectic taste, but as maximalist as the store is, everything flows together nicely. Mismatched rugs cover the tarnished wooden floors, dozens of random light fixtures are strewn across the walls or dangling from the ceiling, a deer head hangs on one wall, and a photo of a pug in a top hat reigns over the other. It's always a bit too warm, but no one would ever complain.

"My favorite businessman!" An obnoxiously loud man says. He's got a greasy wife-beater with a black jacket layered over it and a shit eating grin. "Haven't seen you in a fat minute,

kiddo."

"Schoolwork," Midoriya says quietly, unzipping his backpack. "I have to study."

"You're going to UA, aren't you?" he asks, resting his forearms against the smudged glass cases he's behind. "Isn't that entrance exam coming up?"

Midoriya nods, fishing around his bag. He's got a good haul today. A lot of people come to the city the closer and closer exam day gets because it's less crowded. Locals typically flock to the school, eager for a peek at the potential new students and future Heroes. As important as it is to study and prep for the entrance exam, it's also important to guarantee he has a place to live during the school year.

So, Midoriya carefully plucks copious amounts of jewelry from his bag, laying them on the glass case for Chikara. His Quirk is an interesting one—metal discernment. Even in a world where lesser Quirks like Chikara are frowned upon, he made something of himself. When it comes to the workforce, Midoriya has given up trying. Nobody hires the Quirkless—nobody who does background checks, at least. He's tried the more hidden population of the world, more than willing to get his hands dirty, but trusting a kid isn't an easy sell.

So he makes due in the way he can.

"Hmm." Chikara plucks up one of the watches. "UA would be a waste for you, kiddo."

Midoriya shrugs his bag back on. "I'm going to be a hero."

Chikara chuckles. "How many heroes do you know with analytical quirks?"

Midoriya had almost forgotten that even people like Chikara don't associate with the Quirkless. So, again, he made due. He got away with the lies about having a Quirk for a little while at school, but… but Kacchan made sure it didn't stay under wraps for very long. It spread like wildfire after that. With 20% of the world's population being Quirkless, it's reasonable to assume they'd just be walking around like regular people. The reality is much darker than that.

He's not stupid. He's seen what happens to people like him. There's a scale of power in this world, and Midoriya knows that, no matter what, he will never be on top of it. So he does his best to work within the confines of it, and even then, it's rarely enough.

"Lots of underground Heroes are analytical," Midoriya says as Chikara examines his haul. "Lots of dirty Heroes, too."

"It pays to be smart," Chikara says. For all his doubts, Chikara believes that Midoriya will make it to UA. They have an unofficial official deal. If Midoriya becomes a hero, then he leaves this side of town alone. As rampant as crime is here, Midoriya has little interest in petty thieves or gang violence.

Heroism isn't about purity. Maybe it was when Midoriya was little, but years as a Quirkless, half black-half Japanese kid will teach you a plethora of things. The world was not created

equal, and whatever idiot said violence cannot be fought with violence was just a dumb as the person who likely killed him. Heroism is about doing what is necessary, and sometimes that isn't always the right thing. He's gotten his hands dirty before; he doesn't mind doing it again.

Memories of a burning apartment and back alley dealings melt into his mind. Mama fought tooth and nail for him, and he's going to make sure she never has to again.

"I'm thinking a couple grand," Chikara interrupts Midoriya's mental turmoil with a weary glance. He must've been muttering. "Your mom still need help with rent?"

Though his face burns, Midoriya nods.

"Four grand should do you good, yeah? Cover rent, maybe a couple bills, and some groceries. I can't do more than that, so don't haggle me, kiddo," he says, already opening his register. "Yeah?"

"Yeah." And Midoriya takes the money eagerly. Chikara is fair with his prices, one of the reasons Midoriya comes to him and not any of the other pawnbrokers. He's one of the few people who don't try and swindle a kid, and one of the few people who don't see race, kudos to him. Midoriya wishes he knew Chikara's stance on the Quirkless, but it's not a risk he's willing to take.

The bell above the door jingles when he pushes it open—

"Hey."

He stops, looks over his shoulder.

"You hear All Might's in town?" Midoriya, despite himself, can't help the way his eyes blow wide. He backs into the store again, earning a laugh from Chikara. "It's all I'm hearing about. But… between you and me…"

"What is it?" Midoriya leans over the counter, eager for any drop of information.

"There's a couple of guys talking about taking him out, some gang down East." Chikara shakes his head. "They're rallying up more and more people, couple of jail breaks too."

"There's no way they can take out All Might," Midoriya argues.

"Hey, I agree with you." Chikara puts his hands up in defense. "But be careful getting home at night, yeah? Never know what psychos are out and angry."

"Yeah."

"See you, kiddo."

It's raining outside, dreary streetlights doing little to light up the path home. Still, Midoriya walks it, rolling his ankle as he goes. That tourist had nearly ripped it off his body. No doubt, it'll leave bruises, but it's a small price to pay. He counted the stolen cash from wallets on his

way over. While people hardly carry cash anymore, it was still enough to make a difference. It's enough for groceries, plus Chikara's payout will cover what Mama misses in rent. For a woman working two jobs with only one child, rent should be reasonable. But their landlord doesn't take kindly to the Quirkless, much less to women who won't sleep with him.

They make do, they always have.

Some days, Midoriya wonders why Mama didn't just leave him behind. It would've been easier, far better for her in the long run. She could've been working a better-paying job, in a better part of town, with a bunch of kids who had more of a potential than he ever did. Instead, she took him along, and while he knows there's no ounce of regret in her heart, he can't help but wonder if she ever wanted… more. More than this, more than him. More than two minimum wage jobs and a kid who is likely to never make it past his teens.

And other days, he resents her for it. Resents her for locking him in that closet, keeping him removed from the torment Dad put her through. Resents her for not keeping him there when she left, letting the fire burn away any trace of her past. Resents her for putting so much work into a new life, but still dooming them to the exact fate they live now. The truth is, she's a good mom, but she's not a good person. Not by the standards bestowed upon the world they live in, not even by herself.

But she's a good mom, a great mom, and Midoriya will not become another number in the dwindling population of the Quirkless and throw away everything she's ever done for him. He just wishes, selfishly, hopelessly, through no fault of her own, that she could've done more.

"Izuku?"

"It's me," he says, slipping his backpack off and hanging it on a hook by the door. His shoes go next, and he barely gets the second one off before she's there, holding his face and kissing his forehead.

"How was school, baby?" she asks, urging him to the kitchen.

She sets a plate of food before him. On the rare days she comes home from work, she insists on cooking for him even when he's told her she doesn't have to. While this is not the domestic life he's sure she imagined, it's impossible to deny that Inko Midoriya is a mother, through and through. Fish and rice, cheap, but something he's always thankful for.

"Good," he says, only a half lie.

It was an exam day, which means he gets to fly through the material, turn it in immediately, and earn so many dirty looks that he knows he's going to get his ass whooped later. But it's worth it if he's honest. Because for a split second, when Midoriya is at the front of the room, turning in his work before anyone else, he remembers what he's doing this all for. To succeed, to get into UA, to become a Hero, to do not what's right, but what's necessary.

And nobody in the world seems to be ready to do what needs to be done. Nobody except—

“All Might’s back in Japan.”

Mama’s fork pauses over her plate, and the elation on her face is hard to miss. “Really?”

“Yeah! He’s finally back from the U.S.”

“That’s—oh, that’s wonderful.” She digs into her fish, smiling brightly. “Maybe you can meet him!”

Midoriya laughs a little. “Come on, Mama, in what world do I meet All Might?”

For some reason, that seems to still her. “I… wanted to talk to you about something.”

Midoriya pauses, “What’s wrong?”

“This whole Hero thing… Are you sure this is what you want?” Mama sets her fork down, takes her hand from her spot across the table. “If you don’t make it into UA—“

“I will—“

“Izuku—“

“Why don’t you think I can do this?” he asks suddenly, and Mama’s eyes blow wide. “Is it because I’m Quirkless?"

“Honey—“

“I’m serious, Mama, why don’t you think I can do this? They lifted the ban against Quirkless kids, my GPA is unmatched—“

“He’ll know.”

He holds his breath to keep from freaking out. They don’t talk about Dad. Ever.

“After everything we’ve been through,” Mama runs a dark hand down her face. “It’s not that I don’t think you can do this—it’s that I know you can. What happens if you become famous or—god forbid—what if he’s been looking for us this whole time?” She squeezes his hand. “I want you to succeed, but the consequences of your success could be your downfall, baby.”

Midoriya slumps. “Am I supposed to just give up on being anything, Mama?”

“No, no.” She pushes his hair from his face. “I know you’ve always wanted this. I just worry about you.”

He stares down at the fish, its bulging eye watching him. “You’ve done a lot of things to… make our lives better. I don’t want you to think I’m being careless with that.”

“I’ve never thought that, Izuku.” Again, she strokes his face, long strands of green hair falling onto her own.

“It’s because of you that getting into UA is so important to me.” And she can’t possibly understand what he means by that, but she nods all the same. “I can… I can talk to… I’ll talk to Kacchan tomorrow and see if I can arrange… You know.”

Mama scrunched her face, her eyes wet. “Thank you.”

“Anything for you, Mama.”

When he shuts off his bedroom light and slips into bed, a pit of dread weighs his stomach down. Today was a good day—he aced his exams, he pawned enough cash, it was supposed to be a good day. But run-ins with Kacchan have always made him nervous. He avoids them at all costs, but he made a promise, and if he wants to keep it, then it involves being more than a little uncomfortable.

Chapter End Notes

So what did we think diva?

Chapter 3: What it means to change

Chapter Summary

TW for this chapter!!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

School is one of the most difficult places to navigate for the Quirkless. Suicide rates for kids like him are so high that it's more common for Quirkless kids to die before adulthood than it is for them to graduate middle school. This is something that he's known since the news first broke about his *unfortunate condition.* Spiderlillies on his desk, razor blades shoved through the slits of his locker, a printout of the newest confirmed suicide. He gets it. If anything, it urges him closer to UA, closer to wanting more. He's beaten the odds once; why not do it again?

Midoriya keeps out of the way for the most part. He doesn't seek out friendships or attention. The few times he's tried have only resulted in public humiliation, and as fast as he is, he can't outrun a school full of people. The day consists of getting in and getting out as quickly as possible, and hopefully, Mama isn't home to see the repercussions of when he isn't fast enough. A good education is what will get him into Hero school, so a good education is what he gets.

Contrary to what everyone at this school was made to believe, Midoriya's horrendous relationship with Kacchan started years before they went to school together. Kacchan's always hated him, as though it's been programmed into the boy's head since birth. Midoriya, on the other hand…

"He should be headed to cafeteria now unless he took a few seconds longer at his locker than usual or maybe he's going to the bathroom but he'd have to go to the first floor because the second floor bathroom is locked but if that's the case then he'd already be in the lunchroom —" a hand grips the collar of his shirt, heat radiating from the fingertips.

Midoriya hardly has a moment to curse himself for getting lost in his own head and mumbling like a maniac before he's slammed into the lockers behind him. His skull rattles off the cheap metal, vision swimming with the force of it. The sound reminds him of Mama's jaw, and suddenly he feels sick to his stomach.

"Are you fucking stalking me?"

He blinks slowly, trying to gather his mind long enough to form a coherent sentence.

“You’ve got about five seconds to answer me before I melt your mouth off your stupid fucking face.”

“Kacchan,” he manages, wincing when his eyes finally adjust and focus on the very irritated boy before him. “I-I wanted to talk to you!”

Kacchan’s eye twitches, a vein popping in his forehead. “You think you’re worth a second of my time, Deku?”

“No!” he says quickly, waving his hands rapidly. “I mean—uh—yes! Well, not really, I just —“ He gasps when Kacchan shoves him against the locker again. “Ow, okay, that one hurt really bad—“

“Shut. Up,” Kacchan says through gritted teeth. “Every single interaction with you gives me a fucking migraine.”

“That’s not good, Kacchan.” His airway closes when Kacchan wraps a hand around his neck, so he squeaks, “You should get that checked out.”

“Do you think I won’t kill you, Deku? You and your smart mouth can rot in hell for all I care.”

It hurts, it makes his chest ache and his eyes water, but he talks anyway.“I need your help.”

“Like I’d ever fucking help—“

“Auntie… Mitsuki…”

Kacchan lessens his grip enough to get a large gulp of much-needed air down. “What the hell are you talking about?”

Midoriya doesn’t mention that he had been trying to tell him before Kacchan literally choked him out. Instead, he grips Kacchan’s wrists that still hold him against the locker, hoping to leverage himself in case he’s thrown or choked again. Kacchan stares at their connecting skin, lip curling.

“I need to talk to her about Rin.”

Kacchan drops him, just like that. Before he can right himself, he’s taking a knee to the stomach and kicked to the hard floor. Lunch has already started, not that it matters if anyone were around to see. Nobody would stop this anyway. Part because Kacchan is horrifying, and part because Midoriya is not worth helping.

“Let me get this right,” Kacchan says, pushing against Midoriya’s arm until he’s rolled him from his fetal position. “You think, after so many years of blissful silence from you, my mom wants to deal with your stupid ass?”

Midoriya clutches his stomach. “This isn’t about—“

“I know what this is about, moron!” Kacchan grabs the collar of his shirt again, yanks him halfway off the ground. “This is about my family cleaning up your fucking mess again.”

His heart sinks. Very few people in this world know about Midoriya’s past. In fact, only four other people do. Mama, Kacchan’s parents, and Kacchan himself. In an effort to get away from his Dad, Mama called her old friend she lost connection with years before the abuse got as bad as it did. Mitsuki Bakugou, who uprooted her entire life to accommodate a friend she hadn’t heard from in years, was the woman who answered the phone.

For about a year, he and Kacchan shared a room, Mama slept on the couch, and things worked for a while. It was weird, but it was weird in a way that worked.

Until it didn’t.

“What is Rin going to do to you this time, huh?” Kacchan spits at him. “Your teeth? Your voice?”

Midoriya shuts his eyes. “I don’t know yet—“

“Oh, fuck you!” Another blow to the stomach, and Midoriya holds down last night's dinner. “You can change your hair and your eyes, but you can’t change what you *are*. And you are fucking pathetic.”

“I—“

“Say it.” Kacchan smiles, “Go on, say it, Deku.”

His lips tremble. “I-I’m pathetic.”

Kacchan’s eyes flicker, and Midoriya takes the chance to again grab his wrist to steady himself. The second he makes contact, he’s thrown backwards, recoiling off the ground. It hurts, his body aches and sings with pain, but he endures it all the same.

“The only reason I’m allowing this is because charity work looks great on a resume.” Kacchan stares down at him, daring him to try and stand up. “Find me after school. If you so much as whisper a word of this to anyone—“

“You’ll kill me,” Midoriya says quietly.

Kacchan says nothing more, just spits on him before he turns and leaves. For a long while, Midoriya sits there and debates whether or not it’s worth it to get back up again. For all his taunting, Kacchan has never told a soul the truth about that night, and it’s a truth that’s always held a shadow over their relationship.

Midoriya was born… different. And not just because of his lack of a Quirk, but because he was literally born *different.* Mitsuki Bakugou is a renowned fashion designer with her own modeling agency. She’s wildly successful, rich, talented, all traits passed to her son. But before she was that, she was Mama’s best friend. Mama used to tell him stories about her when he was little. A fierce and loyal friend, someone abrasive yet extroverted, a friend who saved Mama from bullies or gossip.

And powerful friends lead to powerful allies. Mitsuki hired a woman by the name Rin to help models temporarily fit a different narrative. She's since quit and moved to bigger things, but there was a time when Rin did her first permanent work as someone with a DNA splicing and altering Quirk. Midoriya and Mama had black hair, dark as night. Mama's eyes were a soft brown, but Midoriya wasn't so lucky, stuck with Dad's deep, red eyes. So Rin changed it. Permanently. Alongside scars and their ears, Mama's cheekbones and their fingerprints. Illegal modifications, but something to make them new, make them unrecognizable.

From there, new people were born. Mama did most of the work, but Auntie funded it. New social security, new IDs, new passports. There was no line that wasn't crossed to separate the new from the old, and what was left of them burned to ash in that apartment miles away.

But one thing Rin couldn't do was give him a Quirk. The lie lasted until Midoriya told Kacchan the truth one summer night.

Mama had them packed up and moved out the next day. She hasn't talked to Auntie since that night. She doesn't blame Midoriya; he was so young. But for nights, he could hear her crying, and he'd think about where they'd be if he just kept his mouth shut.

He feels his hair, green. He blinks his eyes, green. And he wonders what else is going to have to change for him to become a Hero. Rin's work hurt when he was younger , he can't imagine what it'll be like now. And with something more structured, like his nose or jaw. The thoughts terrify him. But he promised Mama he'd keep her safe, and he doesn't break his promises.

Kacchan is easy to find when you know him as well as Midoriya does. He's leaning against the brick wall of the back of the school, as far away from everyone else as possible. He doesn't want to be seen with Midoriya, and that's alright. Midoriya doesn't blame him; he wouldn't want to be seen with himself either. But for a moment, he stands there, staring at Kacchan with his explosive hands dug deep into his pockets.

What would it have been like if he had never told him the truth that night? Would Mitsuki have kicked his Mama out? Would they be friends still? Would he lie and tell them all he had some lower-level Quirk and lived a life with no bruises and broken bones?

Does Kacchan ever think about it?

When he snaps out of his daze, Kacchan is already looking at him. Eyes narrowed, a permanent scowl on his face, there's nobody in the world who has ever looked so disgusted by him.

"Walk behind me. Don't talk to me. And if I hear one muttered word from your mouth, then you can find Rin on your own."

Midoriya furrows his brows. "We aren't going to Auntie for help?"

Kacchan blinks slowly. "The fuck did I just say?"

Midoriya purses his lips and mimes zipping them and throwing Kacchan the key. Kacchan doesn't so much as blink before turning back around and marching away.

For the record, Midoriya didn't talk for a while. He counted five minutes before the words in his chest built up so much that the pressure was unbearable.

"Did you know All Might is back in Japan?"

Kacchan lets out a long, pained sigh.

"He wasn't supposed to come back so soon! I've got a few guesses as to why but don't you think it's so bizarre how he hasn't made any official statements? I looked into it last night and it turns out that nobody knows. It's almost like he'a trying to keep it a secret! But why would All Might do that? The world's number one Hero trying to sneak around Japan? Maybe something happened in America, or maybe—"

"Deku, do you want to learn what it feels like to have your tongue torn out of your throat?"

"Not really." Kacchan turns his head and Midoriya swallows. "Sorry."

"Keep being a smart ass, I fucking dare you." It's silent again for a long time. When it's broken, it's a shock that it's by Kacchan. "Why do you need Rin anyway?"

Very rarely does he ask questions, let alone questions about Midoriya. He's never cared enough, or he's smart enough to figure things out pretty quickly. Kacchan doesn't ever reveal his hand. As hot-headed as he is, he's good at piecing things together without anyone knowing.

"All Might is back in town," Midoriya says softly. "He always announces his presence or makes a show to let people know they're safe. But this time, he doesn't want anyone to know."

Kacchan let out a low laugh. "And I'm assuming this is something one of your buddies told you? Given it's not in the news."

Midoriya hesitates. It's true. There was a mention of an eyewitness account of someone being saved, but Chikara didn't mention that. Unfortunately, it's people who are subjected to the worst parts of life that often learn crucial news first. Chikara has connections that Midoriya prefers not to think about, but every time he's told him something, it's turned out true.

He's unsure if Kacchan is mad that he has these connections, or because he found out about All Might first. Competitive, hot-headed, but cynical and intelligent. It was hard to navigate when they were younger, and as much as he had wished it would get easier, he knows better now.

"And I'm guessing," Kacchan stops to turn to him. "You learned the information while doing something extremely legal and morally correct?"

Midoroya's face burns, but he confesses, unashamed, "We needed to make rent."

Kacchan faces forward again, keeps them walking down a dirty sidewalk. “So you hear a rumor and run with it, sounds like your stupid self.”

“I won’t risk anything happening to Mama.”

Suddenly, he whirls. Midoriya catches his breath in time before he’s slammed up against the outside of a random house. It hurts worse than the school lockers, but a little pain is worth it.

“After this is done,” Kacchan hisses, hands hot, begging to burn. “Never talk to me again. Never mention my mom again. After this, we are strangers, do you understand?”

He grabs his wrist, feet dangling. “Strangers. G-Got it.”

Kacchan releases him with a shove before gesturing to the house. “We’re here.”

Rin has moved homes since Midoriya last saw her. She used to live in a big, pink house that she absolutely adored. Blue shutters, flowers adorning every inch of grass. The house he stands at now is a far cry from that beautiful home. Rotted wood, shattered and boarded up windows, cigarette buds and alcohol bottles strewn across the grass. If anyone knew Rin before she left the modeling agency, they never would’ve seen these living conditions coming.

But permanent body modifications are illegal, and once you start something, it’s impossible to stop. He blames himself for her downfall; he started it. But he never expected this much fallout. She was wealthy, successful, she was *something.* Her dream was stolen from her; does she blame him, too?

Kacchan doesn’t say goodbye. By the time Midoriya turns to thank him or apologize for again dragging him into his troubles, he’s already gone.

So, now alone, he knocks on the front door. It doesn’t open for a while, so he knocks again, and it swings wide. He jumps back instinctively when a large baseball bat comes swinging for his head. He’s not so lucky the second time when the wood collides with his shin. He yelps and hits the concrete steps to the door at full force, cradling his newest injury.

“I told you to leave me alone!” A deep, trembling voice shouts. When he looks up, he sees her, baseball bat held high over her head and ready to swing.

“Wait!” Midoriya holds his hand out, braces for the blow. “Wait! Please! I-It’s me! Midoriya Izuku.”

A moment, and then the bar is lowered with a gasp. “Holy fuck.”

“Rin—“

“It held!” She drops to her knees, and he’s hit with the stench of pot and lack of hygiene. “I knew it would! I knew it! They all said the color wouldn’t stay, but I told them it would!”

“What?” he asks, patting her back when she leans in and hugs him tight. She’s dirty, grimy, living in horrific conditions. But there was a time when Rin had it all. So for the woman he

used to know, he holds her close.

“The green,” she cries, holding his face in her palms. “I made you green.”

Midoriya gives a shaky smile. “Y-Yeah, you helped me and my Mama.”

Rin stands then and tugs him to his feet. She mutters an apology for his leg and helps him limp inside. The inside of her home is an eclectic mess. Most of the furniture she had years ago is stuffed into the small space, crammed full of colors and textures. It’s as if she kept everything she had before moving away, even if it didn’t all fit. Pinks and oranges and red are a reminder of her former glory. He spots chairs stacked on couches stacked on coffee tables. Hundreds of makeup bags torn up and strewn about. Dirty clothes tossed carelessly around.

Still, he can see glimpses of her that have ingrained themselves into his brain since childhood. A spinning makeup artist chair, a rack of clothes and costumes, handmade quilts and knitted blankets. What happened to her?

“It’s not much,” she says softly, scratching the back of her head. “This is all I got.”

“What happened, Rin-senpai?” He crouches down to a torn shirt, tugs it free. She wore this when he first came to her years ago. All Might merchandise. He can barely see it in the darkness of her home. When was the last time she had the funds to pay for electricity?

“I uhh—I learned my Quirk could be used for more than quick fixes and ran with it,” she laughs humorlessly. “What a fucking mess, huh?”

“I can help fix it,” he offers, standing again. “Clean it up a bit.”

“Ah,” she slumps down into her spinning chair, basked in the flickering lights of what used to be a lovely vanity. “No it’s… it’s alright, kid.”

Midoriya offers a small smile. “Are you sure?”

“Yeah… uhh—what did you need?” She pushes off her stool and approaches.

Her usually upkept appearance has withered, likely a side effect of overusing her Quirk on herself. Her voluminous blond hair has dropped limp and muted. Her bright blue eyes have returned to their natural, sad brown. Her entire face sags with an age she has yet to reach. She looks, genuinely, awful.

“Your color held pretty well.” She again takes his face in her hands, turns his head to the side. “Ears maintained shape.”

“You remember?" he asks.

“I remember every single client,” she confesses, before gently grasping his hands and lifting them to her. “Fingerprints kept form.”

“Everything you altered held up. Even when my hair grew out, it stayed green.” Again, a small smile. “I was hoping you could alter me a bit more, actually.”

Rin chuckles softly before moving away. “Nobody ever asks me for help anymore.”

“Why is that?” he asks.

She grips the back of her chair, looks into the vanity mirror. Her eyes are bloodshot, and her shoulders slump with an invisible weight.

“I killed a kid.”

Midoriya's heart drops to his feet. “What?”

“It was an accident, I swear.” She shakes her head. “I altered a bone, she fell on it mid growth, and that’s that.”

He stayed quiet.

“Goodbye job, goodbye house, goodbye everything.” Her jagged nails drum against the chair. “I helped a few people before it all came crashing down, but… You know. Illegal Quirk usage mixed with child murder? I didn’t really stand a chance after that.”

“I’m sorry,” he murmurs, toeing the ground. “You ran?”

“I had the choice to run away and live in a shithole, or stay and get thrown in jail, aka a shithole. But they would’ve cuffed me with those Quirk suppressors… so…” She shrugs. “I followed those stupid laws against Quirks like mine, and then they just kept cracking down on it. No permanent work. No bone alteration. No DNA alteration. No me. Not being able to use it was driving me insane. Could you imagine a jail full of people like that? On the brink of losing their minds because some assholes decided our Quirks were wrong?”

He can’t imagine that because he’ll never know that feeling. He knows that his mom would get hand cramps unless she regularly used her Quirk, he knows that Kacchan would accidentally set things ablaze or blow holes into objects if he went too long without using it. He knows that pressure builds within you, and suppressing a Quirk could be catastrophic. Some Pros would go weeks without usage so they could unleash the pent-up power in one foul swoop on missions.

But he’ll never know that feeling. He’s come to terms with it, but it doesn’t change the restlessness inside him. The urge to be more, to do more. To be something he’s never really had sight of.

“I don’t blame you,” he tells her. Because one thing he can relate to is a lifetime of being told you're wrong for just being born different. “I’m sorry this happened to you.”

She waves him off and turns around. “What do you want to change?”

Midoriya hesitates. When he doesn’t answer immediately, Rin begins to suggest things. The bridge of his nose, the structure of his jaw, the shape of his teeth, the curve of his lips. It occurs to him then that he doesn’t really want to change anything at all. He doesn’t think he’s attractive by any means, but he’s begun to like his face. Plain, freckled, easy. A face born to blend into the background.

“Here.” She swiped off her vanity of its clutter. “Sit, let me do my work.”

So he does.

He lets her trail her fingers along his skin, adjusting his appearance in micro touches. Hot pain shoots through him occasionally, but it vanishes quickly. Despite how long it’s been and how little he truly knows Rin, he doesn’t fear this. So he lets her work, lets her fingers create something new, something different.

“You’re going to UA still?” she mumbles, dragging her fingers along his brow. He hums his answer. “You’re wasted there.”

He swallows. “What do you mean?”

Rin whistles a little tune. “It never sat right with me, even before things began to change so much. Grooming children to become government loyal killers?”

He frowns. “Not all Heroes kill; it’s illegal.”

Rin outright laughs. “When has the law ever stopped those with power?” She muses his hair. “The only difference between Heroes and Villains is the media coverage, kid. Just another bunch of little boxes to shove human beings into to determine their worth.”

“You really believe that?” he asks, his heart heavy.

“What I did for you and your mom, that was heroic, I think,” Rin says thoughtfully. “But what I did to that little girl—that was the worst thing I’ve ever done. In the eyes of a Hero, I’m a Villain.”

“B-But it was an accident.”

“How many innocent people do you think get by on the idea of accidents?” Rin asks him before dropping her voice to a whisper, “How many accidents have you been chastised for?”

Nine and a half years ago, Mama had begged Rin to get rid of the extra joint in his foot. Any and all proof of Quirklessness could vanish without that stupid bone. But Rin had refused. Her words have ingrained themselves in his mind for years.

There is no amount of change that can alter what you really are. The color of our skin, the way we sound, the position we hold ourselves, an extra joint in the toe.

And he had cried, had taken his shoes and socks off and outright begged. He’s not grateful that Rin refused, but he is grateful for the lesson she taught him.

No matter what, Izuku Midoriya, you will always be Quirkless.

“Done!”

He turns to the mirror, stares into it, and his eyes widen. “What… did you do?”

The darkness that once captured the room has lifted. Within it, he can make out shapes that were previously lost to the dim lighting. Smells slowly waft in, rotten wood and makeup remover the most prominent. But he never could've smelt this before, never could've seen this before.

She… altered his vision. His sense of smell. And as a car whizzes by on the street outside, he discovers she altered his hearing, too.

"I gave you more rods within your eyes. It's a photoreceptor—"

"—That's highly sensitive to low light—you—you gave me night vision?!" He whirls, eyes wide. "That's amazing!"

Rin smiles sweetly. "You'll need every advantage you can get."

He throws himself forward, yanks her into a teary-eyed hug. He never knew she could do this, but altering the genetic components of his DNA could easily make his eyes adaptable to a low-lit environment. He has no idea what impact this'll have in the daylight, but he's not too sure he cares. He has fucking night vision!

Why is it so wrong for her to do this? To help people? How many blind could she cure? How many cleft lips could she restore? How many cancer cells could she eliminate? Why did a government that never met her determine how her life could be lived?

"I'm glad… I got to help someone again." She wipes her own tears before pulling away.

"Let me help you," he says, grasping her hands. "We can sell some of this stuff, make a few grand. We can get you back on your feet—you can get a job like this underground—"

"Kid—"

"Me and Mama can take you in, if you'd like! Our couch is so insanely comfy. And you won't need to pay rent or—"

"No."

He shuts up, catches his breath. "No?"

"No… I… I've made my bed, I'll lie in it." She pushes his curls from his face. "I've already had a few guys come by and try to save me from all this shit. It's not… it's okay."

He furrows his brows. "I don't understand?"

Rin sighs, looks around. "There's no point anymore. I've lived my prime, you know? You… you're gonna be something. But I'm done. I've hit my peak. Sometimes it's best to know when to give up."

He squeezes her hand. "Things can change."

She gives him a gentle smile. “You sound like… ah, what’s the guy's name?” She waves a hand. “There’s this group of low-lifes East of here that are sprouting the same shit.”

East? Hadn’t Chikara mentioned a gang in the East forming against All Might?

“Some of them stopped by here, trying to recruit people. A couple of rough-looking guys. They almost had me convinced this league-thing they were forming was a good idea.” She pulls her jacket tight. “If Hero school doesn’t work out, or you and your mom need some place to go. Head East, there’s some kind of abandoned building that’s taking freaks like us in.”

“Will you go?” he asks.

Rin stares off at her pile of furniture. “I thought about it.”

“And?”

Again, that delicate smile. “I’m really happy I got to use my Quirk again—that I got to see you at all.”

Midoriya nods. “I’m happy too, Rin.”

“Then I guess I’ll see you when you’re a Pro.”

“I guess you will.”

It’s sunset when he leaves her small little house. Despite the darkening sky, he can see just fine. He’s not sure he’ll ever get used to this, if he’s honest. He wonders if his pupils contract and expand the same, or if—

He jolts, birds screaming and flying overhead, as the sound of a gunshot goes off.

He looks at Rin’s house, hears the thud of a body with his altered ears.

And that’s that.

No cop cars come. No sirens sound. No Heroes swoop in. In the middle of nowhere, a woman with a lesser, frowned-upon Quirk lived. She used to be something. But when you’ve lost everything, it’s easier to lean into the despair of it than it is to recover. Heroes can’t save everyone.

So Midoriya stares at the rotted front door for a good while, his hands shaking so horribly it’s a wonder that he can use them at all. He plucks a lone flower growing from a gutter and leaves it on her front porch. A small piece of beauty in a rusted, moldy neighborhood. Then he leaves. And he’s not sure who to tell that her Quirk still held.

Even in death.

Chapter End Notes

Lol

Chapter 4: What is a Hero

Chapter Summary

Midoriya gets into some trouble. ALso, TW warning.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He's lost.

He started off on the right path home, he thinks… but at some point, he began to wander. Kacchan led him to Rin's house, but there was no one to guide him back home.

He's not sure he'd be able to follow them even if they were here. He feels… off. It's dark outside, but he can see clearly. People scarcely walk by. Cars cruise down roads. The world keeps moving, and that's that.

He's freezing cold, his school uniform doing little to protect him. It's going to be spring soon, and in the summer he'll have his entrance exam to UA. With his heightened senses, he's sure to make it in. It should be a victory.

But it's cold outside, and he's never felt so alone before. Most Quirkless kill themselves before they graduate middle school. Less than a quarter of a lifetime is enough to determine they don't want to chance living any longer. What are the statistics for lesser Quirks? A prong up from his own on the social hierarchy, but hardly by much. Do they ever freeze on nights that have no breeze?

Is it just him?

When those recruiters come knocking on Rin's door, will they realize it's unlocked? Will they go inside?

He should've gone inside.

He should've called someone or… or what? She's a criminal, who would've mourned her? They would've asked why he was at the scene, what he was doing, where his parents were. They would've seen his school uniform and the limp in his leg and insisted they take him to a hospital or police station. And when they ran his name through their system and came across his Quirk listing, they would've thrown him right back out.

So what? What was he meant to do? Stay and dig a grave in the concrete of her front steps? Pay for a funeral he can't afford? Call the cops, who already don't like kids like him?

What was he supposed to do?

He should've gone inside. Just to say goodbye, or to scavenge for jewellery to sell, or, or, or,

"I don't know." His voice is hoarse, and when he leans his forehead against the brick of an old building, he only then feels the wet trails of tears that had been streaming down his face. "I don't know what to do anymore."

He's lost. He lost.

Why did she have to go and die? How is that fair? Why does she get to die, and he has to live with the bits and pieces of her still sewn inside him? She had a Quirk, she had a fancy life and money and—

And it wasn't enough. Not in this world. But maybe in the next.

Is that his fate? Is this his prime? Petty theft and concussions? Never landing a job, running around Tokyo with stolen train cards? Fourteen years sounded hard, but he did it.

How many more?

Maybe… maybe Rin was right—

"HELP ME!"

He jolts, looking around the deserted street. There's nobody out. Shops have all closed down. An orange street lamp illuminates the surrounding building. Rain fell at some point, but the sky is clear now. Stars shine down, the moon watching what he'll do next. He's not sure what it wants, looking at him as though he's going to do anything at all.

"SOMEONE—PLEA—" silence.

His ear twitches, and he turns left to the sound of a woman screaming. He's not sure what the hell he's doing. He's no Hero. He never was. He's not sure he ever will be, but… but someone is screaming for help and for some reason he got lost and ended up right where she needed him to be.

So he starts running. His shoes splash in puddles and grind against concrete, but he runs all the same. The notebooks in his backpack jostle, his pencil case bounces against the zipper. He's fast; he's always been fast. He's just got to be fast enough. He turns down an alleyway, panting, then comes to a halt. It's quiet out. No one screams. So he stands there and listens and stares at the moon.

"Come on, come on…" he mumbles, then he's looking around the forked layout of the town he's landed himself in.

Brick buildings, older, so he must be close to school. What else?

He spins, scans the alleyways. On the gravel is a plastic cup from a coffee shop, a popular one. Which means he's close to the bus stop. Somewhere between a coffee shop, a bus stop,

and his middle school. That means all the surrounding buildings are relatively low to the ground, which means—

He spots a drain pipe and begins climbing without second thought. The notches for the screws are his only clutch. Years of jumping fences and swiping wallets have kept him nimble, callouses nearly already formed.

So he climbs. Higher, higher, until he grasps the wet lip of the top of the building. Upper body strength has never been his forte, but with the leverage of the drain pipe, he pushes off the metal with his foot. Grunting, he hoists himself over the edge of the roof until his feet are planted on the ceiling. Up here, the moonlight shines down on him. It seems to tell him to hurry, to not wait a moment longer. And he listens.

With a sprinting head start and a concerning lack of fear, he jumps from the building edge to the next. He barely grabs the concrete with his fingers, but manages long enough to throw an elbow over. Cursing and panting, he pulls himself up again. The wind seems to hold off once more, and Midoriya listens to the night air.

And he hears it. Somewhere below him, metal clatters to the ground. It sounds like a trash can lid, and he happens to know that most shops keep their trash in gated side alleys. So he peers over edges, breath in his throat, and—

And a woman is thrashing against a wall. A man pins her against it, a gloved hand over her mouth. She's crying, her hair stuck to her forehead and her skin worn with sweat as she tries to break free. It's not enough. She's not strong enough. Where is a Hero? There's always at least once patrolling this area since its high crime rates are a risk. Where…

He blinks slowly, takes in the glove the man wears. The mask. The cape.

This is the Hero. He must be new, as Midoriya doesn't recognize him. But this is, undoubtedly, supposed to be the man who saves people in this town. What is he doing? Is this woman a criminal?

But the Hero reaches for his belt, and Midoriya feels a terrible pit of dread in his stomach. How many times had Mama locked him in that closet so he would not have to know what Dad did to her? How many times have girls at school cried in class or hid under hoodies?

How many times is he going to hear about crimes and do nothing about it? There are no keys, there is no closet.

There's just him.

So he jumps off the roof.

And land on the motherfuckers back.

"Fuck!" The Hero screams, knees buckling and bending with the weight of a child thrown onto him.

The good news, in his stupor to not break his legs, he released the woman, and she ran away screaming. The bad news, now it's just Midoriya and a corrupt Hero with a mysterious Quirk. Not ideal.

The man throws him off with a shout, and Midoriya collides with the back of one of the store's walls. Turns out, it hurts a lot more when a grown man throws you full force into a brick building than it does when a group of teenagers throws you into a locker. White, hot pain rattles his spine, but he's gotten too many beatings to lose to some mediocre d-lister.

Oh, if Kacchan knew Midoriya just stole his mean insults, he'd be so mad.

The Hero swings, and Midoriya drops to the floor and kicks him so hard in the balls that there is no hope of the man ever having children. Good riddance, honestly. He squeals, literally, actually squeals, and Midoriya takes the chance to throw himself to the left. He's pushing off the ground a moment later, reaching for the metal prongs of a chain link fence. He gets a leg up, then another, then a harsh tug against the back of his uniform sends him crashing back to the ground.

The man bends down, grabs for him. "You fucked with the wrong—" Midoriya kicks him square in the mouth.

Blood flies, the man's tongue flaps wildly, his teeth shattered. Midoriya kicks again, but the Hero grabs his foot before it ever touches him. With one small shift of his body, he's got Midoriya pinned to the alleyway floor. His hands wrap around his throat, squeeze. Midoriya gasps, claws at his arms, flails his legs. It makes no difference. Blood drips onto his face from the man's mouth. Tears stream down Midoriya's face.

And overhead, the moon shines down. It's light calls to him, begs him, and it sounds an awful lot like a promise he made to his Mama. His vision spots and blurs as his hands search and claw at the ground. Gravel gathers under his fingertips. Blood dribbles off his face. And his hands find purchase on something solid and heavy. He holds tight and swings without second thought.

Only when it collides with the Hero's head, does he realize he was holding a brick.

It's quiet again, and Midoriya lies on his back, panting and gasping up at the night sky. The Hero lay limp beside him, and when he turns his head, he sees the large dent he left in the man's temple. The bloody brick is still in his hand. Midoriya stares for a very, very long time.

Then he stands, digs his hands into his hair and lets out a string of profanity so awful that his Mama would cry just from hearing it. He's on his knees the next second, pushing against the man's neck for a pulse. Faintly, he feels one.

"He's not dead, holy fuck, I didn't kill him." Midoriya streaks his hands through his hair. "That was self-defense, right? I won't go to jail? Fuck! Fuck, I need—I need to call—oh my god." He paces back and forth, drops the brick and picks it up over and over. It takes five full minutes to make up his mind. He scales the chain link fence, fishes a few loose coins from

his pocket, and slams them into the slot of the nearest pay phone. It rings only once before a female voice answers.

“911, what’s your emergency?” He breathes heavily, glances at the alleyway that is currently housing the soon to be close of a Pro Hero. “Hello?”

“Hey!” he squeaks out, before promptly dropping his voice as low as possible. “I—I need—an ambulance.”

The operator doesn’t miss a beat. “What is the injury sir?”

“Umm… I.. I hit a Pro Hero over the head with a brick.”

She pauses. “Pardon?”

“I hit a Pro Hero over the head with a brick.”

Another long pause. “Why…?”

“I need an ambulance.”

“Can you state your name or location?”

“Uhh.” He looks around. The wind whips at the telephone booth. “I don’t really know exactly where I am.”

There’s typing on a keyboard for a brief moment before the operator says, “I’ve pulled your location.”

“Oh shit.”

“I need your name, sir.”

And he’s not sure why, but there’s this gnawing, awful feeling in his chest. It screams at him not to answer, not to tell her. What would happen if he did? How long would it take to pin down his location, to pin down his and Mama’s apartment? Would it still be considered self-defense if they knew he was Quirkless? Would it matter that the Hero was trying to rape a woman? Would it matter that he tried to kill Midoriya?

There is no amount of change that can alter what you really are.

“Sir?”

The color of our skin,

He drops the phone, sprints back to the alleyway.

the way we sound,

He stuffs the brick in his backpack before grabbing a glass shard from the alley floor.

the position we hold ourselves,

He cuts free the parts of the Hero's uniform that he touched.

an extra joint in the toe.

A small packet of disinfectant wipes that his Mama kept in his backpack are used to wipe the chain fence of his fingerprints.

No matter what, Izuku Midoriya,

He scuffs his own footprints in the mud, destroys any trace of his Quirkless brand shoes.

you will always be Quirkless.

And he runs away.

Chapter End Notes

:p

Chapter 5: Reddit is useful for once

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Paranoia is a second skin at this point. It's been two days since the incident, and Midoriya hasn't slept for a single fucking second.

Wednesday, he nearly killed a man after the suicide of a woman he's known since he was four. Friday, he's studying Calculus.

Police have been posted all over the neighborhood. The details of the attack were released this morning. The Hero, known as Bluer, is currently in a medically induced coma. They aren't sure when he'll wake up, if ever. The general consensus is that he was attacked at night, and the criminal is violent and still at large. There's no mention of self-defense that both Midoriya and the woman the Hero attempted to rape had done to him.

Today, Midoriya wears his uniform's collar all the way up to cover the ring of bruises on his neck. His leg still hurts from Rin's attack, and has only flared up with the run-in with the Pro. It's got a nasty bruise, too, tender to the touch. He plans to collect some twigs and make a splint for it, but he's been too nervous to go outside for that long. In truth, he knows he's unlikely to get caught for the crime. He left no prints, no blood, no footprints, no signs of himself. A perk of the rain is the lack of evidence it leaves behind. And the woman, whoever she was, hasn't come forward.

"Attempted murder!"

He stills, turns his head to the front of the room. No one looks at him, though; they're all facing forward. Projected onto the whiteboard at the front of the class is the latest news reporting on the attack. Students murmur and gossip, make guesses at what happened and who did it. Nobody looks his way. Being Quirkless means being forever and perpetually underestimated. What used to destroy him is now his cover, a safeguard. These people would sooner turn on each other than bat an eye in his direction.

Except for one.

Kacchan is turned around in his seat. His hair still holds droplets from the rain outside. One streams down the side of his face, drops off his chin. They lock eyes, and for a moment, he's absolutely certain that Kacchan has figured him out. Did he realize that the scene of the crime was located in the precise town Midoriya would have to walk through to get home? Did he spot the bruises lining Midoriya's neck and know they weren't from his hands for once?

Those red eyes narrow before Kacchan turns back around again, wordless. Midoriya is fairly certain he's pissed himself by the end of the day. He packs his bag quickly, hands trembling just as they did when Rin died. He's as hungry as he is tired. He's been unable to sleep or hold food down, too busy scouring the internet for any trace of himself. Only his fake voice

can lead back to him, and even then, it's iffy. Phone calls distort audio on their own, but with nightlife background noise and a faked pitch, there's no way they can pin it on him.

Right?

"Deku."

Aw, fuck. He packs quicker, shoves a notebook into his bag carelessly.

"Deku!"

The class begins to file out for the day. He zips his bag, adrenaline coursing through him.

"Hey!"

He's running. Some girl cusses him out when he slams into her, but shuts up immediately when Kacchan bounces off her body. Midoriya will feel bad for shoving her later, right now, he's running for his life. His steps hammer down the hall. Pain shoots up his leg, his back soars with it. He runs anyway.

Someone keeps shouting after him. A few kids try to trip him. He slams into the stairway door, throws himself down the rickety steps with force. He grits his teeth through the pain in his leg and pushes past the shoe lockers and onto the street outside.

One large, huffing breath of air before he's taking off after a passing bus. It speeds by, and he just barely grabs an outside rail and swigs his good leg up the bumper. Holding on for dear life, he catches his breath and pants through the throbbing agony of his leg. Only when the bus is turning to the next street, does he look behind him.

Kacchan stands at the front gates of the school, hands clenched into fists. His shoulders rise and fall unsteadily, angrily, and that piercing gaze never wavers from Midoriya.

He's shot by the time he's home. Exhaustion gnaws at him, hunger weighs him down. Mama's working overtime, as she has for the past few days, which means it's another night to fend for himself. On days like these, he'd head to Tokyo for the undeniably busy weekend. But his screwy leg is against that idea as much as the knot in his stomach. He's gone a while without eating before, but mixing it with sleep deprivation is a risky game.

Slinging off his backpack and kicking away his shoes, he debates what bodily function matters most to him. Sleep? Food?

Or self-preservation?

Midoriya pokes open his bedroom door, on edge in case someone is hiding in there and waiting for them. In reality, he knows this wouldn't ever happen, but it doesn't change that his tired mind convinces him it can. His room is covered in All Might merchandise, and those dark eyes seem to be glaring at him now, calling him a coward.

"Screw you," he says, before promptly palming both his eyes. Now he's talking to walls, great.

Slumping into his computer chair, Midoriya hovers over his keyboard. Since Wednesday, he's memorized his towns and the neighboring towns' layouts. Roads, buildings, businesses, houses, even the stop lights or stop signs. He's rebuilt the city within the confines of his mind, sieving through it for any chance that he'll get caught. He's taken everything into account.

Even the witness. Dozens of Reddit threads point to her silence being a permanent addition to this case. Psychology says that victims who don't come forward right away typically never come forward at all. Even then, it was dark, rainy, and Midoriya was half the Pro's size and in dark clothing. The odds of her seeing anything are slim. The odds of her reporting an attempted rape by a Pro Hero are slimmer. If he were her, he'd thank his lucky stars that someone intervened and put the creep in the hospital, and then call it a day. It won't erase her trauma, but it should ease her fears.

Plus, she can't come forward without shooting herself in the foot, right? She'll make herself the number one suspect, and if she's from the same area that Midoriya is, which he predicts she is, then she's smart enough to know that the cops aren't on their side. She'd be lower class, a woman, and a sexual assault victim. The police force cares less about her than nearly anyone else. It's a sad but disgusting truth.

So that leaves one factor. Cameras.

Midoriya clicks onto Reddit, opens a previous thread. The crime was reported on Wednesday night. It likely took all of Thursday to stop by businesses and ask if anyone saw or heard anything. And, if he's right, then any Pro or officer asking for camera footage would have to get a warrant. No business around here would easily associate and work with cops, and it takes about a day to get that. Combine that with the totally bizarre random chance phone call that all stores surrounding the area received, this weekend should have most places closed down.

Was it morally wrong to call six separate businesses from three different pay phones, pretending to be a radio show host giving away tickets to a concert in Tokyo this weekend? Yes. Was it also weirdly easy and sort of funny to do? Absolutely. Even better, all the pay phones in the city can be accessed by taking paths through back alleys.

So he's got the weekend to figure out the camera situation. And he's already begun the long and grueling process of the nerdiest thing he's done yet.

Coding and using Reddit.

You'd be shocked at the amount of illegal shit people just confess to on Reddit. Since Thursday, Midoriya has been working through threads, troubleshooting a few programs and websites he can use. He's found a couple of online courses for coding that he's sped through. If he weren't so caught up on homework, he'd be screwed with the sheer amount of time he spends on the computer.

But if he wants to get away with this, he can't stop.

…not that he wants to.

The worst part of all of this is that one fundamental truth. He likes this. He likes coding, he likes researching, he likes taking out corrupt Heroes. Maybe it's the sleep deprivation talking, but the rush, the thrill, the small flip of his stomach when he jumped off the roof, was exhilarating. He's learning that there are many reasons that people become Pros. For the fame, for the money, for the altruism.

Or for the rush. For the adrenaline that comes from a fight. For the whispers and murmurs of a crowd. It's awful, he knows it's awful. His intentions for becoming a Hero had never been pure, but… god, it's enthralling. He saved a life. Midoriya Izuku, Quirkless, useless, worthless, saved a woman's life.

And he wants to do it again.

"You're kidding, three hours of troubleshooting and all I missed was a semicolon?" He rubs his face. "Can it get any worse?"

The landline rings.

Midoriya freezes before slowly turning towards his door. He attempts to stand, but the blinding pain in his leg makes his knee buckle. Instead, he pushes the chair with his right leg, wheeling to the living room, then to the kitchen, until he reaches the landline. Times like these, he really wishes he could afford a cellphone. No caller ID does not help paranoia, fun fact.

He answers and holds the receiver to his mouth, silent.

There's no noise for a second, until a voice crackles over the line. "Deku."

He hangs up.

The phone immediately rings again, and without a second thought, Midoriya unplugs it. Mama doesn't usually call, so he's not worried he'll miss anything important. The only thing he's worried about is Kacchan somehow showing up to his house and blowing him to itty bitty pieces. It's unlikely, since Kacchan has no idea where he even lives, but Midoriya wheels to the front door just in case. He double and then triple checks that it's locked, turns off all the lights so nobody knows he's home, then wheels to the dining room to grab a chair and jam it under the handle.

He's done for when he goes to school on Monday. But for now, Kacchan can't reach him.

Five hours later, Midoriya has his first few hundred lines of code completed. He knows there are shortcuts and preprogrammed commands that he can use, but starting from scratch was the only option that seemed the most untraceable. He runs it, green text flying across the screen, and then a black box appears on the monitor. A few seconds later, and his monitor flickers, expands, and mirrors the screen of one of the shops.

He did it. He fucking did it!

A few clicks later, and he's accessed the camera system. There are only three cameras, each one pointed at the inside of the store. He combs through footage, determines that no street shots are visible, then exits the program.

Just like that.

"One of six possible cameras." He leans back in his chair, shuts his eyes for just a moment. "Five more to go."

When he opens his eyes again, he's got a knot in his neck and lower back. It takes him looking out his window to see the sun shining high in the sky to start to panic. He fell asleep right there, computer screen blaring in his face. So he wastes no more time.

The second and third cameras are the same as the first. The fourth is trickier to get into, since it's protected, but it only took him another five fucking hours. The fifth was another bust. But the sixth?

The sixth has a street view. And, clear as day, is that stupid pay phone. Even worse, it caught him headed back to the alley, time stamp included. This is the most damning evidence thus far. He usually wears his hood when he's going to do something illegal, but he hadn't exactly planned this. He pauses when his head turns, and his obnoxiously bright shoes and backpack are in plain view, so is his entire guilty and petrified face.

God. Dammit.

His next search on Reddit is "How to delete camera footage from a store camera."

He tracks down one user in particular who seems to know what he's talking about. The same user, Purple_Minion, had come up a few times in other threads as well. Midoriya clicks the profile, opens a DM, and begins to type. He's a bit embarrassed of his own Reddit name, but there are worse options.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: Could you tell me how to delete camera footage from a store camera without having access to the server?

It's risky, but he's out of options. Even getting into the camera systems was hard, but erasing the footage right away is even harder.

Purple_Minion responds right away.

Purple_Minion: What's in it for me?

ALLMIGHT4EVER: What do you want?

Purple_Minion: To know why you've been learning code to hack into computer systems.

His heart stills, shudders.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: How do you know that?

Purple_Minion: I'm watching your network activity. You should really invest in a VPN

Midoriya trembles, vomit stirring in his stomach. This is it. He's caught.

Purple_Minion: I've been cleaning up your trails, by the way.

A pause.

Purple_Minion: I'll tell you how to terminate the footage, but only if you answer a question.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: Are you a cop?

The response is an eyeroll emoji.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: What do you want to know?

Typing bubbles appear, then disappear, then appear again.

Purple_Minion: Why did you try to kill Bluer?

Midoriya breathes heavily, his entire body shaking and buzzing. He's not sure how this guy knows this about him, not sure why they've been cleaning up his digital footprint. He's not even sure what he's supposed to say now. If he lies, there's a chance Purple_Minion knows more than he lets on and screws Midoriya over. If he tells the truth, then this guy has a confession to use against him.

But it comes down to that same question. How does Purple_Minion know what Midoriya did? Did they also access the camera footage? Did they make a guess based on Midoriya's search history?

Purple_Minion: Tick tock.

Midoriya decides then that he's already in a vast amount of shit. If he confesses in all honesty and this backfires, then there's still a chance that he can get away with it based on self-defense. So he tells the truth.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: I saw him trying to rape a woman. I intervened. I didn't mean to hurt him, I swear. He was choking me, and I needed to escape. I called the cops right after.

The message lingers in chat for a moment before blipping out of existence. Deleted. Scrubbed from the internet in a way that should be impossible.

Purple_Minion: The line of code I'm sending you will erase the footage.

A sequence of words and numbers follows the message. Midoriya types them into the IED, and watches as the store footage corrupts. Just like that.

ALLMIGHT4EVER: Thank you

Purple_Minion sends him a link as a reply. It takes Midoriya hours to work up the courage to click it. When he does, the message deletes itself, and a new browser opens. It’s a locked down tab and opens to a new, small chat room. Only him and the guy are inside.

“What is this?” Midoriya asks. His name in the chat has been changed to AM, the correspondent to PM.

PM: I can't always be around to clean up after you. You want to learn how to code properly? Zero trace? Hack into nasty shit?

His good leg bounces as he responds.

AM: Yes

PM: Good. Then let's get started.

Chapter End Notes

meowza

Chapter 6: Open air

Chapter Summary

Midoriya goes on his first patrol but stumbles across some trouble.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya doesn't have friends. He never really has, he's certain he never really will. But this weekend was the closest he's ever come to it. He's still unsure why PM decided to help him, but he's far from ungrateful. It's a long journey to succeeding in coding, but bit by bit, he's learning.

With no camera footage, no witnesses, no evidence, and no prints, the case is handed over to lesser detectives. They won't find anything. The video has been scrubbed, and the assault weapon sits under his bed with the cobwebs. He slept good over the weekend, ate plenty, found some sticks to make a splint for his leg. He's recharged, refreshed, ready to pretend the worst night of his life never happened. He's got Hero school to train and study for, he's got his promise to keep, life is good.

"Deku." Scratch that, life sucks.

He made it to the end of the hall and into the stairwell, but Kacchan caught him with a hand wrapped around the string of his bag. So close, but so, so far. He would've been faster if this makeshift splint hadn't kept his entire leg locked up. The things he does to fix a measly little bruise.

Kacchan drags him by the backpack like it's a leash. He tosses him into the boys' bathroom, and one dirty look sends the few kids inside running. When they're gone, he locks the bathroom door, and Midoriya is struck with the sudden urge to make himself look as small as possible. A prey response, unfortunately.

"Who the fuck do you think you are? Ignoring me like a fucking pussy." Kacchan approaches, lip curled into a sneer.

"I-I had to talk to my mom—"

"Your mom works overtime at the end of the week, try again," Kacchan says, voice low and lethal.

Midoriya doesn't have a spare moment to wonder why Kacchan remembered such a small piece of information before the collar of his shirt is grabbed. Kacchan yanks him forward, mouth set into a scowl.

His eyes dart down, and widen only slightly before he shoves Midoriya backwards.

“Kacchan—“

“What the fuck,” he seethes, and then grabs him again like a rag doll. His fingers tug the collar of his uniform down and reveals deep bruises. “Where the hell did you get these?”

For the first time ever, Midoriya shoves him off. He adjusts his collar, shame eating at his face. “T-those are from when you grabbed me on Wednesday—“

“I don’t leave bruises,” Kacchan cuts him off, eyes slitted. “Do I look like a fucking idiot, Deku? Those spots cover your air pipe and go down to the fucking trachea. That’s not me.”

Midoriya blinks slowly. Kacchan is so smart. Hidden under a rough demeanour is a top ranked student with a perfect GPA. Despite his cronies, he doesn’t drink or smoke, and he workouts and trains as much as he studies. He’s a practiced, well oiled machine, and he’s far from stupid.

“Mix it with this,” Kacchan says, kicking the wound on Midoriya’s leg, “and I’d say someone had it out for you.”

“Why do you care, Kacchan?” Midoriya asks, voice shaking.

And for the first time ever, Kacchan is at a loss for words.

“What did Rin change, huh?” He shoves him backwards. “You look the same, so what did she change?”

“Nothing.”

“Really?” Kacchan asks, grinning down at him. “You went over for a fucking tea party?”

“Is it so bad that I-I just wanted to see a friend?” he asks.

“You’re acting weird.”

“I’m not.”

“Motherfucker,” Kacchan lifts a hand, explosions blasting off his palm. “I will fucking kill you, don’t you get that? Are you too stupid to get that?”

“I-I did what you asked! I didn’t talk to you or—“

The bell rings for the next period, Midoriya’s sigh of relief drowned in its volume. Kacchan is too much of a goody two shoes to be late. It’s one of the things Midoriya admires in him.

“This isn’t over,” Kacchan says, backing up to the door. “Something’s off with you. If you think getting some illegal back-alley shit done to you will give you the jump on me, you’re dead wrong.”

“I don’t—“ the bathroom door slams shut, “—think that.” It’s never easy with Kacchan. He’d give anything to know what goes on in his head. Sometimes he wonders if the anger is just a defense. He’s not sure what against, but he can’t imagine that being so angry at the world comes naturally. He’s always known Kacchan to be hot headed, but he’s never sought him out so much.

UA must be making him antsy.

It’s making Midoriya antsy too.

Mama isn’t home yet when school lets out. It’s a good thing. She’d have something to say if she saw his limp, but it’s not as if he could hide it very much. The bruise has only gotten worse; he really must’ve irritated it.

He sits straight legged in his computer chair before turning on the ancient PC. He’s still not sure where Mama got it from. His best guess is someone at work was throwing it out, or a neighbor left it for the trash men. Either way, he’s grateful to have it.

A message waits for him.

PM: Done with school yet?

Midoriya nibbles his lip before he replies.

AM: It’s not fair that you know I’m still in school, but I know nothing about you

PM: It’s your own fault for googling ‘how to get away with almost murdering a guy’ without a VPN, watching you go down rabbit holes was my favorite pastime

Midoriya’s lips twitch up.

AM: You’re evil.

PM: So I’ve been told.

A brief pause.

PM: For the record, I had school, too.

Midoriya lights up at that.

AM: Maybe we go to the same one!

PM: Please, I would be able to smell your guilt from across the hall if that was the case.”

AM: Give me something to work with here! You’ve been teaching me code for days now, don’t you think I deserve a little hint about you?

PM: Fine.

Text bubbles, there and gone and there and gone. Over and over. A tirade of unsure messages before one is finally sent.

PM: I don’t have many friends.

AM: Really? I couldn’t tell!

PM: Your sarcasm can be heard through the screen, jackass.

AM: If it makes you feel better, I don’t have any either.

Again, bubbles up and down and up and down and up again.

PM: It does, actually.

AM: Don’t be all mushy

Midoriya smiles a true one this time, finding comfort in an anonymous person stuck in a similar situation.

AM: I like it better when you're mean to me.

PM: Me too, it’s easier, too.

AM: Fuck you.

PM: Your mom is too busy doing that.

AM: Tell me something juicy! Something interesting!

And this time, when the bubbles pop up, the message is shot over instantly. As though PM forced themselves to send it right away instead of dwelling on it. It lights up Midoriya’s screen, plagues him with a truth he forgot about in his joyful rush to talk to a new potential friend.

PM: My Quirk is seen as villainous.

Right. For what might be the first time in his life, he forgot about Quirks. And it was nice. They teased and joked, and talked, and Midoriya forgot to question if PM would ever associate with him if he knew the truth.

“Are you afraid?” PM writes.

Midoriya cracks his knuckles before responding.

AM: No. I don’t think Quirks can be inherently villainous or heroic. Just another box to shove people into.

A test message, a way to feel it out.

PM: I don’t think I’ve ever met someone who thinks that way. It’s refreshing.

Midoriya almost smiles when the next message rolls in.

PM: What's your Quirk?

What does he say? Honesty has gotten him this far with PM, but that only works when the person you talk to values honesty over comfort. It's disturbing how many people fool themselves into thinking they want the truth before willingly pulling a blindfold over their eyes. PM was altered to Midoriya's online antics because of how many times he DMed him or clicked on his threads, an inherently invasive start to their friendship. The computer is registered to whatever random person was throwing it out, and he's been stealing internet from the neighbors for years. So a VPN trace couldn't lead directly to him. If he lies now, PM is unlikely to know the real reason. Especially not when he's taught Midoriya so many tricks in the past few days. He can effectively block networks from tracing him, can divert any pathing online to other locations that don't pertain to him. He's not great at it, but he's good enough.

PM did all that without knowing Midoriya's Quirk. Most people care to ask right away, but those who don't typically face some form of discrimination for their own Quirk. It's how Chikara and Rin were, how the few lesser Quirked people were that he's run into.

PM: Hello?

AM: It's not something I really talk about.

PM: I get that. Sometimes it's nice not to talk about Quirks and all that bullshit, you know?

AM: You have no idea.

PM: Want to learn how to hack into webcams?

AM: Obviously.

He gets lost in that for a very, very long time. It's simple like this, nice, easy. A full day of being verbally berated and physically assaulted—this is almost like taking the power back. Kids at school are assholes, easily some of the worst people he's ever met, and pulling in front of them is something that never fails to bring him a bit of joy. It's prideful, sure, but he doesn't often get to have something that others don't. So he gets the good grades, the coding sessions, the amazing Mama, and he runs with it.

But something nags at him, pulls at him, urges him. He holds off from it a little longer, pushes the ache away until it dulls but throbs, pleading him.

Two weeks after the incident, Midoriya can't ignore it any longer.

AM: I need to tell you something.

PM: I'm flattered, but not interested.

AM: It's not that…

PM: The ominous dot dot dot makes me nervous. What's up?

Midoriya takes a breath in, slowly forces it out.

AM: The night I attacked Bluer, it's done something to me.

PM: You mean the night you saved a woman's life, then fought for your own using a loose brick from a building? I imagine that can knock a few things around in the average person's head.

AM: No, it was like… you know those dreams you have about falling and you wake up startled and your hearts racing?

He pauses.

AM: When I attacked Bluer, it was like my brain was finally clear. Nothing else mattered but me and him, it was like waking up from that dream.

PM: Wow, you're kind of poetic.

AM: Shut up.

PM: So? What now? You going to run around saving strangers from evil doers like some kind of vigilante?"

Midoriya hesitated before typing, "Yeah, I think so."

PM's response is instant.

PM: That was sarcasm. Are you suicidal? You almost died two weeks ago and you want to go and spawn camp another potential crime?

AM: I helped someone.

PM's bubbles pop up, then disappear again.

AM: I've been told my whole life I'd never amount to anything, and just when I was starting to really believe it, I proved myself wrong. For a moment, I was worth something, I was proving something. I was turning everything everyone had ever said about me into something worthwhile.

AM: If I wasn't out there, something bad would've happened. And now I can't shake this feeling that I'm wasting not just my time, but someone else's. What if there's more corrupt Heroes? Who is going to stop them?

The chat box is quiet for a long while. And then, with no other messages, PM's green dot flickers to red. He's gone offline.

Midoriya's first friend. Poof.

He stares at the blank screen a moment longer before writing once again. “I’m sorry I upset you. I shouldn’t have said anything. Thank you for teaching me code and chatting with me about stupid stuff. It was fun.”

He’s not sure what else to put down, so he leaves it at that and shuts the computer off.

And goes for his closet.

The disguise is something simple, something he can blend in with. A black hoodie, black cargo pants, and a few modifications to his shoes and backpack. He found a few pairs of old shoes in the trash a few days back. With a good pair of scissors, thread, and a bit of glue, he was able to take the rubber soles of those shoes and use them to create a dark design against the red of his own. It’s not a permanent solution by any means, but it elongates the back of his shoe and changes his footprint pattern. No longer a size eight, but a size ten, with swirling patterned soles instead of crossing lines.

And that’s it. He had considered fixing up his school bag, but no cheap options were available. Is a yellow backpack really such an eyesore? He should be fine… probably.

Midoriya adorns his face mask, tugs his hood over his head, and moves to the glass window of his bedroom. He took the screen out days ago in preparation, so it’s easy to slowly push open the wooden paneling and slip out. His leg still hurts, but not nearly as bad as before. It makes it easy to drop to the neighbor's balcony from his own on the third floor, then to carefully grip the drain pipe that connects to the first floor.

One step at a time, slowly, a path he carefully curated in advance. A little planning ahead can go a long way in a world like this—

“Ah!” He slips and falls the last few feet, thudding on the ground. “Ow, ow, okay, need to work on landing… or not falling… both, yeah, let’s go with both.”

He’s never snuck out before! It’s exhilarating and also horrifying! No one knows what he’s up to, least of all Mama. She’d lose her mind if she knew he was out and about this late at night. Even on days he runs to the city to make some cash, he’s never out this late. He doesn’t even know what to do with himself! This is the cool teenager stuff he was missing out on! Sneaking out at night, getting into fights, talking to your crush who hates you, losing your only friend within just a few weeks of having them… his mood sours pretty quickly. The elation wears off, but the gnawing sensation festers like a disease.

He’s done his research this time. Musutafu, his town, is decently small. The surrounding towns are much bigger, creating a radius around the district that is patrolled typically by one Pro. Despite its high crime rates, Heroes aren’t wasted on lowlifes and minor crimes. The police typically handle neighborhood issues, Pros focus on big cities, and crime keeps on. But now, in the wake of Bluers attack, three Pros patrol the small radius of this section of Japan. It’s separated on a grid scale and disaster level. Recovery Heroes are stationed and rotated in when a building falls or a fire breaks out. Patrolling Heroes are always out on shifts, following rewritten routes to get from one place to another before swapping out. Limelight Heroes are typically those with flashy Quirks who take on crime head-on or are called to scene, like All Might.

But it's the Underground that Midoriya needs to watch out for. Those who blend into the nightlife and city, often undercover or dirty. They often run patrols as well, but in a less public line of sight. They hang in the shadows, creep up and stalk.

His goal for tonight is to locate an Underground Hero. One, so he can stalk them as they stalk others, but in a less creepy way. If he can learn from them, then he'd be better off in the long run. Two, because Underground Heroes are cool as hell and completely anonymous. Three, because if he doesn't detect them first, then they'll locate him.

"This is so exciting," Midoriya mumbles, pushing down a street to his right. "I feel like a ninja. Or maybe a vampire. A little bit like a criminal, too." He ducks under a surveillance camera posted outside a store, careful to keep out of sight. "I bet nobody else is doing their own specially designed patrol."

As hard as Pro's may try, it's impossible to pin down possible criminal locations when you've never lived in a criminal hot spot. Midoriya has walked by some of the most despicable looking places on his way to school and not a single one has ever been investigated by a Pro. Underground Heroes get close to it, but the truth is, unless you are inside of the crueler parts of the world, it's nearly impossible to see them. So, he walks his own patrol route. It loops around the majority of the town, excludes more open and heavily populated streets. It winds through buildings, cuts through neighborhoods, hits hot spots known for drug selling or illegal Quirk usage. He's not going to rat out kids for being stupid or blowing off steam. He's going to go after those who pray on them.

The first hour is beyond boring. The glittery appeal of patrolling dwindles very quickly when you come across only street cats and litter. Though he did pick up all the litter and throw it away, and pet every cat. That's not the point. The point is, a lot of Hero work is just waiting for something to happen. He's stopped to trail a few drunk women home to ensure they made it safely, and unwedged a loose balloon from a tree to throw out, but that's about it.

When his route is done, he's set to head home and call it a night. He might not have achieved his goal, but he managed to locate another Pro on patrol and pet a few scraggly cats, so it was a success. His first ever patrol! Completed—

"Oh my god, you're All Might!" He whips around so fast that his hood flies off. He has to secure it once again before taking off in the direction of whatever person was just talking. It's not hard to locate them, considering the volume they talk out, and Midoriya is in awe the second he rounds the corner.

All Might. He's really here. Tall, muscly, brightly colored and smiling wide. Midoriya is cursing himself for not bringing his All Might memorabilia because he *always* brings it just in case he happens across All Might in this tiny town. The one time he didn't bring it!

He pulls his hood to take it off, to talk to All Might, to ask him the dozens of questions—

"Is that how they sound? Did I get the pitch right?"

Midoriya's eyes almost fall out of his head from how wide they are. Beside All Might, hair slicked back and angled, is Present Mic. *The* Present Mic, side by side with *The* All Might,

just hanging around this nothing town like it's a casual Wednesday night. What is this? Why are they here? Will they give him their autograph if he asks?

"Close enough to the whining frequency." A man Midoriya has never seen before says as he dangles from the roof of a building. He looks homeless, long black hair nearly covering his face completely. Yellow goggles around his throat, a thick scarf keeping him suspended in air.

"You've got your look around the town, any conclusion you've drawn that all the rest of us have somehow missed?" The man asks.

All Might bellows out a laugh that seems to shake the city floor. It's only then that Midoriya can focus on where, exactly, they are. It wasn't a planned part of his official patrol route, as he'd been avoiding the scene for as long as possible, but it's undeniable. Rattling chain link, a lip on the roof above, blood spatter on the opposite wall.

Bluer. All Might is here to investigate an attempted murder scene. *Midoriya's* attempted murder scene. When he grabbed a spare brick and bashed a rapists head in and miraculously got away.

Fuuuuuuck! He doesn't stand a chance against ALL MIGHT? Are you kidding? How's that even fair? That's, like, a level 100,000,000 versus a level two. It would be more unlikely for All Might *not* to pinpoint the exact culprit of this crime than it would be to find him.

"Run me through it again, Eraser Head!" All Might jeers, hands on his hips.

"Eraser Head," Midoriya mumbles, eyes shifting again to the dangling man.

Not just anyone can hang around All Might. Maybe he's Present Mic's friend? But that doesn't make sense. Why are three Pro Heroes, two world-renowned, investigating a two-week-old crime scene? All Might doesn't solve murders; he fights crime. He's the number one Hero for his high villain capture count.

Why is he here?

Eraser Head lets out a sigh that can only be described as agonized. "Scuff prints on the roof hint that the attacker came from above." His scarf juts out, anchoring him from one building to the next. He uses it to hoist himself up to the roof, planting his feet right at the edge. "Abrasions on Bluer's shoulders and waist confirm that someone was on his back at some point." Eraser drops down from the roof, facing the same wall Bluer had. "More scuffs on the ground indicate a struggle."

"Why was young Bluer in an alleyway, twenty yards from his patrol route?" All Might questions.

Eraser gives him a blank look. "Why don't you miraculously wake him from his coma and ask?"

Present Mic laughs before standing between them, a hand out to either of their chests. “What else did we note, Aizawa?”

“Aizawa…” Midoriya slowly shimmies his backpack off, adjusting his position around a building corner. He pulls his notebook out from within, scribbling down names and locations.

Eraser Head—or, Aizawa, grumbles something before squatting to the ground. “The attacker knew how to cover their tracks. Even the weapon, which we believe was some blunt and ridged object, was missing.” Then he points two fingers along the ground in a straight line. “But the attacker didn’t account for the third person present.”

His heart drops to his feet.

“We recovered smaller shoe sizes, likely a woman’s heel.” Eraser stands again, then gestures to a brick-sized hole in the building exterior. “A missing brick that the store owner claims wiggles loose all the time, but they always slot it into place, that’s the weapon.”

All Might hums. “So the story goes that our attacker was assaulting a woman, then Bluer tried to intervene?”

“Not exactly,” Present Mic says, voice echoing into the night. “The brick was located near ground level, meaning that whoever wielded it was swinging from the ground up.”

“CT and MRI confirm it,” Aizawa adds.

“Plus, scratch marks on Bluer's arms, the angle of which the attacker jumped…”

All Might’s tight smile tips down. “You think the attacker was defending the woman?”

Eraser looks around again, glances up at the roof. “Bluer had a few reports of sexual harassment at his Pro’s agency, my guess is someone stopped letting the asshole get away with it.”

“So… I was right!” All Might cheers, and Mic belts out a laugh at the scowl on Eraser's face.

“We came to the same conclusion,” Eraser snaps at him.

“But I got there first,” All Might says with a wink.

Midoriya furrows his brows. His notebook is filled with mindless scribbles, his handwriting so messy it would be a miracle if he could even read it later. But this is valuable information, even if it’s killing him not to run up to All Might and beg for an autograph.

“Strain on Bluer’s legs wasn’t significant, so our guess is a younger, lighter person, someone smart but unseasoned. Prints were wiped with disinfectant; the lab report says it's first-aid grade stuff. They didn’t come looking for a fight,” Aizawa summarizes. “And the cameras were wiped pretty late, hints at inexperience.”

All Might bellows out another laugh. “Sounds like a future Hero.”

Midoriya's heart warms in his chest. Nobody has ever said that about him before.

"Or a future criminal," Eraser argues, "Whoever this was knew the cops wouldn't be on his side until weeks later, if at all. We're likely looking at someone with a record, or an aggressive history."

Well, that's humbling. Midoriya tucks his notebook away as the two of them argue, Mic trying and failing to mediate. He's still unsure why All Might came to investigate this, let alone celebrate a horrific attack and almost murder. Though it does feel nice to have the world's number one Hero on his side. He debates for a moment whether or not he should take off his mask and hood and try to talk to the three of them. He could get their autographs, make copies and sell them for a huge profit. Or maybe he could finally look his most favorite Heroes in the eyes and feel equal to them. Maybe he could ask All Might about… about that fight years ago. When he emerged from flames victorious after a hard battle, saving hundreds of lives as he went.

It's been in Midoriya's head for years. His greatest dreams and worst nightmares had been born from that battle. All Might killed a supervillain, saved Japan.

Midoriya can't shake the feeling that he needs to warn him.

That the supervillain isn't actually dead.

Okay, okay, he's doing this. Most suspects return to the scene of the crime or aid in search parties and police work to throw off the trail. So long as he doesn't mention the attack, he should be okay, right? Midoriya peels off his hoodie and mask. His t-shirt that says "t-shirt" was not his most formal attire, but he hadn't exactly been expecting this. He stuffs the clothes in the bag, slings it back over his shoulder. Flipping to a new page in his notebook, a fresh pen ready to be used, he steps out of his corner.

"Shit!"

He stumbles back as a white cloud of smoke drifts from the alleyway. Did someone smoke out the scene? Why? Maybe the Pros need help! Quickly, he puts his hoodie back on. It's only when he snaps his mask into place that the smoke clears and reveals… a really old dude. Maybe in his fifties? He looks truly awful and sickly.

Mic whips a rag from his pocket, hands it to the old man wearing oversized All Might merchandise. The man presses it to his lips, dabs at the blood that's begun to pour from his mouth. What happened to All Might? Where did he go? Why did he leave some old guy here instead?

"I'm fine, I'm fine." The old man coughs up blood, hunched over himself. "I just maintained form for too long."

"Because you're a performative idiot," Eraser snaps at him, but he reaches into his deep pockets and pulls loose a canister of water. "Drink some water, All Might."

All…

…Might

What the fuck.

That's… All Might? The bony, wrinkly old man is *the* All Might? He can hardly stand, how is this All Might? Is it some sort of illusion? How is this…

"I was hoping you could lead me to my future successor tonight, Aizawa," All Might rasps, dabbing at his mouth with the cloth. "The sooner I can pass on… my knowledge… the better."

Successor? Knowledge? In what world is All Might training a new prodigy? He's in his prime! How is this happening? How does nobody know? Who is in on this? How many people know All Might isn't really All Might? What's going on?

"Let's get out of here," Present Mic suggests. "You never know who could be around."

Right. Getting out of here is a great idea.

Midoriya turns around, stares down another alleyway. The city is an interconnecting web of alleys and backroads. If he didn't know better, he'd say it was designed for crime. It's a good getaway, quick and windy but still direct enough. He needs to get home, research all that he's learned, talk to—

To no one. PM is gone.

He doesn't let his discouragement stop his escape. He's got so much to think about. All Might wanted a new successor, came to the scene of a crime for it…

Did All Might want… him?

His heart picks up, an undeniable smile forming on his face. It wouldn't matter if he's Quirkless if All Might was the one training him! He'd get into UA for sure! If taking out bad guys is the way to get his attention, then Midoriya can do that! A little research and planning and he'd get exactly what he wants. A free ride to UA, All Might training him. He'd become a Hero, he'd keep his promise. He'd do what needed to be done. Finish what All Might had nearly accomplished years ago. He'd—

Midoriya trips over his shoelaces, slamming against a metal trash can. The lid goes flying, clattering yards away, and trash spills to the ground. A stray cat darts away, and the quiet murmur of Heroes talking disappears immediately.

Uh oh.

He takes off running, staying low and as quiet as possible. It doesn't change the pursuit he's absolutely certain is coming his way. Only issue with Pros, they're *good* at their job. Years of rigorous training and education don't fall short on them. So Midoriya creeps while still maintaining speed, slicking his body with the shadows of the town. He knows where the lights are, cameras, dead ends and forks. His only advantage here is that he knows this place better than anyone.

A strange, clicking noise comes from his left. It takes a moment to recognize it, but once he does, he's moving away. Echo location. In a place so quiet but narrow, Mic's Quirk can still excel. It'll pick up on open air, crash when colliding with his body. Any random criminal would have no idea what it was, but Midoriya's been studying Heroes since he was kid. He knows this trick. With All Might likely out of commission, it leaves a well-studied Present Mic and a wildcard Eraser Head. So what's his move? What does a Hero do when they've got no clear exit and are being pinned down?

They go up.

He dashes to the next alley, barely missing a pursuing click. There should be a storm pipe here somewhere—there it is! Midoriya grasps it, wearing a pair of rubber gloves he found in the kitchen, and begins the climb. The notches again help him up, allowing his weight to be held on a sleek lip. Adrenaline courses through him, a crutch for his tired arms. He peeks his head over the edge. Eraser Head is up here, peering over the opposite ledge. The man scans the alleyways, his yellow goggles now adorning his face. Just a few feet away from Midoriya.

One hand holds the pipe, the other slowly reaches into his backpack. He's as quiet as possible as he withdrawals a loose pencil and chucks it as far to his left as hard as he can. It clatters on the street next to him. Midoriya hugs the pipe, blends into the wall best he can as Eraser shoots up and jumps from one roof to the next with a practiced ease. Mic comes clicking from the opposite direction.

With a now empty roof at an elevated position, Midoriya climbs up and out of sight. He doesn't waste a single moment or breath on relief. Instead, he slowly creeps to the opposite edge and jumps to the next roof over. For a moment, the open air greets him, his stomach flips and whirls, and then he lands with a roll.

"That was so cool," he mumbles to himself, pumping his fist into the air.

He sobers the next moment as the building he needs to jump to is far higher than the last. He can't make that, not unless… his refined eyes scan over the brick. This is an apartment building, which means window sills are his best bet. No balcony indicates a sturdier infrastructure surrounding the frame, so the concrete slabs should be fine to hold his weight. This late at night, most people inside will be asleep, giving him a clean shot to jump, land, and hoist himself up.

Okay, okay, he can do this, he can do this.

He jumps, lands, and careens backwards into the gaping alleyway below. Hands reaching out, he just barely secures the upper ledge of the building. His heart hammers wildly, his legs numb and shaking. Still, he pulls himself up to the roof.

"Up top!" Mic shouts.

Uh oh. So much for stealth.

Midoriya glances over his shoulder long enough to see Eraser Head swing up from a neighboring alleyway. His hair floats wildly, goggles keeping his eyes hidden. He honestly looks really fucking cool. Midoriya would sketch him or theorize how the hell that scarf seems to work as their own appendages, but he's too busy running for his life. He takes off, jumps to another roof that's level with his current one. Blood pumps through his veins, night air whips at him. He feels alive, awake, better than he has in years. Another roof, another turn, Eraser giving chase. Multiple times, that scarf reaches for Midoriya but falls just a bit short or just a bit too left or right. A perk of being as unpredictable as he is is that nobody knows what the hell he's going to do next, not even him!

Another jump, and this time, when he looks down, All Might's fragile body is at the bottom. The man looks up at him, bloody rag to his mouth, blue eyes wide as Midoriya soars above. Then Midoriya is gone, flinging himself to the next roof. This one is an abandoned building, and if he remembers correctly, there's a trapdoor up here that leads to the confined insides.

He finds it pretty quickly, flips it up, and stares down the metal prongs of the latter. He's not too sure what this building used to be. He and Mama had crashed here a few times after Auntie kicked them out, but he hasn't been inside since Mama landed a good job and the apartment. He'd nearly forgotten those nights. Mama sacrificed a lot for him. It's his turn to pay her back. He starts descending, flipping the hatch lid as he goes. It's got a small sliding lock that keeps it pinned shut, and not a moment too late. The lid is tugged at, rattling loudly, but holds true. Midoriya drops the rest of the way down, landing on the rickety third floor. Scaffolding holds up the floor below him, and concrete greets the bottom of it all. All doors and windows are boarded up as a way to deter the homeless, and shockingly, it's worked to keep them out. With winter ending soon, he's not surprised that it's so empty.

He drops down to the ground level. This place has a basement that exits to another chain-linked alleyway. He's only gone down there a few times as a kid, but it's nice to see it still remains covered with large pieces of scrap wood and metal rebar. It's easy to lift the large piece of wood holding it all up, slip underneath, and drop into the dark basement. A couple of minutes of stumbling in the dark, he finds a small set of stairs leading to a heavy door. He pushes it open and emerges in the night once again.

It takes another twenty or so minutes to get home and scale the drainpipes and balconies. But when he finally slides open his window and plops into bed, he feels, for the first time ever, utterly fulfilled.

Now, who exactly is Eraser Head?

Chapter End Notes

Gee willikers

Chapter 7: All for one and one for all

Chapter Summary

Midoriya does research

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Now high knees, high knees, jump with your legs tucked up to your chest. We want at least a 90-degree angle.” Midoriya copies the instructional video, jumping up and onto the edge of his desk from a resting position. He’s landed it a few times now and the strain feels beyond good. “Landing with our arms out for balance, this can be adjusted with a bit more practice.”

Who’d have thought parkour was something you could be taught over the internet for free? Well, not completely. He’s coded his own program that runs through a stolen Patreon account to access these classes online. He’s not sure whose account he’s been logged into for a few weeks now, but they don’t seem to mind.

“Now, a quick break for water, and we’ll pick back up with flexibility stretches.” He grabs his water, chugs enough to sustain himself, before rolling into the stretches set up. They’ve done wonderful things for his screwy leg. “Let’s start with our calves, find the nearest wall, and place your toes on it. Then we want to lean against the wall—“

“Izuku! There’s a call for you!”

“One minute!” His legs burn with the stretch, but he pushes anyway.

“Izuku!”

“Hold on!” He alternates feet, stretches, then pauses the video.

Things have been happening quickly since the initial run-in with the Pros. All Might announced his presence the following day, Bluer awoke from his coma with a gaping hole of memory that saved Midoriya’s ass, and a description of his assailant was released to the press. Midoriya saw the words “Shoe size 10” and has been on cloud nine since. His ploy worked, and his costume kept him hidden. A general height was working out closer to his true one, but the shoe size throws the prediction off plenty. Mixed with the lack of facial or print confirmation, he’s golden.

He’s been going out every night, keeping a much lower profile than before and avoiding any and all trash cans. During the day, he goes to school, finishes homework, studies, practices coding through more stolen lessons, and occasionally rides to Tokyo to make some extra cash. But at night? The night is where he really comes alive. He hasn’t seen much activity at

all, but the stray cats have been enjoying the stolen cans of cat food he leaves out for them. He practices jumping between buildings, climbing up windowsills, scaling fences, and locating little nooks and crannies to hide out in.

He's begun to expand his horizons, venturing to new towns and cities, mapping them in his notebook. He takes inventory of street lights, of surveillance cameras, of easily liftable sewer drains and grid systems. He lives for it. When it's dark out, and the moon keeps his company, he doesn't feel so different than everyone else. He doesn't think about Quirks or UA or Kacchan. He thinks about where he's going to go next, what he's going to do, what the best possible route is to each new location.

He loves it.

"Yes, yes he's coming right now," Mama says, smiling so wide as she talks into the phone. "No, thank *you* for calling, it's so nice to hear your voice. You're so grown up!"

Midoriya gives her a curious look. She holds the phone to her chest and mouths: "Katsuki."

He shakes his head back and forth, eyes wide, and Mama purses her lips before lifting the phone back up. "Uhh… I'm sorry, Katsuki, I-Izuku is uhh…"

He makes a cutting motion along his throat to urge her to hang up.

Mama says, "He's dead?"

"No!" he whisper-shouts.

"No! He's not dead… uhh, he's…" He folds his hands by his head, shuts his eyes. "Asleep! Yes, he's soooo sleepy. Did you know he was the cutest little baby when he slept? Snot bubbles coming out his nose and—"

He unplugs the phone. "Why would you say that to Kacchan?"

"I panicked!" she cries, covering her face with her hands. "He's just such a sweetheart, I felt so bad lying to him."

"Really," Midoriya says flatly, "I'm sure he was charming as ever,"

Mama nods. "Oh, he was, I can't believe he let me sit and ramble for so long! I lost track of time. I need to finish up dinner."

"You started an hour ago, Mama, what could you possibly say to him for so long?" Midoriya groans.

Mama turns beat red, hides her face once again. "I wasn't expecting him to call so I asked about school and he told me it was great and that he was planning to go to UA and he kept calling Mrs.Midoriya so I told him he could just call me Inko or Auntie and that Mrs.Midoriya makes me feel like an old lady and he apologized but he kept calling me it by accident and I just had to tell him how much it reminded me of how lovely he was as a little boy and how you were so lucky to have him as a friend—"

She continues rambling. There's no DNA test needed to conclude that she's his mom with how much she mutters and talks about Kacchan with stars in her eyes. The admiration must be genetic.

"Mama." Midoriya pinches his brow. "No more harassing Kacchan."

"He called me first!" she argues, "and he cooks, did you know he cooks? He said he'd cook me some katsudon one day and send it home with you—"

"Mama!" Midoriya snaps her out of it. As much as he loves the wonderful image of Kacchan being nice to his mom and cooking for her, he knows the reality is far from it. "Did he say what he wanted?"

Mama pauses, presses a finger to her lips. "I'm not sure."

Midoriya groans and turns back to his room.

"Oh! Now I remember!"

"Probably wants to know how I managed to get out of a swirlie yesterday…" he mutters.

"He said he heard that All Might visited our town! He wanted to know if you knew anything." Mama clasps her hands together by her face. "He's so considerate. He remembers how much you love All Might."

But alarm bells are ringing in his head. All Might must've just announced his presence in their town if Kacchan heard about it. But when Midoriya slumps back into his computer chair, he sees that there's nothing on All Might's whereabouts at all. Why would Kacchan call and lie? Or, better yet, what if Kacchan wasn't lying and really did hear that All Might was in town? Maybe his friends told him, they're a bit more connected to the bad parts of the population than Kacchan likes to admit.

But why ask Midoriya about it? He told Kacchan nearly a month ago that All Might was here. Why wait until now to ask about it? He once again finds himself wishing that Kacchan's mind wasn't such a mystery.

Finding nothing on the internet about All Might dwindles his spirit almost as much as the lack of information on Eraser Head. Days of research, dozens of websites and chat forums, and Eraser Head remains unheard of. Not even a whisper of his presence, let alone a picture or something. Midoriya has sketched him out in all his glory in his notebook, pulling from memory alone to rebuild the man's appearance. He even searched through Present Mic's digital footprint and came up with nothing about his friend.

Except for that scarf. It's a support item that Pros with less flashy Quirks typically use. Wearing it connects its electromagnetic sensors to a person's brainwaves, allowing a single thought to move the cloth like a pair of arms. It takes a lot of mental strength, not to mention practice, to understand the material. It's inflammable, malleable, strong enough to lift multiple people at once, but breathable enough to wrap around your face and have no issues whatsoever. When Midoriya makes it into UA, he wants one of those.

The longer he thinks about UA, the more his mind drifts back to All Might. He hasn't dared to look into him yet, too afraid that his image of a strong-willed Hero would shatter. But if Kacchan is sniffing around, there's probably a good reason why. Maybe All Might is interviewing successors? Kacchan would make a wonderful choice, even it sends such a visceral pang of jealousy through Midoriya that he has to shut his eyes and calm down for a moment.

If Kacchan is getting a fair and honest shot at All Might, then Midoriya should too. He's worked just as hard for a chance at being something greater than himself. Any way to pull head, he's got to take it.

The search begins with Channel 9 News. These producers are infamous for always making it too late to a scene, typically reporting on facts and details provided after an attack rather than during. Midoriya goes through three All Might fight aftermath coverings before he finally lands on one from four years ago. The reporter talks about the way All Might saved cars from falling off a broken bridge, and as he goes, a thin and bony man can be seen in the background. He exits from a building, disappears into a crowd of people, and nobody bats an eye.

"Genius," Midoriya mutters. He gets away from the scene by making himself practically invisible. A macro celebrity who will never be recognised in public without explicit intent. He's essentially created an alter ego, hiding his name and true identity behind muscles and strength.

So who is he?

It takes a long while to find anything. When an article does come up, it's been buried under years of All Might slop. But it catches Midoriya's eye, dated over twenty years ago.

"All Might, the next big Pro, according to Nana."

He clicks the link, and the article opens to a beautiful woman with long, black hair. It's pinned out of her face elegantly, giving way to dark eyes and a carefree smile. He recognizes her instantly. Nana Shimura, ranked as the number eight Hero worldwide before…

Midoriya's eyes blow wide. She was killed years ago, though her death was never confirmed outright. The article must've been released sometime after she passed, then buried for its harsh handling of her death. But it's written clear as day.

"All Might and I have been working together for some time now," Nana claims. "Now that he's 18, I truly believe he'll make a wonderful impact on the Hero world."

She talks about his success story, how her predecessor trained her, and how she passed on her knowledge. It's something All Might had said as well. He needs a successor soon to pass his knowledge on to. Perhaps there's some kind of secret code, some kind of bizarre training technique that gives success?

He leaves that article, types, "Nana Shimura predecessor."

No results found.

Huh… that's weird.

"Who trained Nana Shimura?"

No results found.

"Nana Shimura training All Might."

No results found. Even the website he came across by pure chance has no connection to the code words he's typed. But why? How is that even possible? Google's coding uses an AI to scan text and pull repetitive words from articles to formulate an accurate search result. So, by all accounts, the article he found should be popping up.

Unless someone tried to bury it.

He goes back to the original website. The article wasn't even officially published by its source, just a fake url that seems accurate at first glance. Why go through this trouble? Why post an article that was nearly wiped off the internet?

He scans through it again, all the text containing the full interview, and that's it. It briefly mentions her life as a mom and grandmother, and nothing more than that. Then, tabbed at the bottom, is her cause of death. He scans it again, again, reads about her insistence that All Might would be the next best thing. The text at the bottom. Read it again. Next best thing. Text at the bottom.

Text at the bottom.

"Nana Shimura was killed in battle against All For One."

All For One.

A few clicks and he's back at that video of All Might emerging from flames, carrying innocent bystanders on either shoulder. Claiming no one needs to be afraid now that he's here. Claiming everything is all right now that he's stopped the evil. All For One.

He types that into the search bar.

Only All Might articles comes up, and the name of his Quirk, which he's called "One For All."

A direct opposite. But why? How? All Might couldn't have known that Nana would die days after his 18th birthday to his arch nemesis. He couldn't have known that All For One even called himself that, not unless he told him himself. Nobody knows what that name truly even means. Nobody except…

Midoriya.

He rummages around under his bed. It's where all his dirty clothes go when Mama insists he needs to clean his room. It's where a bloody brick lies in a paper bag. And it's where a silver watch sits in a small wooden box. He pulls it free from his spot in the corner. Despite his habit of pawning jewellery, he couldn't bring himself to get rid of his father's watch.

He supposes it comes in handy now.

Midoriya flips it over, reads the name and message engraved in the metal banding.

"For my brother, Yoichi Shigaraki. The only gift I can give you is time, use it wisely."

His dad's name is Zen, and the last thing he did was give gifts. Midoriya strokes the words with a fingernail before going back to the computer. He types in Yoichi's name and is shocked to see only one result. He clicks it, and the entire screen goes black. His computer hums and screams, and Midoriya has to shut it off before it explodes. Still, steam rises from its insides, and he cusses as he shoves the bedroom window open.

Okay, different approach, then.

"Mama?" She's on the couch, scarfing down some plain noodles. When she sees him, she smiles wide and sets the bowl down to grab the remote and pause her show. It's almost unfair that she's so kind, so sweet, given how much of a monster his dad was. "Can I ask you something?"

"Sure, baby." She folds her hands in her lap. "What is it?"

Midoriya shifts his weight on his feet. "Did dad have a brother?"

Mama stares at him for a long time, her lips slightly parted. "He… yes, he had a twin, I believe."

Midoriya nods slowly. "What happened to him?"

Mama blows out a breath of air. She tucks a stand of hair behind her ear, sits up on the couch. When she pats the cushion beside her, Midoriya takes it. He feels awful. She got off work early today and planned to relax, and here he is, asking about dad. He's a taboo topic around here.

"Your dad is old," she confesses, staring off at the frozen TV. "Older than most people should be."

"So his brother died of old age?" Midoriya asks.

Mama nods. "For his sake, I hope so."

"Why?"

Mama grabs his hands, squeezes them. "Zen is cruel, manipulative. I can't imagine growing up with someone with so much… power. It was hard for me, and we had only been together a few years."

“Because he was abusive?” Midoriya asks.

“Yes,” Mama says softly. “And addictive, too. He used to… It’s kind of embarrassing."

“What is it?” Midoriya asks.

Mama turns to him, her work uniform still tight to her skin. “He used to give me things, then take them away. It’s how I fell for him in the first place. He seemed charming, clever, and claimed he was going to change the world with his Quirk.”

“What would he give you?”

“Anything I asked for,” Mama says slowly. “Super speed, fire control, mind reading. And whenever I made him upset, he’d take my Quirk away for as long as he deemed fit.”

The blood drains from his face. “He could… *give* Quirks? I thought…”

“Oh, he could,” Mama laughs sadly, “he and his brother lost contact for a bit when he gave him one years ago. When he found him again, his brother had already given it away.”

Give…

Quirks… away.

I need to pass on… my knowledge.

Holy. Fuck.

“You’d be surprised what people tell you when they’re half awake! I used to slip sleeping meds into his meals so he’d tell me more. I guess I was hoping I could use it to get us free of him one day.” Her face is beet-red as she says it, as though she’s ashamed that she’s a badass. “Who knew all it took was my four-year-old begging me to just leave? I kept pushing it off and waiting for the right chance to get out of that house… but maybe I had never stopped hoping he’d turn back into that man I fell in love with.”

Midoriya frowns, pulling her into a hug.

“Kind of pathetic, I know,” Mama sobs, “I thought I was over all this, but… he scares me still, Izuku. I keep thinking he’s going to find us after everything we did to survive.”

“He won’t,” Midoriya says, certain, sure. “I promise.”

He’ll make sure of it, just as he’s always intended to. But with this new information about All Might, plans have changed.

He had planned to kill his dad slowly, horrifically, Quirkless and angry. Unrecognizable until his own cruelty bled through, an unfortunate genetic trait. He’s never killed before, but he knew, since the moment he reached for those keys by the crack of the closet door, All For One was going to die. And he’d be the one to do it.

But now? Now things have changed. No more guesswork to get into Hero school. No more written letters, begging the school board to lift their Quirkless ban. Now, Midoriya Izuku has a clear path to becoming a Hero who doesn't do what is right, but what is necessary.

He needs All Might's Quirk. And he's going to get it. He made a promise ten years ago that no one would hurt his Mama again. He's planning to keep it.

So as Mama cries, he strokes her hair and plans. Nights spent sleeping in an abandoned building. Years of being bullied in school. Changing his hair and eyes and ears permanently. Rejected from jobs, from society. The second he has a Quirk, that all goes away. And he knows exactly how to get it.

Chapter End Notes

meowza

Chapter 8: Swan dive

Chapter Summary

Bakugou says the iconic line and Midoriya hunts down a quirk

TW by the way

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“These applications will be handed out to future high schools. Try and pick based on the job field you want to go into.” Midoriya scribbles in his notebook as the teacher passes out sheets of paper. “I know you all think your Quirks are something special, but let’s be realistic, we can’t all be Heroes.”

There’s joking and laughing, friend groups throwing quips at one another. Midoriya never really understood that. He’s always stood on the outside of social circles like these, never quite managing to blend in. A few new kids had given him a chance, but the moment they realized he was Quirkless, they stopped giving him the time of day. It was better to be alone than it was to interact with someone like him.

He remembers how hard it was when he was younger. He couldn’t understand what was so wrong about him. He did everything he could to try and appeal to his peers and fell short every time. It was worse when the kids themselves didn’t hate him, but while the parents did. Every time a kid turned him away, they never really understood why. As they aged, it solidified, and they began to hate him on their own. But there was a time when Midoriya was just another kid on the playground.

If he’s honest, though, he’s never really fit in. He’s always too much or too little. Too excited about one thing and not excited about another. He couldn’t understand references or master surface-level conversations. His only friend had been Kacchan, and he knew that, had they not been practically forced together, then Kacchan never would’ve wasted his time. PM was there for a bit, too, and Midoriya has read their conversations a dozen times and still can’t figure out where he went wrong with it all. He thinks maybe he was too much, maybe he should’ve kept his mouth shut about his nightly habits. Or maybe he was too quiet, maybe he should’ve lied about an amazing, wonderful Quirk that he didn’t have. He’s not sure. He never really has been.

He keeps his head down, skin crawling every time eyes glaze over him. He’s not very outspoken about his plan to get into UA, not even Kacchan knows. If there were a way to request admission dates that wasn’t through his school, he’d do it, but since there isn’t, he’s forced to write it on the sheets handed out. His next few choices for high school were picked

only because they had high acceptance rates and wouldn't think twice about him being in their program until it was too late. But UA is his top pick, and soon, it'll be his reality.

He turns the sheet in, gets tripped on the way back to his seat, but it's fine, he's fine. He keeps his head down, keeps a low profile. He only looks up once to see Kacchan glaring at him, the rage unfurling from his body in waves. He looks away quickly.

"Hey, Bakugou, you're going to UA, right?"

"No shit," Bakugou says, leaning back in his seat and pointing a thumb at himself. "I aced all the mock tests. I'm the only one at this school who stands a chance at getting in."

The teacher shuffles the papers around, reads each sheet carefully.

"I'll end up more popular than All Might himself."

Midoriya keeps his head down, listening to the tirade and counting down the minutes until the bell rings.

"And be the richest Hero of all time."

A few cheers, more papers shuffling.

"People from all across the world will know who I am. And it all starts with UA high!" Kacchan shouts, hands splayed and ready to blow.

"Oh yeah, Midoriya, don't you want to go to UA, too?" The teacher asks carelessly.

He freezes, slowly looking up from his seat. The room has gone quiet, students swiveling to turn and look at him. His face burns, nerves jitter along his skin. Then the laughing starts. A few pencils are thrown at his head, paper wads, too. His legs shake with the sound of it. On the outside of an inside joke, he looks down at the desk again.

"Midoriya? You're kidding, right? There's no way you're getting into the Hero course without a Quirk!"

He stands up, trembling in all limbs. "T-They got rid of that rule! I c-could be the first one—"

An explosion sends him flying from his seat. His chair is lost somewhere across the classroom, his desk taking the brunt of the flame. He's quick to back up, back pressed to the wall, but Kacchan is quicker.

"Listen up, Deku." He hovers over him, eyes wide and hard, his hand angled to blow at any second. "You're even worse than the rest of these damn rejects, you Quirkless wannabe."

"Kacchan—"

"You really think they'd let someone like you in when they could have me?"

"No, you've got it all wrong—"

“Do I?”

“I-I’m not trying to compete against you! You gotta believe me!”

Kacchan tilts his head, unnaturally still as he stares down at him. His eyes flash to Midoriya’s collar, and when he sees small yellow traces of the bruises that have yet to disappear, smoke drifts off his palm.

“It’s just that… I’ve wanted to be a Hero since I was little. I may not have a Quirk, but I can still try my hardest, can’t I?” He stares up at Kacchan, his face still warm. “Can’t I?”

“You’ll never be anything,” Kacchan spits at him. “You’ll die in the entrance exam. Defenseless. Worthless. This school is already shitty, you really want to embarrass it more by failing in its name?”

“Sit back down, please. I did have a lecture planned for today,” the teacher finally intervenes, though he doesn’t seem too bothered by all this. “That means you, Bakugou.”

Kacchan does. Slowly, with another added glare, he sits back in his chair. Midoriya gets up too, locates his own chair, and drags it back to its place. His desk has a large, ugly black mark from where Kacchan touched it. He stares at it blankly, his entire body weighed down.

He needs to get into UA. He needs to prove Kacchan wrong. He *will*. He knows he will. It’s everything he’s ever wanted. He can’t have gone fourteen years wishing for a miracle just to never receive one. He’s going to be something. He’s not going to rot in a molding house with no one to remember him by. He’s not going to call this his peak, he’s not going to give up.

Tears prick his eyes, and he keeps his head low to hide them. He thinks about Rin, about how even the mighty can fall. He wishes he were anyone else.

When the bell rings, he’s slow to pack up. Piece by piece, he packs his bag. Notebook, folder, pencil. He’s heavy yet empty at the same time. Rent is due soon, he needs to head to Tokyo to help out. He doesn’t have time to sulk.

Kacchan is waiting at the door with two of his lackeys. “You know…”

Midoriya looks away, stares out the window. One tug on his backpack and an asshole has his notebook. He tries to take it back, but they toss it to Kacchan. He takes one quick look through it before tossing it between his hands, lighting it up with explosions.

“Stop!” Midoriya pleads, and when he reaches for it, Kacchan tosses it out the open window.

He doesn’t think he’ll make it to Tokyo today. Maybe not even a patrol tonight. He’s lost a lot of data in that notebook and… and he doesn’t want to deal with this anymore. He doesn’t want to keep coming to school just to leave with less than he came in with. He just wants to go home.

“If you really want to be a Pro, there might be another way,” Kacchan says, that same shit eating grin on his face. It feels dull, fake, so Midoriya looks back at the window.

It’s a clear day today, the first in months. He thinks of the clear days he used to have with Kacchan when they were kids. They’d go to the river and play, or Mama and Auntie would take them to the mall to buy All Might cards. Or they’d stay up late at night and try to count the number of stars in the sky until they fell asleep on top of each other.

“Just pray for a Quirk in your next life.” Kacchan slides the door open. “And take a swan dive off the roof of the building.”

He goes numb. Cold. When he turns to face Kacchan, he’s greeted with a small explosion and a nasty glare. That’s not right, that’s not the Kacchan he knows. Kacchan is mean and abrasive, but he would never go this far.

Or maybe Midoriya had fooled himself into thinking Kacchan was something he’s not. Smart, clever, strong, but certainly not a Hero. Not when he looks like that. Not when he says such horrible things. Not when he dedicates his privileged, lucky life to making someone else's life harder. What the hell did Midoriya ever do wrong anyway? He told Kacchan a secret before hatred was ever instilled in him, so why did Kacchan share it? What the hell did he gain from someone else’s loss?

His blood pumps, and he opens his mouth to yell, to shout, to say something.

“Something wrong?” Kacchan asks, eager for a fight.

A lot is wrong. Midoriya is Quirkless. All Might is a sham. A notorious super villain is his father. Some Pros are corrupt. He almost killed a man.

He did. Midoriya. Not Kacchan, not All Might. Midoriya saved that woman, and Kacchan doesn’t get to take that victory away from him. He’s already taken everything else. From this moment forward, he won’t waste his time holding out for a dream that will never come true. Kacchan doesn’t care for him; he likely never has, and so he’s not worth Midoriya’s time of day.

It’s an odd sort of feeling—to detach. He feels the hand he’s once extended begin o run cold, turn blue, then freeze right off the limb.

He stays quiet, and Kacchan spits at his feet before leaving. Only when he’s gone does Midoriya peer out the window and spot where his notebook landed. He’s down at the koi pond pretty quickly, pulling the notebook from the water with a shake. If he dries it right, it won’t be totally ruined. He can’t really afford a new one right now.

“Stupid, Kacchan,” he mumbles, shaking his head. “What would you do if I really jumped?”

Nothing. Nobody would. And for a moment, disappearing into an eternal bliss sounds nice. It would feel precisely like it does when he jumps across gaps between buildings. Freeing, open air. Something he chooses to do of his own volition, no longer a choice for someone else to make.

What would it be like? He could let someone else take out All For One, could let his Mama succeed in a job that doesn’t underpay her, with a best friend who is no longer disgusted by

her. He could do more for his Mama if he were dead than he ever could if he were alive.

Without thinking, he climbs a flight of stairs. Then another. Then another. And the roof door hardly weighs a thing. There are no fences guarding the ledge. There are no students around. Just him and the open air.

And the ground.

It wouldn't even hurt. If he jumped right, he'd feel nothing at all. There'd be no put-together body for Mama to bury, so there'd be no funeral. She'd mourn alone, but maybe that's for the best. She's young, she could have more kids, a family like she's always wanted. And they all have some special Quirks that she'd be proud to see passed down. She could be something if Midoriya becomes nothing.

His promise feels… feeble compared to that. He won't have to protect if he never flies into his father's radar. She could live long and free, with a new identity and a new family. And he wouldn't hurt anymore. He'd take All Might's secret to the grave, and the kids at school would get what they wanted.

He'd be free.

Midoriya looks over the ledge. He bends over, unties his shoe. No note would be better, then Mama wouldn't have anything to dwell on—

"Deku."

He jolts, nearly teetering off the edge. Whipping around, he sees Kacchan at the roof door. He's panting, shaking, and Midoriya comes to the conclusion that he must've run here. Why?

"You're mom called me. She wants you home, now."

Midoriya blinks, furrows his brows. "What—"

"Go home," Kacchan demands. "Your mom called, she wants to see you."

Midoriya swallows. "I-I wasn't going to jump—"

"I know," Kacchan says, but he doesn't take his eyes off him. "I left a pencil up here. I didn't come for you."

"Oh." Midoriya rolls his shoulders. "Right, uh… hope you find… your pencil."

"Yeah." But Kacchan doesn't search for it. He waits at the door. "Are you going?"

Midoriya scratches his head, his opposite hand drumming his fingers on his damp notebook. He looks at the bright sky behind him, then turns back to Kacchan. He bends down, ties up his shoe again, and moves to pass him. Kacchan says nothing, doesn't even look at him. He doesn't say anything either.

When he’s back on the ground, he stares up at the roof. He swears, for a moment, Kacchan is still up there, peering down at him. But he blinks, and the sight is gone. Maybe it’s a sign or something that Kacchan lost his pencil, accidentally keeping him alive. Works out in his Mama's favor, he guesses. Though it’s weird that she’s off work early and called Kacchan to let him know. She’s been so happy since their last call, so it’s not far off that she’d reach out again to check for the food he allegedly promised her.

Weird.

Midoriya keeps going down the road, kicking rocks in his path. He’s never come that close to it before. It’s crossed his mind a few times, but he hasn’t ever given it that much effort before. He’s thought about it, often dreamed of it, but he’s never… god, he’s an idiot. Mama would be devastated. She got stuck with him, but it would be impossible to say she doesn’t love him. It would ruin her if he died. And dad could hear about the report, locate her, and kill her. He would’ve doomed her all because of stupid Kacchan.

“Stupid, stupid,” he mumbles, kicking another rock.

He stops in front of a building with TVs in the window. People have gathered around, hands over their mouths. But it’s their murmurs that drew him in. On screen is footage of what looks like sludge, grey and green and purple, flying through the streets and knocking down everything in its path. Hot on its heels is no other than All Might.

Here, just a few blocks from where Midoriya stands now. The chase is live, ongoing.

This is his chance.

He pushes in front of people to get a better look. The camera pans down a few different streets, even pulling from a helicopter up above that’s filming as well. Midoriya recognizes a nearby store, a piece of graffiti that looks familiar, a shopping bag that hints at the villain's location. He’s heading West, so Midoriya is, too.

He turns instantly, begins his run down the street at full speed. The villain was moving at a high speed. He’s not quick enough to outrun All Might, but his liquid texture and fluid movements must work to his advantage. Midoriya likely can’t beat him to his next location, so… so he needs to think like him. If he were a villain, where would he hide?

The abandoned building crosses his mind. But it’s too on the nose, too conspicuous. A villain made of liquid would want to hide somewhere he can blend in, and somewhere he can easily escape from.

The sewers! Most manhole covers are solid, but he happens to know the location of a grated one with a perfect tunnel system. It was his backup hiding place in case a Pro decided to chase him down again, but that just makes it the most ideal place for a villain to think of.

He changes direction, sprinting towards a smaller part of town. Any Quirk that can change the build of a person has been Midoriya's favorite. It’s beyond interesting to watch. Sadly, they aren’t very accepted by the world, but it doesn’t change how amazing he thinks they are. How cool is it that a physical form can be altered so significantly by just one strand of DNA?

When Midoriya makes it to the sewer grate, it’s quiet outside. Most people ran and hid indoors or tried to flee the path of the villain. It leaves the surrounding area deserted. A helicopter flies aimlessly ahead, searching the floor below, and Midoriya takes the chance to duck under a small overpass. The bridge covers him from view, the sewer grate glaring at him from the opposite end.

Literally.

Eyes peer at him from the metal before sludge pools out of its opening. Midoriya watches, utterly enamored by the blending and bending of the Quirk. He should run, he knows he should, but—

But All Might always stays to make sure the victims of an attack are okay. And Midoriya wants that fucking Quirk.

So he's going to get it.

The smudge expands, opens its jaws. Midoriya stands completely still. And welcomes it.

Pressure hits him hard, slick liquid moving along his body. His arms are seized, legs flailing as the blob picks him off the ground. He screams in pain when it shoves itself into his nose, but it only uses the opening to push into his mouth, down his throat. He gags, chokes, and the sludge keeps moving. He swears he hears a small apology, but it doesn’t stop the torment.

Oxygen zips out of his chest, pressure builds behind his eyes. He feels like he might pop. Spots spatter his vision, his blood pumps and his heart beats so loud that he can feel it in his head. It *hurts.* He aches, he seizes, his mind is claimed by memories of Bluer pinning him down and strangling him.

Come on, All Might, come on, All Might.

Black dots melt away his vision, muffled nothingness fills his ears. His heart skips and aches, his arms go limp—

“I am here!”

He passes out.

Chapter End Notes

bowowowo

Chapter 9: Generous donation

Chapter Summary

Midoriya finally gets to talk to All Might

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Slight pain stings his cheek. Like an annoying mosquito, an incessant pest swats at his face. It takes Midoriya a minute to open his eyes. When he does, the world is blurry and bright. He blinks a few times, stares up at the masculine face hovering over him.

“Thought we lost you there!”

Midoriya blinks at All Might before screaming and backing away. ALL MIGHT. ALL MIGHT! His plan worked! All Might just saved his life!

“Well, looks like you’re moving around all right.” He smiles wide, waves a hand. “Sorry about that back there. I’m usually better at keeping bystanders out of the line of fire. But you appeared out of thin air! Ha ha ha!”

Midoriya stares at him, slack-jawed.

“Thank you for your help! I never would’ve caught the villain without you!” All Might holds up a soda bottle filled with sludge. What once was a large, intimidating villain is now a colorful liquid trapped in litter.

The real All Might is standing in front of him! Amazing, world-shaking, All Might! He’s got to get an autograph!

Midoriya grabs his notebook, opens it to the end—

All Might has already signed it! He nearly faints but manages to move his body into a deep bow instead. “Thank you thank you thank you!”

All Might gives him a thumbs up before dropping into a squat. He stretches his legs out, cracks his knuckles. “Well, I’ve got to get this evil doer to the police! Stay out of trouble!”

Midoriya’s good mood suddenly drops. “You’re… leaving? So soon?”

“I’m a busy man, what can I say?” All Might bends, readies to take off.

But he hasn't even asked him his questions yet. He hasn't warned him about All For One. He hasn't gotten the conversation he's only dared to dream of. All Might can't leave yet.

But the Hero pushes off the ground, launches into air.

And Midoriya grabs onto his large pockets, his arms screaming at him with the sudden force of being thrown hundreds of feet into the air. He holds the cloth tight, fingernails scraping against the plastic bottles and the wallet laying within. Mid-flight, a bottle slips loose, and Midoriya just barely pushes it back into place. That would've been awful if it had wiggled loose.

All Might hums to himself before looking down at the ground below. When he sees Midoriya's hands, he stares for a moment. Midoriya is certain All Might yells something at him, but the wind pressure is too strong. He just holds on tight, feeling infinitely more secure when All Might lays a large hand on his backpack to keep him in place.

His eyes ache, and he'd shut them if it didn't mean missing a single moment of All Might. He's touching *the* All Might, smelling the cologne of *the* All Might. Mama won't even begin to believe it! He looks up at him, and watches as All Might coughs into his hand, a string of blood trailing down his fingers. He looks away before All Might notices.

When they finally land on the roof, his hair is wind whipped, his lips are chapped, and he's fairly certain he will fall over if he tries to stand up. Jumping roofs is one thing, soaring through the air at an uncontrollable speed with zero safety gear is another. He dry heaves, blinking the dryness from his eyes.

"Not smart, kid," All Might says, patting his pockets. "Now I must leave promptly."

"Wait—"

"No. I have no more time—"

"Please! I need to know."

You're nothing.

You'll always be Quirkless.

Take a swan dive off the roof.

Sometimes it's best to know when to give up.

"Can I still become a Hero even if I don't have a Quirk?" All Might stills on the edge of the balcony. "I'm a normal kid without any powers. Is there any hope I could ever be like you?" He stares down at his red shoes, Quirkless branded. "I want to be a Hero who does what others can't. I want to save the world."

When he looks back up, All Might has deflated. They look at each other for a moment, and then Midoriya remembers he's not supposed to know All Might looks like this naturally.

“Oh… uh… ewwww…” he mumbles.

All Might narrows his eyes. “You can’t ever tell anyone about my true form.”

Midoriya nods, and watches as All Might slumps down to the ground. “What… happened to you?”

All Might doesn’t smile. He doesn’t even sound happy. He lets out a long breath, dabs up his bloody mouth with his grey shirt, and levels Midoriya with an exhausted look. He’s truly tired, body sagging with a weight no one else can see.

He lifts his shirt, reveals a gnarly injury in his side. “Years ago, I was injured by a villain. He took nearly my entire stomach with one blow.”

Midoriya remembers that fight, he’d rewatched the grainy footage a thousand times over.

“I can only maintain my form for three hours a day.” All Might rests the back of his head on the roof railing. “I lost… a lot.”

“I’m sorry,” Midoriya says softly, head down. “I can’t imagine.”

“No, you can’t.” All Might uses the rail to stand. Midoriya offers help, but the Hero just shakes his head. “Pro’s risk their lives every single day. When you’re out there, you make the choice to put yourself on the line for someone else. There’s no time to hesitate, to slow down.”

Midoriya waits, eager, gripping the straps of his backpack. His favorite Hero, his idol. All Might is on his side, All Might wants to give his Quirk to whoever took out Bluer. This is his chance. UA. Hero school. A future as a Pro.

“You want to know if you can be a Hero without a Quirk?" All Might asks, the wind blowing the loose strands of his hair. “You can’t.”

Something cracks. He’s fairly certain it’s in his chest, swarming around his stomach.

“I can’t see a reality where someone with no Quirk could do even half of what the rest of us can,” he says. And it’s not cruel, not mean. It’s honest, and that’s somehow worse.

The rest of us. The people that Midoriya will never mix with, will never have a place with. He’s on the outside of everything he’s ever wanted to be part of. *The rest of us.* But what about him? What about his future, his dreams?

What about him?

“I’m sorry,” All Might says, “There’s plenty of jobs out there, you'd be wasting your other talents trying to become a Pro. I’m sure you’ll find one that fits.”

This was supposed to be the one that fit. This was supposed to be his moment, his chance. He was born to be a Hero, he knows it. Why does nobody else?

“But your Quirk… you need…” how does he word this without showing his hand? “You could train me! I-I could be your successor, you could pass down your k-knowledge!”

All Might lets out a deep sigh. He heads towards the roof door, twists the handle. “Quirkless can’t be Heroes, nothing will ever change that.”

He won’t give him the Quirk. He won’t give him the Quirk. But he has too. He has to. Midoriya has already planned the whole thing out. He’s began to train, to mentally prepare. He can do this. He wants to do this. He wants to be someone. He can make a difference. What happened to Rin, to the woman in the alley, he can stop it from happening to anyone else.

“Y-You need someone who can take out All For One!” Midoriya shouts after him. “I can do that, I *want* to do that.”

“Enough!” All Might whirls, his face drawn. “You don’t know what the hell you’re even saying. I’m not sure who told you that name, but don’t ever repeat it.”

“I—“

“Go home, kid,” All Might says, exhausted. “Pick a new career, excel in it, go home to your mom and dad at the end of the day.”

“He’s not dead,” Midoriya says quickly, hands clenched into fists. “All For One, there are whispers around my town. He’s alive.”

All Might presses his lips into a thin line. “Thanks for the tip.” Then he shuts the door. He’s gone, just like that.

“And thank you,” Midoriya says, digging his hands into his pockets. “For your generous donation.”

He tugs free the wallet he plucked from All Might’s pocket when they soared through the air. In his defense, had he not taken the wallet, then the bottle would’ve just slipped out again. If you think about it, Midoriya saved a life by stealing this.

The wallet is plain-looking—brown leather and foldable. When he combed through interviews and news reports that All Might appeared in without his bulked form, he was able to deduce quite a bit. For example, All Might always pats his left pocket when he leaves a store, his right back when he leaves a building, and stalks off into a crowd where he can effectively disappear. What most people don’t know is that you can often tell what pocket a person uses by just watching them walk down the street.

Midoriya takes out the cellphone he snatched as well, straight from All Might’s right-back pocket. Pro’s rarely keep such personal belongings on them when in uniform. But today, All Might was in tight civilian clothes. He hadn't planned on a villain run-in.

Too bad, Midoriya plans for everything.

Inside the wallet is a gold mine. He has several credit cards, debit cards, a couple of bucks, and the most interesting of all, a government issued ID.

“Toshinori Yagi,” Midoriya reads. “54 years old, six feet tall, blue eyes, blonde hair, male, and… oh.” His address, printed clear as day. “Hmm.”

The phone is next. You’d think the world's number one hero would have a passcode. When you feel so secure and sure of yourself, you never expect something so simple to determine your fate. Midoriya makes quick work of turning off his location, disconnecting Bluetooth, and popping out the SIM card. He can buy a new one for cheap and rewire the phone to be a blank one. He’s never had a phone before, but it’s the least All Might could do for him, right?

Not yet.

Midoriya takes the same door down that All Might did. He keeps his head low as he moves through throngs of people. He feels nothing at all when he pops into the first grocery he sees, grabs a cart, and fills it to the brim with things he and Mama need. Toothpaste, paper towels, toilet paper, new cutlery, new utensils, towels, clothes, shoes for his Mama, shampoo, conditioner, blankets, food. He pulls two carts full of items around the store and checks out without a single problem.

When he pushes his front door in, he still feels this empty pit inside him. He fills it with tasks. Restocking the house, putting groceries away, then heading back out to hit the next store. He buys a new PC, buys a new headset, buys a new notebook, buys a new TV, buys *everything*. He doesn’t stop until he’s crossed off every single thing that other people take for granted.

And then, he buys All Might cards by the box. It racks him higher and higher and higher. The watch and jewellery store is next, and he earns bizarre looks from the jeweller as he buys dozens of Rolex’s and diamond necklaces. Engagement rings, earrings, bracelets, he fills his school bag to the brim, so many products that he feels like he’ll topple over.

Only when that’s done, does he go to his final stop.

“Hello, welcome in!” The front desk lady greets him with a friendly smile. “How are you today?”

“Good,” Midoriya says. “I was hoping to buy some bouquets. Two of them.”

“Any specific colors?”

“Make one pink and the other… make it green, as green as you can.”

“Right away.”

He finds himself ending his day at Rin’s house. The front door is still shut. The windows are still boarded up. Her body still lays inside. Forgotten. Alone. The flower that lay on the steps has withered to nothing. On top of its brown root, he lays the large green bouquet. It’s not

anything special by any means, but he thinks, if she can see him from whatever afterlife there is, she'd be happy to know he stayed green one way or another.

He stays there for a while, staring at the front door of the house. He's not sure he'll ever get the courage to go inside. There lies a woman in there who deserves more than she ever got. He hardly knew her, and it was a choice of his own volition, but it's one he deeply regrets. It's better to be known and loved than to die with no one and nothing. So he honors her by the little he understands about her. With beautiful flowers and a golden memory of a pretty woman, who deserved better cards than the ones she was dealt. He doesn't think of the hoarder with greasy hair and saggy skin, he thinks of her in her prime, remembers her in a way nobody else does.

Then he goes home.

He doesn't realize until late at night, when he tosses and turns, that Kacchan had lied. Mama wasn't at home at all.

Chapter End Notes

ruh roh

Chapter 10: A new identity

Chapter Summary

Midoriya discovers more crime and plans to stop it

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“My favorite businessman!” Chikara cheers when Midoriya opens his door. “I thought you were cheating on me with those scumbags down the road.”

“Never,” Midoriya promises.

He takes a look around Chikara’s small shop. The jewellery cases within are stacked full of random goodies, none of which is anything Midoriya brings in. His items tend to go fast and illegally, not that he’s complaining. He needs money, and this is a good way to get it.

“How much are you willing to take in one go?” Midoriya asks.

Chikara rubs the back of his neck. “Shit, anything, I’ve got to get out of here.”

His fingers are frozen on his backpack zipper. “You’re skipping town?”

“Yeah.” He rests his forearms on the case. “Pros are circling in like fucking vultures. You seen the news? They got Isamu a week and a half ago, slippery motherfucker. I can’t believe All Might captured him.”

Right. The sludge villain. Chikara mentioned that the guy often did his runs around town to sell stolen products. It lines up with All Might's run-in with him, the sludge villain had been robbing a store and shaking down civilians. Midoriya would feel bad that the guy got caught because of him, but the memory of how his body felt as it shut down steals away his empathy.

“Yeah, patrols seem to have tripled since that Pro got attacked months ago,” Midoriya tests.

Chikara takes it. “People are saying the fucker was a woman beater or something. I don’t blame them. If it were my wife? You’d bet he wouldn’t ever make it to the damn hospital.” He shakes his head, ruffles Midoroya’s hair. “I don’t like Heroes much, kiddo, but I think you’ll make a good one. You’ve got the inside scoop that the rest of those goodie goodies don’t have.”

Midoriya offers a shy smile. “And a haul that can get you from this town to the states if you wanted.”

“Big talk from a small guy,” Chikara laughs. “All right, let’s see it.”

With all his strength, he lifts up his yellow school bag. He has filled it to the brim with jewellery, and it weighs enough to nearly topple him over. The bag thuds on the counter, and a few rings and necklaces spill loose. Chikara makes quick work of tugging the zipper all the way down and peering inside.

“Holy fuck.” His large hands shift through the glittering insides, testing for authenticity. He even takes a couple of silver and gold rings out, checks the inside for the small numbers that are always engraved on pure pieces. “Did you rob a fucking jewelry store, kid?”

Midoriya smiles wide. “I had a stroke of luck.”

“Jesus fucking Christ, did you find the end of a god damn rainbow?” He tugs a watch loose, disbelief on his face. “You know this haul could be over a hundred grand, right?”

“I hope so, the bag was pretty heavy.”

Chikara bellows out a laugh, combs a hand through his hair. “Let me call my laundering guy, see if he’s willing to split the profits if he hooks me up with a good deal. I can get you your cash in a couple of hours, but you’ll have to come back tonight to collect.”

“Then I’ll see you in a couple of hours.”

“Hey.” Chikara leans forward, holding up a golden necklace. “Thanks for this, kiddo. My lady’s pregnant, she’s been wanting to get out of this shit town and give the kid a good shot. You just secured that.”

He extends his other hand for a shake, and Midoriya takes it. Paper pushes against his palm, and when he pulls his hand back, he sees a folded slip of paper.

“You ever need something, you got my number. And if you and your mom find yourselves needing a place to go, there’s a couple of guys down East who take people in regardless of Quirks.” He gestures to the folded paper. “Same guys against All Might.”

Midoriya can’t help the wide grin that takes over his face. He only unfolds the paper when he gets home. The back of it has Chikara’s phone number scribbled across it. But when Midoriya flips it, he’s greeted by a color photo of graffiti. It’s red, bubbled, and reads:

ALL HEROES ARE VILLAINS

“A new population is forming. The outcasts, the left behind, the beaten and the neglected. The world has gone too long without any repercussions for its oppressive actions. Join us, and become a United front against the Hero Commission. All entry includes housing and food. We don’t starve you of your potential.”

Below it is a symbol. It looks like purple smoke, with two white, glowing eyes peering at the reader from the paper.

He folds the paper up again, tucks it away in the little box beneath his bed so Mama won't find it. Then he plops into his computer chair, and he thinks and thinks and thinks.

His mind has been a whirlwind lately. The pillars of his fundamental beliefs have begun to crumble. He's learned so much about the world, about himself, and he's unsure how to handle it. The entrance exam is looming closer and closer; with it, his sanity splits. He's still gone to his nightly patrols, still comes up empty, and it's a comfort unlike any other. The night air, the adrenaline. It doesn't seem to wash away the next morning anymore. Maybe it's because he's not cut out for this… or maybe he needs a crime to bust.

He spins his chair around, opens maps. A few towns over, he locates spots and places that look shady. A few bars, clubs, hubs of activity. He puts keywords into his system next, his very own coded AI responding. Without destroying the environment, it summarizes any and all information on a specific set of addresses or locations that it can pull from anywhere off the internet. Within seconds, he's got a screen of information written in green text.

Drug rings, missing persons, domestic abuse. The list tallies on, mentions of illegal activity hinting at something more than he can find surface level. He pulls an IP address from one the bars, taps into their camera system. The footage is live, his headphones blaring with music from inside. It looks like a regular bar, or what he assumes is a regular bar. How would he know? He's fourteen.

Anyway, he takes notes on what he sees inside. Resin countertops, leather barstools. Pricey items for a bar located in a low-income area. Alcohol lines the back wall, the bulk of them mirrored on the glass panel it rests on. There are booths on the opposite side, greasy bar food served from a kitchen that has cameras he easily works through. Karaoke machines that drunk people often vomit on, coat rack at the door, it seems normal.

He goes to the next IP he pulled, jumping into the cameras of a club. A lot more skin is on display than he'd prefer to see, but he works around it. A mechanical bull has a line of people who are far from sober, eager to ride it. More alcohol, more booths, more tables that carry greasy food. Nothing out of the ordinary.

The next location. He taps into the cameras, gazes over throngs of people… and his eyes land on a back door with no cameras that leads to its location. Weird. He moves to an outside street view and is greeted with surveillance that spans over the front of the building. A map view makes it clear the building is boxy, a square shape.

"Weird," he mumbles, clicking back to his regular camera. "The inside of the bar is rectangular, the outside is a square." He's quick to find the blueprints of the building that were sent in an email from a contractor to the owner. He takes the dimensions, fills in the angles and gaps with the numbers listed below.

But the equation doesn't line up. If the dimensions are right, then the bar has been nearly cut in half. Not to mention, Japan's fire laws require multiple exits and windows, none of which this bar has. One entrance, and one other door that leads to, what he assumes, is the other half of the building. When the room was split, the windows and extra door must've been cut off from the main bar. It leaves half the building unregistered and hidden from the population within.

A drunk girl, someone barely older than he is, stumbles across the room alone. She makes it a few steps before collapsing onto a bouncer. Instead of being shoved off or calling an ambulance, the large man hoists her up and carries her through the crowd of people. He opens the back door, goes inside, and returns a few minutes later without the girl.

Oh fuck.

Sex trafficking. Midoriya was looking to capture a low-level villain and instead came across a sex trafficking scheme.

What does he do? Does he call the cops? They can't even search the building without probable cause, and the ramblings of a teenager aren't nearly enough. It's not like he truly *knows* that the bar is really doing this. If he could get evidence, then it would be impossible for the police to deny, and it would make him feel a lot better about the whole thing, too.

So how does he get into a bar?

With a fake ID.

It's easy to type in his town name into his code, mixed with a mention of a fake ID. It spits out the name of a kid from his school, the information pulled from a deleted Reddit thread. Midoriya grabs his jacket and wallet on his way out the door.

He has no idea what he's going to say to this kid. Should he start with, "Hey, I pulled your address from the internet and would like to buy an ID to bust a sex trafficking ring. How much do you charge?" Or maybe, "Do you happen to make fake IDs that can get me into a bar so I can search for drunk girls around my age?" He sounds like a total creep!

He's more nervous than he was when Mama came home from work a week and a half ago to a house full of shit they'd never had before. Her first reaction was to close the front door quietly and see if she had accidentally entered the neighbor's apartment. When she saw it was their home, she then started to cry and asked him if he had gotten into shady business or a debt he couldn't pay. The lie he had spat up was awful and so unbelievable that it's a miracle Mama didn't catch on.

She must've wanted Auntie to like her so badly that when Midoriya said Kacchan's mom had paid for it all, she bought it immediately. She had sent Midoriya to school with long notes and letters claiming she'd pay Auntie back and that she was so grateful for this generous offer. Remarkably, every time Mama tried to call Auntie personally, the phone wouldn't connect. Bizarre. Anyway, Mama fell for it. He had lied and told her that Auntie felt awful for kicking them out, and wanted to settle the score and move on with "mental peace."

Mama's been relishing the fixed bond for days. She cooks as often as she can with a fridge full of fresh food and new pots and pans. She sleeps peacefully at night with a new state-of-the-art security system. She keeps the windows open so the breeze can sway the patterned curtains she's always wanted. Midoriya sat with her for hours and taught her how to use a cellphone, as she hadn't had one since she got with his dad. It reminded him of his mission, his goal, and suddenly his sinking heart from All Might and Kacchan had begun to float, just a little.

He's learned things about himself. He's going to be a Hero, and if he has to do it alone, then so be it. He doesn't need All Might; he never has. He doesn't need Kacchan, he never will. He just needs himself. And that's good, because it's all he's got.

Midoriya knocks on Ito Haruto's front door with so much nerves that he might puke. It takes a minute for someone to answer, but when a teenage boy pokes his head out and sees Midoriya, a wicked sneer takes over his face.

"What higher power did I piss off to be punished with your face outside of school hours?" Ito asks.

Midoriya shuffles his feet. "I-I need a fake ID."

Ito gives him a bland look. "That's illegal, I'm going to call the cops."

"I've got three hundred bucks."

"Four hundred."

"Three fifty."

Ito narrows his dark eyes before tugging the door open. He jerks his chin towards the inside of the house, and Midoroya steps inside cautiously. The inside is a traditional Japanese home. It's much smaller than Midoriya expected, but still nice. Clutter-free, smelling good, nobody would expect a fake ID hub to be operating here.

Midoriya takes his shoes off. When Ito tells them he has to carry them instead of leaving them by the door so his filth doesn't stain the home, he doesn't complain. He just wants to get the ID and leave, even if it means mud stains his clothes from the shoes.

He sits on the tatami of Ito's floor, gazing around his room. Movie posters and band names spatter his walls, little knick-knacks and figurines adorning his shelves. Midoriya has never been in a teenage boy's room other than his own. He feels awkward, uncomfortable.

"I'm tempted to ask why you need this shit, Deku," Ito says, before tugging down a green screen and having Midoriya stand in front of it. "But I really couldn't give a fuck."

He's not sure what the proper response is, so he says nothing.

Ito sets up a lamp, faces it at a certain angle to Midoriya's face, and snaps a photo with a camera he's situated on a tripod. He then tugs a laptop from his school bag and sits crisscross on his bed. Midoriya watches, silent, when he plugs the camera into the laptop with a cable and clicks around on the screen. It's tense, awkward.

"H-Have you heard All Might is in town?" Midoriya squeaks, his best attempt at a conversation.

Ito glances at him for a moment before looking away. "Wonderful."

"You don't like All Might?" he asks.

Ito shakes his head, bleached blonde hair flying. “No, I’m not a fucking fanatic. Is that a problem for you, UA boy?”

“No,” Midoriya says softly. “I don’t like him either, I don’t think.”

“Since when?” Ito says, finally holding eye contact for longer than a second. “You dressed up as All Might for every single Halloween. You talk about him nonstop. Aren't you trying to get into UA to become a Hero or whatever?”

Midoriya shrugs. “I think he’s… a fraud,”

Ito stops clicking around, stares at Midoriya for a second. “Huh.”

“What?”

“I figured you were… different, I guess. Hey, doesn’t Bakugou love All Might? Aren’t the two of you…?”

“Friends?” Midoriya fills in.

Ito snickers. “Sure, let’s go with that. Friends.”

Again, he shrugs. “We used to be. A long time ago. But to be honest…” he’s going to get his ass kicked for this, he knows it, but he’s been dying to talk to someone about his feelings for weeks now. “I think Kacchan is a fraud, too.”

Ito puts a fist to his mouth. “Oooo, Deku has some bite after all. Did you two break up?”

Midoriya furrows his brows. “Like… did our friendship end?”

“Sure, let’s go with that,' Ito says again.

“I don’t know if we ever were friends,” Midoriya thinks out loud. “Guys like Kacchan don’t have friends; they have fans. They have followers and fanatics and it boosts their egos so much that they think nobody else is worth it.”

He’s not sure if he’s talking about Kacchan or All Might, maybe both.

“If that’s the path he wants to take to become a Hero, then so be it. But when I become a Pro, I’m not going to waste my time with fame and adoration.” Midoriya picks a scab on his nail, feeling lighter than he has in weeks. “I’m going to get shit done. Things that really need to change, not superficial shit. Fighting for Quirk rights, or rebuilding broken neighborhoods, or creating spaces where any Quirk can be used, no matter the connotation behind it. I want the world to be safe because people deserve to feel safe. It’s a human right. Kacchan wants the world to be safe because *he* makes it safe.”

Ito watches him for a long moment before looking back at his computer. “You know, my sister was killed by a Pro.”

Midoriya nibbles his lip. “What happened?”

“The Pro was reckless. So hellbent on capturing some villain that he paid no attention to the destruction he caused around him. Insurance went up on cars and homes because he smashed so many in his chase. Rent increased because homes had to be rebuilt. Taxes shot up because the city needed to fix our streets. And people cheered this Pro on when he caught this villain as though he saved the world from some guy shoplifting baby formula for his girlfriend.” Ito looks away, taps numbly on the keyboard. “My sister was in the store where the guy was robbing. He didn’t even have a weapon, was just shoving product into a bag and trying to get home. The Pro barged in and tried to pin him between aisles, and knocked a few shelves over. She got crushed beneath.”

“God,” Midoriya mumbles. “That’s awful. I’m sorry.”

“If you were a Pro, what would you have done?” Ito asks.

Midoriya runs a hand through his curls. “Honestly?”

“Honestly.”

“I’d let him go. Or maybe offer to buy the formula for him so he doesn’t run out. Pros make enough money anyway, I don’t see why they should just sit on it. There’s more important things to focus on than a guy trying to feed his baby,” Midoriya says, picking that same scab nervously.

“I asked Bakugou, and he said that everybody has to pay for things. He said the guy wasn’t any different from the rest of the world, that he didn’t get to get away with stealing shit when everyone else has to pay.”

“Well,” Midoriya says, “that’s because Kacchan sees the world as an equal playing field. Technically, he’s right, but he’s only right because he’ll never be the person who can’t afford to provide for his family. Legally, Kacchan is correct. But morally, he’s privileged. His opinions are formed on the basis of a lack of empathy, of understanding. People like Kacchan will never understand a situation like that, not until he’s lived it.”

“And people like you?” Ito asks, head tilted. “You understand it?”

“Oh,” Midoriya says with a small smile. “You’ve got no idea.”

Ito nods, and a whirling sound fills the air as he prints something. Midoriya stays seated while he moves around the room, grabbing glue and vinyl and a bunch of other products that he takes a mental catalog of. An hour later and a few more stilted conversations, and Midoriya has his fake ID.

He pulls out the cash, but Ito shakes his head. “I only charge $150.”

Midoriya furrows his brows. “But I thought—“

“It’s fine.” Ito takes only a few bills, leaving the rest for Midoriya to put away. “I was going to swindle you, but… I don’t know. I changed my mind.”

“Oh,” Midoriya says. “Well… thanks.”

“Yeah.”

On his way out the door, Ito calls out to him again. “Midoriya.”

He tenses, turns. “Yeah?”

“If you don’t make it to Hero school,” Ito says, fiddling with the door handle. “Consider Adachi for high school, it’s where I’m going.” He shuts the door, and Midoriya descends into silence.

Weird. But okay.

Chikara has a couple of briefcases full of wads of cash when Midoriya shows up later that night. They say goodbye, Chikara urges him to reach out if he needs anything at all, and that’s that. He slips them under his bed when he gets home and waits.

When Mama is asleep, Midoriya pulls on his hood and shoe mods. His backpack is much lighter than before, and his face mask is a welcomed weight. Then he takes off into the night.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 11: Catching aflame

Chapter Summary

Midoriya saves women from a sex trafficking ring

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The moon is hidden by clouds tonight. No stars welcome him, no light dances on the street. Midoriya is, well and truly, alone. But that doesn't mean someone else has to be, so he walks. And walks. And walks.

He'll invest in a mode of transportation later down the line, depending on how successful his admission to UA is. But for now, he walks. Crisp air whips at his hair, stains his cheeks pink. He takes less lit pathways, avoids patrols and Hero's with ease. It takes a few hours to make it to the town of Shika, but when he steps foot across the border, something sinister curls in the air.

His skin breaks out in goosebumps, the wind suddenly whipping between the tall buildings. He needs to think of some way to get to the top of buildings like that. It could provide a great vantage point. For now, he sticks to the street map he sketched out in his notebook and studied. He knows this town as well as he knows his own by this point.

The club, named Aka, sits between two buildings on either side. It's closed during the day, only open late at night when the streets are deserted. Its fluorescent sign out front glows red, illuminating the front entrance. Thank god it's not a club, he's not sure he'd survive a long line and sweaty bodies. Bars are much easier.

He takes a good half hour to check the building parameters. The windows he knew would be on its opposite side are covered with cardboard from the inside. He can tell the frame itself is different from the ones at the front. This one is thicker, screwed in multiple spots, and likely reinforced inside. Not a good look. There's another door here that's made from a different material than the wooden one inside. Thick metal, a keypad, and it leads to a back alley. There's no cars parked here, at least.

Midoriya spots an outdoor trash can for a neighboring store. It takes no time to stuff his hoodie into his school bag, then stuff his school bag into the trash bin. He drags the aluminum to a more discreet spot to hopefully stop anyone from actually using it. He had watched a few YouTube videos that taught him how to do general makeup that would serve to make him appear older, even going as far as shaving his legs just to collect the hair and glue it to his face. Disgusting? Yes. Effective? Unbelievably so. Some insoles push his height

up in his shoes, and padding to a suit coat that he definitely didn't steal off a mannequin gives him bulk he doesn't naturally possess.

He fits the bill, he thinks.

Slowly, timidly, he approaches a bouncer outside. From this close, he can read a sign plastered on the window. "No Quirkless."

He swallows thickly and hands the fake ID over. The bouncer, an absolute giant of a man, darts his eyes back and forth between Midoriya and the card. It's a slow, painful process. Right when he thinks he's been caught and is about to take off running, the bouncer hands the ID back and steps aside to let him pass.

He did it. He did it!

What now?

For all his planning, he hadn't prepared for this. He was kind of hoping that one of the windows would be open so he could snap a quick photo and be on his way. Obviously, that didn't happen.

Now he stands in a bar on a Friday night, packed damn near to the brim, without a clue what the hell he's supposed to do from here. He finds the back door pretty quickly, but it's guarded by two absolutely gigantic guys. Is that just a thing that can happen without Quirk interference? These guys are literally humongous. One has a face full of piercings, the other has slitted eyes like a snake. They both wear black gloves and face masks, which is totally not suspicious at all.

Midoriya keeps his phone low and snaps a few photos of the men. He pockets it right after to avoid any alcohol or vomit damaging it. For a long while, he just observes. He watches how people order drinks, what they order, times how quickly they receive it. He watches how people dance or laugh, ingrains faces inside his head, and matches them to the groups they came with. He mentally tallies the number of people who came alone, pinpoints each location, and memorizes the clothes they wear.

When that's done, he orders a drink.

"Old fashioned, please."

"Tab?"

"No thanks." He slides a bill over the counter. "Can you put a cherry on top?"

The bartender gives him a weird look but does as he asks. The drink is slid over to him in a small crystal glass. Brown liquid swirls around a large ice cube; a Mendocino chair sat neatly on top. He grabs it instantly and pops it into his mouth. Whenever it was his or Mama's birthday, they'd swipe a jar of these from a supermarket. They were much easier to hide than a whole cake or cupcakes. And it was their own little tradition. Who needs presents or parties when you have some sweet cherries? The flavor is sweet, mixed with a husky smoke from his

drink. He's not entirely sure what the hell he ordered, and when he sips from it, he nearly spits it out. It burns and tastes like smoke and bathroom cleaner. What the hell. People drink this for fun? Why?

He keeps his face neutral as he sips again, but his eyes water terribly. It's truly awful. Not even an over the top reaction, it tastes horrible. Still, he matches the pace of the woman at the other end of the bar who is drinking the same thing. She's slow with it, letting the alcohol warm her heart and, apparently, melt her soul out of her ass. How is she so calm? Does it not feel like someone is pouring acid down her throat?

Midoriya glances around, keeps his eyes peeled for any activity. He spots a few creeps lingering and trying to get some play, but nothing out of the ordinary from what he's read online about bars. His face itches, and when he carefully scratches his disguise, he spots the first sign that something about the bar is wrong. A man carefully leans over the counter. The woman he's behind turns to talk to her friend, and just like that, he sprinkles some sort of white powder into her drink. He disappears a moment later, but not before Midoriya snaps a photo of him on his phone as discreetly as possible. Is it really that easy to drug people? Nobody saw anything?

He glances around, catches a few wary glances at the woman and her drink. But nobody says a word, nobody warns her, nobody cares longer than a second. Is this the bystander effect, or a result of fear? Nobody would come to a bar if they knew the truth behind it, right? So are all these people just going to stay silent while a woman is drugged?

The answer, unfortunately, is yes. The woman reaches for her drink, and Midoriya curses before slamming into the guy next to him as hard as he can. The poor guy topples off his stool, into the woman, and spills her drink down the front of her tight dress. She shouts, smacks him, and storms out with a few of her friends.

The guy, however, turns to Midoriya.

"What the fuck, bro?"

Bro?

"What the hellzyour problem?" Oh, he's absolutely plastered. "Cock blockin azzhole."

Midoriya licks his lips, a plan forming. He hops off his stool with his vile drink in hand and shoves any guilt away. A few people gasp when he tosses his drink at the drunk man's face.

"What are you gonna do, pussy?" Midoriya shouts, face red with embarrassment. Kacchan would be so proud of his language.

The man wipes his face off, crooks his arm back, and swings. The thing is, Midoriya has had his ass beaten plenty of times. Those without experience don't usually know that it's the most obvious thing in the world when you're going to punch someone. You can always see their arm in motion, the momentum of their body, the way they lean backwards and fold their fingers. It takes training and thought to go for a swing discreetly. None of which this man has. So when his fist goes for Midoriya's face, he ducks, and the blow collides with whatever

guy was behind him instead. More gasps, and Midoriya slips out from between the two just in time. One guy tackles the other, knocking down a group of girls in the process, whose boyfriends then decide to jump in to defend their honor or whatever bullshit men tell themselves to give themselves an excuse for unnecessary violence. Within seconds, the bar descends into brawls. Even the bartender jumps over the counter to clock a patron.

The guard outside, and the two inside, are quick to try and separate the mess. Midoriya is quick, too. He snaps on a glove that has been stuffed into his pocket in advance and uses it to snatch a pair of keys off the belt of one of the door guards. With those, he darts to the door, shoves it open, and shuts it quietly behind him. He takes a deep breath, then turns around.

Women, a dozen of them, blindfolded and gagged and chained to poles or each other. Most are unconscious, and the few that are awake tremble and cower from the door.

Oh fuck.

Midoriya grabs the nearest chair, shoves it under the bar door. He opens the back door next, retrieves his bag, and slips his hoodie and mask from within. When that's done, he props the door open with another chair and begins the disturbing process of freeing these women.

"H-Hello," he says timidly, unsure what the hell he's supposed to do here. "I'm going t-to untie you."

He goes to the nearest lady, the young girl he saw dragged in here earlier. Her blindfold goes first, to which she immediately screams into her cloth gag. He tries to shush her, and she lifts both legs and kicks him as hard as possible in the balls.

Midoriya squeaks, "I'm trying to help you!"

She seems to process that, glancing at the open door behind him and the keys in his hand. Only when she nods again, does he slit the second key on the holder into her chain lock. It clicks, then falls loose. She removes her gag, rubs her wrists, then stands and sprints out the door. She doesn't owe him any words, her freedom is enough. Midoriya moves to the next woman, then the next, then the next. One of them locates their phone, calls the cops, but he ignores that. He keeps moving, unchaining and assisting, and it's as haunting as it is relieving. For a blissful and awful moment, he doesn't think about anything else. He moves before he thinks, he helps someone who never asked for it, and it binds something inside him that has been broken for a very, very long time.

"Thank you, thank you," a girl cries, "thank you, God, thank you."

He doesn't believe in god, he gave up on that amongst other things. But he can't help the tears in his eyes, this calling inside him. This feeling that, beyond anything else, he is doing what's right. He saw something wrong, and he stood up against it. And maybe it wasn't the legal way to do it, or the easy way to do it, but he *did* it. He is not a stranger in a bar who sees something horrible and says nothing. He is not an abuser who takes advantage of what others can't control. He is not a worthless, useless thing.

He's a person, just as all these women are people. And they deserve, just as he does, something better. A chance at a future that everyone else tells them they can't have. And he does what he can, as much as he can, and it is not for fame, or for money, or for anything other than the relief on their faces when someone is different from what they've been told to expect. He is a wish they've had since they were little girls, since they learned men are a thing to be feared, to be wary of. And it doesn't change that some are. But it makes a difference that one, just one, isn't.

Mama would be proud, he thinks.

When the last woman has been unchained, he sits in a near-empty room. Gently, he shakes away the last few that are unconscious. He tells them where the nearest police station is, says they can wait here if they want for the cops to come. He tells them it's their choice, to do what they feel best. And then he documents.

He takes photos of pill packets, baggies full of dust. Photos of chains and blood. Documents paperwork he finds laying out and scheduling plans. When the room clears out, he doesn't take offense; he just keeps working. Photos of the windows, the keypad door, and chloroform rags. He collects some of it in plastic baggies he bought, just in case.

The bar door rattles, shakes. "Hey! Who's in there?"

Oh shit.

"We gotta bail, Aoi! Cops are here," someone else says. "Shit! Yuto's already dumping the alcohol!"

Midoriya writes the names down, heads for the back too—

The guard from outside is already there. They look at each other for a moment before he smirks, kicks the chair loose, and slams the door shut. Midoriya realizes why a moment later, when the smell of smoke begins to overwhelm the scent of alcohol. Midoriya rushes to the door, but it has no handle; it can only be opened from the outside. He bangs on it, but it doesn't open.

Sirens blare outside, but it's nearly impossible to hear over the screaming music. He reaches for the handle to the other door, but it's scorching hot already. Fuck! He's going to burn to death while Gangnam Style plays in the background. This is humiliating!

He drops to the ground to preserve his air flow, but, in truth, he won't stand a chance in a moment. The entire building is wooden, and once the drywall burns away, the insulation will catch in seconds. One of the guys must've doused it in alcohol and set it ablaze to destroy any evidence. They'd lose their business, but they'd get away scot free with their crimes.

He can't allow that.

"Thanks, All Might," he mumbles, pulling a small ring holder from his backpack, "I guess you helped more than you know."

He pops the velvet box open, revealing a SIM card. It's easy to get his new one out and shove All Might's in. A few moments, and the phone blinks to life. All Might's background is the U.S. flag with dogs in Hero costumes on it. He'd take a moment and coo at the animals if there weren't more important matters. He opens the contacts, stares at a screen that contains what he can only imagine is the most confidential information in the world. But he scrolls until he finds a name he recognizes.

"Okay, Aizawa," Midoriya mumbles, "Let's hope you're a good one."

He sends photo after photo to Aizawa of what he discovered, even going as far as to send the camera footage of the first girl he saw hours ago. It takes a lot of effort, but he manages to get all the photos to Eraser Head without revealing any personal information. Typing bubbles appear, but none are sent, allowing Midoriya to keep going until there's nothing left to send but a synopsis.

He types quickly, lying about half the things he says.

All Might: I located a sex trafficking ring after monitoring camera footage in this bar. I had received an anonymous tip claiming this was a bad part of town, and followed it until I managed to gain access to the building. I've sent the building measurements and blueprints to you as well to show you the conclusion I drew about a hidden back room. In this back room, I was able to locate roughly fifteen women, all chained to walls or pipes, who had been drugged. I unchained them and documented as much as I could in photos. I've also attached images of the men involved. If I make it out of here, I have drug samples to be taken to a lab."

The response is instant.

Eraser Head: What do you mean 'If I make it out of here'. Are you still inside the building?

He can barely hear shouts from outside as something large and heavy caves in on the room beyond. His guess is it's the roof.

All Might: At the moment

He glances around the room, a smoky haze beginning to cloud the air.

All Might: Lol

Eraser Head: Lol? The fuck do you mean 'lol?'"

He shuts the phone off before he sees more of Aizawa's reply.

Quickly, he swaps the SIM cards again. Midoriya then grabs one of the chairs that was kicked loose and smashes it against the window. When it bounces off without so much of a scratch, he knows he's in trouble. Reinforced glass, likely bulletproof. He can't break it. Even worse, regular glass can take heat and warm with it, reinforced glass works better at trapping it. Much like it trapped him.

It leaves the door he came in from as his last chance. Using his gloves, he grabs the handle and twists. The door doesn't budge. They locked it from the other side, too.

"Oh god, oh god." He puts his hands in his hair, paces back and forth. "I'm going to burn alive with Gangnam style playing full blast. I can't believe this."

Think, think, think. How does he get out? What does he do? Is this it? He's going to die here? Alone? In such an excruciating way? Jumping was preferable to literally burning alive! For some reason, he thinks of Kacchan. Things had been good when they were kids. He thinks of the stars they counted, of the movies they'd watch. They both loved those cheesy All Might action movies, where he beat bad guys up and broke down doors…

Break down the door.

Midoriya turns towards it, his heart hammering. Using his shoulder would be a quick way to break it, but his legs have always been stronger than his arms. He looks at the frame, the handle. Where would the weakest point be? The structure is solid, strong. But only spots where hardware has been drilled would weaken the integrity. Which means—

He doesn't waste a second. Lifting his leg, he slams his foot right above the handle. Once. Twice. And on the third kick, with all his strength, the door splinters open. Smoke floods the room, drowning out the cheer of "that was so cool!"

He drops down to the floor again and begins to crawl. Heat licks at his clothes, his eyes burning and watering with it. The entire bar is engulfed in flame. The walls have melted and the insulation caught, damaging the load-bearing beams that held up the ceiling. The speaker still plays, though the song has changed to Blow by Kesha, which is so spot on that he wants to laugh. Instead, he coughs and chokes on his saliva. He needs to invest in goggles like Eraser Head, flame flame-resistant gear would be a good idea too. He's just got to get out first.

The front door is wide open. Smoke blurs his view, but bright red and blue lights can be seen through the haze. Fire trucks or disaster-specialising Hero's should be here soon. They can stop the spread, and Midoriya can get away—

"HELP ME! SOMEONE PLEASE HELP ME!"

You've got to be fucking kidding.

He turns, locks onto a woman trapped under a wooden beam from where the ceiling caved in. He recognises her as the one who ordered the Old Fashioned. She must've stayed seated during the fighting to stay out of it, and ended up caught under a flaming piece of wood. She sobs, coughing and pushing aimlessly at the wood. It's been wedged underneath the resin counter during its fall. There's no chance she can lift it without help.

He moves without thinking, adrenaline pushing him off the ground. He grabs the wooden beam, and with strength he didn't know he had, begins to yank at it. She shoves from her end too, pushing and pushing, until the wood splinters and groans once again. Midoriya shoves it and offers her a hand. She takes it instantly, hair slicked to her face.

When he gets her up, she yelps and stumbles. “My foot, oh my god, I think I broke it.”

He doesn’t hesitate. She gasps, wrapping her arms around his neck as he swoops her up like a baby. He must’ve gotten stronger, or the adrenaline is making him inhuman, because she feels almost light. He’s quick, jumping over fallen chairs and stepping over glass. He narrowly avoids another chunk of the ceiling dropping.

Fire builds, and the exit is blocked.

“Hold your breath!” he shouts at her.

She does, and Midoriya curls her up as much as he can before running through the flame. His clothes caught instantly, and if not for his disguise below, he would’ve caught too. She screams as they run, but the flame doesn’t touch her. He doesn’t let it.

They emerge from the building to a handful of police cars and officers on walkies. A few Pros have gathered, and they point at the flames as he steps through. A helicopter circles above, light flashes as cameras go off from news reporters he can hardly see. The smoke makes his throat ache, his eyes water, and the longer the night air pushes on his skin, the more the pain begins to register. He sets the woman down before dropping to the floor, rolling until he’s extinguished. Even then, smoke rises from his body, his skin burns where the fire pushes through.

And he stands, back facing a burning building, in front of nearly forty people.

He takes off running.

Chapter End Notes

lol XD

Chapter 12: The beginning of an end

Chapter Summary

Midoriya gets in contact with PM and has a minor squabble with Kacchan

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The man, of which media has named 'Viridant' based on his eye color, can be seen carrying a woman to safety and emerging from the bar *on fire,*" a news reporter says, "we've interviewed the woman, and she had plenty to say."

The camera angle changes to a Kobayashi Keiko. She's seated at the back of an ambulance with a blanket over her shoulders, her long, dark hair, framing her face. "He was like a superhero! I thought I was done for, totally pinned under this stupid piece of wood and boom! He's there. He lifts it off me and picks me up without second thought. And when fire blocks our exit, he doesn't even wait, he just walks through it! It was remarkable."

The camera changes back to the male reporter. "Viridant had disappeared after the incident, but police officer and detective Naomasa Tsukauchi claims that he had made contact through a Pro Hero with the man. Viridant had made contact with the bar on a supposed mission to discover and potentially stop a sex trafficking ring. In which, with the vigilantes' support, three men had been tracked down and arrested."

The angles change again, revealing a plain-looking man in a police uniform. "After hours of questioning and lawyer intervention, we were able to offer a lesser charge on the selling out of any conspirators. We will not be releasing any names to the press, but we can confirm that we have pinned down the location of at least four other warehouses, and roughly fifty persons of interest to the crime. No further details will be released."

Again, back to the male reporter. "There's been a nationwide call for the retrieval of this 'Viridant', who's been named a Hero. Over three hundred women and children and over eighty men have been recovered due to the vigilantes' efforts."

"In relation to this," The camera pans to the second reporter in the studio. "A file appeared at the police station days ago that included a full confession from the attacker of Pro Hero Bluer. From none other than Viridant. However, this confession claimed a story unlike one we've heard. Police Captain Tsuragamae Kenji confirms that Bluer had been attacked in an act of self-defense after attempting to take advantage of a civilian. This civilian has come forward after media coverage on the fire in Shika. Here's what she has to say."

A small, timid woman appears on screen. Her short hair is messy, her makeup heavy. "I-I recognized his shoes and backpack from the news, and I knew I was safe to report the

incident that happened months ago. I was afraid no one would believe me… b-but that guy saved my life. Viridant, or whatever they're calling him. Had he not been there that night, I'm not sure what Bluer would've done."

The reporter appears again. "It's been confirmed by police and Pro Heroes who appeared at the scene. Bluer has been charged and faces up to twenty years in prison for multiple accounts of sexual assault and harassment. Pro Hero All Might has come forward with a message to his assailant."

"Whoever this kid is, he's got courage!" All Might booms, smiling wide at the camera. "However, vigilantism is illegal in the country of Japan. We encourage Viridant to pursue a future in Heroism! And, if you're watching this, kid, we encourage you to come forward and accept a personal award for Heroism."

"The Heroes Commission has put out a message in regards to the situation." The reporter says, before switching the camera to words posted on the commission's official website. "We have seen, two times now, the true heart of a Hero. We owe our thanks to Viridant and urge him to continue to take the necessary paths to a career that welcomes him with open arms." The camera cuts back to the reporter. "But millions of citizens across Japan ask themselves—who, exactly, is this kid?"

Midoriya mutes the TV.

Mama is at work. The apartment is dark, only the light from the screen illuminates the space. He sits on the couch, stares at the images of himself on fire. His hood was up, thank god, but he truly looked like something other than himself. He's not sure what to make of it all, but he knows one thing for sure. He is absolutely *not* coming forward to "accept an award." He'd rather die. He was hoping that turning in a detailed confession with evidence to the police would lead to a direct response to shutting the media coverage on him down. Instead, it amplified it. He hadn't expected anyone to believe him, let alone report on it for the country to see.

But it's right there. *He's* right there. Useless, worthless, Quirkless, Midoriya Izuku. He saved someone. He made a difference. Would they still praise him if they knew he was Quirkless? Would anyone have seen him in that burning building and saved him if they knew what he was?

Does it matter?

He saved a life—multiple lives. And he wants to do it again, and again, and again, for as long as he can. A Hero who does what's necessary, what no one else will. A Hero who gets his hands dirty, who isn't afraid to bend the law to save a life. A Hero who changes the world.

Midoriya slowly stands from the couch, wincing at the raw feel of his wounds. The rescue took place on a Thursday, and he slept through Friday. When he woke up on Saturday, it was from throbbing pockets of pain on his body. Even now, on Sunday, he hurts beyond belief. Turns out, the fire did burn through his clothes. His hands and face are unscathed, thankfully. But where his hoodie didn't cover on his neck are bubbles of molten skin. Small patches on his arms, legs, and especially his back are the worst, though.

Who knew getting burnt would *itch?* He has to resist scratching the wounds and instead dab them with cream he bought the same day he turned in his confession and any extra evidence. He still has to buy new clothes—courtesy of All Might's credit card that still hasn't been shut off. He just hasn't had a spare moment to research good material for it. He's been too busy panicking.

He wasn't supposed to be well-known, that's not why he's doing this. But it's undeniable that news about him has spread like fire, get it? Because the bar burned down? Anyway, he's searched through dozens of online forums, Reddit threads, YouTube videos theorizing about his Quirk. He even found a wiki page dedicated to him. It's nerve-racking, even if most of the information is wrong… definitely not because he changed it or anything. For now, his identity remains hidden, but if he plans to keep up with his habits, he has to do it in a way that hides who he is.

When he opens his computer to navigate Google, he accidentally opens an old tab. The chatroom with PM opens up, and Midoriya stares at the new message that came in Thursday night, a mere hour after he ran from the bar

PM: How's those burns treating you?

His heart sinks, but he replies.

AM: No idea what you're talking about.

PM: No? The name Viridant doesn't ring a bell? Such a unique name, I wonder how the media got it.

His jaw drops.

AM: You son of a bitch.

PM: Don't worry, I told them it was your eyes that were green, not your entire head of hair

AM: You told me you never watched the security footage of me after Bluer's attack!

It was one of their first real conversations before PM disappeared off the face of the earth. Midoriya types frantically.

AM: You lied to me.

PM: Of course I lied to you. You thought I'd risk my first-ever friendship? I didn't want to scare you off.

A second message follows that.

PM: I'm sorry.

Midoriya is red in the face when he responds.

AM: You didn't seem to care about our 'friendship' when you ghosted me for months.

PM: I was upset. You made out fine.

AM: I needed you

He only thinks of how pathetic it sounds when he sees those typing bubbles go up and down a few times.

AM: So much shit has happened that I needed to tell someone about. And the one person I thought of had decided I wasn't worth so much as a goodbye.

PM: I'm sorry, alright?

AM: No. It's not alright. Are you going to sell me out to the cops?

PM: Jesus Christ, no, of course not.

AM: Are you sure? You're pretty good at screwing me over.

INCOMING CALL.

Midoriya didn't even know that was an option in this chat room. But there it is, big and bold on his screen. An answer and decline button is just below it. He hits decline, and the call goes through again, this time with the button gone. Dammit. The asshole coded the whole chatroom; of course he took away Midoriya's choice to decline. Will the phone just ring forever?

He waits five minutes, the ringing bouncing through his headphones.

PM: Answer, dickhead.

AM: Fuxk you.

PM: Nice typo.

Midoriya grits his teeth but connects the call. It's quiet for a long while, then a smooth voice crackles over the mic.

"Uhh… Hey."

Woah, that is not what Midoriya expected him to sound like. He didn't know PM's exact age, but he was expecting a bit older. There's no way he's any older than Midoriya is.

"Hello? Did I code it right?" PM asks, then immediately adds. "Don't answer that."

"I wasn't planning to," Midoriya responds.

"Oh my god, you're a squeaker." PM lets out a low laugh. "You're voice just cracked."

"No," Midoriya lies.

“Right, I’m sure.” Silence, awkward, tense. “Listen… you’re right. It was shitty for me to lie, and even more shitty to disappear for a while. The truth is, I was thinking about all the shit you said that day about being worth something and helping people, and it got to me, I guess.”

“Got to you?” Midoriya asks.

PM sighs. “I uhh… It’s hard to word it right. My Quirk is… tricky. It makes it hard to talk. But I told you I get a bad rap for it and I guess… I kind of leaned into that. I know you don’t like to talk about your Quirk or anything, so you probably got stuck with a pretty shitty one, too. So reading about how you wanted to make the best out of yourself despite it… It was a reality check.”

“Oh.” Midoriya flushes. “Thanks.”

“Ew.”

“Shut up.”

“But I’m serious,” PM says quietly. “I needed that. I’ve been studying my ass off and working towards a goal I’ve had for years, but I’ve never really believed I could make it. Then you came around and I pulled my head out of my ass for the first time in years.”

Midoriya let’s out a small laugh. “Would it be weird to say I’m happy for your head? I bet it smelled awful down there.”

“Wow. Here I am, giving a heartfelt apology, and here you are, totally shitting on me.” But PM is laughing a bit, too. “I’m sorry I lied about seeing you on camera, too. To be totally honest, I was going to turn you in to the cops, but when I saw your search history, I took my chance to see if you were a good person or not.”

“And your thoughts?” Midoriya asks.

“You’re a good person, a really good one, I think, anyway,” PM says. “So, let me make it up to you. I know what you look like, but nothing else. Should I send you a selfie or some shit?”

Midoriya laughs, but ultimately tells him no. “It’s your privacy, I won’t violate it. If you really want to make it up to me, then PLEASE teach me how the hell to merge contacts from one SIM card to another. Or, better yet, if I send you a list of phone numbers or names, if you could give me as much info on the correspondent as possible, then we can call it even.”

“Hold on, slow down,” PM says quickly, “Did you get a new phone or something?”

Midoriya nibbles his lip, bounces his leg. “If I tell you something, you have to promise not to share it.”

Images of him and Kacchan late at night flood his mind. They drown under PM’s promise, the certainty in his voice. As though he is taking a blood oath, a vow, a promise to not just keep a secret, but to never betray Midoriya at all.

“I stole All Might’s phone.”

There’s a long, drawn-out silence.

And then, “You’ve got to tell me fucking *everything*.”

So he does. He tells him about his first patrol, about the Heroes he stumbled across. When he mentions Eraser Head, he hears a small gasp of admiration, but PM urges him to continue. He tells PM of his research on All Might, leaving out who his dad is, he explains All Might’s Quirk and how he had planned to steal it. He tells him about the sludge monster, Isamu, and how he flew through the sky on All Might’s leg. He tells him that All Might said he’d never be a Hero, how he stole his wallet and phone, and bought so much shit with it that he’s set for a while. He doesn’t mention Kacchan, or anyone by name, not yet.

And when he’s done, PM is quiet for a while. He waits to be told he’s lying. He waits for the doubt. He waits for the moment of friendship they have to crumble into nothing.

PM says, “I’m sending you a link to an underground Hero forum. Eraser Head is mentioned a lot there. I think you’ll like some of his work. And as far as All Might’s phone, I think I’ve got a good way to transfer those contacts without setting off your location.”

Midoriya can’t help his resounding laugh, the pure joy coursing through him. When PM asks why he’s so giddy, he answers him truthfully.

“I don’t have any friends. I never have. This whole… communication thing, it’s pretty damn new to me. I was expecting you to laugh or make fun of me or end the call, but you stayed.” Midoriya palms his eyes. “I think I’m very lucky to have found you.”

PM’s response is soft, genuine. “I feel the same way. We’re going to be good friends, you and I.”

He couldn’t agree more.

They spend a few hours creating a pseudo-messaging app. It works by essentially duplicating All Might’s Apple ID and layering it atop of Midoriya’s. The message app on the phone operates based off your phone number, which is connected to the Apple ID. PM’s idea was to add a function to the app that allows the phone to pull from the Cloud’s last uploaded data to create a separate messaging screen. It took actual ages to code it, and it’s early in the morning when they finally get it running.

The iMessage app requires a code to enter. Depending on which one he types in, it recalls the data of whatever Apple ID corresponds. Typing in, “Inko” opens Midoriya’s iMessage, which is completely empty save for Mama and, now, PM. But typing in “OFA” opens All Might’s iMessage, filled to the brim with contacts.

They go even further. Midoriya plugs the phone into his PC and transfers over any and all messages and contacts. Together, they alter the AI Midoriya coded and program it to run through the uploaded data. It’s quick, efficient, and summarizes all previous conversations. A quick link to a forum that PM provided, and the AI fills in any missing information

effortlessly. Midoriya downloads all of it into a folder on both his PC and phone, backing up another version into a thumb drive just in case All Might somehow deletes the data.

This is a jaw-dropping amount of information, and so illegal that they could face the rest of their lives in prison for even attempting to do this. But PM did it all anyway, effectively saving Midoriya's ass from figuring this out alone.

The sun is rising when they finally hang up the call. He's tired, but skipping any more school when he's so close to the entrance exam is beyond stupid. So he stands, stretches, applies more cream to his burns, then goes about his merry way.

Chatter about Viridant hasn't died down at all. He sits at his desk, head down, listening to his classmates oooo and ahh over the noble Hero. They're completely unaware that he's sitting right beside them, or that he got his head shoved down a toilet this morning.

His phone buzzes with a message. When he open it, he sees it's from PM. It's a recording. One tap and it opens. Filmed from the back of a classroom that is nothing like his own, PM recorded his classmates gushing about Viridant. One girl even says that he personally saved her, which he definitely did not do, but people gasp at it all the same.

AM: Kill me.

PM: But then who would help all the old ladies in this world cross the street?

Midoriya pursues his lips to keep his laugh in. He slips his phone into his pocket, his heart lighter than it's ever been. The teacher demands the class's attention, and the chitchat about Viridant dies down immediately. All focus is at the board—

Except one.

Kacchan is again turned around in his seat. His dark eyes rake over Midoriya slowly, carefully. They finally stop at his shoes, then flicker to his yellow backpack beside it. He looks back up, meets his eyes, then turns to face the board again. What he would give to be inside Kacchan's head, to know what he knows, to think what he thinks.

Just that one look makes him antsy. He has to remind himself that he doesn't care about Kacchan anymore. He's given up on him, the same way Kacchan gave up on him so long ago. No more wasting time on things that don't matter.

AM: Please tell me you're learning something interesting. My teacher is covering the same material for a third time.

PM: I left class to go smoke weed on the roof. Good luck, though.

AM: Delinquent!

PM: School is insufferable. Everyone keeps talking about you. Yuck.

AM: You gonna cry about it?

PM: I'm thinking about it.

Midoriya bites his lip to keep from laughing.

PM: I've been thinking about your injuries. I've got a list of materials that I think would work well for you. I've got no idea how to sew though, so you're on your own there.

What follows is a list of supplies that can only be purchased at a fabric store. Midoriya reads through it anyway, impressed by the choices. If what he sees is correct, then a flame resistant layer would be added between layers of cloth, effectively hiding the weird textures while keeping him alive. He's lucky that Mama insisted he needed to learn household skills to be a good husband one day. Aside from cooking and cleaning, he's nearly an expert at sewing.

AM: You did all that research for me? Awww.

PM: I actually gagged reading that.

AM: :(

PM: >:)

AM: :o

He puts his phone away again, too worried about being caught on it to keep it out very long. Kacchan's glaring at him again, but Midoriya ignores him outright. It seems to piss him off more.

Oh well.

"You'll have the rest of the class to study for finals next week," the teacher says. "And—"

Kacchan raises his hand.

"Yes, Bakugou?"

"Deku's on his phone." Midoriya's jaw drops. "Model behavior for someone trying to get into UA."

The teacher sighs. "Bring it up, Midoriya."

"But—"

"Now."

Motherfucker.

It takes until the end of the day to get his phone back. The typical procedure is to have a parent sign it out in order to have it returned, but Mama has put the fear of god into Midoriya's school, so they don't chance calling her for anything. After he had been purposely marked down on tests for a semester and came home crying, Mama called in sick to work to

‘handle it’. His grades were fixed the next day. He still doesn’t know what she said, but no teacher ever touches his grade with anything other than the utmost honesty.

He gets a long lecture about respect and moral values that his peers are magically exempt from. But he gets the phone back eventually. PM has texted, and Midoriya responds as he exits the room. He doesn’t even hit send before the phone is plucked from his hands for a second time today. This time, by Kacchan. There are a few lingering students outside, eager to see a fight. Kacchan speaks quiestly enough that they can’t hear.

“You know what I think’s weird?” Kacchan asks him, tossing it between his hands. “How a Quirkless, jobless idiot has the newest cellphone on the market.”

“Give it back, Kacchan.”

“So how’d you get it? Did your mom pick up a third job? Or, hey, maybe you finally landed your first one.” Kacchan grins at him. “Or maybe my mom bought it for you. I think that’s what your mom said on the phone Thursday. So weird, you must not have been home to intercept that all, huh?”

Dread lines his stomach. “Just give it back.”

“Tell your mom how grateful I am, Katsuki. Has my baby been giving you the notes I wrote? Oh, I’m just so thankful, you have no idea,” Kacchan says, mocking Mama’s voice. “What could someone like *you* be doing on a Thursday night? Much less come across what must be at least ten grand in household appliances.”

Midoriya says nothing.

“I’m getting really fucking annoyed with the suspicious shit you’ve been up to. Something’s off with you, do you think I’m too stupid to pick up on it?” Kacchan demands, sneer on his face. “You look different, you act different. Do you think you’re better than me?”

“Just give it back.”

“Or what?” He taps the still-open screen, his voice picking up as kids surround them. “You make a new friend, Deku? Do they know what you are?”

“Stop, Kacchan!” He reaches for the phone, and Kacchan shoves him back.

He presses his hand over his mouth, holding him against the wall. Then he taps the screen again, puts the call on speaker. Midoriya’s heart races, and he again reaches out only to be shoved harder.

Don’t pick up. Don’t pick up. Don’t pick up.

“You wouldn’t fucking believe what my teacher just said.” PM picks up. “We’ve got a free write essay as a final, and someone asked to write about Viridant.”

Kacchan tilts his head, stares at the Caller ID. “Who the fuck is his?”

PM pauses, then says, “The guy who’s bending your mom over the counter every night.”

PM doesn’t know that Kacchan can’t ever seem to take a joke, let alone be made fun of. Every sentence is an attack on him, every word is a threat. He doesn’t pick up on the social cues that the rest of society sees clear as day. He’s constantly on guard, constantly under attack.

“I’ll give you one chance to tell me your name before I blow Deku’s phone into the next room, got that?” Kacchan’s gaze slides to him. “Or you can tell me, Deku, I’d love nothing more than to fucking hear it.”

When PM doesn’t respond, Kacchan lowers his hand for Midoriya to talk. “H-He’s no one, Kacchan. Just give it back. P-Please.”

“Really?” Kacchan asks, eyes ablaze. “Does ‘no one’ know about you? Does he know what you are?”

Midoriya trembles. No one intervenes. “Stop, please—“

“Do you know he’s Quirkless?” Kacchan asks, holding the phone to his mouth. “Did he leave that part out? He tends to do that, fucking liar. Did he tell you he’s going to go to UA? He’s going to be the world's first Quirkless Hero! Round of applause, huh? Takes some real fucking guts.”

Midoriya’s nose burns, his throat bobs, his eyes fill with tears.

“Go ahead, Deku, cry.” Kacchan says slowly. “I’m sure your buddy cares a whole lot, right?”

Kacchan holds the phone upright, waits for PM’s reply. He doesn’t get one. PM hangs up the call, and Kacchan chucks the phone across the hall. It’s quiet now. Kids snicker and laugh. Teachers are sealed away behind doors. Birds swoop down through the window.

And Midoriya is quiet. Just as he’s always been.

“Just wanted to remind you of what the truth looks like, since you’ve enjoyed playing stupid,” Kacchan snips. “Tell your mom that I changed numbers. If she calls my house again, who knows who might answer?” He releases him with a shove.

Midoriya crumbles to the ground, trembling in all limbs. He hurts all over, no direct spot to pin it to. Kacchan kicks his phone back to him when he makes it down the hall. The screen is completely shattered, the sides dented and ruined. It’s all scraped up, and when he taps it, it doesn’t turn on. He holds it in his palms as he boils over, as he crashes down to earth.

“What did I ever do to you?” he whispers.

Kacchan pauses his descent. “What was that?”

Midoriya stands, shouts, “What the fuck did I ever do to you!”

Kacchan stares at him, an unreadable expression crossing his face before anger takes over. “Who the fuck are you talking to?”

“You, dumbass!” Midoriya shouts, screams, rages and burns. “I’m talking to you!”

A couple of *oooo*’s break out.

Kacchan approaches, smoke escaping his clenched fists. “The fuck did you call me?”

Midoriya shakes horribly. “I called you what you are. A *dumbass.* You want honesty from me? Sure, here it is. You are the most miserable, selfish, terrible person I’ve ever met. I have done nothing, *nothing,* wrong to you. I’ve spent years admiring you, caring about you, worrying about you, and you know what? What a waste of fucking time that was. What a waste of time *you* are.”

Kacchan shoves his chest.

And Midoriya shoves him back. “What’s your problem with me? Seriously, I’m dying to know. Is it because I’m Quirkless? Is your delicate ego threatened by me? What is it?”

“I’ll fucking kill you, you think I won’t—“

“THEN DO IT!” Midoriya shoves him hard, watches him stumble. “Come on, Bakugou, do it!”

Something snaps inside Bakugou at the name. He grabs Midoriya by his collar, throws him to the ground. “Don’t you call me that, don’t you ever fucking call me that.”

Midoriya kicks his shin, drags his opposite leg until he falls flat on his ass. “Or what, Baku—

He takes a blow straight to the jaw. But he’s angry, he’s *been* angry. His life has been ruined for *years* because of one measly man. He’s made something of himself, he’s created something for himself, and he’s not going to lose it. Not again.

Bakugou doesn’t expect to be hit right back. Midoriya thinks he may have never gotten in a fight before, because for a moment, Bakugou holds his cheek with his hand. Wide, unseeing eyes are latched onto Midoriya’s face.

Do you see me now?

He tackles Bakugou to the ground. Kids hoot and holler, forming a circle around him. Midoriya ignores them and swings hard, clocking Bakugou right in the eye. Bakugou hits back harder, grunting and flipping them, raging as he slams him to the ground. But Midoriya escaped a burning building and murder conviction, he knows what adrenaline feels like, and he’s *burning* with it. He lifts his head, slams his forehead into Bakugou’s nose, takes an elbow to the jaw just to flip them again.

Bakugou hits his chest, Midoriya hits his head, and he wonders if that’s how they’ve always worked. Bakugou in his heart, Midoriya in his brain. A parasite, feeding off each other, draining the other dry.

Bakugou hooks his legs around his waist, twists his body to the side to gain leverage. Midoriya blocks the first punch, but the second and third and fourth make it through his hands. Smoke pushes from Bakugou's palms, fire burns though his veins, and Midoriya's vision flickers and wavers.

Mama's jaw cracks. She tries to keep silent so Midoriya can't hear from the closet. But he can see. Dad is holding her down, he's hurting her, and Midoriya can finally reach the key.

So he unlocks the door.

He grabs Dad's shirt and throws him off. He jumps on him. He screams so loud it shakes the walls. He makes a difference. He matters. This time, he's the one who hurts *him.* He cracks dad's jaw, he slams his elbows into his ribs, he takes every burning punch in return, and when dad tries to flip them, Midoriya lifts both hands and brings them down on his face. Hard.

The apartment catches on fire, it burns his clothes, his face, sears his skin. He brings his hands down again, wraps them around Dad's throat. No more. No more.

No more hurting. Not Mama. Not him. Nobody is going to hurt them again. He made a promise. Dad needs to die, he *needs to die.*

Dad grabs his forearms; his hands burn, they brand, and still, Midoriya chokes him, squeezes so hard that Mama calls for help, she tries to pull him off. He doesn't let her.

Dad gasps; his red eyes flicker. "Stop."

"Oh my god! Someone get a teacher!"

"Stop," Dad rasps, his hands smoking, searing Midoriya's skin. "De… ku."

"He's going to kill him!"

Dad's face wavers, but his eyes stay the same. Kacchan appears, face beaten and bloodied, only one eye open. He grips Midoriya's forearms, nails digging into his skin.

"I hate you," Midoriya whispers to him, tears dripping off his face. "I fucking hate you."

Kacchan raises a hand, his palm sparking.

"Look what you did to me," Midoriya sobs, "Look what you made me into."

BOOM!

Chapter End Notes

lol XD

Chapter 13: The ashes

Chapter Summary

Midoriya fixes his phone and trains for UA

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya is suspended the same day. Mama left work early. Auntie Mitsuki made it to the school at the same time. Mama didn't get the chance to thank her before Auntie smacked her, hard. Midoriya isn't sure what she shouted at Mama, only that Mama hadn't said a word back. She just held her cheek in her hand.

Mama drove them home silently from the school nurse. His injuries don't require too much care. Kacchan's did. They took him away in an ambulance. The school said they'd send a bill home for all the damages that needed to be covered because of 'Midoriya goading a star student into a fight.' They said his finals could be taken online and submitted electronically to the school, but he would not be allowed back again.

Mama seals herself inside her bedroom. She doesn't talk to him. He can hear her trying not to cry too loud, so he won't hear.

He stands shirtless before the bathroom mirror. His shattered phone sits useless in his pocket. He gazes into the mirror, stares at his arms. At the handprints on either forearm, red and angry, forever tattooed into his skin. And he wishes, more than anything, that he were someone else.

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The flowers he left at Rin's doorstep have withered. He sits beside the remains, dozing off. It's a clear summer day. He aced his finals, graduated middle school in his childhood bedroom. Fifteen years, and he made it out alive.

"It's my birthday, you know," he tells Rin. Her corpse rots in the summer heat. "Mama said I could be officially 'ungrounded' today, gave my computer back, and everything."

He's not sure why this is the first thing he decided to do today. He sucks on a cigarette from a box he stole from a passing stranger. He has begun to like how the smoke feels in his lungs. It

burns like he's alive.

"Is it really so bad that I hit him?" Midoriya asks her, rubbing his eye with his palm. "I hadn't meant to go so far."

Fractured ribs, broken nose, bruised trachea. Mama made him be the one to talk to Auntie about it. She wanted to teach him a lesson about hurting people. Auntie wasn't mean; she didn't even ask for Midoriya to cover the cost. She asked him why he did it, and he said he hadn't meant to. He said it wasn't Bakugou he was hurting, Auntie said he didn't need to say more than that. She told him to take care of his Mama, and then she hung up.

"We have a tradition," Midoriya tells Rin. "We eat these super artificial cherries every birthday. Do you think Mama will remember?" He palms his eyes. "You know, I'm kind of mad at you. You took the easy way out, really bummed me out. I don't blame you for it, we hardly knew each other, but I guess I kind of resent you. Or maybe I'm just jealous."

He stares at the passing clouds.

"You know, I'm beginning to think something's really wrong with me." A long, lung-filling drag of smoke. "I'm not doing so good, I don't think. What do you think?" He looks back at the front door. "Oh, right." He looks away. "Well, I'm off, see you around. Or maybe not."

Midoriya stands, rubs his eyes. He leaves a new bouquet of fresh flowers outside her house. She rots inside.

The repair store he goes into looks at his phone as though Midoriya was the one to smash it to bits. "What did you say happened?'

He purses his lips. "A bird swooped down and grabbed it. Then dropped it from a few dozen feet in the air."

"Right…" The man looks the phone over.

"Then it got hit by a car."

"Sure," he huffs. "You need a new screen for sure. If you're okay with external damage to the frame, then there's no need to replace it. Give me a few hours and I'll have it spick and span for you, yeah?"

Midoriya nods, and then heads down the street for something to do. He's kept his nightly routine, stopped a few muggings and carjackings. He's strayed away from the bigger things, mainly because Mama had his electronics locked in her room as punishment, and he had yet to learn how to lockpick. But the point still stands, he's kept off the internet.

Not maps, though. With nothing else to do, he found a few paper city maps he decided to study. At night, he does his usual patrol, then navigates to whatever town he's yet to discover. Paper maps teach him the layout, and an on-foot exploration reveals hiding spots and cameras to watch for. He's been working on a new costume, too. He managed to remember most of the materials that PM had listed and put them to good use. It's still a work in

progress, as books Mama checked out of the library on sewing years ago aren't the most helpful. It's better than nothing.

He's been working out, too. No school has been making him antsy, so he found something else to fill his time. Mama thinks that, while she works, he sits at home and reflects on his poor behavior. In all fairness, he *has* been reflecting, but not at home. No, he spends his days at Takoba Municipal Beach Park, located right in his town. It's a notoriously fifthly beach, filled with litter and trash. It's been a dumping ground for years.

And he's been cleaning it up. He's not sure why, honestly. He came across it during his nightly patrols and began mindlessly cleaning it. He had been cleaning it for weeks. It's just over halfway done, his days dedicated entirely to it. People have already begun to use it, some going as far as to help pick up some trash here and there out of nothing more than their own kindness. It's been refreshing, relaxing. Not to mention how it's toned him pretty well. Moving furniture and random heavy items has done him good. It's fulfilling.

He works at it now, picking trash out of nooks and crannies, filling disposable trash bags with litter. It's not fun, nor is it easy, but it's necessary. He never asked to be Quirkless, and the Earth never asked to be destroyed. It sustains him, so he sustains it. Hours later, when the sun has started to set, Midoriya returns to the phone store and collects the device.

He powers it on right then and there, sitting on a bench outside.

Over one thousand messages stare at him. Every single one is from PM. His fingers tremble as he scrolls to the very beginning, the date and time stamped a few minutes after Kacchan had thrown his phone.

PM: I'm sorry I hung up. I had a feeling you didn't want me to hear any of that, so I backed out of the call before that dickhead revealed any more.

The next.

PM: Are you okay?

The next.

PM: Was he lying? Are you really Quirkless?

The next.

PM: I assume you're busy. I'll be here if you need me.

The next.

PM: Since you aren't answering, I'm just going to text you random shit about my life. You'll just have to respond whenever you can check your phone.

And PM does just that. The messages range from one thing to the next. In one of them, PM describes why he thinks killer whales are total assholes; in the next, he tells Midoriya that he's in the foster system. One message talks about how springtime is the worst season out of

all of them, and the next talks about how his parents gave him up when they learned about his quirk.

PM started a daily update, strings of messages that came every night before he went to bed, recapping his day. He did great on his final exams, some kids at school picked on him, he got a summer job at a cafe, and on and on and on. He texted about a weirdly shaped crack in the sidewalk, about some gum he stepped on, about how much he hates matcha. He shared photos of stray cats he passed, talked about what books he read, described what it was like to live with three teenage girls.

He messaged Midoriya every single day for over a month.

Midoriya hits the call button, lifts the phone to his ear.

PM answers on the first ring. “I know I was super excited for this job, but I think I’d rather die than go to work on a Saturday.”

Tears prick Midoriya’s eyes. “Are you obsessed with me or something? Over a thousand messages.”

“Yuck,” PM says, “Please tell me you whooped that guy's ass.”

“I almost killed him.”

“That’s hot.”

“My Mama grounded me for, like, a month.”

“Your mom is hot.”

“I swear to god.”

“So it’s true, then,” PM says quietly. “You’re really… You know.”

“Yeah,” Midoriya whispers, caving in on himself. “I’m Quirkless.”

There’s a long, drawn-out pause. “Hi, Quirkless. I’m Shinso. But you can call me Hitoshi."

He stops breathing.

“I did some research on Quirkless people while you were sulking, I’m sure. I *knew* those ugly ass shoes couldn’t have been something you willingly wore. I still can’t figure out the backpack, though. My best guess was it’s like a high-visibility vest that those construction workers always wear.” Hitoshi laughs. “Or maybe you love to wear shit that’s colored like bodily fluids. Blood red shoes, piss colored backpack.”

Tears run down Midoriya's cheeks. “If your pee is that color, then you need to drink more water.”

“I hate water, I think. *Love* coffee, though. You should see my eye bags.” A pause. “Tell me you’re okay.”

“I’m okay.”

“Great. Now tell me who ‘Kacchan’ is. I’ve searched every single database I could find and still didn’t manage to pull his home address. I've got a homemade pipe bomb to throw at his front door.”

Midoriya belts out a laugh. “You really don’t care that I’m Quirkless?”

“I’m not a loser, the last thing I give a shit about is what Quirk you have. If anything, it’s kind of cool. So many Quirks are based on screwing with other Quirks, like Eraser Head! You’re totally immune to it. You should play The Last of Us. There’s this girl in it called Ellie, and she’s like, immune to zombie bites, so—“

“Hitoshi,” Midoriya says, “I don’t think you’ve ever talked this much in your life.”

“I’m nervous,” Hitoshi confesses. “I also kind of respect the shit out of you.”

“What?” Midoriya says, shocked beyond belief.

“You literally saved almost half a thousand people last month. You’re a fucking vigilante who took out a Pro Hero. You’re like Batman or some shit. And all that stuff you said months ago about being worth something and proving everyone wrong—it makes so much sense now. I had thought you had some lame Quirk like, I don’t know, your poop was orange or something.” He pauses when Midoriya chokes on his own spit. “Lots of people like us, people considered below everyone else, we turn out to be awful people because that’s all we’re ever given the chance to be. But that’s not you, Viridant. You inspired me, I guess.”

“I’m gonna cry.”

“That’s gross.”

“You’re not allowed to be nice to me.”

“Kiss my ass.” Hitoshi blows out a breath. “So, tell me about UA.”

“I’m going to try.” Midoriya wipes the snot off his face. “I’m going to try really fucking hard.”

“Me too.”

“You’re… applying?”

“This is the goal I told you about weeks ago. I want to be a Pro too. I’d like to do Underground work… but yeah, I’m going to UA,” Hitoshi says, proud of himself. “Maybe I’ll see you there.”

Midoriya smiles so wide that it takes up nearly his entire face. “Maybe you will.”

The call ends when PM—or, Hitoshi, has to leave for work. It's a surreal experience to make plans to call someone later, let alone have a friend who knows the truth about him. He's Quirkless, and he found somebody who doesn't care.

"Happy birthday to me," he whispers quietly to himself.

He decides then that he'll go out tonight in search of some big trouble. He types in the passcode to switch to All Might's messages. He needs to review what he sent to Eraser Head ages ago so he can build off…

There's a message waiting for him from Aizawa. It's been there for a little over a month, dated just after Kacchan smashed his phone.

It reads: "UA entrance exam is in two weeks. If you tell me who you are, I'll give you full access to it with no repercussions. Anyone of any age can apply; we'll sort you with your group when you get here. You should do it.

Midoriya hovers over the keyboard for a long while. When he types, it's with so much anxiety that he nearly drops his phone a few times.

Viridant: What's in it for me?

It's read almost instantly.

Eraser Head: How'd you get All Might's phone?

Viridant: Carefully.

Eraser Head: Illegally, too.

Viridant: Are all underground Heroes this sassy?

Eraser Head: To a reckless vigilante? Yes.

Midoriya can't help it; he squeals and kicks his feet. He can't believe he's talking to a Pro Hero right now! Much less going back and forth like they're old friends. This is a dream come true.

Eraser Head: Come to the entrance exam. You can do this whole song and dance legally. The last thing I want to do is put you behind bars when you're trying to do good work.

Viridant: You'd have to catch me first, Aizawa.

The reply is quick, brutal.

Eraser Head: If I don't catch you, then a villain will. If neither of us does, then you'll slip off a ledge or miss a jump. You need genuine training, not a Wikipedia article setting you up for failure. You are not invincible.

Viridant: You know nothing about me.

The response is instantaneous.

Eraser Head: I know you're male, your eyes are green. I know you're about 5”8, but maybe that’s just the insoles you’ve begun wearing. I know you’ve sustained a previous injury to your lower left leg because you had a slight limp when I chased you. I know that you’ve only recently learned how to cover your tracks. So here’s my guess, Viridant. You’re young, inexperienced. You’re old enough to know how the world works but young enough to make stupid mistakes. The backpack you wear was last manufactured six years ago, and you had on the same pair of pants with a hole near the pocket both times I’ve seen you.

Midoriya swallows a lump in his throat, glances around. He’s paranoid, unaware that so much about him was on display.

Eraser Head: So here’s your story. You stumbled across a Pro Hero trying to hurt a woman and decided to intervene. You attack him with a brick and panic that you took a life by mistake. You call the police, but suddenly come to the conclusion that the world isn’t all sunshine and rainbows, and you’ll go down for murder before you ever go down for self-defense. So you alert the cops of your location, clean up surface-level clues from the scene, then go home and sleep it off as best you can. But then you remember the store cameras, and you spend days figuring out how to wipe the footage. And when you finally figure it out, you lay low, keep a low profile.

Another message right after that.

Eraser Head: But you liked how it felt, didn’t you? Did you feel free? Did you feel untouchable? You teach yourself more and more about the world, stumble across some shit you know nothing about, and decide to bust a sex trafficking operation. You narrowly escape death and wake up as a famous entity.

Eraser Head: So here’s what I know about you, Viridant:

-You’re from a low-income neighborhood

-You’re young, no older than 18

-You’re male with green eyes

-You likely have a background with abuse, my guess is from your dad, which is why you can’t help but save every woman you come across

-Your Quirk is either insignificant or doesn’t exist at all

Eraser Head: How’d I do?

Viridant: You’re wrong.

Eraser Head: I’m looking right at you.

Midoriya whips his head up, glances around. People bustle about, minding their own business. There’s no sign of Eraser Head anywhere. Midoriya scans the rooftops, then the

alleyways, and only looks back at the phone when he's concluded that it must've been a lie.

Eraser Head: I know that you likely just looked around you. You're smart, you know how I operate, so you probably checked rooftops first. Do you know how I know all this?

Viridant: Enlighten me.

Eraser Head: Because I trained. I went to UA. I worked my ass off. I did things the right way, the legal way. So I'm giving you that same chance. Go to the entrance exam, begin Hero school, don't ruin your life over an adrenaline rush.

Midoriya huffs, runs a hand through his hair. He feels like he's being lectured by his Mama. Except this time, is a stranger who thinks he knows everything about him.

Eraser Head: Are you angry now, Viridant?

He responds quickly.

Viridant: Of course not. You're right, about some of it, at least. I'm just thinking, that's all.

Eraser Head: About what?

Viridant: How easy it was to outrun you. How easy it's going to be to do it again.

Viridant: And again.

Viridant: And again.

The text bubbles appear, disappear, appear again

Eraser Head: I'll see you at the entrance exams.

Chapter End Notes

Yupp

Chapter 14: Breaking

Chapter Summary

Short chapter lolsies. Midoriya hears his results from UA.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

UA's front gates are way more intimidating than they were from afar. The metal looms above him in an arch, guarding the brick school from the harsh world around it. He stands there for a while, gazing upon the massive expanse of the school. It's huge, filled to the brim with the world's next batch of Heroes.

He spots Eraser Head right away. The Pro stands with Present Mic at his side. They aren't handing anything out or making introductions; if anything, they look on edge. Eraser Head scans the crowd, eyes passing over Midoriya time and time again. He's looking for Viridant. For a moment, they look eyes, but Eraser Head looks past him a second later.

Midoriya turns, steps to the side, and comes face to face with Bakugou. His heart drops to his toes, a rush of nerves pushing against his skin. Bakugou looks totally fine, all injuries wiped away, likely by a healing Quirk. Still, an apology works its way up Midoriya's throat.

"Get out of my way now before I set you on fire," Bakugou says, though there's no real bite to it. He passes by, ignoring Midoriya's call after him for good luck. Weird.

The entrance exam starts with an auditorium full of students. Present Mic sits at the front of the room, yammering about the exam and point systems. Midoriya pays attention until his phone vibrates. There's two messages sitting there. One from Hitoshi, the other from Eraser Head.

Hitoshi: I don't mean to alarm you, but a Pomeranian with rabies is sitting next to you

He's attached a photo taken from across the room of Midoriya and Bakugou. Midoriya looks up to search for him, but it's impossible to discern who he could be.

AM: That's Kacchan.

Hitoshi: Good news, I brought my pipe bomb.

AM: Hush, he's behaving at the moment. I think he's nervous.

Hitoshi: You should throw him over the balcony edge.

Midoriya sucks his lips in to keep from laughing. Bakugou is staring straight ahead when he looks up from his phone again. He really must be so nervous. Midoriya has never seen him act like this.

He goes to Aizawa's message next

Eraser Head: Last chance, kid. Don't make this mistake.

He leaves him on read.

Eventually, the room is split apart. Somehow, he and Bakugou end up in the same group. They stand outside large, yawning gates to a training environment for students. When the gates open, kids take off, desperate for a chance to make their start. Midoriya takes a deep breath, and goes with them.

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Aizawa is *pissed.* Viridant never showed. Nezu was insistent that Aizawa stand at the front gates and wait for the vigilante, even if it meant having to interact with human beings. He agreed because he truly thought Viridant was a smart kid and would show up for the exams.

He didn't, and Aizawa is halfway to sending him a tirade of messages. The little shit got under his skin with his blatant sass and attitude, and now he's gone a step further and skipped out on a chance to handle things legally. He has no idea how hard Aizawa had to try to convince both UA and the police captain to drop all charges against Viridant if he showed up today. Vigilantes are almost as much of a pest as villains are, often causing more trouble than they're worth. He was hoping for one less headache.

And, maybe, he was hoping to get a kid out of a tough spot.

"I'm disappointed." He rubs his temple as All Might speaks. "I think I can speak for everyone. Viridant would've made a great addition to this school."

For once in his life, he agrees with All Might. They had put so much work and planning into finding this kid. Very rarely does All Might help with minor cases like this, but he's been oddly useful for the investigation. He had come to Aizawa months ago with a long list of credit card charges that lined up with his missing phone. It was only a hunch, but they chased the trail and kept up with the device and the missing wallet. All Might even agreed to keep his cards all active so Viridant could use them.

And it paid off. Viridant activated All Might's phone and pinged his location immediately. Unfortunately, it only happened once, from inside a burning building, and never again. The whole basis of allowing Viridant such flexibility with the stolen wallet was that none of All

Might's personal information had been sold online. Anyone else who would've taken his belongings would've rushed to sell the ID and info to the highest bidder.

Unless they already knew that All Might has two forms, which Viridant did. Now they're at another dead end with the kid. And Aizawa is pissed. He's got to sit at this meeting and determine which kids are in his class and which kids get rejected. He wanted Viridant. He wanted someone with raw potential, with intelligence, with a guaranteed success rate and a bright future. But the kid never showed up.

"How about these two?" Nezu clicks to the next slide. "From the same school, we've got Bakugou Katsuki and Midoriya Izuku."

All Might chokes on his water when their images are displayed. "What's the green one's name?"

"Midoriya."

"Quirkless?"

There are murmurs from the other professors. Aizawa levels them a glare so visceral that they shut their mouths.

"Yes, how'd you know?" Nezu asks.

"I've met him before." All Might shakes his head, "Interesting character, he's certainly brave."

"He did fine on the entrance exam," Aizawa says, gesturing to his results. "10 villain points, 30 rescue points. And his GPA is flawless."

"Not his record," Vlad King says, opening a folder that contains all school data submitted. "His middle school resubmitted his file days before the exam. Apparently, he sent another kid to the hospital."

"We let kids with records in all the time," Aizawa counters.

"Not Quirkless ones," Midnight says, resting her elbows on the table and holding her face in her hands. "I'm with Vlad. Quirkless is one thing, but a temper is another."

"I don't want to rework my lesson plans to include someone that I don't even know how to begin training," Vlad King adds, arms crossed over his chest.

Ectoplasm, shockingly, speaks before Aizawa does. "I think that's a very outdated view. This child excels in school, and it's clear he can fight if he puts a kid in the hospital with no Quirk. That's no easy task."

"I'm with you," Aizawa says, staring at those green eyes on screen. "I'll take him if you won't, Vlad."

“You can’t just take kids that aren’t in 1-A. He didn’t get enough points; he’d fall into 1-B or C, or Support. Maybe Gen Ed would suit him,” Snipe disagrees, looking at Nezu. “Or we give the spot to a kid who we know can be a Hero.”

“His rescue points are one of the highest yet,” Cemtoss claims, “But the low villain points worry me; I’m afraid he won’t hold up in battle.”

“That’s Midnight, Snipe, Vlad King, and Cemtoss on team no,” Nezu squeaks out, “Aizawa, Ectoplasm, and, I assume, Present Mic for team yes?”

Hizashi grabs Aizawa’s hand beneath the table, squeezes it.

“I vote yes,” Nezu says, his small hands smoothing his suit. “For too long, this school has shut out those it deemed too diverse. I’d love to see where this Midoriya could take us.”

They all turn to the last vote. All Might sits at the head of the table, small in his chair. He wears a yellow suit that reminds Aizawa of Viridant’s backpack. The two Pros have agreed on so much lately, much more than they ever have, especially concerning the vigilante.

He only hopes All Might makes the right choice here.

“I’ve met this boy before the exams,” All Might says quietly. “He showed bravery, courage, and curiosity. He’s made it far in the exams, and he seems to have a good head on his shoulders. His school report concerns me, but it might be something to overlook. At the same time, he’s very plain; he doesn’t stand out. Someone like Bakugou, with the highest villain points allowed, is an easy choice. Young Midoriya is a difficult decision to make.”

Nezu nods his head. “So, what do you choose?”

***

“Izuku! It’s here! It’s here!” Mama nearly falls to the floor trying to get the letter to him. “From UA!”

Midoriya rushes to the door, takes it from her outstretched hand. He shakes like a dog, heart hammering in his chest, and Mama tells him to open it in private.

It glares at him from his desk. He stares at it, unopened, his palms clammy. This is it. This is his future. A small slip of paper inside an envelope. When his phone buzzes, he sees it’s a message from Hitoshi.

Hitoshi: GEN ED!

AM: omg!

Hitoshi: I can't believe I got in. I'll have to work my way into the Hero courses, but I did it. I got in.

AM: I'm a proud mom.

Hitoshi: Shut the hell up. Open yours!

So he does.

He slides his nail along the fold, peels open the envelope. Carefully, as though it's something to be cherished, he reads the letter:

Dear MIDORIYA IZUKU,

It is with our deepest regret and utmost apologies that we cannot offer you a place within UA. After careful consideration, we have come to the consensus that your talents do not fit our criteria. We wish you the best of luck and hope for your success in your future.

His nails dig into the paper, crumpling it beneath his fingers. Buzzing fills his ears, a mindless ringing circles his head.

"Izuku?" Mama asks through the door. "Did you get in?"

He slides it open, holds up the paper. "No."

Mama's face falls. "Oh, baby, I'm so sorry."

"It's okay, it's just—" he chokes, "I just thought—"

Mama wraps her arms around him as he collapses into her. He sobs into her shoulder, knees buckling, heart hurting.

"I really thought I'd do it, Mama."

"I know, baby, I know." She rocks them back and forth. "Me too."

He feels his promise slip and fall, crack and bend. Just as his soul does, his sanity. He's lost everything he's been working for. Years of suffering, months of studying. Gone, like it never mattered at all.

He goes to bed and stares at his ceiling in the dark. His thumb rubs the burnt handprint engraved in his flesh. He feels… nothing.

Chapter End Notes

it only gets worse, don't worry!

Chapter 15: New gear

Chapter Summary

Midoriya suits up

Eraser Head: Why the hell didn’t you try out for the entrance exam?

Eraser Head: I told you I could get you a free pass for all the shit you’ve been pulling.

Eraser Head: You're a smart kid, Viridant, why make such a stupid choice?

Eraser Head: I can’t help you now, don’t you understand that? This was your one chance.

Eraser Head: I waited for you outside the front gates.

“Class 1-A got attacked.”

Midoriya exits out of the message thread as he lies in bed, rubbing his eyes. “What?”

“Class 1-A got attacked. I didn’t even know until I came to school today,” Hitoshi whispers, as though it’s something he’s not supposed to share. It probably is.

“And you decided to call me at seven in the morning with this riveting information,” Midoriya yawns, sitting up in bed. “Did villains breach the school?”

“*Hundreds* of them. You’ve got to get me that camera footage, I’m begging you. I have to see what went down,” Hitoshi pleads. “Kids died, a few dropped out.”

Now he’s awake. Midoriya’s eyes go wide, and he pushes out of bed to plop into his computer chair. School starts at 8 for him, though he usually skips first period to catch up on sleep he lost while patrolling. It’s easy to open his line of code, tap a few buttons, and find his way into UA’s camera system. It would be harder if he didn’t have an inside man to help him, but as a way to make Midoriya feel better for not getting in, and as a belated birthday present, Hitoshi and him spent nearly a month trying to get into the system.

“I’m pulling footage now. Do you know who died? What even happened? School started, like, thirty days ago,” Midoriya yawns, rewinds the saved footage from its server. “Does this mean kids in 1-B will be moved to 1-A?”

“I don’t know, I just got here,” Hitoshi says. “Everyone’s freaking out.”

“Mmm.” Midoriya rubs his eyes as an attendance list finally appears on screen. “Alright, I’ve got a list.”

“Hit me.”

“Tsuyu Asui, seat 3, deceased.” He clicks to the next screen. “Minoru Mineta, seat 13, deceased.” The footage manages to load in its entirety. Midoriya pulls up their chat logs and sends the clip over. It’s maybe fifteen minutes in total. “I’ve got the lesson plan loaded on my other monitor. Looks like it was meant to be light training and a tour at an Unforeseen Simulation Joint facility called USJ.”

“Jesus Christ,” Hitoshi hisses. “People are saying All Might saved as many as he could, but two dead kids say otherwise.”

Midoriya clicks around some more. “Looks like five kids dropped.”

“Who?”

“Yuga Aoyama, seat 1. Mashirao Ojiro, seat 6. Koji Koda, seat 9. Rikido Sato, seat 10. And Toru Hagakure, seat 16.” He counts those remaining, eyes glazing over Bakugou’s name. “12 out of 19 are left.”

“This is fucked.” Hitoshi’s fingernails scrape against the screen. “These villains appeared from… I don’t even know what the hell this is…”

“I’ll watch now,” he says.

The video is pretty easily available. Based on the power grid, UA’s electricity had been cut. Backup generators keep essential things on, like the surveillance system, which has its own AI that detects any unauthorized activity. Thus, the entire school shut down, but the cameras and gate held strong. Not that it did much, the villains didn’t bypass any gates or security bots.

They came from inside.

Purple smoke with glowing eyes captures all students within its shadows. When it pulls away a moment later, the students have been scattered. Flicking between cameras reveals each environment and pairs of students randomized. Both students who died had landed in the Flood Zone and were overrun with villains on a lone ship in the water. Everyone else seemed to have sustained minor injuries, if any.

But Midoriya is looking at the abomination of a villain that came through the portal. It’s large, mindless, its brain exposed to the open air. All Might spends ages fighting it—it almost *kills* him.

“What the fuck is that?” Midoriya whispers, leaning in to his screen.

Hitoshi says quietly, “I’ve got no idea. The guy with the hands all over him seems to be directing it. He’s directing the entire thing, it looks like. One big group of guys to take out All Might.”

Huh… why does that sound familiar?

Midoriya rewinds the footage to the very beginning. That purple smoke wisps out of a well-dressed villain. But it's his eyes that Midoriya stares at. Where has he seen this guy before?

Where…

He drops to the floor, digs the dirty clothes out from under his bed. His hands search blindly for the small box filled with definitely not illegal items and yanks it out. Within it is a folded piece of paper. His fingers make quick work of opening it and revealing the flyer that Chikara gave him another lifetime ago.

ALL HEROES ARE VILLAINS

His brows furrow, and he rereads the text below it.

"A new population is forming. The outcasts, the left behind, the beaten and the neglected. The world has gone too long without any repercussions for its oppressive actions. Join us, and become a United front against the Hero Commission. All entry includes housing and food. We don't starve you of your potential."

The villains who had flooded the school. Some didn't know how to fight, others just stood in place and observed. No bodies had been recovered; the smoky villain had transported them all away.

The smoke…

The symbol below the text looks identical to the villain on screen. Purple smoke, glowing white eyes. The guys who tried to recruit Rin and Chikara. The group that attacked and killed students at UA. This new league—formed against All Might. A league of villains.

"This is the quietest you've ever been, I think." Hitoshi's voice snaps Midoriya out of his daze.

"Yeah… I just…"

Does he tell Hitoshi the truth? This isn't some talk about nightly patrol routes and how much the world sucks. Two kids are dead because of this league. They infiltrated a notorious Hero school. They've gathered people from across Japan to join their cause in the East.

Does anyone even *know* about these fliers? Even if they did, how would they know where to go to find the location of the league? Chikara and Rin knew to go East, but that must've just been word of mouth. The fliers grab attention, but it's all underground talk that actually gets people to this organization. It keeps Pros out of it but spreads its message behind their backs. Whispers and urging and recruiting.

He can't get Hitoshi involved in that—not yet, at least.

"My mom came home early," Midoriya lies, "I have to go. Stay safe, okay?"

"Yeah, yeah, talk to you later."

“Bye.”

“Bye, freak.”

The call hangs up.

Midoriya decides to dial a new number immediately, one that’s written on the back is the flier, courtesy of All Might’s credit card. The line rings for a long while. When it’s finally answered, it’s silent, as though the person on the other end is waiting for him to talk first.

“C-Chikara?”

“Oh fuck, it’s you, kiddo! I thought you were one of those robocallers. Fucking hate those things. How are you?” Chikara says. In the background, the crying of a small baby can be heard, and a woman singing softly.

“I’m good, you had your baby?” he asks.

“Yup! We’re all situated in a nice and fancy part of Japan, too. That’s thanks to you, kiddo. You know what I named the little guy?” A small laugh. “Izuku. My lady liked the name and liked it even more when I told her you were the one to save our asses.”

His heart picks up, warms. “You’re kidding.”

“I’m not. You have no idea what it means to us. We’ve got real jobs—good ones! A fucking live-in nanny, a house with a backyard. People walk their fancy ass poodles down the block; there’s an HOA. I can’t believe it. Police came knocking one night, and I thought they’d bust my ass, but they came for a *noise complaint.* A noise complaint! I live in a neighborhood that calls the police because people are loud, not because they’re fucking stabbing each other,” Chikara lets out a loud laugh. “You got me here. I hope this kid grows up to be a fraction as good as you are… minus the stealing, that would be bad.”

Midoriya smiles wide, his face hot. “I’m really happy for you.”

“What do you need, kiddo?” Chikara says, joy lining his voice. “You called for a reason, yeah?”

“I uhh… You mentioned a group of people down East. Said me and Mama could go to them if we ever needed…” He’s not sure how to word it, luckily, he doesn’t have to.

“Yeah,” Chikara hums. “I’ll send you the address of a buddy of mine. She’s the one who told me about the group in the first place, so you’ll have to go to her for answers. I’ll warn you though, she’s tricky to pin down. If someone gives you any trouble, you just mention me or the code word.”

Midoriya swallows thickly. “What's the code word?”

His phone pings as Chikara sends him an address. “Nomu.”

Nomu. Midoriya writes it in his notebook, zero idea what it means in this context. Just scribbling the notes feels wrong, like some sort of omen that he doesn't fully understand.

"Thank you," Midoriya says.

"Of course. Anything you need, kiddo. Take care, yeah?"

"Yeah."

The call clicks off.

Midoriya lies flat on his bedroom floor, stares up at the ceiling. He can't, in good conscience, do nothing about this. There was an attack on UA, two children were murdered. This is the school his best friend attends, a school that Bakugou—

He shakes his head free of that last thought.

Midoriya has a lead, he has a chance to stop this. He needs a solid plan, sure, and a bit more time to finish his vigilante suit. But he can do this. He can gather information on this league and report it to the police. Unlike the bar, he won't get ahead of himself and try to solve a crime. He'll get in, gather evidence, and get out. That's it. He can do that.

But if he's going to do this, he needs to be fully prepared for it.

He sends a message to Ito that he won't be in school. Ito responds with a middle finger emoji followed by a gun emoji. Not landing UA wasn't… as awful as he thought it would be. He spent the rest of his summer mindlessly cleaning up the beach. Mama didn't complain, happy that he was still going outside and getting fresh air. A few news articles came out talking about the nice and clear beach, thanking the people of Musitafu for coming together as a community to clean it.

School started relatively soon after that, and Midoriya took Ito's advice from months ago when he gave him the fake ID. He attends Adachi High School, already at the top of his classes and still skipping half of them. And, even weirder, he hangs out with Ito and his small group of friends. They've all got lesser Quirks, and Ito was surprisingly on board with Midoriya's plan to keep his Quirklessness hidden. Unlike Bakugou, Ito doesn't spread the truth around for no reason other than to torment Midoriya. As far as his peers are concerned, Midoriya has an analytical Quirk. They bought it immediately, especially when Midoriya had dozed off and muttered to himself a few times.

It's been… good, he thinks. He eats lunch with his little group of students. They don't mind that he's quiet. Ito is pretty loud, extroverted, he pulls Midoriya along with everything he does. So it all balances it out, he supposes. Nobody messes with him anymore, nobody seems to know him at all. He blends into the crowd, he's nothing out of the ordinary.

But at night—that's when he becomes someone. He is still unsure how to explain it. Maybe Eraser Head was right, and this vigilantism is all an act of an adrenaline rush, or maybe… maybe Midoriya feels something when he does this. When he chases down perps, when he saves lives, maybe his heart beats only when others can do the same. His blood pumps

because theirs does, he smiles because they do. He's done good, he wants to keep doing good.

He intends to.

He pulls wads of fabric loose from underneath his bedframe. His nightly adventures have consisted of petty crimes and tormenting Pros. He learned that it's more entertaining to screw with Heroes on patrol than it is to capture some random girl who decided to steal some makeup products. He doesn't care about petty theft or minor crimes; he's after the big guys, and it's a thrill to be chased around town.

So far, he's made one Pro quit and two more swap patrols with others in their agencies. He just follows them around at night, watching them fight, learning how they operate. And when he has their style memorised, he throws pebbles or coins at them until they get pissed off enough to chase him down. He evades them every time, and it's exhilarating. He learns how to move in ways his body never has, the moon urging him further. On his bad days, he screws with a clueless Pro for entertainment, on his good days, he takes on fights with pedophiles or people with domestic violence charges. Public records are a great tool.

He likes to capture villains with a wire. Turns out, most thrift stores have gigantic spools of wire. He found the first green one he could, stuffed his bag, and wrapped his enemies up nice and neat, even including a little bow he bought from a gift wrapping store. He snaps a photo, sends it to Eraser Head, and that's that.

But it's because of his suit that he doesn't go for bigger fish. He's been researching, memorizing, and analyzing. His notebook is filled with drawings and sketches of towns that are hours from his own. He searched online forums, got in contact with a few lower-ranked members of given gangs. He's close, beyond close, to solving a true crime. No more nightly routines of pissing off Pros or practicing his fighting skills with random freak shows. He's going to be a god damn Hero. The Hero that does what's necessary.

And this league might be his key to it all.

Midoriya lays out his costume materials. He's gotten most measurements down, but what he doesn't, he makes quick work of completing. He stretches tailor's tape along his arms, copies the measurements to his notebook, before sketching on the remaining fabric with chalk.

He finished his shoes first, reinforcing them with black steel and adding sharp, pronged edges. It can hold him on roofs easily, alter his footprint size and shape, and the rubber bottoms make it easier to scale walls and drainpipes. The steel is detachable, revealing his regular red Quirkless brand shoes.

His mask and helmet came next. Hitoshi came up with the brilliant idea of a voice modulator, since he had to do it when designing his own Hero costume. Learning about Hitoshi's Quirk was a trip, but they had fun screwing around with it. Hitoshi would ask him questions and Midoriya would answer truthfully and set a timer to see how long he could go before he snapped out of it. It made his friend feel better about his Quirk, he thinks. Hitoshi seemed unbelievably happy during that call. For someone so dry and monotone, it was a good turn of pace.

His mask is meant to resemble a smile. Its silvery outside hides wiring and a microphone inside. His voice can be amplified or lowered by the dial on the side of his mask, and pitch can be altered on the opposite side. Within it is an FFP face mask. On top of stopping smoke inhalation, the mask can also work in dusty areas or asbestos-ridden buildings. This took the longest to make by far, but he and Hitoshi had spent long phone calls manufacturing and designing it.

His helmet and goggles were next. A pair of swimming goggles were easy to cut up and alter. All Might's credit card bought Midoriya a new pair of Meta glasses, to which he rewired and programmed to his own AI. Attaching the technology to the swimming goggles, he was able to find a way to connect his vision to his phone. His helmet was just a regular motorcycle helmet that he beat the shit out of with a hammer and hacksaw until it came apart. He attached speakers to the inside that align with his ears, paired them to his phone, and boom, full headset. Hitoshi made him paint it and add fabric because it was so ugly looking, and it turned out even better.

And a little bit mean. He added sharp, angular bunny ears. They stick out from his helmet and can be retracted and pulled off to use as a weapon. A small box cutter blade sits hidden in its base for quick access. The entire helmet is green, the black of his goggles making his eye sockets look like hollow pits. Even then, the slight resemblance to All Might is evident. He had designed his Hero costume years ago based on All Might, and decided to carry that mocking mindset into the new costume.

The rest of the outfit is essentially layered fabric. Knee pads, elbow pads, and red compression sleeves on his arms and legs. On top of that, FR-treated cotton, making him effectively flame resistant. Dry Fit green pants and a long-sleeved shirt are the final layer, breathable and flexible, so he won't overheat or get caught on anything. He stitched on black lining and pockets, even designing a red belt to wrap around his waist. The last touch was gloves, which are regular biker gloves with some blue stitching.

Honestly? He loves it. It's comfortable and secure, not too heavy but solid enough to protect him from harsh blows. He's worn bits and pieces out, practiced with them, but the final piece is something he's yet to ask Hitoshi for.

He wants Eraser Head's scarf.

The capturing weapon would be a perfect tool. He could swing through the city rather than go everywhere on foot. Any slip off a building or slight mess up could be immediately corrected. If he had that scarf during the bar fire, he could've been two times faster. He's getting that scarf. He's not sure how, but he knows it's going to happen.

When Midoriya finishes the final touches, it's just barely dark outside. He puts the full suit on, different parts and pieces clicking into place. He feels powerful, unstoppable. It's well fitted, no more loose fabric to get caught or to weigh him down. He feels… complete. Whole.

He waits until it's darker, until Mama comes home and goes to sleep. Then he slides open his bedroom window and slips into the night. Time to be a Hero.

Chapter 16: A new ally

Chapter Summary

Bakugou gets a POV

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Let's get one thing for absolutely fucking certain, Bakugou is not a damn idiot. He knows when something is… off. He can't always pin it, can't always understand the shared looks others have from across the room or what tone they use to keep things from him, but he's got a good gut. And his gut tells him something is off.

Villains infiltrated the school yesterday. He got stuck with some red-haired freakshow, but they handled themselves. Two of their classmates died, five other cowards dropped out. And the response to it isn't right. Students were urged to return the next day, no breaks, no time to recover or mourn. They were told Heroes don't get a moment to remember those they lost, that mourning is a privilege, is something you earn in the face of victory. And as Aizawa-sensei spouted that bullshit, he looked like he hated every single moment of it.

Bakugou won't ever admit when he's not the best at something, but social cues are tough. He's adjusted, adapted, just as he always has. He can put together the micro expressions he spent years learning so he could understand emotions and conversations better. Aizawa's downturned lips, the slight dip of his brow, his gaze locked on a newly empty seat. The guy nearly got his skull crushed by some zombie-looking fuckwad and showed up the next day with some bullshit story about All Might saving the day and not needing to worry.

It's fucking bullshit. He can smell it from miles away. Part of Hero work is honesty, truth, and he's damn tired of being kept away from it.

Deku's face flashes in his mind. The jackass didn't make it into UA, Bakugou knows this because he spent his first week at school looking for him. He's not sure why he even bothered, why he kept telling himself he was just trying to make certain that the moron stayed below him. For someone who values truth so much, he's gotten good at lying to himself.

He knows why Deku has ingrained himself in his mind, why he's been bouncing off the thick walls of his skull since the moment they met. But he won't ever admit it. Not to himself, not to the world. His career hinges on publicity, and nothing would take him out more than—

He won't waste a moment thinking about stupid fucking Deku. All he ever does is think about him. His nose, his eyes, the way he lied to Bakugou's face, the way he looked as he

strangled him, as he broke open and revealed the fucked up interior that Bakugou always knew was underneath his skin.

Look what you did to me. Look what you made me into.

It didn't look like Deku. When he was holding him down, killing him. It's all Bakugou could think. His self-preservation disappeared under that one recurring thought. That didn't look like Deku. He's not sure what creature lives under the skin of Midoriya Izuku, but he caught a glimpse of it, and he's been…

He's been…

He's been reserved. He's less angry these days. Less… anything.

I hate you. I fucking hate you.

He shakes off a chill that's begun to crawl up his skin. The last thing he is scared of is Deku. Off-put, sure, but scared? He's not a fucking pussy, he doesn't get scared.

He needs to talk to Aizawa-sensei. He's been antsy lately, in need of a fight and having nobody to fight with. Frustration builds within him, a ticking time bomb, and without a way to release it, he boils over and often says things he never truly means. He doesn't dwell on it. You can't change the past. Why would he dwell on it?

Look what you did to me.

"Get out of my head," Bakugou mumbles, pushing down UA's hall. "I got rid of you. Why are you still here?"

He doesn't let himself dwell on it. He buries memories of the two of them bundled up on the couch watching All Might movies. He locks away the image of Deku on the school roof, erases that hopeless look from his mind. He's not sure why he waited at school instead of leaving with his friends that day. His gut told him to stay, his chest ached with something unfamiliar. And then he looked up, and Deku was on the ledge and…

And his gut is never wrong. That's why he's at UA now, after class has let out and students have gone home. He purposely left his wallet in class just in case he needed a viable excuse to be back on campus in case some jackass came sniffing around. But for now, he's got to hunt down Aizawa. He's got a bone to pick, a fight he wants to win. His rage is a living, breathing monster, bubbling and boiling through his veins. Aizawa lied to the class, instilled values he doesn't believe in, and Bakugou wants—no—*needs* to know why. He needs the truth.

He makes it to 1-A's obnoxiously large door. It's cracked, just a sliver, and he grasps the handle—

"Think, All Might! Use the microscopic portion of your brain that still fucking works."

Bakugou pauses at the door. He's never heard Aizawa raise his voice. Be a dick? Sure. Raise his voice? Never. He moves, squatting down to avoid detection and peering through the small

gap in the doorway.

Inside the room are three people. Aizawa stands at the front, surprisingly mobile and high functioning despite yesterday's attack. Sitting on Bakugou's desk is Present Mic. Though he's nearly unrecognizable with his hair down and combed out, tinted glasses low on his nose. Then, sitting where an absurdly pink woman sits, is a long and spindly man. He has less meat on his bones than fucking Deku. One strong wind could blow this skeleton-looking motherfucker away. He looks like a Tim Burton character, all long limbs and sickly, large eyes.

His eyes flicker to the man's pinstriped suit. The same suit All Might wears when teaching their class. It was unexpected for All Might to become a UA professor, but nobody was complaining when he saved their asses yesterday. Is this guy a fan? But where's All Might? Wasn't Aizawa-sensei talking to him?

The man starts, "I am *trying,* Aizawa. But there's nobody I can recall—"

Sensei cuts him off. "We've got such a strong description of Viridant, and you can't even *guess* who he might be? Think! Use your brain."

"Shouta," Present Mic says, voice soft. "I know how important this is to you, but you need to —

Sensei ignores him. "Sometime between April 10th and 12th, your wallet and phone went missing. The person who stole it is a fan of yours, we know that much because the little shit just sent me a photo from *your phone* of his new fucking costume."

"That's not my costume," The man argues. "If Viridant was trying to make a play on my suit, then it's not a positive one. The intention is clear as day; he doesn't like me."

"Then what fan boy did you piss off!" Sensei shouts. "Green eyes, 5'8, witty, tell me *something,* All Might."

… All… Might?

The man sighs, slumps in on himself. *That's* All Might? What is this shit? Last he checked, Halloween is a few months away. Having the same hair and suit doesn't make you All Might. Having the same eyes and… and voice… and…

All Might. This is All Might.

He's a *liar.* A fucking *fraud.*

Bakugou clenches his fists, grits his teeth. He's tired of this, he's tired of *everyone.* Hero school was supposed to be different. Things were supposed to be different. He doesn't get it. Why does everyone lie? He needs an outlet, he needs—

"I'm sorry," *All Might* says, frowning deeply. "Viridant is… remarkably clever. I've done everything I can to keep his trail up, but he knows exactly how to play us every time. He buys products from stores scattered hours apart, he erases any camera footage of him, and

that's saying there is any in the first place. Every day that we spend setting up to catch him is a day that he spends learning and practicing."

"This is why," Sensei says through clenched teeth. "We needed to catch him and get him to UA *before* he set down this path."

"Aizawa, you can't stop this." All Might shakes his head, stands. "You can't change the course of someone's life unless they're willing to change it themselves."

"This is a teenager," Aizawa says, slamming a hand down on his podium. "This is someone's child. This isn't a surface-level vigilante who chases fame. This is some kid who has no idea how deep he's digging, let alone that he's digging a grave. Building a suit indicates he intends to stay on this path, and his message to me today was unacceptable."

Silence. The two Pros stare at Aizawa.

"Do neither of you understand how fucking *important* this is?" His frustration is eminent, it darkens him up, colors him with shadows. "Especially now, after the attack—"

All Might pitches forward, coughs harshly into his hand. Present Mic shoots up from his chair to help steady him, offering a handkerchief for… for the blood spilling past his lips. They descend into silence as All Might coughs and coughs and coughs. Blood pours through his teeth.

Bakugou feels smaller than he ever has before. His heart weighs heavy, his mind tells him to leave before he sees any more. He forces his feet not to move, he forces himself to watch, to learn.

"I'm dying," All Might says, and even the crickets outside seem to stop making noise. "There isn't much time left for me. And… and I can't spend the rest of my days waiting for a kid that will never come."

Present Mic helps him to the door before All Might waves him off. Bakugou takes the moment to hide, to sprint down the hall and slide open 1-B's door. It's pure luck that Vlad King isn't inside, giving Bakugou perfect cover.

He peers outside as All Might exits the classroom. The Pro says something more, but Bakugou doesn't hear it. He watches as All Might slowly makes his way down the hall, coughing into his rag as he goes. All Might is dying. He needs Viridant. Bakugou isn't sure why, but he knows it's true. He's unsure who this Viridant is, why he matters so much. He's seen the news, the fan pages, and he admits, Viridant is admirable. But he's not anything special, just another wannabe Hero who didn't have the skills to get into UA and makes due in another way.

What would Deku think of him? The nerd probably has an entire notebook dedicated to the vigilante. He probably mapped the guy's movements, questioned his morals, determined everything he possibly could, and wrote it down for later. He probably sat there, mumbling about it and biting those… lips..

Bakugou cusses. He should've exploded Deku into another fucking school. He can't shake the ghost of him, this phantom that haunts everything he does. Those eyes, wicked, unseeing. His hands as he tried to kill him, as though Bakugou's death was wrong but… but necessary. In that moment, he's not sure anything could've stopped Deku other than the explosion Bakugou has launched at him. And even then…

Look what you did to me. Look what you made me into.

Murmurs sound from the hall. Bakugou peers out again, sees that 1-A's door is still open, the light still on. He pushes into the hall, slowly approaches the door again. He squats down, looks through the small hole in the handle.

Present Mic holds Sensei's forearms, strokes his thumbs across the exposed skin. And Aizawa… doesn't stop him. They talk quietly, whispers that nobody is meant to hear. Bakugou does anyway.

"Viridant knows about the UA attack. We've done everything to keep it under wraps. The press knows nothing, the media knows nothing. Somehow, this random kid knows about it. And he apologized to *me.* Told me how sorry he was that I lost my students, and that he hopes I'm doing well, as though I'm the one who needs to be consoled for failing and not the parents of these kids." Aizawa shudders, and Mic pulls him to his chest, hugs him tight. "I can't stand the thought that someone's baby is out there. He said he's going to do his best to solve the problem for me. It's not his responsibility."

Present Mic sways them back and forth. The two of them are polar opposites, and somehow, they fit together. Aizawa is not affectionate. He's mean, and he's headstrong, and he's clever and, and, and he's a *man.* Present Mic is his opposite in every way, but they're both *men.* Together.

Smoke leaks from Bakugou's fingertips. He can hardly hold his blast down. He's so *angry.* So frustrated and upset. He's not sure why, he's not able to understand why it pisses him off so much. It's the same feeling he got when he saw Deku smiling down at his phone in class, like there's something so wrong about someone enjoying his company. He *hates* it. He doesn't know how to get rid of it. It chases him everywhere he goes, it follows him like a shadow, and fills his dreams with green eyes and a declaration he never wanted to hear.

I hate you. I fucking hate you.

"Maybe he's a UA student," Present Mic offers, resting his chin on Aizawa's head.

"I purposely ran a night session with 1-A all the way to Gen Ed just to check that. My stationed Pros still said he was out and about." Aizawa sighs. "I don't know what I'm going to do if he ends up like…"

"He won't." Present Mic pulls away, holding Sensei's hands in his own. "We'll make sure of it. I'm on your side, okay?"

Aizawa nods stiffly, turns towards the door, "I just—"

His gaze lands on Bakugou. Aw fuck.

“I left my wallet,” Bakugou says, pretending to tie his shoe. “Is it in here?”

He stands from his squat, looks back up at them. Both of the Pros have separated, though they still stand too close together, as though they aren’t sure what he’s going to make of them. He doesn’t let himself make anything. It’s not his business. Technically, none of this was his business. He had just stumbled into something he hadn’t meant to, that’s all.

Bakugou points to his desk. “I think I see it.”

He walks around the two of them, careful not to touch, and scoops his wallet off the floor from where he planted it. He stuffs it in his pocket and looks literally anywhere fucking else as he walks out. But for some terrible, stupid fucking reason, his gut tells him not to go yet. He stops in the doorway, stares at the windows lining the hall, and cusses out every fucking thought that led him here.

“Is there something you needed, Bakugou?” Aizawa-sensei asks.

He’s not sure why he says it. Maybe it’s because he’s been so quiet lately when he never has been before. Maybe it’s because All Might is a sham, and Bakugou needs something to do to take his mind off it. Maybe he just needs an excuse to… to run around his hometown looking for someone. But he confesses a truth he’s been keeping in his chest for months now.

“I know a way you can catch Viridant.” He turns, meets Aizawa’s eye. “But you’ve got to use me. I want to be involved.”

Aizawa narrows his eyes. “Close the door and take a seat.”

Chapter End Notes

yah

Chapter 17: A new plan

Chapter Summary

Bakugou reveals a secret and joins a side.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I've been following him for a few months now."

Aizawa's eye twitches. Aside from that, his perfectly blank face would reveal nothing about his mood. He leans against the whiteboard, arms crossed. Present Mic sits on top of a nearby desk, his feet pressed against the front of the chair. Bakugou watches them exchange a look, beyond pissed that he can't understand what the hell that means.

"You're going to need to explain," Present Mic says in a voice that is meant to be nice but wobbles and falls flat.

Bakugou doesn't like being told what to do, but he doesn't like being on the outside of something more. If he wants the truth, then he needs to earn it.

So he says, "You got a damn notepad?"

It started a few months ago.

He woke up from a nightmare early in the morning, just like he always does. To calm down he… he opened his curtains and counted as many stars as he could. It's been a habit since he was a kid, not that he tells Aizawa-sensei and Present Mic that. It's something he won't confess to anyone, especially not himself.

Typically, he tries to go back to sleep when he's calmed down. But on this particular night, there was a man outside. He'll be honest, when he first saw him, he thought it was Deku. His curiosity had kept him watching the guy long enough to discern that his shoes were different. But still, he watched. The guy had a hood and sweats on and was lurking outside of Bakugou's house, *of course* he watched him. He had to make sure he wasn't going to get robbed fucking blind.

Well, this guy passes by Bakugou's house, goes to a seemingly random building, and begins to climb the side of it. It was so fucking bizarre that Bakugou just stood in the window, watching the little freak jump from one windowsill to another until he eventually got on top of a roof. He didn't know what to make of it, assumed it was some weird ass kid high on acid or something, then went back to bed. Except, the next night, there the two of them were again. Just him and the guy and the moon overhead.

Maybe he was delirious, or maybe just sleep-deprived, but after a week straight of waking up at an ungodly hour and watching this random stranger scale a building, Bakugou decided to figure out what the hell he was up to. He hadn't intended to follow him or anything; he didn't even know it was Viridant at the time, since the bar fire had yet to happen. He just listened to his gut. So when night fell, Bakugou set his alarm to wake him up twenty minutes before the guy would come around. When he woke up, he got dressed in a hoodie and sweats just like the weirdo and headed to the building.

He climbed up the windows and bricks, a fact that makes Aizawa's eye twitch again. When he got to the roof, he went to the opposite side and slowly dropped to a window ledge. Then he waited. And right on time, the creep scaled his way up, then took a running jump to the building next to it.

"And then?" Aizawa asks, jotting down notes. "What did you do?"

"I went after him slowly. I kept him in view while keeping low to the ground. I lost him the first few weeks at different points in his patrol route, but once I got it memorized--"

"Hang on," Present Mic says. "You know his patrol routes?"

Bakugou makes a face. "You don't? Aren't you idiots supposed to be Pro Heroes?" Aizawa takes the insult in stride, urging Bakugou to keep going. "I got it mostly memorized, but Greenie seems to expand his routes often. He's got the city mapped out, and he's expanding his patrols to places he plans to hit. Like the bar. I followed him there--" he catches his mistake too late.

Aizawa's blank face shrivels under the pure anger forming on his features. Bakugou observes him. Furrowed brows, wide eyes, dilated pupils, lifted upper lip, tight cheekbones. Definitely pissed.

"You were at the bar?!" Aizawa shouts.

Bakugou mirrors him. "Better than what you fucking morons were all doling! Someone had to back the idiot up!"

Present Mic rubs his forehead. "I don't get paid enough for this."

"I didn't know what he was doing!" Bakugou shouts. "I lost him around the side of the building! I left before the fire started!"

"I should expel you!" Aizawa snaps. "I should--"

"Use me," Bakugou fills in for him, matching the glare thrown his way. "I know how this dumbass thinks."

"You don't know shit--"

"How many times have any of you been able to follow him?" Bakugou again cuts him off.

Present Mic purses his lips, looks to Aizawa. They say nothing.

“For whatever fucking reason,” Bakugou says, palms nearly sparking. “He doesn’t detect me. Or maybe he does and lets me follow his idiotic ass around Musutafu for fun. But--”

“Musutafu?” Aizawa says, exasperated.

Bakugou’s mouth curls. “Fucking Christ, maybe I should just bust the idiot on my own. He’s from some place around my hometown, Musutafu. His patrols started small and expanded from there. But they start every night at the same time in Musutafu.”

Aizawa scribbles this down, Present Mic in awe.

“He always takes some path home that's hard to pinpoint. He goes into this abandoned building through this hatch on the roof and--”

“Disappears inside,” Aizawa says, voice drifting. “All blueprints have been scrubbed from the internet of that place. I’ve searched it top to bottom, there's nothing.”

Bakugou narrows his gaze, scoffs, “Need me to help you look? Seems like you could use the support.”

Aizawa readies to say something, but Present Mic beats him there. “He’s right.” Surprise filters through Bakugou’s blood. He expected more of a fight to get them to agree. If he knew all he had to do was win only one of them over, he would’ve just done that. “Bakugou clearly has some kind of advantage that we don’t, it would be stupid to try an keep him out of this.”

“No shit,” Bakugou says.

“Shut up,” Aizawa snaps at him, eyes glowing. “The adults are talking, matter of fact, go wait in the hall.”

“Fuck no--”

“Now,” Aizawa says, his hair slowly beginning to lift. “I won't ask again.”

Backugou grits his teeth, licks the front of them, a nervous habit he’s always had. With a glare and string of profanity, he steps into the hall. The two Pros shut the door tight behind him, and speak only in whispers so he won’t hear.

This is bullshit. He would’ve been more fucking stingy if he knew they were gonna stiff him. He’s on the outside again, far from the truth. It pisses him off, sets his blood on fire. He needs to get better at lying; he has to improve. He has to be the best. He has to be the greatest. He can’t keep being on the outside of everything.

How does Deku do it?

He palms his temples, curses himself again and again and again. But the thoughts persist, questions he has floating around his mind, screaming at him.

Where did he get those bruises from? Who had choked him? Their classmates were cruel, but those marks indicate attempted murder. That wasn’t some funny little joke; it was an attempt

on Deku's life. And he tried to blame it on Bakugou. As though Bakugou would ever leave a mark on his skin. He would never, he *has* never. He may shove Deku around, but he doesn't damage him, he doesn't…

Their fight replays in his head. A new emotion takes reign, one he's grown to hate, to loathe. *Regret*. It tastes sharp, like metal, like the blood that filled his mouth when Deku hit him. He's never stood up for himself before, and when he finally did, Bakugou was at a loss. He didn't know what to do with Deku. This kid he's known his entire life who's suddenly changed so much in the past couple of months. Anyone could see it if they knew where to look. Deku was headed down a dark path.

Where is he now? What's he doing now? Bakugou isn't stupid enough to think he's out and enjoying his life. Hero school was it for Deku, and now that he's failed, Bakugou realizes that he had been expecting him to get in just as much as Deku was. He can't imagine that kid sitting at home, twiddling his fucking thumbs. So what's he doing?

Why can't Bakugou stop caring?

The image of Aizawa and Mic embracing fills his head. Two opposites, and they made it work. Two men, and they made it work.

He leans his head back, rests against the wall, does everything he can to expel the wicked rage from his system. It doesn't go away, it never does. It lingers, just as Deku does, and it defines everything he's ever done.

"Bakugou."

He turns his head, meets Aizawa's gaze.

"Let's go."

Bakugou furrows his brows. "Fucking where?"

"You tell me." He stuffs his hands into his pockets. "Lead the way."

So he does.

He starts them at his house. Mom and Dad are asleep, so he sneaks two Pro Heroes up to his bedroom with little issue. From his room on the second floor, he shows them the window that faces the street. He explains what direction Viridant comes from, at what time, and then he takes them back outside. Aizawa holds his breath as Bakugou scales the wall and climbs to the roof, but he follows right after him, listening as Bakugou explains the patrol routes.

"Viridant follows the same general pattern. 2-1-3-1, then repeat. Two days in a row he'll take one path, one day he takes another, then three days in a row he takes another, then one day he takes a different one. But he always follows that exact pattern. He's got four routes that he divides up across a week. I'm not sure what pattern he follows that determines what route he'll take at the start of the pattern, but I know it's that sequence exactly." Bakugou points

left. “That’s one way.” Right. “That’s another.” Forward. “The other.” And then diagonal, right between right and forward. “And that’s another.”

“But it always starts here?” Aizawa plants his feet wide, stares out over the cityscape. “This building is low. All the rest of them are taller. So he starts here to have a cover and decide a route.”

It’s true, and fucking obvious. The building they stand on now is abandoned, as many are in Musutafu. It leaves nobody to ask any questions. He’s seen Viridant jump to the other building, balance on a windowsill, and peer just barely over the ledge. It hides him from view while giving him a great vantage point.

“Walk me along the routes,” Aizawa says. He makes for the next building, but Bakugou doesn't follow. “What?”

“No.”

Present Mic laughs at the look on Aizawa's face before shutting up at the withering glare he receives. The Pro suddenly finds the ceiling tiles more interesting than Aizawa and Bakugou.

“What do you mean, no?”

Bakugou crosses his arms. “Are you fucking deaf? I mean no. N-O. Do you want me to say it in English?”

“This is an ongoing investigation that I’m allowing a student, much less a first-year, to take an active part in,” Aizawa says carefully.

“I don’t want a stupid part, I want a role. I want to be in on this investigation.” Bakugou grins at him. “You’re lost without me. I’ll help, but I’m going to be just as much a part of this as you are. Put me in with the fucking big leagues.”

Silence, and then, “He’s right.”

“Stop agreeing with him,” Aizawa hisses at Present Mic. “You reinforce his poor behavior.”

“I’m not a fucking five-year-old,” Bakugou snips.

“But he’s right, and he knows it. Why are we trying to pretend he isn’t?” Mic gestures to Bakugou. “This is the best lead we’ve had since Viridant started this in March. It’s August.”

“Hizashi—“

“This is the right call,” Present Mic says, looking right at Bakugou. “We’ll give you a bigger role. You have my word.”

He huffs. “I’m so glad we came to the same fucking conclusion.”

Aizawa gasps when Bakugou runs and jumps to the neighboring building. He climbs up the brick, jerks his chin for them to follow, and begins the long and grueling task of showing

them Viridant's patrol routes. The thing is, Viridant knows his shit. The dipshit must be a resident of a nearby town because he's aware of where all the activity and nightlife takes place. Bakugou takes them along the four different paths, pointing out spots where students often smoke or where streetlights are broken.

Each route covers parts of town that Pros don't monitor. Except one. The diagonal route cuts across multiple cities, sitting in the path of Pros. It's often taken when Viridant needs to go somewhere else, like the bar he narrowly escaped being burnt alive in. That's also near where he found Bluer. Bakugou stops them on the ledge of one particular building, points down at a camera latched to its side. He explains that Viridant knows where all surveillance is located, that his routes are designed to avoid them.

Present Mic fills Bakugou in while Aizawa stays silent. Apparently, Viridant has hacked into the city cams. His trails are untraceable, several sweeps done to ensure there's no clues left behind. But that, in itself, is a clue.

"How many times?" Bakugou asks, peering down at a street cat eating from a tuna can.

"What?" Mic questions.

"You said there are several sweeps done on each camera, right?" He looks between the two of them. "How many?"

"Two," Aizawa says. "At the beginning, Viridant left bits of footage behind, like he was unsure how to delete it. But then he did a second sweep, and the footage was completely gone."

Bakugou snorts. "Well, there you go." They stare at him. "It's embarrassing that I have to do your jobs for you." He turns, starts heading in a different direction. "Two sweeps on cameras he's caught on. One isn't done well, the other is, and now he's so good at it that a second sweep is only done to ensure it's properly cleared. You can check how often someone taps into a camera, can't you?"

Aizawa nods. "Yes."

"Then that settles it." Bakugou hops off a roof, lands in a squat atop another. "Viridant is two people." He stops on a roof with a latch. One quick movement, and he's got it lifted and quickly climbs down the metal ladder within. "Somewhere along his journey, someone came in to teach him code. Viridant has two pieces: the one who appears in public, and the presence online. Someone double-checks his dirty work. You want to know how he's getting intel on UA?" Bakugou slides down the inner scaffolding, lands on the bottom floor of the building. "He's got a man on the inside. Even better, you said he messaged you today about the attack, yeah?"

Silently, Aizawa hands Bakugou his phone. He looks through the message thread, brows furrowed.

Viridant: I'm really sorry to hear about what happened to your students. I hope you're doing okay. I'm doing the best I can on my end to solve this! I even got a new suit, do you like it?

The image attached is disturbing. Viridant doesn't look very much like a Hero at all. The green fabric is dark and can blend into the shadows with ease. Aizawa was right that it seems to mock All Might's costume; if anything, the droopy bunny ears represent All Might in his weakened form. It's likely that Viridant knows that All Might is actually built like an uncooked shrimp.

"Look at this timestamp," Bakugou slides the message to the side, flashes the stamp to Aizawa. "This message was sent after school. His informant likely told him about the attack this morning, giving Viridant enough time to pull a suit together and head out."

"But why message about the attack today, why not yesterday?" Mic asks.

Aizawa wipes a hand down his face. "The informant isn't in 1-A. Whoever it is must be in a lower class."

"But still a first year," Bakugou adds, "The older classes weren't told about the break-in." He hands the phone back. "You want to find Viridant? Then there's an easy way."

He looks around the warehouse floor. Aizawa-sensei had said he searched the place top to bottom. But Viridant didn't just disappear or teleport out of here. He searched it up and down… but did he search below it?

Bakugou starts lifting things. Anything that looks like it could cover a manhole or ladder. He locates it a second later. A large piece of scrap wood, so much shit stacked on top of that it wouldn't even cross someone's mind that it could be lifted. But everything stacked on it is hollow, light, and Bakugou picks it up with ease.

"Got you." Bakugou grins, peering down at the staircase. "Here's his route home."

The two Pros gather at his side, staring into the darkness. If they set cameras in here or a trap, they can catch Viridant. That goes without saying.

"What's the other way?" Sensei asks, turning to Bakugou.

Bakugou can't help the giddiness inside him, the urge to investigate and explore. "Find his informant. Odds are, they've tapped UA's cameras. Check which ones are most frequented. Consolidate the classes, compress the searchable area. Whoever this is must agree with Viridant's morals and ideology. You have the freak's number, so text him, learn about him, see what students match his values."

Silence.

When he looks up from the hole, Aizawa is extending a black phone towards him. Bakugou takes it slowly, unable to read his sensei's blank face.

"That's a burner. It has no traceable location, and it's only programmed with one number." Aizawa looks at Mic, and Bakugou can finally place the look. Trust. This is Aizawa taking a chance because Mic said he should. They trust each other. Any wicked and unwarranted rage

dissolves when Aizawa speaks again. “Text Viridant. Reveal only what you must about yourself. You’re around his age, in class 1-A, he can use that.”

Present Mic holds the wooden platform up so Bakugou can step back. The phone is a bit dated, but it works. Turning it on reveals Viridant’s contact name and number, and that’s it.

“Anything you learn about him, text on your personal phone to me. Any messages on the burner are compromised the moment you reach out to the punk. He’s good at scraping data. We’ll have meetings once a week about what you learn; anything else is too suspicious.” Aizawa-sensei frowns. “You can’t tell *anyone* about this. Do you understand? You’re being held legally responsible for any leaked information on this case by accepting this role. This isn’t a small case. Alright?”

Bakugou doesn’t respond. He starts texting.

“What—you’re already texting him?!” Mic laughs out. “It takes me hours to give Aizawa the courage.”

“Shut it.”

“My bad.”

Bakugou grins. “This guy is some lonely freakshow. If he needs a conversation, it won’t be hard. I’m great at that.”

Aizawa purses his lips and looks at Mic, who audibly snorts.

But Bakugou wants the truth. More than anything, he wants to be on the inside. So he will be.

Chapter End Notes

Anyway

Chapter 18: New discoveries

Chapter Summary

Midoriya receives a text from a random number and explores a new location.

Chapter Notes

Pretty long chapter for you guys. I'm super nervous about where I took the story, so I hope everyone likes it lmao

"Hello, how are you?"

The bus driver looks at Midoriya like he's just shot someone. Decked out in his gear, he supposes that he does look a bit peculiar. His stolen bus pass is so small in his gloved hand, but he hands it over all the same.

"Nice night out," Midoriya says, his modulated voice deep and gravelly.

The driver doesn't look away from him as he scans the pass and hands it back. Midoriya takes it with a nod and heads to a seat. Luckily, no one is out this late, so he's free to spread out. The address that Chikara sent him is ages away, and he has no hope of making it there and back by morning. So, bus it is.

He takes out his phone when it finally starts to move. He had planned to call Hitoshi through his headset and talk about pointless things like usual. But he checks All Might's contacts just in case. Eraser Head has left him on read, but… there's a new message from a new number.

Midoriya furrows his brows. Did All Might give out his number? Who is texting him?

Without reading it, he sends the number to Hitoshi and asks him to trace it. The response is near instant, a big thumbs down, which means it came back with nothing. No location, no name, no phone information. A burner, maybe? But why text All Might?

He taps the message, opens it.

Unknown: Green is my favorite color.

"What the hell…?" Midoriya isn't sure what to say, what to respond.

Unknown: It looks good on you.

Slowly, he looks at the middle-aged bus driver. The man is pants pissing afraid, eyes darting to his rearview to check on Midoriya at least eight times a minute. He's got no phone in sight, not that he could even do that while driving without Midoriya seeing it.

Did Eraser Head show someone his costume photo? Maybe Hitoshi made a friend and told them to contact Midoriya? No, that's not possible; this message was sent to All Might's phone. It was deliberate, meant for Viridant and Viridant only.

Viridant: Who is this?

Unknown: Who do you want me to be?

His face flushes red, and he screenshots the message before sending it to Hitoshi.

PM: Omg, a romance is blooming. I'm a proud dad.

AM: Whqt the fuck do o say?!

PM: Those typos tell me you're freaking out.

AM: HELP ME.

PM: Jesus, okay. Say… uhh… Say, "You wanna kiss?"

AM: I am not sending that.

PM: Booooo you suck.

He switches messages, sees that the new number has texted again. He's really not sure who this is, and the name the person gives him does absolutely nothing to help him.

Unknown: You can call me Ground Zero.

Viridant: You're a Pro?

Ground Zero: No.

Viridant: How'd you get this number?

Ground Zero: Tapped Eraser Head's phone.

Midoriya's eyes blow wide. Even Hitoshi couldn't do that. And they tried for hours.

Viridant: How old are you?

Ground Zero: Fifteen.

Viridant: Bullshit.

An image comes through of the unknown person's ID. They cover almost everything with their hand, only revealing their age. No birthday, no features, just that age. So whoever this is

has a driver's license. Midoriya sends the photo to Hitoshi, and he comes back with so many possible people that it can't be narrowed down without more information.

Ground Zero: Your turn :)

This is… so weird. Midoriya isn't that good with social interactions, but this is something else. He has no idea where to go from here, and Hitoshi keeps telling him to try and land a date with whoever the hell it is, so that's no help.

This could so easily be a trap, but it could be a huge resource too. Someone smart enough to tap Eraser Head's phone that's around his age?

Viridant: What's your Quirk?

The reply hits him in the fucking gut.

Ground Zero: I don't have one. You?

Ground Zero is Quirkless. Nobody would willingly claim to be that. Unless they know he's got nothing, and are trying to trick him. But how would they…? He's so thrown off. He's not sure what to say, what to do. He's always got some sassy response for Eraser Head loaded and ready, but he's at a total loss right now.

He sends one last-ditch effort to Hitoshi for help.

PM: Omg. I'm kicking my feet and twirling my hair.

There's absolutely no way that's true, but Midoriya chuckles anyway.

PM: I kind of love them. Is that bad?

AM: This could be a grown ass man trying to lie to me right now.

PM: Boooo you suck.

Midoriya rolls his eyes, opens his message thread with Ground Zero.

Viridant: I don't share that information.

Ground Zero: You're breaking my heart, Greenie.

Viridant: What do you want from me?

Ground Zero: A conversation.

Viridant: About?

The resulting message takes ages to come. The typing bubbles stay up for a while, looming over Midoriya for a good while. The bus continues down the road. He'll be at his stop soon, then it's a good few-hour walk to Chikara's texted address. He should be mentally preparing for this mission—

His phone buzzes.

Ground Zero: I want to know more about you. You're fucking awesome. How many Pros do you think walked by or into Aka without a fucking clue what was going on? Or, even worse, how many knew about the situation and kept it secret? I bet you learned about that bar and went and solved the problem immediately. You don't wait around for a Hero to come and save the day. I respect that. I just want to know more about it, about you. You didn't intend to become famous from it, I'm sure, but I'm thankful you did. It puts you on my radar, and I can't complain. It's a good view.

Midoriya stares at the message for a long while, debating the credibility. He won't deny the way it made him feel, mushy and warm, likely the way it was intended to. This guy is good, manipulative—or maybe he's just honest. Some honesty is nice every once in and while. But Midoriya isn't stupid; he won't trust this right away.

Viridant: I don't suppose you'll send me a photo of yourself?

Ground Zero: At least take me to dinner first, Greenie.

Viridant: Funny.

Ground Zero: What fun would it be if you knew who I was? I don't know who you are, and that's fine by me. You don't have to reveal anything, unless you want to, which is more than fine by me.

Viridant: Do you flirt with every person you message?

Ground Zero: Only you, Greenie.

Viridant: Aren't I so special?

Ground Zero: I think so.

Viridant: You don't know me.

Ground Zero: Oh, but I plan to.

Viridant: Stubborn.

Ground Zero: Too a fault, Greenie.

The bus stops down the street. Midoriya again thanks the driver, earns a bizarre look, and he's off. He forces Ground Zero from his mind, tucks his phone into his pocket. He's got a mission to do; he doesn't have time for whoever this guy is.

Tokyo is darker than he remembers. He hasn't been in a long, long time. He'd take the bullet train if it wasn't littered with people and cameras. So he took the bus, made it as close as he could, and walked the remainder of the way into town. He's got the city ingrained in his mind. His days of pickpocketing give him a decent understanding, but his extra studying is a needed perk.

Midoriya works his way through the city. The moon smiles down at him, its clouds providing a perfect cover. Midoriya thanks it and continues on. The address is easy to find, but he doesn't rush in like before. He circles it from many angles, learns its floor plan through observation.

Two stories, but compressed. Likely a two-bedroom, one bathroom. It's upkept but not enough to look spick and span. A worn layer of blue paint blends it into the houses around it, and under its left window, a pair of white eyes has been spray-painted. The symbol for the league in the East. He's got the right place.

Midoriya shimmies down a storm pipe, lands just out of view of the house. Slowly, with the cover of night, he approaches. He opens the chain link fence that holds the house, steel shoes walking up the front steps. With a gloved hand, he knocks.

A minute passes. Two. Then the door opens. A dark skinned woman stands in the frame, wild brown hair sticking up in bizarre directions. A baseball bat with chains wrapped around it is slung over her shoulder. She leans against the doorway, a cigarette hanging from her mouth.

She looks him up and down, raises a brow.

"Nomu," Midoriya says, his voice deep.

Her lips tilt up into a grin, and she holds the door open wider, allowing him entry. He steps inside and takes in the completely empty house. No tables or couches, no dishes or food, there's not even lights. The bulbs are shattered, angry glass jutting out of the ceiling. The woman wordlessly leads him down the hall.

She twists the golden handle of a basement door, gestures to him to go down. When he takes the first step, she slams the door. He hears a lock slide in place from the other side. Great.

Instead of pounding on the door like his mind begs him to, he takes the stairs to the bottom. It's completely concrete down here. The string light on the ceiling is the only one that isn't broken. It sways with an invisible breeze, illuminating the empty basement. And the large, gaping hole in the right wall. It looks like it had been bashed in with a sledgehammer. Jagged lines and angles form an archway that leads to a dark, dirt tunnel. There's no way the city approved this.

He walks down it anyway. His adjusted eyesight is wonderful, but still imperfect. One tap to the side of his helmet and the screen of his goggles flickers, switching to night vision. The tunnel stretches on for a long, long while, randomly jutting left or right. He follows it down, the rumble of cars overhead making him antsy but not enough to turn back. It's held up this long; it must have some sort of structural integrity.

He feels along the walls with a glove, wondering what Quirk carved this out. The lines are ridged, and he knows better than to think some actual machine was used to excavate this legally. Some sort of drilling Quirk, or something more elemental-based? He goes deeper and deeper, the darkness engulfing him until… he hears it.

It’s muffled, sounding like thud after thud. The more he walks, the louder it gets, until he can eventually make out the bass. It’s music, playing from who knows where. Deeper, further down, and he finds a ladder. It leads to a fully covered manhole lid. It’s easy to push it up, shove it aside. The music floods into the tunnel, loud and heavy. He follows it and the newfound light upwards.

And he can’t believe what he’s seeing.

It’s a night market. It spans down a long, straight alleyway that cuts between dozens of buildings. Dim lights are strung across buildings and tents and booths, the entire place filled with people. And not just any kind of people. The flier did exactly as it said it would; it houses the less fortunate, the rejects. He doesn’t even look out of place here; everyone is unique and different. One woman is made entirely out of spikes, and her small child has only flames for hair. He turns, and there’s a man with his mouth and eyes swapped. Beside him is a dog wearing a suit and walking on two legs.

What the fuck is going on?

The entire city is underground. The tunnel he walked must've been descending at an unnoticeable pace. It leaves this society to be built in a dome-like shape, dirt and stone packing it in.

He looks at a building with words graffitied on it.

ALL HEROES ARE VILLAINS.

And those white, glowing eyes right below it.

Chikara was right, this is a safe haven for society's most hated. Some of the scariest people he’s ever seen live here peacefully, enjoying their everyday lives.

So where the hell does the league of villains play in here? The psychopaths who attacked a high school, who killed two kids. Where…

His eyes land on a shrine. Slowly, he approaches. Flowers and candles have been spread out on a street corner, dozens of photos resting on a small table set out. He looks them over, meets the eyes of the dead. And, amongst them, are the two UA students who were murdered.

A man wipes his eyes, lays a flower down.

“Excuse me,” Midoriya asks. “What is this?"

The man, with a throat that bulges like a frog, says, "You must be new here.”

“I-I am,” he confesses.

The man sighs and strokes a flower petal. “This is the underground city. Our leader built it for us. No monsters can bug us here. We’re free to do as we like.”

Midoriya looks at the photos of the UA students. “What happened to these people?”

“Our leader attacked UA. The goal was to capture All Might, but some of our people took it too far. This is where we mourn those who lost their lives.” The man frowns deeply. “No one was supposed to die.”

And Midoriya believes him. This society—it’s beautiful. There’s free housing labeled down the road, and what looks like a school is across from it. An active night market that sells food, water, and clothes. A safe space for anyone who might need somewhere to go, to hide.

This is not what he thought he was walking into. He expected a villain's lair. He expected some evil mastermind. This? This is everything Midoriya ever dreamed of.

“Who is your leader?” he asks.

The man’s throat bulges, but he points down the road to where a new tunnel stretches out. “You can find him out there.”

“Thank you… what… what happened to the people who killed those students?” Midoriya asks.

The man looks away. “Our leader deals with the traitors accordingly.”

That’s not ominous at all.

Midoriya takes his time wandering around the city. It's not big by any means, only having enough space to house a couple of hundred people. Kids laugh and kick a ball around its dirt streets. There's a sheet where you can request items you need, and it'll be brought here by whoever runs this place. Free schooling, free beds, it's a small slice of heaven.

What he would've given to know about this when he and Mama had run away. They wouldn't have had to hide, wouldn't have had to change themselves. This is a place dedicated to the safety of those who aren't safe anywhere else.

Something tugs at his glove, and he looks down to see the small girl with flames for hair. He can just barely see regular, dark hair beneath the colorful fire. She smiles at him, orange eyes bright.

"I like your bunny ears," she says.

Midoriya squats down. "Why, thank you." He flops the attached ears on his helmet, wiggling them and making her laugh. "Do you and your mom live here?"

The little girl nods. "Mhm."

"Well, I'm very happy to hear that. You must be very brave."

She smiles widely. "Thank you, Mr.Rabbit. Bye bye!" Then she takes off to go play with the other kids down here.

Midoriya watches her for a while before again gazing around the dome. This is beautiful. It's so far from anything he ever expected. The flier had seemed so ominous, but this? This is amazing.

Eventually, he takes the man's advice, heading down the road to a yawning tunnel on the other side of the large market. He had spotted four of them in total, but this one is located on the far left wall. This place is beautiful, welcoming, and full of people who are living a better life because of it. Maybe UA got it all wrong. These guys aren't villains; those deaths weren't warranted, but it seems like the perps are being handled.

Right?

Ugh, he should've told Hitoshi. He was truly so worried this would be something awful…

An hour in, and the tunnel starts to stink. It smells like spoiled meat, raw chicken or cow infiltrating Midoriya's senses. Midoriya makes it halfway through before night vision is needed, and when he clicks it on, he sees why it smells so awful. The tunnel is drenched in blood, guts, and intestines strung about. Someone was dismembered here, torn apart, and scattered. No bones remain, but chunks of human skin lie on the dirt.

Do the people in the town know? How wouldn't they? Is this the price they pay for freedom? Keep quiet about whatever the hell happens with their leader, and they get to leave peacefully? How is that right? How is it any better than what happens on the surface?

The tunnel goes for a very, very long time. The whole way, it absolutely reeks. Decay and bodily anatomy is everywhere. He comes to the conclusion that this isn't just one person; the further along he goes, the worse it gets. Whole limbs are lying out. Arms, legs, so much gore that it stains his shoes and gloves. Anything that touches the floor or walls is colored red and brown.

He's shaken to his core when he finally reaches the end. Another ladder that leads up to a manhole cover stands before him. He fears what's on the other side. He moves anyway.

A twist and a shove, and rain pours down from the open sky. Both tunnels he'd been in must slowly slope up or down, carrying him deep to the earth or closer to the surface. Midoriya pokes out from the hole, suddenly standing in the center of a four-way alley system. He can go any direction, but none of them reveal where the hell he ended up. He can't be anywhere near where he was when he first started. Even worse, nothing up here leads to a person. All stores that connect are closed and dark, completely empty inside.

But someone must be coming in and out of the manhole. Maybe… maybe he should wait? But with how fresh that blood was, it must've been recent. Whoever came out of the tunnel is gone by now, the rain washing away their sins. He'll have to dedicate an entire day to the tunnels to pinpoint a person who killed all those people down there. Even more, he needs to explore the tunnels surrounding the town. He spotted several holes all leading in different directions.

For now, the sun is beginning to rise. He needs to get home—

He cries out when something sharp pierces his side. It cuts deep, pushes through the layers of cloth and embeds itself in his side. Fuck. Fuck!

“Ooo, aren’t you so cute!”

He looks up at the sound of a girl's voice. There’s a teenager here, uniform and all. Her blonde hair is tied into messy buns on either side of her head. She giggles when he looks at her, points a second knife at his head.

“I’m so hungry,” she whines, “I didn’t think I’d find a good meal so soon.”

Midoriya backs up, and pain like no other pushes into his side. The knife she threw was designed for that specific purpose, leaving the blade slightly smaller and the end extremely pointed. It would be stupid to pull it out, but it *hurts.* He’s never felt such a sharp, drumming pain before. It sets him on fire, pushes adrenaline into his veins.

One tap on the back of his headset sends his location to Hitoshi. A second one sends it to Eraser Head. Midoriya retreats more. The schoolgirl follows. She can’t be older than he is, if that. He doesn’t recognise her uniform, and no school insignia makes it hard to get a general location of it.

“I bet you’re so handsome under your mask!” she says, her voice high-pitched. “I bet you’re even more handsome underneath all your skin.”

“Not interested,” he grounds out.

She giggles, twirls. “Dabi hasn’t been back with the bags yet. I haven’t eaten in days.”

“No idea who that is,” he grunts, backing up further. She follows after. “Maybe you should wait for him.”

“I don’t think so, mister,” the girl says, laughing again. “I think I waited long enough. Have you ever waited for someone you adored?”

Bakugou comes to mind. He disappears a moment later.

“It’s such a sad feeling,” the girl says, a hand grasping her sweater, right where her heart is. “They say absence makes the heart grow fonder. I don’t agree. It only makes me hungry.”

His phone buzzes in his pocket. He can’t pause to look at it.

“Have you ever loved someone, cute mask man?” she asks. “Have you ever had a crush? I have a crush.”

“O-On who?” he asks, backing up further. He’s almost to the street.

She smiles wide. “On you!”

“You just met me,” he argues.

“Love at first sight! What’s your name?”

Anything to buy time. “Viridant.”

The girl gasps, squealing at full volume. “I LOVE VIRIDANT!”

She throws her second knife, a scream tearing from his throat as it finds a home in his shoulder. She's on him in seconds, tackling him to the ground. She lands atop him, a new blade in her hand.

“I’m sorry!” she says, raising it above her head. “But I can’t help it. Cute boys drive me insane, and I’m so hungry.”

She drives the knife down. Midoriya raises his arms, grunts in pain at the knives buried in him. He manages to capture her wrists, keeping her arms in place with nothing but the strength he’s built up for half a year.

It lasts all of five seconds before she yanks her wrist loose from his arm with an awful grip. She grabs the knife from his shoulder, yanks it out.

And licks it clean.

His eyes blow wide, and he manages to roll and push her off before she can stab him again. The knife grazes his chest, but no blood forms on the tip. He shoves her, lifts his legs, and kicks her stomach as hard as he can. He must’ve forgotten his own strength because the girl goes fucking flying, crying out when her back collides with the brick wall of a building.

He shoves guilt down, places his good arm on the ground, and pushes off the wet floor. The rain washes away his blood, but it comes streaming down anyway, painting him as red as his shoes. By the time he turns to face her, she’s changed.

Literally.

Standing in her place is *him.* It’s the trippiest thing to see. He’s half wondering if he already lost too much blood as he watches himself smile, revealing sharp fangs, and wiggles his fingers in a wave. He taps the back of his helmet twice. Again. Again. Again. Eraser Head receives his location over and over again. It’s not as though a Pro can get here in a reasonable time. He’s hours from home, hours from Tokyo.

Dizziness suddenly hits him, and he stumbles back, more pain dancing along his skin.

The other him wastes no time. He swings, and Midoriya blocks it just in time before swinging back. To anyone else, this must look beyond bizarre. Shit, to *him*, it's bizarre. The other him grunts, lifts a leg, and knees him in the balls. Not fair, so not fair.

He goes further, and slams his head forward as hard as possible. His helmet cracks against the fake him’s forehead, and then he drops to the floor, unconscious. Midoriya stares down at him, his vision blurring and doubling. Slowly, the skin begins to molt, returning back to the teenage girl.

He lingers long enough to check for a pulse. When he feels it, thumping bright and loud, he takes off.

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.

He holds his shoulder, blood leaking through his fingers. The wound in his side is just as deep, excruciating and angry. Rain slickens the city streets, sunrise painting the town he's ended up in. He looks for a street sign, for a billboard, for *anything.* He can't go back in that tunnel.

He needs to go… somewhere.

Midoriya hobbles down the street. Agony wears on him, his adrenaline dropping now that the fight is over. He's bleeding out, slowly, surely, he's bleeding out. How long does it take to fully bleed out from two stab wounds? How much time has he already wasted?

He can't hardly see, let alone think. He's ended up in a suburban neighborhood somehow. He spots a sedan pulling out of a garage and peeling down the opposite street. That's going to have to do. He stumbles forward, hits the ground, and forces his body to roll underneath the still-closing garage door. Eventually, the weight of it hits the concrete below, casting him into the darkness.

"Fuuuck," he pants through his teeth. "Oh g-god."

He's shoving himself off the floor again, collapsing once, twice. He gets up on the third try, stumbles to the door that leads inside. He twists it, pushing into this random man's house. He's not sure if anyone is home; he doesn't really care. The bathroom is located right next to the garage door, and his body bangs against it.

Midoriya leans on the wall, kicking the door shut behind him. He stuffs a hand towel into his mask.

Panting through his teeth, he counts down. "1…2…3" He moves his good arm, biting a towel on a holder to muffle his scream as his bag slips down his arm. He always brings medical supplies when he goes out, and tonight he's thankful for how over the top he was with packing his bag.

His phone buzzes again, and he can't even begin to think about explaining this to Hitoshi. He's certain Eraser Head is blowing up his phone as well, which is somehow worse. He doesn't need a lecture or panic. But when he thinks about pulling the knife from his side so he can slip his uniform off, he loses his nerve. He doesn't want to be alone, and if he's not distracted from what he has to do, then he's going to faint or throw up at the sight of the injury before he can manage to stop the bleeding.

"Please…" he whimpers, pulling his phone from his pocket, switching to All Might's messages. "Be… a good… guy…"

He calls Ground Zero.

The call picks up immediately. “Did you miss me so soon, Greenie?”

He must’ve lost a lot more blood than he thought, because he swears, with everything inside him, Ground Zero sounds just like Kacchan. He means—Bakugou. He doesn’t call him Kacchan anymore.

His response is a low breath and grunt. “Hi.”

“Wow, you sound like shit,” Ground Zero says, and in his mind, it’s Kacch--Bakugou’s face. “Let me guess, you were hit by a bus.”

“No.” Though, that would be the funniest way to go. Midoriya’s hand drifts down, reaches the hilt of the knife. Just touching it sends ripples of pain through his side.

Ground Zero hums, “Did you fall off a roof?”

He grunts out, “Not yet.”

“Are you sure it wasn’t the bus thing? We can circle back to it if you’re embarrassed.”

Midoriya groans, grasping the handle and trying to yank it out. It’s stuck. The girl threw it into him at the worst possible angle. He has to grab it from an awkward position with his bad arm or risk wiggling it around a bunch with his good arm.

“Okay, what the fuck?” Ground Zero says, his voice rattling Midoriya’s ears. “Talk to me.”

“Stabbed… Distract… me...” He tries to yank it out again, fails, “Please...”

Ground Zero pauses, then says, “Did you know All Might is built like a fucking coat rack?”

Midoriya, despite his situation, bucks out a small laugh. “What?”

“Okay, hunker down for this load of shit,” Kacch--Ground Zero, says. “Here I am, minding my own fucking business, walking down the hall-er-road. And I hear these obnoxiously loud voices fucking yammering away.” Midoriya grabs the handle with his bad hand, his eyes shut as he listens. “And it's this homeless-looking guy who’s arguing with the human embodiment of a stick bug. They're going back and forth and back and forth about who the fuck knows.” He tightens his grip, tears leaking from his eyes at the pain. “And the homeless motherfucker goes, ‘this is important, All Might.’ and I had to sit there, looking at this jack skeleton wannabe, coming to terms with the fact that it's *the* All Might.”

He yanks the blade free. Midoriya screams into the towel, sobbing as the knife clatters to the floor. Ground Zero pauses, listens to Midoriya’s heavy breaths, before continuing.

“I used to know this guy back in middle school. Kid was a total All Might fanatic. I just stood there thinking about how he’d react to all this shit. We both loved the guy, and then boom, everything is fucking different,” Kacchan says.

Midoriya nods along, his wounds bleeding freely. Blood drips from his gloves, spatters on the floor. “What happened… to your friend?”

“That's the thing, “ Kacchan says, “We were never really friends. We grew up together, then we drifted apart, and we never really got along like we should have.” He pulls the cloth from his mask, squats down to grab rubbing alcohol from his bag, but topping over instead. “Not for lack of trying on his part, though. Kid wanted to be my friend so bad, but I kept shoving him away.”

Midoriya lifts his good arm, slides it out of his suit. It takes long moments, but he manages to slide the rest of the suit own to his waist. “Why?”

Kacchan is quiet. No--Not Kacchan--this isn’t Kacchan. Kacchan doesn’t care about him anymore. Kacchan isn’t even real. He killed him in that hallway back at school, strangling him until he was dead. This is someone else.

“I don't know,” Ground Zero says, and his voice is soft in a way that Kacchan’s never was. “I try not to think about it.”

Midoriya grabs a brown bottle from his bag, pops the lid. He bites his lip as he pours it on his wound, fresh tears pouring down his face.

“But it's different without him around.” Ground Zero says. “I’m different without him around.”

“What… are you… like?” Midoriya asks him. Another small pause. Midoriya uses it to grab his gauze. He does his shoulder first, since it's been exposed the longest. He presses the pad onto it, then another, then another, and grabs for his medical tape.

“No one has ever asked me that,” Kacchan says quietly. “I don’t know what I’m like. I know I’m stubborn, hot-headed at times. I like to tell myself it's all for a good reason, but it never really sticks too long.”

Midoriya pulls off the end of the tape with his teeth. With one wound covered, he moves to the next.

“I lied, by the way, I’m not Quirkless,” he confesses, and Midoriya pauses. “I guess I was testing you. I wanted to see how you reacted.”

“If.. it was bad?” Midoriya grits out, placing several new gauze on the wound. “What then?”

“Oh, I think you would’ve broken my heart, Greenie,” Kacchan says, and Midoriya’s heart beats a little faster. He has to remind himself, once again, that this is not Kacchan. He’s delirious, losing blood fast. Clairity will come tomorrow, when he’s healed…

But for tonight?

He dresses the last bit of his wound, rests his head against the wall. His helmet keeps his face warm, but the cool morning air makes goosebumps flare along his bare abdomen. He’s suddenly exhausted, and he isn’t sure what to do from here. He doesn’t have the energy to get home. It’s a weekend now, at least, so Mama won’t notice he’s gone. But he can’t just stay in this random bathroom.

“Here’s something,” Kacchan says, his voice low, just as it’s always been. “I fucking love soup.” He’s not sure why he laughs, only that once it starts, it can’t stop. “Don’t laugh at me, jackass, I’m serious!”

“Why soup?” Midoriya asks, his voice a whisper.

“It’s versatile, easy to cook,” Kacchan hums, “When I was little… the kid I told you about? His mom used to take our crockpot and fill it with shit at the beginning of a school day. She’d tell us it was like a witch’s cauldron and she was making a stew that would turn any All Might fan into super Heroes if they ate their fill.” That’s funny, his Mama has said the same thing to him and Kacchan when he was young. Must’ve been a common story to tell kids, like Santa Claus and the Tooth Fairy. “And I remember we’d both spend the entire school day passing notes and giggling about all the people we were gonna save. It was just him and me back then. I don’t even think he remembers it. But I do.”

Midoriya blinks slowly, his vision fading. “And when you got home? Did you… did you turn into a superhero?”

Kacchan says, in a voice so sad that it hurts Midoriya’s heart, “Yeah. I think, for just the one night, we did.”

Midoriya’s eyes flicker, shut, and he drifts to sleep. Still, even in his dreams, he’s with Kacchan. They run around the living room like maniacs, chasing each other around the house in matching All Might onesies. He had forgotten about that memory. He only remembered how it ended. With the two of them sitting in Kacchan’s bed, counting the stars, and Midoriya sharing a secret he wishes he never had.

Chapter 19: An almost bad aftermath

Chapter Summary

Midoriya narrowly escapes trouble with the help of his new ally

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Eraser Head, we got something!”

Aizawa rushes over to the spot he was alerted to. It’s midday now, the drive to Viridant’s location taking up hours of his day. He ended up too late, as he often is, to the scene of the crime. He had sent a couple of Pros out, alerted the entire fucking police force to arrive here the second he got Viridant’s location. Nobody made it in time.

He stands on top of a manhole cover that's cemented into the ground. A few Pros tried to lift it, but it seems to be some weird decorative choice. Regardless, it sits in the middle of a four-way alley system, hours away from Viridant’s regular patrol locations. He has no idea why the kid was even out here, let alone what could have happened. The rain has washed away nearly every trace of Viridant.

“What is it?” he asks.

A detective lifts a lone, blonde strand of hair. “Is your vigilante a blondie?”

He finds that his lips tilt up, just a little. “He could be.”

The detective carefully puts it into a plastic evidence bag. “I’m sending this to my lab. The department will call you the second we get any results back on that DNA strand.”

It wasn’t completely worthless. He wasn’t completely late. That’s one strand of hair closer to the kid. He just wishes he knew what the hell happened out here. There’s no sign of a fight or struggle, but he’s received five messages from Viridant, each one pinned to this exact location.

One thing is for sure, though. It smells absolutely awful here. There must be some sort of trash that needs to be emptied, or an animal curled up and died nearby. It’s pungent, harsh, giving the alleyway a large radius due to how far from it everyone seems to want to be. It’s vile.

His phone rings, and he’s quick to answer and set it against his ear. “What did you find out?”

“He's alive,” Bakugou’s voice crackles through. “He’s out cold, fucking snoring and everything.” A slight, mocking snicker. “You’re gonna be pissed at this next part.”

“Tell me.”

“Stab wound,” Bakugou says flatly, ignoring the sharp intake of breath that Aizawa has. “I’m not sure how many, but I heard the dumbass pulling it out and the metal hitting the floor. I also heard some sort of liquid being dumped; my guess is a disinfectant.”

“He knows how to dress a wound.”

“Confirms your theory about a previous leg injury. Any damage he’s sustained, fucker knows how to heal from it.” Bakugou yawns. “Didn’t get much info out of him aside from that; he’s not much of a talker. Or maybe it's the excruciating fucking pain he was in, who knows?”

“Why not call his informant? Or me? Why did he pick you?” Aizawa questions.

“Fuck you.”

“Bakugou.”

“I don’t fucking know,” he snaps at him, scoffing. “Maybe he knew you’d give him a damn lecture.”

“Maybe that’s why he didn’t call his buddy, either.” Aizawa rubs his temples. “I should head back to UA, see if anyone is acting panicked or—“

“No, don’t go back yet,” Bakugou interrupts. “That motherfucker couldn’t have gotten far with a stab wound.”

“We’ve checked every single surrounding building. Unless he’s inside a house—“

“You’re not listening,” Bakugou hisses. “You said he hasn’t charged All Might’s credit card.”

“Yes.”

“And he’s unconscious right now, which means he can swipe any camera footage,” Bakugou says.

Aizawa frowns. “He knows to dodge cameras.”

“Exactly.”

“So?”

“Oh my fucking god, do I need to spell it out for you?” Bakugou snaps. “How did he get from near Musutafu to well past Tokyo without getting caught on camera? He couldn’t have walked there.”

Aizawa palms his face. He's an idiot. "I gotta go."

"You do that, dips—" he hangs up before Bakugou pisses him off anymore.

He's up and in the air instantly. Without so much as a goodbye, he swings between buildings, launching himself as far and as fast as possible. He only stops to take a few calls, and each one directs him to the exact information he needs.

Bullet trains are a much better form of transportation, but they're stuffed with cameras that Viridant didn't have time to turn off or wipe. So he either planned to wipe the cameras later…

Or he took an alternate path.

Only one bus runs so late at night, and it's a few towns over from Viridant's starting town. It'll take him far if he rides it pretty much the whole route, but he'd still have a lot of ground to cover on foot. Even then, it's another lead. Eraser scans the city below him, and when he spots the bus he's looking for, he swings towards it. He lands on top of it with a thud before swinging down to the door. Luckily, it's still picking people up from a bus stop, or this would've been much harder.

The driver gives him a look. "Is there a costume party I'm unaware of?"

Aizawa takes his phone out, flips it around. "Have you seen this man?"

The driver looks at the photo of Viridant and nods. "Yeah, I picked him up a couple of hours from here. He got off about ten stops down."

"You scanned his bus pass?"

"Yeah." The driver taps an electronic screen at the front of the bus. "This is him."

Eraser looks at the photo that's popped up and sighs. The man on screen is aged in his sixties with large, brown eyes. "You don't check IDs?"

"Shit, man, he was fucking terrifying looking. He paid, so I drove him." The driver shrugs. "I didn't ask any other questions."

"Which way did he go from the bus stop?" Eraser asks.

"East, I think. He was in a hurry."

At least there's something useful. That gives him a radius to search for Viridant. And if not him, then whatever the hell brought him hundreds of miles from home on a Friday night.

***

Midoriya wakes up in an unfamiliar location. He blinks blearily, his eyes crusty and dry. So is his mouth, and throat. He stretches and immediately gasps at the pain in his arm and side.

He forgot, he was stabbed twice, and crashed in the bathroom of a random house.

“Good morning, dumbass.”

He jolts, looks down at his phone on the floor. It’s been connected to his headset this whole time. His memories are a bit fuzzy, but he can recall that he phoned Ground Zero. Do all teenage boys sound like Bakugou, or is it just this one?

“How… long was I asleep?” he asks, his voice modulated.

“Oh, you know, just since six a.m. this morning. It’s 7 at night, by the way.” Ground Zero snickers at Midoroya’s panic. “Yeah, a stab wound will knock you out.”

“Fuck,” he mumbles, shoving off the bathroom floor. “I got to—

Something clatters in the room outside. He hears a curse follow it, and can only assume that the owner of this house is home from wherever he went thirteen hours ago. He must not have checked the bathroom, which is good, because Midoriya bled through his bandages and stained the guy's wall.

“Oh no.” Midoriya stands slowly, pure panic settling in. “This is bad.”

“What’s bad?” Ground Zero asks, his voice taunting. “The stab wound, or the oversleeping?”

“I-I had to crash nearby, and I just—oh god, I’m an idiot—I saw this guy leaving his house so I broke in and—“

“Yeah, fucking rewind, you broke into a guy's house?” Ground Zero says. “I thought you were supposed to be smarter than other people, not more stupid.”

“I was bleeding out from *two stab wounds,”* Midoriya hisses. “Not that you were any help.”

“I was a great fucking help!” he snips at him.

Midoriya pulls a spray bottle filled with bleach from his bag and begins to spritz the bathroom door with it while Ground Zero yammers on about how much of a great support he was and how Midoriya never would’ve made it without him and yada yada yada. He uses the wipes his mom gave him to wipe the bleach up, filling wads of cloth with blood.

Only when that’s done does he begin to dress his wounds, cringing at the amount of blood that pushed through.

“And I even waited on call with you, you’re fucking welcome, by the way. I had shit to do this Saturday that didn’t involve babysitting,” Ground Zero says.

“Thank you,” Midoriya throws in. “You… helped me a lot.”

“Fuck you.”

“I’m being nice to you!”

“I know. Fuck you still.” A TV clicks on in the opposite room, and Ground Zero belts out a laugh. “I can’t believe someone is actually home and didn’t come across you. You’re a lucky son of a bitch.”

“It was calculated,” Midoriya lies, stuffing his bag with the bloody gauze and tape.

“Oh, was it? Did you mean to call me ‘baby’ in your sleep? Was that planned as well?” Ground Zero asks. Midoriya goes beet red, and only when the asshole laughs from his side of the line does he realize that he’s messing with him. “That was funny. I think I heard your heart drop.”

“I thought you admired me or whatever you said,” Midoriya whisper-yells. “This is not what I needed to hear.”

Ground Zero laughs again. It’s cruel, wicked, and sounds just like Bakugou. This is what he gets for calling him instead of toughing it out. His delirious brain has tricked him into hearing Bakugou’s voice and not whoever the hell he’s talking to right now. Which is *not* helpful when he’s trying to calm down.

The good news is, his wounds have clotted. They’re fresh, extremely painful, and nothing short of gnarly, but they aren’t spurting blood all over the place. It’s easy to redress them and stuff his bag again. He kept a pair of shorts and a t-shirt in there as a “just in case”, which is great considering his suit is absolutely soaked through. Ground Zero is still laughing as Midoriya strips and then stuffs the ruined clothes into his backpack. It’s a pain to close it around his helmet, but he manages.

“Stop laughing, and start helping me!” Midoriya hisses, and Ground Zero goes silent. “What?”

“Are you deepening your voice?” he asks, and when Midoriya doesn’t respond, he starts laughing again.

“I’m hanging up,” Midoriya hisses, and Ground Zero coughs and pounds his chest to stop from laughing. “I don’t need this right now.”

“Okay, okay, tell me what you need, Batman.” He starts laughing again. “My bad, I’m just so fucking funny.”

“Hilarious,” Midoriya says flatly. “You said you taped Eraser’s phone?”

“Mhm.”

“Then you can code, right?”

A pause, then. “Uhh, yep.”

“Great,” Midoriya taps his phone screen. “I’m sending you my location. I need you to send me blueprints of the house so I can figure out a way out of it.”

“Ahh… yeah, send it over and I’ll do that.”

“You *do* know how to code, right?”

“Of fucking course, send it over here. I’m on it.”

Midoriya does, despite the weird feeling he’s got in his gut about this. He only got Ground Zero right now. Hitoshi is likely so mad that he wouldn’t pick up if Midoriya tried, so this is his best option. The location hovers in the chat for a moment, and Ground Zero is silent. He can hear him tapping his phone screen like a psychopath, so there must be something he’s doing.

“Alright, there you go, that was easy.” The message loads with a screenshot of the house. “See, I’m great at this. What’s next?”

“I need you to tap a street cam and tell me if there are any cops out,” Midoriya says.

“Oh, that's easy. Yeah, they’re coming.”

His heart stills. “What?”

Ground Zero pauses, then says, “A neighbor’s kid saw you go in, they just told their parents. I’m reading the 911 report right now, it was just called in, like, literally a fucking second ago.”

“Fuck.” Midoriya scans the floor plan. “Okay, okay, new plan.”

“I’m listening.”

“Call 911, tell them you saw me a few blocks down.”

“Ahhhh, yep, I got that.” He pauses. “Now, or…?”

Midoriya hangs up.

The floor plan is absolutely awful. It makes a beautiful home, but it screws Midoriya over in a lot of different ways. This bathroom door opens to a narrow hallway that, just a few feet away, expands to the living room, where the homeowner is definitely watching TV. The garage is a bust, since there’s no door out from there, and he can’t exactly open the large one without drawing attention. That means he needs to sprint from the bathroom, all the way to the kitchen. There’s a slider to the backyard located in the living room, which is so unhelpful it’s not even funny. To make it worse, the front door is directly across from the archway into the living room, meaning that the homeowner would have a direct view of him if he tried either exit.

So he's got to get to the kitchen, hide behind the island, and find a way to get the owner to look somewhere else long enough to run across to the stairs.

"Fantastic," he whispers, before slowly pushing the bathroom door open. He's careful not to leave any prints or traces of himself behind, just in case.

The TV blares loudly from the living room. Midoriya creeps into the hall and moves forward just enough to catch a glimpse of the entertainment center. The TV stand shares a wall with the doorway, meaning there's no possible way to slip by unnoticed.

Unless…

Ground Zero: I called 911. The cops said they didn't believe me and that they're coming anyway. Goodluck.

Viridant: I need you to do something for me.

Ground Zero: Wonderful, another task. Can I hold your coat, too, Greenie?

Viridant: Call the landline.

Ground Zone: Who the fuck uses those?

Viridant: This guy does. I can see it. It's in the kitchen.

Ground Zone: I don't know the number!

Viridant: ??? then go get it???

His message is read, and then a few moments later, the landline rings.

"Oh, god dammit," a man's voice says.

Midoriya presses himself to the wall as he emerges from the living room. Luckily, he stares right at the phone, never once turning to the side. As he goes, Midoriya slowly follows behind. When the guy grabs the phone and turns to face the living room, Midoriya drops and hides behind the kitchen island.

"Hello?"

A pause.

"What the fuck did you say about my mom?"

Midoriya palms his eyes.

"You listen here, asshole, I don't know who the fuck you think you are, but prank calling isn't even funny anymore."

He's going to kill Ground Zero.

“No, *you* sound like a pussy.”

Oh my god.

“Yeah, fuck you too!” The man hangs up. “What a dickhead.”

Midoriya goes right, slowly circling the island when the guy comes around the opposite side. With his back turned towards the kitchen, Midoriya quietly sprints past the front door and to the stairs. He goes up, the carpet hiding his steps. There are three doors up here. One leads to a master bedroom, one to a bathroom, and one to a guest room. He opens the guest bedroom door, which faces the back of the house, and seals the door shut behind him.

The room is small, but it has a glorious, wide-open window. With one simple tug, the screen pops loose, and Midoriya carefully sets it aside. He pushes out the hole, puts the screen back in place, then wipes down his prints with a spare gauze pad full of bleach.

“That wasn’t so bad.”

Sirens sound down the road.

“Mother. Fucker.”

Viridant: I need an ETA on any Pro Heroes in the vicinity.

Ground Zero: Do you just have this shit up and ready to go normally? How the fuck do you just expect me to pull that out of my ass?

Viridant: Please, I can’t get caught.

Ground Zero: Why?

Viridant: What the hell do you mean?! I don’t want to go to jail?!

Ground Zero: What if they don’t put you in jail? What if they let you go to Hero school or some shit?

Viridant: They won’t.

Ground Zero: Why?

Viridant: UA won’t take people like me. Can you help me or not?

Ground Zero: Eraser Head is two minutes away. You’ve got a couple of losers that are further out.

Viridant: Thank you.

He sits on his butt and slides down the roof. Cop car doors slam, and there are instructions yelled to rush the door and send someone else around back. Midoriya lands on the grass outside and hides behind the jutting of the chimney.

When a cop comes around, he jumps onto his back. He puts him in a headlock with his good arm and covers his eyes with the other. When the officer slowly crumbles to the ground, Midoriya lets him go. He's not dead; oxygen flow will bring him back pretty quickly, but he's definitely blacked out.

Before he goes, he snatches his handcuffs and radio. It's easy to shove them in his chunky cargo pockets, turning the radio off with just a click. He takes off to the neighbor's fence, hops it. The wound in his side stabs him, and he's certain it's reopened. Oh well. He dashes to the next house, hops the fence. Then one more.

Three houses down, he unlatches a side fence right as Eraser Head lands on the roof of the original home. Sorry, random guy, he'll feel much worse later down the line.

He walks down the street as nonchalantly as humanly possible. He even takes his phone out, plugs his headphones in. When he passes by the house, he snaps a photo of Eraser Head on the roof. Officers wave him on, he goes without a fight. Idiots.

When his phone rings, he answers.

"We've got you surrounded," Eraser Head says, voice grim. "Come outside. We just want to help you."

"Oh, I'm sure," Midoriya says, talking normally. Aizawa can't listen to this call again, let alone sequence the frequency of Midoriya's voice. Not without gear, which he doesn't have by the looks of him on that roof, "I'm sure you want to help me more than anything, right?"

"Kid—"

"And when I leave that house," he interrupts, picking up speed as he rounds a corner, "Will you do the grand honor of cuffing me, or do you just take the credit? I never really understood how it works with you Heroes."

"I gave you a chance," Eraser Head says, exasperated. "Come forward, take the entrance exam. You skipped out. *You.* You sealed your own fate."

"Mmm," Midoriya hums. He hurries downtown, quickly descending the first bullet train stairs he sees and scanning his actual card. The bus stop is too far away; his wound won't let him get close enough. And a stolen card can alert the security system on the bullet train. So long as he doesn't act suspiciously, the camera will register him as a paid user, and he's home free.

"Well, you seem upset."

"I'm disappointed," Eraser corrects him, "You're wasting your talents doing this."

"Yeah?" Midoriya patiently waits for the train car to arrive. "Then come inside and get me. I surrender." He hangs up the phone.

He takes a seat, sandwiched between an old lady and an American tourist. Only then, when he's out of the fray, does he send Eraser Head the photo of him on the roof. He snickers when

the Hero leaves him on read.

Ground Zero: So?

Viridant: You saved my ass.

Ground Zero: Of course I did, I'm the fucking best.

Viridant: Yeah, yeah, I guess you're a little useful.

The train shoots off, leaving whatever city he landed in behind. Midoriya's t-shirt that says "sweater" is black, so the blood he feels seeping out of his side isn't so obvious. His shoulder seems to have held up, but the rest of him hurts like a motherfucker.

Ground Zero: So how'd you get away?

Viridant: Quickly.

Ground Zero: Still leaving me out even when I proved my loyalty. So mean, Greenie.

Midoriya rolls his eyes damn near out of his head, but Ground Zero is right. He's proved he's loyal, and he's a quick worker. Those blueprints saved his life, and even though Ground Zero couldn't get the cops away, the warning about Eraser Head was enough to ensure he wouldn't get caught.

Now he just needs to get home.

Viridant: Fine. I guess you're right.

Ground Zero: So… tell me something juicy, I can help you out.

He pauses, thinks, then remembers what Ground Zero said about All Might on their call. Why not give it a try?

Viridant: So remember what you said about All Might?

Ground Zero: About how he's built like a McDonald's French fry?

Viridant: Oh yeah, you ready for this?

Ground Zero: I doubt it's as crazy as you're hyping it up to be.

Viridant: No, it's absolutely insane. You can't tell anyone, okay? Promise me. And you have to believe me.

Ground Zero: Promise. Now hit me.

Viridant: He's Quirkless. His Quirk was passed down to him through someone else.

The bubbles appear, disappear, appear again.

Ground Zero: What?

Viridant: I couldn’t believe it either, but everything I’ve learned about him confirms it. He’s trying to find a new successor to give it to. Have you heard he’s teaching at UA now? That’s why he’s there. He’s trying to find some kid to give it away to.

Ground Zero: That’s why everyone is hell bent on finding you. All Might wants to give you his Quirk, doesn’t he?

Viridant: Smart.

Ground Zero: So why not take it? Why are you hiding?

Viridant: I tried.

Ground Zero: What the fuck does that mean?

Midoriya bounces his leg, glances around the train.

Viridant: I talked to All Might. I hinted that I knew. He didn’t even bat an eye. That’s why I’m not doing the Hero school bullshit. He told me to give up, he said I’m wasting my many other talents trying to become a Pro.

Ground Zero: What the fuck.

Viridant: Right?! You have to believe me.

The next message comes in instantly.

Ground Zero: I do.

***

Bakugou sits with his arms crossed at a large, oval meeting table. On his right is Present Mic. On his left is Principal Nezu. At the far end is All Might. The spindly man looks nervous, drumming his thin fingers on the table top. Bakugou has half the mind to ask him if it’s true —if he’s really… Quirkless.

Deku is on his mind, his unnaturally understanding smile wavering and falling flat.

When Viridant had texted him about All Might’s secret, he didn't want to believe it. He was insulted by the mere implication. All Might couldn’t be Quirkless; he’s the best Hero there ever was. All Might, who could smash through walls. All Might, who could save thousands

of people in one day. All Might, a known symbol of peace and safety. All Might, Deku's favorite Hero.

What would he say if he knew the truth? Would he be devastated? Would he be ecstatic? The truth is, Bakugou knows exactly what Deku would do. When something about you is wrong, is unacceptable, is far from normalized, it doesn't matter how much you advocate for equality. It doesn't matter how much you tell the world you are equal, you are unashamed, you were not born wrong. Because some small, tiny, awful part of you will always agree with those who hate you. Some minuscule, nagging voice is always going to tell you that the rest of the world is right, you *are* wrong.

Bakugou knows the feeling.

So he knows, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that if Deku were to learn about All Might's quirk… he'd go after it. He'd try to take it, to wield it. And Bakugou is certain that Deku would be kind at first, but if he didn't get what he wanted, he'd find an alternate route to the same destination. Most people think Deku is this pathetic, helpless little thing, but Bakugou knows better.

He's seen the path Deku has started to walk. A ring of bruises on his neck, a limp in his leg, a burn mark on his arm. Deku has no Quirk, but he's nothing short of analytical, cynical. He has a way of hiding things from the world that Bakugou can't even begin to unravel, no matter how much he fucking tries, and he's tried more than he likes to admit.

So he knows that Deku is a few wrong people away from diving off the deep end. Hero school was supposed to pull him out of that. But he never got in.

What would he think now? If he saw All Might so tentative and small? Would he turn to Bakugou and ask him if the way All Might looks haunts him? Would he tell Bakugou that the way All Might must've been treated growing up is an exact reflection of what Deku went through? Would he laugh in Bakugou's face, tell him he's known the truth for a while, always one step ahead?

Bakugou doesn't know. The Deku he knew had been so bent over the years that the last real interaction they had… Deku snapped. He had been splintering and creaking for years, but he finally broke open, and that thing inside him escaped for just a moment.

Look what you did to me. Look what you made me into.

The door to the meeting room squeaks open. Aizawa-sensei steps in, tosses a Manila folder onto the table. "Lab results came in. The hair sample comes back to a Toga Himiko. She's been missing since she was seven."

Fucking Christ.

"That is rather unfortunate news. I hope she's doing alright on her own," Principal Nezu says, hands clasped behind his back. "Any probable reason she could have a run-in with our special vigilante?"

Aizawa drops onto a chair beside Mic. While the table covers anything below their chests, he can tell by the angle of Mic's arm that he must've reached for Aizawa's hand. Bakugou looks away, shoving down memories of a small hand that was once outstretched to him.

"I think the kid is trying to figure out the UA attack," Aizawa says, voice worn with exhaustion. He tied his long hair back as he talked, revealing deep eye bags previously hidden in shadow. "I couldn't tell you why that brought him to Koto, but we've got some new leads, according to Bakugou."

Before Bakugou can talk, All Might leans forward.

"We haven't formally met, young Bakugou. I appreciate you joining the case," All Might says, earning a snort from Aizawa-sensei. "What information have you gathered?"

He told me to give up, he said I'm wasting my many other talents trying to become a Pro.

Bakugou opens his mouth.

UA won't take people like me.

The words build in his throat.

You can't tell anyone. You have to promise me.

His memory takes him back to ten years ago. He and Deku lay on his bed, bellies full, eyes drooping with sleep. Deku leans over, whispers a secret, and something so heavy, so painful breaks open in Bakugou's chest. When Deku falls asleep, he knocks on Mom's door. He's crying, pointing at his bedroom door where Deku sleeps peacefully.

He keeps thinking about what he said, tears clogging his throat. "How are we supposed to be Heroes now? 'Zuku doesn't have a Quirk, Mom, how can we be Heroes now?"

He doesn't cry anymore. And he's finally learning how to shut his fucking mouth.

"He mentioned his run-in with All Might and the stolen wallet," Bakugou says, "He also mentioned how quickly he got home, so we should check bullet train cams."

"On it," Present Mic stands up.

Aizawa-sensei leans forward. "Anything else?"

And Bakugou lies through his fucking teeth. "Not yet."

His sensei deflates, rubs his temple. "The information you fed to him—the house blueprints, the landline, my location, did any of it help?"

Bakugou nods. "He's starting to warm up to me. He's definitely fucking iffy on the whole thing, but I'm working him."

"Then that's all we can do," Nezu says, clasping his hands together. "Keep trying our best."

When the meeting adjourns, and Bakugou goes home, he takes the second phone out of his pocket. In the darkness of his bedroom, two messages wait for him.

Viridant: For what it's worth, coming from a kid who got a lot of shit from classmates growing up, I think it would be worth it to reach out to the friend you told me about this morning.

Viridant: If it were me, I think it wouldn't have mattered what you had said or done, but how you learned from it later on.

Bakugou reads those two texts over and over and over again.

Ground Zero: What if I didn't learn anything at all?

The response is instant.

Viridant: Maybe it's a good time to start.

Chapter End Notes

rawr XD

Chapter 20: Break-in

Chapter Summary

Midoirya and Hitoshi break into UA to steal support items!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Wow. So you cheated on me."

Midoriya pinches the bridge of his nose. "First of all, we aren't in a relationship. Second of all, Ground Zero and I aren't in a relationship. I simply called him for help—"

"Instead of me," Hitoshi butts in, levying a long sigh his way. "After all we've been through, you let another man aid you with your stab wounds and plan your grand escape. This is just like The Notebook."

"Okay," Midoriya grunts, sitting up in his bed. "This is nothing like The Notebook."

"I'll wait for you, Viridant. I'll build you a house with blue shutters and a wrap-around porch while you go behind my back and SCREW ANOTHER MAN," Hitoshi wails.

Midoriya rolls his eyes. "He helped me escape. He saved my ass."

"After all I've done for you," Hitoshi fake cries. "I even dumped milk on Kacchan during lunch. It was amazing."

"You… what?" Midoriya rubs his head. "His name isn't Kacchan."

"Oh, I know," he snickers, "But the look on his face when I said 'I'm sooo sorry, Kacchan' will go down as one of my best moments."

Midoriya scoffs, "You actually dumped milk on him?"

"I dumped a fucking cup of noodles on him the day before. Dickhead was pulling artificial corn out of his hair the entire day. I'm thinking I should dump an entire container of glitter on Monday," Hitoshi sighs wistfully. "He's got cute friends, zero idea how he landed them, but the stupid one is my favorite."

"Weren't you just saying I was cheating on you?" Midoriya asks, standing from bed. "Hypocrit."

"Oh, right. HOW COULD YOU! DIVORCE!"

He hobbles to the bathroom and slowly peels his shirt off. He's lucky the wounds were small, the blade thin enough not to warrant stitches. It went deep, but not deep enough to kill him, yay!!!

"You've got a lot of energy," Midoriya says, poking at the pink, tender flesh. It's finally starting to scab; it only took a full week. "Are you nervous about consolidation?"

"The paper tests are easy," Hitoshi says. "It's the bullshit Quirk tests that kick my ass. If I get paired against Kacchan—"

"—Bakugou—"

"Then what the hell am I meant to do? The worst part is, I *know* I'm a good fighter, I also know I'm good at pissing people off," Hitoshi yawns, "But my disadvantages are so much larger than every other kid here. I've yet to meet a single student with a mental Quirk. Plenty of physical."

"Well, then they won't see you coming," Midoriya offers, snickering at Hitoshi's grumbling agreement. "You've been training with Eraser Head, haven't you?"

That's all it takes to get Hitoshi back to a decent mood. Growing up, Midoriya's idol was All Might. But Hitoshi? He's been Eraser Head's number one fan since he learned how to access those hidden underground Hero forums when he was twelve. Midoriya still isn't clear on how, exactly, Hitoshi began to get into coding. He's not sure he wants to know. When he asked, Hitoshi had only snickered in response before changing the subject.

It was only slightly terrifying.

"We've been working with the scarf support tool that you love so much," Hitoshi says, "I've got the basic mechanics of it down, I just wish I got longer sessions with him or someone to practice with."

Midoriya says, voice laced with sarcasm, "You should sneak me onto campus and I'll steal one to help you practice."

Silence.

"No, that was a joke—"

"Let's do it."

"Hitoshi—"

"I'm serious, why not?"

"It's UA," Midoriya says, voice quiet, "Even if you could get me on campus, I wouldn't want to be there."

"But think of it. It's like one big 'fuck you' to the dipshits who denied you." There's the sound of rustling, sheets moving as though he's getting out of bed. "This fucking house *sucks*

to be in, and I'm so stressed out about this exam coming up. A distraction that involves being anywhere but here sounds wonderful."

"This is so stupid," Midoriya palms his eyes, "If you get caught, then you're getting kicked out of UA. You'd be throwing your future away."

"Fuck it, we ball."

"*No,* we do not ball," Midoriya squawks, "I can't do this knowing I'm risking your career. Let's go get ice cream or something if you need to get out, or you can crash on my couch, Mama won't mind."

More rustling, the sound of a window sliding open. "I agree, this would be such a stupid and irresponsible idea."

"You're sneaking out to go to UA aren't you?"

"Yup. See you there." The line goes flat.

God. Dammit.

Midoriya hadn't planned to ever go back to UA. He can't even look at it, sitting atop a hill and overlooking the cities below it. It's one of the most secure buildings in the world, filled to the brim with top-of-the-class students and Pros. This isn't some random high school; it's UA, it's everything he's ever fallen short on.

He worked so hard to get into that school. In the end, it still wasn't enough. It feels kind of pathetic to go and think about what could've been.

But… it *would* be a really quick way to piss Eraser off, which is was more funny than it should be.

He chews a nail. "Am I really doing this?"

His phone buzzes, and when he checks it, it's a message from Ground Zero. He eyes it, taps his foot. Three people would be hard to sneak into UA, but Ground Zero would mash really well with Hitoshi.

Ground Zero: How's your stab wounds?

Viridant: Healing.

Ground Zero: No shit, Sherlock. Are they infected or anything?

Viridant: One is, but I handled it.

Ground Zero: How does one handle an infection from a knife wound?

He huffs a laugh through his nose.

Viridant: What are you doing tonight?

Ground Zero: Aww, you want to call me and tell me goodnight, Greenie?

Viridant: Just tell me.

Ground Zero: Studying. I have a big fucking exam coming up.

Midoriya frowns. He would've invited him if it hadn't been taking him away from his schoolwork.

Viridant: Never mind, then. I was going to invite you out with a friend of mine, but no worries! Studying is important.

Ground Zero: EHAT

Ground Zero: FUCK WAIY ILL GO

Ground Zero: HELLO?!

Ground Zero: FUCK

Midoriya has already pocketed his phone. He leaves the bathroom after wrapping his wounds again, just in case he goes too hard tonight. He's been keeping it easy since the initial incident, back to hoodies and sweatpants. He plans to eventually go back to that weird underground system, but for now, he's got to recover.

Instead, he's been handling issues through the internet. He and Hitoshi have been working on something big for weeks—something that can change this whole operation if they succeed. It's the hardest thing they've done yet, so illegal that he feels awful to even consider asking Ground Zero for help. He's kept him carefully separated from the bulk of what he's doing. Committing a crime is one thing; stringing someone along with him is another.

Unfortunately, Hitoshi is already way too deep into this. Midoriya's taken him on a few patrols or stays on call with him as he goes. They get a kick out of sharing the live recording from his goggles and finding the best way to torment a Pro. As much as he likes the company of the moon and stars, it's not so bad to have Hitoshi at his side.

They meet at UA in nearly identical outfits. Midoriya stitched some green lining onto his clothes, kept his mask, and added the steel coverings to his shoes. Hitoshi gives far less of a shit, in regular grey sweats and a puffy jacket. He does have his own voice modulator on, at least. It's part of his Hero costume, and he loves wearing it. Plus, it's hidden enough that cameras can't pick up on it below the hoodie.

"I always forget you're so small," Hitoshi whispers when Midoriya appears beside him.

"Fuck you."

"Shhh." Hitoshi points at a passing, rolling robot. They met outside the school's front gates, just out of view of the camera that faces this way. "I couldn't tap the cams without it alerting

the Pros. Somehow they caught onto us using them."

"You tell me that after I walk all the way over here?" Midoriya cries out. "I had planned to bust a drug ring tonight!"

"SHHH," his friend again says. "Those little fucking robots can detect noise from yards away."

"We don't even have a plan to get in here—" Hitoshi dangles two lanyards in front of Midoriya. He recognizes the names listed on them as Class 1-C students. "You planned to do this tonight?"

Hitoshi turns to him, winks a purple eye. "I've been planning this for a while. You're not the only one who knows how to survive."

"That's… kind of cool as hell," Midoriya says, taking the offered lanyard. "So, the plan?"

"I've followed these two kids around for weeks. They always scan in late at night to train in the facilities. The cameras will pick up on us and alert a Pro, but once we scan the badges, it should report that we've got pre-authorized clearance and clear the alert." He points at one of the robots. "Those dickheads operate on a totally different system. They scan an individual's entire body and can pull a name from the school's database about who it's looking at. So long as we avoid those guys, we're fine."

Midoriya nods and tracks the robot's path. "It really just walks back and forth like that?"

"Yup," Hitoshi says. "We've got to be quick about getting in. The front gates will open for us, but they go back up the second we cross inside. They won't open again until we scan our barcodes. We've got an allotted two hours before it alerts a Pro again."

"So we need to clear these alerts as fast as possible before someone checks the cameras and sees us running around the halls," Midoriya again watches the robot. "That's seven seconds to scan our cards before that thing turns back around and spots us."

Hitoshi snickers. "Easy enough."

"I'll follow your lead."

When the little robot whirs across the cement of the front entrance, Hitoshi takes off running the moment it turns. Midoriya follows after, careful to keep his steps light and secure. They make it to the front gate and flash their cards up at the camera.

He's certain they're screwed, but the camera announces the confirmation of entry for the Class-C students before the door slowly clicks open. They squeeze into the small gap before it fully opens, just barely missing the robot as it circles back. The gate slams shut behind them.

And then they're in. UA, right at its front door. It's huge, sky-high and flawless. Not a single smudge dirties the pristine glass of its structure, not a speck of dirt touches the beams of the building. He came for the entrance exam, sure, but he never got this close to it.

He holds a hand out, runs a glove down a panel of glass. What he would've given to be here.

"Come on," Hitoshi says, jerking his head to the side. "Let's go in."

Midoriya nods, trails after Hitoshi as he enters the large square center. The courtyard is pretty, nature surrounding the paved pathways. More robots whir around, but they're so easy to avoid now that they have more room to work with. The two of them walk along the small concrete walls that frame gardens and trees, laughing as they go. The robots can't scan that high, so they bump off the concrete and turn around to bump off the next.

Midoriya debates taking one, deciding he likely will at the end of this.

They approach some glass doors. Hitoshi scans the stolen lanyard and then holds the door open, snickering when Midoriya rolls his eyes. The inside of the school is very minimalist, likely to have enough room to fit a large number of students. They walk the halls in tense silence for a long time. Midoriya can't help but be quiet. He's looking at everything he's ever dreamed of.

"Tell me about the guy," he finally says as a way to break the silence. "One of you-know-who's cute friends, you said?"

"Cute and stupid, the whole lot of them," Hitoshi answers right away, taking them down the long hallways. He leans in to whisper, as though anyone is around to hear this, "This guy is a blond, about my height, with a Quirk that makes him all stupid when he overuses it."

"Oh, I know exactly who you're talking about," Midoriya says quietly. He'd seen him on Class-A's roster, "You're going for a big fish, huh?"

"He's a nice guy; it's a whole mystery why he wastes his time with the dickhead," Hitoshi sighs wistfully. "He knows my Quirk, but he still comes up to talk to me."

"Ooooh," Midoriya coos. "You think he's interested?"

"I don't know," Hitoshi mumbles, "He's nice to pretty much everyone. And he's always hanging around this girl with a super loud Quirk. I like to think that I made some sort of impression, but honestly, I think he might be straight."

Midoirya whispers, "He has a lightning strike hairclip."

"Okay, *mainly* straight." Hitoishi snaps loudly.

Midoriya hums, looks up at the ceiling as they walk by classrooms. "Well, go find out."

Hitoshi stops and scoffs. "What—ask him out? That's insane."

"Yeah."

"And risk being outed to the whole school."

"Yeah."

“Are you crazy?” Hitoshi gestures to the school around him. “I finally made it to a school where I don’t feel like everyone is whispering behind my back. Could you imagine if they knew I was…”

“Gay?” Midoriya finishes, laughing when Hitoshi glares at him. “I’m pretty sure they could take one look at you and know that.”

“I take offense to that,” Hitoshi hisses. “I can’t do it, okay? This is the closest I’ve ever gotten to peace, I won’t risk it on some guy.”

“Some cute guy.”

“*Very* cute. But he’s such an idiot, too. He once asked me what I was reading. I said Little Women, and he asked me how they got so small,” Hitoshi says, shoving Midoriya’s shoulder when he bends over laughing. “That’s not even the dumbest thing he’s said, I’m not joking.”

Midoriya has to hold onto Hitoshi's shoulder for support, tears leaking from his eyes.

“I told him I was lactose intolerant one time, and he brought brownies to school for his friends and decided to give me one he made special for me,” Hitoshi says, snickering, “It was so sweet, then I read the note.” He takes his phone out, shows Midoriya a photo of the note.

“I made these vegetarian since you’re lack toes in toddler ant.” With a pile of poop drawn next to the words.

“Vegetarians can still have dairy products!” Hitoshi cries out, "And how does he not know how to spell lactose intolerant? He’s in *UA.”*

Midoriya wipes tears from his eyes, his chest aching with laughter. “I’m more caught up on the pile of shit with flies he drew next to it. You know what’s even worse? I bet you still ate the brownies.”

“Inhaled them, suffered the consequences, asked for more, and then ate those too.” Hitoshi shoves him again when Midoriya belts out another laugh. “I’ve got it bad for him.”

“He made you a special batch! It sounds like he really likes you.”

“Or he’s super friendly, since he gave everyone else brownies as well. I don’t know. I hate this,” Hitoshi groans before grabbing Midoriya’s wrist, “Let’s talk about you, I can’t stand thinking about him a moment longer.”

“What about me?” he asks as Hitoshi drags him up a flight of stairs. “My love life is extremely boring.”

“You’ve never had a crush?” Hitoshi asks, before adding. “I can’t imagine you not falling head over heels for some rando.”

A face comes to mind, but it dissolves immediately from his brain. “I’ve never let myself, I figured it wouldn’t ever go anywhere.”

“Oh my god, have you even kissed someone?” Hitoshi asks. “This is so sad.”

Midoriya shakes his head. “People thought I’d infect them, like I've got herpes or some shit.”

“That’s genuinely awful,” Hitoshi says, frowning. “What about Ground Zero? He’s a good option.”

“What about him?”

“He seems pretty interested.” Hitoshi knocks their shoulders together before tugging open a classroom door. “I bet he’d make a good kisser.”

Midoriya makes a face. “We don’t really know each other, I guess. I’m not sure a relationship is really in the cards for me right now, if ever.” He glances around the classroom. “I almost invited him tonight.”

“Tell me more.”

“I…” He sets a hand on a student's desk, a desk he would’ve done anything to sit in. “I don’t know. I told myself that the two of you would get along, but saying that out loud makes me realize it’s not totally true. I guess I just… I don’t know, I thought it might be nice to have him here—don’t give me that look.”

“One phone call and he’s got you hooked, that’s impressive.” Hitoshi snickers when he gets shoved back. “You trust him.”

“I think he’s getting there,” Midoriya corrects. “And… if you ever mention this to him or bring it up again, I swear, I’ll never talk to you again.”

“Say it.”

Midoriya looks around as though someone is going to hear him confess all this. “I like his voice. He sounds… I don’t know. I could listen to him talk and fall asleep to the sound.”

“OH MY GOD YOU HAVE A CRU—“ Midoriya yanks Hitoshi’s mask down so he can slap a hand over his mouth. The camera in the corner is facing the idiots' back, thankfully.

“I do *not.”*

Hitoshi licks his palm, and Midoriya yanks his hand back in disgust.

“You do too.”

“Do not.”

“Do too.”

“Do not.”

“Do too!” Hitoshi snickers, "This is so cute #prouddad.”

“Don’t say hashtag out loud, it sounds so weird.”

“#prouddad #queerdad #mysonisgay—“

“You are a *pain,* you know that?” Midoriya says, but he’s laughing, “Ground Zero is the first person to ever show an interest in me. That’s all.”

“This is just like the n—“

“If you say this is just like the notebook, I will text Eraser Head your full name.”

Hitoshi rolls his eyes. The brief silence that follows drops the mood drastically. Midoriya had tried to keep it positive and happy, but it’s impossible to deny this hole in his chest.

He keeps looking at these desks. Keeps imagining a different life, one where he has a Quirk, where he made it to UA, where he was… something. Someone. A life where he wakes up every day and there’s something to keep going for, to keep working for. He can’t shake this pit in his stomach that he’s too late, that he’s too far behind, that he can’t ever catch up to those ahead of him.

Nothing seems to go right with him. Every time he saves someone, it costs him weeks of pain and agony. Every time he thinks he’s getting better, he’s reminded just how out of touch he is. Every time he thinks it’s going to be a good day, something whispers to him, calls to him, tells him he’s not going to get any better than he’s always been.

He keeps thinking about the roof. He keeps thinking about the life he was so ready to throw away, keeps thinking about the things he’s failed to do, the promise he needs to keep.

Hitoshi says, “Sit down.”

“What?”

“Sit down.”

Midoriya blinks at him. Then, slowly, as though it’s forbidden, he sits in the chair.

“There you go,” Hitoshi says, a hand gesturing to Midoriya. “A Hero in UA. You made it.”

His heart is heavy, his eyes wet.

“Welcome to it.” Hitoshi heads to the front of the class, stands behind the podium. “This is first period, which means you’ll learn math from Ectoplasm.” He spins around, makes a crazy loud scream, and waves his hands. “This is second period, English with Present Mic!” Another spin, and Hitoshi leans against the pillar and twirls a fake strand of hair. “Third period, art history with mMdnight.” Another spin, and he’s stone-faced, matter-of-fact. “Fourth period, history with Cementoss."

Midoriya’s lips warble.

Hitoshi steps forward, grabs his hands, and tugs him upward. “Come on.”

“Where are we going?”

“You’ll see.”

His friend leads him to the official UA training grounds. USJ has been temporarily shut down, so most students practice in a large room with concrete jutting from the floor. It’s enclosed in a glass dome, the textures frosted for privacy.

“This is Heroics. Taught by Eraser Head,” Hitoshi says, arms spread wide, “Here, they teach students how to navigate terrain, how to sharpen their skills in an ever-changing environment.”

They stare at the large concrete slabs, the tip almost touching the dome class.

“You know what the idiot told me?” Hitoshi says, voice quiet. “He said that Eraser Head makes them climb all the way up here and down at the beginning of every class. If each student can do it and jump across that gap at the top in under three minutes, then the class gets easier drills. If not… Then good luck.”

Midoriya stares at the course, thinking, analyzing. Hitoshi tugs his phone from his pocket, opens the clock app.

“I’ll time you,” he says, grinning at him so wide that, even with the mask, the crinkle of his eyes hints at his joy. “Ready, set… go!”

So Midoriya does. He finds the best possible route, his shoes finding purchase in the divots and holes in the concrete. He hoists himself up, pushes himself to move faster. Faster than he ever has before. Another ledge, another divot. His callouses scrape against the concrete, his feet scrape against the wall. And when he makes it to the top, he doesn’t even think. He runs, jumps, and that moment of open air sets his heart soaring.

He lands on the other side, rolls, jumps down another ledge. Piece by piece, bit by bit, faster than he’s ever gone before. And when he lands on the ground below, Hitoshi pauses the timer.

“So?” Midoriya pants, his body lit up, blood pumping. “How’d I do?”

Hitoshi says, "There hasn’t been one first year in this school who could finish on time.” He flips the phone around. “Until now.”

Two minutes flat.

He looks back at the large structure he scaled, then turns back to Hitoshi.

Two minutes, when nobody could’ve done it in three.

“It should’ve been you,” Hitoshi says, and he looks so sad as he does. “It should’ve been you training here, it should’ve been you at the top of your class, it should've been *you.”*

And Midoriya can’t help it. His face scrunches, his eyes boil over, and a loud sob works its way from his chest. He hasn’t cried over UA since he first got the rejection letter. He hasn’t

let himself think about it, hasn't let himself mourn the life he so desperately wanted to live. But he mourns it now, and the grief is unbearable.

Hitoshi pulls him into a hug, squeezes him tight. And Midoriya cries and cries like he's a little kid.

"I wanted it so bad," he sobs, his shoulders shaking. "I spent every second studying. I took every mock exam. I trained for *months."* Hitoshi rocks them back and forth. "I thought—I thought if I wanted it enough, then it would happen. I thought if I put everything into it, if I dedicated my life to it, there's no way they could turn me away."

Hitoshi says nothing.

"I lost—I lost everything," Midoriya chokes out. "And I'm so fucking humiliated. I told everyone that it was going to be *me.* And all I ever got out of it was this realization that they were right the whole time." He shudders, shakes horribly. "They were all right. I thought—I thought I could be something."

"You *are* something," he finally says, his voice soft. "You are *someone."*

And he's not sure why he says it, why it's the first words out of his mouth, but it slips between his teeth like he can't contain it anymore.

"My friend killed herself."

Hitoshi stills. "What?"

"She shot herself." Midoriya shuts his eyes tight, the sound of a gun echoing in his head. "I found Bluer the same night. The reason I was in that part of town—I got lost on my way home from her house. I knew the way back, but I got lost, and I thought—I thought it had to be for a reason. She couldn't have just-just died for *nothing.*"

The flowers on her front steps are fresh. They always are. He leaves new ones every time he goes for patrol, talks to her from her front porch.

"And I think UA was going to be my way to prove her wrong. To tell her that there's more in the world. That this isn't it for people like us, like me." He pulls back, shakes his head. "I didn't even get to tell her that I failed. I didn't even get to tell her that I never got in."

Hitoshi blinks, his own tears falling down his face. "I'm so sorry."

"Ah," Midoriya wipes his eyes. "There I go, being a big crybaby."

"You're not a crybaby," he says, "You're alive."

Midoriya shrugs, looks at the course behind him. "And look how much good it did me." He turns back around, laughs at himself. "I'm sitting in the same spot I started in. I feel like I'm in this pit that I just can't crawl out of. And every time I get to the top, it's like, it's like I just let go and fall right back down to the bottom again."

Hitoshi squeezes his arm. “You haven’t…”

“Almost,” Midoriya confesses. “I’ve almost done it.”

“But you didn’t.”

Deku.

“But I didn’t.”

Go home.

“Come on,” Hitohi whispers, tugging his sleeve. “Let’s get what we came here for.”

With thirty minutes remaining, the two of them head back to the main school building. It’s easy to break into the Support workshop, and even easier to snatch one of the spare scarves from a hook in the wall. Eraser Head has a white one, Hitoshi’s is purple, and Midoriya’s is black.

They slip out of the school the same way they came in, dodging little robots and laughing when Midoriya picks one up and starts running with it.

And late at night, when the two of them fall asleep watching movies on the living room couch, Mama comes home. She doesn’t know much about what her baby goes through, but she knows that this is something good, something that he needed. So she takes a spare blanket and drapes it over their sleeping bodies. She gets the best sleep she’s had in fifteen years, knowing it was all worth it. *He* was worth it.

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Aizawa stares at his laptop screen, head popped into a fist. His lips tremble, but he doesn’t allow any noise to escape them. A large hand rubs circles into the back of his shirt, soothing and comforting. It does little to help, but it’s nice to know that Hizashi is still trying.

Two Class-C students had reported their student IDs missing a week ago. Aizawa had a hunch what that meant, so he kept them active. When he got the alert that the IDs had been scanned, he immediately opened the security system. The cameras caught two men openly committing a felony.

But what those men don’t know is that the UA camera system underwent an extensive update. If Viridant was going to hack the camera system, Aizawa was going to know what the little shit was hearing.

So he added a sound system.

“It’s alright, Shouta,” Hizashi whispers, rubbing those circles into his back, “It’s alright.”

The cameras caught two men committing a federal crime.

But it also caught two teenage boys talking about crushes. Two kids shoving each other around and laughing about stupid things. One student comforting a friend, and one Vigilante breaking a school record for a building he would never be allowed inside.

He had given Viridant so much *shit* for not going to the entrance exam. He was furious! He had thought he wasted months of convincing the school board to give a crime-wielding child a chance, and he allowed it to curve his perception of the kid. And here he sits, learning that Viridant had tried.

And it was Aizawa who turned him away. It was Principal Nezu. It was All Might. It was the very staff of people who promised to take the kid in that turned him away.

The vigilante got away last night. Aizawa was supposed to lock him inside whatever classroom he entered using a virtual locking system, and he fell through on it. He couldn’t do it. He couldn’t lock the kid away, knowing that he’d be going to jail for just wanting to do what’s right.

So he let him go. With a stolen alarm bot and a support item, he let the kid go.

He puts his face in his hands. “I couldn’t do it.”

“I know.” Hizashi rubs his back. “It’s what I love about you. You’ve got a heart too big for your chest.”

And nobody says that about Aizawa. And he cries, and his husband comforts him, and he thinks about how many nights these kids have spent by themselves, with nobody to tell them it’s going to be alright.

He’s got to fix this. He’s dealt with plenty of vigilantes, but never one so young and persistent. He’s got to fix this.

“What?” Bakugou answers right away despite how annoyed he sounds. “I’m eating fucking breakfast.”

“Did Viridant contact you early this morning?” Aizawa asks.

Bakugou groans. “My pancakes are getting cold so you can ask me—“

“Bakugou.”

“Yes, he did.”

“You didn’t inform me.”

“We have weekly meetings, I planned to tell you then,” Bakugou replies smoothly. “Did something happen to the idiot?”

“Just—text me from now on, okay? The second you hear from him, I want to hear from you.” Aizawa gazes at the laptop screen, at the two intertwined students. “I think I have a lead, and you need to help me chase it.”

“Great, can I go back to my fucking pancakes now?”

Chapter End Notes

oof

Chapter 21: Analyze that!

Chapter Summary

Midoriya and Ground Zero get along

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya pushes the food on his lunch tray around with a plastic spork. Mama usually packs him bento boxes full of food for school, but she's been working extra to pay back Auntie even though Midoriya tells her she doesn't have to. She insists and gives him envelopes full of money to drop off at her house. He just sneaks the bills back into her wallet instead. It's not that he can't pack his own lunch… okay, he can't pack his own lunch. He could burn water. He nearly set the kitchen on fire the last time he attempted to make ramen noodles.

School lunch it is.

"What do you think, Midoriya?"

He looks up from his tray. "What?"

"About the All Might fight at UA?"

He blinks slowly. "Oh, sorry. I think it's really sad."

"Right? And then…" he zones out again.

He hasn't been doing too hot. Pushing off the grief that came from missing out on UA has now backfired. It's like the few months he's missed out on have come back to haunt him, dropping his mood to awful levels. He hasn't felt like this since middle school. Not that it's been very long, but still.

Hitoshi still calls, and they hang out at Midoriya's house often now, playing video games and making pillow forts. But when he leaves, and the quiet comes back in, Midoriya feels…

Empty.

He plugs the hole festering inside him with his work, but it never stays full for long. What used to be so fulfilling has become heavy. But he's been floating through his everyday, so it's good to be weighed down, to drop back to Earth.

His phone buzzes.

Ground Zero: Hey, Greenie.

Midoriya rubs his eye, yawns.

Viridant: To what do I owe the pleasure?

Ground Zero: Any updates on the scarf? I'm waiting to see that shit in action.

Viridant: I've got some plans coming up. I can send you footage of it once it's done.

Ground Zero: You think I can't help?

Viridant: I think you can, but I think you shouldn't have to.

Ground Zero: I can handle myself just fine, Greenie.

Midoriya debates it. When Ground Zero had reached out after the school break in, Midoriya filled him in on the scarf-heist portion of it. Weirdly enough, the guy didn't follow up for any more information. Now they sit at a weird impasse. Ground Zero wants to be more involved, Midoriya doesn't want to burden him with it, so on and so forth.

But, honestly, he really likes Ground Zero. He's mean, but in a way that tells Midoriya he doesn't really mean it. He's a bit flirty, but he's witty and passionate, too. He offers an alternate perspective to any problem that Midoriya comes to him with and has saved him multiple times.

But the shit that happened in Koto is something far deeper. Midoriya has been having nightmares about the tunnel he came across. The smell was so potent, he could taste it in his sleep. He hasn't shared that footage with anyone, not even Hitoshi, who has literally begged for it so he could figure out what was going on.

He sends out a text message.

Viridant: Have you ever seen a dead body?

Bubbles pop up then disappear. When they come back, the message is worded differently.

Ground Zero: Did you kill someone, Viridant?

Since when does Ground Zero call him that? Weird.

Viridant: No.

Ground Zero: What happened, Greenie?

Back to normal, then.

Viridant: Answer me.

Ground Zero: You first.

He huffs, earning a weird look from Ito across the table. Still, he types.

Viridant: I'm investigating the UA attack. I found a lead and followed it.

Ground Zero: Too Koto?

Viridant: Not just Koto. I can't explain it all yet, but I came across something fucking massive. The attack on UA? It's nothing compared to this.

Ground Zero: I've seen dead bodies. Couple of strung-out homeless people who have overdosed, a few suicides in my town, too. It's not pretty, but it's reality.

Midoriya nibbles his lip.

Viridant: I came across corpses. Maybe twenty of them. No identification or anything, just torn off arms or legs, intestines strung about. It was the worst thing I've ever seen. And the smell. I never knew something could smell like that.

Ground Zero replies instantly.

Ground Zero: You need to report that, fucking now if possible.

Viridant: I can't.

Ground Zero: Why the hell not?

Viridant: It's not that simple. I can't have any Pros or cops involved. They might ruin it.

Ground Zero: Ruin what?

Midoriya curses himself for letting this random kid get involved in his shit. He stands from the lunch table, says his goodbyes, and then heads to the bathroom after dumping his lunch tray. Only when he's locked in a stall, does he message again.

Viridant: I'm going to show you a video I took.

Ground Zero: You fucking filmed it?

Viridant: My goggles have a camera function. Anytime I wear my gear, exactly what I see is recorded and uploaded to a backup software. Just in case something happens.

Ground Zero: Send it over.

Viridant: I haven't shown anyone this.

Ground Zero: Not even your buddy?

Viridant: Not even him.

Ground Zero: Why not?

Midoriya swallows thickly. Hitoshi said he trusted Midoriya to reveal whatever information he wanted to Ground Zero. So, here goes nothing.

Viridant: He attends UA. I didn't want to scare him. He knows about what happened, but I haven't told him about the bodies.

Ground Zero: I'm fucking honored. Send the footage, Greenie.

He does. He's careful to crop the beginning and end, only allowing Ground Zero to see a few minutes of it. From when he came out of the tunnel into the ground city, the shrine for the dead, his walk through the dark, bloody tunnel. His voice is modulated the entire time, but aside from that, nothing else is left uncertain.

Ground Zero doesn't respond for a very long time.

Viridant: I'm sorry, I shouldn't have shown you.

A new message comes in.

Ground Zero: I'm happy you shared this with me. Are you okay? That's not easy to look at.

Once again, a response that doesn't sound like Ground Zero at all. Maybe he's just paranoid, maybe he's just on edge.

Viridant: I'm fine, I just don't know what to do. Honestly, I'm kind of scared.

Before Ground Zero can respond, Midoriya shoots off another message.

Viridant: Especially since I'm going back.

Several messages are sent immediately.

Ground Zero: DO NOT DO THAT.

Ground Zero: DO NOT GO BACK.

Ground Zero: THIS IS NOT THE RIGHT CALL. YOU NEED TO CALL THE POLICE.

Viridant: They'll wipe out that city. If I get anyone high up involved, I'm dooming all these people.

Ground Zero: They're aiding in MURDER. DO NOT GO BACK.

Midoriya clenches his jaw, brows furrowed.

Viridant: I can see that you don't understand. I won't bug you with this anymore. I'm sorry I dragged you into it.

INCOMING CALL.

He groans, rests his head on the bathroom stall door. The bell rings for the next period, and he debates not answering and blocking the number. He's got too much to deal with now; he can't add this on top of it.

But a new message comes through.

Ground Zero: You're right, I'm sorry. I'm on your side. Let's make a plan to get you in and out safely.

What the hell is going on with him? It's like there's two different people texting Midoriya at once. It's giving him whiplash. He takes a deep breath before answering the call.

"I'm at school," he says right away, faking a deeper voice. "I can't talk right now."

"Too motherfucking bad," Ground Zero responds. "I just looked at nearly two dozen horrifically dismembered human corpses, we're talking whether or not you like it, Greenie."

Midoriya scoffs. "I'm not a child."

"Pretty sure you literally are, but sure, let's say you're a grown adult. The lacerations on the limbs you sent me, yeah, that wasn't done with a knife. Those people you saw had been literally *torn* apart," Ground Zero grits out, his frustration eminent. "I need to make sure your grown self is fucking *aware* of what, exactly, you saw. Something that you nearly died seeing —"

"I got stabbed for a totally different reason!" Midoriya cuts him off.

"That really makes me feel better about this stupid ass plan to go *back,"* Ground Zero says, "Care to share that story? Are you going back to that fun little stabby location?"

"Not anytime soon," Midoriya says.

He pulls the phone from his ear, taps more footage from the same day. He doesn't show him exiting the bloody tunnel, just in case it somehow connects to Ground Zero where this all takes place. The footage he sends over only briefly shows his fight with the teenage girl, cutting when she shapeshifts into him.

It picks back up with her unconscious, natural form, showing him stumbling from the alleyway, impaled by a knife. Then, as he finds a random garage, crawls inside, falling into a random man's bathroom. It cuts when he calls Ground Zero for help.

"That's the fight," Midoriya says as Ground Zero reviews the footage, "The girl has a shapeshifting Quirk. I had to cut half the video because she turned into *me.* Without my mask, my gear, she knew what I looked like. I think it's because she ingested my blood. Isn't that the coolest Quirk ever?"

A small pause, something that sounds like a whisper. "How the fuck is the 'coolest Quirk ever'? How does this connect to UA?"

Ugh, explaining this entire situation is draining.

“It just does. Trust me.”

“And you’re still going back?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“Ummm.” He takes a moment to think. “Sometime this week, maybe the next. I’ll have to see.”

Ground Zero says, “I’ll come with you,”

“Yeah, no,” Midoriya unlocks his stall door, exits to the main bathroom. “I work alone.”

“This is—“

“Serious stuff, I know. I can handle it.”

“You don’t—“

“Have any idea what I’m doing? I’ve got a pretty good plan in place—“

“Interrupt me again,” he says lowly, “I dare you,”

He sounds so similar to Bakugou, it really catches Midoriya off guard. For a moment, he has to remind himself that they’re two different people. Even then, his brain processes them as the same person. It’s really not helpful when he’s trying to focus.

“This is… why are you doing this?” Ground Zero asks. “Why risk your life? Why not call for backup?”

Midoriya stares at his reflection in the mirror. “I’m one of them.” Ground Zero stays silent. “Those freaks in that city? I’m one of them. Those are my people. If I sell them out, I betray myself. I hurt people who just want to feel safe again. They’re so terrified of this world that they’d rather hide underground, sheltered by murderers, than risk a moment above ground with abusers at every corner.” The green of his eye burns bright. “If I get others involved, there’s a chance I ruin this operation. There’s a chance that those people die, or that they get arrested, or that they get ran out of a place that’s supposed to keep them safe. I’d be no better than the worst of society who put them there if I drove them out.”

Ground Zero says slowly, “There’s no way to convince you not to do this, is there, Greenie?”

Midoriya laughs softly. “I’m scared shitless, but no, I’m not giving up on it. I can’t trust Heroes anymore. I have to make sure this is done right. Maybe it isn’t the legal way to do it, or the easy way, but it’s necessary."

“Tell me more about that.” Ground Zero’s voice sounds like he’s annoyed to say it. “You said you don’t trust Heroes, why?”

A kid opens the bathroom door and gives him a weird look for standing inside and talking on the phone. Midoriya gives him an awkward smile before shoving into the hall. He heads down a few steps before he replies.

“Look, I’m in the middle of school right now. I can’t exactly tell you my life’s morals.” He thumps down the steps to the first floor. “I’ve got—“

“What if I told you about me?” Ground Zero asks suddenly, voice a grumble. “Would you talk then if we swapped information?”

Midoriya hesitates. On one hand, he doesn’t want Ground Zero to know anything about him. On the other… he’s curious about this stranger who’s managed to get in contact with him. Especially is he was telling the truth about taping Eraser’s phone. It’s impressive. He’d make for a powerful ally.

Ito sends him a middle finger when Midoriya says he’s skipping the rest of the day.

“Fine,” Midoriya says into the phone, flashing his bus pass at the driver he located. “You’ll be coming with me, then.”

“Where the fuck are we going?”

“*I’m* going to the store, you’re staying on the phone with me.”

“I thought you had school?”

“I’ll skip.”

“Won’t your grades drop?”

Midoriya barks out a laugh. “No.”

“Confident, huh?”

He grins, a bit of arrogance leaning into his voice. “I’ve had a 4.0 since I first began school. Half of my classes are for seniors. I’m set to graduate two years early.”

A brief silence. “How the fuck did you manage that?”

“Doesn’t matter, what *does* matter is that skipping school makes zero difference to me.” The bus hums to life, the driver pulling away from the curb and leading him to town. “And you? It’s 1:30 on a Tuesday, you don’t have school?”

Ground Zero says, “I get to skip class under special circumstances.”

“Really? Like what?”

“Like talking to a pretty boy, Greenie,” he says smoothly.

Midoriya stares at the window. “Hmm.”

“That’s all I get? Really? That was smooth as fuck.”

“Was it?”

“People heard me fucking say that, jackass, and I get nothing for it?”

“What do you want? A sticker?”

“You—“ Ground Zero cuts himself off with a scoff. “You should be flattered. I’m a fucking gentleman.”

Midoriya can’t help the loud squawking laugh that rips from his throat. It’s obnoxious and loud for a crowded public bus, but he can’t help it. Ground Zero cusses him out, but it’s drowned in the tirade of laughter that tears out of him. His eyes water, his face red.

He has to put his face in his hands to stop laughing. Eventually, Ground Zero shuts up and waits for him to cut it off.

“Oh man,” Midoriya wipes his eyes. “I haven’t laughed in weeks.”

“That’s depressing as fuck."

“Yeah, well,” he coughs. “Maybe I should talk to you more often, then.”

Ground says, “Maybe you should.”

Midoriya sighs, stands from his seat, and exits the bus when it arrives at a station. “Come with me.”

Open silence hits him. “To… the severed limb tunnel?”

“Yeah.” Midoriya smiles. “I’ll keep you on call and connect you to my goggles. You’ll be able to back me up, see exactly what I see.”

He emerges in a town near his own. The street is littered with people going about their day. Midoriya heads to a fabric store. He needs to patch his suit up, add reinforcements.

“That’s… yeah. Let’s do that. Call me before you head out, warn me in advance, and I’ll help you navigate those tunnels,” Ground Zero says, voice steady and certain. “Since you won’t let me show up in person.”

“And have to save your ass?” Midoriya asks.

“The fuck did you just say to—“ he cuts himself off, starts again. “Phone call it is.”

“Look at you, managing your anger. They grow so fast.”

“I will fucking pummel you.”

“Yikes.”

“What are you doing now?” Ground Zero asks him.

Midoriya pokes his head into a store, checks that it’s mainly empty, then gets to work sorting through the many different fabrics. He needs something rough that can catch a sharp knife. Anything to slow its speed down as it makes contact with him will keep the resulting wound shallow. He tells Ground Zero that, who says he’s an absolute moron. Oh well.

When he finds the material he needs, he goes to check out. He pays cash, he always does, then heads back to the street with the bag in hand.

“You wanna hear something funny?” Midoriya says, giggling a bit. “I stole All Might’s wallet.”

“I’m beginning to think you're a kleptomaniac.”

“He had it coming,” Midoriya argues. “Anyway, I use his credit card all the time. I like to scan it at places that are far apart to make sure it can’t be traced back to my location. But still use it frequently enough that it alerts Eraser Head.”

“You *know* that he’s looking at the card statements?” Ground Zero asks. “Why use it?”

“It’s funny,” Midoriya says honestly, “and then I get to study him when he shows up to look for me.”

“Study?”

“Oh, you’ll love this.”

Midoriya explains it in detail. Sometimes he’ll scan All Might’s credit card and wait hidden nearby. Other times, he’ll scan it and go the opposite direction and bust some crime, but most days, he stays to watch Eraser Head swing in. He’s got to figure out how to work this damn scarf.

Hitoshi has been training him the best he can, but Midoriya is doing all he can to figure it out on his own. It’s not working very well, given he can only lift it a solid inch into the air before it goes stiff, but still. He explains how he plans to use it in the tunnels, how he’ll have a quick escape if he needs it.

And then they keep talking. He tells Ground Zero that his friend goes to UA, and that the two of them met following Bluer’s near-death. He explains how Hitoshi, whom he calls PM for privacy’s sake, was going to turn Midoriya in to the police before Midoriya had explained himself. He talks about the time PM ghosted him in the wake of finding out Midoriya was going to do vigilante work, and how they came back together eventually and now work together.

He doesn’t tell Ground Zero about the in between. About the pit inside him, aching to be filled with violence. About the handprints forever burned into his skin, a reminder of all he’s lost. About the middle school roof, how the peace of death is more appealing than the drag of life. He doesn’t tell Ground Zero that he feels like he’s already dead, like he’s a reanimated

corpse. Most days, Midoriya feels nothing at all; other days, he is angry, so fucking angry. And there's always an underlying current of sadness or despair.

He'd do anything to fill that pit. He's *going* to fill that pit. Or he'll die trying.

"Your turn," Midoriya says, swinging his bag back and forth as he walks down the street. "Tell me something good."

Ground Zero keeps quiet.

"We had a deal, didn't we?" Midoriya tempts him. "The more you tell me, the more you get in return."

"Fucking… I don't know." Ground Zero taps his fingers on a table. "I'm tall."

"Riveting," Midoriya responds, "I tell you about how I narrowly escaped a murder charge and you tell me you're tall."

"What the hell am I supposed to say? I don't fucking know!" he snaps. "Uhhhh… ummm… I like cooking. In the fucking best at it."

"Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why cooking? What about it do you like?"

Ground Zero thinks for a second before he responds. "It's always got a good ending. There are set steps that you follow, and they always bring the same result. There's no guesswork."

"You like to be sure of yourself," Midoriya concludes. "You like being in control, you like things going as planned. Mix that with your insistence to be involved, I'd say you're a bit of a control freak. You're upset when anyone challenges your perception of yourself or the world around you, and it comes off as angry, but in reality, you're just scared. It feels vulnerable when you don't understand something, so you always find a way to."

"Did you just fucking psycho analyze me?"

"I've been practicing!" Midoriya says cheerfully. "Did I do good? How accurate was I?"

"Fuck you."

"I was close, wasn't I?" Midoriya snickers, keeping his pace down the road. "Tell me more."

"Fuck no."

"I'll let you go next!"

"You'll give me something good?" Midoriya bites his lip but agrees. "Fine. Uhh… I… like.." he sounds like he's in physical pain. "Romance manga."

Midoriya's mouth goes wide. "WHAT!"

"Psycho analyze that." He sounds so smug.

Midoriya does. "You're a romantic. The way you struggled to admit that you enjoyed reading about that tells me you're either reading something inappropriate," Ground Zero chokes, "or your romantic life is in shambles. I'd guess the latter, which is why you flirt with me but never follow through."

"Follow through on what?"

"Asking me out," Midoriya says. "Now *that* was smooth."

Ground Zero clicks his tongue. "It was not."

"You struggle to admit anyone could ever be better than you because you're terrified that—"

"Moving on," Ground Zero says, cutting him off, "Your turn. Make it good."

Midoriya groans. He stops by a fruit stand and grabs some berries before sitting on a bench outside. He had planned to go to more stores today, but he's otherwise occupied with this little weirdo he's on call with. Though he is learning a whole lot about Ground Zero.

"I hate cooking," Midoriya fires back. "And I'm not one for romance novels."

"Okay, okay," Ground Zero thinks out loud. "Why do you hate cooking?"

"I'm awful at it. I almost caught my apartment on fire last time I tried it!" He pops a berry into his mouth. "Psycho analyze me!"

Ground Zero snickers. "Let's see… knowing you, you go into the kitchen with a plan and a recipe. But, somehow, it always goes wrong. Burnt or undercooked, never a healthy middle. And the idea that you can mess up something so simple drives you up the wall. Most people would learn to stay away from the stove, but you keep going back. I'd guess that you've messed up nearly everything you've ever made, but you keep attempting it and hoping for a different result."

"And why?" Midoriya asks him, finding that he's pretty accurate. "Why do I keep going back?"

"To prove to yourself you can do what everyone else can," Ground Zero says, unaware of the way Midoriya's smile drops off his face. "You follow the same steps, the same recipe, and it never turns out right. When everyone else seems to grasp it, you can't, and you aren't sure why it bugs you so damn much. But it *kills* you, doesn't it? Never being equal, always too much or too little." Ground Zero's confidence can be heard through the phone. "How's that?"

Midoriya plays with the hem of his school uniform. "Pretty good, I guess. You missed the romance novel part."

“Did I?” Ground Zero asks him.

His stomach flips, and he scoffs before he ever confesses that. “You really think you’re so slick.”

“I know I am.”

“You…” Midoriya trails off, his eyes landing on something. “What… is *that?”*

“What?” Ground Zero asks.

Midoriya doesn’t respond. He stares at a hooded figure standing in an alleyway. Slowly, standing from the bench, he approaches. He can’t tell the person's age, or any features, only that they’re around his height and in dark clothes. They spray paint the side of a building, bubble letters covering several feet of brick.

“I… I have… I have to go to.”

“What—“

Midoriya hangs up. The graffiti is complete with one more swoop of the person's arm. For just a moment, Midoriya almost calls out to the person, but the words lodge in his throat. They turn, face barely exposed as they take him in. They run away a moment later, and Midoriya doesn’t have the gall to chase them.

He just watches their feet as they go. Red, Quirkless brand shoes are pounding down an alleyway. The figure disappears around a corner. All they had left behind were a few words sprayed into the side of a building.

ALL HEROES ARE VILLAINS.

Chapter End Notes

Poopy

Chapter 22: Joint exams!

Chapter Summary

Shinso POV <3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

PM: My exam starts soon, I'm trembling.

AM: You're going to walk them like dogs.

PM: Who the hell taught you that?!

AM: I have been using the social media apps you sent me! Very funny stuff :)

PM: You text like a divorced dad.

AM: Skibidi toilet!

PM: Go ahead and delete those apps.

AM: :(

Shinso huffs a breath of air out of his nose before pocketing his phone. He's not too sure what the hell Viridant is up to at the moment, but he knows it's nothing short of reckless. He's been a bit distant from the vigilante lately, too busy studying and training, but he plans to dive right back into one-on-one time soon. He just needs to pass this test first.

And part of training is, unfortunately, observing. Gen Ed is allowed to watch as Class 1-A practices and work through exercises from a comfy observation room. He's been watching teams of four work to beat the shit out of a different team of four for the last twenty minutes. He's up next, and he's so nervous that he's already thrown up twice this morning. As important as studying these students is, so that he can better understand how to take them out, he can't help but feel like there's got to be a better test for Heroes to take.

How is it fair that someone with a Quirk like his—or with no Quirk at all—takes tests that are designed to accommodate those who have higher-level Quirks? It fucking blows. He knows that, without a doubt, if Viridant were here, he'd be challenging the system that sets this whole operation up.

But Viridant isn't. So Shinso sits alone, staring at a massive screen.

The pairings are randomized, challenging how well students work together with peers they don't know. Shinso is on team C and E. As part of this Joint Training Battle, he had to pass a written exam that allowed him to participate in this practical entrance exam. He gets two shots to come out on top. Team E is him and four Class-B students; Team C is him and four Class-A students. He's fine to work with the few 1-A kids he's been assigned, and it'll be easy to take out the four Class-B.

But his 1-B group, that's a session he's going to enjoy. He's partnered up with Yosetsu Awase, Sen Kaibara, Tetsutetsu Tetsutetsu and Pony Tsunotor. And he's going up against Kyoka Jiro, Hanta Sero, Ashido Mina, and Bakugou Katsuki.

One of which he can't *stand.*

"Really? Again?" Kamanari's voice is annoyed, alerting Shinso to any conflict. "How many weekends are you going to blow us off, Bakugou?"

"Preferably all of them," is the rude response he gets.

Shinso narrows his eyes on this *Kacchan* he's been forced into close proximity with. He hates this guy's guts, unable to tear the wicked things Kacchan said to Viridant from his mind. How many times had Shinso been in a similar situation? How many days did he wish that someone would stand up for him, say something for him?

So, so many.

When he finally got the asshole's name, Shinso ran a *very* thorough background check. Viridant really had whooped the idiot's ass; otherwise, Shinso would've handled the situation. And by handled, he means he would've grabbed Kacchan's mind and made him walk into oncoming fucking traffic.

Okay, maybe not that brutal, but he's definitely thought about it.

"How are you feeling?" A deep, monotone voice asks him.

He gets a thrill every single time Eraser Head acknowledges him. His favorite Hero is his mentor; he can't let him down. The idea of failing and staying in Gen Ed is terrifying, partially because he doesn't want to disappoint Eraser. This test usually comes as an opportunity near the end of the semester, but it's been moved to mid-September instead. Results are decided within two weeks, and in October, Class 1-A and 1-B go to a training camp that hammers Quirk training into them around Halloween.

He needs to be in those classes. He's one of six kids who made it to this exam, most of whom have failed their first chance at it. He's been training his ass off, has spent weeks practicing one-on-one with both Eraser Head and Viridant. He's stolen footage from previous students' test runs, analyzed them, and taken thorough notes. He's utilized his chronic insomnia to his advantage, sneaking out at night to go on runs with his friend and put his capturing skills to good use.

He's going to do this. He's going to fucking win this.

“I’m fine,” he says. Cool, collected.

“You know,” Eraser Head mumbles, “The nerves—the fear, that’s a good response. It means this matters to you. It means you’ll respond quickly.”

Shinso nods. “Thanks.”

“And for the record,” Eraser says, his voice hard. “If it were my choice, you’d have made it into my class from just the first entrance exam.”

Shinso wants to believe him, he really does. But he’s hacked the system report. He’s seen the point deviation for the entrance exam. He’s seen that he had scored low, but still landed Gen Ed.

And he had seen the score of a Quirkless kid. A kid who beat Shinso’s points, beat a few kids in Class 1-B’s points. And they still turned him away. He’s scrubbed Viridant’s real name from his mind, remembering only a few of the letters and nothing more.

And then, without a second thought, he plucked the vigilante's name from the system. He deleted Viridant’s application to UA, deleted his name from the system, deleted his points, and rejection notice. He cleaned up any trail that Viridant had shown up at all. He’s never told his friend the truth, but he couldn’t stand the idea of what he would’ve done if he knew that the reason he was rejected from UA wasn’t because he didn’t try hard enough.

But because he was Quirkless.

There is no amount of admiration for Eraser Head that will bury the sickly feeling in Shinso’s gut every time he looks at the Pro. He knows it’s a council, it's a unanimous voting system for who passes and who doesn’t, he knows this doesn’t all just fall on Eraser Head.

But that awful twist in his stomach never seems to go away. Viridant should’ve been here, he should’ve succeeded. They took in *Katsuki Bakugou* before they took in Viridant. They took in cowards who dropped the course the second a real villain attack happened. They took in *him*. Shinso loves this school, he loves his courses, he’s beginning to love his Quirk for the first time ever. And it still isn’t enough.

What would Viridant do if he knew the truth? If he knew that he’d been turned away for the very rule that was promised to be removed? Shinso loves him, truly, but he can’t imagine where his friend would be right now.

“You got this, kiddo.” Eraser Head says, snapping Hitoshi out of his daze. “You’re going to do just fine.”

And he does. His match with 1-A goes off without a hitch. The team leader, Kaminari Denki, who Shinso tries not to stare at for too long, was very good at divvying up the rest of the team's talents. Also on the team was Ochako Uraka and Fukimage Tokoyami. All the teams had been difficult to determine, as the 1-A students missing weighed heavily. But the match went off well. They won.

Now he just needs to win one more.

“Since my Quirk can be resistant against Bakugou,” Tetsutetsu says, hardening his arm into metal. “I was thinking I should focus primarily on him.”

And Shinso, finally, for the first time in his life, stands up for something he believes in.

“No.” The three 1-B students turn to him. Yosetsu gives him a curious look, Pony nibbling her lip. “Leave him to me.”

Tetsutetsu doesn’t seem to agree. “His Quirk, no offense, could blast you away in seconds.”

Shinso can’t help the small grin on his face. “He’s mine, trust me.”

The three seem a bit wary but eventually agree. The general consensus is that keeping Bakugou as separated from his team as possible is the best way to win. They throw around words like ‘natural-leader’ or ‘authoritative’ to describe him. Shinso prefers ‘stupid fucking abrasive idiot.’ There’s mention of leading him around blindly, but Shinso knows how guys like Bakugou work. They’re used to being confrontational and loud, used to chasing others around.

They never expect to be taken head-on.

I can help you beat him, Viridant had said on a rooftop one night. They both had sat on the ledge, talking about life and useless things. *I know exactly how he functions, how he fights. I think you can take him on your own, but if you really want to claim a victory, I think I’ve got a good way.*

You don’t know that I’m even against him, Shinso had argued, peering down at the people passing hundreds of feet below.

Just in case, Viridant had said, his eyes glowing green. *It pays to plan ahead. You’re going to want every advantage you can get.*

Shinso had agreed, and Viridant had pulled out five small, blue-spined notebooks from his bag. Shinso had thought they contained notes about thousands of Heroes. They were stuffed full of notes and annotation markers. Highlighter and pen and colored pencil. But then he saw the covers, Sharpie labeling the contents of all five notebooks.

Kacchan.

Ten years of data, of sketches, of fight styles, and documentation. All of itwas written in those notebooks, all noted down and preserved for reasons that Shinso didn’t want to ask.

And now, every single detail sits in his head. Waiting, prowling, eager.

When the exam starts, his group spreads out to locate different students to capture. Shinso doesn’t. He stands in place, and he listens.

BOOM!

And he's off, sprinting straight towards the sound, tuning his mask as he goes. His capture tape is warm in his hands, just as eager as he is.

He gets stronger the more pissed off he gets, Viridant had said. *If you really want to beat him, you need to find a way to change the anger, turn it in a different direction.*

Shinso had thought long and hard about what he was going to do. As he climbs pipes, uses his capture weapon to swing into buildings and gaps, his plan solidifies.

His palms secret nitroglycerin, one spark, and he blows. Viridant had dragged his finger along his notes, pointed to the chemical equations he curated that explained the process of Bakugou's Qurik. *The exam is being held in the fall. You won't have the weather on your side, but you'll have the knowledge that the more worked up he gets, the more he sweats.*

And the more explosions he lets off, the less he can handle.

It hurts him to use his Quirk too much. Those arm guards on his costume? They keep him from releasing too big of blasts, sparing him additional pain or hand cramps. Viridant showed him a sketch he had made of Bakugou's Hero costume. *Steal one of those hand supports, and you've got yourself a bomb.*

Everyone on Bakugou's team has a means of quick transportation. Except one.

BOOM!

But no explosions are in the air. Because Bakugou isn't making that sound, Kyoka Jiro is. Trying to lure Tetsutetsu out, she's unaware she's got someone else. One of Bakugou's grenade arms is braced onto her own, and she fakes its booming sound as she runs around a lower level. She's got a means of a quick escape with it, but not quick enough.

Shinso adjusts his mask. "Hey, Earphones, change of plan! Can your stupid Quirk take on the horned extra instead?"

She turns, answering before she ever sees him. "Yes, but that's not the plan—"

Her eyes glaze over, her muscles lock. She stands perfectly still, unable to snap out of her mental state of being. This Quirk has ruined any of Shinso's chances at friendships. Except for one. So he feels no guilt when he wraps the purple-haired girl in tape and steals Kacchan's canon. Especially not when he thinks of Kaminari, of how he can never seem to take his eyes off her.

"What's the plan?" he asks her.

And she tells him.

***

Bakugou pushes through a building filled with tubes and tunnels. He keeps low to the ground, quieter than he's ever been. He prefers a faster approach, but he doesn't know enough about the Gen Ed students Quirk to rush into a battle right off the bat. As annoying as it was to draw that conclusion, it was necessary.

He knows it works through conversation, but the point of the exercise was to be ill-prepared for a battle, so he knows hardly anything else. Which is fucking fantastic, really. His phone has been buzzing with messages from Viridant, and Eraser Head had sworn up and down that he would make sure the idiot didn't rush into the tunnels without Bakugou there to help him. But it makes him antsy, his palms slick with sweat.

They've been preparing for when Viridant goes back. Pro's have been stationed throughout Koto to Tokyo, spreading out in the city's grid system to aid if Viridant calls. Police and first responders have been alerted and put into standby, waiting for the moment the vigilante decides to explore. All Bakugou has to do is talk to him on the phone and project the moron's live camera onto a screen in which several people will be watching.

Aizawa-sensei, Present Mic, All Might, Nezu, Mightnight, Snipe, Vlad King, Cementos, and, obviously, Bakugou himself. This is Viridant's ticket into UA, the determination that he can again be forgiven for his crimes and taken in. Footage of a school break-in and a record beaten has proven his worth, a conversation with his conspirator has proven his youth, and his desire to save the world has proven his Heroism.

As far as Aizawa is concerned, Viridant *will* be attending UA. Once he catches him, once this operation ends, Sensei is certain that Viridant will be a student in his class. He plans on providing the vigilante resources, too. Plans to force all 1-A students into weekly counseling as part of 'de-escalation and emotion training' for diffusion tactics. The reality is, if all students are attending, then Viridant won't feel singled out and get the mental support the idiot clearly needs.

Bakugou watched the camera footage, listened to the conversations, and followed his own instructions to a perfect accuracy. Contact Viridant daily, multiple times a day, if he can. Befriend him, get him to trust him. Do it by any means, and most importantly, secure his safety by any possible methods.

And so he has.

He'll be in Tokyo this weekend and the next, leaving class early on Friday to fly into the city. The video call will take place there, where he can be easily accessible if Viridant again needs him. He'll push for in-person contact, claiming he came to the city to back him up since he knows Viridant sent his location from a neighborhood relatively close by.

It's likely going to take place late at night, so the school has sweetened the deal for Bakugou. If he successfully aids in the capture of Viridant, it counts as credit towards the final exam at the end of the year. It's their way to ensure he stays loyal, to ensure he doesn't become too friendly with the Vigilante. In and out, a simple mission, nothing more.

And then, starting next Monday, 1-A begins counseling. Fucking riveting.

He hops over a large pipe, unbalanced without his grenade arm. It's a welcomed weight, and the loss of it is fucking aggravating. But Earphones should be—

"Kacchan?"

He whirls around, his heart in his damn throat.

"Kacchan? Are you here?"

Deku?

"Kacchan, where are you? I can't see."

He opens his mouth, shuts it. His stomach hurts, his gut screaming at him to move, to think. How is Deku here? *Why* is Deku here?

Why is he calling him Kacchan again?

"You wanna know a secret, Kacchan?" Deku whispers from his left.

Bakugou whips around, meets darkness and shadows.

"I'm Quirkless," Deku says, and Bakugou's vision flickers, stars appearing in the darkness. He counts them, he loses track. "You can't tell anyone. But it'll be okay, we can still be Heroes."

"Where are you?" Bakugou grounds out, spinning around again. How is this possible? How is Deku *here?*

"Promise me you won't tell anyone." Stars whirl in the darkness, his vision smoky and dim. "Pinky promise."

The building he's in has no electricity, no speakers. There's no way to trick him, is there? Is this that mind control freakshow? Is he already in Bakugou's head?

"Kacchan," Deku whispers, and Bakugou turns to his right. Nobody is there. "Are you scared of the dark?"

His heart slams against his ribcage, but he doesn't answer.

"I know you are," Deku continues. "I know you're scared of the dark, of being alone in it. You told me that secret, do you remember?"

Bakugou whirls again. He sees nothing through the pipes and shadows. His palms sweat, his head spins.

"You told me your secret, and I told you mine," Deku whispers. "We promised never to share. Why did you break it?"

He steps backwards, lightheaded, dizzy.

“I see you, Kacchan.”

“Where the fuck are you?” Bakugou shouts, his voice echoing. Silence caresses him, shadow lurks around him. “Show yourself, coward!”

He doesn’t. Nothing stirs in the darkness, but there’s a presence here, he can fucking taste it. It can’t be Deku, it can’t be—

But no one else knows that secret. No one else knows that Bakugou can’t stand the darkness, the quiet. No one else knows he still sleeps with a nightlight, with the fear that something waits for him beyond the light. He only told Deku, and Deku *promised.*

He must—he must be losing it. Mind control can’t do this, can it? *Is* he even mind-controlled?

His throat is dry, his eyes red. It’s so dark, smoke filling his lungs.

“Do you regret it, Kacchan?”

Bakugou nearly takes off. He doesn’t run from fights; he doesn’t run from anything. He’s confrontational and loud and aggressive—he doesn’t *run,* he chases. He’s Bakugou fucking Katsuki, for fucks sake, he—

“Do you know what it was like?” Deku asks him, his small voice shaking. “Every day, you put me through hell, every day, you never let me have a moment of peace.”

“You’re not real,” Bakugou mutters, retreating like a fucking coward.

A hand touches his shoulder. He whirls around to it, but only a dark corridor stares back at him. He swears he sees movement within it, but one explosion later, he discovers it’s empty.

“I think,” Deku says, somewhere from behind him. “That I would’ve loved to be a Hero with you.

“Get out of my fucking head,” Bakugou growls, firing off concentrated shots to light up the pipe-filled building. No one and nothing is revealed; the darkness persists.

“We were going to have our own agency. Do you remember the day by the lake? The day you fell in?” Deku whispers, and Bakugou swears to god can smell him.

Cheap soap, 2-in-1 shampoo and conditioner, and somehow, his skin, always the smell of something sweet. It’s always been that way. He doesn’t know why. He doesn’t let himself think about why. But it occurs to him then, that Deku smells like caramel, like burnt sugar, like the smell of Bakugou’s hands. How often he’d touch him, shove him against walls, throw him down—it mixes with the gentle scent of Deku’s soap, intoxicating and warm.

He rubs his eyes, shakes away a forming headache. His arms feel heavy, his eyes doubling his vision. His breaths come fast, infrequent. He’s used to panic attacks, but never ones that

come so slowly, so hauntingly. Bakugou coughs wildly, grips a pipe to stay upright.

There's nothing to attack, nothing to fight. Just a phantom voice, just a lingering pit in his stomach.

"Why didn't you take my hand?" Deku asks him.

And Bakugou answers, his voice rough. "I was afraid!"

And his… m i n d

g o

e

s

Blank.

***

"Welcome to Class 1-A," is Eraser's form of congratulations. The proud look in his eyes is unmistakable. "You've earned it."

The cameras have no audio in the training ground, but wary glances are still thrown his way for the performance that they just witnessed. He had wanted a bit more fight from *Kacchan*, had been eager to bash his teeth in. But fear works in ways nothing else can.

Shinso watches as a few medical bots carry Bakugou away on a stretcher, his limbs dangling limply. Smoke inhalation. He'd set his grenade up, altered it with a little rewiring, and smoked out the inside of the building. All he had to do was bide his time, using the Kyoka Jiro to project his voice into the building. It was easy. Paranoia did most of the work for him, the smoke slowly driving Bakugou insane.

And once his mind was caught, Shinso had almost let him just stand there until he passed out.

He wishes that's what he did.

Instead, he entered the building, poked at Bakugou's chest to ensure he was completely under Shinso's control. And he asked him a question, just one simple question, hoping to bring Viridant some peace of mind.

"Why did you pick on him?"

Bakugou's answer was slow, as if being pulled from the drudges of his mind. Still, it shook Shinso to his core. He was quick to tie him up, to let the smoke knock him out, then to drag him and his teammate behind him, claiming a victory. He made it to 1-A, he's in the Hero course, he's going to become something.

But he keeps thinking of that answer, of that confession. He buries it deep inside his head, keeps it secret, hidden. He will never tell another soul, and Bakugou will never remember sharing it.

So when Eraser gives him an approving nod, and Present Mic shakes his head, and his new classmates welcome him to 1-A, Shinso doesn't feel victorious. He feels like, more than ever, he has completely failed.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Chapter 23: Wipe out

Chapter Summary

Viridant and Ground Zero go exploring!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya's new suit is a masterpiece. Its old clothing fabric has been replaced with high-grade, green Kevlar. Its synthetic fibers are often used in bulletproof vests, but Midoriya couldn't easily wear one of those and keep his needed mobility. So, a thick layer of it will do the best it can. Knives can rarely get through the texture, bullets will be slowed enough to, hopefully, not shatter if he maintains that kind of injury, and, even better, the fabric is flame-resistant.

It's honestly perfect. He dropped a few grand purchasing this from an extremely sketchy market he found online. The actual guy behind it was just a normal man who handed Midoriya a grocery bag full of the material in exchange for the cash without a single word between them. He spent a few days taking chalk to it and slowly cutting the fabric up to his measurements. His bunny rabbit-looking headgear got a nice layer, too, and all extras were set aside for Hitoshi to gush over.

He's been weirdly busy, even after acing his Hero exam. Their calls have been short, brief, and his friend has been unable to say much at all before claiming he had something else to do. Midoriya doesn't let himself dwell on it, he doesn't let himself think of the worst possible scenario. Even though a horrible truth lingers at the back of his mind, he buries it under work, under school, and ignores the awful thoughts that rage in.

But when he tries to fall asleep at night, it whispers to him, it lingers in his mind. Hitoshi made the Hero course. He's surrounded by peers with wonderful, amazing Quirks. He'll be seated right beside friendly Kamanari Denki. His future is set in stone, he beat the odds, and he's going to become a Hero.

He doesn't need Midoriya anymore.

Viridant: I'm going out tonight. You want to come?

The bubbles appear, disappear. Hitoshi doesn't respond.

Viridant: Finished my new suit, you'll love it.

Nothing.

Viridant: How is it having Eraser Head as a teacher? I know you're going crazy.

Silence.

That's fine. Midoriya learned to like the quiet. He's learned how to find distractions, how to stay moving when everyone else seems to be standing still.

He's going back to those tunnels.

He leaves on Friday, right after school. To stay inconspicuous, he packs his bag with his vigilante gear, opting to dress normally on the way there. It gives him access to a bullet train, cutting his travel time in half since the first visit. It's dark when he exits the train car and slowly walks up the steps.

He checks his phone for messages from Hitoshi when he gets there. Nothing. So he pretends it's okay, focuses his mind somewhere else. He changes into his costume in a back alley, knocks on the front door, greets the woman at the door, and enters the house without so much as a second thought.

He dives into the terror of what he's going to face and not the fear of what he's already lost. Today, he is going to find the leader of the League of Villains. He is going to solve the UA attack mystery, see what needs to be done about this group underground. He's going to do what others can't, just as he always has.

"New message," a robotic voice reads to him from the headset inside his helmet. "From: Ground Zero. Should I read it?"

"Read it," he says, voice heavy.

"Ground Zero says: What are you up to, Greenie? Anything fun?" the robot says. "What would you like to respond?"

Midoirya takes a deep breath in, blows it out. "Call Ground Zero, connect the call to my goggles."

The AI works flawlessly. He programmed it all on his own, no Hitoshi to help him.

Ringing sounds in his ears before the call immediately connect. Midoriya activates the night vision, allowing Ground Zero to see clearly. He had brought a flashlight this time around, but the darkness had comforted him more than he liked to admit.

"What the fuck! You're already inside?" Ground Zero snaps, "You said you'd call me."

"I did," Midoriya responds grimly. "Welcome to the call."

Ground Zero sighs. "You sound… sad." Midoriya doesn't respond to that; he keeps walking. "What's your damn problem, Greenie? Hit me."

Midoriya nibbles his lip. He's felt better after ranting to Ground Zero before. There's a chance it works again, but he's not sure he has it in him to explain the full story. He doesn't

want to think about it, doesn't want to make it real by admitting it. So he changes the subject, tries to sound chipper.

"Let me show you my map." He stops to take his bag off, pulls his notebook from his bag, and opens it to the last page. "Can you see it in the dark?"

"How the fuck could I possibly see that?"

Midoriya almost smiles. Almost. He digs in the large pocket for his flashlight before shining it down on the page. He turns his night vision off since it works best with no surrounding light. And then they're sitting in the dark with only a small light illuminating the paper.

He drags his finger over the sketched-out tunnels. "There are at least four that I could see when inside the housing complex. One had those severed limbs, and the other three are a mystery." He flips a page back, shows a detailed entry that covers the full diagnostic of the town. "I made sure to write down all discoveries to ensure I could see if anything changed."

"Jesus Christ," Ground Zero says, "How do you have so much free time?"

Midoriya shrugs his bag back on. "I don't really sleep."

"The fuck?"

"I just don't." He shrugs. "Maybe a handful of hours, but I can never stay down longer than three before I wake up and have to hope I can get back to sleep. That's one of the reasons I slept so long after I got stabbed."

He keeps walking as Ground Zero talks. "Do you have insomnia?"

"No, I just get nervous. My brain keeps thinking and thinking and thinking, and then I get nightmares based on whatever I last thought about before I calmed down enough to sleep," he confesses. "I like to think I'm testing those theories about cognitive decline from lack of sleep. I'm doing great!" He trips over a rock, stumbles, and Ground Zero belts out a laugh. "Shut up."

"Yeah, you're doing fucking wonderfully." Ground Zero clears his throat, then says, "Can I ask you something?"

Midoriya keeps up his pace, closing in on the lid to the underground. He'd walked most of the way there before Ground Zero reached out, so there's barely five minutes of walking left, if he timed it right.

"Would you ever consider being a student at UA?"

Midoriya scoffs out a laugh. "What? Where did that come from?"

"You said your friend goes here—uhh—there. He goes there, right?" Ground Zero says. "Would you ever consider it?"

Midoriya answers honestly. "I tried out, but I didn't get in."

“Would you try again?”

“Why? To fail a second time?”

Ground Zero hums, “Just curious.”

Midoriya finds the latter. He stares at it for a while while he thinks.

Would he go to UA if he could?

It’s all he’s ever dreamed of, all he’s ever wanted. It’s a wish he’s made a thousand times over. It was devastating to miss out on it, he felt that more than anything when he was there with Hitoshi. It’s a good resource; it could get him closer than ever to Pro’s and set him on a direct path to All For One.

So, he says, “Yeah.” Ground Zero is quiet. “If I could go to UA, I would. But I can’t. So there’s no point thinking about it.”

“Anyone of any age can take the entrance exam, you know. You could always try again—with how advanced you are, you’d probably pick up with the first years… if you’re fifteen.” A small pause. “Are you… fifteen?”

Midoriya snorts. “Yes.”

“See? You should try again.” Midoriya grabs a ladder prong, climbs up. “Heroes aren’t all that bad.” He pushes the lid off the manhole cover. “You’d love it.”

Midoriya pokes his head out of the hole and only remembers, as he emerges from the ground, that there was music playing last time. He looks around, and his heart drops to his feet.

Blood. *Everywhere.* The floor, the sides of buildings, spattered across windows and doors. No signs of life, of anyone. There are no bodies, but the sheer amount of gore hints that no survival came out of the massacre. Women, men, children, *people.*

Words are written in blood across the pair of white eyes near the ceiling. Three words that have followed Midoriya for his entire life. Three words that have defined his very existence. Three words that have splintered him open time and time again.

I AM HERE.

“What…” Ground Zero trails off.

Midoriya can only stare at those words, the heavy scent of iron, of blood, making his throat dry. There’s nothing to say, nothing to do. They can only look at once was. The fairy lights are still intact, food is still sitting neatly in booths to be handed out.

This was a total wipeout. Nobody must’ve seen it coming.

“Viridant?” Ground Zero asks. “Are you okay?”

Viridant feels a rage unlike anything he's ever felt before. It burns like a flame, his heart doused in gasoline.

"Hey, talk to me—"

"And say what?" Viridant snips, holds his arms wide, gestures to the underground city. "Look what they did. Look what the Heroes did."

"You don't know—"

"Oh, wake up!" Viridant shouts, points at the words in the wall. "Wake the fuck up! Bluer was a *rapist,* All Might is a fucking sham, PM used me to get into the Hero course, who's next? Name a Hero, I'll tell you the crimes they've committed. Here's one, *discrimination."* He looks at the floor, covered completely in red. "There's nothing left. A society built to protect—wiped out. You don't get to tell me that wasn't intentional. You don't get to tell me I don't know who did this."

"All Might would *never—"*

"It wasn't All Might," Viridant grits out, turning to the shrine. Photos lay knocked over and shattered. He picks them up, flips them over. "All Might couldn't finish the fucking job. That's why this happened."

"What job?"

Viridant rages, "All For One." He spins in a circle. "He did this."

"That's… how do you…"

"He doesn't leave bodies."

"How do you know about All For One?" Ground Zero asks.

Viridant flips over the photos of the two UA students. "I never should've gotten you involved in this."

"What—" he ends the call. When Ground Zero calls back, Viridant doesn't reply.

He's not sure what takes over his body. Maybe the ghosts of all those who died. But he moves without thinking, grabs the strewn lights and yanks them free, throws them around. He kicks over wooden booths, screams as he smashes windows. He leaves nothing untouched. He flips students' desks, rips apart bloody bed sheets. Everything comes crumbling down on him; the weight of the world pushes him down.

That small girl comes to his mind. Her orange eyes, her flaming hair. Did she know this was coming? How could she have possibly fought back? She was supposed to be safe here. How did it go wrong so quickly? Is this here blood that he stands on, cold and still wet, seeping into his shoes, his pants, his clothes, and skin.

He falls to his knees in the dirt, feels the last bit of his mind slipping away. Ground Zero calls again and again, Viridant won't answer.

All For One did this. He knows he did. Dad never leaves bodies behind. He couldn't have known that Viridant would be the one to stumble across the scene, but his message still slams into Viridant's ribs, making his heart ache. These deaths served as a reminder to whoever had begun to dig into this small slice of heaven that there is no such thing as a world that isn't run by those with power. Heroes, villains, what difference does it make?

He will always be at the bottom of it all.

"New message," the robotic voice clicks on. "From: Ground Zero. Should I read it?"

"No," he croaks.

"Ground Zero says:"

"I said no."

"I have your back, Greenie. I'm with you on this. Talk to me, please—Would you like to respond?"

Viridant curls into a ball on the floor. Blood soaks through his clothes.

"New message, from: Ground Zero. Should I read it?"

His chest cracks open, sobs tearing from his throat. Panic seizes him, makes his breath come fast and uneven, his heart racing.

"Ground Zero says: You aren't alone. I'm with you. Me and you, okay? I've got your back, I want to be part of this—Would like to respond?"

"Call Hitoshi," he says softly, "Please."

"Calling Hitoshi."

It rings, and rings, and rings.

"Call declined."

Chapter End Notes

Rawr XD

Chapter 24: Destruction

Chapter Summary

Viridant and Ground Zero continue to explore

Chapter Notes

Sorry, this one is kind of long lol

When he wakes up hours later, he's shivering cold. He sits up, suit sticky and red. Panic attacks knock him out every time, and that one was… the worst one he's ever had.

He sniffles, blinks his eyes blearily, and checks his phone. Nothing from Hitoshi, dozens of messages from Ground Zero, a few from Eraser Head, too.

Viridant gets up, shakes the blood off himself. He picks a tunnel, starts walking. He needs to get to whoever runs this place, needs too—

"Incoming call from: Mama," the robot voice says. "Would you like to answer?"

Mama.

Midoriya curses. "Yes."

"Izuku?" Mama's worried voice comes over the line. "Oh, baby, why didn't you tell me you went out? Are you with your buddy?"

He turns his voice modulator off, keeps walking. "Yeah. Sorry, Mama, I forgot to tell you."

"Don't even worry about it, baby," she says softly. "I made some soba tonight, it'll be in the fridge when you come home, alright?"

When he… goes home. To Mama. He almost… he almost forgot about that.

"Thank you, Mama."

"Of course. I won't bug you anymore. Go have fun, and stay safe!"

"I will, I love you."

“I love you so much more, baby.”

The call ends.

He lets out a long, pained sigh. He didn’t mean to get so angry. He’s usually better about stuff like that. It just… it was all just too much. He had almost forgotten what he was doing all this for, what his purpose was.

“Rin,” he says, activating the AI. “Call Ground Zero, connect him to my goggles.”

He picks up on the first ring. “You’re fucking dead, do you understand me? Dead! D-E-A-D. Three hours of fucking silence? Are you kidding me?”

Midoriya yawns. “I was sleepy.”

A disbelieving laugh. “Oh, did you get some fucking shut eye? What the hell is wrong with you?”

“Do you want a list?”

“I swear to god—“

“You didn’t stop texting me,” Midoriya interrupts, his voice soft. “You kept reaching out.”

Ground Zero hesitates before he responds. “Of course I did, why wouldn’t I?”

Midoriya pauses in the tunnel he chose, waits for a moment to gather the courage, then blurts it out. If he’s going to be working with Ground Zero from now on, then he’s going to be honest with him. He won’t stand for another friendship where he’s taken advantage of and left the second the friend achieves their goals.

So, he says, “I’m Quirkless.”

Absolute silence greets him.

Viridant kicks off the metal covers of his shoes, revealing the plain red fabric. “Always have been, always will be.”

Nothing. He steps back into the prosthetics.

“Truth is, I’ve been told my entire life I would never amount to a single thing.” He heads further down the tunnel. “And then I stumble across Bluer, trying to hurt someone, and for the first time, I had fooled myself into thinking I could be a Hero.”

Quiet.

“And I just… I don’t know. I just thought I should tell you. In case you want to leave me too. You should know the full truth, and that’s it. I’m sorry I kept it—“

“It’s okay,” Ground Zero says quietly. “It’s alright.”

Midoriya lets out a sad little laugh. “Am I still so admirable, Ground Zero? Nothing about me is special. I’m just… I’m just some kid. I’m just some kid who… who wants to be something more, I guess.”

Ground Zero says, in a voice that sounds just like Bakugou, “You *are* special. You are something. Okay? Stop kicking yourself down, you’ve made it this far, haven’t you?”

Midoriya sniffles. “Yeah, I guess I have.”

“Well, there you go,” Ground Zero sighs. “Tell me why I can’t find you in UA’s system.”

“What?”

“I looked through the system, you aren’t there. No Quirkless tried out for the entrance exam; all traces of them have been wiped out.

Midoriya lets out a small laugh. “Oh, PM, he always saves my ass.”

“He wiped the data?”

“Probably wiped me from everything before he left. All the Qurikless who tried out probably got wiped too. Here, can you get into a Quirk database?” Midoriya asks.

“Yes.”

“And if you type in my description, I don’t pop up, do I?”

“Nope.”

“I’d ask you to type my name in and see what Quirk PM put in for me, but that would be a bit too honest, huh?”

“I don’t think so at all.”

Midoriya chuckles. “I’m sure you don’t.”

Ground Zero exhales loudly. “Still keeping me in the dark?”

Midoriya swallows thickly. “Not forever, just for a bit.”

“Why’s that?”

He comes across another ladder. “Can’t let you get too attached, now, can I? Who knows what’s going to be up here?”

“That’s not funny.”

“Really? I thought it was.”

He shoves the manhole cover. The dark of a room leaks in, and Midoriya shoves from the hole in the ground. He kicks the cover back into place, looks around at where he ended up.

What… is this place?

“So what happened with PM?”

Midoriya looks around the room, taking everything in. “He had a joint exam to get a higher placement. I trained him for weeks, and he got in. So he left me behind, I guess.”

Ground Zero keeps quiet as Midoriya walks around. It’s a small room filled with what looks like chemistry supplies. A desk strewn with papers sits in a corner, a lone lamp illuminating it. Midoriya approaches, picks up a file from the desk, and flips it open. A photo of the frog man from his first day is in there, notes about some sort of transformation listed right below it. Midoriya doesn’t understand what it means until he spots another door exiting this room. It's heavy, thick metal.

He pushes it open and stands perfectly still in the doorway at the sight before him.

Tubes, dozens of them, with these humanoid monsters inside them. Green liquid fills the glass, keeping these creatures suspended in their cases. Giant wires and water flow pipes scatter across the floor. Another desk sits against the back wall, a few screens above it, but nothing that’s turned on. His skin crawls, the hair on the back of his neck standing straight up.

Midoriya enters slowly, cautiously, peering around the narrow space and staring at each floating corpse imprisoned in the glass tubes. He stops at one in particular, stares at its bulbous, familiar throat.

“That’s the man in the file,” Midoriya whispers, “He’s the guy I talked to the first time I came here.”

“This is fucking weird,” Ground Zero responds. “Why make a safe haven just to slaughter and encase everyone inside?”

The blood drains from his face. “Because nobody would come looking for them.”

“Fucking Christ.”

“It’s a human slaughterhouse. They’re farming lesser-Quirked people.” Midoriya lays a hand on the glass tank. “Building these monsters… doesn’t it look a little like…”

“The Nomu who attacked UA?”

Midoriya pauses. “Nomu. How did you hear that word?”

“What?”

“Nomu. You said Nomu, why?”

Ground Zero thinks for a moment. “It’s just what everyone calls it. I don’t know, why?”

He pulls his bag off, tugs out the flier Chikara gave him months ago. He holds it, folded in his hands. “Are you sure you want to be part of this?”

“I’m all fucking in, Greenie.”

Midoriya carefully unfolds it, revealing the flier. “This is my lead.” He keeps it open, lets Ground Zero read through it. “The eyes—it’s the same as the villain who opened a teleportation gate at UA. After the attack, I reached out to the guy who gave me this, and he gave me the home address of the person who’s taking all of these rejects in. The tunnel I was walking in when we first called? It’s *under* her house.”

“What the fuck.”

“Right?” Midoriya folds it back up, careful not to reveal Chikara’s number. He stuffs it back in his bag, slings it onto his shoulders. “So this league spreads around this promise for safety to harvest the bodies.”

“What the fuck.”

“They probably weed out those with potential, recruit them to their club, then murder everyone else.”

“What the fuck.”

“The frog guy had said that the ‘villains’ who killed the UA students were ‘dealt with’, but I don’t think that’s true. I think that tunnel full of limbs was a whole different story.”

“What the fuck.”

“Focus!” Midoriya hisses, turning to the computer. “Let’s see what info I can get off this.”

“Uh, no, back track, you need to call a fucking Pro.”

“I will,” Midoriya says, “After I clear the rest of this place.”

After all, there's nothing he's protecting anymore. It's a horrible thought, but it settles deep within him, a truth he wishes he could push away. He wiggles the mouse of the computer, the monitors flaring to life. It's password-protected, of course.

“Well, dead end, call a Hero now.” Ground Zero says.

Midoriya snorts. “You’re funny.”

“I am actively not joking.”

It’s easy to pull out a thumb drive, another custom-coded project of his. He pushes it into the computer, humming as the screen flickers and changes. A bar appears, and the words ‘Downloading Data.’ Midoriya watches the bar slowly tick by until it flashes white, and he unplugs his drive and drops it into the pocket of his school bag.

He'll have to review that later. For now, he needs to get back to the main room. He steps over wires and tubes, humming as he goes.

"SYSTEM COMPROMISED."

Uh oh.

"ENABLING SELF-DESTRUCT PROGRAM IN 1 MINUTE."

"Oh shit," Midoriya mumbles.

He grabs the door handle, tugs, it doesn't open. The system must have some sort of virtual connection to an inner lock.

"What's happening?!" Ground Zero panics.

Midoriya flings his bag off again. "I'm locked in."

"WHAT?!"

"Okay, deep breaths," Midoriya says slowly, "It's alright."

"Don't you fucking patronize me!"

"I wasn't."

"*You* are trapped in a room that's about to explode!"

"Yep."

"How are you so calm?"

"I either make it out," Midoriya says flatly, yanking a metal tube from his bag. "Or I don't."

He squeezes the side of the tube, a red laser appearing at the other end. What? You didn't think he *only* stole a scarf from UA, did you? Midoriya carefully cuts a gap into the metal door. Hot, orange edges release an uneven circle he's cut. He pushes the inside of it, the iron clattering to the other side. He crawls through it.

A quick glance behind him reveals the timer at 20 seconds.

"Now I can panic," Midoriya says, laser cutter still in hand.

He takes off running. As fast as humanly possible, adrenaline rushing through his veins, he sprints down the hall. It lights him up, brings a smile to his face that he had been previously missing. He *loves* that feeling.

"What's the plan? Call the—"

"Not yet!" Midoriya shouts as he runs, pushing faster and faster. "Let me focus on one thing!"

“Then *run faster!”*

Midoriya lets out a whooping laugh, cheering as he goes. His heart hammers, sweat breaks on his skin, and it’s fucking exhilarating.

A large, earth-shaking explosion sounds far behind him. The pressure catches up a second later, and Midoriya is blasted the remaining way out of the tunnel. Good news—the fabric he switched to worked wonders! Bad news—he’s flying through the air.

Midoriya gasps, soaring through the bloody underground city, before slamming against the side of one of the building's windows. Glass shatters against his helmet, and his body careens inside the building and onto the floor. Heat fills the safe haven, but the explosion doesn’t go past that singular tunnel.

He groans from the floor, dizzy, and his shoulder is in so much pain it’s not even funny. Ground Zero is talking, saying something, but he can’t hear it over the incessant ringing in his ears. He blinks blearily, vision doubled and swirling.

“I think I hava c-concussion,” he murmurs, his own voice rattling around his head, “Auugh.”

Ground Zero is shouting but Midoriya can hardly hear it, too busy trying to see straight. He grunts, tries to get up but his arm is killing him. He falls back down, crunching in glass.

“Viridant!” Ground Zero’s voice echoes over and over again. “Viridant!”

“Mhm?” Midoriya shuts his eyes, “Yesh?”

“Oh my god, send me your fucking location!”

“Gonna taka nap.”

“No! No! No naps!” Ground Zero yells. Midoriya swears he hears more voices talking. “Get up! Up! Up!”

“Mmm em sleepy.”

“GET THE FUCK UP!” Ground Zero screams it, and it sounds so much like Kacchan that Midoriya’s eyes shoot open. “GET UP! WAKE UP!”

“Shhhh,” Midoriya grunts, rolling over to his chest.

His head throbs, his left shoulder in such agonizing pain that it’s a wonder his adrenaline hadn’t caused his body to go numb or shake. He’s not in shock, which is a bummer, because *ow.* Midoriya shoves his good hand on the floor, pushes off the ground. He stumbles forward, falls down again, shoves himself back up.

He eventually makes it to a bathroom that’s in the apartment he landed in. The blaring light is headache-inducing, but he’s more focused on the view than he is on turning the light off.

“Oh my god, I’m gonna vomit,” Ground Zero announces.

Midoriya stares at his double reflection. His left arm is significantly lower than his right. When he hit the window and shattered the glass, he must've slid on the floor and popped his arm out of his socket. Not ideal.

"I can't believe it," he mumbles, turning his head, "One of my bunny ears fell off. I used super expensive glue."

"You can't be serious."

"Mmm." Midoriya grabs his shoulder, takes a deep breath, and shoves it back into the socket. He hears Ground Zero throw up. "Ouch."

"Something is so wrong with you," Ground Zero heaves, more vomit. "That sounded fucking —" another wave. "That was worse than when you pulled the knife—" another.

Midoriya massages the flesh. "It's not that bad." Another round of vomit. "I think I've dislocated, like, most of my body before. Just gotta put it back."

"You need to go to a fucking hospital."

Midoriya snorts. "That's expensive." He blinks slowly. "I'm good."

"You just exploded out of a tunnel, smashed a window with your head, landed on your shoulder and dislocated it, slid across glass shards, and you're 'good'?" There's the sound of a water bottle lid popping open, then Ground Zero as he sips from it. "You need to call for help."

He stumbles out of the bathroom, moves to the window. Fire still rages from the far right tunnel, but it's slowly dying down. More importantly, no Nomus seem to have survived that. Midoriya opens the apartment door and heads for the stairs. He trips a few times, but only falls about a flight down, so he's good.

"You're a walking fucking hazard," Ground Zero snaps at him. "You should've had me come."

Midoriya grumbles, turning to face the two remaining tunnels. "Which one should I—"

"Motherfucker, *no*. You can't do this, I'm so fucking serious, Greenie. *NO*. Do you know that word?" Ground Zero all but begs. "Just take a moment, just a few minutes. Collect yourself, recover."

"But—"

"Sit. Down."

Midoriya huffs but listens, plopping down on the bloodied floor. His vision sways and warbles, pain blooming across his body. At least the new fabric of his suit held up. None of the glass cut him up. If only there were a fabric for dislocated limbs!

He groans, holds his head.

“I’m sure that window felt fucking wonderful,” Ground Zero says, voice snarky. “Do you have water? Did mommy remember to pack that for you?”

“You arf so nean,” Midoriya slurs. He’s so out of it, beyond sleepy, as well. “I got wader.”

“Drink it then, dipshit.”

He grumbles and pulls his bag forward again. He unzips it, sifts around the inside for an unreasonable time before Ground Zero verbally guides him to the plastic top of a bottle. He tugs it out, face flushing at the sight of it.

He hadn’t bought a new one, so he’s stuck with the same one he’s had for years.

“What the fuck is that?”

“My All Might limited edition 2023 Stanley water bottle,” Midoriya says with perfect clarity, “I stole it.”

“I don’t even know what to say to that.” Midoriya flaps the bottle’s custom little hair pieces that stick out of it. “Stop doing that. Drink the water.”

“Yup.” Midoriya stares at it. “Ah.”

“Open the hole in the top.”

“Yup.” He does that, lifts it to his mouth to drink, and clanks it against his mask. “Whoops.”

“Oh my god.”

“I gotdis.” He tugs his mask down, remembers to deepen his voice, which is a miracle in itself. “Bazinga.”

“Drink the fucking water.”

He does, only choking once. He gets a lot of it down, feels the cold of it burn against his stomach. He puts the bottle back in his bag and grasps mindlessly at the red-topped box in there. When he pulls it out, he hears a loud scoff.

“You are not seriously about to smoke right now.”

“Tell me whure my lighter id.”

“Fuck no, you’re going to set yourself on fire.”

“Bitch.”

“The fuck did you just call—“ he stops talking, but Midoriya swears he can hear his teeth grinding. “Smoking is a health risk.”

“Bitch,” Midoriya repeats, digging into his bag.

He pulls out his All Might lighter, laughing at it. A few tries later, and he gets the end of it lit. He inhales, exhales, his chest burning. Only when he's finally warm again does he stand.

He keeps the stick between his fingers, slides his bag on. "Let's a go!" He stalks forward, picks a random tunnel. He walks completely blind for a while before remembering that Ground Zero probably wants to know what the hell he's looking at. To be fair, Midoriya can't see a thing either.

He flicks on his night vision, humming as he ventures down mystery tunnel number three.

"How's your brain, Greenie."

"Oh, it's good," Midoriya says, then rolls his arm. "Shoulder is fine. I'm great."

"Then let's back track a bit. What the fuck just happened?"

"What happened was a pre-coded system that prevents any tampering with a computer system." He takes a deep breath in. Out. "My flash drive must've tripped whatever program was running."

"So it self-destructed and destroyed all those people? All that information?" Ground Zero asks.

"If it were me, I'd have a backup. I always back all my information up three different times. I can't imagine how thorough these guys are," Midoriya tells him, "There's a chance that there are several underground systems just like this one that's dedicated to wiping people out and turning them into a Nomu."

"That's great, next question, who the fuck gave you that flier?" Ground Zero presses.

Midoriya finishes his stick, presses the end of it into the dirt wall, and then smashes it with his foot. "A friend of mine had given it to me. There's no way he knew what was going on."

"So they were just handing this shit out?" he asks, "How has no Hero caught on?"

"Passing it out is one thing," Midoriya answers him, "But the address is given through word of mouth. And the code word to get in, get this, is 'Nomu'. Literally sign your fate by entering."

"That's fucking awful."

"I just can't help but wonder… where did the rest of the bodies… go…" his shoes squelch in the dirt. "Uh oh."

"What? What is that? I can't see fucking see it."

It must be extra dark, because Midoriya can't see it either. He's hit with the smell of metal. He takes his flashlight off his belt, shines it on the floor before dragging it up. The place is covered with blood.

“Don’t go over there.”

He goes over there. The dirt walls get more and more disgusting the more he goes. The smell hits him a moment later, and he gags from it. He keeps moving, light shining, and when the tunnel begins to curve, he sees it.

“Oh my god,” he whispers, shining his light. “Oh my fucking god.”

Bodies.

Only a few had been turned into Nomus and were floating in their tanks. The rest… the rest are stacked in this tunnel. They’re packed to the brim, bodies contorted in different directions, certain bits and pieces. The last one, piled right in front of him, is the little girl he saw the first time he came here.

“That’s… that’s where the rest of the bodies went,” he says, voice shaking. “Oh my god. They just fucking stuffed them in here.”

“You need to call—“

“I will. I need to get out first,” Midoriya shines the light right on the little girl. Her bright eyes are completely gone, her mouth agape. “Fucking Christ.”

He sticks a hand out, slowly closes her lips. Even though her eyeballs are missing, he shuts her eyelids. Then, carefully, he tucks loose strands of her hair behind her ear. He’s not sure why, but he still checks for a pulse. It’s a bit pathetic, but he tries anyway.

Nothing.

“Ground Zero?” Midoriya whispers, “What if… what if the Pros think I did this? I-If I call it in, what if they—“

“That won’t happen,” he says immediately. “Eraser Head is on your side, remember? He’ll believe you.”

The flashlight trembles as he does, the light shaking. “I’m scared.”

“Call it in, Greenie.”

“Okay—“

A loud, inhuman screech sounds from far down the tunnel. Midoriya shuts his light off, drops low. He turns the night vision back on, but stays perfectly still.

“What the fuck was that?” Ground Zero asks.

Midoriya doesn’t know; he truly doesn’t. Slowly, surely, he creeps out of his tunnel and back to where the scream came from. The main underground room is seemingly empty, though he doesn’t trust it. The scream came from somewhere.

He jolts, turns to his left as the screech sounds again. The smoke from the exploded tunnel is still clearing out, but Midoriya knows he was wrong the second bright, orange eyes peer at him from within it.

The explosion didn't kill all the Nomus.

RAARGHHHHAAA!!!

"RUN!" Ground Zero screams at him.

He turns, takes off. The manhole cover that leads back to the woman's house is way too far away, not to mention that it takes two hours, *at least,* to get through the full thing. He can't run that long. Which means—

"Rin!" Midoriya shouts, sprinting down the fourth tunnel. "Send my location to Eraser Head and Ground Zero!"

The robotic voice replies instantly. "Sending location to Eraser Head and Ground Zero."

The tunnel is totally dark, his night vision working wonders, but not nearly as much as a flashlight could. In this close of quarters, he needs something brighter. He turns it off, clicks on his flashlight, and screams as he passes dismembered corpses.

The Nomu screams again, and Midoriya makes the mistake of glancing behind him, his light pinned on the fucking thing. It's *close,* its lower body is completely gone. Only its top half remains, large, claw-like hands dragging it through dirt. Its orange eyes glow at him, its face half broken and brain exposed.

"I need to know what I'm running to!" Midoriya shouts. "Is this a dead end?"

Frantic tapping. "You're headed towards Chou City. I'm pinning your location, there are several manhole covers or sewer drains."

RAARGHHHHAAA!!!

His ears ring. He can hear its loud claws gaining on him.

"Fuck, fuck," Midoriya pants, pushing harder. "I totally thought I'd go out cooler."

"Shut up!" Ground Zero snaps at him.

"Distract me," he pleads, following a bend. "Please."

"Shit, uhh, fuck! Okay, okay, I started therapy a week ago, it's fucking weird." Ground Zero picks something random. "My first session went so bad that now I have to see this lady three times a fucking week, it's so stupid."

Midoriya sucks in air, coughs as he runs. He stumbles, trips, rolls, and gets up as fast as humanly possible.

“They wanted to medicate me, mood stabilizers, like I’m some nut job,” Ground Zero says it all so fast, his voice panicked. “But now they think something else is fucking wrong with me. Like I need to be fixed. I’m not fucking broken.”

Midoriya chokes on saliva. He again peers behind him, sees that thing crawling just a few feet behind, he faces forward immediately.

“And I had thought everyone felt this way, but apparently, nope, just fucking me!” Ground Zero swears repeatedly. “Also, my therapist is a fucking bitch! Gives me fucking mood charts like I’m five, I *hate* that woman.”

Up ahead, Midoriya sees a ladder. His heart picks up, and it feels as though he runs just a bit faster. He sprints, grabs the bottom rung, and climbs so fast that he should earn a record. He hits the manhole cover, but it doesn’t move. He bangs on it, nothing.

“Come on, come on,” he whimpers, shoving as hard as he physically can. The lid comes loose, and he launches himself up and out.

The Nomu swipes at him. Midoriya throws the heavy lid at its fucking head. It takes it with ease, grasping and bending the metal like it’s paper. Midoriya again taps his helmet, looks around.

“Where the fuck am I!” he shouts, staring at the building he’s in. It’s empty, nothing but boarded-up windows and—

Another abandoned fucking building! How many exist? How does he always fucking find them?!

The Nomu roars, and Midoriya whips around to the stairs that go up. With no front door to exit out of, since, for some reason, it’d been boarded up like a fucking crack house, Midoriya scampers up the stairs.

“Chou City, an abandoned building set to be demolished tomorrow," Ground Zero says, “The second floor has roof access.”

Thank god.

He’s winded, flying up the stairs and sprinting to another damn ladder. He climbs, feeling a long claw scrape at his leg. It doesn’t tear through his fabric, a fact that he will thank that random man for over and over and over again. The roof is perfect. Flat, small ledge, maybe a six-foot gap to the next one.

He runs, legs pumping, breath in his throat. The ledge meets the tip of his shoe, and he jumps, legs high to his chest. Adrenaline whips through his veins, the open air a welcomed friend. He lands on the other side in a roll, then he’s up again. The Nomu jumps too, misses, its claws imbedding into the side of the building before climbing the rest of the way. It gives Midoriya an advantage.

“Why… chasing me?” he pants, jumps to the next roof.

“Fuck if I know!” Ground Zero responds. “Shit, you're too far down. You need higher ground. The building roofs are going to start getting higher and higher.”

“Eraser… where?”

“10 minutes away.”

10 minutes. Midoriya can do that. He jumps to the next building, lands on the frame of a window, fingers gripping the tiny ledge. Bending to a squat, he pushes from the glass to the next window, then the next, and on the next one, the Nomu jumps and lands on the building wall. Midoriya swings around, pushes off a lucky flower planter that gets him to he next story.

He grips iron wrought balcony rails, pulling himself up until he’s standing on the thin bar. From there, he turns and jumps to the building beside it, fingers grasping the roof ledge. Upper body strength typically fails him, but he manages to operate off pure adrenaline.

He stands on the roof, takes one large breath before running again. He jumps, climbs, and scours the side of a building until he’s on top. Higher and higher, his stamina is being tested the more he runs. When he hits another building, he yanks the last one of the green ears off his helmet. The blade on the end catches the light, and he jams it into the next window he’s on.

He crashes through a broken window for the second time today. Bad habit, he fears.

“There are knives in your fucking ears?!” Ground Zero says. “How the hell are you doing this?”

“Fast.” Is the panted response.

Businessmen and women gasp and hide behind their cubicles as he sprints through their building. The Nomu doesn’t even bat an eye at them, giving chase the entire time. The elevator on this level dings, people clearing out as he runs for it. He slides inside with random strangers, presses the button for the twenty-fifth floor, and pants.

The doors slide shut. The Nomu slams into it, pries them open. But the elevator has already begun to ascend. The creature roars, and the glass floor of the elevator reveals it falling to the bottom of the shaft.

Midoriya breathes heavily, then looks at the handful of people in here with him. “What’s up with that guy, huh?”

Someone slowly raises their phone, snaps a photo of him. A loud, piercing scream comes from the bottom of the shaft.

Midoriya ushers them to get off the elevator the second it stops on the thirteenth floor, telling nobody else they’re allowed on. Then he rides it to the top. He stares down at the black abyss of the elevator floor. The fucking monster claws its way out of the dark, screaming, nails dug into the walls.

“So,” Ground Zero says, “What the fuck are you going to do?”

Midoriya eyes the Nomu, its body far less put together than before. The explosion blew it in half, but the drop split it down the center. It’s still alive. Something bigger needs to happen to kill it.

Lucky for him, he’s got a good plan.

“How far out is Eraser Head?”

“Three minutes.”

Sike, he has no plan. Unless… Midoriya nibbles his lip, staring down at the Nomu. It’s fast, huffing and screaming as it climbs up the elevator shaft.

“That’s not quick enough,” he says, heart in his throat.

“What? What are you… No, no, Greenie.”

“I’ve got to kill it. Or it’ll just start attacking.”

“This is crazy, this is fucking crazy!”

“For what it’s worth,” Midoriya says, voice hoarse. “I don’t think you’re broken at all.” He hangs up the call, hands trembling.

He’s doing this. He’s really doing this.

“Rin,” he says, watching the number on the elevator tick upwards. “Send all footage from today to Eraser Head.”

“Sending footage to Eraser Head.”

The elevator doors open. He steps out, takes the stairs to the roof. His heart thunders, his throat dry. He’s slow, deliberate as he walks to the edge. The Nomu roars, metal tears, and the roof door opens.

It’s alright. He was ready to be done, he thinks. He was ready to be done with it. He’s given Eraser Head a great lead with the case, and Hitoshi has already left his life. This is the next best step. He’s been erased from police databases, from the UA database; there’s no one who would know what happened to him.

When he hits the bottom of this building, his body will smush and smash into nothing but red. That’s alright, he thinks. Maybe it’ll feel a little bit like he’s flying.

The Nomu tears through the roof door, roars, runs after him. Midoriya lets him get close, lets him almost rip through his chest.

Before holding his arms out wide and jumping off the edge of the building.

Air whips at him, pressure pushing at his clothes. The Nomu flings itself off the ledge, but its weight is too heavy despite being cut in half. It races for the bottom, screaming as it falls and falls and falls.

Midoriya doesn't feel that way. He feels like he's in slow motion, like he's a feather drifting down. For the first time in his life, he feels light. He is no longer weighed down, no longer heavy. He'll feel no pain when he smashes against the road below. He's done fifteen years, he's ready.

"Incoming call from: Mama. Do you want to answer?"

Midoriya breathes. "No."

"Mama left you one voicemail. Would you like to hear it?"

"Yes."

There's a click, then Mama's voice. "Hi, baby! I know you're busy, but I can't help but check in on you."

He falls lower, windows passing him by.

"I just came home from work and saw you had done the dishes. I don't know how I got so lucky to raise a teenage boy who cleans up after himself, but I feel so grateful."

Tears prick his eyes.

"Just wanted to remind you that I love you! I'll see you at home tonight, okay? Bye."

Wind whooshes by, pulls at his clothes.

God dammit.

He unzips his backpack from over his shoulder. Everything that is inside immediately flies out, but Midoriya manages to grab the tail end of a piece of cloth first. He squeezes it as tight as he can before wrapping it around his neck. He leaves a lot of slack and prays to whatever higher power there might be that this works.

"Come on, come on!" he says, staring down at the nearing ground. "Go!"

The fabric stiffens, bends, then shoots out. It grabs onto a roof railing nearby, tightening around the metal. Midoriya screams in pure joy, grasps the end before it can choke him, and holds on tight. His body careens right, so he withdraws the current hold and gets a new one on the left, swinging between two buildings like fucking Spiderman.

He lifts his legs up as he passes over cars, cheering and whooping when he goes up again. The support item doesn't fail, grasping buildings and lamp posts, and anything it can to keep him steady and swinging. People film him as he soars by, but he's more interested in the Nomu.

Its large body is spattered on the pavement below, nothing but guts and gore to show for it. A success, Midoriya took out a fucking Nomu!

He shouts again, cheering, the wind whipping at his face as he soars through the city. He can get used to this.

When he gets to the abandoned building in Musutafu, he's on such a cloud nine that he doesn't think about anything else. He slips through the trap door and peels off his helmet. His lower mask stays on, as this building is full of dust that he doesn't want to inhale. He hops down the scaffolding with helmet in hand, goggles dropped into the inside of it.

Midoriya hums as he lifts the wooden panel at the bottom, crawls into the hole, and works his way through the tunnel in the dark. He must've hit his head pretty hard, because everything seems much darker than he remembers. When he emerges from the back alley and starts to head home, there's a twisting feeling in his gut.

He ignores it, climbs up the drain pipe to get to his room, and plops into bed with a wicked grin. That was *awesome.*

He peels off his suit, stuffs it under his bed. His stomach is growling for the soba Mama made for him. He shoves open his bedroom door and spots a woman sitting at the kitchen table. Long, black hair pinned back, she looks a lot like Nana Shimura, All Might's predecessor.

She turns to him, brown eyes wide, and Midoriya's heart drops.

Mama.

He stumbles forward, tripping over his feet as he heads to the bathroom. One flick of the light reveals the truth. The reason he couldn't see as well, smell as well, or hear as well—Rin's Quirk finally wore off. His ears are back to their rounded shape, his fingerprints completely looped once more. His hair is a deep, midnight black. And his eyes—

His eyes are a bright, unyielding red.

Chapter 25: A conversation

Chapter Summary

Midoriya goes out for a night on the town with his buddies! What could go wrong?

Chapter Notes

Kind of long chapter, my bad

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You did good work, Shouta," Hizashi says, smiling at him. "We've got a whole new lead now."

Indeed, they do.

The abandoned building cameras were tripped a few hours after Viridant killed the Nomu. To keep it discreet, they used a trail cam-shaped device and pinned it to a wall that was covered with debris. It snaps photos of whatever activates it, and it got Viridant clear as day. Bakugou gave them a huge lead, showing the warehouse that Viridant always uses to get home.

He's not sure how the media got 'green' eyes, because Viridant has a deep, red iris. Dark hair, dark skin, dark eyes. His lower face is covered, but all Eraser needed was the top half.

He slides the laptop to All Might, a candid photo of Viridant on the screen. "You've met this kid?"

All Might stares at the screen, shakes his head. "I'm certain I haven't."

Aizawa is going to throttle him. Present Mic sits in the chair next to him, Nezu pouring tea into some cups at the other end. And, of course, Bakugou, lost deep in thought a few chairs down. The kid did a lot today for this cause, saved Viridant's life with quick thinking and Hero accessed information. But every time they finish a meeting or session pertaining to the vigilante, Bakugou withdraws.

He'll check on him when he's through with All Might.

"You've run into this kid, looked him in the eyes. You've *talked* to him," Aizawa says slowly. "You don't recognize him?

All Might Frowns. “When Viridant had said he was Quirkless, I was certain I knew who he was. I had met a Quirkless young boy months ago. But his description—completely different. The boy I met was scrawny, green hair, green eyes, a small little kid. Viridant? His total opposite. I would remember…” He stares at the photo, swallowing thickly. “I would remember eyes like those.”

Aizawa deflates, and when he looks over, Bakugou is staring right at All Might as though he’s personally offended him. To be fair, that’s how Bakugou looks at everyone, so Aizawa doesn’t think much of it.

Then Bakugou says, “What was the kid's name?”

All Might gives him a curious look. “I… am not sure.”

Bakugou doesn’t like that answer. “Was this in Musutafu?”

“Yes. A few blocks away from—“

“Aldera junior high.” Bakugou leans back in his seat, nodding his head in a silent confirmation. He doesn’t say anything else, just stares at the wall, his mind anywhere other than here.

“Nezu,” Aizawa turns to his favorite coworker, not that he will *ever* admit that out loud. “Anything from the system?”

“We have several backup servers!” Nezu says cheerfully. “Viridant confirmed a UA student had wiped the data of the entrance exams, but we have all data accounted for on the fourth server.”

Aizawa can’t help the small grin on his face. “What are we waiting for?”

“That server is encoded,” Nezu claims, sipping from his tea. “It was created years ago as a last effort in case something takes out the other programs we have. It’ll take time to open it and access the data within it, but it is very much possible!”

It’s possible. They’re going to save this kid. He passed the test yesterday with flying colors. Every Pro in that room, watching him, agreed that he would be a needed force at UA. Even after his confession, which had left most of them speechless, it was agreed that Viridant would be attending UA.

When they finish discussing the remaining details and the meeting is adjourned, he tells Hizashi he’ll meet him at home. His husband knows better than to question Aizawa’s constant need to stay moving and working, so he kisses his head goodbye.

“Bakugou,” he calls out, watching the student pause at the end of the hall. “Wait.”

He does, standing still long enough for Aizawa to meet him. He matches the kids' pace as they head down UA’s halls. Bakugou keeps his hands stuffed into his pockets, his head angled high but his eyes low to the floor.

“What's wrong, kid?”

“Nothing.”

“Bullshit.” Aizawa tugs him to a stop. “Are you wanting out of this mission?”

“No,” Bakugou says quickly, avoiding eye contact. “I was just thinking. Am I not allowed to fucking think anymore?”

Aizawa sighs. “Talk, kid.”

He still won’t look at him, but he says, “Do you know the number of Quirkless people in this world?”

Not off the top of his head. Aizawa stays silent.

“20% of the world population is born without a Quirk. Do you know how many live past their thirteenth birthdays?” Bakugou asks him, finally meeting his gaze. “Two percent.”

Aizawa listens, his heart heavy.

“I keep thinking about what Viridant said about his dislocated shoulder, about how he wanted to be a Hero so badly and… and I don’t fucking know,” Bakugou scoffs. “I kept thinking of Deku.”

Aizawa purses his lips. “Who named a kid that?”

Bakugou shakes his head, eyes turned back to the floor again. “That’s not his actual name—it’s what everyone called him.” He doesn’t look away from the tiles. “I was the one who started it.”

Aizawa isn’t shocked to hear that Bakugou was a bully. You’d be surprised to know that most Pros were. Second year classes revolve a lot around self-reflection and growth, hammering abusive people back into what they really are—hurt kids. Somewhere along the line, people like Bakugou Katsuki got the short end of a stick, and they ensured nobody would ever know about it.

So Aizawa isn’t shocked, or afraid; he’s only sad. His heart weighs heavily, his soul aching.

“I just keep thinking about him, it’s like I can’t get it out of my head. I destroyed Deku,” Bakugou grinds his jaw. “It’s like it’s constantly playing on loop. I had always thought he was so far behind me, and somehow, he was always ahead. I kept thinking—how could someone like *him* smile every day, work his ass off to secure a future, how could he possibly fall short?”

The kid’s voice is hoarse when he says, “How did I end up chasing after him? He had followed me our whole lives, and then one day it all changed, and I was—I was on the outside of something I had no idea I enjoyed being part of.”

Aizawa listens quietly.

“I’ve been at UA for two months,” Bakugou says, finally meeting Aizawa’s eyes again. “And I can’t convince myself I deserve to be here.”

Aizawa knows that feeling better than anyone. He’d been picked on for as long as he could remember. And when he finally proved those kids wrong, when he finally made it into UA, he came to a horrible conclusion. He didn’t think he could’ve made it into UA either, just as all those kids had always said to him. So for months, he sat in Class 1-A, waiting and watching for when someone would finally come and drag him out, put a real Hero in his place.

And maybe it isn’t the same reason Bakugou feels like he doesn’t belong, but it’s the same twist of the gut. The same drop of the heart. The same pound of frustration in the temple. He *knows* how it feels, even when it’s not from the same root, they’ve both grown the exact same.

So Aizawa says, “Very rarely do I have a student who can have so much growth in a mere two months, Bakugou Katsuki. But you continue to surprise me.”

Bakugou shuts his eyes, letting Aizawa tug him close. Neither one of them are affectionate people, but the awkwardness of it only serves to make it more vulnerable. He rubs the kids' back, thinks back on all the shit that he had endured in his school years.

“You want me to be mad at you—I won’t be,” Aizawa says softly. “You want to pick a fight, I’m not giving you one.”

Bakugou says nothing.

“You’ve got to forgive yourself, kid, then work on trying to fix what you’re apologizing for.” Aizawa pulls back, rests his hands on Bakugou’s shoulders. “The shit you’re doing for us, for Viridant? That’s something, that’s *more* than something. Would this Deku ever expect to see you in that room, helping a Quirkless vigilante?”

Bakugou shakes his head slowly.

“Then start there,” Aizawa tells him softly. “Defy the odds, mend a bond.” And he says words he had always wished to hear growing up. “You are not irredeemable. You are not broken and in need of fixing. You are just a kid, you’ve got years to learn how to live with who you are.”

Bakugou won’t look at him, but Aizawa can see the slight shine in his eyes.

“It’s never too late to fix things,” Aizawa tells him. “Not at all.”

When Bakugou finally turns to leave without another word, Aizawa feels just a smidge bit lighter. These kids are going to drive him insane; he knows that better than anyone. But he thinks he’d gladly lose his mind for them.

He turns the opposite direction, ready to head home—

A hooded figure peers at him from the end of UA's long hall. The second Aizawa sees him, the kid takes off running. Aizawa gives chase, but the student is gone by the time he rounds the corner. Fuck!

Fuck!

If he heard that conversation, he'll tell Viridant about Bakugou being on the case. Ground Zero's identity needs to be kept under wraps; they can't afford to lose such an integral connection to the vigilante. Especially not after today's near-death situation.

"Wait!" Aizawa calls into the empty hall. "Whoever is out there, please, just wait!"

Silence fills the air, nothing but quiet.

"Viridant has been excused of all crimes!" he shouts, nerves racking in his chest. "We're trying to get the kid into UA. He won't face any repercussions, not a single one."

An autumn breeze whips at the windows.

"Please. I know he's your friend, but we just want to help him. Get him away from the dangerous parts of the world, or send him in with backup. Please, please don't tell him." He's never begged before, but he's close to it now. "We can't mess this up."

A small form appears from behind a pillar. Black hood, black sweatpants, a face mask that hides his lower face. Aizawa has no idea who it is, but the kid gives him a small nod before taking off again.

And Aizawa hopes he listens.

***

Mama usually succumbs to fear and panic with tears. The woman sitting next to him now is a far cry from that. When he had come home days ago to her, she had insisted they go back to Rin to be fixed up again. He had told her that Rin had passed away, a quick and painless death, and Mama hadn't even cried. She was stone-faced, even when he lied and told her he had gotten a job and funds to help her out.

So they could afford a trip to the drug store to buy bleach and green hair dye. They had spent hours doing each other's hair. Mama had insisted he go first, so he sat perfectly still, letting her work thick lumps of bleach through his black hair. Then they swapped, and he was extra careful to treat her long, silky hair with care. Midoriya has curly hair, a part of being mixed means his hair is a lot looser than Mama's tight coils, but still difficult as hell to manage.

So they researched, they take care of their hair carefully, and with so much coconut oil that it's not even funny. Mama straightens her hair with a hot comb every day, and doing that before bleaching makes it a bit easier to evenly apply the bleach and hair dye. And when it's all done, only their eyes give away who they really are. What they really are.

Mama spent a long time staring at him while he did her hair. She never said a word about what she was thinking, but he could see it written on her face. He knows who he looks like.

After all, he got his Dad's eyes.

"Have you heard the news?" Ito asks at lunch. He lifts a sandwich to his mouth, then stares at Midoriya mid-bite. "Did… did your eyes change color?"

"Nope," Midoriya responds.

Ito shrugs. "Anyway, Viridant busted another missing persons case. He's at, like, eight hundred and fifty people saved! UA is calling for his retrieval, it's fucking insane."

Banri, one of the other kids at the table, pipes up, "I heard he didn't make it in time. All the bodies that the guy uncovered were already cold."

"Ewww," a girl, by the name Sayori, squeals out. "I'm trying to eat over here, asshole."

Midoriya stays quiet. He pushes his food around his plate. Mama quit her second job since he told her finally managed to land one of his own. Of course, he has no job, but now he has an excuse to slip out of the house during the daytime. He 'gives her' all of his 'paychecks' to help with rent, even if she doesn't ask for it. He can't help but notice how much more she's at home and relaxing.

"And Viridant took out one of those Nomu!" Ito says, musing his blond hair. "All Might could barely do that."

Banri says, "It was technically *half* a Nomu."

"You're such a Viridant hater for literally no reason," Ito laughs at him. "What did the guy ever do to you, huh?"

"I just don't trust him," Banri responds, shrugging his shoulders. "The guy freaks me out. Looks like a total villain."

"Does he give you nightmares, Banri? Do you need me to tuck you in at night?"

"Fuck you."

"In your dreams, loser."

Sayori interrupts, twirling her short hair around her finger. "I think he's pretty cool."

"Ew," Ito throws a carrot at her head, unaware of how red in the face Midoriya has gone. "Threw up, like actually threw up."

“He’s a cool guy! That’s all,” Sayori giggles out, dodging a head of broccoli. “My cousin said he chased a Pro off her when she stole some makeup to cover up her scars. You know, her Quirk really messed up her skin.”

Banri groans, blue eyes darting between them all. “I can’t believe you guys like this kid. He seriously freaks me out. I can’t shake this feeling that something’s wrong with him.”

“Oh, I definitely get that,” Sayori says, before a wicked grin takes over. “That’s why I like him so much.”

Ito gags, throws a celery stick that bounces off her nose. “What do you think, Mido?”

Midoriya stiffens when they all turn to him. “Uhh… I don’t know.”

“If you take my side,” Banri offers, “You can come with us to Tokyo this weekend.”

“Don’t torture the baby,” Ito hisses, “Mido doesn’t do that stuff. He’s not nearly as dumb as you two.”

Midoriya tilts his head. “What are you doing?”

Banri gives him a smirk. “Getting together with a couple kids from a school down there. Smoke, drink, tag a few buildings.”

He *does* need to get back to Tokyo. He lost everything from inside his backpack, and he heard the woman inside that house had been arrested. There’s a chance he could go visit her in her holding cell, claim he’s a neighbor checking in about her pets, or something stupid.

He bounces his leg. “I’m into that stuff.”

Ito snorts. “Really?”

“Yeah,” he says, voice cracking. “Definitely.”

“I don’t think you’ve touched pot in your entire life,” Ito argues.

Not true. He’s smoked with Hitoshi before. It didn’t make him calm and tired like it did his friend, though. It only spiked his paranoia, making him think someone was going to find his location and break into his house. He was also fairly certain he would accidentally eat his tongue. It was a weird experience.

Still, Midoriya tugs loose a new pack of cigarettes he stole from a gas station. “See? I’m not a baby.”

“Did you buy that with your fake?” Ito asks, snatching the box and taking one out. “Bastard, holding out on us.”

“You should come,” Banri says, elbowing Sayori. “There’ll be more girls other than this loser.”

“Screw you, Banri.”

“Pass.”

Midoriya chuckles when they start shoving each other back and forth. “Sure, I’ll come.” He thinks for a second before adding, “Can I invite a buddy of mine?”

“Anyone is better than these dipshits,” Ito says.

Midoriya takes his phone out, typing quickly.

Viridant: Do you drink or smoke?

The response comes within seconds.

Ground Zero: Do I seem like a fucking idiot? No.

Viridant: Oh, okay, no worries. I was going to see if you wanted to come out with me and a couple of kids tonight. We were going to drink and smoke. Sorry to bug you!

Ground Zero: WAIT NO I WANT TO GO

Ground Zero: FUCK

Midoriya pockets the phone before he sees the messages. “Never mind.”

“Let’s meet tonight and we’ll ride down to the city together,” Ito says, laughing when Sayori hits Banri in the balls. “You’ll like these kids, Mido. Fucking Americans, they’re funny as shit.”

And Midoriya does.

When they make it to Tokyo, they have bags stuffed to the brim with spray cans. The two other kids they’re meeting, named Rody and Melissa, are bringing the alcohol and weed. More kids are set to come, including two UA students, which Midoriya was nervous to hear about. But when they all arrive at some random parking lot, his nerves dissipate.

Kamari Denki and Hanta Sero, two 1-A kids that Midoriya has no correlation with. Well, not technically true. Both of these kids hang out with Bakugou, and one of them is Hitoshi’s unrequited lover.

But he was right, Kaminari is *very* friendly.

“FINALLY!” The blond cries out, “Someone new! Everyone here makes so much fun of me.” He immediately latches onto Midoriya in a tight hug. “Who are you?”

“Midoriya Izuku,” he squeaks out, lungs compressed in the hug. “I can’t breathe.”

“You smell great,” Kaminari says.

“That’s fucking weird, bro,” Hanata adds. “You can call me Sero.”

Midoriya takes in a large breath of air when Kaminari finally releases him. That lasts until brownies are shoved into his face, which Kaminari always brings to these meet-ups. Midoriya stares at them in his hand, a sudden lump in his throat.

“No Mina?” Sayori asks. “Melissa and I have to deal with you assholes alone?”

“We should ditch them,” Melissa says, American accent thick, dripping off her Japanese like honey. “Go get massages or something.”

“Mina’s coming, she’s trying to drag one of our other buddies out, but he’s a fucking grump,” Sero says, rubbing his large elbows. “He was in an especially bad mood today, you should’ve seen it. He’s been glued to his phone for the past, like, two months. Definitely getting scammed by some catfish.”

Kaminari barks out a laugh. “You’d love him, Midoriya. He’s just a total sweetheart.”

Midoriya raises a brow. “I got a feeling you’re full of shit.”

Kaminari laughs, and then they start walking. He’s not sure where, but he tries his best to keep up. He’s never hung out with so many people before! Midoriya takes in the large group, observes how they interact and joke. He was just starting to get good at communicating with Ito, and now he’s got six others to deal with. Good news, at least, almost all of them seem to be extroverted. He and Melissa are definitely quieter than the others, but there seems to be some shared decision that they don’t mind listening while everyone else talks.

Ito still keeps by his side, wary of all the others. When he introduces Midoriya officially, Ito doesn’t mention anything about a Quirk. Midoriya learns why only after he’s been walking with the group long enough to get a good look at them all.

And Melissa’s Quirkless brand shoes.

He stares at them for a long time, unsure what to say or do. She’s painted them purple, but he knows the shape and brand logo anywhere. This is the third Quirkless person he’s come across—or maybe the second? It’s possible that she was the person he saw graffitiing a few weeks back. But if that’s the case, then she is likely part of the league.

Dammit. He hadn’t intended to play Viridant tonight. He brought his support gear, just in case, but this wasn’t exactly on his list.

Rody’s Quirk is a bit unusual as well. A small, colorful bird sits on his shoulder. It’s been staring at Midoriya unblinkingly for nearly the entire time. It’s only slightly unsettling.

“I say,” Banri pipes up, “That we hit Chou City. That’s where the vigilante was last at, right? It could be fun.”

“Oh, don’t get me started on that guy,” Sero laughs out. “He’s got my Sensei so worked up, I think he’s the reason half our training sessions kick our ass.”

Midoriya can’t help the small smile blooming on his face. “Really?”

“Dude, you wouldn’t believe it, but I think that kid pisses off our teacher more than we do,” Kaminari says, earning a laugh from Sayori. “Poor thing, he’s done for when Aizawa catches him.”

“Oh, he’s cooked,” Sero agrees. “He’s got no chance.”

Nerves fill Midoriya’s stomach. “You think Aizawa would lock him up?”

“Dude, that would be a mercy,” Kaminari laughs, “I’m afraid what he would do if he *didn’t* lock the kid up.”

They keep walking, keeping their hoods down and masks off for now. They look more like a group of casual friends taking a nightly stroll on a weekend, not a couple of losers on their way to spray paint buildings and drink or smoke.

He’s a bit nervous, if he’s honest. He hasn’t gone back to Chou City since he escaped the Nomu. In the meantime, he’s been setting up a new laptop. He’s worried the flash drive of information he saved might have some kind of virus or corruption software on it. So he’s been patient, teaching himself how to code a malware connection that can receive the information safely.

It’s way harder to do it without Hitoshi.

He doesn’t let himself dwell on the friend that he’s had no contact with in weeks. Even after he made the news for a second time, Hitohi never reached out. Midoriya tried for the first few days, but getting left on read is beyond discouraging. It’s not like his phone broke, or was stolen, and it lines up too perfectly with his admittance into 1-A. Midoriya didn't even hear about that from Hitoshi. He had to hack the attendance schedules again to learn that his friend had succeeded.

It hurts, he’ll be honest. It hurts terribly. But he’s got bigger things to worry about than his first friendship failing.

Like, for example, the call that Kaminari answers. “Yeah, yeah, no fucking way, you convinced him to come?”

Midoriya takes the temporary stop in place to approach Melissa. He seriously has no idea how to talk to girls. He’s decent with Sayori, but that took *months* to manage. If he’s honest, women are very scary. His Mama is one of the strongest people he knows, and Auntie is literally insane. Men are simple, stupid, and easy to figure out. But women? Midoriya has no idea what they’re thinking, and it scares him to no avail.

He’s awkward about it, just standing within close-but-not-close proximity, dead silent. The others chat, and they listen, but it’s completely obvious that he’s got no idea what he’s doing.

Okay, okay, be smooth.

“Heugh,” oh fuck, his voice cracked.

She turns to him, tucking a strand of blonde hair behind her ear. “Hey.”

“Uhh…” says something! “You… uh… feet?”

Melissa gives him a weird look. “What?”

“I mean,” he’s so bad at this. “What are your feet like?”

Melissa blinks slowly. “Excuse me?”

“Your shoes,” he finally gets out, “I-I like them.”

She looks down at her sneakers, nervously biting her lip. When she peers over at his, she stills. Slowly, she looks back up at him, an emotion in her eyes that Midoriya can’t read. Is she going to attack him? Laugh? Why are they *so* scary? He can take on a Nomu in a tunnel full of severed limbs, but put him around a girl and he’s scared shitless.

Finally, she offers him a soft smile. “You’re name was Midoriya, right?”

“Y-Yup.”

“Melissa.” She holds a hand out. “I’m here to work with the support course at UA. My dad and All Might know each other; he got me a good connection.”

Midoriya takes her hand after wiping it on his pants to ensure it wasn’t clammy. “That’s wonderful. Are y-you an inventor?”

Her entire face lights up. “I am.”

“That’s… that's amazing. What’s it like working with the UA kids?”

“Kind of intimidating, if I’m honest. Nobody knows what to do with me.”

“Well,” Midoriya says without thinking. “I’d know what to do with you.” Her face turns a deep red, and he backpedals immediately. “That is *not* what I meant! I meant—oh my god—if I w-was a UA student—which I’m not—I mean, I wouldn’t treat you any differently.”

Retreat. Retreat. His mind blared a red warning at him. Retreat. Retreat.

Melissa offers a little laugh. “You’re funny.”

“Thanks! I’m not trying to be.”

She laughs again. “Have you ever been out with a group like this before?” When he shakes his head, she continues on. “They’re all pretty welcoming, I think. I haven’t told them… you know. Nobody but Kams and Sero know, and they couldn’t care less. So don’t worry about that.”

“Ito as well,” Midoriya tells her, and it’s nice to both confide in and share something with someone who *gets it.* “We’ve told Sayori and Banri that I’ve got some kind of—“

“Analytical Quirk?” she finishes for him, “I think I’ve used that one about a hundred times.”

There's a warm feeling in his chest, a relief that is unlike anything he's ever felt before. "Do you spray paint often?"

"Oh, no." She shakes her head. "I'm just here for the booze."

So she isn't the person Midoriya saw weeks ago. He's thankful for that, at least. He had been worried that she had some kind of part in the creation of Nomu's.

And with that out of the way, he starts firing questions at her. The Support Course is still a mystery to him, and the more she talks, the more he thinks he would've loved it. She tells him about the gear she makes, how she makes it, her crazy classmate called Hatsume, who constantly sets things on fire. She even talks about the scarf she made, how it disappeared from a hook on the wall, along with a laser cutter. Midoriya keeps his face as neutral as possible as she talks.

She's clearly very intelligent. She gets lost in talking about her work. And when the group gets moving again, she walks at his side, explaining the chemical components that go into creating suits for Heroes whose bodies need to be able to operate within the fabric. She talks about one student who can faze through walls or the floor, his own clothes constantly disappearing every time he activates his Quirk. Her fix? A suit made from his own hair. *Genius.*

"And, of course, I remake a lot of things," she says, twirling her hair around her finger. "Lots of first years absolutely destroy their gear. You wouldn't believe it. Pure recklessness."

He listens, hands deep in his hoodie pockets. Kaminari moves up ahead, calling out and waving to the other two friends who have been invited. Midoriya focuses only on her, listens intently as she talks.

"For a project coming up, we get to design gear for any well-known Hero or sidekick that we think could benefit them. I picked that vigilante, Viridant. His gear is *incredible.* So I simply found a way to improve it," she smiles shyly. "Sorry, I've been talking nonstop."

"No, don't stop," he urges her, "You clearly know what you're talking about. I like listening."

She blushes. "If you insist. But if I talk too much, you've got to stop me."

Midoriya smiles at her. "I'm not sure that's possible."

Melissa's gaze flickers between either one of his eyes, her own smile bright. "Well, I've been designing gear for Viridant. Obviously, not *for* Viridant, but in relation to his work. My first thought was to work out his suit. He must've gotten a good fabric to keep him safe, but I thought if I could add some sort of sensors to the inside, then he could get a full body scan on demand." Voices talk and greetings are made, the two of them ignore it. "Police reports identified some sort of AI within his helmet, so if I could connect those sensors to his headgear, then he'd be able to receive live diagnostics in relation to his body. Even better, I could add cooling or heating features to ensure he can move in every location without difficulty."

“That’s… that’s smart,” he tells her, thinking, “It could make it easier to call for backup, too. He could send a direct consult to a Pro.”

“Exactly!” she exclaims loudly, before immediately lowering her voice. “Sorry, I just get so excited. I’m not used to talking with someone who—“

“Gets it?” he finishes for her, just as she had moments ago. “Trust me, I know the feeling.”

Melissa opens her mouth to say more, but it’s interrupted by loud cursing and a few laughs. The two of them turn towards the commotion, observe the new people joining their group. One of them is a totally pink woman. Hair, skin, everything except her eyes, which are pure black. Even the hoodie she wore is hot pink, despite everyone trying to dress in darker colors to keep a low profile. And with her, gripping Kamanari’s shirt and throwing him to the floor, is—

“Oh shit,” Midoriya mumbles, pulse racing.

“What?” Melissa asks, eyeing the scene. “Do you know that guy? I’ve never seen him with our group before.”

“Oh, I know him,” Midoriya says, scoffing, “Don’t tell him you're Quirkless, he’s… not the most accepting.”

“Copy that,” she replies, squinting behind her glasses. “I think I made him a new arm piece after the joint exams; something happened to his old one.”

Midoriya happened to see the footage of those exams, so he knows precisely what happened to that arm piece. He doesn’t tell her that, though, too busy watching the scene unfold before him.

Kaminari, despite being pinned down, has a shit eating grin on his face. “I didn’t mean to offend you about your love life, man. It’s not my fault that you can’t get a text back.”

Midoriya winces. “Do they always pick on Bakugou?”

Sero appears from thin air. “It’s our favorite pastime. We see who can get him the most pissed off by the end of the day. Winner gets a black eye but twenty bucks.”

“I will *kill* you,” Bakugou snips, planting a foot on Kaminari’s stomach. “How about we talk about your fucking abysmal, pathetic love life?”

Kamaniari’s face drops. “Okay, okay, I’m sorry.”

Bakugou tilts his head, “I don’t think you are.”

“*Please* don’t flame me,” Kaminari begs. “I’ve been absolutely throwing enough as it is, I can't take you doing this to me, Bakubro.”

“Don’t call me Bakubro.”

“Bakubro.”

Midoriya leans towards Sero. “What does throwing mean?”

Sero snickers. “It means Kaminari is awful at flirting. It’s one of the worst things I’ve ever had to watch.”

Midoriya clenches his teeth. “Who’s the unfortunate recipient?”

Sero opens his mouth to answer, but at that moment, Kaminari calls for him to save him. Of course, that makes everyone turn to see what stupid reply Sero will have. Including Bakugou, whose eyes stay on Sero for maybe half a second before sliding over to him.

He drops Kaminari.

“Oh shit,” Midoriya mumbles again.

“What the *fuck* are you doing here?” Bakugou snips.

“I literally do this every weekend,” Sero answers.

“Not you, dumbass.” Bakugou lifts a finger, points at Midoriya. “*You.”*

Midoriya laughs awkwardly, stuffs his hands into his dark green hoodie. Bakugou is wearing a black one with an orange X on the front, more neon designs on the arms. It matches his Hero suit, not that Midoriya can say that out loud without sounding like an actual creep. Instead of saying anything, he takes in the smudged eyeliner on Bakugou’s face, another part of his Hero costume.

He stares a little longer than he should, eventually forcing his gaze away.

“Mido is our new buddy!” Kaminari cheers, right as Ito appears at Midoriya’s side and slings an arm over his shoulder. “He’s great, doesn’t threaten to end my life or anything. A-tier friend.”

Bakugou’s eye twitches. “What the hell are you doing, Deku?”

Ito answers for him. “Mido’s part of our crew now. He’s the only reason Sayori and I are passing chem, and the only reason Banri hasn’t lost his life from pissing me off.”

Midoriya feels a warmth in his chest at the way his new friends have defended him. But he knows how Bakugou works. He’s like a trail of gunpowder leading to TNT. He can only take the spark for so long before he explodes. And the look on the blond’s face says that he's very close to blowing.

So Midoriya squeezes Ito’s arm and steps forward. “Can we talk for a moment, Kacchan? We’ve got so much to catch up on.”

Bakugou seems to have short-circuited, staring blankly at Midoriya. He hadn’t meant to use his old nickname, but it slipped out. They haven't seen each other in so long. It must’ve really

made Bakugou mad, too, because he can't seem to form a response. Midoriya takes advantage of that and quickly moves forward, grabbing Bakugou's hoodie sleeve and dragging him away.

A chorus of *ooo,* and *this is gonna be good,* and *Kiri is gonna be pissed that he stayed for tutoring,* follows after them.

Normally, he'd never risk touching Bakugou unless it was to stop him from literally trying to kill him. But he can't risk these new friendships he's just gained. He already lost Hitoshi; he can't lose everyone else. It's not something he can handle again.

So he drags Bakugou into the nearest alley, out of sight from the others. When he lets go, Bakugou glares at the spot on his sleeve where Midoriya touched him. Likely forming some sort of insult about transmitting him a Quirkless disease, or maybe thinking of a reason to beat Midoriya to the ground.

"Listen," Midoriya says immediately, before he can manage to throw a single insult his way. "I know you weren't expecting to see me, but *please* don't mess this up for me, okay? You made it to UA, you're on the path to becoming the best Hero of all time, so there's no need to hate me anymore. I-I will stay completely out of your way."

Bakugou's lip tilts into a sneer. "The fuck are you saying?"

"I'm sorry for… for what I did," Midoriya keeps going. "I was going through some stuff, I never should've--"

"Who the hell do you think you are?" Bakugou grinds out. "Telling me some bullshit like that."

"Please, Bakugou--"

"I told you not to call me that." His eyes flash, palms sparking. "Didn't I?"

"Okay, okay," Midoriya backtracks, frustration slowly bleeding in. "Okay, fine, Kacchan. What does it matter?"

"It fucking matters."

"Just," Midoriya takes a deep breath. "Let's be civil, alright?"

Bakugou narrows his eyes. "With those fucking idiots out there? What the hell are you doing hanging around Haruto Ito? You know how much shit that kid's been caught for?"

"He's my friend."

"Really?" Bakugou snorts. "When was he your friend, huh? When his little gang would force your head down toilets? Or when he told the entire school rumors about your mom?"

The blood drains from Midoriya's face. "What?"

“Oh, did your *friend* not mention that? Imagine that,” Bakugou scoffs.

Midoriya shakes his head, his heart heavy. “Ito isn’t like that anymore, he's changed.”

“Of course,” Bakugou says, grinning wide. “I’m certain he’s a stand-up guy. Remind me, what were you invited to do tonight?” Midoriya’s face goes red. “Right. Illegally tag walls and drink and smoke underage. Tell me, Deku, does he still sell fake IDs? Did he tell you that he’s been to juvie? Did you know his sister--”

“No,” Midoriya says, cutting Bakugou off. “No, you don't get to do that.”

Bakugou tilts his head. “Do fucking what?”

“You don’t get to ruin this for me!” Midoriya shouts, voice wobbling. “You don’t get to share somebody else’s personal information, you don’t get to try and scare me away.” He clenches his fists. “Look at you, you’ve got it all, Kacchan. You landed UA, you get to go home to home-cooked meals and a Mom and Dad who don’t have to worry about making rent. You don’t get to take this away from me. I’ve made something of myself, and you aren’t going to come in here and ruin it again!”

Bakugou snarls, “Oh, fuck you! I’m trying to fucking help you.”

“Yeah, like you helped me with my other friend?” Midoriya asks, watching Bakugou swallow. “Yeah, there goes that connection. Thanks to you, he realized it was easier to use me and leave me than it was to stick around for someone he considered beneath him. You got what you wanted.”

“That’s not what I fucking wanted!” Bakugou argues, “Stop putting words in my damn mouth! What kind of friend would dump you the moment he learns the truth? That’s someone you wanted to keep around, Deku? You aren’t that fucking stupid, are you?”

Midoriya grabs his collar, slams him against the wall. He’s done. He wanted one night out with friends, not a fucking mental trip. "Here's how this is going to work, Kacchan. You’re going to keep your mouth shut about my life, or I’m going to *ruin* yours. Do you understand me?”

Bakugou grins. “Yeah?”

“Auntie is one call away,” Midoriya whispers to him, watching his eyes flicker to his mouth and back to his eyes. “I think we both know how she deals with you.”

Bakugou’s lips tremble, but he bites back. “And what about your mom, huh? You think she’d love to hear what her precious little baby is up to?”

“Then it’s mutually assured destruction,” Midoriya tells him, gaze heavy. “My Mama will forgive me. Will yours?”

Bakugou’s jaw flexes, and he shoves Midoriya off him. “You have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“No? How’s that nightlight?” he asks, grunting when Bakugou grabs him this time, pressing his back into the chain link fence separating the alleyway from the rest of the street. The streetlight hits them, coloring them in orange.

“I don't know what the hell has happened to you,” Bakugou says through gritted teeth. “But you’re going down a dark fucking path, you understand me? Something is *wrong* with you.”

“Fuck you.”

“You--” Bakugou’s eyes dart between his own. “What the hell is wrong with your eyes?”

Midoriya’s blood runs to his feet. “Nothing.”

“Did Rin do more work for you?” It’s a punch to the gut. “They’re too dark, that's not your usual green.”

“You have no idea what you’re--” Midoriya rears backwards when Bakugou reaches for his eye. “What the hell are you doing?”

“Are you wearing… contacts?” Bakugou’s eyes lift up, land on his hair, then widen. Midoriya tries to wiggle loose, but the asshole has too strong a grip. His pale fingers push back strands of Midoriya’s hair, revealing his earlobes.

He releases him then, watching as Midoriya stumbles.

“It wore off,” he says darkly. “You’re back to normal, aren’t you?”

Midoriya *hates* that Bakugou knows about this. When Mama had brought them to Auntie’s house, they hadn't yet met with Rin. Even then, he hadn’t undergone the DNA splicing until school was about to start. He had several blissful months with Bakugou with his natural appearance, and it seems like he hasn’t forgotten.

“Your hair isn’t the right shade, your earlobes are rounder, I’d bet your prints are back to normal, too, aren’t they?” Bakugou offers him a grin. “Do your friends know about that?”

Midoriya smooths out the grip Bakugou had on his hoodie. “Does UA know that you cheated in your entrance exam?”

Bakugou furrows his brows. “What the hell are you talking about? I didn’t cheat.”

“Really?” Midoriya asks lowly. “So if someone called to report you, they wouldn’t pull you out of your classes to do a full investigation? You wouldn’t fall behind? Better yet, you wouldn’t miss the training camp coming up, right?”

Bakugou stares at him, lips parted. “You’d ruin my career?”

Midoriya doesn’t answer.

“What happened to you?” he asks, voice low. “You’re completely different.”

“I didn’t get into UA--”

“No, no, this was before then,” Bakugou says, his body painted in the street light. “This started months ago, with those bruises around your neck.”

Midoriya stands in the shadows. “I told you, you left those.”

“I don’t leave fucking marks on you,” Bakugou snears, “I never have, I never fucking will.”

“Really?” Midoriya asks, laughing. “Then what are these?

The look on Bakugou’s face when Midoriya lifts his sleeves is an expression he can’t describe. He’s not sure why he showed him; he hasn’t even shown Mama. He just felt so much rage, so much pain, and he wanted Bakugou to feel it too.

He quickly tugs them back down, shame and regret eating at him. Bakugou doesn’t look away from his sleeves, as though those handprints have burnt through the fabric, as though he can still see them. The marks itch suddenly, a recurring pain that never seems to leave him. Especially not now, not when Bakugou looks at him like that.

They don’t say anything to each other for a while. There’s so much to say, but no words to formulate it. It leaves them standing feet apart, their friends laughing and joking far away. He feels entirely separate from that world, from those people. He feels like he’s walked into a new dimension, one where he and Bakugou are still kids together. One where so much has happened and there are no words to describe it.

“My mom,” Bakugou says quietly, a pitch Midoriya has never heard from him. “She’s got an artist who specializes in scar removal. You can get those removed—“

“No.” The sound tears from Midoriya's throat with a speed he didn’t know he had. He’s not sure why he said that, and he doesn’t explain. He just lets it linger in the air, lets it dissolve between them.

Bakugou swallows, rolls his shoulders. “I won’t say anything.”

Midoriya has heard that promise before. Still, he says, “Me neither.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

It’s awkward, tense, and Bakugou stuffs his hands into his pockets before carefully moving around him. He walks out of the alleyway without a single word more. Midoriya takes a moment to collect himself before trailing after.

When he makes it back to the group, Bakugou is as far removed from his as he can be. He walks with Kaminari and Mina, silent as the two of them poke and prod. Midoriya stays with Melissa at the back, hidden behind the others.

She elbows him. “You alright?”

Midoriya nods numbly. “Yeah.”

“Weird question,” she says quietly, leaning closer to him. “Can I get your number?”

Midoriya blinks quickly. “Oh, uh, sure.”

She smiles, takes his outstretched phone. “What did you think about my idea for Viridant’s gear?”

He finally snaps back into reality. “What?”

“The sensors,” she chuckles, “in his suit?”

Midoriya stares at her for a long while. “Do you wanna get out of here?”

Melissa’s brows shoot up. “What?”

“Let’s go somewhere else.” He looks around at the other members of the group. “Let’s go do something fun.”

She lets out a laugh of disbelief, waiting for him to say he’s joking. When he doesn’t, she tucks a strand of her hair away and nods. “Alright, let’s go.”

He tells Ito they’re taking off, handing him the spray cans he stuffed into his bag. His friend raises his brows and gives him a look that Midoriya narrows his eyes at. Banri gives him a thumbs up, and Sayori giggles like an idiot and wiggles her brows.

He pays no attention to it. Instead, he bumps shoulders with Melissa and they head in a different direction. He needs his mind off Bakugou, off those red eyes that he knows are following him and Melissa down the street.

“The sensors,” Midoriya picks up where they left off, mindlessly wandering. “How would you go about installing those?”

Melissa is eager to explain. “You know who Baymax is from that old superhero movie? The fat robot guy?”

“I *hated* that movie,” Midoriya confesses, earning a gasp. “They left the original Baymax all alone in that portal thingy. Younger me was sobbing.”

“Okay, that was pretty sad,” she agrees, laughing a little. “And when the brother died? I almost stopped watching then.”

“I did,” Midoriya says, earning another laugh. “I had to pick it up years later and finish it. Just for the ending to be almost as awful.”

“Well, sorry to say, my Viridant suit design is pretty much Baymax’s scanning AI connected to heat sensors,” she hums, “And… hey, were you and that Bakugou guy dating or something?”

Midoriya chokes. “What?”

“I mean, we’re halfway down the block and he’s still staring at me like I kicked a puppy.” She glances behind her. “I’m pretty sure his hands are smoking.”

Midoriya refuses to look back. “Just ignore him. He’s… I’m not sure what’s wrong with him.”

“If you say so,” she says softly, “So, let’s talk about Viridant’s protection layer.”

“What about it?”

“I couldn’t get too good of a look, but I think he’s using… are you *sure* you weren’t dating that guy?”

Midoriya lets out a long breath before glancing behind him. Bakugou immediately turns and looks in a different direction, but his hands are, in fact, smoking. Seriously? What the hell is his problem?

“We weren’t dating,” Midoriya says stiffly. “We weren’t even friends.”

“Okay—“

“Mellisa!” Rody calls out suddenly, heading over from his place beside Mina. “Hey!”

Midoriya’s eye twitches as the brunette comes rushing over. His colorful little bird has a smug look, and Midoriya sees a fifty-dollar bill clutched in its mouth.

“We got to go,” Roday suddenly says. “Uhh… something came up… with… uhhh, David.”

Melissa’s face immediately morphs into concern. “What? Is everything okay? Did something happen?”

“Yeah, he just needs us home,” Rody says, slinging an arm over her shoulder. “Sorry to take her from you, Mido. But duty calls, you know? David Shield is paying me to be here for school, so when he says his daughter’s gotta come home, then I make sure she does.”

Midoriya again eyes the bird on his shoulder. “Sure.”

“See you around, though.”

“See you.”

“I’ll call you,” Melissa tells him, smiling sweetly. “Goodnight, Midoriya.”

He smiles back. “Goodnight.”

The two of them stalk off, leaving him alone on the sidewalk. He’s not mad, honestly. If Bakugou had offered Midoriya fifty bucks to get Melissa out of here, he’d take it in a

heartbeat. So he doesn't blame Rody. He just wishes he could've talked to her more. She seems incredibly smart and devoted.

When he returns to the group, Banri laughs at him. "It was a good try."

Midoriya shoves him, making Sayori laugh. The remaining group members continue on, joking and poking fun. He sticks by Ito, whom he tries not to question about any of the awful things Bakugou said. He was just trying to get under his skin, trying to ruin a good thing that Midoriya finally managed to land. Just as he always does.

He pops a cigarette from its container, puts it between his lips. As they walk, he stares at Bakugou's back. That large orange X seems to taunt him, as though marking the perfect spot to attack.

Fuck, he's not usually so violent.

"Hey, Mido," Kaminari hangs back to bump off Midoriya's arm. "You've got to tell me how you pissed Bakugou off so bad."

"I breathed," Midoriya says.

Kaminari chuckles, "Okay, but seriously."

"That was serious."

"Nobody's been able to piss Bakugou off like that other than Shinso," Sero says in a whisper. "You should see the two of them showing down. It's like watching two chihuahua's battle for dominance."

Midoriya nibbles his lip, asking, "Who is Shinso?"

"Literally the best person ever," Kaminari sighs wistfully. "A shame you haven't been blessed with his presence."

Sero rolls his eyes. "He's a new kid in our class. Kaminari is obsessed with him; the guy has no idea Kaminari exists."

"That's not true. He said hi to me yesterday."

"Was this before or after Bakugou threw you across the room and you landed on his desk?"

"…Irrelevant."

Midoriya's lips twist up. "Sounds like he's in love with you, you should ask him out."

"Don't egg him on, Mido," Mina calls from the front of the group, side by side with Bakugou. "He's tried, like, 6 or 7 times."

"6 7," Kaminari says, waving his hands up and down.

“What does that mean? What is 6 7?” Midoriya asks.

“Don’t question it, anyway, Kams is too stupid at confessing his love. It’s painful.” Sero laughs out. “He’s way better at rage baiting Bakugou.”

“What is that?” Midoriya asks, a brow lifted, “What is rage baiting?”

“Oh, this is amazing,” Mina says, spinning in circles until she’s at Midoriya’s side. “We get to teach you so many things! This is better than making Kirishima run into walls!”

Midoriya has zero idea what they’re talking about, but nods along as they begin to explain different obscure internet references. He used TikTok for maybe five minutes, learned one thing, and texted it to Hitoshi, and was shut down so fast that he deleted the app immediately. Social media is something he’s never had access to until recently, and he’s found that he’s not the biggest fan of it. Even using Reddit is taboo in his mind, but you do what you need to do to gather information.

While these three UA kids begin explaining bizarre sayings, then laughing whenever Midoriya repeats what they tell him to say, he stares at Bakugou’s back. He walks alone, at the front of the group, silent and staring ahead. His hands are buried deep in his pockets, hood resting against his neck. Midoriya is struck with the awful guilt of taking his friends away, not that he had ever intended to.

He tries to bury that guilt, and when he finally manages to get rid of it, it comes rushing back in at the memory of the look on Bakugou’s face when he’d seen the burn scars. Midoriya really isn’t sure what to make of it, of the way Bakugou’s face had looked. It was the same sort of reaction he had when Midoriya had hit him in the middle school halls. Like he couldn’t possibly believe what was right in front of him.

“Say, ‘I’ve got that dog in me.’” Kaminari directs him, his phone out and recording. “Say it, say it.”

Midoriya takes a drag of his cigarette, laughing a little. “I’ve got that dog in me.”

The three of them cheer and laugh. He truly has no idea what he’s even saying, but they seem to find it hilarious.

“Say it all together, say it all together!” Mina begs, giggling.

Midoriya shakes his head. “You guys are so weird.”

“Say it!” Sero demands.

Midoriya snickers. “6 7 Skibbidi toilet rizz.”

“YEAAAAAAH!” Kaminari screams, grabbing his two friends and jumping up and down. “YEAH YEAH!!!”

He makes eye contact with Ito, who looks like he’s in physical pain hearing all of this. “It’s not even funny, that’s the worst part.”

“Shut up, Ito,” Kaminari shouts. “Okay, now say ‘femboy omega’”

“Do *not* say that,” Banri calls out to him. “You guys need to leave Mido alone, he’s got no idea what you’re making him say.”

“Femboy is a kind of man who—“ Sero starts explaining, coughing when Sayori elbows him. “What? I’m educating him?”

“This is not even close to an education,” Bakugou finally pipes up. “It’s more like fucking mental torture.”

Midoriya rolls his eyes. “Femboy.”

Kaminari laughs so hard that Sero has to help him up off the floor. Bakugou only looks over his shoulder to glare, a warning, and Midoriya keeps his mouth shut. They try to get him to say more, but he won’t jeopardize his deal with Bakugou. But he doesn’t memorize some of the weird things they tell him, just so he can use them later on Eraser Head.

“Pssst,” Kaminari whispers, sliding his phone over to Midoriya. “Give me your number, but keep it lowkey. Bakugou said we weren’t allowed any contact.”

Midoriya takes his phone, responds, “What is a lowkey?”

“Just give me the damn number.” So Midoriya does, careful to give him the right one. “I’ll add you to our group chat. You’ve got to meet the Bakusquad. You’ll love Kiri, he’s so stupid.”

“No one is as stupid as you, baby,” Sero tells him.

“End your life,” Kaminari responds. “Anyway, we do stupid shit every weekend. You should come with us. It’s not always illegal… not *usually* always illegal.”

Midoriya agrees, his heart lighter than it’s been in weeks. “Now tell me about Shinso.”

Sero belts out a laugh and wishes Kaminari good luck before he catches up to Ito and Banri. Mina is gone a moment later, bumping hips with Sayori and talking about how stupid most of the people in this group are. It leaves Midoriya and Kaminari alone, staring off at the others when they arrive at their location. It’s the abandoned building Midoriya first came out of when a Nomu was actually trying to rip him in half. It’s been kept open, its demolition pushed back, to allow for a full investigation of the place.

It’s all over now, though, and the building sits taped off and awaiting its doom. They have to duck under caution tape to get inside, hoods and masks up. The others grab paint and start going ham on the walls, Sayori and Banri chasing each other around with a blue bottle and trying to spray each other.

Midoriya sits on a loose concrete slab, watching this peculiar group of people all get along better than he’d ever expect.

“Well, this guy,” Kaminari starts, drumming his hands on his lap. “He appears outside of our class one day to make fun of Bakugou and get a good look at 1-A. Said he’s unimpressed, that Bakugou is an arrogant dickhead, and it was love at first sight.”

Midoriya smiles softly. “You said he’s in 1-A now?”

“Oh, god, yes,” Kaminari palms his eyes. “I’m going insane sitting next to him. He’s so smart and devoted, you should’ve seen his joint exam. Bakugou still won’t talk about what happened.”

Again, that guilt. Midoriya had promised not to share Bakugou’s secret, but he had wanted Hitoshi to succeed more than he wanted to keep his loyalty to someone who never gave a shit about him. So he didn’t explain why, but he told Hitoshi Bakugou’s greatest secret.

He’s afraid of the dark.

Even now, Bakugou leans against a wall, far removed from the activity. But Midoriya doesn’t miss how he lingers a bit closer to other people, far from the dark shadows of the building. He regrets that he told Hitoshi the truth, and regrets how it was used against Bakugou. Despite all that he’s been through, Midoriya doesn’t wish that torment on anyone else.

“I keep trying to ask him out, but I fuck it up every time. I think that he thinks I’m just trying to be nice, or maybe that I’m an idiot. I don’t know,” Kaminari trails off, watching his friends spray paint penises onto the walls. “Any advice?”

Midoriya looks at Bakugou, the moonlight shining against his face.

“Just tell him outright,” he finally says, looking away. “If he likes you, which I’m certain he does, then you won’t waste any more time guessing. It’s possible that he’s just as clueless about how to approach you as you are him.”

Kaminari gives him a look. “Come on, you really think he’d give me a shot? I’m a total idiot —“

“You aren’t,” Midoriya tells him, gesturing to the group of students around them. “You know how to pick good friends, you know how to pick a good crush. You landed UA, you’re succeeding as a Hero. I don’t think you're dumb at all.”

“I’m blushing, Mido,” Kaminari says, punching his shoulder. “But, seriously, thank you.”

“Don’t waste your time worrying about what could go wrong. He either likes you, or *he’s* an idiot, and that’s that.”

“And that’s that,” Kaminari repeats. “The love guru has spoken.”

Midoriya blinks slowly. “That is—I’m not—“

“THE LOVE GURU HAS SPOKEN!” Kaminari declares, and his group assembles as though he’s activated a code word. “TOMORROW, HITOSHI SHINSO IS MINE!”

“YEAHH!!!!” They all cheer. Midoriya truly doesn’t understand the dynamic here, but he nods like he does.

“Viridant saves the day again,” Banri says bitterly. “This building must have some sort of special Heroism effect. Saved a student's love life, and threw a Nomu off the roof.”

Midoriya says, at the exact same time Bakugou does, “That was a different building.”

Silence falls, then Sayori grins. “Uh oh, a new challenger has arrived.”

“Challenger?” Mina snickers, “Bakugou knows Viridant inside and out.”

“Mido is our resident genius,” Ito pipes up, “Anything and everything there is to know about Viridant, he’s already heard it.”

“I call a duel!” Sero shouts, hands in the air. “Team Bakugou Katsuki, versus team Midoriya Izuku!”

“What?” Bakugou snaps. “This is the stupidest thing I’ve ever heard.”

“I agree,” Midoriya says, probably the first time he’s ever said that to Bakugou. “This is—“

“I *obviously* know everything about Viridant,” Bakugou interrupts him, “I’m practically a fucking expert.”

“Ooo, you gonna let him get away with that, Mido?” Sayori asks, snickering.

Midoriya thinks this is the stupidest fight he could possibly have right now. Bakugou likely knows nothing about Viridant, only trying to get a gain in this argument. But Midoriya? He literally *is* Viridant. There’s no possible way to lose this battle. It would be ridiculous to fight over this.

“I’ve been studying Viridant for months,” Midoriya says, a coy smile on his face. “Sorry, *Kacchan,* I think I’ve got you beat.”

Bakugou grins. “Green eyes, 5”8, male.”

Midoriya’s blood thrums as he shoots back. “Teenager, lower income, broke into UA.”

Bakugou’s eyes narrow, but it’s Kaminari who says, “Shit, I didn’t even know that. Is that where he got that scarf from? I thought it looked familiar.”

“*Applied* to UA,” Bakugou shoots back.

Midoriya has no clue how he knows that. Maybe Aizawa mentioned it after reviewing the UA footage.

“Applied, rejected, then went and cleaned up Musutafu’s beach.” Midoriya offers him a smirk. “Did you know that one?”

“Oooh,” Mina whispers, “That was attractive.”

“Shut up,” Bakugou snips at her. “Has a conspirator.”

More gasps and *ooo*’s. It makes sense that Bakugou was able to piece that together, always so far ahead of his peers. It must’ve clicked in his mind the moment Midoriya got access to UA.

“Has *two* conspirators,” Midoriya shoots back.

“No way,” Sero mumbles. “How do you know that?”

Bakugou’s eyes are narrowed, his lips curled. “Viridant hates All Might.”

“He hates All For One more.”

“Who is that?” Ito asks.

But Bakugou’s eyes flicker. “How the hell do you know that?”

Midoriya shrugs. “Are you giving up?”

“Fuck no,” Bakugou grinds out. “Viridant got stabbed, twice.”

Someone sprays the wall, writes both of their names, and a few tally marks below each one.

“Viridant knows the truth about All Might.”

Again, Bakugou’s eyes flicker with curiosity. Or rage. Midoriya can never really tell. A point is sprayed under his name.

“Viridant is…” Bakugou’s eyes flicker to Midoriya’s shoes, then back to his eyes. “Uhh… he’s fifteen.”

“You’re kidding!” Banri scoffs, “He’s our age!”

Midoriya really needs to check what the news has reported on. He had no idea any of this was public information.

“Viridant has contact with Eraser Head,” Midoriya shoots at him.

Bakugou huffs. “He’s got contact with *all* Pros.”

How does he know that? Is UA really so bad at keeping information from students?

“One of his contacts is a UA student.”

More gasps, whispers, and a point is sprayed onto the wall. Bakugou opens his mouth, shuts it, and when he comes up with nothing, Midoriya is crowned the winner. Money is passed around, as apparently bets had been placed. Midoriya can’t help the bit of smugness inside him; pulling a win over Bakugou isn’t easy, not by any means.

He takes a photo of the scoreboard, hearing a snort behind him.

“Little victories get you going, nerd?”

Midoriya glances over his shoulder, eyeing where Bakugou approached from. Everyone else has begun passing out pot and alcohol. It leaves the two of them alone on the other side of the room.

“Against you?” Midoriya questions, “Always.”

Bakugou eyes the chart. “How’d you know half that shit, anyway?”

“Common sense?”

“No,” Bakugou immediately snaps back at him. “All for One? All Might’s true form? You just happened to figure out about that?”

Midoriya doesn’t look at him. “So what if I did?”

“I don’t fucking buy it,” Bakugou argues back at him. “Is there… is there some sort of online chat room?”

… huh?

“For… you know.” Bakugou gestures to Midoriya.

“What are you talking about?” Midoriya asks, arms crossed.

“Listen,” Bakugou sucks in a tight breath, whispers, “Viridant’s Quirkless.”

Midoriya’s blood runs cold. “How do you know about that?”

“See? You *do* know something,” Bakugou hisses. “His shoes are a dead giveaway.”

His face burns red. “So?”

“So,” Bakugou says slowly, patronizing, “Is there some sort of secret fucking online form or something? Have the two of you talked?”

Midoriya isn’t sure what’s more offensive: the fact that Bakugou had assumed that two Quirkless people simply *must* know each other, or that there’s no possible way Midoriya could ever be Viridant. The thought likely hasn’t ever crossed Bakugou’s mind. If it had, for even a moment, then Bakugou could piece it together. He’s smart enough to do it.

But Midoriya will never not be this weak, fragile thing in Bakugou’s brain.

So, why not fuck with him?

“What I do in my free time,” Midoriya says through a smile. “Isn’t any of your business, Kacchan.”

He swears to god, Bakugou's eyes nearly fall out of his head from how wide they are. "You've talked to Viridant?"

Midoriya snorts. "So what if I have?"

Bakugou opens his mouth, and at that exact moment, a flashlight shines through the front windows of the warehouse. "Chou City police! This is private property!"

Uh oh.

"Run!" Sayori shouts, and they all take off in different directions.

Kaminari throws himself through a window, Mina chasing after him. Ito sprints to take cover in random debris and boxes, cursing and dragging Sero behind him. He's unsure where the hell Sayori and Banri end up, and he doesn't question it as he sprints for the stairs.

He knows this building pretty damn well after literally almost dying in it. When the front door gets kicked down, he wastes no time going for the stairs to the roof. He pushes through the open door, and only when it shuts behind him does he realise he isn't alone.

Bakugou picks up a spare pipe, jams it between the door handle and frame. When someone starts throwing themselves at it a moment later, it holds strong. That would've been helpful two weeks ago! Or maybe not, since the Nomu could bend a manhole cover in half.

"Why did you follow me?" Midoriya squeaks out.

Bakugou glares at him. "It's not my fucking fault that you ran here! The idea was mine first."

"How could you possibly be arguing with me right now?!" Midoriya whisper-yells.

"Because you're being an idiot!" Is Bakugou's response.

The door shakes. "Open this now! You're trespassing on private property!"

The two of them look at each other, look at the ground below. Then Bakugou whips his head to the building beside it.

"Come on," he says, yanking Midoriya's arm. "Let's go."

"What—"

"Do you want to end up in jail, Deku? Let's fucking go!" Bakugou grinds out. "Follow me."

He watches as Bakugou takes a running jump off the edge of the building, landing precisely where Midoriya had weeks ago. There must've been someone filming, maybe even a news station or civilian across the street, because Bakugou perfectly executes the way Viridant had climbed in his escape.

Midoriya follows, red shoes landing on window sills and balconies until they pull themselves onto a roof. The door finally busts down, and five officers flood the paneling. They look around, peer over the edges, and, with mass amounts of confusion, they go back inside.

He's still staring at the empty rooftop when Bakugou says, "We can go around the next building. From there, we can get higher ground, or we can take a side ladder down to the street."

How many times has Bakugou watched the news footage to know Viridant's pathing with perfect clarity? Even in the dark.

"Deku, did you fucking hear me?"

Midoriya turns to him then, his brows furrowed. "Are you some kind of fan or something?"

Bakugou scoffs. "Of what?"

"Viridant," Midoriya says, jerking a hand out to the building. "How did you know his exact path?"

Bakugou opens his mouth, shuts it, opens it again. "I—fuck, yeah, I'm a fucking fanatic. Can we go now?"

"He's Quirkless."

And Bakugou says, with audacity Midoriya has seen before. "So?"

So?

"You bullied me for *years* for being Quirkless." Midoriya grips his own chest. "And, what, Viridant gets a free fucking pass?"

Bakugou holds his arms out at his sides. "What the fuck do you want from me? Do you want me to make some tweets online about it? Gather a fucking rally?"

"A little consistency would be nice!" Midoriya shouts at him.

Thunder sounds distantly, sprinkles of rain beginning to drop.

"Consistency?" Bakugou laughs out, "You want to talk about fucking consistency?" Clouds gather in the sky, darkness falling over the town as the moon hides behind them. "You haven't been the same since the beginning of this year! I don't even know who I'm looking at right now."

Midoriya can hardly believe what he's hearing. "Are you kidding me? This is *me,* this is how I've always been! *You're* the one who changed! Viridant's fanboy? A Quirkless guy's fucking fanboy?"

The sprinkle turns into an outright pouring. Rain pelts down harshly, unrelenting.

“You’re pissed that I’m not shitting on him?” Bakugou says, lips parted into a grin. “You’re mad that I’m not hating on another Quirkless person?”

And he realizes that Bakugou is right. Never, ever, not in a million years would Midoriya wish the kind of torment he endured onto someone else. But this *isn’t* someone else. This is him. And it’s a version of him that Bakugou knows nothing about, but that he still cares for more than he ever cared for Midoriya.

So he is mad. He’s fucking enraged. How is it fair that Viridant gets some magical, golden stamp of approval with *everyone?* Where does Midoriya fall short that the vigilante doesn’t? Why does Viridant get the fan base, get the offer to UA, get the admiration that Midoriya has been chasing for years? Why does Viridant get that?

If Bakugou Katsuki truly admires Viridant, if he truly doesn’t care that he has no Quirk, then that means everything Midoriya went through is for nothing. It was never about his Quirk; it was about *him.* It was about making his life hell for *nothing.* He got rejected from UA, he got pushed away from All Might, he lost his best friend, for absolutely nothing.

“Why me?” he asks.

Thunder claps, lightning strikes.

“What?”

Midoriya blinks rain out of his eyes. “Why me? If it was never about my Quirk, then what was it?”

Bakugou breathes heavily. But he doesn’t answer.

“What’s the difference, Kacchan? Because I’m at a loss here.” He holds his arms out wide, letting Bakugou see all of him. “What does he have that I don’t? Why does he get no grief when you’ve been giving it to me for years? Why me?”

And Bakugou says, his voice mixing with the rain, “He’s a Hero.”

A Hero.

Lightning and thunder. Rain pouring down from the clouds. It soaks through their hair and clothes. It dances along the concrete rooftop. It slickens and darkens the roads below. It washes away the people they once were.

“I’ve been going to therapy,” Bakugou tells him, his eyes nearly glowing in the night air.

Midoriya doesn’t know what to say. So he says nothing at all.

“I’m doing better,” Bakugou says. “I’m getting better.”

“Why now?” Midoriya asks. “What changed?”

“I did.”

They stare at each other.

“Do you regret it at all?” Midoriya whispers, the sky brightening with lightning.

Bakugou doesn’t answer, and it seems to be much darker than it was before. So Midoriya retreats to the edge of the building, deciding he’ll take the window sills down to the street. He hopes the rain covers the streaks of tears running down his face, the sound of his heart splintering in his chest.

“I’m happy for you, Kacchan.” He turns to him one more time. “I hope you get everything you’ve ever wanted.”

“Deku—“

Midoriya slides down to the windowsill. His shoes scrape against brick as he drops down to the next level. When he finally hits the floor, he wastes not a second longer walking away. He never did manage to search around for his missing backpack items. With this weather, all possible remnants of his belongings will be washed away.

He leaves Bakugou on the roof. Despite the eyes he feels burning into his back, Midoriya doesn’t turn around. Not even to say goodbye.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 26: Intel is a privledge

Chapter Summary

Midoriya visits a buddy in jail and learns new info

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Ground Zero: Can you do me a favor, Greenie?

Viridant: Depends.

Ground Zero: Keep out of trouble this weekend, can you manage that? I'm going away for a few days, I can't help you if anything goes wrong.

Viridant: Aye aye Captain.

Ground Zero: See? Is it so hard not to cause chaos?

Viridant: I am going to bomb you.

Ground Zero: What the fuck, Greenie?

Midoriya snickers, enjoying messing with Ground Zero. The two of them have been conversing more than usual. In the absence of Hitoshi, Midoriya has learned that not everything he does has to be surrounded by misery and loss. Is he still upset? More than anything. But he's doing better, and it's all on his own.

Definitely not because he's been thinking about Kacchan. Bakugou—he means Bakugou.

Oh, who is he kidding anymore? It's Kacchan, it's always been Kacchan.

Truth is, he's been thinking about that night. He can't help the sick feeling in his stomach when he reflects on Kacchan's admiration for Viridant, but… but it's drowned under a wave of relief. He feels guilty about being mad at Kacchan, and even though it still irks him, he's begun to calm down.

And, maybe, he's a bit smug about the whole thing. Kacchan admires *him*. It might not be Midoriya in his mind, but it's Midoriya in his rawest form. His beliefs, his ideals, his personality, and Kacchan can't get enough of it. It's bittersweet in a way, knowing Kacchan supports him one way and despises him the other.

But even then, Midoriya isn't sure that's true. Kacchan was… different. Still angry, still violent, but quieter, too. The Kacchan he knew would've never reacted like that to his burn scars, but Midoriya can finally place the look on his face. Horror. Pure, genuine horror.

So, even if Kacchan hasn't asked for it, Midoriya has already begun to forgive him. Maybe he doesn't regret what he put Midoriya through, maybe he doesn't care about him, maybe he's half of what he claims to be, but Midoriya can't help but want a Hero in his life again. And Kacchan is starting to go down that path.

So he lets go. He doesn't hold onto what happened to him before. It still scares him, still angers him, but he keeps thinking about that haunted look on Kacchan's face… and it all feels… better.

No more feeling sorry for himself. People change, they grow, they move on. And he's going to do the exact same.

Ground Zero: I'm serious about this, Greenie. Promise me you'll keep your word. We can return to our regularly scheduled bullshit next week, but just this weekend, I need room to breathe.

Midoriya rolls his eyes.

Viridant: I pinky promise.

Ground Zero: Wow. A pinky promise? I'm fucking honored.

Viridant: You know, Eraser Head is going out of town this weekend too. If I didn't know better, I'd say the two of you are plotting against me.

There's a long, drawn-out pause, then another message.

Ground Zero: You caught us.

Midoriya snickers.

Viridant: I'll keep out of trouble. All my partners in crime are leaving me out :(

Ground Zero: Taste of your own medicine for not inviting me out TWO TIMES IN A ROW!

Viridant: Whoopsie.

Ground Zero: I'm gonna whoopsie your ass, dickhead. No matter what, let me come with you next time.

Viridant: I'll think about it.

Ground Zero: Asshole.

And when he feels like he's ready for it, which he's certain he finally is, he sends another message.

AM: Have fun at your training camp this week, Hitoshi.

He doesn't get a reply; he never does. But that's okay. He doesn't need one, not really. Hitoshi might've just been using him, but he was a friend when no one else was. So Midoriya holds no ill will in his heart, not even when he wants to.

The training camp was supposed to happen after the UA sports festival, but that event was pushed to the spring instead. Apparently, there weren't enough students to warrant the public match, so tickets go on sale in January instead. Midoriya debated buying one, but he's not certain he'll want to attend yet. He'll have to see what comes of the new year. Soon, he'll have to make a choice, one he isn't much prepared for.

For now, he does exactly as he promised. He stays out of trouble.

Mostly.

He's been working on this new laptop for nearly a month now, and he's proud to say, he thinks it'll be able to withstand any potential virus that could be on the flash drive he has that's full of the information provided to him via the Nomu tunnels. He's still got a bit more details to hammer out, like where he'll access the flash drives' information that isn't near people but also has wifi if needed, but he's pretty much set. So, while Ground Zero is out this weekend doing who knows what, and Eraser Head supervises UA kids hours away, Midoriya will work on recovering case information.

Se? He can be good.

But before he does that… he holds a fake ID in his hand, staring down at the profile he and Ito had worked so hard to photoshop. A wig, new colored contacts, and hyper-realistic facial hair has done Midoriya good at completely changing his identity. Even better, more practice at coding, and this ID has legs. Scan it, and it'll bring up enough legal information to pass any test. For a little bit, at least. Any digging that goes below the surface is another story.

But for now, this new person he can become will get him very, very far.

To Chou City county jail, in fact. He hadn't gotten what he needed when he last came to the city, so he'll get it now. And Ground Zero can't even be mad! Midoriya is here as a citizen checking in on his jailed friend. Not Viridant trying to solve a crime. Not that these people can tell, at least.

He gets patted down at the jail's front entrance. He made sure to stash his backpack a few blocks away, only his fake ID coming with him past the front doors. He goes through background checks, metal detectors, and security checkpoints. Not a single ounce of nerves wracks him; his trust in Ito's work outweighs the potential breach. All for good reason, because he makes it through.

Visiting hours for the jail are almost over, so he has to make this quick.

He's guided by a few officers into an empty room with circular tables. There are vending machines against one wall, a line of bared windows on the other. Two officers guard either

door, watching him with zero expression. Jails are breeding grounds for violence, often making criminals worse coming out than they were going in. The justice system has always been flawed, and jails are a prime example of what violence can create.

But he won't deny that what happens to some of the sick individuals in here is nothing less than what they deserve. When a woman is yanked from behind solid metal doors and shoved into the room with him, he feels no pity for her ruined appearance. Split lip, crooked jaw and nose, a black eye that he's certain will follow her for the rest of her time here. He feels nothing for her, especially not when she casts him that same lazy grin she had when he first knocked on her door months ago.

She's far different than the woman with a cigarette hanging from her lips, a baseball bat slung over her shoulder. She looks awful in her tan jumpsuit, the color horrific against her rich skin. She sits down in front of him wordlessly, hands bound in front of her.

"Well, hello," she says smoothly, her Japanese laced with an accent that Midoriya can't place. "Are you here to break me out?"

A guard at the door shifts uncomfortably.

Midoriya says, "Hardly. I'm here to ask you some questions."

She laughs softly. "They let anyone in here to ask questions?" She leans forward, dark eyes pinning him. "My fans would love to hear that."

"Your fans are a bunch of men on the internet who get off on women who kill children. I'm sure they'd absolutely love to see you in person," Midoriya replies coldly, watching a bit of the fire in her eyes die off. "Consider yourself lucky that I'm not one of them."

The woman, named Yuuka, leans back a little. "To what do I owe the pleasure?"

Midoriya isn't entirely sure where to start. There's so much he wants to cover, so little time to do it. He's certain that his visit here will notify any authorities. It's for that reason that he wore such a heavy disguise and full coverage clothing. He even went as far as to buy foundation shades lighter than his skin tone and paint himself in it. He won't risk his identity being leaked on prison cams, and he knows he can't make a second trip here without risk.

Eraser Head isn't in town. That's why he tried this at all.

"I assume you've already been questioned about the tunnels?" Midoriya asks, watching her smile widen. "So I won't bore you with questions on why you participated in it."

She tells him anyway, "Because I liked it."

"Better than you like being beaten in a jail cell, I'd bet," he shoots back.

Her eye twitches. "Much, much better." Her Quirk suppressant cuffs clack as she rests her hands on the table's smooth top. "What's your name?"

"Fumihiro," he lies, stating the name in his ID. "I have more questions."

“Then ask them, Fumihiro,” she whispers, biting at him. “I’d love to hear them.”

Gross. “Were you waiting for All for One to rescue you? Or have you realized yet that he’s not going to save you?”

Her smile droops. “How do you know about that?”

“How *don’t* you know about that?” Midoriya retorts, laughing at her. “You seemed at least a little smart, maybe I was wrong?”

“You’re trying to piss me off to get information out of me,” Yuuka says sweetly. “I’m an open book, Fumihiro, no need to provoke me.”

“Then tell me.” He pops a hand on a fist. “This is such an intriguing story.”

So she explains. Midoriya lets her talk, nodding along and asking questions as she goes. But the story isn’t far off from what he expected. Her behavior thus far has given him a general idea about the truth, as has the police report detailing her arrest. She truly is an open book, so unafraid of consequences that she doesn’t mind sharing her actions. She believes, beyond a shadow of doubt, that she is going to be broken out of this jail.

She has no idea that All for One doesn’t leave trails, much less bodies. She won’t last until the end of the month; it’s a miracle she’s gone this far. But there must be a reason he’s kept her alive, so Midoriya came to visit.

“I was just like them, you know,” she confesses, giggling as she does. “Stupid, hopeful, convinced this city was a great idea. My Quirk—it was miserable. It put me through excruciating pain, my blood made from literal acid. Can you imagine?”

“So, when someone offered to change it,” he prompts.

“Of course I took the deal.” And she seems unaware that Quirks are designed for each user. It might hurt, which is an unlucky side effect, but she wasn’t designed for anything other than that. “And my pain was gone, replaced by euphoria.”

Literally, euphoria. Every time she lied, a rush of hormones would course through her. She was practically addicted to the feeling, lost herself in the chase for the next good feeling. This was an easy job for her, taking people in, lying about their safety. Stay silent as they were wiped out.

There’s no doubt in his mind that she could’ve been a good, genuine person. If every human with a villainous Quirk were really so wrong, then the world would be overrun. But it isn’t, because that’s just another rumor spread to keep those with power in power. He doesn’t need to say any of that, though. Yuuka is well aware of the dynamics of this world. An active Quirk rights protestor, someone who spoke up for Quirk therapy and safety rights. She was, undoubtedly, picked as a message.

Midoriya just can’t seem to figure out who it was for.

“Even better,” she leans forward, her eyes bright, “He’d let me watch.”

And that—that is something he didn't know. "Let you watch what?"

Yuuka bites her lip. "Watch as they wiped them all out. Carved them apart. Built those monsters. Stuffed the bodies into tunnels. I got to watch it, and it was almost as good as knowing I caused it."

Disgust boils in his core, hatred echoing in his mind. "They let you stand there and observe?"

She lets out a loud, squawking laugh before leaning closer and whispering, "Oh, you don't know, do you, Viridant?"

His heart drops, but he keeps his face carefully blank.

"The whole place was *filled* with cameras. Dozens of them. You wouldn't know because you never bothered to try and look. A stupid move, on your part, for someone so tech savvy you'd think you'd take an extra moment to check, wouldn't you?" Yuuka's cracked lips pull into a horrible smile. "You don't seem to know anything at all. You're just a child."

"Please step away from the prisoner, sir," a guard calls out, glaring at Yuuka. "She tends to bite."

Midoriya doesn't listen. Anger lines his bones, fills the space between his lungs.

"You're going to die in here," he whispers quietly. "All for One isn't coming for you; no one is."

"How would you know?" she asks him, taunting.

Midoriya leans in, inches away. "My dad doesn't let loose ends live."

The blood drains from her face, her eyes going wide. He steps away when she launches herself at him, guards grabbing her by her Quirk suppressants and yanking her backwards. She screams, thrashes. But even she can't deny the resemblance he has to All for One. Even with a wig, with contacts, with pale skin, he will always be his father's son.

"You have no idea what's coming for you, boy!" she screams, jerking against the men who drag her away. "You have no idea what they're going to do to you!"

Midoriya watches her go, offers her a smile through the bulletproof glass on the walls. It doesn't waver, not even when she slams her head against it, blood spattering.

"You'll rot in hell with all the rest of them!" The words tear from her chest, can be heard through the thick walls. "Another fucking zombie!"

When he checks out the prison, he dumps his disguise pretty quickly. He wouldn't normally reveal such confident information, but that itch to break and destroy, that awful trait passed down through his DNA—it tends to get what it wants. And it wanted Yuuka to shake like a dog as she waited for her death.

Because she will. She will sit in a jail cell with nothing more than ecstasy-riddled memories when someone comes to take her life. Her lies won't save her then, not when they bleed her dry, and not after, when her name is erased from the world and forgotten. She will die as she lived, a worthless, hollow bystander. Another body laid to eternity without so much as a flower atop her gravestone.

He feels no guilt. He hopes Dad takes his time, hopes she lingers in her cell, stays awake at night, horrified that someone will smother her in her sleep. She'd be lucky if that's how they did it, and she knows it, too. Jail is a disgusting, horrible place, and it's nothing short of what she deserves.

He thinks of that little girl, her stolen eyes. He will avenge her, and it starts here.

The news comes the next day. Yuuka didn't last more than three hours after his visit. He doesn't care, doesn't even think about it. Instead, he dives into his work.

The foolproof laptop glares at him. Its bright screen is an eyesore in the empty parking lot he's landed himself in. He connects to a nearby cafe but enables his location on the device. He wants to make sure the store doesn't go down for his stupidity, so he lets his location stay active as he plugs the thumb drive into the side of it.

He stands back, just in case his program doesn't work and the device self-destructs. It takes a good twenty minutes for all of the information to download on the beat-up laptop. But, good news, it didn't explode. Yet, at least.

He approaches again, squats down to the asphalt floor. Clicking around the screen reveals a singular folder, filled to the absolute brim with data. It took up nearly every ounce of storage in the uncluttered device. This could take days to sort, so he supposes it's good he started now. He's got a very long night ahead of him.

The first file he clicks is a video. When the camera flickers to life, it reveals an empty Nomu room. There are no tanks, no wires, just a short man sitting in a chair, staring at the camera. Midoriya recognizes him immediately. It's the Quirk doctor, the one who diagnosed him as a child. Midoriya understands now how his Mama was unable to hide the results of his testing from Dad. This asshole gave him up the second he could.

Dad wanted a child with a Quirk. Midoriya still isn't sure why; he's not sure he ever will be, but that's one fundamental truth about Dad that he knows. He wanted a Quirked kid, and when he didn't get one, he tried to hurt Mama. He's not sure what stopped Dad that night, not sure why he didn't kill her then. But for whatever reason, he left the house, left him and Mama alone, thinking she was too weak to do anything.

It will be his biggest mistake.

For now, Midoriya reviews the video files. It seems to be daily updates and cataloguing. The doctor talks about his creation plan, documents the steps and procedures so completely that Midoriya could recreate everything he's been doing if he truly wanted to. It's for that reason alone that Midoriya will ensure this data is never retrievable by anyone else. He will not turn

this over to the Pros; he will not keep it for himself. He will wipe it off the internet with the hopes that this can never occur again, especially not when placed in the hands of the mighty.

So he watches. He doesn't look away as the doctor works, as he thoroughly documents the people he ruins. He doesn't look away as the doctor fills the tanks with preserving liquid, as he stitches corpses together like Frankenstein. As he drags people, one by one, into his study room and dissects them while they still kick and scream. As he holds that little girl down, cuts her eyes out of her head, and lets the blood loss slowly kill her.

Things don't stop, don't slow down. This lab predates the creation of this underground city by years, and this doctor has been operating the entire system. It's awful, horrible, and Midoriya doesn't allow himself to look away. He reads through hundreds of journal entries, observes thousands of failed experiments. Watches Nomus come to life through the eyes of another.

And when it's done, he accesses the cameras. They only came into existence when the city did, documenting daily life. There's a hard cut already previously made in the footage that erases the actual extermination from view. But it picks back up with a motion sensor of him pushing the manhole cover out of his way. They'd been watching him since the beginning. Walking the tunnels, talking to people, they've been observing him.

It takes two days to come to the end of the files. He told Mama he was staying with his friends or working the entire weekend, giving him the space to live and breathe in this empty, sectioned-off parking lot.

He opens the last video. It's the doctor again, mustache hanging over his lip, big eyes staring openly into the lens.

"I'm not too sure which one of you will see this first," he says, voice grainy. "But whether it is Tomura or the vigilante is the last thing I care about. What I care about is the success of our mission and the return of my test subjects. I need stronger Nomu's, one that can outlast a measly explosion."

Midoriya swallows harshly. They knew he was coming, knew he'd self-destruct the Nomu room. Well, him—or whoever the hell Tomura is.

"I think I've got a good few kids in mind," the doctor says, smiling suddenly. "Don't you? I don't need to breach your city at all, UA picks them for me."

A final message, and Midoriya knows it well. His hands shake, his eyes wide. He rushes home, stashes his laptop. His promise to Ground Zero shatters and breaks as he pulls on his gear, rushes to the training camp.

Because the league of villains is after the UA students, and Midoriya happens to know one who could survive a thousand explosions over again.

Chapter End Notes

Teehee

Chapter 27: Breaking the seal

Chapter Summary

Midoriya save Kota :)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The camp is on fire. There were no text messages, no calls. He arrives at the sound of screams and the smell of smoke. It's been years since he's stared at a fire like this, since he's bared witness to a tragedy as it actively happened. But he looks over it now, stares at the blue-infested woods. Somewhere in there are children, are Heroes, are people who did not ask to be part of a war.

He calls Eraser Head and gets no answer. He calls Hitoshi and gets no answer. He calls to the moon and stars and they look down at him, asking him what he's going to do next.

He doesn't know.

He doesn't know what to do.

He's not a Hero, he doesn't know what to do.

But he knows how to try. So he launches himself into the flames, and he does just that. He tries.

He lands somewhere dark, smoky. A roaring can be heard from miles away, the sound of a deep scream rattling in his bones. He retreats from the treeline and immediately bumps off someone else. The two of them whip around at the same time, ready to swing, before freezing completely.

Class 1-A student, Uraraka Ochaco, is dripping blood. A cut on her face, slashes down her stomach, she truly looks awful. He steadies her when she nearly falls, demanding answers, and she collapses in response. Midoriya drags her deeper into the woods, pushes her body into thick brush, and covers her with leaves and branches.

When he steps back out again, he sees the cause of her blood loss.

"I knew you'd be here!" He stares at the schoolgirl, a mask adorning her face that looks nearly identical to his own. "I can't believe it! Dabi said you likely wouldn't show, but I told him! I said, Viridant will go wherever trouble is. And look! I was right!"

“What did you do?” Midoriya’s voice shakes, his modulator hiding the bulk of his fear. “What have you done?”

The girl flips her knife in her hand. “Just collected, that’s all. I don’t want to kill anyone, if that’s what you're asking.”

And it’s impossible to deny that she seems… calmer than last time. Not sane, not by any means, but not out of her mind with blood lust. She must’ve eaten, must’ve used her Quirk, must’ve lost the pent-up aggression that comes with suppressing it. Her eyes are withdrawn, still an unusual yellow, but guilt-riddled.

She confesses, “Bad things will happen soon, Viridant. I’m grateful a Hero is finally here.”

He balls his hands into fists. “You know what I have to do? Don’t you? You know I need to restrain you, turn you in—“

“Yeah,” she says softly, “I know. But I just thought I should tell you first—I’m sorry. About what I did in the alley—it wasn’t me, you know that, don’t you? I was just… I was just so hungry.” Her knife shakes in her hand. “Some cops picked me up, held me for a few days just because they didn’t like the looks of me. I was already low on my bags, but they wouldn’t feed me any. I was freshly rescued when I came across you.”

Midoriya says, his voice harsh, “Did you eat those people in the underground city?”

Her guilt turns to anger. “I’d never do such a thing! I-I don’t mean to hurt anyone! They hurt *me.* Why doesn’t anyone get that? Why does nobody understand?” She wipes at her eyes. “It only means that I love them, can’t they see that?”

He breathes heavily, looking around the inflamed woods. “You really don’t mean to hurt anyone?”

“Nobody,” she claims.

“Then help me,” he says, voice rough. “Tell me where to go. Where am I needed?”

The girl looks around, glances up at the sky, then back to him. “There are some among us who aren’t supposed to be here. They’ll kill anyone they come across.”

“Where? How many?”

“Two.” She points behind him with her knife, then to her right. “One in the mountains, one in the woods. Make your choice, Viridant.” She retreats, shoving her knife into a holster. “Don’t let them catch you.”

He turns, starts running. The woods are full of smoke, near impossible to navigate. He’d do better with higher ground and can make something of the vantage point. He’d be able to see the whole camp if he got higher up, and a sadistic villain is somewhere up there. He needs to help, and he will. There’s no time to waste on a teenage girl who can’t help her reaction to her Quirk.

Midoriya races through trees and terrain. He scales walls, follows trails to the rumble and shake of a mountain. This was supposed to be safe. This training camp—these students, they were supposed to be safe. He tells Rin to call Eraser Head, to call Hitoshi, but he again gets no response.

How did the villains know about the camp? Is there a spy? Or are they just as vigilant as Viridant is? Did he leave holes in UA's defense by mistake? How did this get out? The doctor hinted that they were going after Kacchan, a fate Midoriya can't bear to lie witness to. But how did they know about Kacchan at all?

He messed up, somewhere along the way. Midoriya must've messed up. The league has attacked UA kids twice now, and he can't help but feel as though this time it's his fault. Maybe he left a backdoor in his code, or he blew a hole through a firewall he shouldn't have. Or—

The mountain rattles and shakes, debris ripping from the study walls and streaming downwards. Midoriya keeps his path, cursing at the lack of support for his scarf to grab onto. If he could just find something to grab, anything to grab. Smoke fills the air, hovering over the forest like a thick blanket. It leaves him nearly blind as he goes higher, searching and searching.

And then, a scream. This time, it's from a small, young child. Midoriya hits the flat siding of the mountain. What was once a lookout point is now a meeting point between a young boy and a gigantic man. His entire body is red, throbbing, as though he's made out of muscle fibers. Closer inspection reveals just that—the man *is* made entirely from muscle mass. Thick, dense cords of anatomy wrap around his body.

It leaves only his blond head poking out, his singular eye wide and manic. Before the villain is a small boy. He's got a red hat with horns, a pair of shorts, and a small shirt. He trembles horribly, crying, both arms out and pointed at the villain. Water shoots from the kid's palms, his only defense.

This must be the child of those two Pros who died ages ago. Their death was stuck on the news for weeks. It was horrific, brutal, and it left behind their only son.

And when the villain raises a muscular arm, Midoriya moves before he thinks. He won't let another child die; he won't stand by while those who are defenseless are wiped out. His support item reaches out, wraps around the kid's waist, and yanks him back so quickly that his hat flies off. Not a moment too late, as the villain slams his hand down with the intent to spatter the child's body on the mountain's harsh rock. Just like that, the boy would've been dead. Nothing more than guts and limbs…

Just like the bodies in the tunnel. What was it that the girl had said? That there are two people here who aren't on the league's side? Two people who are violent, set to kill. And this is one of them. He must've been responsible for the carnage in the tunnels. Ground Zero had said the bodies were torn apart, and here stands one of the only people Midoriya knows who could be strong enough to do that.

The kid sobs, hitting Midoriya when he's pulled from the blast. Debris covers them for now, but Midoriya doesn't have time to waste. This kid won't stop attacking him, assuming he's evil. He's scared, trembling, so—

So Midoriya takes off his mask. He tugs it up onto his head, pulls down his mouth cover. He reveals his face, meeting the little boy's dark eyes.

"It's ok, it's ok," Midoriya whispers, slowly releasing his support tool. "You're safe."

The boy breathes heavily. "You can't beat him, he's too strong."

"Go back to camp," Midoriya tells him, tugging his helmet off. "Keep calling for help, do you understand me?"

"I—"

"What's your name?" Midoriya shoves the helmet down on the boy's head. It's a bit too big, clunky, and large on the small child, but it'll keep him safe. He flicks the side switch, activating night vision, before adding his face mask on next. No smoke inhalation, full access to Eraser Head.

"Kota."

"Listen to me, Kota," Midoriya demands, his voice soft but stern. "You tell the AI, her name is Rin, you tell her to call Eraser Head. Tap the left side twice, and it'll send your location. Do you understand me?"

The boy shakes his head. "You'll die—"

"You don't ever stop running, okay? Avoid the woods, keep on the trail, and get yourself back to camp."

"Where are you, kiddo?" A deep, masculine voice calls. "Where did you run off to?"

Midoriya holds the kid's shoulders, squeezes. "You have to be a Hero, do you understand me? You have to be brave." The kid shakes his head again, and Midoriya shakes him lightly. "You can't stay here, it's too dangerous."

"You aren't a Hero," Kota tells him, his voice gravelly with the modulator. "You won't win."

"You're right, I'm not a Hero," Midoriya tells him, knowing that a Hero is the last thing this child needs. "I'm someone who doesn't give up, who fights until the evil is gone. I'm no Hero."

Kota trembles. "What's your name?"

Midoriya smiles reassuringly before wrapping his support weapon around the kid's waist again. "Viridant."

He throws his weapon out, the kid screaming as Midoriya dangles him off the cliff. He works quickly, lowering the weapon as fast as he can, more and more, until Kota's shoes touch the bottom of the cliff. Only then does he let the child go. He's met kids like that before—shit, he *was* that kid. They never know when to run away, too hell bent on trying to save someone, on trying to change the fate of someone who has already passed.

Midoriya won't risk it.

"Caught ya!"

He grunts as a muscular arm wraps around his own and throws him full force into the rocky wall of the mountain. Pain shoots down his back and arms. His head nearly hits the stone, which would've been actual hell without his helmet. His temporary hair dye is covered in dust and debris, blood and bruises bubbling to the surface of his skin.

"Where'd the little shit go, huh?" The man asks him, muscles growing larger, denser. "Did I knock him off?"

Midoriya grits his teeth as he peels his body from the wall. The villain smashes against his spot moments later, nearly killing him. At least, now, Midoriya has a vantage point for his support tool. He whips the scarf out, wraps it around the muscular man's arm, and swings himself off his body. He gets air time, throws his body upward, and jumps to the wall. His shoes hook, gloved fingers wrapped around a jutted-out stone.

So what's his move? The guy could take any blows, bullets, explosions, everything. He's hellbent on causing death and destruction. There's nothing that stops him from jumping down into the woods below and attempting to take more lives. Midoriya can't let that happen, so what's his move?

Thick cords of muscle, his entire body writhing and slithering like snakes. What's his move?

His dark eye looking around, the other missing. What's his move?

His head secured at the top, nearly hidden in folds of muscle. What's…

His move.

Viridant wraps his support tool around the stone, swings off it. The idiot swipes at him, bellows, and hits the mountain when he misses. Viridant swings in circles, tightening and loosening his scarf for flexibility. He tightens it around the rock's edge, plants his feet on the rattling ground. But another blow sends his balance tipping, and Viridant stumbles to the side. The scarf goes tight, keeping him barely suspended, dangling off the edge.

The villain laughs at him, peers over at him from the ledge. He grabs the scarf, tugs Viridant up with a smooth grip, dangling him by the fabric around his neck.

"Look at you, little Hero," the villain coos, his good eye whirring. "See what happens when you try to play nice? When you try to resist your natural violence?"

Viridant grins at him. "Who the hell said I'm not violent?"

He jerks his leg up and, with all the strength he can muster, kicks his steel-pronged shoe into the villain's face. He drives the elongated metal top into the man's eye, using the idiot's grip on his scarf to leverage himself closer. He drives and drives, grunting and pushing as he shoves his foot forward. Blood sprays, the villain stumbles.

And then he crumbles to the floor.

Viridant yanks his foot free, pulling his scarf from the villain's grip. He stares at his limp body, watches all those muscles retract. What good that did him, huh? The human skull has hardly any muscles compared to the rest of the body. It was natural to go for the head.

When his Quirk shrinks away, it reveals a tall man. Viridant stares at his head, where the hole in his eye reaches his brain and severed neurological pathways. Dead.

He feels nothing. He grabs the man's arm, drags him to the edge, and shoves him off. Despite the trees below, he watches as the body spatters and separates. No trace will be left behind that Viridant was the one to kill him. Good. Makes this easier.

Violence roils inside him, an unsatisfied anger calling for more. That little boy is alive because of Viridant, because of his violence.

So what's next?

Viridant moves on, ties a simple black cloth mask onto his face, and throws himself off the cliff. He catches his support weapon on a tree branch. With plenty of newfound leverage, he works his way through the trees silently and quickly.

Darkness works its way through the woods, a feral scream ripping from someone. Midoriya passes by the corpse of a student. He's managled, it's many arms and limbs spread wide. The student's shirt is torn, blue pants are the only intact part of his body. His head is completely gone; the lack of bone or brain stem, paired with the harsh lacerations, indicates it wasn't cut off. It was *bitten.*

Screaming, loud, awful screaming. Viridant only realizes, seconds later, that it's not just screams. It's crying, sobbing, shouts of guilt and sadness. He stares as another student appears in the woods, body covered by a large, vicious shadow.

"PLEASE!" The student screams, trying to resist the darkness wrapped around him. "I CAN'T CONTROL IT."

Viridant turns and runs.

***

How the fuck did Bakugou get stuck with Icy Hot, of all god damn people? The idiot carries some class B kid on his back, his weight balanced carefully as they sprint through the woods. No warnings are given, no one to prepare them. He had first thought this was some sort of training exercise, but he knew, somewhere deep inside of him, that this wasn't right.

Maybe it's the fucking blue flames that Icy Hot can't stop staring at, or the maniac with steel teeth that's throwing him off. Either way, he's fucking over it. Relaxing weekend retreat his ass.

"Bakugou," The walking candy cane says, "We need to warn the others."

Bakugou is too busy trying to figure out what the hell this toothy moron is saying. He's picking his body up at an awkward angle, contorted and wild, jabbing at the two of them in an attempt to slit them open.

"Yeah? How do you suppose we do that? Should I fucking phone a friend?" Bakugou snaps at him, dodging a solid tooth shard. "I can't even activate my explosions in case this gas is reactive, or without catching the forest on fucking fire. So you tell me, dumbass!"

Half and half grunts, flinging himself sideways with the student on his back. "We need support. I can try to freeze his teeth, but the bone could be too solid. And my fire is too risky."

Steps sound from behind them, running, panting. They keep dodging, Bakugou hissing when the Quirk nicks him. His palms smoke, eager to spark. If he could just bomb this idiot already, this whole tirade would be over. They wouldn't be stuck dealing with this bony idiot, they—

"Hey, jackass!" a voice sounds from behind them. "How's the weather up there?"

"You—" the villain's eyes flicker, turn vacant, before his lengthy body crashes to the floor.

Shit. That's that.

Icy Hot is silent at the approaching form, Bakugou seething that he didn't get to do the final blow.

"Yuck," Shinso says, before reeling his foot back and kicking the villain in the head. "He's not waking up for a bit. Do either of you have wire or something? We can tie him up."

"Why the fuck would we have wire?" Bakugou snaps.

Shinso slowly drags his eyes to him. He looks him up and down, then turns to Todoroki. "Tell me you have something."

"I can tear my shirt off," the dumbass ass offers.

"Oh," Shinso looks away, "Yeah, sure…"

Bakugou looks away, too. Both of them stare in opposite directions while the idiot between them rips his shirt into strips. Only then do they grab the limp body on the floor, wrapping his wrists and feet with the cloth that Todoroki tore off.

It's anti-climactic, honestly. The three of them stare at this crazy guy with absolutely shattered teeth. He's freaky as hell looking, his arms all tied up and eyes covered. Weirdo.

Todoroki adjusts the weight of the student on his back. "We should get back to the main camp, see who needs our support."

"Yeah," Shinso agrees, eyeing the cuts and blade marks on the two of them. "Let's go—"

The trees begin to rustle. They pause, staring, as a few topple over. Screeching follows, a few squirrels and birds fleeing the scene. Then, a thin, arching piece of black fabric juts out. It wraps around Todorki's waist, and Bakugou has to quickly grab it before the idiot is yanked forward and into the abyss.

The momentum and drags another form into view. Panting, blood dripping down his face and staining his hair red—

"Oh, isn't that the vigilante kid?" Todoroki asks calmly. "What's he doing here?"

Viridant stands, looks at them, looks away. He pauses, slowly turns to take them all in again. Bakugou stares right at him, Shinso as well. Todoroki yawns.

The trees tremble and shake, more roots falling. And then shadows, darkness, rage incarnate as Tokoyami comes barreling through. Fuck this, fuck the fucking forest!

Bakugou lights up. His palms dance with color, orange and red basking in the night air. Tokoyami halts before him, jaws wide, screaming against the color. He doesn't stop, his ears ringing, until the demon shrinks back and withers away inside Tokoyami's chest. The bird motherfucker hobbles forward, sobbing.

All three of them kind of just stare at him. Eventually, Todoroki pats the guy's back awkwardly, mumbling, 'there, there. '

And Viridant watches, scarf withdrawing. Bakugou keeps his other grip on it, tugs it closer when the vigilante tries to pull away. Only then does the idiot actually look at him. And he's struck, immediately, by how wrong he'd been about the description of the vigilante.

His eyes are red. A horrible, bloody red. His hair is black, drenched red with blood. His skin is speckled with it as well. What isn't hidden by his suit or a plain black mask is red. Instantly, he looks painfully familiar, his hair matted with blood clots and gore.

Who does he look like? Why can't Bakugou place him?

Viridant gives his scarf another yank, and Bakugou's palms burn as it's finally ripped from his hands. His red eyes flicker to the captured villain, Todoroki's bare chest, Shinso, then back to Bakugou.

Then he takes off fucking running. Bakugou cusses, sprinting after him. Todoroki calls out as Shinso follows right after. They don't have time to waste. Viridant is *here,* clearly fresh from some sort of fight that he wasn't prepared for, if his loss of gear is any consolation.

He follows the trail, faster than all four of them, headed towards the main camp. They give chase, and not a single one of them notices the well-dressed dumbass watching them from the trees until it's too late. Tokoyami shouts something from the back of the group, and Bakugou turns in time to watch Shinso flicker out of existence, his essence captured in a blue pearl.

His captor wears a white and black mask, an oversized top hat, and a thick tan coat. An Alice in Wonderland wannabe, that's what he fucking is. Bakugou readies another explosion, but the villain looks at him next, head tilted.

And the world goes dark.

Chapter End Notes

whip and nae nae

Chapter 28: Capture

Chapter Summary

Midoriya fights to save Bakugou and Shinso from Mr.Compress

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Viridant can hardly keep upright. He's exhausted, smoke inhalation making him loopy. Honestly, he's not thinking much about that. His brain is elsewhere, focused on getting *anywhere* but where he just was. Both the best and worst place to have ended up.

His shoes crunch on the dirt path, his breath coming in pants. He keeps running long after silence chases him, keeps running until he again bounces off a body. He steadies the girl, eyes narrowed immediately.

"Oh my god," she whispers, blonde buns bouncing as she jumps up and down. "You *are* cute."

"Spare me," he snips, and she squeals at his real voice. "The threats are eliminated, get out of here before the Pros capture you."

The girl giggles, fangs showing. "My ride is just down this path!"

His brows furrow. This path leads right back to Kacchan and Shinso.

"Hey, my name is Himiko, by the way," she says, winking. "Just so you know what to call me."

He stares blankly at her. "Why attack the camp?"

"What?"

"Why attack the camp?"

Himiko shrugs, tugging her mask back up. "Tomura came for someone, wouldn't say who."

Tomura.

I'm not too sure which one of you will see this first. But whether it is Tomura or the vigilante is the last thing I care about.

Test subjects. The league is here for test subjects. And if Himiko's escape is through that portal that attacked UA the first time, which he suspects it is, then there's no chance of

anyone left behind escaping. He's still got no idea about the two killers sent in here, but he knows, with absolute certainty, that he couldn't have lost Kacchan that easily.

Which means..

Himiko gasps when he grabs her knife. In one quick motion, he's got her back pressed to his chest, the knife pressing against the skin of her throat.

"They won't leave you behind, will they, Himiko?" he asks quietly.

She squeaks out, "Jokes on you, I am *not* against this."

Viridant urges her forward. "Walk me through your plan, take me to your ride. Or I'll slit your throat and leave you in the fucking mud."

"Jesus," she mumbles, grunting as he walks them forward. "We all had different instructions. Mine were to collect blood—lots of it. Dabi was told to set the woods on fire, and Twice was told to keep the Pros occupied."

"And?"

"And that's all I know! There are more of us, but I don't really care much for them," she giggles, holds onto his arm as he walks them. "You're so muscular. But also lean. I bet you'd taste great, like chicken."

Viridant huffs a laugh. "You're a loose screw, but you're practically harmless, right?"

"Whatever you say," she waves him off, "The two others here; they aren't with us. They belong to the big boss. He always sends Tomura in with backup, never trusts his plans not to fall through."

Viridant pushes them forward, following the bend of the path. "Who is Tomura?"

"Come on, Viri, you know that already," Himiko snickers. "You two would get along great. Very threatening and sarcastic. Hey, what cologne do you use? It smells great."

"Keep walking."

"Okie dokie."

They arrive at the clearing. Viridant tugs her behind a tree, tells her to keep quiet, and she vibrates with absolute joy. How anyone could enjoy being held hostage, he isn't sure.

He peers out from around a tree, taking in the messy scene before him. The unconscious girl from before, Uraraka, is up and moving. She hovers over an unconscious Tokoyami, trying to shake him awake. Todoroki Shoto is here as well, whom Viridant expected to be as much of an ass as his Pro Hero father is. But he seems to be a harmless airhead so far.

Either way, it's clear UA is down on its luck. Four villains wait at the gate. Viridant commits their features to memory, forcing Himiko to fill in any gaps. She tells him everything he asks.

The one in a black and gray suit is Twice, who has a Quirk that allows him to duplicate either himself or others. A well-dressed man tossing two marbles between his fingers is Mr.Compress, who currently holds two students between his fingers.

Viridant hears nothing else. He doesn't care about the scared man who taunts Todoroki Shoto, or the lizard-looking motherfucker. His eyes are locked on those two marbles, on the missing students.

Kacchan. Hitoshi.

His hands tremble, the knife nearly cutting through Himiko's throat.

"T-They aren't dead," she gasps, grabbing his attention again. "Just sleeping, really. You can get them back."

Viridant stares at her, debates what to do.

"Negotiate me!" she urges. "Dabi and Twice won't let me get hurt, a-and you'll get the students back."

Hm.

That'll do.

Himiko coughs as he pulls the blade away, dragging her by her sleeve. Despite her near-death death, she doesn't seem to mind being brought along on this plan. She mutters something about loving boys fighting over her, and he does his best to ignore that. Instead, he kicks out the back of her knees, grabs a handful of hair, and yanks her head back. He holds the knife to her throat as he calls out.

"Trade?"

Mr.Compress looks up from his hand, body stilling. Dabi peers over, too, and the air seems to get a few degrees hotter. Himiko hisses in pain, so he loosens his grip until she thanks him and goes back to humming whatever song is in her head.

Todoroki falls flat on the floor, and a harsh kick to the stomach from Dabi keeps him there. The tall, scared man approaches. He gets only a few steps before Viridant pushes the knife in, a trail of blood running from Himiko's neck.

"Down, boy," Viridant says, head tilted. "Unless you don't mind missing out on goodbyes?"

Twice laughs, "Kill her!" He whips his head side to side. "No, no, please don't kill her."

Weird, but he's dealt with worse. Viridant keeps the knife steady, tracking all people currently in the clearing. He makes note of any sudden movements, pivots the two of them accordingly.

"No one needs to get hurt," Viridant says, his rage a living, breathing monster. "I'll give you her if you give me the students back."

“Do it,” Dabi snaps, glaring at Compress.

Mr. Compress tosses the marbles into the air, catches them again. “Doesn’t seem like much of a fair trade.”

“Do it!” Dabi shouts, his voice awful and ruined. “I will melt the fucking skin off your face, do you hear me?”

“Hm,” Compress twirls the circles along his fingers. “You know how much trouble I’ll be in if I come back empty-handed?”

“Less than you would if one of you came back a corpse, I’d guess,” Viridant offers, pushing the knife in. Himiko winces, and he whispers a quiet apology. “Tick tock.”

Wind whips through the clearing, blowing smoke and blue flames closer. Viridant waits, his grip on Himiko tight and unforgiving.

“Compress,” Dabi snips, right as Twice drops to his knees and begs the man. He’s up a moment later, urging Compress not to give in. Then he’s down again, begging him to give up his captives.

Compress tosses a ball up, catches it, then flicks the second one to Viridant’s feet. It rolls, flashes, and Hitoshi pops out. He hits the floor and spins, grunting with the force of it. He collides with a tree that stops his momentum, groaning as his body slams against it. Viridant hasn’t seen him in… in a long time. But he’s not done, there’s no time to think of Hitoshi's hiss of pain.

“The other,” Viridant demands.

Himiko calls out, “Can you guys hurry up? I’m really tired.”

Four things happen at once. Blue fire shoots for Viridant’s body, right as his waist is tugged backwards by a magnetic force. The flames separate him from Himiko, who immediately grabs her throat and coughs. Ice follows the flames, attempting to control it, and instead throwing off whoever just yanked Viridant backwards.

They don’t stand a chance.

Viridant whirls, punching at the woman whose magnetic force threw him off. She parries, trying to swing at him with a massive weapon. Her hair catches the wind, blows in her face, and Viridant nails her in the stomach. She falls flat on her ass, barely dodging the foot he stomps for her head. These fucking assholes still have Kacchan. He doesn’t care if they die; he’ll be the one to fucking do it if he has to.

“Go go!” someone shouts, and he hears Himiko arguing before her voice cuts out, likely shoved through the transportation portal.

No, dammit. He will not lose.

The woman screams as his shoe collides with her arm, pinning it to the floor. She writhes, and Viridant doesn't feel a single thing over it.

"Magne!" Twice yells, the ice wall hiding them. "We can't leave her!"

Viridant stares down at her, grabs her other wrist when she swings for him, and holds it down. "You know you're going to die, don't you?"

She hisses in pain. "You don't look very Heroic right now."

"I'm not." He twists his shoe, eliciting another scream.

The ice wall steams, melts, and that blue flame comes racing for him again. He wraps an arm around Magne's waist, throws his scarf with his other hand, and swings from harm's way. The fire follows him, setting trees ablaze, narrowly missing Shinso's head.

Viridant lands when the flames momentarily cease, his eyes locked on the retreating forms. The lizard man jumps through the portal, and then Compress—

His support weapon shoots out, grabs the man's arm, *PULLS.* A scream follows a loud pop, the arm dislocating. His fingers open, the blue marble falling from his fingers before he finally falls through the portal. It rolls on the dirt floor.

Viridant looks at it, looks at Dabi. Then the two of them sprint for it. He casts his weapon out again, and the tall man grabs it, twists it, ducks below it, and slides along the floor. He reaches the marble first, but Viridant throws himself full force atop him, knocking it loose. Magne sprints by, throwing herself through the portal.

The marble rolls away, and Viridant jumps for it—

But he's yanked back by the cloth on his neck. He chokes, gritting his teeth, and the marble flashes and morphs. Kacchan appears, blinking slowly.

His eyes land on Viridant, and his plans immediately spark.

It's not quick enough.

Dabi yanks him back, grinning, pulling the two of them into the portal.

Viridant manages, just before he's taken, three words. "Don't come, Kacchan."

***

"NO!" Bakugou falls through the black smoke, hitting the forest floor on the other side. His palms grasp at dirt, his skin scraping against the ground. Flames paint the air, his classmates unconscious or injured behind him.

And he's not sure why this is a failure that runs deeper than any other. His gut screams at him, his mind racing.

Bakugou hits the ground, over and over, until his knuckles bleed and his skin breaks. He's not sure why he's so angry, so beyond fucking angry.

A scream rips from his throat, louder than he's ever been. His chest *hurts,* his breaths quick, his heart hammering. He shakes, his vision fading in and out. He failed. He failed. He failed. He can't fail; he hates failing.

And it's so *dark.* He hates the dark. He hates it he hates it he hates *everything.*

Panic seizes him, his palms sparking, his throat aching as he screams and screams and—

"Hey, hey," Hands grab for him. "Come on, come on, look at me. We'll get him back, we'll get him back. Won't we?"

"I—" Bakugou's mind goes blank, empty. The panic stops, the fear disappears.

There is…

N O T H I N G.

***

Shinso is the one who gets them all help. Tokoyami was the worst by far. He suffered no external injuries, but upon being freed from his Quirk, was unable to get up. He could only lie in the dirt, staring up at the sky, his eyes haunted.

Todoroki was the second worst. Minor burns to his entire body, excess smoke inhalation. The Pros ask him why he didn't fight Dabi outright, why he allowed himself to be baited by taunts. He didn't answer.

Then, Uraraka, whose blood loss was so significant that she was taken to a hospital. Shinso isn't sure how much was taken, only that she won't be returning to school for a while.

And then Bakugou. He doesn't like him, not by any means, but he can't imagine that feeling. Being so close, but not close enough. Watching as Viridant disappeared. Landing on the other side.

The failure Shinso feels isn't near what he's sure Bakugou must be going through. So when he saw the panic attack coming, he knocked the guy out. He's still there, lingering in the mental state far longer than normal. Either Shinso was a bit too strong with his Quirk, or Bakugou is chasing the feeling of nothingness. The comfort that comes from feeling nothing at all is often addictive.

When Shinso was a kid, he used to sell it. Forty bucks for an hour of silence, of emptiness. You'd be surprised what people would pay for a second of relief. He doesn't let himself think of that now, though. He lets first responders check him for injuries and bandage his wounds. And he stares forward, at Kota, who refuses to let anyone take the helmet and mask off his head.

Viridant gave them up. His disguise, his safety, his comfort, for a kid he doesn't know. For Bakugou.

For *him.* Months of silence, and Viridant still came for him.

When he's bandaged up, he rubs his head, tugs his hair. He can't just sit here, can't just watch these kids converge and mourn and grieve while he does *nothing.* He has been doing nothing for his whole life.

So he stands up. He doesn't know where he's going, but he knows he can't stay here. He needs to find Viridant, recuse him, explain the silence he's been forcing on the guy for months now.

"Shinso." Eraser clasps his shoulder, "You're okay, thank god, you're okay."

Shinso wobbles, "Viridant—"

"We're doing all we can," Eraser reassures him, "He wasn't supposed to be here, damn kid."

"He saved me, he saved—he saved everyone." Shinso has to tell someone. He's not sure why.

"I know," Eraser says softly. "You hit your head, kiddo, you need to lie down."

"No, no, I got to—I need to find—find him—"

"Let us handle it," Eraser all but begs. "Let us handle this. You're a kid, just be a kid, okay?"

He helps Shinso into a small tent set up for medical aid. He urges him to lie down on a provided cot. It's right next to Bakugou, whose limp body doesn't react to his presence at all.

"No—" Shinso grits, pushes back. "I *need* to find him."

Eraser holds him down. "Sleep. Do you understand me? *Sleep."*

"I-I-"

“Tomorrow,” Eraser tells him, a promise. “Tomorrow we will talk about this, okay? But for tonight, just recover. You can’t save anyone like this; you need to relax.”

Shinso stops fighting, his head swimming. He spots a first responder's bag, their laptop, and suddenly agrees with Eraser completely. His Sensei lays a blanket over his cold body, urging him to rest. And the second those tent flaps close, Shinso is up again.

He grabs the laptop, flips it open. It takes seconds to get inside its programming, to shut off its first responder presets. He quickly opens the shared communication he’s had with Viridant, but none of it alludes to his current whereabouts. He sees an endless amount of missed calls and messages, but nothing helpful.

Didn’t Viridant go and search those fucking tunnels again? He had said he thought it connected to the UA attack—sp maybe whatever he found could lead to him. Shinso curses himself for his silence, hates himself for his stupidity.

He needs to fix this, needs to make it up, needs to find Viridant.

And he knows exactly where to start.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Chapter 29: Offering

Chapter Summary

Shinso searched for Midoriya, and Midoriya meeets the leader of the League of Villains.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shinso finally makes it home. Or, not home, he doesn't really have one of those. What he means to say is that, after several hours of sitting and waiting for his foster parents to pick him up from the UA training camp and then still not showing, he finally convinced an officer to let him head home alone. Everyone else got rides home from Mom or Dad. Shinso got a police escort. He feels so special, really.

He creaks open the front door quietly, careful not to wake anyone. The only thing that they hate more than inconvenience is being woken up. He sneaks up the stairs by the door, pops into his small bedroom, and sits down at the tiny desk he shares with his roommate. He lives with four other girls, each one more peculiar than the last. This is one of those foster homes where the 'parents' don't have any kids of their own and get paid to 'raise' less fortunate children to 'prepare' them for their own.

Aka, they get checks from the foster agency that get higher and higher with each kid they take in, especially problematic ones, which Shinso is. So is his roommate, who is literally the spawn of Satan. She's the oldest of all the girls, Shinso just a bit younger, and the other three range far more. He's only stuck with these dickheads for another two months. Home rotations work in six-month increments, and switching to this shithole in June was an unwelcome birthday gift for the following month.

But he's got shit to do other than think about how much longer he has left here. Viridant was taken on October 31st, and it's early morning in November. He needs to hurry, pinpoint the idiot, and hopefully swoop in and save his ass before it's too late. He never should've stopped talking to him.

He just couldn't take the guilt. Knowing about Viridant's denied admittance to UA, about Ground Zero's identity, about the secret Bakugou mindlessly confessed to him. He just couldn't do. He couldn't talk to Viridant every day and pretend he had no idea what was really going on. And he couldn't tell Viridnat the truth, either. He was worried that his friend would retaliate with even more recklessness or get closer to the fine line he walks with death. So Shinso just disappeared, drowned himself in the guilt, and never said another word to anyone.

Shinso carefully packs his backpack. He's as quiet as a mouse, listening to his foster sibling snore in her bed. He stuffs clothes inside, his laptop that he definitely didn't steal years ago, a

charger, and his phone that he also didn't steal years ago. He packs his entire life, which isn't much. Some clean clothes, his UA uniform, and that's it.

When it's done, he heads back into the hall and out the front door. As he walks, he makes a phone call.

"Hello?"

"Hey," he says quietly, tugging his hood over his head as he walks down the street. "Is this Miss Midoriya?"

A small pause. "Yes, who's this?"

"This is Hitoshi," he says.

Her relief can be heard through the line. "Oh, thank goodness! How'd you get my number—oh, it's not important. Is everything alright, sweetheart?"

"Of course," Hitoshi lies through his teeth. "I just wanted to call you to personally ask, would it be alright if Midoriya and I slept at my place for the week? I'll make sure he still goes to school in the morning and work in the afternoon. We're just collaborating on a project I have to turn in at UA, so it's a bit time-consuming."

Her response is instant. "Of course! Aren't you just such a considerate sweetheart! Just have my baby text me when he can, okay? Do you need me to drop clothes off?"

"No!" Hitoshi nearly shouts, before clearing his throat and trying again. "No, it's alright, he can borrow mine."

"Okay, honey," she says sweetly, "Have fun!"

"Thank you."

"Bye, honey."

"Bye."

He hangs up right as a city bus pulls up. He rides it until it stops in Musutafu, then hops off. Rain slices down from the sky, so he tugs his hood a little closer to his head as he walks. When he arrives at a run-down, old apartment building, he shakes off his nerves and gets to work. His hands grip the wet drain pipe, carry him upwards, and to a balcony. He pushes off its railing, jumps to the windsill above, and slowly creaks it open.

He mentally apologizes to Viridant for getting mud and rainwater on his bed before throwing his body through the open window. He's careful to shut it after, then creep towards Viridant's bedroom door and double-check the lock. He can hear Miss Midoriya on the other end, humming as she gets on with her morning routine before work. She's in a good mood, just as Shinso was hoping she'd be. It means she won't check in with worry.

Shinso makes quick work of the small robot that Viridant stole from UA. It's positioned in the corner of the room, its eyes scanning for intruders and sending an alert to Viridant's phone. He quickly disables the bot, patting its tiny head as the life bleeds from its code. Viridant is smart, able to handle himself even in Shinso's absence.

He frowns, looks around the room. There used to be more All Might memorabilia, but Viridant either sold it or threw it out a long time ago. Most of the room is blank, the tiny space not having much space for anything more than a twin bed and desk. Shinso eyes the bedding, a unique design he's seen somewhere. Black with orange stitching and X's. When he can't place it, he moves on.

Slowly, he sits in Viridant's squeaky little chair. He cringes at the sound, going still in case Miss Midoriya heard. When her humming continues, he clicks the computer to life. It's passcode protected, of course, but if Viridant hasn't changed it…

He types in *KacchanIsAwesomePlusUltra,* and the computer hums to life. Shinso would normally have to type in another fifty fucking passcodes to get anywhere, but he insisted Viridant build in a bypass key for Shinso. He types it in, heart aching when it still works. Even after a month of silence, Shinso still remains an active part of Viridant's life.

Dammit all, he never should've disappeared.

"All right, Viridant," he mutters, clicking around the PC, "Let's see what you've been up to."

It's bad—worse than bad. Viridant's headset automatically backs up all data to a preprogrammed encoded folder. When Shinso manages to crack the code and infiltrate, he's greeted with hours of lonely footage. Solo patrols, silence as he wanders around at night. A few weird times when he peered inside Bakugou's window while the guy slept—which Shinso pretends he didn't see and moves on with.

He scans through footage of tunnels, of fights. Of conversations with Ground Zero, conversations about *him.* Viridant uses his code name for Shinso, but he still talks about him. Sometimes he even mumbles to himself about the whole situation, tries to place where he went wrong. Shinso is going to be the biggest ass kisser when he gets Viridant back, and he *will* get Viridant back.

A few curiosities come up that Shinso notes. He's never heard a mention of All for One; he's not even sure who the hell that is. More so, why it seemed to drive Viridant to near insanity when whoever that is wiped out the city? The footage is disturbing, haunting, and leads Shinso nowhere.

It doesn't get better from there. He watches Viridant give his mask and helmet away, sees Viridant's real face through the lens of a child. If you can even call that his real face--it doesn't look like Viridant at all. Red eyes, black roots to faded green hair, he looks nearly completely different. Shinso is at a loss for what's truly going on here. All he knows is that one of his closest friends is… someone else completely.

The little boy, Kota, is lowered to the bottom of the mountain and takes off running. Shinso watches as he makes it to the main camp, sobs to one of the Pussycats about the mountain.

One races after where Kota points, but nobody seems to get there in time. Shinso's out of luck. There are no leads here. He's not sure how Viridant made the jump to the training camp, how he knew to show up right on time.

He's at a dead end. Searched through Viridant's entire room, his personal information, and came up empty. Night is falling already. He's spent the whole day coming up with jack shit.

Shinso rubs his eyes, a headache pounding in his skull. He can go to Tokyo, search the four-way alley in Koto. There's a chance it leads somewhere other than to a random alley system. Even the building in Chou City could have a good lead to pick up on. It could tie to the idiots that attacked UA, so it's a start. Shinso quickly nabs an area map of the two cities, pulling the location from the footage in a few minutes flat. He prints the data out, grabs the sheet, and stuffs it into his school bag for later.

When it's done, he logs out of the PC and pushes the bedroom window open again. It's difficult to get down, but not nearly as hard as it was to get up. When his feet land, he heads toward—

A hand shoves him against the wall of the apartment complex, heat radiating from the palm.

Bakugou grins, head tilted, "Looks like it's my lucky fucking day, Eyebags."

***

Midoriya groggily blinks his eyes open. His skull throbs, and the distant memory of a loafer to his temple bubbles to mind. He was knocked out; someone knocked him out. Immediately, he tries to stand up. His wrists ache, his legs shake, and his body can't seem to stand from the chair he's in. One blink later, and he realizes that he's been tied down.

Fuck. Not good. Very not good.

His yellow backpack rests in a bar chair, the room empty of life. Midoriya has absolutely no idea where he is, or where the hell everyone else is. His wrists are tied together and shut inside a metal box. The small, glowing light on it indicates it suppresses Quirks. Not that it makes much of a difference for him.

Wiggling his mouth reveals his mask is still on, but a metallic layer has been added to keep him quiet. He's shocked they didn't blindfold him or something, letting him look around the pricey building. Dated whiskey and fine wines litter the shelves on the back wall. The bar counter is freshly finished or well upkept. The room itself is spacious, large enough to fit multiple people in it.

He's never come across this anywhere. He truly couldn't even guess where the hell he is.

Midoriya tugs at his restraints, tests the integrity. His hands are absolutely done for. He's got no hope of getting out of this iron box on his own. He might be able to work the rope at his feet, but it wouldn't be easy. His shoes are still on, blood still coating his skin. He's been in this chair for a while already; there's no telling when someone will come back.

He cranes his neck backward, checks the chair he's in. Wooden. If he can stand and throw himself backwards, there's a chance the chair will break. He can use that to get his feet loose, which will let him roam around at least. The muzzle on his face and the box of metal on his arms is a different story.

Carefully, he tries to stand.

The door behind him squeaks, and he goes limp and shuts his eyes before the full thing opens.

"Anything?" a distant voice calls.

Midoriya listens as footsteps enter the room. Slow, heavy, deliberate. He counts their paces, tries to match it up with the villains in his memories. He thinks it might be Twice, but the utter silence from whoever it is makes him second-guess. His next option is Dabi, and the longer the person stands in front of him, the more he's convinced of it.

"Hey, dipshit, is he awake?" the voice calls again.

Silence. Then the steps move to the door. It opens, shuts, and Midoriya stays perfectly still.

Dabi scoofs, opens it again and actually leaves this time. "He's out still,"

"Shit, kid must've been sleepy!" Twice laughs, "Let's kill him—no, keep him alive! Best friends forever."

"Shut up," Dabi mutters, then silence descends on the room again.

Midoriya finally opens his eyes again, ready to slam this chair into the wall and bash his metal hands into someone's skull—

Himiko smiles at him from the barstool she sits on. She wiggles her fingers in a way, giggling softly at the narrowing of his eyes. She must've snuck in with Dabi, hung off him like a koala bear, or matched his steps.

"Hi, cutie." Her neck has a small cut on it, it'll likely scar. Guilt eats at him, disappearing immediately when she twirls a set of keys around a finger.

Aw, man.

"Welcome to the bar!" she whispers-shouts, holding up a peace sign. "This is where we torture people! In the very chair you sit in."

Midoriya's eye twitches. He can't talk, otherwise, he'd urge her to hand the keys over. That's likely the reason they muzzled him in the first place.

"Don't worry, Tomura only tortures the bad ones. I told him you're good, but… We'll see." She winks at him, kicks her legs back and forth on her barstool. "I drained your blood while you slept, by the way. Sorry, I didn't ask first. At least I didn't drink it right out of you, right?"

Midoriya blinks slowly, looks down at his restraints, then back at her. He offers what he thinks is his best wink; he's not sure, he's never done this.

Himiko laughs outright. "Ooooh, you're smart. But I'm under strict orders! No unlocking your restraints."

Dammit.

He breathes heavily out of his nose, leans back in the chair. Limply, he gestures to her, urging her to keep talking. Might as well learn what he can while he awaits the chance to break out.

Himiko flattens out the pleating of her skirt, frowning down at it. "You know, I think this whole idea was totally stupid! They all said it was genius, that they could recruit a man on the inside, but I told them. I said, Guys, this kidnapping plan isn't going to sell at all."

She twirls a lock of blonde hair around her finger. With her hair down, she looks almost normal. If it weren't for the slight mania on her face, he'd assume she was a regular, functioning member of society.

She keeps talking. "And they all think they're going to get your cooperation, like you would agree after the fire and attempt on the students' lives." She waves a hand around. "Oh well."

Midoriya listens, blinking away his headache the best he can. He'd kill for some nice, crisp ice water. Those flames and the resounding smoke dried him out. Not to mention that however long he slept absolutely did a number on him. This is why he hates suffering injuries; he always oversleeps! He much prefers to be out and about, not knocked out in some chair getting his blood pumped out of him.

His stomach rumbles, and Himiko nibbles her lip. She peers over the bar counter, grabs a bag of Animal Crackers, and eyes him. He nods eagerly, urging her, and she again twirls those keys.

"You literally *can't* bite me, okay?" she says, slowly approaching. "I'm being so nice doing this, but if you screw this up, I'm in so much trouble. And Dabi will melt your eyes out of your head, so, your call."

He stays still as she carefully slits a key into the lock of his muzzle. When it's off, and he can breathe out of his mouth, it's a relief. Despite how badly he'd like to bite her finger off, he knows it'll only doom him.

Himiko carefully peels off the stiff face mask. The blood has dried, making the fabric filthy and solid. It reveals his lips, which in turn makes her spin in circles and comment on how cute she finds him. He's glad for the blood, because it hides how red he is. He can't believe he's flattered by this. He's just so put off that he's not sure how to properly react.

"Okay, okay." She digs into the plastic bag, holds a cracker out. "*Do not* bite me, okay?" Midoriya takes it, chews slowly, and she smiles wide. "This is just like Minecraft! I think I just tamed you."

Midoriya furrows his brows. "What is Minecraft?"

Her jaw drops. "You've never played Minecraft? Were you neglected or something?"

His eyes blow wide. Whatever Minecraft is—it must have some kind of intensive database that can determine abuse factors. Maybe it's some sort of intrusive AI? Does it connect to police databases?

Himiko pulls her phone out. It's the newest model with a white bunny phone case. He sees her screensaver, which is a photo of him sleeping in the chair. Her Home Screen is almost as bad, a photo taken from behind a tree of the 1-A student, Uraraka. He doesn't question it as she opens up a little app on her screen.

She sits on the arm of his chair, animal crackers long forgotten, and begins to walk around the little world she's created. Midoriya has no idea what the hell he's even looking at. Everything looks like squares and obnoxiously bright colors. He forgot how normal children are. While Himiko isn't normal in many senses, it seems she still keeps a lot of childhood traits that he lost. He's tried video games and was so confused that he gave up.

"This is my horse," she says, "I had to cheat in the diamond armor because I couldn't find any. Dabi said I'm a noob, but he's even worse than I am, so what does that tell you?"

Midoriya swallows and says, his voice dry with dehydration, "That… he uhh… he's a noob?"

"Yes!" she cheers, "You get an Animal Cracker."

He takes it greedily, and when he asks for water, she makes him rate her house first. He gives it a ten out of ten and earns a full cup. Thank god.

She spills it down his face when she tries to give it to him, but it's a welcomed chill. This bar is warm, comfortable, with rain pattering on what sounds like a metal ceiling. No wonder he was out for so long. Blood loss, a kick to the forehead, warmth, and rain in the background? He stood no chance.

"Okay," he clears his throat, "So you're trying to build a mob farm."

"Yes," she says, exasperated. "But it's so hard to do on a phone because of the water physics. But everyone says I can't have a computer yet, and it's like, why not?"

Midoriya nods. "Yeah, you should absolutely have one."

“Exactly.” She feeds him another animal cracker. “Let me show you my villager dungeon.”

“What the hell is that?”

He was not expecting to wake up in the league of villains' hideout and learn about video games. He was waiting to be beaten and cut up and horrifically tortured. Not hand-fed Animal Crackers and taught how to play mobile games. He’s not complaining… or maybe he is? It’s kind of hard to escape when he’s being taught about why the new update to the game is amazing.

It reminds him of how much of a childhood he missed out on.

“So, then—“ Himiko looks up as steps sound down the hall.

She quickly apologizes and puts Midoriya’s mask back on, darting from her chair as the door opens. He eyes the bag of Animal Crackers that she finishes off, annoyed that he didn’t get to polish off the last of it. Dammit.

The door squeaks as it’s opened wide. “Look who’s finally fucking awake.”

Slow, heavy, deliberate. Dabi appears a moment later, face stoic. He walks to Himiko, lingers by her side. He eyes the new dampness of Viridant’s costume but says nothing, not even when more bodies fill the room. Compress takes up a corner, the lizard man leaning against a wall. Magne is next, her bandaged arm seeming to glare at him.

Then, smoke. Midoriya keeps his face perfectly blank as the purple wisps of smoke enter the room. They’re attached to a metallic neck, the eyes floating just above that. The smoke man is dressed to the nines, just as Compress is, which is the most bizarre thing to look at when they stand next to these eclectic individuals. The lizard guy is dressed like an actual ninja; Magne is in basic street clothes. Dabi dresses like a homeless man, and Himiko still wears a school uniform even though Midoriya is absolutely certain it’s a weekend.

Slow, uneven steps sound last. Midoriya listens to the scuff of shoes, unsure who has just entered the space. The figure appears a moment later, and his heart drops to his feet.

Black hoodie, black sweat pants, bright red Quirkless brand sneakers. This is who he had seen graffitiing the side of the building. The one who wrote *ALL HEROES ARE VILLAINS*.

This… this is Tomura. Midoriya is sure of it.

The man pulls his hood off, revealing a head of blue hair and flaky, dry skin. His chapped lips are pressed into a line, and a large hand sits on his face. But the skin around it, the truth of this Tomura.

He can’t be any older than Midoriya is. The leader of the league of villains, the orchestrator of the underground city, the face behind the Nomu’s creation… is a fifteen-year-old boy.

Midoriya can’t help the laugh peeling out of his chest. The muzzle muffles it, hides it, but his shoulders shake anyway.

Tomura tilts his head. “This is the vigilante?”

“Yup!” Himiko pipes up, giddy. “Isn’t he so cute?”

“Barf,” Twice responds, his arms crossed. A moment later, he clasps his hands by his face and kicks a leg up. “So cute!!!!”

Midoriya’s getting whiplash at this point.

Dabi mumbles something to the smoke, and the walking portal grabs for alcohol and pours a glass. So he’s… a butler? Midoriya is truly so lost.

“That’s him, alright,” Magne says, her lips pulled into a sneer. “Almost lost my fucking arm to him.”

Tomura sighs, sitting on a stool. “Dabi, take his mask off.”

“Are you out of your mind?” Dabi spits back, sipping his whiskey. “I think it’s got fucking rabies. I’m not going anywhere near it. Twice, you do it.”

“No way!” Twice shouts, before taking the keys that Himiko tosses to him and approaching Midoriya. “Right away.”

He doesn’t take his eyes off Tomura’s face as his mask is unlatched, his face mask again pulled to the side. He wishes, more than anything, that he could see the guy's face. But he can’t. So he stares at the pale hand that’s attached to Tomura’s flesh. It’s slender, likely female, holding on tight.

Tomura is silent as he watches him.

“Well?” The lizard guy says, “Are you going to ask him to join?”

Midoriya furrows his brows, asks, “You want me to join this league of yours?”

Silence, a few shared glances. Midoriya isn’t sure what he said that warranted such an outlandish reaction, but when Tomura raises a hand, he’s certain he said the wrong thing.

“Everybody out.”

“But—“

“Out.”

One by one, they all file out of the room. Lizard guy goes first, Compress next, and Magne lingers to look him over. Twice and Dabi drag Himiko out between them. She kicks over Dabi's glass of whiskey as she goes, the glass shattering on the bar floor. It leaves Midoriya and Tomura. And the portal-butler guy—Midoriya is still unclear on that.

“Kurogiri,” Tomura says darkly. “Just one moment, please.”

“Master requested—“

“Just a few minutes.” Tomura looks at him, and whatever is on his face convinces the butler-portal-human guy.

Kurogiri warps away.

And the room is empty.

“What’s your name?” The man asks him, dragging the stool before Midoriya’s chair. “Don’t say Viridant, I’m not that stupid.”

Midoriya keeps his mouth shut, his face blank.

“Do you… know who you look like?” Tomura asks him, leaning forward, resting his elbows on his knees. “Do you know what will happen when I tell him I found his child?”

His heart stops beating. His blood turns cold. How… how could this random villain possibly…

Tomura lifts off the pale, slender hand on his face. Red eyes peer curiously at him.

It is only then that Midoriya sees the slight black roots of Tomura’s hair, small strands of white mashed between blue. The curve of his earlobe. The tweak of his nose. The shape of his eyes. The angle of his jaw.

The sound of his voice, so similar to Midoriya’s.

The red, Quirkless brand… shoes.

Midoriya shakes worse than he ever has. His heart hammers wildly. His air catches in his lungs. His fear wraps a hand around his ribs and whispers into his lungs. He breathes in ghosts and cobwebs, unsure what he’s truly looking at.

Tomura smiles at him, and they both have the exact same dimple. “Dad’s been looking for you.”

Mama, he wants Mama. He wants to go home. He wants to be held and rocked to sleep. He wants to pack away his pretend little costume, go back to his blissful unawareness. He doesn’t want this—he doesn’t want any of this!

This can’t be right. This can’t be true.

“I’ll ask again,” Tomura says quietly, “You can give me your name or…” He grabs a spare glass, holds it between his fingers. It creaks, cracks, and withers to nothing.

Midoriya can’t respond. He can only stare at those red shoes. At the Quirk that Tomura shouldn’t have, not when he wears shoes adjusted for his foot shape.

Does he know? Does he know he's Quirkless? Or has Dad fed him a totally different line of bullshit?

Fuck, fuck, fuck.

He wants Mama. He wants Kacchan and Hitoshi. He wants Ground Zero. He wants Eraser Head. He doesn't want this—he doesn't know what this is. He always plans ahead, he always prepares—

He's *scared.* He's so scared. He's shaking like a dog, like a child who was told by a cruel doctor that his life is over, that he will never have a place in this world. He doesn't know what to do. He's lost, he's lost.

"Fine," Tomura sighs, slipping off the chair. "Have it your way." Tomura approaches, grabs Midoriya's chin. He lifts only his pinky into the air, offers a small smile. "Consider this a mercy."

Midoriya shuts his eyes tight, ignoring how they fill with tears. Tomura lowers the last finger, and right before it touches his skin, he blurts it out.

"Ito," he whispers so quietly, a name he is whipped with guilt over. "Banri. I-Ito Banri, that's my name."

Tomura hums, steps back. "You lasted longer than the rest of them."

"Of… of who?" Midoriya asks, his confession lying limp on his gut.

"Our siblings." Tomura sighs slowly, grabs the severed hand, and sticks it back on his face. "Dad wanted an heir. He spent a while trying to create them."

"I don't understand," Midoriya says quietly, his voice cracking. "There's more of us?"

Tomura looks over his shoulder, his red eye nearly glowing. "Was."

"H-How many?"

"However many he could stuff into stupid, broken women," Tomura responds, sitting back on his barstool. "Your mom—I assume she has no family, no friends, impoverished and poorly educated?"

Fire ignites in Midoriya's veins, a rage kindling in his chest. "My mom is none of your fucking business."

Tomura sits back, and Midoriya would say he was shocked. "Oh?"

"So what is this, huh?" Midoriya asks, breathing the smoke of his own flames. "Dad finally found an heir, you, and now you've got a little gang of thieves and murderers to do All Might in? Is that your master plan?"

Tomura's lips stretch into a smile. "Is that what you think?"

“I think you captured hundreds of innocent people in an underground city and *murdered* them, that’s what I think,” Midoriya snips, his lungs burning. “Am I right—“

The blow to his face is harsh, strong. The pain registers seconds later, a gnarly warmth racing across his face. Another blow hits him in the nose, breaks it, and he’s yanked forward by the collar of his shirt.

“You don’t know what the hell you're talking about, brother,” Tomura hisses, voice low and lethal. “You think your stupid little antics have taught you a single fucking thing? You have no idea what you’ve been born into.”

Midoriya spits blood onto Tomura’s shirt. “Then why don’t you enlighten me, huh? I think I’ve got a pretty good grasp.”

“Yeah?” His *brother* asks, laughing a little. “Did you know the training camp infiltration was a trap set just for you? That took *ages* to orchestrate, to get Dr.Ujiko to finally slip up, to mention the planned attack. He almost didn’t say it quickly enough. I was worried you wouldn’t know to go to the camp in time.”

Midoriya narrows his eyes. “I feel so special.”

“You should,” Tomura whispers, eyes flashing between outstretched fingers. “You *are.* Dad is never one-upped, much less by a woman and a kid. Not that we knew who you were when we watched you on those cameras—but I knew, the second you saw the wiped out city, that I was going to take you for myself before he could.”

He stays quiet, listens as Tomura exposes the truth.

“He wanted your mind for a Nomu, so I eliminated that possibility. Consider it a gift, I’m offering you something better,” he says quietly, eyes darting to the door and back to Midoriya. “Join me—join us, and you can walk out of here without issue. You can be part of the league of villains. I’ll hide your identity from Dad. So long as you keep quiet, I can offer you protection.”

“And aid in the death of all those people?” Midoriya asks, watching those eyes darken. “Is that what you stand for, Tomura?”

Another blow, to his jaw this time. “Don’t *ever* call me by my name, do you understand me?”

Midoriya spits out blood, watches it fall to the floor. He lifts his head slowly, eyes the broken glass that Dabi dropped.

“You’ve got connections,” Tomura says, drawing Midoriya’s attention. “Access to UA, to underground communities. We could use that.”

Midoriya flexes his jaw. “For what?”

“Don’t play stupid.”

“Please,” he says sweetly, “Enlighten me on your path to taking over the world, I’d love to hear it.”

Tomura’s temper is a short fuse, leading to explosive outbursts. It must be genetic. Midoriya’s anger can’t rival it, not when Tomura shoves him backward. The chair goes down, and it must be stronger than he thought, because it doesn’t break. Midoriya hits his head off the back of it, wincing.

“You’re beginning to piss me off,” Tomura warns him, his voice lethal. “Do you know what Dad did to our siblings?”

Midoriya glares up at him. “Tucked them into bed and read them stories?”

Tomura kicks his stomach, knocking the breath from his lungs.

“Slaughtered them. If they were girls, they were killed the second they popped out,” Another kick. “The boys? They were allowed to age, and the moment any of them turned out Quirkless, he’d rip them apart.”

Midoriya holds down vomit, his stomach aching, his eyes tearing up. “And the mothers?”

Tomura laughs softly. “Most try to run. Only two have ever gotten away, but one got caught later on.” He squats down, and Midoriya is hit with the discovery that he’s talking about both their moms.

Two women who tried to flee, one that was caught.

“And then I was born,” Tomura says, his eyes hard. “The first one that came out right.”

Midoriya stared at those red shoes. The thing with Quirkless feet is that the extra joint in the toe creates more mobility, allowing the pinky toe to bend. Quirkless people don’t fit into regular shoes, always needing more space. And Quirked people can’t fit theirs, always needing more width. It’s a fucked up truth, but it’s a truth nonetheless.

He reads the brand stamps, confirms it over and over again.

Tomura has no idea.

“So that’s it?” Midoriya asks, staring at those red shoes. “You come out with a Quirk and become his prodigy?”

Tomura laughs outwardly, grabbing Midoriya’s hair and pulling his face up. “You privileged little freak, you truly don’t know what’s happening here.”

Privileged?

This is privileged? His life is privileged? Always on the run, always stealing to eat, spending nights homeless or with no electricity? Getting beaten by his peers, changing his genetic makeup to hide his identity? *Privileged?*

He can’t enter a store without being watched, his skin color drawing attention. He can’t pursue any careers, his pinky toe inhibiting him. He is forever condemned to a fate beyond his own choosing because he was born without his own permission. And he’s *privileged?*

He has fought for every single thing he’s ever had, tooth and fucking nail. And here comes Dad’s favorite, some stupid, idiotic brother who has *no idea* what the fuck he’s talking about. He gets to live in this cushy building, bills paid, food supplied, a Quirk that is beyond special. He doesn’t have to look over his shoulder every day, doesn’t have to lose his friends because of things he could never control.

Midoriya decides, then and there, that Tomura is next in fucking line. Dad first, then his shitty, smart-mouthed brother. End the legacy of sexist, stupid men, before they can do more damage to the world.

“Last chance, brother,” Tomura urges, “Join us, or die.”

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 30: Escape

Chapter Summary

Rescue time!

Chapter Notes

This chapter was inspired by a suicide squad scene and also a funny ah ah TikTok so I hope you guys like it :)

Bakugou shoves Shinso to the ground, teeth bared into a smile. “Talk, jackass.”

Shinso glares up at him. “I’ve got better things to do.”

“If you think, for a single fucking second, that I’m letting you out of this, then you’re dumber than you look,” Bakugou warns him, circling his body on the floor. “You just came out of Deku’s house, who I know has ties to Viridant. So, if you want to keep your head attached to your body, then you’re going to talk.”

“Why should I?” Shinso shoots back.

Bakugou narrows his eyes. Two times now, this asshole has gotten him with that Quirk of his. It won’t happen again.

Shinso scoffs, pushes off the ground. “I’m going after Viridant. I’ve got a good idea of his location.”

“Great,” Bakugou grits out. “Then lead the damn way.”

The idiot outright laughs at him. “You’re kidding, right? You want to save Viridant?”

Bakugou searches for a good excuse, nearly spits it out. He quickly stops himself, holding it in as he remembers the asshole’s Quirk. Shinso narrows his eyes, lips pressed into a tight line.

“I guess I forgot,” he says simply, “Ground Zero is friends with Viridant, isn’t he?”

Fuuuuck, that’s not good. Bakugou can’t even fucking defend himself! He’s stuck, glaring at the purple-haired idiot and making no noise at all. They stand on the street outside Deku’s

apartment. It seems like they both knew who to go to for their information, using the cover of the night to get them by.

“Is that why you want to save him?” Shinso asks him, lips curled into a snarl. “To redeem yourself? Poor little Bakugou feels so bad for bullying a kid that he’s trying to atone. Do you even know how Viridant really is? Or are you too dense to connect those dots?”

Bakugou is fuming, grinding his jaw, licking his teeth.

“Go ahead.”

“Fuck you!” he shouts, first and foremost. “You’re a piece of shit, you know that? I’m trying to help your friend—*our* friend, and you're trying to fucking deny me like some self-righteous piece of shit? You think I don’t know my own history, jackass?” He steps into the idiot space, face pulled into a sneer. “I’m not losing this kid again. So you can either lead the fucking way, or I will climb to Deku’s window myself and bang on it until he opens it up and tells me exactly what he just told you.”

Shinso snorts. “Idiot.”

“You’re—“

“Hey, guys.” They both turn, staring as fucking *Todoroki* appears. “Sorry, I’m late.”

Bakugou rubs his temples. “What the fuck are you doing here?”

Todoroki smooths down a hoodie he wears, the tag still fucking attached to it. “I thought we were going after Viridant?”

“You seriously invited a fucking friend,” Shinso spits.

“I didn’t invite shit!” Bakugou yells.

Todoroki says, perfectly stoic, “Oh. I thought it was a volunteer job.”

They stare at him. He blinks slowly. The moron went and bought a hoodie and sweatpants to match Bakugou and Shinso. Even then, it’s pristine, high quality, a far cry from the street clothes both of them wore for the occasion. He’s wearing name-brand shoes, for fucks sake, he thinks he’s going to fit into this town?

Shinso shakes his head. “This is personal, Todoroki.”

Icy Hot nods, then pulls a gun from his pocket. The two of them immediately cuss and duck when he waves it around.

“I stole my dad's gun.”

“What the fuck!” Bakugou shouts at him, approaching quickly and yanking it away. “Why?!”

“I’m confused by the question,” Todoroki says.

Shinso starts laughing. It’s hysterical, on edge. “I can’t believe Viridant’s life rests in the hands of two idiots. This is the worst possible thing that could’ve happened.”

Todoroki tilts his head. “I don’t think you and Bakugou are idiots at all.”

“Oh my god,” Bakugou whispers, shutting his eyes tight. “Okay, we’re doing this. Fucking huddle, god dammit.”

“No, no way,” Shinso argues. “I’m not working with either of you! This isn’t some fucking play date!”

Bakugou glares, fists clenched. “Teamwork is an effective tool for success.” His therapist would be cheering right now. “Get the fuck over here and work with us, or I will call Eraser Head right now and sell this entire shitty plan out.”

“You wouldn’t sacrifice a chance to save Viridant,” Shinso challenges.

“I’m taking the best possible route to rescuing him, and that includes your involvement,” Bakugou grits out, surprised at the lack of shame from the confession. “If you opt out, then Eraser becomes the next best option. So you tell me, Eyebags, are you going to get a fucking grip so we can find him, or are you going to wait for someone to change your god damn diaper?”

Shinso has the cruel promise of death in his eyes as he approaches them. He snatches the gun from Bakugou, slides it into his waistband. Bakugou isn’t complaining. Guns are fucking boring. His hands are literal bombs; the last thing he needs are bullets.

Todoroki looks around, takes in the flickering street lamps and trash in the street. “Why did you guys decide to meet here?”

“We didn’t decide to meet,” Shinso says, eyes dark. “Bakugou followed me.”

“Yes, I fucking did,” he says, not an ounce of shame. “Pulled your address right from UA files. This hacking shit isn’t nearly as hard as I thought.”

“Especially when you're working for the damn school, I’d bet,” Shinso retorts. “I wonder what Viridant will say about that? I bet he’ll be fucking ecstatic.”

Todoroki asks, “Why would he be happy about that? I’d think he’d feel betrayed or something.”

“Wow, even the walking mannequin understands that concept.” Shinso offers Bakugou a slow smile. “I hope I’m there to witness him finding you out.”

“You? Being part of Viridant’s life long enough to bear witness to something? That’s a foreign concept for you, isn’t it?” Bakugou asks.

“I think we should hurry,” Todoroki says, putting himself between them. “Most kidnapping victims are found within the first few hours. We’ve already burnt a day. We don’t have time to argue about Bakugou being stupid. That happens all the time. What we need to focus on is a solid, good plan.”

He can’t believe that Todoroki Shoto is the voice of reason right now. He lets the insult slide, deciding instead to talk the two of them into the bullet train. Shinso, shockingly enough, agrees with the plan. Keep it quiet, undetected, and get into Tokyo with zero notice.

The plan starts to differ when they pick locations to search. Shinso says Chou City is the best option, but Bakugou thinks Koto is better. He then, of course, has to admit that he had been in Chou City recently and came up empty on potential places to have a hideout. Even the abandoned building was a dud. It might have the most direct tunnel to the underground city, but it’s since been filled in and cleaned out. They’d be wasting time on a dead end.

Explaining this simple concept to Hitoshi Shinso is like talking to a brick fucking wall. The idiot claims that Koto has already been searched top to bottom when the Pros were hunting for Viridant when he first got stabbed. There’s absolutely no chance that they left a secret hideout unturned, let alone didn’t go back to search the town again once seeing where the tunnels led. It would be a waste of time.

Todoroki says, “What about in between them?”

They stare at him. He took the middle seat on the bus, squishing Bakugou against the window and Shinso in the aisle. Bakugou is trying to convince himself it’s because he wanted to separate the two of them, but he’s pretty sure the dipshit just wanted to sit under the AC.

“It’s about an hour walk between the two, and there’s a huge shopping and housing district. Plus, no direct tunnels connect to the gap between them, meaning it would be left undetected by Pros or police.” Todoroki yawns, rubs his eyes. “This is such a late time to be out, I’m getting tired.”

“He’s… right,” Shinso says, exasperated. “I can’t believe he’s fucking right, I’m never this stupid, I think arguing with you is frying my brain.”

Bakugou scoffs. “Whatever you have to tell yourself.”

More details are hammered out, discussion about the town and what ground to cover. Bakugou pays attention to all of it, hears the words they say, ingrains them into his mind. He’s going to save Viridant, he’s going to figure this out.

When the bus goes quiet, and only the hum of its engine fills the air, Bakugou thinks about Deku.

He should’ve climbed up to his window and knocked anyway. Or made his mom some food and knocked on the front door. He’s not sure why it was a relief to find Shinso already here, why it was a relief to not have to talk to Deku. He comes up a lot these days, between therapy and his own mind. He’s working on not thinking of him as a ghost, as this entity that haunts him.

But it doesn't change things if he's honest. He likes to think he's doing better, but he's not too sure if he really is. When the two of them stood on that roof in Choi City, with the rain pouring down on them, and Deku had asked him outright if he regretted what he'd done to him… Bakugou couldn't get the words out. It was like they were stuck in his throat, choking him, and he just couldn't clear the way to talk, much less to breathe.

He couldn't figure out how Deku would've convinced himself that Bakugou didn't regret it. Name-calling, picking on him, throwing him around—none of it compared to those handprints, forever engraved in Deku's arms. And Bakugou is awful, he is mean, he is cruel, he's hotheaded and angry—but he isn't that. He isn't the kind of person to leave marks like that. Not on anyone's skin, but especially not on Deku's.

This whole time, he was so worried about… about Deku's dad coming back. He saw those bruises, the small burns, the limp in his leg. He called the landline every day just to see who picked up the phone. He doesn't know about Deku's life before he moved to this town, but he knows, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that no kid deserves to go through what he had.

And, as it turns out, it had been Bakugou the whole time. Every bruise, every scar, every burn. *Him.* He's not sure what to do with himself, what to make of himself anymore. He's no Hero, Heroes don't do that, but then again, Bakugou isn't too sure what a Hero really is anymore. Maybe he's exactly on par with the course, following down the path so many have walked before him.

But Bakugou doesn't want to be angry anymore. He doesn't want to hurt people anymore. He doesn't want to yell and shout and feel so *angry* all the fucking time. It's in every single thing he does, this frustration and devastation, and he loathes it. He's not sure any amount of therapy, of reflection, of atonement, will ever make up for those two handprints on Deku's forearms.

So maybe Eyebags was right. Maybe Bakugou is here not just for Viridant, but for Deku. Maybe giving his all to someone who would hate him if they knew what he's done—maybe that's Bakugou's fate. Maybe he'll be perpetually stuck in this cycle of hurting others and trying to fix it until the day his heart stops beating. But he thinks, maybe, just maybe, that's enough. Maybe it'll be enough, maybe it'll make a difference. Maybe Deku won't look at him with that pain on his face, as though he's still burning, still breathing the embers of a fire he never started.

Bakugou likes Viridant. He does his best to be honest, and he's not too good at doing that. But their conversations are always softer than Bakugou's usual. He doesn't yell—unless it's urgent, and they joke and Bakugou learns how to talk in a way he's never had before. He is the best version of himself when he talks to this vigilante, and he can't lose Viridant almost as much as he can't lose those pieces of himself that have finally bubbled to the surface. He likes who he is when he's with Viridant.

Shinso keeps his eyes shut, his head tilted ever so slightly backwards. Bakugou stares at his face, at the exhaustion lining it. This is PM. This is Viridant's right-hand man. Why did he leave? Why did he disappear from Viridant's life? Because Bakugou sees how he fights for him now, and he knows that Viridant must've gotten it all wrong. PM didn't use him, didn't

leave him behind when he got what he wanted. Bakugou isn't sure what happened, but he knows it wasn't that.

You don't get attached to someone and walk away without the colors of them painted along your ribs. And Shinso is green, maybe just as much as Bakugou is.

"Shinso," Todoroki says when they make it to their stop. "You should go after people. See if you can get any witnesses or mentions of a hideout."

He turns to Bakugou next. "You take to the rooftops, stay high up. See if you can get the drop on anything."

"And you?" Bakugou asks, stretching out his arms and legs. "What will the genius IcyHot do?"

Shinso rolls his eyes, stalks off to start. He misses when Todoroki says, "I've got my own lead. We'll call if we find anything, okay?"

"Fucking ominous as hell, but fine."

And then they split up, going in opposite directions. He can't even begin to imagine what led Todoroki could possibly have, so he doesn't waste a moment thinking about it. Instead, he climbs up building walls, peers into windows, opens roof latches, and gazes inside. He comes up empty every time.

When his phone buzzes, he whips it out with hthe ope that it was Viridant. He sees that it was his regular phone, and the hope dies in his chest.

Aizawa-sensei: Where are you?

Oh fuck.

Bakugou: At home, why?

Aizawa-sensei: Interesting, because I'm currently standing in your living room with your parents. Want to try again?

Double fuck.

Aizawa-sensei: We were discussing opening a dormitory system at UA to ensure student safety, and I got the nagging, terrible suspicion that your absence wasn't because you were asleep.

Bakugou: I couldn't just give up on him.

Aizawa-sensei: Where are you?

Bakugou: I'll update when I can.

INCOMING CALL.

Bakugou declines it, slides his phone back into his pocket. He is absolutely fucking done for when he goes home tonight. Of course, he had to get Bakugou's parents involved.

The thought makes him shiver. Being out in the night always makes him antsy, but being alone, wandering alleyways and coming to dead ends, it sets his nerves on fire. He doesn't like that dark, not since—

He shakes it from his mind, moves on, pushes through the fear. He hates being afraid almost as much as he hates being angry. But both seem to fucking plague him, his walking punishment for his brutality.

He drops from a roof to an alleyway, gritting his teeth when he sees where he landed. His feet on the manhole cover at the four-way, standing atop dozens of corpses. Viridant went straight when he landed here, and Bakugou knows it was searched completely when the cops and Pros arrived. If forward is neighborhoods, then backwards leads towards Chou City. He goes that way, cursing the darkness for making this so much harder on him.

Koto and Chou City connect over a body of water, one of which Bakugou is nearly about to cross. He stares at the bridge, traffic driving loudly over it. He takes a left from there, heading down another alleyway. It's just a bunch of fucking alleyways. It's beyond him that Viridant can navigate this shit, but he tries anyway.

He makes it a few feet before he spots a mark on the side of a building. It's black, flaky, and he runs a finger through it to determine what it is. Ash. Someone burnt a mark into this wall. He goes a few more steps, turns a corner, and sees another mark. Someone with a fire Quirk made a path, a way to get back home, wherever the fuck that is.

Bakugou grins and follows it. A quick text to Todoroki and, unfortunately, Shinso, has them finding him pretty quickly. Todoroki had been following the same trail on the opposite end of the city, Shinso being told about it minutes ago by passing civilians. So the three of them walk together, deathly quiet, and follow the trail of soot.

Todoroki spots the marks quicker than the other two, urging them along as he guides them. His flame keeps it well lit, though he seems to hate the idea of using it. Bakugou won't complain, it's freezing fucking cold out here, and so dark that he can barely see his own two feet.

The marks eventually stop outside a brick building. It's short, stumpy, windows blocked with cardboard from the inside. There are smaller houses and buildings around it, but this one seems to be the most hidden. It doesn't stand out, doesn't even appear to be operating.

The three of them divide up tasks. It's decided that Shinso will use his support weapon, which he reveals he had brought and stuffed under his fucking hoodie. He'll wrap it around Todoroki's waist, then stand on the roof and slowly pull him upwards. It'll bring the Candy Cane to the windows, where he'll burn a hole in the glass pane and push the cardboard aside to let them get a good look in. Bakugou will keep a lookout below, and when it's clear, blast a hole into the fucking wall and rush in.

Shinso lands on the roof, gives the signal, and then the rescue mission starts.

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Midoriya can hardly see out of his eyes. His head spins, his clothes soaked through with blood. Tomura beat the ever-loving shit out of him. You'd think agreeing to join this league would've spared him the additional torture. Fun fact, it didn't, and the pain he's currently in is excruciating.

At least he's lying on the ground. Tomura untied him from the chair the second he confirmed he was Quirkless. Makes it a bit easier to beat him senseless. His brother put an artist's glove on to ensure he didn't disintegrate Midoriya as he beat his face in. He's so considerate, isn't he?

Midoriya coughs, chokes on his own blood. He spits it onto the floor, his body aching with the movement. His ribs are on fire, definitely a few broken or bruised. It's nothing compared to his face, which he's certain is horrifically mangled.

Tomura flicks blood off his shirt, squatting down to Midoriya's level. "You need a better pain tolerance."

"Thanks," he wheezes out, "I was a visual learner anyway."

"Do you understand why I'm doing this to you?" Tomura asks him.

Midoriya answers the same thing he's been saying since this first started hours ago. "Because you've got cuteness aggression?"

He socks him in the throat, making it close up and swell. Midoriya coughs weakly, grunting at the lack of oxygen.

"Because this is nothing compared to what Dad will do to you. You still haven't broken, so I'm actually kind of impressed. But I'll ask again, just because you're being a pain in the ass. What is your mom's name?" Tomura waits, hand removed to reveal his flaky skin.

Midoriya says, as seriously as he can, "Toshinori Yagi."

His brother sighs. "I'm going to start cutting off body parts, you understand that, right? I need this information to keep her safe."

"Oh, I'm… sure," he pants, his voice rough and ruined. "Safety… number one… priority."

Tomura stands, clicks his tongue. "You don't even beg, it's not fun."

Midoriya grits his teeth when he's lifted up by his shirt, his ribs aching and screaming. The bar floor is soaked with his blood, saliva, and vomit. His body trembles with it, his animal crackers long gone. He's unsure how long they've been at this, only that nobody has interrupted them. Wherever the other people went, they're gone now, or at least in the room outside of this bar. He's beginning to think he's inside some kind of weird ass house.

"Last chance," Tomura says softly, his knuckles torn open. "Your mom's name, and I won't go get someone with a stronger stomach to rip your fingernails off."

Midoriya smiles weakly, spitting on his face. "Nana Shimura."

Tomura's eyes go dark. "Where'd you hear that name?"

"That's my mom's name."

"Bull fucking shit!" Tomura shouts at him, throws him backwards. "You are *infuriating*. No DNA test needed, I can tell exactly who's fucking son you are."

Midoriya keeps his mouth shut, holds his vomit down.

"You've got a few moments to recover. The torture stops once you start talking. And trust me, with what you're about to endure, you'll be talking." Tomura stands, approaches the bar. He grabs a bit of cloth someone dropped off for him, wrapping his knuckles and hands with it. "We'll see if you make it out of that."

Midoriya shudders when his brother steps over his body on the floor. The door opens, shuts, his uneven steps disappearing somewhere down the hall. The music Tomura put on is still playing softly, some stupid video game background music that Midoriya has been losing his mind listening to.

Only when he's certain the guy is gone does Midoriya try to roll over. Pain shoots along his body, his vision spotting, but he moves anyway. He expected not to get brutalized when he agreed to join this league; look how good that did him. He grits his teeth, tears in his eyes as he manages to flip to his right side. He won't make noise, won't beg, won't reveal his hand. He'd die before he ever sells Mama out, and if he stays here, he will.

He pushes off the floor with his bound-together feet. The rope is tight, keeping his feet firmly together. His hands are even worse, still trapped in that stupid metal box, tied within that. His backpack is long gone, so he goes for his next best option.

The glass Himiko shattered still lies on the floor. He knows this because he was thrown onto it a few times. Either way, large shards lay flat on the floor. He works his way over, as quiet as he can be. Luckily, his blood loss works to his advantage. The liquid pooled enough to make the floor slippery, allowing him easier mobility to slide through it. When he makes it to the far corner with the glass, his ribs are on fire.

"Come on, come on," he whispers, biting his lip as he forces his legs to his chest.

He can't get his shoes off, the rope too tight, but he can just barely part his feet from each other. Midoriya sets his shoe atop a shard of glass, slides the thick piece along the bloody floor. He carefully pushes it against the bar counter, trying his best to balance it against the wood. It takes a few panicked tries, but he manages to get the shard to point up. So very slowly, so very carefully, he pushes the glass in the tiny gap between his shoes.

His spine burns, his ribs throbbing. Still, he lifts his legs up and down, shimmies his feet side to side, pressing the sharp glass against the rope. He shakes horribly, more vomit rising, but nothing comes out. He's empty of anything, just trails of stomach acid spilling past his lips. The sting of it is nothing compared to his chest, his back, his face.

The glass shard falls through his shoes, and he has to do the long process again. On the second try, with more careful wiggling, it drags through the rope. When it's severed, tears of pure elation stream down his face. He did it. He fucking did it. His feet ache and buzz when he stretches his legs out, pushing his back against the countertop. He hunches, uses the wood as his leverage, and gets his body up and off the floor.

Midoriya stumbles a bit, his vision dizzy, but he's up. He's on his feet.

He heads for the only door in this room. He knows it leads to what is likely a hallway, which most definitely leads to people. But he's got no other option. He needs to get the fuck out of here.

He lifts his leg again, puts the crevice of his knee against the circular doorknob. Then he rotates forward, spins the handle, and pops the door open. It's a miracle that it wasn't locked. Once again, his Quirklessness renders him a damsel in distress. They didn't even think to lock him in.

Midoriya creaks the door open, peers out. The hall itself is empty, but he can hear the sound of a TV in another room to his right. There are a few doors, but he locks onto the long corridor. At the end, there's definitely some sort of exit. Maybe stairs, or a door, or who gives a shit, he'd take a fucking window right now!

But he's got to find his bag first. His support weapon is in there, his notes, his phone; he needs access to his shit again. So he creeps into the hallway, moves to the first door he sees right across from the one he was in. He twists the handle with his leg, pushes it quietly open.

Himiko looks up at him from where she sits against the wall. The room is decked out in teenage design choices. Pink walls, posters, and clothing. She's got cat bedsheets, a small table full of knick-knacks. He spots a mini fridge against the opposite wall, the clear glass of it revealing clear bags inside. Stuffed full of blood.

She grins at him, her eyes darting behind him. Midoriya spins just in time, catching whoever the hell was sneaking up on him. The perks of the metal box on his hands, it packs a punch. He bashes it against Twice's head. Once. Twice. And he flops to the floor on the third time.

The first time the guy was actually quiet. Midoriya almost feels bad.

"Hi, cutie!" Himiko whisper-cheers, giggling at him. "Welcome to my bedroom!"

Midoriya can't even blink at her; his eyes are too swollen. "Where's my shit?"

She snickers. "Downstairs, second door. You've got to get past Dabi's room, and he's in an awful mood, so good luck."

Midoriya nods. "Keys?"

She outright laughs at that. "Spinner's got those."

"Lizard guy?" Midoriya musters up.

"Yup."

"Ugh."

"I can't believe a boy is in my room!" she squeals, wiggling her shoulders. "Dabi will kill you if he finds out. He's very protective."

"You live here?" Midoriya questions. "Where the hell… am I?"

"One of our home bases," she says, standing before sliding to the floor. She opens her mini fridge, pulls a bag out. "We don't usually torture people inside them, but Tomura was insistent."

Midoriya watches as she pops off the plastic lid to the pouch and sucks the contents out. Dark, red blood fills her mouth, painting her teeth and staining her lips. He wonders how much of that is his or Uraraka's. He can see a hospital logo on the bag, so maybe this is donated bodily anatomy. He's unsure.

"Well, get going!" She shoo's him. "Or you'll suffer the consequences. I'll see you around!"

"Hopefully not." He shuts her door, not anymore clear on what the fuck is happening than he was before.

Twice is limp on the ground. Midoriya steps over him. He takes off down the hall, unsure which door is Dabi's or which is Spinner's. He doesn't exactly care to fucking find out; he just needs to go home.

Slowly, he heads down the stairs. He has to jump right back up as the smoke-guy, Kurogiri, walks by. The man seals himself inside a room downstairs a moment later, and Midoriya takes that as his chance to get the hell out of here. He lands on the bottom floor, spots the second door, and pushes it open.

Not a moment too late, as Kurogiri exits whatever room he was just inside. What the hell is this place? A housing facility? Why are there so many rooms here? Himiko said it's one of their home bases, and her room was decked out enough to accommodate that theory. But what the hell? What is going on with the League of Villains?

He's not coherent enough to question it. His eyes land on his yellow bag sitting atop an ugly green sofa. He heads for it and stops abruptly when a large, rusted blade is pressed to his

throat.

“I don’t like you Hero types,” Spinner says, his voice sounding as though he’s hissing at him. “Can never leave well enough alone.”

Midoriya sniffles, keeping his face blank. “Tomura would be pissed if you killed me before I ever got the chance to confess whatever the hell he wants me to.”

Spinner huffs a laugh. “Bummer for him.”

“I’m joining your little league,” Midoriya says instead. “You think Heroes need to die, don’t you? I’m on your side. They’re corrupt, ruinous.”

“Typically, you don’t try to flee from organizations you’re a part of,” Spinner informs him, slowly circling, blade still to Midoriya’s throat. “I don’t think you’ve got what it takes to be part of us.”

Midoriya’s throat bobs, the tip of the sword pressed to it. “I killed that muscular asshole.”

Spinner tilts his head. “Is that where he went off to?”

“Bottom of the mountain,” Midoriya says flatly, sucking in air when Spinner withdraws his blade. “It was easy.”

“Easy?” Spinner repeats, disbelieving. He steps closer, face inches from Midoriya’s. “How’d you do it?”

Memories flash. The rage, the hatred.

Midoriya smiles sweetly. “Quickly.”

He bashes his head forward, knocking his forehead harshly against Spinner’s nose. The bastard raises his sword, swings down, and Midoriya catches it on his metal box. The blade embeds itself into the element, and he lifts a leg to kick Spinner’s balls under their connected limbs.

He squeaks, and Midoriya kicks again when he hunches forward, this time to the chest. As he goes down, Midoriya yanks his metal box forward, dislodging the sword, and brings it down on Spinner’s skull. He flops like Twice did, nearly just as easily.

Do these guys have no training or something? They have housing, but how do they not have training? This is kind of sad. It shouldn’t be nearly as easy as it is to bash their heads in with a box.

Oh well.

He squats down, uses his tongue and mouth to grab the keys off Spinner’s belt loop. He holds them between his lips, digs the serrated edge into the lock of his shackles. They clank and pop off, thudding on the floor and revealing Midoriya’s hands. He doesn’t have time to unbind the second rope.

He sprints to his bag, rips out a spare fabric mask, and ties it over his mouth and nose. Then he slings the bag over his shoulder, undoing the straps to get it over his bound arms. And then, just like that, he's set, he's getting the hell out of here.

He shoves open the door again, meeting Magne and all her glory. Midoriya makes quick work of her, shoving her full force into Kurogiri and sprinting in the opposite direction to the front door. He makes it in time, barreling through it and slamming it shut when smoke races for him.

Night air whips at him, and he wastes no time running to the opposite side of the building. There should be some alleyways to get lost in or…

Three people look at him from their spot outside the building. Hitoshi is on the roof, his capture weapon wrapped around the waist of Endeavor's son and helping him climb the brick. Then, of course, Bakugou, who has his hands outstretched and ready to blow.

Midoriya blinks, deepens his voice. "What are you guys doing here?"

Bakugou opens his mouth, shuts it. Hitoshi speaks up, "We came… to rescue you."

"What?" Midoroya's eyes water, his heart racing. "You guys came to save me?"

"Yeah," Bakugou says flatly, "Had the whole thing fucking planned out."

"That's," Midoriya lifts his bloodied, tied-up hands to wipe his eyes. "That's so sweet, I can go back inside?" Todoroki still dangles from the support item. Slowly, Hitoshi lowers him to the floor. A loud rumbling comes from around the building, the front door flying open and banging against the side of the house. "On second thought, run!"

Midoriya takes off past them, heat chasing his back as blue fire rushes after him. He messes with his ropes as he goes, cursing and sprinting down alleyways.

"Fuck it," he snaps his thumb backwards, lays it flat against his hand, and yanks the rope over it. The pain is minor compared to his other injuries, not to mention his adrenaline pumping enough to keep him functioning.

He reaches into his bag as he runs, tries to yank out his scarf. Heat pulses, fire rages, nearly hits him—

BOOM!

A loud explosion sounds from behind him. Midoriya only has a second to gasp as a solid body collides with him, sweeping him off his feet.

Wind whips at him as they take off into the sky. Midoriya clings onto Bakugou for dear life, arms wrapped around his neck, his legs supported by Bakugou's arms. By *Kacchan.*

A glance down shows a thick, corded fabric around Bakugou's foot. Hitoshi, holding on with his support item, Todoroki hanging from his side. What is going on?!

More fire chases them into the air, but Kacchan is too fast. He blasts into the sky, higher and higher and higher, Midoriya clutched against his chest. They launch into the stars, pierce through clouds. Just the two of them, the moonlight shining down on them from up here.

And they look at each other, eyes locked, faces inches apart. Just the two of them.

“AIRPLANE!” Hitoshi screams.

“Fuck.” Kacchan blasts downwards as a plane comes rushing in.

They take off in the air, the momentum launching Hitoshi and Todoroki upwards, keeping them steady. They weave through the city, the nighttime providing a cover as they fly through the sky. Midoriya had always wanted to know what it felt like to fly; he hadn’t expected it to come true like this. Kacchan keeps them in the air, moving between buildings and spaces.

When they finally land on a roof, Todoroki throws up from motion sickness. Hitoshi is bad off, too; his hair whipped in bizarre directions. Kacchan is fine, and Midoriya feels lighter than he has in… in a long time.

Todoroki retches off the side of the roofing again as Kacchan and Shinso turn to him. Uh oh.

“What the fuck were you thinking, huh?” Kacchan grinds out, lips curled. “Getting captured like that? Are you a fucking idiot?”

Shinso pipes up. “Thanks for saving us, but are you out of your fucking mind?”

Midoriya is getting whiplash again. “How did you guys find me?”

Todoroki groans, pukes again.

“We aren’t fucking stupid,” Kacchan says, stepping closer. “You’ve got a lot of damn explaining to do.”

He pokes Midoriya's chest, reeling his hand back immediately when he hunches and grabs his ribs. It *hurts.* The adrenaline is wearing off, the panic and pain settling in. His ribs are definitely the worst of all, screaming in pain. But he’s certain his face doesn’t look too good either.

“What happened to you?” Hitoshi asks, reaching a hand out to rest on Midoroya’s shoulder.

Midoriya pulls away, ignoring the way Hitoshi’s face falls. “Nothing I can’t handle.”

“Wrong fucking answer,” Kacchan says, glaring at him. “You need to go to the hospital. I can call Eraser—“

“No!” Midoriya says quickly, coughing and spitting up blood. “No, we can’t. I just need some rest.”

“That won’t fix this,” Hitoshi says softly, earning the most bizarre look from Kacchan. “You need medical attention, Viridant.”

“I-I don’t,” Midoriya stutters out, exhaustion pulling at him. “I’m fine. We need to get out of here before someone calls in about the whereabouts of the league.”

“I already did.” Todoroki wipes his mouth. “It’s already been called in.”

“What?” Midoriya seethes, his rage boiling over. “Why would you do that? This was a huge lead! The Pros will *bury* this, we need—*I* need to—“

“You’re not going fucking anywhere,” Kacchan snaps, grabbing Midoriya’s arm. “You look like shit. Icy Hot made the right call. This shit is beyond you, leave it for the Pros.”

Midoriya looks for anyone to back him up. Hitoshi stays quiet, toeing the floor. Todoroki crosses his arms. Kacchan holds him in place. Midoriya’s going to get caught! They’ll throw him in jail, or tell his Mama, he’s not sure which is worse.

“You agree with this?” he asks Hitoshi, his voice wavering. “Did you tell him who I am?”

Hitoshi finally meets his eyes. “No, he just came on his own.”

“Oh, fucking fantastic!" Midoriya cries out, yanking his arm and still not getting it loose from Kacchan’s grasp. “So I get to have an identity reveal in front of everyone, that was the plan?”

“We came to help you.”

“I was *fine* on my own,” Midoriya says, hysteria roiling in him. “I can’t get caught, you don’t understand.”

“*You* don’t fucking understand,” Kacchan says, eyes hard. “This is—“

Midoriya can’t take it. He uses his other hand to rip his scarf from his bag. The material instantly adheres to his brain waves, shooting out to grab Hitoshi and yank him harshly forward. He hopes his bad karma doesn’t come after him for this. He throws Hitoshi atop Kacchan, bashing their temples together until they both go limp.

When his hand is finally free, he steps away from them.

Todoroki puts his hands in the air. “I’ll pass on getting knocked out, please."

Midoriya breathes heavily. “You’re going to let me go.”

“Tell me something first, and I won’t tell anyone anything,” Todoroki says quickly, his face perfectly blank. “Dabi—did you talk to him?”

He called Midoriya a feral animal and kept a far radius. “Briefly.”

“Is he… is he doing alright?” Todoroki asks.

Midoriya furrows his brows. “What?”

“Just tell me.”

He takes a deep breath in, his ribs burning. “He’s doing fine. He takes care of this teenage girl in there, I guess.”

Todoroki nods, sits down on the roof. “I’ll tie us all up. Run, Viridant.”

Midoriya launches the scarf out, latches it onto the side of a building. “Why did you want to know about Dabi?”

Todoroki doesn’t answer, just stares straight ahead, tying himself up with Hitoshi and Kacchan. Midoriya decides some things are better left untouched, and swings from the roof of the building without another word.

Chapter 31: Mama's boy

Chapter Summary

Aizawa and Bakugou deal with the aftermath of Viridant's escape.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is also inspired by a TikTok

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Hey, bestie!”

Aizawa holds his phone to his ear. “Viridant. You’re okay? Thank god, I was worried you’d gotten hurt or—“

“Nope!” Viridant wheezes out, his fake deep voice strained. “Quick question, though, where’s my mask and helmet?”

Aizawa rubs his eyes and leans against the door frame of his house. He just returned from the Bakugou’s household, which was a very concerning environment. He’ll be sure to have a talk with Bakugou about his home life, amongst other things. Like sneaking out at night to rescue Viridant. The lack of response from the student, but a complete response from Viridant, indicates it was a successful rescue.

Which is great, because he can recall the police and Pros he sent after Bakugou. It doesn’t change that Aizawa will have to fetch the child at some point, but he’s going to make him suffer first. Despite Bakugou sneaking out of his house to find Viridant, Aizawa’s been having a fantastic day.

For one, the dorms are all but ready to be moved into. The construction had been occurring previously, and was rushed in light of the training camp attack. Therefore, it’s ready for all students. For two, Nezu is almost done recovering the fourth encoded server at UA, and officially revealing who Viridant actually is. And that’s saying that Aizawa doesn’t figure it out first based on the photos he has of the kid's face, as well as the DNA from inside his mask. Which is his third reason for a good day. He’ll hear back from the lab tomorrow about a turned-in hair follicle or potential blood or saliva.

And, fourth, of course. Viridant is okay. Though he certainly doesn’t sound like it.

“You want to know where your gear is?” Aizawa questions, sipping a cup of coffee at eight in the afternoon. “You know what I want, Viridant?”

The kid guesses, “Pasta!”

Aizawa shuts his eyes, takes a deep breath. “Turn yourself in.”

“Oh, let me think about that really fast!” Viridant hums quietly, wind whipping at his phone speaker as though he’s traveling. Likely by his stolen support weapon. “I’m going to give it a pass, maybe next time, though.”

Aizawa crosses his ankles, stares outside at the dark sky. “UA will pardon you of all crime on the condition that you actively partake in our Hero program. You can do this legally, with proper training.”

Viridant laughs lowly. “Why would I trust you?”

He frowns. He and Viridant aren’t buddy-buddy, but he had at least thought the kid trusted him somewhat. He’s done his best to keep a distance while still maintaining the vigilante’s safety through Ground Zero. But maybe he hasn’t been doing enough.

“I know you were rejected from UA,” Aizawa says softly, his voice carrying on the night air. “It was the biggest mistake we’ve made yet. Let us fix it. I can send you whatever proof you need to believe me. I want you in my class, I want to teach you and help you learn and grow. I think you want that, too.”

Viridant is quiet for a long while. The wind whips at his speaker, the sound of cars honking coming in and out on the receiver. Aizawa keeps the phone to his ear the whole time, listening as the kid keeps on swinging by.

“We’ll see,” Viridant responds, and Aizawa has no doubt the kid will search for the documentation himself to ensure its authenticity. “I left your students tied to a rooftop in Chou City.”

Aizawa blinks slowly, sips from his coffee. “Great.”

“Tell them I’m grateful for their help, but to stay home next time.”

“Oh, believe me,” Aizawa says, downing the rest of his drink. “They will be dealt with.”

“Have a good night, Sigma.”

He furrows his brows. “What the hell did you call me?”

The call ends with a small, childish laugh from Viridant. Aizawa doesn’t have it in his heart to be mad about being whatever a sigma is. The kid sounded just like his students did in class, and that’s enough for him not to be mad at all.

He places his cup in the sink, says bye to his husband, and gets onto the long task of swinging hours away to Tokyo. He has a car following him, though he beats it there very

quickly. He's certain Bakugou, and whoever else decided this journey was a good idea, will want a car to sleep in on the ride home. After he's done ripping into them, of course.

It takes ten minutes to find the three students. It's an odd collection, and one he's beyond disappointed to observe. He crouches on the ledge of a neighboring roof, taking the three of them in. Bakugou was a given. Aizawa had a feeling he'd do something stupid in the absence of Viridant. He had upped a few patrols around the kids' house and stopped by it early on in the day just to make sure. Seems like he managed to find a way around it anyway. Todoroki is a wildcard, though it does line up with the students' encounter with Viridant. He likely wanted to repay a debt.

Then, there's Shinso. Aizawa's had his eye on Shinso for a while now. He's been training the kid to get into 1-A, his personal prodigy, and the resulting interactions between them have been… interesting. Six students made it to higher-level classes from Gen Ed. Two were female, and the other four had the potential to be PM, Viridant's conspirator. Aizawa's been slow to act on them, wanting to make absolutely certain he was correct.

But here his number one guess sits, cursing and trying to get out of his own support weapon. Aizawa is disappointed. He wanted Viridant's friend to be someone else, someone who was impulsive or careless. Shinso is anything but. He's smart, shows promise, and Aizawa has personally enjoyed every session with the kid. He wants to be a Hero; he has the same kernel of fire inside him that makes a great Pro.

So he's disappointed—in all of them. He expected something less reckless, something more thought out. Or, god forbid, he expected them to come to him about their plan. They managed to locate a villain's hideout, managed to save a life. And had they done it legally and with supervision, maybe they wouldn't be tied up and left on a roof.

He swoops down, lands carefully beside them. Their previous arguing and fighting comes to a complete halt.

"Never, in my ten years of teaching," Aizawa starts, arms crossed over his chest. "Have I ever had three students do something so completely stupid and disrespectful."

Todoroki says, "How old are you?"

Shinso purses his lips and looks away, Bakugou pressing his lips into a tight line.

Aizawa takes a deep breath. "I should expel all three of you for your recklessness."

He stares at the scarf they're still tied in. Bakugou and Shinso have matching bruises on either of their faces, likely a result of being bashed together in Viridant's escape. Todoroki looks at ease, perfectly blank-faced, so he's got no idea what to even make of that. He's too busy focusing on the two main problem children.

Slowly, he approaches, gives the end of the knot a yank, and watches the whole thing come undone easily. They immediately separate, Bakugou and Shinso repelling to opposite ends of the rooftop like magnets. Todoroki stays seated, yawning.

Aizawa is at least grateful that there weren't more students involved in this ridiculous plan. But self-defense training and escape techniques will be added to their curriculum immediately. This is just embarrassing, honestly.

"Explain yourself," he says, deciding Bakugou is his best bet to go after. "And be very, very clear."

The kid licks his teeth, a nervous tic. "We came out here to find fucking Viridant. The idiot freed himself, and when we tried to escape with him, he knocked me and Eyebags out."

"*How* did you know where to look?" Aizawa asks.

Bakugou shrugs. "Just guessed."

Aizawa's hair picks up, his eyes flashing. "Do you enjoy your time at UA, Bakugou?"

His student keeps quiet.

"I'm disappointed, I truly am. The school trusted you to be part of a bigger operation that you legally agreed to, and you pulled this? Months of progress, of work, and you throw it away for a half assed rescue mission?" Aizawa lectures him, his voice hard. "Does Viridant know your identity?"

Bakugou stares off in the distance. "I don't think so."

"Oh, well, if you don't think so!" Aizawa grinds out. "Is that other student...is he—"

"No," Bakugou shakes his head. "I recruited him because I thought his Quirk might be fucking useful. He's not PM."

Aizawa deflates a bit, runs a hand through his hair. "You're off the mission."

Bakugou startles, his eyes wide. "What? Are you fucking kidding me?"

"Burner phone." Aizawa holds his hand out. When Bakugou doesn't move, he grumbles, "Now."

"We are closer to Viridant than we've been in—"

"*Now*, Bakugou. Or you can take a week's suspension on top of it." Aizawa curls his fingers. "Phone."

Bakugou scoffs in what can only be described as pure disbelief. "You're making a damn awful call."

Aizawa doesn't blink, just curls his fingers. Bakugou lets out a string of curses before digging in his pocket. He slaps the old phone onto Aizawa's hand, his face getting more and more red, his hands more and more smoky. Aizawa, despite what many think, doesn't enjoy being the bad guy. Kids who deserve a little punishment are enjoyable to put through it, but there's no joy in Aizawa's soul as he does this.

Bakugou keeps his teeth gritted, head lowered so he won't have to do so much as look at Aizawa.

"I can't trust you on this anymore," Aizawa says, voice stern. "Can you manage to get down safely and into the car waiting for you?"

Bakugou ignores him, blasting off the side of the roof and dropping to the floor below. Aizawa moves on to the next.

Todoroki stared up at him, face perfectly crafted. "Sorry, sensei."

Aizawa sighs, squats down in front of him. "You understand that I have to call home, don't you? For both you and Shinso?"

Todoroki stares blankly ahead. "Yes."

"What's your story of events?"

"I followed Bakugou. Seems like he knew what to do. So we came out here and tried to help, but Viridant was already ahead of us." Todoroki blinks slowly, his darty eyes the only sign of his nerves. "Don't call home. Call my sister."

"I've got to call a parent or guardian," Aizawa says, voice stern. "Is there a reason I can't call your dad?" He knows the kid's mom is not listed anywhere on his admission paperwork, a fact he has tried not to look into. "Kid?"

Todoroki shakes his head. "No."

Aizawa sighs again. "Give me something to work with, kid."

Todoroki's eyes slide to him. One brown, one blue, with a large red scar taking up half his face. "Are the dorms ready?"

"Yes?"

"Okay." Todoroki stands, dusting his pants. "I'll be moved in immediately. Are there assigned rooms?"

Aizawa is at a loss of words. "I was going to cover this in homeroom—that's—you aren't off the hook yet, I haven't given you a punishment."

Todoroki buries his hands in his pockets. "You're calling home. That's enough of a punishment."

Concerning, and the most sassy of a tone the kid has ever taken with him. Todoroki slowly hops off the roof, the car door clicking when he makes it down safely. It leaves one kid on the roof, who seems to be the most nervous, no matter how much he tries to hide it.

Shinso fidgets with his capture scarf, the purple color of it wrapping around his fingers. "Are you going to drop me from classes?"

“No,” Aizawa says, coming up to his side. “You’ve earned your place in 1-A, doesn’t mean I’m not immensely disappointed in you.”

“Oh, good,” Shinso says with a shake of his head. “I was hoping I’d get the same lecture as the other two. What are you going to do? Phone home? Sorry to say, they won’t answer.”

Aizawa frowns. “You seem to be upset.”

“Obviously!” Shinso shouts, turning to him. “*Obviously,* I’m upset. The mission failed, I failed, he’s still out there somewhere doing god knows what with broken bones and a messed-up face. *Obviously,* I’m upset.”

He listens, breathing deeply.

“I thought we could save this kid—I feel like an idiot. He didn’t even give me the time of day. I don’t blame him, god, I don’t blame him. But I don’t know, I was hoping for something.” Shinso kicks a rock off the roof, glaring at the distance. “So what’s my punishment? Cleaning desks after school? Suspension?”

Aizawa shakes his head. “Seems like you're punishing yourself enough.”

Shinso scoffs, climbs down the roof. Aizawa follows him off, approaching the sleek black car that’s pulled up for them. He grabs the passenger door, but Shinso stills outside of his door, his face dark.

“Why did you reject him from UA?”

Aizawa looks up from his door handle, his brows furrowed. “I didn’t.”

“How can you be sure?” Shinso asks again, his face withdrawn. “How do you know?”

“I remember every kid I reject,” Aizawa says softly. “I know he wasn’t part of that list.”

Shinso nods slowly, tugs open the car door and slides inside. Aizawa opens his a moment later, peers inside to ensure he’s collected all of his problem children. Todoroki sits in the middle, his eyes shut, and he’s leaned back against the seat. Shinso’s on his left, curled up against the car door, glaring outside but seeing nothing. Bakugou’s on the opposite side, a hand pressed to his mouth and his hood pulled over his head.

Aizawa *hates* punishing good kids, but he can’t allow them to risk their lives again. A negative correlation with this incident will deter them from attempting it again, even if he feels awful for doing it. His eyes again scan them over, Bakugou’s burner phone buzzing in his pocket. They land on Shinso, whom Bakugou had assured Aizawa wasn’t PM.

Aizawa isn’t that stupid.

“Take them home, let me know if any of them try to run off,” he says to the driver, shutting the door.

When the car pulls away, he takes out the spare phone, eyes the messages.

Viridant: Remember how I promised I wouldn't do anything stupid this weekend?

Viridant: Well, it held up for about a day. But I've got to tell you what just happened to me!

Ground Zero: By all means.

The messages come in quickly after that. One after another after another. Aizawa pockets the phone long enough to head to the location Todoroki had alerted him to hours ago. There was a reason he didn't rush over here, having listened to the police captain of Chou City explain the issue. When he lands on the floor nearby, he lets out a long, pained sigh.

Gone.

An entire building, completely gone. That warp gate must've expanded his entire body, wrapped the small building within his smoke, and planted it somewhere else on the map.

It's going to be a long week.

***

Bakugou is the last one to get dropped off at home. They hit Todoroki's house first, whose sister was already outside waiting for him. He doesn't know what kind of relationship IcyHot has with his family, but watching Todoroki's sister try and lay a hand on his shoulder only to get lightly shoved away makes something ache inside Bakugou's chest.

Shinso is second, who pops out of the car without so much as a word between them. The driver waits for him to get inside, eyeing the home that's a far cry from the rich gates of the Todoroki home. The whole place looks like it's one strong wind from toppling over, and nobody waits outside for Shinso. He unlocks the front door, opens it just enough to squeeze inside without revealing any inner contents, and then the car continues down the road.

Bakugou hasn't cried in years. He still hasn't, but he got very, very close. His eyes are surely red-rimmed, watery, a fact he's beyond ashamed to admit. He keeps his hood up, hides his face within the dark fabric. He can only hope no one is awake. Mom and Dad are always early to bed.

As they pull up, Bakugou can see the kitchen light still on through the window.

Fuck.

He steps out of the car, his front door swinging open a second later. He doesn't get even two steps before warm arms wrap around him, hold him tight and close.

“Katsuki,” Dad murmurs into his hair, holding him against his chest. “What were you thinking? We were worried sick about you.”

Bakugou doesn’t hug him back. His arms hang limp at his side, pinned between his dad’s warm embrace. He isn’t one for physical affection, especially not after tonight. He just wants to take a shower and sleep.

Dad pulls away, holds his face in his hands and checks him over. “You didn’t get hurt, did you?”

“No,” Bakugou grumbles. “I’m fucking fine.”

Dad lets him go, adjusts his glasses on the bridge of his nose. He keeps his hand on Bakugou’s back, waving to the car driver with his other, before ushering him inside.

Bakugou looks up from the walkway, spots Mom in the doorway. Her arms are crossed over her chest, eyes ablaze with a rage he knows all too well.

“Hey, little shit.” She grins at him. “Did you have a fucking fantastic night out?”

Bakugou pushes past her, moving for the stairs.

“I know you aren’t about to ignore me, Katsuki Bakugou, you aren’t that fucking stupid, right?” Mom shouts at him, slamming the front door. “Turn your ass around and look at me. And take that god damn hood off inside my house.”

He stands on the first step, slowly turning and dropping his hood. “What?”

“Cut the fucking attitude,” Mom says, voice harsh, hands on her hips. “You sneak out of my motherfucking house, embarrass me in front of your teachers, and you think you’re going to stand on my steps and give me attitude?”

“I wasn’t trying—“

“Zip it!” she yells, eyes wide. “Zip it. Shut your mouth. Don’t talk back to me.”

He doesn’t bother trying to explain that he wasn’t talking back. He just wants to go lie down.

“What the hell reason do you have for sneaking out of my house?” She crosses her arms over her chest. “Let me hear it.”

Bakugou stuffs his hands into his pockets, shrugs. “I was trying to save a kid who helped me at the training camp.”

“And did you?” Mom asks, drumming manicured nails against her arm.

He looks away. “No, he was fine, but—“

“Shut it!” she yells again, ignoring Dad when he tells her to go a little easier. “So not only did you try and swindle us, but you fucking failed at it.”

Failed.

Bakugou doesn't respond.

"You can go to your room," Mom says, voice hard. "And get comfy in there, because you're not going to school tomorrow."

"Mom—"

"I don't want to fucking hear it, Katsuki." She shakes her head. "If you're going to run out of my house to play Hero and fail at it, then there's no point in going to an expensive ass school because you're *clearly* learning nothing."

"I am learning—I just wanted to—"

"Shut. Your. Mouth." Mom points up the stairs. "Get the fuck out of my face."

"Mitsuki," Dad starts, his voice gentle. "We agreed that we'd talk about this as a family."

"Look at him." Mom gestured to Bakugou. "I don't have anything else to fucking say."

Dad says more, but Bakugou is already up the stairs. He moves to his room quickly, trying to keep his steps quiet despite the anger within his lungs. He thinks about slamming the bedroom door, but the last thing he wants is a slipper to the fucking head. So he shuts it quietly, throws himself onto his bed.

And he cries.

He failed. He failed. He can't fail; he never lets himself fail, but he did today. He didn't save Viridant; he didn't even get to talk to him. He failed it; he fails fucking everything.

Bakugou curls up, his chest aching. He didn't make it to that stupid portal on time, and he got captured in those ridiculous marbles, and he doesn't get to talk to Viridant anymore, and he loves who he is when he talks to Viridant, and, and, and,

And Bakugou sobs into his pillow. He hasn't cried in years, not since…

He squeezes his eyes shut, his breath coming fast. Panic seizes him, his body shaking with it. He *hates* being afraid, hates failing. He can't, he can't, he doesn't fail, he never fails, he's not allowed to.

A soft knock sounds on his door. Bakugou doesn't answer, trembling in all limbs. The door squeaks open anyway, soft, quiet.

"Hey, buddy," Dad says, his voice gentle.

Bakugou doesn't respond. He keeps his face hidden in the pillows, stays as still as he can as Dad steps into the room. He moves closer, sits on the side of the bed. Those large, warm hands rub circles onto Bakugou's back. Soothing, comforting.

“Your mom's just worried about you,” Dad tells him, his voice a near whisper. “She just doesn’t know how to show it. She was terrified that you could’ve been hurt.”

Bakugou shuts his eyes tighter, face scrunched.

“You know we love you, right?” Dad asks.

He breaks, sobs pushing past his lips. He moves to his right, buries his face in Dad’s waist, wraps his arms around his stomach. Dad holds him tightly, drags his hands up and down Bakugou’s back. He tells him it’s all going to be okay, that it’ll all work out, that he’s so proud of him, and one night doesn’t determine the course of anything.

Bakugou’s head throbs. Crying is awful.

“She’s upset about the whole UA dorm system thing. She’ll never admit it, but she doesn’t want you to go. She’d miss you too much,” Dad says quietly, squeezing him closer. “I’ll miss you too, but I know how much this stuff matters to you.”

He sniffles, shakes his head.

“I’m proud of you, buddy,” Dad tells him, hugging him close. “Whether it’s Hero school, or anything else you decide to do. I know you’ll succeed in it.”

“I failed today,” Bakugou says, voice shaking. “I failed, Dad.”

“No, you didn’t,” Dad whispers, “You just tried a different path. You learned from it, didn’t you?”

Bakugou nods slowly.

“Well, there you go,” he murmurs, smiling down at him. “Is your friend okay?”

“I don’t know,” he says quietly. “I don’t think so.”

“Can I help at all?”

Bakugou shakes his head. “No, I’ll figure it out.”

“You come get me the second you need me, you understand?” Dad tells him, hands still rubbing his back. “I can kick some butt, too. I’m not as scary as Mom, but I’m pretty strong.”

Bakugou laughs a little bit, teary-eyed and snotty. “I think a cat could beat you in a fight.”

“What the heck,” Dad chuckles, digging his fingers into Bakugou’s armpits and tickling. “Take it back.”

Bakugou jolts, holding in a laugh, all but hissing, “Don’t tickle me.”

“I’m not,” Dad says, actively tickling him. “No idea what you're talking about.”

Bakugou squirms, thuds on the floor, tries to escape. “Stop it!”

“I’m not doing anything!” Dad argues. “Must be a cat!” He grabs his ankles, drags him backwards, digs his fingers into Bakugou’s sides. “Meow, meow.”

Bakugou wheezes, laughs tearing out of him. “I can’t breathe.”

Dad stops then, smiles down at him. He squats down to press a kiss to Bakugou’s head before going to the door. He flicks off the light.

“Goodnight, buddy.”

Bakugou sits up, rubs his eye. “Goodnight, weirdo.”

“Don’t think I won’t tickle you again.”

“Whatever.”

Dad chuckles. “Love you, Katsuki.”

“Yeah. Yeah.”

“Say it back!”

“Tch. Love you, Dad.”

He shuts the door, steps thudding down the hall. Bakugou catches his breath, wipes the last remaining tears off his face. He goes to bed, exhausted, and only wakes up to nightmares once. When he checks out the window, Viridant isn’t there. He wishes he could text or call him, but he’s got no way to do it.

So he rolls over, goes back to sleep.

He’s shaken awake hours later, groggy. He’s on high alert the second he sees Mom standing over him, a hand on her hip.

“Hmm?” Is the only sound he’s awake enough to make.

Mom licks her teeth, looks away. “Get up, you’re gonna be late for school.”

Bakugou blinks the sleep out of his eyes. “I thought—“

“Go get ready.” She cuts him off, heads for the door. “Breakfast is on the table.” She disappears.

Bakugou sits up, stretches. He gets out of bed, turns to open his curtain—

Words are written on the outside of the dusty glass. Viridant must've visited while Bakugou slept. It reads,

“Thank you.”

Chapter End Notes

Bakugou's mom was listening to him and Bakugou's dad, btw. She was crying :)
Gee willikers. Thanks for this idea from TikTok lol

Chapter 32: Earth-shaking

Chapter Summary

Midoirya gets access to a lot of new information.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya has tried every single method he could to get rid of the bruises. Cold spoons, heat packs, foundation or concealer. They've faded, sure, but not nearly enough to go unnoticed. The swelling is god awful, and it would be easier if it were just his face. But nope, he's covered in splotches of purple and yellow all over his body. Half his skin is split open, his lips and eyelids the worst off. He's certain he's got a horrible scar across his right cheek, too, from where Tomura split the skin against the bone.

And his *ribs*. He's gone through nearly an entire bottle of Tylenol in a week. No amount of wrapping his chest, trying to sleep, limiting his activity on patrols, seems to stop the pain. He feels like a wimp. A few bruised ribs never killed anybody. But here he is, struggling to breathe and move.

He can only avoid Mama for so long before she starts to wonder what he's been up to. As it is, he's been getting daily calls questioning about school or work or how his fun weekend with Hitoshi went.

That's a whole other can of worms.

Hitoshi has been texting him again. Calling. Leaving voicemails. Picking up right where they left off. Midoriya hasn't even bothered to check what he's been saying. Truthfully, he's afraid to go back to that friendship. He was crushed the first time around, then the second, and now Hitoshi wants to pick up for a potential third? How many times does Midoriya need to get ghosted by his best friend before he learns not to pick up the phone again? It feels like having a toxic ex, or whatever they say on TikTok.

He ignores his phone buzzing with messages. Ground Zero has been distant, and he's the only one Midoriya would ever bother actually communicating with. He's certain the guy is mad at him for getting into the very trouble he promised not to, but it's not as if Midoriya could really help it! He couldn't stand by while the league attacked those he cares about. So he didn't.

And, honestly, Midoriya's been a bit distracted too. He keeps thinking about what Eraser said about UA, weighing whether or not it's true. He and Hitoshi had been working on hacking an impenetrable system, and when he left, Midoriya kept attempting. It's been an ongoing

project, one that lingers in the back of his mind. Once he gets into that—then he'll worry about UA's oh so generous offer.

But for now, he's focusing on one thing at a time. Like the league literally attempting to dismember him, or hacking into a system so much bigger than him that a success would be earth-shattering, or the fact that he has a *brother.* He still can't wrap his mind around it.

His phone buzzes right as he finishes wrapping his ribs. He's not certain it's actually doing anything, but the compression feels nice enough. He downs more Tylenol, chugs a glass of water, and retreats to his bedroom.

The message is from Ito.

Ito: Hey freak.

Midoriya: Yes?

Ito: Smoking tonight, u in? We'll keep away from the city after the villain shit went down there. Just a couple of us getting together in town.

Midoriya: I think my face would scare them away.

Ito: I can't believe u don't even have a description of the asshole who jumped u. Would've gotten Banri and a few baseball bats and whooped him for u.

Midoriya's heart swells. He's unsure if it's because Ito would fight for him, or because the visceral image of Tomura taking a baseball bat to the skull is beyond appealing. He's been more violently inclined after the death of that muscular guy. It was a relief, honestly. He's been itching to get in another fight, to draw more blood.

Midoriya: My Hero <3

Ito: Shut tf up

Midoriya: I can't tonight, but maybe during the weekend or something. I've got schoolwork to do.

Ito: Nerd

Midoriya: So mean!

He chuckles at their messages before his eyes dart to PM's. There are several dozen texts there, waiting to be read. Midoriya has debated blocking him, but he's worried that Hitoshi might need some place to crash or help in case he gets into trouble. Midoriya may be against a friendship with him, but he isn't heartless.

He switches tabs, checks his messages from Eraser Head and Ground Zero. Both threads have been unusually dry, one of them making Midoriya more antsy than the other. What is Ground Zero possibly up to?

He decides to give him space to sort out whatever is bugging him. Instead, he searches through his backpack for his notebook. He had to buy a new one since his old one flew who knows where after the Nomu attack. He hasn't written anything since a few days ago, when he took notes on what he uncovered on the laptop. But he's going to need those notes now to track down some more information about Tomura or…

He flips to an open page, stares at the text written within. It's very clearly not his handwriting, and a deep, unsettling feeling pins him in place.

"Congrats on your escape. Contact us for more information on your new life.

-Shigaraki"

Shigaraki. Dad's last name. Tomura Shigaraki.

It was a fucking setup. Beating him, trying to pry answers from him, it was a setup. That's why it was beyond easy to take out his cronies, why only Dabi gave chase and not the others. They let him go, wrote him a note with a phone number for him to find. He had searched his school bag top to bottom to ensure there were no tracking devices; he hadn't thought to check for anything within his notebook.

He goes through the data he took notes on, seeing that his black pen has been crossed out or written over by Tomura's red text. Correcting theories, adding his own thoughts. His brother went through his entire notebook, reworking half-finished theories or ideas. A setup. A test. A way to see how loyal Midoriya was.

Asshole.

He traces a thumb over the script, rereading the phone number. He'd be an idiot to call from his house, so maybe he'll take a trip downtown and dial the number. For now, though, he needs to calm down, chase a different lead. He's far too pissed off by this whole situation to have any reasonable or productive conversations.

Had the entire camp infiltration been a coup specifically to recover him? Tomura hinted at it, but Midoriya didn't want to jump to any conclusions. It's possible that the fucking doctor was in on it, setting Midoriya up from the get-go.

After school on a Tuesday maybe isn't the best time to seethe over his asshole brother. He'll pick a date he can't actually do anything about it to rage over it. For now, he's got other things to do.

Like trying to penetrate the most difficult firewall he's ever come across.

Midoriya clicks around his computer screen, having changed all his settings since Hitoshi's apparent break-in. He even had to find a way to bring Bear back to life, which is what he named his stolen UA bot. All reprogramming just for Hitoshi to unplug the dang robot. Makes him a little annoyed about how easy it was to bypass all his systems, so he removed Hitoshi from them completely.

With his information secured again, he's been using a new VPN backed by a real person's information across the world. It's been covert enough to allow him access to several new servers, which has therefore opened a plethora of opportunities. This includes his big, earth-shaking project.

He's going to hack into the Hero Commission. The official Hero's database, where all personal and legal information is stored. Where all patrol routes, agencies, future villain busts, *everything* is located. Midoriya should be able to pull an extensive history from it as well, see what he can pinpoint about Tomura Shigaraki, if there's anything to pinpoint at all. He's got a lot of digging to do, and after months of not being able to crack to system, he feels as though he's closer than he's ever been.

He's been nonstop running an AI program to keep attacking weaker firewall defenses, worming his way into the system as undetected as possible. It's so locked down that he's barely made a scratch since he first began this project. Still, he keeps trying. He troubleshoots for a while, distracting his mind with code and functions, until he can't take it anymore.

Viridant: Hey, you busy?

The response takes longer than usual.

Ground Zero: Is everything okay?

Viridant: Just bored, wanted to see if you were down for a call or something. I haven't heard from you in ages.

He's expecting some sort of playful response, maybe even a few curse words. What he gets in response is anything but that.

Ground Zero: I am preoccupied at the moment.

Midoriya huffs, taps the call button. It gets declined almost immediately, and he rolls his eyes.

Viridant: Pretty please :(

Ground Zero: Now isn't a good time.

Viridant: Are you mad at me :(

Ground Zero: I'm busy with school.

Viridant: Poopy

He tosses his phone onto his bed, groans. This *sucks.* He doesn't want to sit here doing nothing; he's bored out of his mind! He can't go out looking like the purple Teletubbie with all his bruises, and he can't sit at his desk watching his code try and fail to penetrate a database. He'd do more vigilante work if his mask wasn't out of commission, his old notebook containing all his old measurements and information to rebuild it. He could always

go off memory, but buying resources requires showing his face in public, which isn't the most appealing option.

He picks his phone back up.

Viridant: I'm sorry I broke my promise not to do anything stupid last weekend! I told you a bit about it, but I promise I'll tell you more if you talk to me.

Bubbles, then none.

Midoriya sweetens the deal.

Viridant: It's really juicy stuff. I'll tell you about what I learned about the league of villains!

Ground Zero: Give me a moment.

Viridant: For?

Ground Zero: Patience is a good skill to develop, give me an hour.

Midoriya frowns at his phone, beyond annoyed.

Viridant: Poopy

He gets up, heads to the bathroom. With an hour to kill, he works on his hair, slicking it with dye. The green is really struggling to stay, fading each day. He's already redyed it twice, and both times, it's held poorly, fading to a seasick sort of color. He absolutely hates it. He's searched for a couple of Quirk users who could permanently alter it again, but he hasn't had the guts to pursue a single one.

He keeps thinking about Rin. She'd be devastated to know it didn't last. In a way, he feels guilty going to someone else to fix it. He feels like he's betraying her, betraying the hard work she did for him and Mama. At the same time, he's closer to Dad than ever. He can't keep up with his natural eye and hair color. Mama's struggling too, even if she won't admit it. She hates being back to black hair, has gone through so many colored contacts that it's not even funny. Midoriya can't stand to look in the mirror, his own reflection startling him.

And one night, when the color had first worn off, he had come to the kitchen for a glass of water and to hug Mama goodbye for work. She had her back to him, didn't hear him as he came up behind her. And when she turned around, she flinched backward on pure instinct, curled in on herself. She had apologized immediately when she realized it was him, but for a moment, he knew exactly who she had seen standing there. She had been scared, and it's a feeling he never wants to see on her face when she looks at him.

He'll work up the nerve, he has to. He needs to be brave for Mama. Maybe Kacchan knows something, can provide him with a good source. Auntie might have a contact. He hates asking him… but… but he can't get Mama's terrified face out of his mind.

He glances at the landline, approaches—

His phone rings from his bedroom. Sorry, Kacchan, he's got something else to do!

Midoriya all but runs to his bed, snatching his phone up.

"Hey!" he says, voice chipper despite how he deepens it. "Where have you been! I thought you were purposely ignoring me."

The line crackles, then Ground Zero talks. "Never, Greenie."

Midoriya lies on his bed, stares up at his ceiling. "So? What's with the silence?"

"I have… very… supervised phone access," Ground Zero says, his tone sour. "So I can't respond as much as I'd like to."

"Ew," Midoriya snickers. "Are you grounded or something?"

"Feels like it." Is the grumbled response. "Talk to me, Greenie. What happened last weekend?"

So Midoriya does, rambling and ranting, nonstop with his story. "Basically, I decided I'd investigate the information we recovered on my flash drive, remember?"

"Of fucking course, because you couldn't *not* do something for a weekend, yeah?" he asks, voice taunting.

"Thank god I didn't!" Midoriya snaps, though there's no real bite to it. He's been dying to talk to someone about this. "I sorted through files and videos, and it was horrible, everything I learned—I'm glad you didn't see it."

"Jesus, what was it?"

"Human experimentation."

"Fucking Christ."

"All of it was taped; it was horrific. To make those Nomu's they need to keep their victims somewhat alive as they extract from them. I couldn't do it; I think I threw up a few times. Anyway, the UA training camp." Midoriya takes a deep breath, his run-on sentence making him red in the face. "As I'm going through these files, the last one I click on is some doctor guy talking about needing more Nomu's for his experiments. And he mentions how perfect UA would be for his work. And, get this, he mentions one student in particular."

"Who was the student?"

"Katsuki Bakugou," Midoriya says, his full name foreign on his tongue. "Said his body could be used to withstand explosions or something. And I *know* I promised to leave it all alone, but… I don't know, I couldn't let them do that to him. So I showed up, kicked some ass, and got taken instead."

Ground Zero is quiet for a moment before urging him to continue.

“Well, I get kicked in the head by that scared-all-over guy. I wake up tied to a chair, literally tied. Arms, legs, everything. They had my hands in a Quirk suppressant box, muzzled me. It was awful,” Midoriya laughs it out, his ribs hurting. “And Himiko was there, it was so weird.”

“Who the fuck is that?” he asks.

“Himiko, she’s… okay, let me explain it again.” He goes into detail about his run-in with the teenage girl. How he found a 1-A student and hid her in a bush, got directions from Himiko about two potential threats to the mission. He doesn’t tell Ground Zero about what he did to the muscular man, only that he was taken care of. He explains how he found Tokoyami and the half-eaten student and took off running. Then, how he came across Himiko *again,* how he used her to free to captured UA students.

He’s careful not to mention Hitoshi by any name other than Shinso. When he talks about how Himiko fed him animal crackers in the villain's hideout, Ground Zero seems just as appalled. Then Midoriya explains the conversation with Tomura, mentions his Quirkless brand shoes, and how he has a Quirk despite it. He doesn’t tell him about the DNA connection, uncertain that he ever will.

“And then he said, Join us or I’ll kill you,” Midoriya does his best Tomura impression. “I totally thought he was going to disintegrate my face!”

“So what did you do? How did you escape?” Ground Zero persists.

Midoriya chuckles, “I joined them.”

Silence. “What?”

“I joined them,” Midoriya says again, “I joined their little group. Or, I told them that, at least. He was seriously going to kill me if I didn’t, and I thought, maybe this will be a good source of information. Then guess what?”

“…I’m not sure I want to know.”

“He started to beat the crap out of me!” Midoriya scoffs. “I mean, seriously, actually beating me senseless. I’ve gotten it a few times, you know? But never like that. He took me out of the chair just so he could get a better angle on me.”

Ground Zero takes a deep breath. “And what happened? Do you still have all your parts?”

“Yeah,” Midoriya says, smiling wide, knowing someone cares enough to ask him that. “Almost didn’t. He left to grab some more tools so he could start taking off body parts, but I managed to use all my blood loss to slide across the ground and get free. I looked *terrible,* I still do. Do you know how hard it is to get blood out from under your nails? I swear I was in the shower for over an hour!”

He hums. “I can’t imagine you looking bad, Greenie.”

Midoriya flushes. “No, I definitely do. My entire face is just a bruise. And my *ribs,* oh my god. I can’t breathe too deep.”

“And if I said you should go to a hospital?”

“I’d tell you no way in hell.”

“Why am I surprised?” Ground Zero asks, laughter in his voice. “Did anyone try and save you?”

Midoriya raises a brow. “Where did you hear about that?”

“Around,” he says, “Well, did anyone?”

“Three UA students, I felt so awful for dragging them along. I know I got them in big trouble with Eraser, too.” Midoriya says.

“You can say that again,” Ground Zero mutters.

“What’d you say?”

“Nothing,” he says quickly, “What did you think of… the UA kids?”

Midoriya furrows a brow. “What do you mean?”

“I don’t know,” Ground Zero says, “Were any of them… attractive?”

Midoriya blinks slowly, behind caught off guard. “What?”

“Were any of them attractive?” Ground Zero repeats. “Did you lose your hearing, Greenie?”

“No, I just wasn’t expecting that!” Midoriya laughs out, running a hand through his still-wet hair. “I wasn’t really thinking about that, I guess.”

“Not at all?”

“Why are you asking me this?” Midoriya sits up, nibbles a lip.

“I’m just curious. Not a single one was attractive to you?”

“You’re weird,” Midoriya says, standing. He heads to the kitchen, flips open his cupboards in search of food. “I guess. One was.”

“WHO?!” Ground Zero shouts, making Midoriya jump. “Which one?!”

“You are way too invested in this.” He grabs some crackers, taking them back to his room. “It’s not that serious. I just noticed him more than the others, that’s all.”

“Tell me right fucking now.”

“Geez, fine.” Midoriya sits back on his bed, nibbling a cracker. He can’t believe he’s about to admit this out loud, but it’s true. All three of his rescuers were a shock to see, but only one really grabbed his attention. “The one I told you about before, Bakugou.”

“FUCK YEAH!” The sound of a chair clattering as Ground Zero shoots out of it. “HA HA!”

Midoriya raises a brow, eats more of his cracker. “Is my opinion on a random guy a victory for you?”

“Oh, absolutely, Greenie,” Ground Zero whistles as he sits back down. “This is the best news I’ve had in days.”

“Why?”

A pause. “I don’t know.”

Midoriya snickers. “You are so weird.”

“Fuck, I don’t know,” Ground Zero says again. “That was… I don’t know why I reacted like that.”

“Maybe talk to your therapist about it,” Midoriya laughs out. “Weirdo.”

“I will,” he says quickly. “Change the subject now.”

“Sure,” he says, “Did you know that—“

His computer dings, and Midoriya turns towards it immediately. He stares at it for a long moment before rushing away from his bed, throwing himself into his desk chair. He wiggles his mouse, scrolls across the screen.

He’s in. He’s in the Hero Commission’s database. He did it.

He goes quiet, wheeling forward in his chair. For long moments, he just clicks through the screen, looking at all these things he’s never had access to before. He types in Aizawa Shouta, laughs when so much information comes up that it’s not even funny. Name, address, ongoing missions, phone number, Quirk, completed missions, arrest documentation, this is insanity! He types in All Might next, is met with the same wall of information.

Oh. He’s soooooo excited.

“What happened?” Ground Zero asks in response to Midroiya’s psychotic laughing. “What did you do?”

“I’d tell you, but it would make you an accessory to a federal crime,” Midoriya says, giddy. “Just know that I have accessed the holy grail.”

“I’m getting fucking nervous,” Ground Zero says.

Midoriya types in ‘Nana Shimura’, clicks through her file. He might be able to trace down All Might’s… uh oh.

He clicks on the name of her listed grandson. A kid who’s been missing for the past ten years. Tenko Shimura, whose description matches someone familiar. Quirkless, red eyes, black hair that’s turned white with stress.

Mother fucker.

This explains Tomura’s obscure reaction to the name Midoriya fed him. How does this keep tying back to his literal brother? In what world is it fair that All Might has more of a correlation to the idiot than Midoriya does? He keeps clicking around, digging deeper and deeper into people and names. Nana Shimura seems to have been trained by a Gran Torino, a name Midoriya is familiar with, as the man used to be a Pro years ago. He jots that down in his notebook, typing out a few more names and places and coming up with nothing.

Not a dead end, but definitely something to be explored. Maybe he can get in contact with Gran Torino, see what happens with that.

And, just for his own fun, he types in Shinso’s name. The Hero’s commission database should have access to any and all potential Heroes, and like clockwork, Shinso’s full profile comes up. All details, his progress at UA, his admittance to the Hero course, it’s all here. He types in Kacchan’s name next, skims through the profile. He's a bit shocked that he has some family history with a Hero named Toshitsugu Kudo, or Gear Shift. Kacchan never mentioned the distant relative, weird.

Finally, he types in Todoroki, eyes a bit wide as he takes it all in. There is a lot more data for the kid than there is for the other two. Having a dickhead Pro as a Dad will do that. But Midoriya stares at the ‘Call Log’ button, brows furrowed as he clicks on it.

There are sixteen listed audio files under Shoto Todoroki’s name. However, not all calls seem to be from him or about him, a few of them dating from before his birth. Midoriya clicks on the first one, the crackle of a child's voice shaking him to his core.

“911, what’s your emergency?” an operator asks.

And then, “My Dad is hurting my Mom.”

Midoriya blinks quickly. How does the Hero’s Commission have access to 911 call logs?

“What’s going on, kiddo? Can you tell me your name and address?” the operator asks.

A loud, harsh bang. Then the kid talks again. “Touya Todoroki.”

Midoriya opens a new tab, types that name into the database. It pops up with a file for a deceased thirteen-year-old.

There’s the sound of someone crying, of someone else shushing them. “I’ve got your address pulled, kiddo. I’ll send police and an ambulance to your location, okay?”

“Hurry.” The call ends.

Midoriya looks at the other 15 calls labeled here. He clicks the second and is immediately thrown off by the difference. It is again Touya Todoroki calling, but the operator isn’t the same woman who picked up before. This time, it’s a stern man who claims he will send police operatives out immediately to aid. Midoriya checks police records, and he sees that since that first call, there has never been a single police car dispatched to the Todoroki house.

He keeps listening to the calls, and the last one is the only one that doesn’t follow the same pattern. This time, when the operator asks for a name, a very young, very soft voice answers “Shoto Todoroki.” He says his brother needs an ambulance, that there’s a fire in the woods, that Dad hasn’t come home in hours.

When the call clicks off, Midoriya is far more disturbed than he ever thought he would be. He keeps clicking through files, typing in ‘Endeavor’ and ‘Touya Todoroki’, and ‘Rei Todoroki’ until he can gather enough information to make a reasonable decision.

The Hero Commission has been intercepting 911 calls from the Todoroki household. They’ve documented each one thoroughly, but nothing has ever been done about it. No police documentation, not even on the first dispatch of officers. Midoriya checked the follow-through, learned the original 911 operator was fired, and all officers on scene resigned the same night. What the hell happened at the Todoroki house?

Why did nobody come looking? Midoriya knows Hero society is corrupt, but he had always assumed it was Pros exploiting a system, not the system itself being inherently flawed. But this? This hints that the Hero’s Commission was actively aiding domestic abuse.

He again looks at Touya Todoroki’s file. There’s an extensive history listed, as there is for all potential Heroes. Touya even submitted requests for transfer to UA from his private middle school, one of the reasons he’s on the Commission’s radar and listed so intensively. This kid wanted to be a Hero, despite what is evidently horrific abuse.

And then he died. No body recovered, just a jawbone. In a forest set on fire with blue flames.

…

Blue…

Flames.

“Oh fuck,” Midoriya whispers, quickly typing in ‘Dabi’ into Google. Grainy images pop up, a few articles about mass arson and burn marks.

Then he sees the image of a man, scars and dark hair, the very man he had brawled with at the training camp. Midoriya cross-references *everything.* Dabi’s similar eye color, his messed-up facial structure indicating the lack of a jawbone, the peaks of white in his dark hair. The. Blue. Flames.

Midoriya holds his face in his hands, his heart racing. “This is bad. This is so bad.”

“What is?”

He screams, jumps in his chair. “I forgot I was on call, oh my god.”

“Yeah, you’ve been whispering to yourself for the last half hour. It’s fucking weird,” Ground Zero says, voice calm despite being completely forgotten about. “What shit did you get into now?”

Midoriya doesn’t know what to say. He bites a nail until it bleeds, his heart hammering in his chest. Shoto Todoroki has a villain as a brother, and he *knows* it. That’s why he asked about Dabi on the roof. When did he figure it out? At the turning camp? After? Before? Has he always known?

Is he betraying UA? No, if he were doing that, he wouldn’t have asked Viridant about Dabi’s well-being. So *why* ask? Is that why he came along to save Midoriya? For a chance to see his brother again? Or maybe it was to dissuade his theory about Dabi being related to him? There’s no way they don’t know, right?

Maybe Dabi is a double agent! Maybe he works for the league but also for his father… but if that was the case, this trail of 911 calls wouldn’t exist. Besides, Dabi went missing when he was 13, *years* ago; there’s no way he’s working for anyone other than himself. So what the hell is going on with the Todorokis?

“Viridant,” Ground Zero snips, “What are you muttering over there?”

“I’m just…” Midoriya blows out a breath of air. “I don’t know if I should intervene or not.”

“On what?”

“I found a huge abuse case,” Midoriya says quietly, clicking around the screen. “I’m talking about gigantic amounts of abuse. If this goes public—it would derail the career of a famous Hero. But I can’t, in good conscience, leave it alone.”

Ground Zero sighs deeply. “What the fuck do you do in your free time other than disturb shit that doesn’t involve you?”

At this point, he’s not sure. Midoriya palms his eyes, frowning deeply. “Sometimes, I wish I had never gotten involved in any of this.”

Ground Zero huffs a sort of laugh. “A bit too late for regret now, huh?”

“Yeah,” Midoriya whispers, staring at those call logs.

How many times had Mama called the police for help? How many times did they never show up? They couldn’t have possibly known who his Dad was; they couldn’t possibly have just… just let him do that to her, could they? Was it because he was Quirkless? Because he was black? What stopped the Heroes from saving him?

What stopped them from saving the Todorokis?

Midoriya looks at the phone number scribbled in his notebook. Then his eyes switch to the computer screen, where the address is listed clear as day for the Todorokis. He can't leave well enough alone; he knows this about himself better than anything. He's never been too good at watching things pass him by, never been good at keeping his mouth shut, at letting the bad continue when he knows he can stop it.

Alright, fine—he's going to get into contact with one of the Todoroki siblings. He's just unsure which. Or how.

For now… for now, he needs a distraction. Who would've thought his boredom would lead him down such mind-numbing rabbit holes?

"Can I ask you something personal?" Midoriya asks Ground Zero.

"Fuck no."

"Please!"

"What the hell do you want to know?"

Midoriya nibbled his lip, checks the date on his computer. "Christmas is a little over a month and a half away. I wanted to get you a present."

"What the fuck are you talking about?"

"You know, a present is when you buy something for someone and wrap it up and—"

"I know what the hell it is!" Ground Zero shouts, angrier than usual. "Why the fuck are you getting me a present?"

Midoriya hesitates. "I thought we were friends."

Ground Zero clicks his tongue. "How would you even give me a damn present? You don't know who I am."

"I'd leave it for you somewhere, and you'd pick it up later," Midoriya says, having thought this out perfectly. "I guess all I really need to know is what you want! I have a few ideas, but this is my first time being able to buy gifts for Christmas. So I don't want to mess this up."

"I don't need any fucking gifts, Greenie," he says, voice hard. "Especially not from someone who's injured. I doubt you'd be able to drop anything off, let alone go shopping for presents."

"You wanna hear my list? I've got a whole bunch of goodies I plan on getting everyone!" Midoriya flips to a notebook page despite Ground Zero's clear disdain. "For Todoroki-kun, as a thank you for trying to save me, I was thinking something silly! Like an All Might plushie."

"What the hell."

“For Shinso,” Midoriya says, careful to use the right name despite how ingrained his first name is in his mind. “I was thinking something with cats, he seems like a cat guy, doesn’t he? My first thought was a sweater, but now that UA has a dorm system, an actual cat isn’t too far off that list.”

“This is fucking stupid.”

“And for Bakugou,” Midoriya starts, confused when Ground Zero seizes all noise. “I have a special gift for him! I hope he likes it.”

“What is it?”

“I can’t tell you,” Midoriya snickers, “You clearly have a bias, can’t have you ruining this for me!”

“Tell me what it is NOW.”

“No!”

“I swear to god.”

“You want to hear what I’m giving Eraser Head?” Midoriya asks instead, and he hears the phone on the other end hit air. “Hello?”

“Had to take you off speaker,” Ground Zero says, wind whipping at the speaker. “Just ignore that—what are you getting him?”

“Okay, you ready for this?” Midoriya asks, giddy, despite the fact that it sounds like Ground Zero is running. “I found this coffee cup that changes color the more you drink it, revealing cats in different sweaters.”

“That’s so—OW!—That’s great,” Ground Zero huffs, “Do that, do that!”

“Are you… running from someone?” Midoriya questions.

“No,” he says, though more things clatter over the phone line. “Any other gifts you’re giving?”

Of course there is. While Ground Zero takes an impromptu run, Midoriya explains. He doesn’t get into too much detail, but he tells him how Mama works on Christmas Eve. How he plans to stay up late, decorate the entire house for her. They’ve never been able to afford a Christmas, but his Mama would always buy the candy and goodies that went on clearance the days following it, and they’d exchange little treats like that.

And, before her night shifts, she’d dress them up in sweaters and scarves, and they’d take a walk through richer neighborhoods. They’d spend hours looking at the lights and decorations on the houses, sometimes following after carolers and singing to each other. And maybe it wasn’t the Christmas that most kids got, but it’s a Christmas he’s loved since he could remember.

So this year, when she comes home from work, he's going to make their apartment look like one of those fancy houses. He'll get a large tree, string it up with colorful lights. He'll buy some cookies and gingerbread. He'll play music on the TV, and they'll hang ornaments and build gingerbread houses. And then they'll go to presents, to stockings, and it'll be the first year his Mana will ever have a stocking full of goodies, but it'll be worth it. He even custom-made her one, having spent days gathering fabric and stitching together matching stockings to hang in the house.

He'll use expensive wrapping paper, buy jewelry they thought they could never afford. The house will be covered in tacky decorations and hand-cut snowflakes, and it'll be perfect. It'll be their Christmas, just as they've always wanted it to be. And when that's all done, they'll go take a walk through those wealthy neighborhoods, sing stupid songs, and watch the lights. Him and Mama, just as they've always been.

"What do you think?" Midoriya asks him, having covered several pages in his notebook filled to the brim with notes on the holiday. "Do you think she'll like it? Is there anything I'm missing?"

Ground Zero is quiet, thinking. When he finally speaks, his voice is soft, gentle. "I think she'll love it."

Midoriya pushes out a breath of relief. "You really think so? I feel like I've done so much research on this. I hope I got it all right."

"No, no, you've got it down," Ground Zero assures him. "I think it'll be a good Christmas."

Midoriya can't help the smile on his face. "I'm so getting you a gift, by the way."

"Whatever."

He laughs. "And you're going to looooooove it!"

"I seriously doubt that."

"And, by the way," Midoriya says quietly, suddenly serious. "I don't know what… if… whatever your situation is like at home, if you need a place to celebrate, there's always a mug of cocoa for you here, okay?"

Ground Zero lets out a soft sort of laugh. "I'm all covered in that department, Greenie."

"The offer is still there," Midoriya says sweetly. "If you need a place to celebrate Christmas, you've got it."

And there's a small lift in his voice when he says, "Thanks, Greenie."

Chapter End Notes

Meowza!

Chapter 33: Christmas time

Chapter Summary

GUys its freaking christmas time guys

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He makes the phone call two weeks before Christmas Day.

It took that long to get things in order. He had to make an entirely new mask from scratch, which wasn't as hard as the first time, but definitely not easy with his ribs. He couldn't bend over completely to cut fabrics and tear through metal, and researching to find products that could be more sturdy was a task without his old notebook. Good news, at least, it seems as though nothing came out of losing over half his gear.

In fact, only benefits.

He spent long hours on the phone with Melissa, talking about Viridant suit designs. She didn't mind at all, and he added her to his list of gifts to give. Her sensor design was an absolutely difficult construct to implement, but once she began to describe how she'd go about it, it was much easier to work out the logistics. It works a lot like a heart rate monitor, detecting optical signals the heart produces or the pressure of his blood. A simple solar-like design can pinpoint the metal of blood when released into the suit, determining injury. And, Rin, his AI, has undergone a full upgrade. No longer able to just send or read text messages, she can also pick up on a full scan of heat signatures around him. Her current radius without him looking is only about ten feet, but that's still better than nothing.

On his own, with a new mask and goggle system, he can pick up heat signatures through walls if he wants. Night vision included, he's stronger than ever before. He even put that UA bot to good use, fixing its wheels to allow for 360 mobility; it's his eyes and ears before his actual ones. People see a cutesy robot strolling down the street and think nothing of it. He couldn't have done it without Melissa's genius ideas, and he decides then that he really likes her. She's easy to get along with, extremely intelligent, and shy but sure of herself. If she weren't dating Rody, he might've let his feelings develop a little further. But the two of them make a great couple, and he's happy to include them in his expanding circle of friends.

Speaking of which, the Bakusquad, as they call themselves, have become a new part of Midoriya's life as well. He got added to a group chat with several other UA students titled 'Pissing off Bakugou Club' and has been relishing in the stupidity of it all. They don't really talk about anything important, just goof off and make stupid jokes, mainly about Kacchan.

He's not in the group chat, a fact they all hate but never changes, because every time they add him, he immediately leaves the group.

It's a weird dynamic. One that… that Midoriya will have to face eventually. He never did manage to contact Kacchan about Auntie's potential makeup artists, but he certainly plans to.

He just… needs to do this first.

The line rings and rings. He's calling from his regular phone, but in a location far from home, just in case. Snow falls from all around him, covering his fading green hair with white.

"Hello?"

Midoriya adjusts his mask, ensures his voice modulator is on.

"Is this Todoroki Shoto?"

"Yes?" the kid says. "Who is this?"

Snow falls, people laugh, and walk down the street. Midoriya sits on a park bench, bundled in layers of clothing.

"This is Viridant," Midoriya says smoothly, voice deep. "I wanted to call you, follow up on a few things."

"How'd you get my number?" Todoroki asks, his voice completely monotone. "What did you need?"

Midoriya shivers as a cold wind hits him. "Your father—I've looked into his files, I've seen what he's put your family through. I have to power to bring all your family has endured to light, to change the power dynamic. But I wanted to ask you first, is this what you want?"

Todoroki breathes deeply. "You… you can take my father out?"

"I will do whatever you permit me to," Midoriya tells him, voice strong. "Destroy his career, kill him, put him in jail. Or I could leave him alone completely. It is entirely your call."

Todoroki is quiet for a moment, the sound of UA kids laughing in the background. "Can I think on this?"

"Of course," Midoriya says. "Call this number again when you've made your choice."

"Okay," a pause. "Thank you."

"It's what I'm here for," Midoriya says.

When the call ends, he stares down at his phone. Then, he pulls a new one from his pocket. No way in hell was he going to contact the league on his actual cellphone. He might not always make the best choices, but he definitely doesn't make stupid ones.

The phone rings loudly. Midoriya watches children play in the snow, parents enjoying hot coffee or cocoa, and laughing together.

“Only took you a little under two months,” a voice crackles over the line. “This isn’t a call whenever you please operation, you know.”

“I know,” Midoriya says back, waving when a child smiles at him. “Just had to find the joy in my heart to make this call, I didn't want to end up throttling you.”

“I’m honored,” Tomura retorts, “Holiday cheer, huh? Did you just get off Santa’s lap?”

“Did you just get off Dad’s?”

“Fuck you.”

“Cry about it,” Midoriya scoffs. “Did I pass your stupid escape test?”

“Barley. You took nearly five minutes. That’s pathetic,” Tomura says, his voice grating on Midoriya’s ears. “I’ve done less with more injuries.”

“Have you, Tenko?”

A very tense, angry silence. “You’ve been doing your research.”

“Had to know who my big brother really was,” Midoriya snips at him. “You’re an Aries, I should’ve guessed with all the aggression.”

“I’ve been doing my research, too,” Tenko says darkly. “Fake name, I should’ve known.”

“You really should have,” Midoriya laughs out. “It was pretty easy to deceive you. Like, criminally easy.”

“Oh, but I know Dad’s history,” Tenko says, his voice ravelly. “I know who you are, who your mom is, and where you were last seen. Sooner or later, you’ll slip up. And I’ll hunt you down like a fucking dog.”

“Geez,” Midoriya sighs, making a silly face at one of the children. “I thought I had joined your freaky little gang, now you want to kill me?”

“I’ve *always* wanted to kill you,” Tenko informs him. “Members of my *freaky little gang* don’t get to pick and choose when they contact me. You are to act as our informant and colleague, not a fucking phone-in.”

“Boo-hoo,” Midoriya says.

“You’re dead when I find you.”

“I’m surprised if you can see out of your crusty ass eyes.”

“You—“

“Here’s how this will work,” Midoriya cuts him off. “I’m willing to work with you, and I think you’re willing to work with me. You clearly wanted me for some reason, or you wouldn’t have gone to extreme lengths to capture me. So, we can give and take, big brother. I’ll scratch your back, you scratch mine.”

He seems to debate this, emptiness hanging onto the line.

“What information are we trading?” Tenko asks.

Midoriya grins. “You tell me about Dad, I’ll give you any piece of information you want on Heroes.”

“What information could you possibly have that I don’t?”

“Access to the Hero Commissions database,” Midoriya shoots back, laughing at the resounding silence. “Merry Christmas, brother, you’ve got yourself a new ally.”

“It seems I do.” Tenko’s voice trails off, lost in thought. “We’ll see.”

When the call ends, Midoriya gets on with his day. He’s got a busy two weeks ahead of him; he’s got no time to wait!

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“Aizawa-Sensei!”

Aizawa looks up from his laptop, a headache already forming. “Yes, Iida?”

The class rep keeps his hands perfectly straight at his side, which looks ridiculous when he’s wearing an elf costume. “There are presents at the front gates!”

Aizawa blinks slowly. “What?”

“Come, sir!” Iida says, turning and sprinting away.

Fucking Christmas. He *hates* holidays, this one most of all. It was fun for a little while, but after losing one of his friends he enjoyed celebrating with, it just hasn’t felt the same. He prefers to avoid it, get lost in work and grading final assignments.

But it’s impossible to deny the joy in the air when he comes to the common room. Snow falls heavily outside, the heaters inside the 1-A dorms are going full blast. They’ve got a tree, presents below from the game of Secret Santa, the students insisted on. Aizawa hasn’t felt like playing, all his leads on Viridant having dried up and shrivelled his Christmas spirit. No

DNA was found within the helmet that could be used. Fingerprints had been secured on the back, but Viridant has no previous record, license, passport, or any form of valid ID, because the kids' prints came back with nothing. It was agreed that if there's ever a hit on Viridant's prints, he'd be the first one contacted, but that's all they managed to pull.

Even better, the fourth encoded server was an absolute dud. They recovered the files within, and in mere seconds, all data was wiped. Viridant had apparently gotten onto the mission, though nobody knows how he figured it out. It was highly secured, the Commission getting involved and everything, and the kid still managed to fry the data. It left them at a loss, which Bakugou benefited from. He's been permitted contact with Viridant again, but only when there's a Pro to monitor his activity. It annoys the kid, but he listens regardless.

So Aizawa is not having a good Christmas. Especially not when he peers through the dorm windows and locks onto the stack of presents sitting outside UA gates. Of course, no camera picked up on them, and the UA bots bounce off the stack uselessly.

Fucking vigilante.

He approaches the stack first, tears the red ribbon off, and reads the note:

"For the 1-A students and their wonderful, homeless Sensei! Merry Christmas,

-Viridant"

Aizawa rubs his temple. Despite how badly he doesn't want to reward this poor behavior, he can't deny the joy radiating from his students. Dammit.

He passes out the presents one by one, eyes narrowing at the attention to detail. Several students went home for the holiday, but the few who remained got exactly what they wanted. Not to mention, Viridant somehow knew exactly what students would be here and what wouldn't, likely having sent their gifts to their homes and families.

Iida pulls out a small detailing brush kit for his leg blasters, as well as a fireproof sealant to keep the metal pristine. Uraraka gets a very good pair of fighting gloves, her knuckles given extra cushioning to protect her bones when she fights. Every single student gets something perfectly curated for them. Aizawa tries not to rush over to Shinso when he pulls a small kitten from a box with holes poked into it, his lips warbling as he lifts the small black creature from the box. He's too busy looking at the cat to see Todoroki pull an All Might plushie from his box, followed by a thick file full of documents and pictures. Only one word is stamped on the outside. 'Touya.'

Christmas and holiday joy fills the air, and Aizawa can't help but enjoy the cheer on his students' faces. He misses the few he lost this year, and that failure doesn't dim, even in the bright red and green lights. But it lifts, just a bit, as the smell of cookies and cocoa fills the air.

"Here, Sensei," Tokoyami approaches. He's been quiet ever since the incident in the woods, barely hanging onto Hero work. It's nice to see him so happy, clutching a very large crystal in his hands. With his other hand, he gives Aizawa a small box. "From the vigilante."

Aizawa takes it, doing his best to appear disinterested or annoyed. When the students look away, he carefully unwraps the cardboard and tears through the wrapping paper. He peels off the lid, a brow raised.

A coffee cup sits inside, and when he pulls it out, he sees it's one of those expensive cat ones. He adores these cups, never allowed to have any more because Hizashi forbade it after he filled every cabinet in their kitchen with them. But this one is special, each cat on it designed to look like one of his students, even the ones he's lost. He can't help the wobble of his lip, staring at the three students who passed, designed as little cats in sweaters. It's thoughtful, beyond thoughtful.

Within the cup is a paper. He pulls it out, slowly unfolds it to see what is written inside. His eyes widen as he stares at it.

"You said you wanted me as a student. While I can't accept that offer, I thought I'd give you the chance to experience what it would be like to have to suffer through my awful handwriting and grammar. Merry Christmas, to the best Sensei and Pro there is.

-Viridant"

There's a thick envelope at the bottom of the box. Aizawa pulls it out, his eyes widening as he flips through it. The UA cameras had been replaced to have audio included months ago, and the Vigilante took advantage of it. This folder includes notes on every single lesson that's been taught to 1-A. Essays that the vigilante wrote, presentations he's prepared, homework he's completed, as though he were a student here. It's thorough, filled with random doodles as the kid got distracted or needed to connect thoughts.

Aizawa can't believe he's happy to receive more work to grade as a gift, but he truly is. There's another box for Hizashi, too, and Aizawa is too nosy not to peer inside. He sees a custom-made frame pertaining to his husband's radio show, a photo of him and his husband inside it. Thoughtful, beyond thoughtful. He had assumed the lack of activity from Viridant was a sign that he was more injured than they thought, but it appears the kid just had a lot of gift-making and wrapping to do.

He doesn't say a word about this, but the students of 1-A happen to notice the new cup he takes with him everywhere, and papers on his desk stamped with A's.

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Where the fuck is it?

Bakugou isn't a damn idiot! Viridant had said there was a gift for him, not a fucking scavenger hunt. He's been running halfway across the damn town, finding note after note leading him to the next location. He's got to earn this damn gift, Viridant knowing this is the only way he'd ever accept it.

When he finally shows up at a park, his eyes narrow on the large box hidden below an empty play structure. He heads to it right away, crouches down, and yanks the box out. He's too impatient to bring it home, ripping the paper off right then and there and…

It's a new cooking set. Stand mixer, pots and pans, cooking utensils, beyond any reasonable amount of items. And it's not that low-quality silicone shit, this is state-of-the-art, new products. Nonstick pans, metal bowls, Viridant went all out. Bakugou's been stuck with the same whisks he's been using since he was a kid, his parents not knowing about this little hobby of his. Mother fucker, it's a *good* gift. That's not even fair.

Bakugou snatches the note taped to its side.

"You better bake me something sweet! I expect the best cookies of my life, thank you very much. Inside the box is a recipe book! You were right that I can't cook, but my Mama can. I've copied down every family recipe we've ever had. I might not be able to recreate them, but you can. I can't let those years of trial and error go to waste!

Thank you for always having my back. And Merry Christmas.

-Viridant"

Bakugou pries the box open, pulls out a thick notebook. Viridant wasn't lying; it's filled to the absolute brim with family recipes. Some of the shit in here looks absolutely fucking delicious, and his hands itch to get to the kitchen and start cooking. He grabs a second book inside instead, his face immediately burning red at the title. He quickly hides the novel back in the box, muttering to himself as he flips through it.

Viridant annotated one of his favorite romance novels. How the hell the jackass knew which ones Bakugou liked is beyond him, but the dickhead went through it completely and thoroughly. Little tab markers, highlighter, pen, there's barely a sentence that the guy didn't analyze completely. Bakugou will have to reread it, look through each line, and see what the vigilante thought as he read it.

Despite how much he hates gift-giving, there's a bit of a pep in his step as he carries this all home. He'll never admit it, but this is one of the best gifts he could've gotten. He takes it to his room, sets it on his floor until he can unpack it without Mom and Dad breathing down his neck.

"Katsuki!" Mom shouts, and he grumbles and heads downstairs. "This was on the porch."

Bakugou glares at the green gift bag, snatching it from her hand. "Who left it?"

"How the fuck would I know?" Mom asks, kissing his head. "Be grateful."

“I *am,”* he snips at her, tearing the orange paper out of the top.

There’s a card, and he flips it open. Another gift from Viridant, one addressed directly to him and not Ground Zero.

“Thanks for ‘attempting’ to save me. Very rarely do I have such pretty fans, but I guess I’m lucky. Merry Christmas.

-Viridant”

He scoffs, forcing away the heat that ran to his face. He tugs out a shirt from the gift bag, lips curling upward at the custom text.

The front is a photo of Viridant swinging through Chou City, a photo he’s seen posted online from fans who filmed the vigilante soaring through the sky after the Nomu attack. The words on it read “Viridant’s #1 fan.”

Take that Deku. He’s got the Viridant stamp of approval, get shit on!

Bakugou snorts at the black shirt, shaking his head. He’ll wear it only where no one can see it, but it’ll definitely be worn. Right next to his All Might shirts.

He heads back to his room, but a knock on the door stops him in place. He turns as Mom opens it, her body blocking the view of whoever is outside. But he can feel it in his chest, in his gut, and he freezes on the stairs.

“Izuku?” Mom says, her voice more confused than it’s ever been. “Oh my… It’s been so long.”

“Hi, Auntie,” he says, voice soft. “Merry Christmas. This is for you and Uncle, from me and Mama.”

Bakugou creeps down the steps, slowly approaching. He keeps out of sight, hiding under the shadows of the night sky. Mom takes whatever gift Deku hands her, gushing out thank yous and telling him to wait so she can grab some treats to send home.

“Is Kacchan home?” Deku asks.

Bakugou freezes, shakes his head rapidly at Mom. She grins wickedly. “He’s right here!”

Bitch.

Mom drags him from the corner, a plate of gingerbread in hand. She puts it in Bakugou’s hands, shoving him towards the door.

“Go take a walk,” Mom insists, her voice hinting that this isn’t a suggestion. “Be *nice.”*

Bakugou rolls his eyes. “I’m always fucking nice.”

Mom gives him the look, and he feels the threat to his core. Be nice or she'll give him hell later. Whatever.

He hands Deku the cookie tray, who takes it with a soft smile. The idiot is red in the face from the cold, his Santa hat obnoxiously bright against his light green hair. Bakugou gets a final shove to the porch before the door shuts behind him. Mom was always insistent that he get to be better friends with Deku. She likely sees this as some sort of Christmas miracle.

Bakugou stuffs his cold hand into his pockets. "What do you want?"

Deku laughs at his tone, leans to the side, and grabs two small boxes that he must've purposely hidden around the corner of the house. He knows Bakugou would refuse if he saw them, so the asshole waited to draw him out. Evil. Fucking evil.

"No way," Bakugou snips at him. "I don't want your gifts."

"It's from my Mama too!" Deku insists as Bakugou backs up. "Please, Kacchan!"

Bakugou turns, catches his mom's wicked, evil glare through the side window, and turns back around. "Fucking fine, what is it?"

Deku bounces with joy. He hands Bakugou the first box, which is heavy and sloshes. When Bakugou tears off the paper around it, he freezes at the contents. It's a glass Tupperware container, filled with soup.

"I-I can't cook," Deku confesses, toeing the snow. "So I had my M-Mama help me. Uhh… I don't even know if you remember, but she used to make this special soup f-for us when we were kids. She said it would turn any All Might fans—"

"Into Super Heroes," Bakugou finishes, his hands warming with the container. "I didn't think you'd remember that."

Deku shrugs softly, smiling brightly. "I was reminded of it a few months ago. I never thought we'd be in a place where I could give it to you, but… but I think we are."

Bakugou swallows stiffly, holding the soup in his hands. It's just soup. He's not sure why it seems to make the air feel different, the porch light turning Deku orange and bright. There's stars in the sky, and he has the bizarre urge to ask Deku if he'd count them with him. He holds that down, despite how much he might want to say it.

"Open this one," Deku hands him the next box, grinning ear to ear. "I think you'll love it."

Bakugou takes it with narrowed eyes. It's very small, barely bigger than his hands. Still, he pulls the orange and green wrapping paper off, hands stilling as he reveals what's inside. He feels like a five-year-old, the way his palms spark and his eyes light up.

"Do you like it?" Deku asks, biting his lip. "I hope you do!"

Bakugou doesn't know what to say. When he was little, and he and Deku didn't stand worlds apart, Mom and Miss Midoriya would take them out to the mall. They'd collect All Might

cards, bicker over who got the better done in a pack. What Bakugou holds now is a glass case, a lone All Might card sitting in it. It glitters, the Hero stamped on the front of it in all his glory. This is a limited edition version; it must've taken… god, fucking *years* to track this down. Not to mention the price on it, if Bakugou sold this, he'd have thousands of dollars.

And on the back—

He holds down his gasp, eyes wide at the Hero's signature scrawled onto the back. He had thought the infatuation with All Might had disappeared, but it's here, full throttle, at the gift he holds in his hands.

"How did…" Bakugou can't find the words.

"Lots of trading," Deku says, scratching the back of his head. "Might've scammed a few kids, who's to say?"

Bakugou taps the box with his fingernail. "That's… I don't have a gift for you."

Deku buries his hand in his pockets. "I know, Kacchan. It's okay."

"But—"

"Merry Christmas," Deku interrupts him, smiling wide. "And… I know you never said it, but… I forgive you. And I'm happy for you. I'll be watching you from now on, okay? Your number one fan. I'll get all the cheesy merch and show up to the sports festival, even when you don't want me there."

Bakugou takes a breath, searches for words.

"I can't wait to see what you do," Deku backs up, retreats to the sidewalk. "I'm rooting for you. Happy Holidays, Kacchan."

He turns, hands deep in his pockets, starting down the sidewalk home. Bakugou's heart thrums in his chest, his palms drying and begging for their spark back.

"Wait!" he calls out, and Deku turns to him. He's got no other words to say, nothing but embers of a flame within his lungs. "You aren't coming to UA?"

He's not sure why those are the first words from his mouth. Deku doesn't seem to know either, his brows raised to his hairline.

"What?"

"Try out again," Bakugou says, his voice full of demand. "Try out again, come to UA. I know you've talked to All Might, and he said some stupid shit, right? But it changes nothing, come to UA."

Deku blinks quickly, looks around himself. "There's no way I'll get in."

"Try it anyway," Bakugou says, his voice unwavering. "Tell me you'll try anyway."

Deku opens his mouth, shuts it, opens it again. “I… I’ll try it anyway.”

Bakugou nods. “Okay.”

“Okay.”

He retreats to his front door, twists the nob. “See you soon, then.”

Deku lets out a laugh of disbelief. “Yeah… I… I’ll see you soon, Kacchan.”

Bakugou shoves the door open, slips inside with his gifts in hand. He doesn’t know it, but he’s smiling wider than he ever has. When he looks up, Mom and Dad loudly sip wine from their glasses, side eyeing him.

“Don’t even,” he snaps, and Mom winks while Dad wiggles his brows. “You two are the fucking worst.”

“We love you, Katsuki!” Dad shouts as he sprints up the stairs.

“Whatever!” Bakugou shouts.

“Say it back, brat!” Mom yells.

“Love you!” He slams his door.

Slowly, carefully, like he’s touching a precious artifact, he sets the All Might card on his bedroom shelf. His entire room, though he’ll never admit it, is covered in All Might merchandise. Some idiot was donating all their shit months ago, and he got the fucking good haul of it. His romance novels sit on a bookshelf on the only inch of his walls that aren’t covered with posters or fan memorabilia.

He pulls the novel from Viridant off the shelf, flipping it to the first page. He sits on his green and black bedsheets, pops off the lid to his soup, and eats while he reads. Merry fucking Christmas, it was.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed this cute little chapter! It only gets worse from here :)

Chapter 34: Reveal

Chapter Summary

Viridant's notebook is recovered.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa frowns at his class. He watches them like hawks, eyeing the open seat left for Viridant. He can't shake the desire to have the kid in his room already. But as the first semester of school ended, and the second began, he started to… lose hope. He fights like hell for the Vigilante, but little progress has been made since they first learned a thread of information about the kid.

It gets to a certain point, so much disappointment rooted within his system that he can barely think. He's created Viridant's report card already, built a system for all the work the kid turned in. He's one of his star students, and he's not even in the damn class. Aizawa loves all his students, not that he'd *ever* confess such a thing, but it's impossible to deny the gap in the room.

Viridant's been unnervingly quiet, too. Large breaks in his crime-fighting pattern typically indicate some sort of extreme planning for an extremely stupid mission. He's given the kid chase dozens of times, has swung after him between buildings and into the night, but it's impossible to deny that the vigilante isn't nearly as active as usual. It could be because of whatever injuries he's sustained, but Aizawa can't help but feel as though there's something *more* that he's not understanding.

It's been nearly a year, and they are hardly any closer to catching the Vigilante than they were at the beginning. This child is still out there, risking his life, having face-to-face run-ins with the league. This January month seems to drag by slowly, darkly, the winter keeping the sky dim and dull. He had wanted Viridant in his class by now, and he can't shake the feeling that he's losing his hold on the kid. They've set traps, cameras, and dug into every bit of personal information the vigilante was willing to offer.

And they've got… nothing.

Aizawa watches his students take their test in silence, frowning at the empty seat behind Bakugou. That's the exact spot he'd put the vigilante. Behind Bakugou, beside Shinso, pressed against the window so he could still look outside. He *wants* this kid more than anything; he wants to help this kid.

And he can't seem to do it. He can't lose another one. He already lost three students to unfair circumstances, already lost a handful of others as a result. He can't lose this kid. This

brilliant, talented kid. He became a Pro to protect kids like this, and he's—

A phone rings, and Aizawa narrows his eyes preemptively. Whatever student decided to bring a device to class today, on an exam day, is going to regret it. He's got a strict no phone policy, and—

"Sensei," Iida whispers, adjusting his glasses. "Your phone is distracting."

Oh. Whoops.

Aizawa snatches it from its spot on his podium. He entrusts Iida with the task of making sure no one cheats before stepping into the hall. Normally, he wouldn't take calls during school hours, but he needs a good distraction to pull him from his depressed thoughts.

"Yes?" he asks, exasperated.

The voice that answers is loud, cheerful. "This is Eraser Head?"

Aizawa furrows his brows. "Who is this?"

"My name is Hiroto, I'm a responding officer to the Viridant case that took place in Chou City," the man says, his voice upbeat. "We got something."

Aizawa's eyes widen, his energy picking up. "What did you get?"

"A civilian just turned in a notebook. They said their kid found it and held onto it, but they uncovered it in their backpack. It's Viridant's, and you're going to want to see it."

His hands shake. "How can you be certain it's his?"

"The amount of information in here… you have my word, sir, it's Viridant's. You're the responding Pro on the case, right? When is the earliest we can meet so I can hand this over?" the officer asks. "I've already scanned for prints; we have an exact match to the set already pulled from the headgear."

Holy shit. "I'm on my way."

"I'll send you a good location to meet at," the officer says, ordering people to get him a car. "I hope this is the break you need."

Aizawa doesn't have the breath to say he hopes the same. He calls Hizashi, who immediately agrees to watch his class while Aizawa hauls ass to the meeting point. He doesn't let himself hope or fear on his way over, trying to stay rational as he throws himself through buildings and open air.

It's just a notebook. While it's definitely Viridant's, there's no hope of finding actual information from it. And if the vigilante was watching the cameras, there's a chance he'll come snatch it first. It's unlikely, though. The child is likely in school, midday, in the center of the week. He hurries all the same.

He meets Officer Hiroto at the halfway point. He signs stacks of legal papers that are presented to him faster than he's ever signed anything in his life. He doesn't even read the text, just signs his soul away and takes the plastic evidence bag that the notebook is sealed in.

When he makes it back to UA, he locks himself inside his empty classroom while All Might teaches the Heroics class. It's not like him to miss any sessions or class periods, but he can't help the tremor in his limbs. He takes the notebook from the bag, lays it flat on the podium. He scrambles for Viridant's gifted essays, taking a deep breath when the handwriting on the title lines up identically to the turned-in homework.

This is really the vigilantes' notebook.

Aizawa ties his hair back and gets to work.

The title read, 'Don't take this one to school, Viridant stuff only!' The kid notes to himself, but still notes nonetheless.

He flips open the first page, eyes a bit wide. Sketches, hundreds of them. Each one of different. Some are of Aizawa, detailing everything about him that the kid learned. Others are of 1-A students, even pointing out 'Hitoshi', otherwise known as PM. Aizawa knew it, he fucking *knew it!*

He keeps going, reading and reading. Notes about the tunnels, Nomu's, the UA attack. Sprinkled in are class notes from whatever school the vigilante attends, mixed with plans to hang out with friends or homework reminders. Aizawa consumes every single thing written, his eyes turning red with how long he keeps them open.

He reads about the suit design, the updates made to it, and how it was done. The heist to steal the scarf, the personal entrees about being afraid he scared PM away.

And, more than anything,

How much he hates Kacchan.

"Who is Kacchan?" Aizawa murmurs.

The amount of death threats, details of how he'd kill Kacchan, and reasons why he'll never "forgive him". It's alarming, to say the least. This dates back years ago to reliably three and a half months ago. It's possible that Viridant no longer wishes ill on whoever Kacchan is, but the sheer amount of anger written on these pages is concerning.

He keeps going, files away information about league discoveries and mentions of Rin. He believes Rin is the name of Viridant's AI device, but the notes depict her as a real person.

Then there's a new segment of pages. Entries. Notes. Every single one of them pertains to Katsuki Bakugou. Notes about the kid at UA, how Viridant is envious that he got in, how he always knew he was destined for greatness, how he needs to learn from the kid's fighting styles in case it comes in handy in the future. Page after page, documentation about Bakugou.

It stops after a certain point, switches to extensive notes about Shinso Hitoshi, and Aizawa connects the dots that this must've been around the time PM ceased contact with the vigilante.

His first instinct is to go after Shinso, see if he can get the kid to talk and confess the crime Aizawa had a hunch he was committing.

But then he turns to the last noted page. In big, sprawling black pen, Viridant wrote:

"GROUND ZERO IS NOT KACCHAN, STOP FORGETTING THAT. KACCHAN IS DEAD. KACCHAN IS DEAD. KACCHAN IS DEAD. I KILLED HIM. ONLY BAKUGOU REMAINS."

This borders fucking psychotic. Aizawa doesn't know what to make of it, but he knows, beyond a shadow of a doubt, who does.

He makes it to the training field too late. All Might coughs up blood, sits on a bench outside UA.

"Where are my students?" Aizawa asks, as calmly as he can manage.

All Might gives him a perplexed look. "At the dorms, it was a rough training day! I didn't let them go easy in your absence, Aizawa!"

He's already sprinting away. He's not sure why he's so anxious. Maybe it's because Bakugou Katsuki might've been playing Aizawa for a fool, feeding Viridant information. Maybe it's because the opposite, maybe Viridant knows who Ground Zero truly is. That entry didn't hint that he knew, but it was alarming enough to put Aizawa in high gear. Those notes were… were not normal. That notebook had been filled with death plans and promises, detailed notes on how to remove any 1-A student from their life.

Viridant has always been in danger, but Aizawa had never seen the kid as dangerous. He still doesn't fully think he is, but he definitely needs psychological attention. Most of those notes were incoherent words written over more incoherent words, run-on sentences written in states of mental breakdown. It's a new, vulnerable side to the vigilante. One that Aizawa needs to get a handle on immediately.

He pounds his fist against Bakugou's dorm door.

"Oooooh, Bakugou's in trouble," Kaminari taunts from below the balcony. "Suspend him!"

"Shut up!" Aizawa shouts, hair lifting and eyes glowing. Kaminari immediately turns and walks the other way, still laughing.

When Bakugou swings the door open, Aizawa shoves into his room with no warning.

"What the fuck?" Bakugou snips, shutting his door. "I was going to take a shower."

Aizawa still holds the notebook in his hands. He lifts it up, keeps it in the air, and weighs Bakugou's reaction. His student stares at it, his eyes twitching wider before smoothing back

to their neutral position. He recognizes it.

“Kacchan,” Aizawa says slowly, and Bakugou’s eyes flicker with *something.* “That’s you, isn’t it?”

Bakugou clenches his jaw. “Where the hell did you get that?”

Aizawa reels the notebook backwards when his student grabs for it. “Who does this belong to?”

Bakugou grits out, staring at the burnt edges of the book, “None of your fucking business.”

“Tell me, now,” Aizawa holds it away, his hair lifting once again. He’s agitated, on edge; he can’t stand to be in the dark here. “Or you can kiss UA goodbye.”

Bakugou scoffs, disbelief on his face. “Are you fucking kidding me? Over a notebook?”

“This is Viridant’s,” Aizawa hisses.

And Bakugou goes shock still. He doesn’t say anything, just stares blankly at Aizawa, his eyes beyond wide. When he does finally move again, it’s his mouth, opening and closing in search of words.

“Who does this belong to?” Aizawa demands.

Bakugou shakes his head. “I don’t… I don’t know.”

“I will expel you so fast that you won’t even have time to pack your damn room,” he threatens, eyes glowing. “Tell me who this belongs to. I know you have that answer.”

Bakugou trembles, breaths quickly. “You can’t be right, it can’t be his.”

“Bakugou, *now.”*

“Fuck!” Explosions shoot out of his hands, and Aizawa narrowly avoids it when he grabs a desk chair and throws it full force at the wall. “FUCK!” Books go next, his backpack, shoes, everything thrown around in a rage.

Aizawa watches, the notebook still in his clutches.

“It’s *him,* why is it always fucking *him?!”* Bakugou screams it, digs his hand into his hair. “I’m going to kill him. Melt the skin off his fucking face.”

Aizawa blinks, connects the dots. “Deku.” Bakugou huffs, in and out; he won’t look at Aizawa. “The kid you mentioned, the Quirkless one. The one you bullied, it’s him, isn’t it?”

He can’t imagine what is going through his student's head right now. Viridant’s entire decision to do what he does was made because of bullies and mistreatment. Bakugou is a good student, a good Hero, Aizawa knows that—

But does Viridant?

Bakugou's palms spark. "I want to be back on the case."

"No—"

"I'll tell you who he is," he interrupts, turning with wide eyes. "But I'm coming with you when you track him down. For all of it—I'm going to be there. He doesn't get to pull this shit without me. I want to be there, let me be there."

"You are way too close to this."

Bakugou nods slowly, let's out a laugh. "Then I guess I'll be packed and ready to leave tomorrow."

Aizawa grits his teeth. "I can catch him without your help."

He grins. "Can you catch him with my interference, Sensei?"

God. Dammit.

Aizawa clenches his fists, hair flowing, eyes glowing. "You've got one chance to give me his name. I'll let you come along, but if I find out you lied to me, you're done."

Bakugou laughs outright, his face flushed. "His name is Izuku Midoriya."

***

"Okay, okay," Midoriya mutters into the phone, balancing it between his shoulder and ear. He works on homework on his bedroom floor, talking to Ito as he goes. "Yes, I can help you study. Chem is super fun."

"Only psychopaths say that, by the way," Ito laughs at him. "Sayori and Banri can tag along, yeah? I'm pretty sure we're all done if you can't help us."

"I got you, Ito," Midoriya assures him. "I can come over in a few hours, and you'll be ready for the test by the end of tonight."

"You are such a sweetheart, you know that?" Ito says, laughing as he mocks him. "Seriously, though, thanks, Mido. I'll leave my window unlocked, just sneak in past my Dad. He'd kill me if he knew anyone was over on a school night."

Midoriya snickers. “Wouldn’t want to make daddy-poo angry.”

“Fuck off,” Ito laughs. “See you soon.”

“You too.”

The call clicks off, giving him the room to actually focus on his homework. It’s been a boring few months. His ribs don’t hurt as badly, but they still ache and throb from time to time. He’s been keeping it low activity, busting small crimes like drug rings and kidnapping. He’s saving his big adventures for when he has more mobility and means to operate.

Recently, things with Tenko have been…. Weird. His brother hasn’t contacted him for much. When he did, it was on easy information. He’d ask for every piece of information Midoriya could give on Hawks, the world's number three Hero. From what Midoriya could tell, Hawks is decent enough. He’s some sort of government-raised soldier for the Commission, but he’s got no history of misdemeanor or anything. So Midoriya sent the information over to his brother and gave the Commission an anonymous tip that someone is trying to take the Pro out.

Just because he helps his brother doesn’t mean that he’s going to betray every Hero out there. The system is flawed, but killing all Heroes off isn’t the way to fix it. It has to be systematically disassembled, which is what Midoriya has been working on in the meantime. He’s begun leaking lesser crimes of Heroes to the public. Cancel culture is a surging issue in the media these days, and people are eager to take down those who have seemed so untouchable before. Midoriya hasn’t gone after the big names; All Might and Endeavor are untouched until he gets the clear from Todoroki and an actual sign that All Might is a bad person. Truthfully, the worst All Might has done is be honest with Midoriya.

He can’t be a Hero. Good thing he’s given up trying to be.

Midoriya blasts music, humming to himself as he flies through Calculus sheets. Once this is done, he’ll leak another crime to the media and watch another Hero fall from grace. He gets more information out of his brother every time he does it.

For example, Dad has an arsenal of over a hundred Quirks. Or, Dad only visits Tenko every few months to ensure no connection can be drawn between them. Apparently, that doctor from before is working on Dad constantly, trying to keep him alive or something. Tenko gets squirmy whenever Midoriya gets too close to knowing certain things, and it’s beginning to piss him off.

He takes it slow, steady, but it’s still tedious and mind-numbing. Gaining the leader of the league of villains' trust is a difficult task, imagine that.

When Midoriya is done with homework, he packs his school bag in preparation for tonight. He’ll slip out of Ito’s house and go straight to patrol from there; that way, he won’t have to worry about waking Mama up by coming home to grab his gear. He sets it all nice and neat in his bag, patiently awaiting for when he’ll sneak into the night.

He keeps playing his music as he sits in his computer chair. It's so loud that he doesn't hear a knock at the front door, or the resounding conversation.

"Izuku!"

Once he gets this next Pro down, he can tap into the lecture of Eraser's class that he prerecorded. Getting that work done helps him improve and understand the Hero logistics a bit better.

"IZUKU!"

He clicks around quickly, sending images and documents to the press. Humming the whole time.

"IZUKU MIDORIYA!"

He pulls an earbud out, looks over his shoulder at his shut door. "Are you calling for me, Mama?"

"Yes!" she says sweetly, "Katsuki's at the door for you."

Midoriya's eyes widen. "Uhh… one second!" He jumps out of his chair, grabs the first pair of pants he sees, and slides them over his All Might boxers. What the hell could Kacchan want from him?

"Izuku!"

"Coming!" he calls, though he actually runs his hands through his hair to fix the mess it is. He slides his phones into his pocket, logs out of his computer. Kacchan might want to talk in private, and the last thing he needs is him seeing Midoriya's phones.

"Baby!" Mama shouts again.

"Okay, okay!" He slides open his door, steps out. "What is…"

Kacchan stands in his kitchen, and for the first time in Midoriya's life, he thinks that Kacchan looks guilty. On his right is none other than Eraser Head, his hair tied back into a low bun. Then, blocking the front door, is All Might's lanky body.

Uh oh.

All Might points weakly at him. "You're the kid I talked to on the roof."

Midoriya squints his eyes, laughs awkwardly. "Uhh… I don't think so. Who are you?"

Mama clasps her hands together. "These are all people from UA!" She turns to Midoriya, her eyes sparkling. "They wanted to speak to you."

Midoriya smiles his sweetest little smile. "Really? I'm honored. Can I get you tea?"

Nezu, the principal of UA, who is also a mouse, hops on the kitchen counter. Midoriya didn't even know he was here. This is the most surreal group of people to have in his apartment right now.

"Tea would be lovely!" Nezu says, hands in the air. "It's a pleasure to meet you!"

Midoriya looks at Mama, Mama looks at Midoriya. He awkwardly shuffles to his kitchen, and Mama guides the people deeper into the apartment. He just needs to stay calm, play it cool. They don't know anything. He catches All Might peering at the slight opening to his bedroom, and one high-pitched whistle from Midoriya has Mama shutting it discreetly.

You don't escape an abuser and *not* know code words or gestures with the person who helped you escape. He keeps whistling as he sets a kettle on the stove and searches for teacups and a pot. Mama is on high alert now, though she plays it off wonderfully. She's good at that, the main reason they were able to survive in this world as long as they have.

"Which do you prefer?" Midoriya asks, flipping open cabinets. "Chamomile? Earl Grey? I can make Matcha if you're willing to hang around."

Nezu stands on the coffee table in the living room, his suit perfectly clean. "My, such manners! Chamomile is my favorite."

So Midoriya makes that. He's genuinely trembling right now, but he helps as steady as he can. When he grabs the box of tea, his ribs scream at the stretch. He holds down the wince of pain, working through it, humming to himself to calm down. They must be onto him. And, somehow…

Kacchan fucked him over. It's a bit too unlikely that he'd be here, just hanging around Midoriya's biggest fucking threats. There goes his temper, always flaring at the worst times. He was beyond nice to Kacchan, kept him far removed from this part of his life. How did he find him out?

How can Midoriya turn him off his trail?

He places tea bags in cups, brings the tray and the kettle over once it's ready. He sets it carefully on the table, grabs a cup for him and Mama after pouring one for everyone else.

"So, what can I help with?" Midoriya asks.

Eraser Head hasn't taken his eyes off him, those dark irises pinned to Midoriya like he's going to disappear out of thin air. Slowly, without looking, he withdraws… oh fuck.

Midoriya's notebook is set on the coffee table. He does his best to look confused, smiling softly. "Uhh… a notebook?"

"Is this yours?" Eraser Head asks.

Midoriya raises his brows, purses his lips. "I don't think so." He carefully reaches for it, flips it open. He scans the pages, keeping his face neutral. "Yeah… I don't know whose this is, why?"

“You didn’t write in that?” Eraser Head asks. He doesn’t touch his tea. Nezu and All Might do, which is bad, considering their the only two who can’t catch Midoriya in a heartbeat.

He needed Kacchan and Eraser to drink it; the high-grade sleeping meds would’ve knocked them out fairly quickly. Mama fake sips from hers, standing by the kitchen counter. They’ve got a baseball resting against it, just in case.

“I didn’t,” Midoriya says confidentially. “Is something wrong?”

“Deku—uhh…” Kacchan clears his throat. “Izuku, I know you have notebooks like that one.”

Izuku.

He holds down the bizarre increase of his heart, handing the notebook back to Eraser Head. “I have lots of notebooks. This brand is sold for super cheap down at the CVS across the road. I can go grab my other ones, if you’d like?” He moves slightly, and every single person lurches forward as if he started running.

Midoriya’s eyes widen, and he holds his hands up. “Uhh… did… is something wrong? I’m not too sure what’s going on.”

Eraser rubs his temples. “We know it’s you.”

“What…? What’s me?”

“You’re Viridant!” Nezu says cheerfully, sipping more of his tea. “Our vigilante!”

Midoriya does his best portrayal of pure shock. “What? The vigilante?”

“This is Ground Zero,” All Might says, clearly going off script, judging by Kacchan’s reaction. “He’s been working as a spy of sorts.”

Kacchan…

Bakugou. Ground Zero.

Midoriya is going to fucking kill him.

Rage like no other builds in his chest. Red, hot, *scalding* him. Kacchan is Ground Zero. This entire time, he’s been a double fucking agent? Playing Midoriya, lying to his face. Selling him out, just as he always has.

Oh god, he’s told him *so much.* The Nomu’s, his attraction—oh fuck, oh fuck! This entire time—

Midoriya lets out an awkward laugh. “What is that? What is a Ground Zero?”

“I *know* it’s you,” Bakugou says, eyes hard. “I’ll call your phone.”

Midoriya furrows his brows when Bakugou does just that. His regular phone is almost always on silent, and Midoriya pulls out his burner just for the occasion, showing them the blank screen.

All Might deflates, Nezu frowning at his tea. But Bakugou and Eraser both seem like they aren't yet fooled. He knows Bakugou will drag this to the end, but if he can convince Eraser Head, then he might stand a fucking chance. The small yellow couch barely fits them all, and it's still so weird to see them all together.

"Is this about… my Quirk?" Midoriya asks.

"What?" Bakugou snips, "Stop playing stupid—"

Midoriya holds a hand out, and a pillow from the couch comes flying into his palm. He clutches it, holds it in his grasp. The people on his couch, and coffee table, blink slowly.

"I-It wasn't cool enough to get me into UA," Midoriya mutters, scratching the back of his neck. "But I don't think it warranted Professor's interference."

Bakugou's eye twitches. "You fucking liar."

Midoriya gives him a sheepish smile. "What?"

"That's not your Quirk, that's your mom's fucking Quirk!" he shouts, standing.

Mama gives him a perplexed look. "What do you mean? I don't have a Quirk, Katsuki. You know that."

Midoriya almost laughs at the ground rage on Bakugou's face.

Instead, he says, "Was there something I could help you all with?"

"You don't have a Quirk," Bakugou seethes, snatching the pillow away. "You're Quirkless."

"I... I've always had a Quirk..." he looks at Eraser, doing his best to seem small in the face of Bakugou. "I-I'm sorry, can I help with anything else?"

"No," Eraser Head says, standing suddenly. "I'm sorry, my student seems to have forgotten who we were looking for."

Midoriya raises his brows, "Oh… I'm sorry I couldn't help more." He's actually getting away with this.

Bakugou throws himself at him, hand outstretched, and Eraser catches him before he ever reaches. Midoriya feigns being startled, shrinking against his door. And Bakugou nearly fucking explodes, shouting, beyond angry. Eraser falls for it hook, line, and god damn sinker. He apologises when Midoriya trembles, feighing fear at Bakugou's outburst. It gets them out the door quicker.

"It's him!" he screams. "You liar! Liar!"

Midoriya truly has to tamper down his smile. He'll deal with Bakugou later; for now, he needs to get out of the woods with the Pros. Nezu apologizes, sets his teacup down, and thanks them for their hospitality. He's out first, All Might following.

Eraser all but drags Bakugou from the apartment. He's quiet, thanks Mama on the way out, obviously deep in thought. There's no doubt he'll learn he was deceived, but for now, tonight, Midoriya got away with it.

"Wait, wait!" Bakugou says, shoving against Eraser Head. "You're right! Okay! I'm sorry."

Midoriya raises a brow as Bakugou holds onto the door frame. Eraser sighs, lets go of him so Bakugou can firmly apologize.

"You aren't Viridant," Bakugou says, clearing his throat. "I-I'm sorry. I projected, you two seemed so similar."

What is he playing at? Midoriya stares at Bakugou, Bakugou stares back. Is he trying to set him off? Bait him into a confession? He won't get one.

Midoriya smiles softly. "It's alright, Kacchan."

Eraser freezes in his retreat, slowly turns. Bakugou is grinning. He… he slipped up. But where? What set it off?

Aizawa locks eyes with him. They stare at each other, Midoriya's sweet smile sharpening.

All at once, several things happen. Aizawa shoots off his scarf, missing Midoroya by an inch as he drops to the floor. Bakugou shoves through the doorway, grabs for him, and Midoroya rolls in the opposite direction. Then, he whistles, loud and strong. And Mama grabs that baseball bat and hits Eraser so hard in the stomach that the Pro actually gasps.

Midoriya gets up, sprints to his bedroom. He slams the door in Bakugou's face, locks it. Thank god he packed his bag, because he grabs it in a second, kicks open his window, and jumps from it. He lands on the neighbor's balcony, cursing at Present Mic and Midnight stationed outside. He grabs his scarf from his bag, yanks it forward, and not a second too late. Purple smoke is released from Midnight's skin, and he swings around it, hooting and howling as he soars through the air.

Mama will be okay. She could whoop all of those Pros if she were the focus at all. There's no doubt in his mind that they'll chase after him instead, leaving her alone to pack a bag and get the hell out of the apartment before they remember to go back for her. Midoriya will come back for her, and they'll pinpoint one of their many runaway locations to meet up in.

For now, he needs to put as much distance between himself and Mama as humanly possible.

Midoriya lands on a roof, takes off running. Explosions sound in the air, the crisp sound of fabric sliding against metal following. The sound disappears under loud thumps of music, Present Mic's way of keeping Midoriya blind by eliminating what sounds he can hear.

That's fine, he can do that.

“Stop!” Someone shouts after him. Midoriya just laughs.

He jumps a large gap, rolls, gets back up, and then launches his support weapon out, swings, and lands again. It’s almost too easy, and he learns why a moment later as Bakugou lands in front of him, palms steaming. The loud music indicates Eraser is still right behind him, so Midoriya needs to make it quick.

“*You,”* Bakugou says, eyes slitted. “What the fuck is your deal, huh? This whole fucking time! You’ve been—“

“Spare me,” Midoroya shoots back. “I’ve got better things to listen to *Ground Zero.”*

He bends backwards as Eraser’s scarf shoots for him, grinning when it wraps around Bakugou’s arm instead. He side steps it, runs to the ledge, and jumps. He catches open air, slings his scarf out, then takes off. Building after building, his regular clothes doing nothing to warm him against the night air. Present Mic plays a loud song, something that makes Midoriya laugh as he keeps going.

That purple smoke races for his feet, and he reaches behind him, yanks his new mask from his bag. He slings through it, drops into it, hides within the scent of it. His mask keeps him from breathing it in, giving him a cover he didn’t have before. This stuff lingers, takes ages to clear away. Only Midnight can resist it, and he checks for her through the thick of it.

He pulls loose his helmet as he stands in the smoke, setting it on his head. The AI connects immediately, detecting any head signatures it can. Nothing comes up right away, so he slips on a hoodie he stuffed into his backpack. The cold bites died out, the fabric warming him. It’s not his usual suit, but it’s the best he’s got.

“Rin, text Mama,” he whispers, slowly moving through the purple smog. “Tell her I’ll explain later, but to keep herself safe.”

“Texting Mama,” Rin confirms. "Heat signature dedicated coming West."

“Aww,” a voice coos, and he turns, meets the smoke. The body form is clear as day. “Mama’s boy, how sweet!”

Midoriya retreats, backs away. He can’t see her through the smoke; he can only see the heat displacement through his goggles. He keeps moving backwards as she prowls closer, speaking softly, as though informing others of his location. A scarf shoots down a moment later, and he barely dodges it. Eraser can’t see him, but Midnight can, and he’s trying to capture him through her eyes.

The spare moment he took to look up, she advanced. Midoriya gasps when she collides with him, knocking him to the floor. He wrestles her, but she’s *good,* keeping him pinned down as her smoke starts to clear. Midoriya grunts, reaching for his helmet. She shoves his arm down, grins at him, dark hair falling in his face.

“Sorry, kid,” she says sweetly, “Can’t have you getting away.”

Midoriya swears. “Rin, analyze. Apply.” The AI does exactly as told, stealing Midnight’s voice from the very words she just spoke. So Midoriya opens his mouth, says, “He’s on me! Grab him, Eraser!”

The scarf shoots down, wraps around Midnight’s waist, and hauls her out of the smoke. He’s up a second later, taking his ploy as a victory, sprinting through the alleyway he’s landed in. The voice stealing was Hitoshi's idea from months ago; good to know it worked well. He pants, going as fast as he can to get out of here. Explosions greet him a moment later, and he’s getting awfully tired of Bakugou’s shit.

He grabs a trash can lid as he runs, and when Bakugou swoops down, he all but launches at the asshole's head. It doesn’t affect him much, but he loses sight of Midoriya for enough time to shout a curse and search for high ground. Present Mic and Eraser remain unaccounted for. All Might and Nezu are likely out of commission or will be soon, so he doesn’t have to worry about them.

Midoriya keeps running, breathing heavily, swinging when necessary. He scales a fence in seconds, and when he thinks he’s finally escaped them, he slows down and catches his breath.

Fuck. This is not ideal. Rin tells him Mama texted, but he can’t find the spare breath to respond.

Especially not when fabric wraps around his left arm, and he’s suddenly jerked into the air. His ribs sing with pain, and Eraser wraps the other end of his scarf around a lamppost. Midoriya dangles from his right arm, the binding tight around his shoulder, keeping him secured in place.

“I told you, didn’t I?” Midoriya grits his teeth, claws at fabric. “That’d I catch you.”

He huffs, gives up on trying to break free. “When was that? Eight months ago? Maybe more?”

Eraser’s resounding grin is wide, his eyes bloodshot but gleeful. “I still caught you, didn’t I?”

Midoriya still pants, coughs a bit. “I guess you did.”

“It’s been you, this whole time.” Eraser shakes his head. “So close to Bakugou, living in the hometown you patrol every single day.”

“Surprise,” Midoriya says, spinning a bit from where he dangles by his arm. “Do you want to let me down?”

Eraser only smiles at him. “I’m sorry, I’m still reveling in the joy of finally capturing you.”

Midoriya coughs again, his ribs screaming. “I imagine Bakugou sold me out? He’s pretty good at that.”

“You don’t seem to like him much,” Eraser says, his voice a bit louder so Midoriya can hear him through the snow-clogged streets. “If your notebook was any indication.”

“Oh, really?” Midoriya asks, laughing a bit. “You’d think I’d adore the guy who told me to kill myself.” Eraser stares blankly at him. “Did he not tell you that? Did he tell you that he used to beat me during school? That he ruined my fucking life? Told everyone I was Quirkless, left these marks?” Midoriya reaches a hand up, yanks down his sleeve. If he’s going down, he'll bring Bakugou with him.

Eraser stares at the handprint forever burned into Midoriya’s arms. He’s at a loss for words.

“Makes sense that he’s Ground Zero,” Midoriya grunts out. “Any chance he could get to be close to another Quirkless person, right? Did he sell you his devoted, undying loyalty act, Eraser? That he’s just an honest person, that he wants to be on the inside of everything? Is that why he told you he’s doing this to me?”

“Kid—“

“No!” Midoriya shouts at him, angry, so very angry. “You don’t get to act like it's some amazing, wonderful moment for you. Do you know what he put me through? Put my family through? And you… You told him to do this to me? To be my friend? To play me until you could find my identity?”

Eraser’s smile drops entirely, replaced with a grim expression. His lips are pressed tightly together, his eyes dark but soft.

“We just wanted to bring you in safely,” he says, his scarf still holding Midoriya up.

Midoriya’s arm hurts, aches, and when Eraser blinks, he yanks himself harshly downward. The pop of it coming out of its socket is loud, and Midoriya gasps with the pain of it.

“M-My arm,” he stutters, pain whipping through him. “Ow, ow,”

Eraser lowers him immediately, rushes forward. “Shit, show me it.”

“It hurts,” Midoriya cries out, tears filling his eyes. “It hurts, it hurts.”

“It’s okay, you’re okay.” Eraser grasps for him, lifting his sleeves. Those burn marks call out to him, singing in the night air. “Jesus Christ, kid. I need to go under your shirt, okay? I can pop it back in place, but you need a hospital immediately.”

Midoriya whimpers, nods softly. He lifts his shirt, and all those bruises and scars are out on complete display. Eraser Head doesn’t comment on them. He reaches for his lowered shoulder, counting down before shoving it into Midoriya’s socket. He cries out, leans forward, and rests his head on Eraser’s shoulder.

“I got you,” Aizawa says softly, wrapping his arms around him. It’s warm, full of concern. “You’re okay.”

Midoriya says, his voice gentle. “You’re easier than All Might was.

Aizawa's capture weapon whips out, grasps the man's wrists. Midoriya wears it loosely on his neck, able to have gathered the fabric quickly while the Pro was distracted. It wraps around Eraser Head quickly, tying his arms and legs together tightly before mummifying him. Midoriya takes the end of it off, ties it into a nice little bow, before pushing Eraser's chest and watching him crash to the floor.

"Geez," Midoriya says, rolling his shoulders. "You'd think you'd learn that trick."

Eraser shouts, but it's drowned in his own scarf. Midoriya takes the chance to put his own back on. He then crouches down, dangles Aizawa's phone in front of his face, smiling a little.

"I think it's the defenseless act that does you Pros in," Midoriya tells him, dangling his wallet as well. "Did you even feel me in your pockets? I mean, come on, you're a Pro, aren't you?"

He steps back when Eraser lurches his body forward. He's currently rolled up like a worm, so it doesn't do much.

"Rin. Analyze, apply," Midoriya says, readjusting his mask. When the sequencing is finished, he unlocks Eraser's phone with the Face ID and an unwilling victim. He calls Mic.

"Hizashi," Midoriya says, his voice uncanny. "Tell everyone to hit the ground. He's headed for a bullet train."

"Okay!" Present Mic says. "Are you alright?"

"I'll be fine when I catch this damn kid. Hurry!" He hangs up. Looks at Eraser, tugs his mask off. "How'd I do?"

Eraser glares up at him, his eyes squinted.

Midoriya sighs, drops the phone onto the man's tied-up body. He stands in the shadows of an alleyway as blasts go overhead, Bakugou rushing to get to the bullet trains. He doesn't see the other Pros, but he hears Present Mic's bass trying to drown out the blasts. They all pass by, and that's enough for Midoriya.

He carefully pries his notebook from within the confines of the scarf. "I've actually been waiting for this to come up." He flips it open, skims over it. "I can only imagine your urgency to retrieve me had to do with my concerning passages, yeah?"

Eraser lets out a muffled noise. Midoriya plops onto the floor next to him, pulls out a pen. He takes notes, logs what happened today, and what to look out for.

"I journal to calm my mind," Midoriya confesses, voice sad. "One of the things I write about is the anger I feel, or how to take down opponents. When you spend your life being pushed into place, you begin to search for ways out of it."

He writes down about Bakugou, about Ground Zero, that anger rising again.

“I can’t risk you messing up my operation,” Midoriya says flatly. “I had trusted you before, you know. I was considering applying to UA again this summer, but after this? I’m not so sure.” He jots that down, too. Never trust Eraser Head again. “For the record, it was fun while it lasted. But I’ll make sure to be more careful from now on.”

He stands, retreats. But Eraser gets his mouth free, calls out to him.

“You can still be a Hero!”

Midoriya pauses, glances over his shoulder.

“We were wrong about you,” Eraser breathes. “You’re talented, you’re smart, you know how to play us better than we imagined. Please, please untie me. It doesn’t have to end like this.”

He looks at him, at his face pressed to the concrete floor, his limbs tied away. He doesn’t look much like a Hero at all.

Midoriya smiles at him. “See you around, Eraser.”

Chapter End Notes

Chicken little

Chapter 35: Change

Chapter Summary

Midoriya hunkers down with his friends for the night!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He calls Mama immediately.

“Izuku,” she says, panting. “What the hell is going on?”

Midoriya swings through the air, propelling himself away from the bullet train. “I’m sorry, Mama. Are you safe?”

“Yes!” she says, plastic rustling. “They left me with the mouse and the skinny guy. Both of them passed out from the tea. I packed our bags and left.”

Midoriya says quietly, “I have a second apartment for you. I’ll send you the address."

Mama squawks out, “What is going on!”

“I’m Viridant,” he confesses, beyond tired. “I lead the Pros away from you. I’ll stay with my friend tonight while you take the apartment. It’ll keep the Heroes off you.”

“Oh my god,” Mama sighs, but she still opens her phone and takes the address he sends her. “You need to come see me and explain, Izuku.”

“Trust me, please,” he says to her, his heart heavy. “Just for tonight, Mama. I promise it’ll all make sense soon.”

“I trust you,” she tells him. “Of course, I trust you. We stick together.”

“Like glue,” he says, and she lets out a watery laugh. “I love you, Mama.”

“I love you more, baby.”

Impossible, but she’s probably close. She hit Eraser Head with a damn baseball bat for him. He wouldn’t doubt that she loves him, not even for a moment. He wishes he hadn’t put her through all this. But it’s true, he doesn’t have a second apartment set for them. A backup in case Dad found them. He had the means after All Might donated his credit card, so he used it. Secured a second location, ensured he and Mama would be safe forever.

And now it's come in handy. He'll need to go on the run again. His identity is sold, so he'll have to get in contact with the appearance alerting Quirk users without Bakugou's help. Not that he's helping fucking anything. He can't believe Ground Zero and Bakugou are the same person. The voice was a dead giveaway, but their hearts seemed different. Those months of flirting, of long talks, of confessions about things they loved or hated. All a trick, another one of his cruel little jokes to play on stupid little Deku.

That's the last fucking time that happens.

Midoriya swings and lands on the second story of Ito's house. He doesn't plan to do any studying tonight; instead, he'll drop confessions and beg Ito to make more fake IDs for him and Mama.

It's not ideal, and Ito shouldn't have to be involved in Midoriya's mess, but he's always been good at getting others involved in shit they never asked for. Midoriya stuffs his mask and helmet back into his backpack, slowly shuffling across the roof shingles. He and Mama need to get out of the city fast, with a new life, before someone catches them.

He taps on Ito's window. Peering in, he can see Banri lying in bed, likely already asleep. The light is still on, and Ito sits on the floor beside the bed, staring down at something. Midoriya taps again, and Ito doesn't move. Asshole must be mad at him, or listening to music.

Midoriya pushes the glass, slides it open. "Ito." He crawls inside, careful not to wake Banri. "I have to tell you something, don't be mad, please."

He steps off the bed, tugging his shoes off to keep the carpet clean. Midoriya snickers a bit, hysterical as he finally tugs it off. He crouches down to Ito's right side, peers down at whatever he's looking at.

Blood.

Midoriya stares at it, then slowly looks up. Ito's eyes are gone. He stares and stares, unable to do anything but breathe and stare at him. Stare and stare and stare. His throat is carved open, a large hole in the center of it, and his head is lulled to the side. His hands are covered in blood, like he tried to hold the wound closed.

Banri's dead too. He lies in bed, blanket tucked over his shoulders. Midoriya stares, and he keeps thinking, the light is still on. The light is still on. How are they dead?

The light is still on.

"Ito." Midoriya shakes his shoulder. "The light's still on."

Ito slumps forward, lips parted slightly. He doesn't talk. He shakes him again, holds his face in his hands.

"What are you doing?" Midoriya asks, shakes him. "What are you doing? Why are you doing this?"

Why is…

Why is this happening?

He should've gone inside Rin's house. He should've… he should've looked at her. Seen what happened to her.

"Stop it, Ito," Midoriya whispers, careful not to wake Banri up. "Let's study for chem, let's study. The light's still on."

Ito doesn't respond.

Midoriya shakes him.

He doesn't respond. He doesn't talk.

He doesn't blink.

Midoriya stares at Ito. Ito doesn't respond. But the light's still on. He gets up, he turns it off, and he stares at the two of them in the bedroom. He flickers the light. They don't respond.

Wet, gnarled gasps fill the air. He turns slowly, peers down the hall, stares and stares at the long trail of blood leading to the living room. He follows it, his footprints staining the carpet. Ito's Mom and Dad are on the couch. Midoriya turns the lights off in the room, shuts the TV off, stares at them. They don't respond.

More gasping, he follows it to the kitchen.

Sayori.

She claws at her body, nails dragging down her face. Midoriya stares at her. She looks at him, tears streaming down her face.

"Help, help," she says, her voice wet with blood. "He put the pain inside me. The acid."

Midoriya blinks slowly. "What are you doing?"

"I didn't tell him," Sayori whispers, her eyes wide, her fingernails clawing at her skin. "He said—came for Ito Banri—for Viridant."

Viridant?

Who… who is that?

"I didn't tell him," Sayori gasps, her eyes flickering. "He's melting me, inside me, I'm melting."

Midoriya stares at her. "The light's on."

Sayori gasps, clutched at her skin. "Didn't tell him—he doesn't know about you. We didn't tell—and he—put the acid—" she gurgles, spasms. "Midoriya."

She chokes. Coughs. Spits up blood. Her eyes roll. She grips at her throat. She dies.

Midoriya stares at her, clicks off the kitchen light. She doesn't respond. On. Off. On. Off. Sayori doesn't respond.

Her skin bubbles, oozes, thick liquid pooling from her body. Acid. Midoriya stares at it, still carrying his red shoes.

What is…

What's wrong?

He can't think. He goes back to Ito's room. He lies on the floor. He shuts his eyes.

He sleeps.

Chapter End Notes

Damn, who wrote that? That was sad af.

Chapter 36: Aftermath

Chapter Summary

Bakugou and Aizawa investigate!

Chapter Notes

I usually only upload two chapters a day, but I thought since the last one was short (Like Ito's life), I'll give you a third for today :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Aizawa laid on the floor for an hour before someone finally found him. It was Midnight. And she laughed so hard that it took her ages to untie him. When she finally did manage to get him undone, he shot up and rushed back to the kids' apartment.

Where All Might and Nezu slept peacefully in the doorway.

“Wake the fuck up!” Aizawa snaps, shoving All Might’s shoulder. “Are you kidding me?”

The Hero doesn’t even stir, snoring loudly. Drugged. The civilians drugged the world's number one Hero and the principal of UA. With fucking tea. Even worse, both of their legs appear to be broken, likely with a baseball bat while they were unconscious. This must be the work of whatever drug Viridant has stolen from the bar months ago. He kept some for a chance occasion like this. And his mother stopped the Pros from giving chase, even if they managed to wake up.

Aizawa grumbles to himself as he looks around the apartment. The place looks ransacked. He takes a long walk around despite it. It appears that Viridant’s mother was as much of a wildcard as the kid was. He truly had convinced Aizawa that Bakugou had gotten it all wrong somehow, his lies so well done that Aizawa was ready to count his losses and regroup. Then Bakugou sniffed Viridant out like a hound, All Might revealed all their cards, and now he’s walking around an abandoned apartment.

This is the worst possible scenario.

He peers into the master bedroom. The dresser drawers are askew, closet doors thrown open. It matches the state of the kitchen, cabinets and drawers half-opened or pulled out entirely. The mom was in a rush, packing what he assumes is a trash bag or two full of supplies, if he guessed the reason for the bags on the counter correctly. The living room is relatively

untouched, minus a small book outline missing from the entertainment center. Aizawa's guess is a memory album.

Then there's Viridant's bedroom. The base of operations.

His computer is smashed. The mom knew to destroy it, the screen, the PC itself; she left the bat sitting halfway in the monitor. All data, gone, erased. Likely backed up somewhere Aizawa can't place.

He steps on clothes half pulled out from underneath a bed. A quick look under reveals more dust prints that seemed to outline boxes. Whatever was down here is… he hand catches something, and he pulls it out.

A brick, blood painting the corner of it.

This entire time, right under their noses. Bakugou's classmate, housed in Musutafu, a couple of miles from UA. Aizawa drops the brick, rubs his temples. He can't believe it. This entire time, he's been right here. Just another face in the crowd. He can recall the Quirkless classmate who appeared alongside Bakugou during the entrance exam.

The kid had stood and *stared at Aizawa* outside of UA's front gates; he remembers it clearly. This entire time.

He stands from the floor, pokes around a bit more. There was a bookshelf in here, likely housing more notebooks, but it seems to have been cleared off in the mom's rush to cover for her son. There's a wardrobe that's half opened, revealing empty hangers and stolen clothes.

How did they have this so well coordinated? Aizawa took a baseball bat to the stomach just from a whistle, which, now that he thinks about it, the whistling and humming had been code this entire time. Two people who are used to living on the run, who have practiced escape tactics and created phrases or actions to indicate danger.

Genius. He's furious, and all he can think about is how genius this whole thing was. The mom couldn't have known what her kid was up to, but she knew to cover for him the moment he needed it. And Viridant had trusted her to take care of it all, to steal and make out with their things.

Aizawa opens the bathroom door. He's hit with the sheer amount of green. Staining the tub, the sink. His photos of Viridant indicate a boy with black hair and red eyes. The child he met today had green hair and green eyes. A glance into the cabinets and he finds bleach, colored contacts, rubber gloves, and brushes. How long has this been going on?

What were they running from?

"Mmm," All Might groans as someone steps over him, kicking him as they move.

Aizawa doesn't even have to look.

"He got away?" Bakugou asks, voice a growl. "How the fuck did he get away? We had him!"

Aizawa shuts his eyes, breathes deeply. “He deceived me.”

“I told you. I fucking *told* you, he’s a fucking liar. Tricky as shit,” Bakugou cusses, pacing around the living room. “He’ll hunker down and hide out somewhere, maybe with a friend.”

Aizawa can’t get it out of his head. The way the kid looked hanging from the lamppost, the awful things he said. Torment, torture.

He asks, “Did you tell him to kill himself?"

Bakugou stops pacing.

Aizawa turns, his face drawn. “Tell me you didn’t say that, kid. Tell me you say that to him.”

His student doesn’t look at him, gaze locked on Viridant’s bedroom. “It was a long time ago.”

“And the marks on his arms?” Aizawa asks, his voice rising. “When was that?”

Bakugou swallows. “More recent.”

“Fucking Christ.” He runs his hands through his hair. “You told me you picked on kids, I thought that meant name-calling or spreading rumors—did you hit him?”

He doesn’t answer.

“Oh my god.” Aizawa pinches the bridge of his nose. “What did you do, Bakugou?”

“It’s not my fucking fault!” he shouts, throws his arms out. “I bullied him—I know I fucked that up. But he was like this before, him and his mom.”

“Like what?”

“Broken!” Bakugou screams the words, the walls shaking with it. “Broken. Off. *Wrong.* They can up and move and change their whole life like it’s fucking nothing. Look at this place—they had an escape plan ready to go. A place they’ve lived for years, and they just left it.”

Aizawa calms himself. “They felt threatened—“

“They *always* feel threatened.” Bakugou sits on the arm of the sofa, head in his hands. “Always on the run. Always hiding from *something.* You could never tell what the hell they’re thinking, planning, like two peas in the same fucked up pod.” He tugs at his hair. “He must’ve been doing this before UA—he told me the bruises were from *me,* fucking liar. Fucking liar!”

“Stop,” Aizawa says slowly, holding up a hand. “Every single thing you know about this kid, tell me it.”

“You got all fucking night?” Bakugou bites out.

“Yes.” His eyes glow. “I do.”

Bakugou scoffs, runs a hand down his face. “His mom and my mom went to school together, best friends. She moved away right after to be with some fucking asshole she met one night, and stopped talking to anyone for years. Then one day, she calls my mom, begging for a place to stay with her son. My mom takes them in, and then everything fucking changes.” He stares down at his shoes. “We did some shit to keep them hidden from her husband, but Deku’s dad—he’s some kind of lunatic, I don’t fucking know. When he and his mom came to live with us, she was nearly dead; he’d beaten her so bad. Deku was wrong from the day he came to our house.”

“What does that mean? Wrong?” Aizawa asks.

He sits at the small kitchen island, listening as Bakugou talks.

“I mean what I said. He’s always been off kilter. He doesn’t talk about his dad, *never,* and nobody brings it up. Then one day, his mom and my mom decided to take it a step further. Fake everything. Fake IDs, fake social security, they create two new people. Inko and Izuku Midoriya. They get to this lady with a DNA splicing Quirk, and she changes their appearance. Green everything,” Bakugou says it all fast, avoiding any and all eye contact. “I noticed his hair and eye color seemed off a few months ago—but I never connected it to Viridant’s sudden appearance change. He must be—“

“Dying his hair and wearing contacts,” Aizawa finishes, mind reeling. “When did this occur?”

Bakugou hesitates before he says. “When we were about four and a half years old.”

“Oh my god,” he says again, slouching in his chair. “Ten years? Ten fucking years? How did they fly under the radar for this long?”

“They’re *tricky*,” Bakugou says, trying to hammer it into Aizawa’s head. “Slippery, conniving. His mom is a sweetheart, but she’s quick, smart. And Deku, he’s—he’s a fucking super genius, okay? He thinks in patterns and numbers, and it never shuts off. His brain is constantly running, scheming, analyzing. And he’s a damn *liar,* anything he says, don’t trust it. Even the way he delivers things—it’s all an act with him. He wants you to pity him, underestimate him, that way you don’t see when he fucking stabs you.”

Aizawa learned that firsthand. He’s not sure which child to be more upset with. Bakugou clearly needs a bit more handling than Aizawa had first thought, but if what he’s saying about Viridant is true… then Aizawa needs to rethink some of his strategies. Lying down traps for the kid doesn’t work; he needs to sniff him out

“You said they’ll try and lay low?” he asks.

Bakugou nods. “Lay low, then probably try and find a way out of town.”

“But if we’re looking for them, then they stand no chance… unless—“

“We don’t know who we’re looking for.” Bakugou stands, rushes to the door, and jumps over a sleeping All Might. “Follow me, I’ll show you where the DNA splicer lives.”

“Her name?”

Bakugou grins, racing down the street. “Rin.”

***

He stands outside of Rin’s defaced house. He only came here once to drop Deku off, leaving immediately after. He remembered the address from when Mom used to call her after she left the business. She doesn’t call her anymore, though.

Night air whips at them. They wasted a lot of time chasing Deku down, walking to Rin’s house as quietly as possible. Aizawa wouldn’t even use his capture tool, too wary that Deku would be out and lurking, waiting to hear the soft sound of the cloth. The nerd’s got them both paranoid, a feeling he doesn’t enjoy.

There are fresh flowers on her porch. He eyes them. “I’ll knock first, you surround the building.”

“Bakugou, so help me.”

“He’s going to be mad,” Bakugou says quickly. “If he thinks I’m alone, he won’t be able to keep his mouth shut, okay? Just let me talk to him first.”

“I’ll guard the back. If he sneaks out, you need to be ready for my call to take him down,” Aizawa-Sensei says.

Bakugou nods, then slowly approaches the crumbling house. The small lawn is overgrown, if you can even call it that. It’s more like a minuscule patch of grass, an ant hill stamped right in its center. He avoids it, walking up the concrete steps of her front porch. The flowers on her step are unusual. Their green is vibrant, seeming to shine in the night air. They must be fresh if they could survive the winter air. Maybe a lover?

He lifts a hand, rasps on the front door. He’s ready to call out, but the wood creaks under the pressure from his hand. The door groans open, and Bakugou ducks as a bird flies out immediately. Still, he pushes the door the rest of the way open.

What the hell?

It’s covered in furniture, clothes strewn around. There’s a vanity, a few lights shattered on it. Dishes cluttered in the kitchen, bugs crawling across the cutlery. Bakugou steps inside, careful not to touch the few roaches running around. It’s infested with bugs; even a lone All Might t-shirt is crawling with them.

This is not the Rin he remembers. To be fair, he doesn't know much about her, and hardly ever talked to her. But he knows this isn't… right. He's certain Deku isn't here.

Bakugou grabs the flowers from the porch, holds them in his hands. "Rin? It's Katsuki. My mom is Mitsuki Bakugou?" Silence.

He walks deeper. The air feels stale, stuffy, and empty at the same time. Something in here smells weird, old, rotten, but leathery. He's never smelt that before, and it makes his nose curl. He flips a light switch, but the light doesn't turn on. Electricity must've been cut already.

Does she actually live here? Flies buzz in the air, bugs are scattered on the floor. He passes a door, pushes it open, and sees a bathroom. It's full as well, trashed, and he moves on. There's one more door, and Bakugou slowly approaches it. The flowers are cold in his hands, thorns pricking his palms as he knocks on it.

"Rin?" he asks softly, the darkness of the house making him uneasy. "Are you… Are you here?"

He gently pushes the door open. It gets caught on something, and when he looks down to see what it is, he's met the view of a hand.

What… what is that?

Bakugou swallows, toeing the skeleton limb. He squeezes into the room, peers around the door, and—

And there she is. He's unsure how long she's been lying on the floor, being picked away by bugs and birds. Her skin is nearly completely gone, leaving mainly bone and puddles of innards that have decomposed. A few blonde hairs still stick to her skull, but her corpse is already well and gone.

And in her outstretched hand, sits a black gun. Bakugou looks down at her, the hole on the side of her head lining up perfectly with it.

She's dead. She killed herself.

Bakugou blinks slowly, shivers at the night breeze. It's so cold in here, and so dark.

So dark.

He hates the dark.

"Mom?" he says, backing up, looking around. But he can't see anything. "Mom? Open the door."

He bangs on it, reaches for the handle, but he's not tall enough. He can't grasp the handle; he can't touch it.

“Mom! Open the door!” He bangs on it, kicks it, rattles it. She can’t hear him, she doesn’t even know he’s inside. “Mom! Please—open the door!”

She doesn’t. Dad always takes care of him while Mom works. But he’s not home for the weekend, it was Mom’s turn to watch him. But she got busy, she got busy with work. She forgot about him.

How could she forget about him?

Nobody can forget about him. He’s not allowed to be forgotten. He can’t.

“Mom!” he screams, pounding against the door. “Please, let me out! Please, please!”

She doesn’t open the door. She doesn’t even know he’s locked here. She’s busy with work. He keeps banging on it anyway, shouting and screaming.

Doesn’t she remember it’s her turn to watch him? How did she forget him? How—

“Bakugou, kid.” Hands grab him, voices talk. “Get him outside, he’s having a panic attack.”

“Mom?” he asks, grabbing mindlessly at the door. “Open the door. I can’t see. I can’t see, let me out.”

Hands grab him, the door stays shut. He doesn’t want to be locked in here—he’s afraid. How could Mom forget about him?

“Hey, hey,” a voice whispers, hands smoothing his hair away. “You’re okay, you’re safe. Bakugou, you’re outside. There’s no door.”

“I can’t get out,” he says, blinking in the darkness. “I can’t see. It’s dark.”

“Open your eyes,” the voice whispers. “Open your eyes, kid.”

Bakugou grabs for the door handle, but he can't reach it. “What… what’s happening?”

“You are outside of Rin’s house. We’re searching for Viridant,” the voice says, and cold water touches his skin. “Open your eyes.”

Bakugou does. Stars look down at him. He counts them, and he calms as he does. He counts and counts, loses track, and starts over again. He counts so many that he forgets about what he's scared of; he forgets.

“Are you okay?”

He blinks slowly, turns his head. The sun is rising. Police cars are here. He sits up, shakes his head. His heart has slowed, but humiliation eats away at his skin. He’d gotten too worked up over Deku and Viridant, and Rin sent it over the edge. That’s all.

He’s not a fucking weakling. It was just a moment of stupidity, that’s all.

Bakugou gets up, ignores Aizawa-Sensei when he urges him to relax. “Rin’s dead. Suicide.”

“We know,” he says, voice soft. “Body is almost a year old. Viridant mentioned a friend who took their life, this lines up with the timeline.”

He rubs his face, shakes off the feeling of vulnerability. Deku never got work done that day, did he? Or maybe he did, but Bakugou wasn’t able to see it. The nerd looked exactly the same as he always had since he first changed, so he just assumed that maybe Deku had been telling the truth, maybe he just came to visit an old friend.

Bakugou is certain the DNA-altering didn’t wear off until a few months ago, when Viridant first appeared on camera. He must’ve not known, must’ve been trying to return back to his regular identity. Bakugou didn’t piece it together. The most obvious fucking clues, and he didn’t piece it together. The bruises, the limp on his leg, the small burns from the bar fire. The exhaustion Deku always wore like clothes, the sudden bulk to him, the monster beneath his skin prowling closer and closer to the surface.

A vigilante, this entire time.

Even worse… Bakugou… Bakugou isn’t surprised. He’s angry, he’s fuming, but he’s not surprised. Some part of him, some buried, whispering part of his soul, it knew. It knew the second he saw Viridant scaling that building outside of his bedroom window. But it was easier to pretend, to delve into this vulnerable part of himself without worrying about what the seemingly faceless entity would think. It was easier to pretend he was offering Viridant a huge service, helping him. It was easier to pretend he was doing it for the truth, for honesty, not because some part of him can never seem to stay away from Deku, no matter how hard he tries.

Rin is dead. She’s been dead for nearly a year, and Deku’s been grieving her silently, leaving flowers on her front porch. Who would he have told? He had no friends, no family other than a mom who worked herself to the bone. He had no one and nothing other than himself, and that’s exactly what he’s made of himself now. He became the Hero no one ever allowed him to be.

Bakugou watches the house. Police cards sit outside, lights on but not their sirens. The place is being taped up, and an ambulance comes with a body bag. She’s all zipped up and hidden when they take her out on a stretcher. They’ll perform an autopsy the best they can, standard procedure, and it’ll conclude that Rin is dead. She’s been dead this entire time. Nosy neighbors poke their heads out for a look, but nobody says a word otherwise. No one reported a gunshot or called a welfare check.

He furrows his brows, sighs deeply. Deku didn’t come here any time recently to get fixed up. Which means he’s somewhere else, somewhere he could hide out until the heat dies down. But if not Rin, then…

“Fuck,” Bakugou mutters, “Can you find the address of one of his friends?”

Aizawa nods. “Give me a name.”

“I’ll give you several,” he says, already heading towards a car that arrived for them. “Ito Haruto, start with him. If we get nothing, we’ll go to the next idiot he hangs out with.”

They head to Ito’s house immediately. Bakugou has never liked this kid. He’s loud, runs a shitty fake ID business out of his house. He spent some time in juvie after he tracked down a Pro and beat the guy with a metal pipe. Something happened to his sister, something Bakugou unfortunately can’t seem to remember. He’s a dickhead, this kid. His old crew in middle school spread rumors about Deku or his mom for the love of the game, took turns fucking with the nerd just because they could. The turnaround to being his buddy was weird, but Bakugou has clearly seen weirder things by now.

The front door is open.

“Stay in the car,” Aizawa-Sensei says.

Bakugou doesn’t listen, immediately opening the passenger door and following his Sensei to the house. It’s a nice place, small, and Aizawa slowly creaks open the ajar front door. Bakugou trails after, both of them quiet as they take in the scene.

“Shit,” Aizawa mutters, before pulling his phone out and dialing a number. “We’ve got a double homicide… Christ, triple. Send forensics.”

Bakugou moves inside slowly, taking in the clean home. Both parents are dead on the couch, throats with large holes in them. Their position indicates they didn’t see the attack coming, similar to those civilians in the Nomu tunnels. A trail of blood leads to the kitchen, the pattern hinting that someone dragged themselves through the house, likely trying to escape. He peers into the kitchen, sees only a puddle of human remains. He’s certain it was a body before, but what looks like acid has completely decayed the bone marrow and muscle tissue. It smells god awful, a few flies buzzing over the puddle, then melting into it when they land.

He moves on, quiet as Aizawa continues talking on the phone. The hallway walls have words written in blood.

I AM HERE.

All for One, that’s what Viridant said in the tunnels. This is the work of All for One. Bakugou still doesn’t really understand who that is, but All Might’s reaction to the conclusion months ago was apparent enough. All for One is bad, worse than bad. This is a gruesome scene, disturbing, and Bakugou follows the blood trail to the bedroom.

The window is open, and two bodies are slumped in here. There are bloody footprints that exit the room, and Bakugou isn’t too sure that the murderer was the one who left them. He’s not too familiar with who Ito hangs out with, but the corpse in the bed looks somewhat familiar to a kid he saw that night he ran into Deku in Chou City. There’s Ito himself, as well, lying on his side on the ground. More holes in their throats, eyes stolen from them.

What the fuck happened here?

He eyes the cellphone on the floor, picks it up. He types in Ito's sister's name for the passcode, a fucking miracle that he remembered it, and the phone opens. He goes right to the call log, sees a five-minute call between Ito and Deku. Then texts follow that, asking if Deku is on his way to study, and what's taking him so long.

Then nothing.

Deku came here. Those footprints—they must be his. He must've seen the bodies, freaked out, and run away from the scene. It's barely morning now, and they're already far behind because of Rin's corpse and Bakugou's mental break. They can't lose this lead.

"Bakugou," Aizawa says, tracking him down. "Jesus, kid, are you okay?"

"I'm fucking fantastic," Bakugou spits at him. "All for One did this."

Aizawa takes in the two bodies. "Why?"

"I don't know," he says, hating admitting such a thing out loud. "But I know who does."

"We've got to find him," Aizawa mumbles, his eyes dark, shoulders heavy. "The kid is being hunted."

Bakugou looks over those footprints again and follows them to the front door. They're relatively fresh. It's disturbing, but… but Deku might've only left recently. There's a chance he slept here, or stayed inside and hid with the bodies until daylight. He knew people were searching the night, so he waited it out.

This whole thing is unsettling, but they're hot on his tail. They're close, following him around without him knowing. But now they need a new lead, a new way to find him.

It takes hardly any time to make it back to UA. He leads Aizawa to Shinso's door, annoyed that the Pro seems not the least bit shocked. Bakugou knocks.

"I thought Viridant wasn't in contact with PM anymore?" Aizawa-Sensei whispers.

Bakugou nods slowly. "He isn't. But PM taught him everything he knows about code. If there's anyone who can find him, it's him."

There's a crash on the other side of the door. Aizawa literally breaks it down, his face clouded with a panic that Bakugou hasn't ever seen on his face. He rushes in immediately, swoops up the small black kitten that Shinso received for Christmas. Bakugou is more preoccupied with the window, where Shinto clearly broke through the screen and jumped.

He grabs the sill, peers out. Shinso is running, sprinting, and Bakugou curses before launching out after him. He slams into the asshat in no time, tackling him to the turf outside. Shinso claws at him, scratches, and nearly throws Bakugou off. But he's learned from his mistakes with this asshole, pinning him down to the floor until Aizawa appears a moment later. The cat sits inside his scarf, purring loudly.

"Shinso," Aizawa says.

Shinso gives up fighting, panting heavily. “Fuck you, Bakugou.”

“What the fuck!” Bakugou shouts. “I didn’t even say anything!”

“You sold me out!” Shinso snaps, yanking his wrists and failing to get free. “Fucking cop out, that’s what you are. Snitching piece of shit.”

“I figured it out months ago,” Aizawa confesses, earning a dirty look from Bakugou and ignoring it. “I hadn’t pursued it because Viridant ceased contact, so it seemed pointless for the time being until you could prove useful. Which you now can.”

Shinso slumps, stares up at the sky. “I’m not saying fucking anything. I’ll take a lawyer.”

“You aren’t under arrest,” Aizawa-Sensei argues. “You aren’t even in trouble. We’re here to ask for help.”

“You won’t get it. I’m not selling him out.”

“Izuku Midoriya,” Bakugou says, the name still foreign on his tongue. “We’ve already tracked him down. The fucker got away. We know it all.”

Shinso doesn’t seem afraid. He’s very stoic normally, unexpressive, but his reaction is anything but. His lips spread wide, and a loud laugh peels out of his chest. He shakes with it, his entire body shaking as he laughs and laughs and laughs.

“How's that feel, huh?” he asks Bakugou, his Quirk stripped away by Aizawa. “I bet you regret it now.”

“You don’t know any—“

Shinso spits, saliva dripping off Bakugou's face. “Pussy.”

Bakugou sneers, reels his arm back, and Aizawa wraps it in his capture weapon before yanking him backwards. He doesn’t even land the blow on the piece of shit, getting restrained with a cloth instead. Shinso just laughs at him again, and fire ignites in his fucking blood.

“He’s in fucking danger!” Bakugou screams, fighting against the cloth. “I’ll kill you, do you hear me?”

Shinso ignores him, looks at Aizawa. “And I assume he learned about your big plan to capture him?”

Aizawa deflates. “Did you warn him?”

“No.” Shinso pushes off the ground. “I stayed out of it. Which is what you should’ve been doing.” He glares at Bakugou, scoffs. “You know, I actually respected you a lot, Sensei. But this? Including fucking *Kacchan* in this shit?” He holds a hand out, and the kitten jumps from the scarf to his palm. Bakugou has zero idea how a cat that small can be trained like that.

“I just wanted to keep him safe,” Aizawa says, voice a rasp. “And we need your help to ensure that he is.”

Shinso shakes his head. “I meant what I said, I’m not telling you anything.”

“He’s being hunted,” Bakugou grinds out, still trying to escape his scarf jail. “All his friends have been fucking murdered, someone’s trying to kill him.”

What would have happened if Deku went to that study session on time? If Bakugou and the Pros hadn’t shown up at the apartment?

Shinso looks between Aizawa and Bakugou, finger stroking his small cat’s head. “And you think I can find him.”

“I think you’ve got a better shot than the rest of us do,” Aizawa says, face hard. “We need to hurry.”

Shinso sighs, starts walking. “I need computers. My laptop is too small to work on. I can’t guarantee I’ll find him, but I’ll do my best.”

And that’s exactly what he gets. Aizawa takes Shinso to a UA computer lab. There are PCs and monitors surrounding tables, and Shinso picks a random wheeley chair and gets to work. Bakugou waits by his Sensei’s side, ignoring the few other teachers who come in to stare at the student wheeling between three different monitors.

It’s bizarre to watch. Shinso moves so fast that Bakugou can’t even make out what’s on half the monitors before he’s on a new screen. A black box runs what he assumes is code, green text flying across the screen. Shinso goes through dozens of cameras in seconds, some kind of software searching for Deku. He doesn’t know how any of this works, having gotten his information to help Viridant from Aizawa’s surface-level skills.

This shit is on another fucking planet. The cat stomps along the desk tops, swats the computer mice off the pads just to be a nuisance. Aizawa’s been eyeing it as if he doesn’t show up to class every day with a handful of cat fur colors stuck onto his dark clothing.

Shinso keeps moving.

“Where did you learn this shit?” Bakugou pipes up.

Shinso ignores him until Aizawa repeats the question. “My old foster sibling taught me a few things; I learned everything else.”

“You’re a foster kid?” Bakugou asks. “That makes way more sense now.”

Shinso shakes his head. “I came from a broken home and still have a better attitude than your bitch ass.”

“The fuck did you just say—“ Aizawa grabs his arm, jerks him backwards. “Why is he allowed to be a dick but I can’t?”

Aizawa gives him a warning glare. Shinso snorts.

“Okay, I’m grabbing him,” he finally says, pushing his chair backwards. “I can’t get a location, but I checked records and camera activity. Looks like a new apartment was rented out around the same time he stole All Might’s wallet. Payment is completely in cash, and the landlord never sees anyone there. I caught Viridant on a cam nearby, but only the back of his head as he walked down 5th street."

“Where is it?” Aizawa asks, peering at the map. “He had planned for us to catch him; he had a second location secured already.”

“He plans for everything,” Shinso says, a hint of admiration in his voice. “You can’t outsmart him, you just have to follow after him and hope he slips up.”

“Give us the damn address," Bakugou snips.

Chapter End Notes

Yikes!

Chapter 37: Revelations

Chapter Summary

Bakugou goes after Midoriya

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya left right before the sun hit the sky. He still carries his shoes in his hand, his socks soaked through with blood. He's not sure why he couldn't put them back on his feet; grief does weird things.

The realization of what happened only hit him in the morning. He had no nightmares, slept completely through the night, and woke up to his friends still dead. The writing on the wall, the acid Quirk given to Sayori from Yuuka. He knows exactly what happened. All for One attacked.

He came for Ito Banri, a name Midoriya had only given to one person. He never said a last name, so he hadn't truly expected anything to happen. He's not even sure why he said his friends' names. It was just the first thing to come to mind.

And his brother sold him out.

Midoriya wanders the streets, his shoes dangling by their laces off the tips of his fingers. Mama is at the new apartment; she's already called him a handful of times, but he's taking the slow route there. He feels… hollow. He keeps thinking about how he's skipping school right now, how Ito is going to pissed that Midoriya didn't give him a heads up. Then he remembers that Ito is dead. They have a chem test this Friday, and Ito is still dead.

He truly didn't think anything would come from giving up his friends' names. It was just the first thing to come to mind. There are thousands of Ito's and Banri's in Japan; he didn't think he was signing their death warrant. He never would've said a word if he knew—they were just the first things to come to mind. Midoriya was going to disintegrate if he didn't say a name, and for some reason… he said theirs. It was the first thing to come to mind. It was just the first thing to come to mind.

He had blamed Bakugou for spilling secrets, for never keeping his mouth shut. But Midoriya was the one who told him in the first place, wasn't he? He sold himself out, then he sold out his friends. And now they're dead. And there's nobody to blame but himself and his stupid mouth.

Grief hits, and he cries as he walks home. All for One killed everyone in that house, assuming Viridant was one of them. Sayori melted from the inside out for keeping her mouth

shut. She knew Midoriya was Viridant, and she never breathed a word about it. She died for him, they all did, and Midoriya wishes he would've just kept his mouth shut.

Dead. Everyone is dead.

Mama calls again. He walks home to her, his socks turning black with dirt. When he makes it to the new apartment, there's a hole inside him that begs to be filled. His anger is gone for now. It'll come back, if it always does, and he's not certain what will happen to him when it appears.

For now, he goes home.

This new apartment is about the same size as the last. Mama unlocks the door for him, pulls him into a sweeping hug when he comes inside. She holds his face, kisses his head, and hands him some food she snatched for them to eat.

Then he explains. All of it. He explains how Rin truly died, how he came across a Pro trying to rape a woman. He explains that he just wanted to be a Hero, that he tried to stay unnoticed while helping. He tells her it's been going on for months, that the way he got the money wasn't from Auntie, but from stealing from All Might. He tells her everything. All Might is a fraud, Eraser is hunting him down, Bakugou betrayed him. Hitoshi left him behind. He doesn't spare a single detail. He tells her about Ito, about Banri, and Sayori. He tells her he was kidnapped, that he met his brother for the first time.

He tells her that he failed. That he ruined everything.

And Mama cups his face, she kisses his head, and she tells him how proud she is of him. She tells him that she's known he's been up to something, but that she never wanted to invade his space. She tells him that she loves him, no matter what, and that in her eyes, he is a Hero. And when he cries, when he grieves for the friends he's lost, Mama pulls him into a hug and rocks him back and forth like he's a little kid again.

He doesn't know what to do with himself. Not when she shows him the things she grabbed from under his bed, a hiding spot she's used dozens of times. Not when she tells him she saved all his notebooks, the spare flash drives of data from his computer. Not when she tells him that she used to want to be a Hero when she was a little girl, but she never got to live that dream. And she's so happy, even if it terrified her, that Midoriya could be one. On his own terms, in his own way.

And that's she's sorry, more than anything, that he had to go through all of this alone. She's sorry that she wasn't there when he needed her. That she didn't push harder to understand what he was going through. His Dad is awful, a piece of shit, but Mama? She's the best thing that could've ever happened to him.

For a very long time, they sit in the empty apartment, holding onto each other like lifelines. He thinks that maybe Mama is his lifeline, the thing that's been keeping him afloat.

"So the homeless guy wasn't mad that I hit him with a baseball bat?"

Midoriya belts out a watery laugh. “No, Mama, I don’t think he had any idea what to do.”

“I hit him pretty dang hard,” she murmurs into his hair, laughing when Midoriya does. “You should’ve seen Katsuki’s face, he looked like I had just shot the guy.”

Midoriya’s shoulders tremble. “Mama.”

“Yes?”

“I’ve got to go away for a little while.”

Mama squeezes him even tighter. “I knew you would say that.”

“I can’t let him get you,” Midoriya whispers, pulling away. “He’s after me, I’m not even sure he knows who I am—but he’s trying to kill me. I can’t… I can’t let him get anywhere near you.”

Mama’s eyes water, bubble over. “Oh, baby. I’m your mom, it’s my job to protect you.”

He grabs her hands, squeezes them. “Please, Mama.”

“I can’t,” she says quietly. “I can’t let you go.”

“I know.” He drops her hands, steps back. “I love you.”

“Izuku.”

“I’ll see you when this is over, okay?” His lips warble. He backs away to the door on quick feet. “Don’t go outside. I’ll drop off food and water and all the things you need, okay?”

“I—“

“I love you, Mama.” He opens the door. “It’s my turn to protect you.”

He shuts it, bends the doorknob as best he can. When she tries to open it a moment later, the door doesn’t budge. She’ll find a way out; there’s no doubt in his mind. But he’ll be gone by then.

Midoriya adorns his mask, his helmet. He had cleaned his feet inside and got new socks that he put on. He slides his shoes on top, clicks into place the metal prongs that cover the brand. Then he’s off, running through back alleys, dropping into sewers. He needs to get far away, needs to find a place to sit and think.

To plan.

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Miss Midoriya is waiting for them with a cigarette in her mouth. Aizawa waits around the corner with other Pros who surround the apartment complex top to bottom. Bakugou approaches her, eyeing the giant hole in the door that looks to be made with a knife. She must've gotten locked inside. He knows Deku isn't here without even having to ask. His gut tells him, the energy in the air is different than before.

He sits next to her on the concrete steps that lead up to the third floor. She takes a long drag in, pushes it out.

"Where'd he go?" Bakugou asks.

She stares off at the wall of the stairwell. "I don't know."

Bakugou frowns down at his feet. "I'm sorry for how I behaved."

"I know," she says warmly, smiling at him. "You're a good kid, Katsuki. Sometimes good kids make bad choices."

He slouches, stares down at the echoing room. Apartments like these give him the creeps; the enclosed stairwells are breeding grounds for perverts or predators. That's no doubt why Deku picked this place, giving him the cover of criminal activity.

"You know," she says, a cigarette held between two fingers. "I had always thought I was such an idiot for not leaving sooner. What kind of mother stays in a house where her kid could be put through hell? And I knew, the day he begged me to leave, that I was holding onto this idea of a father figure for him and a loving husband for me. And there was never really one there."

Bakugou listens, tracing stars into his baggy jeans.

"It took my four-year-old telling me to leave for me to come to the realization that it wasn't about me anymore," she says quietly, "I have a kid now, my life wasn't about me anymore. And I always sort of knew it. I did everything I could to protect him, and shelter him, and I thought staying with this horrible man would be better for us in the long run because at least we had a roof over our heads. At least we had food. At least we were together, a family unit."

Bakugou says, "I'm sorry my mom kicked you out."

Miss Midoriya laughs softly, shakes her head. "She didn't kick us out, Katsuki."

Bakugou stills, turns to her with wide eyes. "What?"

"I left," she confesses, tucking a strand of green hair behind her ear. "She confronted me about Izuku being Quirkless, and asked me why I didn't tell her. I panicked. It reminded me

of my husband, so… so I left. I didn't even say goodbye. I just loaded myself and Izuku up and ran."

Bakugou stares down at his feet. "Oh."

"That's how I knew he was lying to me about how he kept getting all this money. Your mom is a good person, Katsuki, but she's not a miracle worker. She's just a woman who didn't want another woman to suffer." Miss Midoriya flicks the bud of the cigarette to the bottom of the concrete stairs. "I never should've gotten your family involved with our crisis. I've risked your lives doing this. I knew it was selfish, and wrong, and I did it anyway. I just wanted to keep my baby safe, and I ended up messing him up."

Bakugou keeps tracing those shapes into his jeans. "It wasn't just you. People are cruel; I was cruel. I told everyone he was Quirkless, I got him—"

"What?" she asks softly, "You never told anyone he was Quirkless."

"Yes, I did. I told my mom, and kids at school…" Bakugou trails off at her bewildered face. "What?"

"Katsuki, Izuku told them." She blinks slowly. "You had warned him not to, but Izuku told them anyway. You don't… remember this?"

He opens his mouth, shuts it. He doesn't remember this at all. He can't pinpoint the exact time when someone had started to treat Deku differently, only that once it started, it never seemed to stop. They were young, barely five years old. He can't remember everything that happened.

"It was on the playground one day. After we had gotten all that work done to change how we looked," Miss Midoriya says, her hands resting on her knees. "Some kids had asked him what his Quirk was, and he told them he didn't have one. I guess a parent overheard, started to spread it around. But you never told anyone, not that I know of, at least. You would tell him that it's a secret, that you wouldn't share his secret."

Bakugou can hardly breathe. "I did?"

"Yeah," Miss Midoriya knocks their shoulders together. "I hope you didn't blame yourself for this. Izuku is awful at keeping secrets. Some of them, anyway. I doubt he even knows he told someone."

There's a weight lifted off Bakugou's chest. There are parts of him that are broken, splintered, far too many to count. But one, just this one, mends itself. Stitches back together, glows within him. He hadn't ruined Deku's life with that. He hadn't even known until this moment that he had thought he ruined Deku's life at all. But it's there now, glaringly obvious. He didn't do it. He definitely didn't stop it, but he didn't cause it.

"Are you okay?" she asks.

Bakugou nods stiffly. "Yeah."

“Are you still trying to find Izuku?”

“Yeah.”

“Well.” She stretches her legs out. “He’s not coming back here anytime soon. He was insistent on that. I’m not sure where he went. He likes to go out and think.”

“Oh,” Bakugou’s voice rumbles in his own chest. “I think I know where to find him, actually.”

She perks up. “Let me know when you do. I’ve got a bone to pick!” He stands, offers her a warm hand that she takes. “And please, don’t be too mad at him, Katsuki. He just wants to keep everyone as safe as he can.”

Bakugou doesn’t agree or disagree with that, just helps her back inside. He says he’ll send a repairman to fix the front door, to which she blushes wildly and looks away. She tells him to wait at the door so she can grab him something. When she returns, it’s with a small bag full of notebooks.

“I suggest you go through these,” she says, voice soft. “It might help you understand why he’s doing all this. Don’t tell him I gave them to you, I think he’d ignore me for weeks.”

He agrees, taking the bag and heading downstairs. When Aizawa asks him what’s inside, he says it’s some food that she packed for him and that’s it. He stashes it in the car, asks the driver to ensure it gets back to his dorm in its entirety. Then he sneaks away. While Pros debrief, and Aizawa turns his back, Bakugou runs off.

Viridant’s Christmas gift scavenger hunt didn’t end at the playground. When Bakugou had arrived, he had thought it was weird that the present was left under the slide of the play structure that he and Deku had frequented as kids. He had assumed it was a coincidence, never looking too much into it. But it had been a clue this entire time. Viridant, revealing a sliver of his identity, if Bakugou just knew where to look.

He knows now.

Bakugou heads to the small opening in a chain link fence surrounding the playground. He yanks it up, crawls into the gap, and pushes out the other side. When he and Deku were very young, they’d stomp through the forest trail with a few friends, singing and chanting about future Hero agencies. They came across a river, and Bakugou fell in. The others laughed, waiting for him to get up.

But Deku had jumped right after him. Had offered him a hand, had asked if he was okay. Bakugou doesn’t remember what he said back, only that he never took Deku’s hand. And from that day, things had changed. Not just because they stopped being friends, but because Deku never offered his hand again.

Viridant sits on the log overlooking the river. Helmet on, mask on, decked in his full gear. Water lazily rushes through the small passage, splashes of it hitting the floor and his shoes. Bakugou stands on the edge of the woods, watching him.

Clouds come in, and the rare sunny winter day dies in a flurry of rain. It comes on suddenly, it always does when it's just the two of them.

"All for One," Bakugou calls out, and Viridant turns to him. "He's after you. You know that, don't you?"

Viridant stares, his goggles making his eyes glow green.

"You can't do this alone," Bakugou says, voice shaking. "You can't take him alone. You know that, I know that."

Viridant stays seated on that log, his legs still dangling over the vast expanse of water.

"I came alone." He announces. "You think some makeshift gear is enough to take on one of the most powerful villains of all time? The same guy who nearly wiped out All Might? That's what you told me, isn't it? That All Might is Quirkless, he's in need of a successor." Bakugou slowly approaches, hoping to gain any ground he can. "That can be you. You *know* it's going to be you, don't you?"

Viridant looks away.

"This is a suicide mission," Bakugou shouts through the rain. "You can't do this alone."

"What the hell could you possibly offer me?" Viridant asks, his voice deep, grim. "Stay with you and risk your life in a battle you have no part in? Is that what you recommend, Bakugou?"

"That's not my damn name!" Bakugou yells, his voice echoing off the trees. Rain pours, filling the silence, the yawning gap between them.

Viridant stands slowly, silent.

"Come on," Bakugou says. "I'm here for you, I've always been here."

"Always?" Viridant asks, looking terrifying under the dark sky. "You have *never* been here. Not once. Everything that's happened—that's been *me.* I survived, I fought, I—" he breathes heavily, grasps the collar of his own shirt. "I killed them."

Bakugou swallows. "You didn't kill anyone."

"I killed that man on the mountain," Viridant says, voice cold. "I stabbed him through his eye, threw him off the cliff."

Bakugou had heard about the recovered body of one of the villains at the training camp. They had assumed he fell. That it was some unfortunate yet lucky turn of events.

"I told Tomura about Ito and Banri." Viridant steps back on the log. "I instigated Rin."

"None of that was your fault," Bakugou calls out, stepping forward. "This isn't all on you, you aren't this person—"

“You don’t know who I am,” Viridant all but growls. “You don’t know how to help me, you don’t know a damn thing about me.”

He turns to the words, scarf lifting. Bakugou is fast, but Viridant is sneaky. He’s got no hope of catching him if he takes off. But…

But he can’t lose this. He can’t lose him.

“Akatani!” Bakugou screams, the sound guttural and half broken. And he watches, the rain pouring down on them, as he finally stops moving. “Did you think I forgot your name? You think I forgot anything about you?”

He turns, eyes hidden in shadow.

“I know you!” Bakugou shouts, trembling in all limbs. “I know you, Akatani Mikumo. I remember you, I remember every single thing about you!”

He waits, watches, turning just a little.

“I remember your hair, it’s black, it’s darker than night,” Bakugou whispers, his voice nearly drowned. “I remember your eyes, the most genuine shade of red I’ve ever seen.” His mouth moves without his permission. “I remember the curve of your ears, the freckles on your face —two hundred and seventeen of them.” His voice wavers, breaks, “My hands know the curve of your shoulders, my ears know the sound of your voice. I could draw the shape of your teeth from the memories in my mind, the scent of your shampoo, the taste of your soap. I know you, I *remember* you.”

He faces him now, hunched, splintering.

“You can’t do this alone, you can’t do this without me,” Kacchan says, arms out wide. “I’m sorry, I’m sorry for all of it. For everything I’ve ever done to you, and for all the things I’ll continue to do wrong while I learn how to fix this, how to fix us.” He grips his own shirt, calls out, “We can still be Heroes together.”

Akatani’s shoulders rise and fall, uneven, heavy, burdened with a weight he was never meant to hold.

“We can still be Heroes together," Kacchan says again, his fingers trembling. “Me and you. Me and you, just like it’s always been.”

He doesn’t say anything, his body swaying ever so slightly.

“I’m sorry,” Kacchan says again, tears bubbling in his eyes. “I’m so sorry, Akatani, I’m so fucking sorry.”

They look at each other, and Kacchan holds his hand out this time. A plea, but also an offer. Of partnership, of understanding.

“Please,” Kacchan whispers. “Please.”

And Akatani wavers, stumbles. Kacchan runs the remaining distance, catches him before he hits the wet forest floor. He's shaking horribly, covered in dirt and grime and blood. Kacchan holds him all the same, squeezes him close to his chest.

Just the two of them, drowned by the rain. Kacchan peels off the helmet, tosses it to the floor, the mask goes next. Until he's looking at his face again, those red eyes, the fading green of his hair. It's him, it's always been him.

"I'm sorry," he says again, holding his weight up. Akatani's filthy, staining Kacchan's clothes, but he doesn't care. "Everything I've done has been wrong—I know that. But I want to be in your life long enough to fix it."

Akatani slumps completely against him, his forehead pressed to Kacchan's shoulder. "I don't know how to repair us. I don't know if we ever weren't ruined."

Kacchan holds him close. "Then let's try. Let's try. Please, let's just try."

When he pulls back, tears stream out of dark eyes. "I messed up so much, Kacchan. You were right, something is wrong with me. I break everything I touch, I killed my friends." He sobs, unable to shake away Kachan's hands as he holds his face in his palms. "I lost everyone. It's my fault. I lost everyone."

"You aren't broken," Kacchan tells him, "You aren't wrong. You aren't irredeemable."

"You don't know that."

"I know *you."* Kacchan wipes away the tears with his thumbs, holding his soft face in his hands. "And I know you are strong, capable. You're passionate, you don't give up on anything. We're going to fix this all, okay? We'll take out All for One, we'll mend the bond. Me and you."

"Me and you."

"Just like it's always been."

Akatani nods slowly. "The night I came to your house. When I gave you your Christmas presents." Kacchan listens silently. "I wanted to ask you if you remembered when we'd count the stars at night."

Kacchan lets out a small breath, his lips twitching up. "I was going to ask you the same thing."

Akatani lets out a tear-clogged laugh. "Really?"

"Really."

"I can't believe it's been you this whole time," he says, still gripping his arms like a support. "Ground Zero."

“I can believe it was you,” Kacchan says right back. “I think a part of me has always known.”

He scoffs, smacking his chest. Kacchan catches his hand, holds it tightly.

And they look at each other. Rain drops off their chins, the sun hidden behind clouds. And it’s just the two of them.

Akatani’s eyes flutter, dart to his lips. Kacchan’s heart races in his chest, and he’s so nervous that his hands begin to smoke. Still, he leans in, rain running down his face. Akatani lets him, lips parted slightly, eyes half shut. Their lips brush, raindrops covering them. And—

“Police! Get down on the ground!”

Reality storms in, and Kacchan steps back, raising a hand to cover his eyes at the flashlights shining in his face.

Akatani flinches backward from his raised hand. And he’s brought back to the truth of who they are, of what they are.

“Back away from the criminal now!” An officer shouts, and Bakugou doesn’t realize that they’re talking to *him.* He doesn’t see a criminal, but officers still shout, and he backs away on pure instinct.

Deku’s eyes widen, and he looks around. “You said you were alone.”

“I—“

The police yell, “You are trespassing on private property!”

But they’ve come here before when they were kids. Nobody was ever mad then. He doesn’t understand, looking around. Deku’s gear isn’t even on. His mask and helmet are on the floor, his costume passing as weird but regular clothing. Why are they shouting?

Bakugou is yanked backwards by a hand, and officers take his place.

“On your knees! Hands behind your head!”

And in the light of their flashlights, Bakugou finally understands. Because Deku is no longer a masked Hero. He’s a black man.

“On your knees, now!” And Deku is trembling, but he drops anyway, putting his hands in the air.

“Wait—this is a misunderstanding—“ Bakugou is again pushed backwards, ushered towards what is the safety of more police officers. “You’ve got it all fucking wrong! He didn’t do anything!”

They don’t listen.

Deku grunts as a boot collides with his back. And when he's flat on his chest, one of the officers grabs his wrists, starts cuffing. They repeat his Miranda rights, and when Deku doesn't stand quickly enough, they yank him off the floor by the metal of handcuffs. Quirk suppressant handcuffs.

"Stop!" Bakugou shouts, trying to shove past them, but there are too many, surrounding what used to be a peaceful clearing. "God dammit! Listen to me!"

Deku is marched forward. He doesn't say a word. He complies as best he can. They still keep their hands on their guns, flashing badges and giving orders. The two of them lock eyes, and Bakugou is again struck by the monster that lives beneath Deku's skin. His eyes have darkened, gone entirely blank, and it shakes Bakugou to his absolute core. It occurs to him that Deku is afraid; that he's detached himself from reality on the chance that they just shoot him.

Bakugou doesn't know how to help. He doesn't know if he can. He watches this kid he's known his entire life, who wouldn't so much as hurt a fly, get treated as though he's committed some capital offense. Who called this in? What the hell even was there to call in? Two teenage boys sitting by a creek?

He turns to the nearest officer, demands answers, and they're offered up with zero complaints. A passing by civilian saw an aggressive-looking black man threatening a teenage boy. No questions asked, they had guns pointed in minutes. Dozens of officers, for *what?* Bakugou was the one yelling; he doesn't understand how Deku got pinned for it.

He corrected the officer, and when they asked for his statement, he outright refused. It's only when Aizawa-Sensei appears, beyond pissed off that he had to track Bakugou's phone, that the full situation begins to make sense. His Sensei keeps a blank face as it's explained, urges Bakugou to give an accurate statement, and only when it's filled out does he begin to tear into the police force with a rage that can only be described as deadly.

Bakugou waits for Mom to pick him up. Rain pours down, and the police car Deku is in pulls away as soon as it can. He still looks at the window, but Deku doesn't so much as turn around.

He feels that mended piece inside himself splinter open again, break. And he didn't even touch it, didn't do anything to it. The world did. Police officers pointed a gun at a fifteen-year-old who hadn't done anything more than sit by a creek. Bakugou had always thought Deku wore the mask because he wanted to remain anonymous, wanted to protect his privacy.

He hadn't thought to consider that he wore it for safety. It hadn't occurred to him that Deku covered his skin not just because he didn't want to be found, but because the public would not paint him as a Hero if they knew his skin didn't match theirs. And he feels, more than anything, that everything had begun to change again.

And he doesn't know how to fix it.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys are still liking the direction I took this fic!

Chapter 38: Recovery!

Chapter Summary

Bakugou goes to therapy and looks for info on Midoriya

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When he was very, very young, Dad took a weekend to visit his family in a different town. Mom was the one to build a successful company and career, and so Dad quit his job when Bakugou was born to be a stay-at-home parent. The agreement between Mom and Dad was that for this weekend, just Friday to Sunday, Mom would watch Bakugou instead of locking herself in her office and doing work for the company.

But Friday morning, when Dad left, Bakugou followed him to the door. He was young, hardly old enough to talk, to walk, and Dad waved goodbye and kissed his head. Mom had left Bakugou downstairs to go grab her phone from her office, and promptly forgot about him. It wasn't her fault. She had so much work to do, to catch up on, and she wasn't used to taking care of Bakugou. Dad had always been the one to do it, so she couldn't have known. Old habits die hard, and she sat in her desk chair for hours, working and working.

Her office was on the second floor, stocked with a mini fridge full of water and snacks so she could work throughout the day without interruptions. She couldn't have heard Bakugou wandering around alone, his All Might onesie keeping him warm. She didn't hear when he dragged a stool to open the hall closet, or when he shut it. But there was no stool inside the closet, and he couldn't open the door back up.

And since Friday morning, all the way to Sunday evening, Mom didn't come downstairs once. It didn't matter how loud he screamed or how hard he pounded on the door; he wasn't able to reach that door handle. When Dad came home, he immediately knew something was wrong. They had screamed at each other, searched the house top to bottom, called the police. And, finally, someone had opened the closet door.

Bakugou doesn't remember what happened right after. He knows that Mom and Dad spent some time apart. Bakugou lived with Dad and Grandma and Grandpa for a few months. And when he came back home, every single door handle was removed from the house. He couldn't stand the dark, so nightlights had been placed down every single hallway, every single room, and a lighting system was installed that could be voice or motion activated. Mom and Dad didn't get along for a very long time, and Dad never left him home alone with Mom again.

It was tense. It was bad. And Bakugou couldn't shake the feeling, even as a child, that it was his fault. He had failed to open the door. He was too weak to get out. He was forgettable, worthless. And he decided, from a very young age, that he would ensure no one would ever forget him again. He would be strong, he would never fail, and he'd be remembered. People would hear him when he screamed, and if he ever got locked in that closet again, he'd find a way to get that door to open.

Mom and Dad only got along again when Deku came to their house. When Miss Midoriya showed up on their doorstep with two trash bags and a sideways face. He and Deku—they became best friends. And one night, when Bakugou couldn't sleep, too afraid of the darkness in his room, he had rolled over and told Deku his secret.

"Mom forgot about me, and I got stuck in the dark for three days."

And Deku had told him his.

"I'm Quirkless."

And all the promises they've made since then have been terribly, disastrously broken.

He's never told anyone that before, and when the story finally slips out, his therapist doesn't look completely thrilled by the confession.

"And your mom," Yazmin says, twirling a pen between her dark fingers. "How's your relationship with her now?"

Bakugou wipes clammy hands on his pants. "It's fine."

"Fine?"

"That what I fucking said, isn't it?" He doesn't like questions about Mom. The ones about Dad are much easier. "She's fine."

"Do you like your mom, Bakugou?"

"She's my mom."

"That's not what I asked."

He bounces a leg, glances at the clock. "Times up."

"And I will be seeing you in two days," Yazmin says, standing to grab the door for him. "We will be continuing this conversation."

Sure thing, bitch.

Bakugou doesn't like therapy, not one fucking bit. The lady isn't mean or anything, but she's got these brown eyes that pierce through his goddamn soul. Therapists have this uncanny way of just knowing shit. He yawned during his first appointment, and she told him that people tend to yawn when they're uncomfortable or nervous. He'd decided at that moment

that she was going to piss him off, and he's been right. He's seen her over forty times now, three times a week for months on end.

He doesn't feel lighter or better after therapy like people said he would. He feels guilty, if anything. He walks out regretting any single thing he admitted, and it hits especially hard today. Over forty sessions, and he's just breached the conversation about Mom. For his first handful of sessions, they just sat in silence. He refused to talk, had thrown shit around the room in an attempt to be freed from her, and she still told him to come three times a week. Then, she began to talk about herself. Her husband, her kids, her Quirk, her life. More and more, and Bakugou didn't realize she was trying to lull him into a sense of security until he started to talk briefly about his own life.

He's never mentioned much about Mom before, but she seemed to lock onto that fucking awful relationship instantly. She always asks about Deku, Viridant, or Bakugou's about his friends, about what he did at school what day, what he ate, how he slept. It's invasive as shit, and he ignores it as best he can. It would be a lie to say some of her methods and practices don't work. Truthfully, everything she suggests and tries to pry out of him has only benefitted him.

But it's that act to begin with. He can't fathom opening up to her, spilling all this information bubbling inside him. The only person he's ever been so open with is Viridant and Deku, both of whom were the same fucking person. She's asked plenty about that. About how Bakugou feels about the arrest, how he interfered, what his thoughts are, and this and that and this and that, and he *hates* it. She's paid to listen to him, lulling his mind into safety by convincing him she cares about his progress.

She doesn't. Or maybe that's what he tells himself to stop his damn mouth from opening and confessing shit he regrets the moment he's out of the room. She wants to medicate him, or get him a diagnosis with something. She won't tell him what it is, which is so great to hear, and when she attempts a talk about testing, he shuts it down instantly. He's not fucking broken. He doesn't need to be fixed.

It's the world that fucking sucks. If people were just more honest and less god damn nosy, nothing would be the matter. He wouldn't feel like people are invading in his space, in his life, and he wouldn't be left out of big things in return. The world would level, and the need for god damn therapists would disappear. His classmates seem to love their therapists; the school students only benefit from it. But Bakugou can't stand to be sitting in a room where his every action has to have some deeper meaning.

He stomps down UA halls, in a mood far worse than when he came in. If counseling weren't a part of his final grade, he'd never fucking go. He'd spend his time doing more important shit.

Like figuring out what the hell happened to Deku.

It's been a week. Seven days. One hundred and sixty-eight hours. And he's heard next to nothing. He knows Deku faces no time in prison under the circumstances that he attends UA as a student, but there's been no other follow-up. He's called Miss Midoriya and went straight

to voicemail. There's nothing on the news. Aizawa-Sensei isn't ever in class anymore, and when he is, he doesn't answer a single fucking question.

Bakugou hates being left in the dark, literally and figuratively. He's on pins and god damn needles, trying not to blow a fucking fuse. No one is telling him what's going on. And he's had enough of it.

Shinso opens his dorm door when Bakugou pounds on it. He's since got a new one after his old one was busted down, which is a fact Bakugou feels a thrill of pure joy about. His cat sits on the bed, fighting a piece of string that's been taped to the ceiling to keep it entertained.

"Any update?" he demands

Shinso rolls his eyes. "I'll tell you the same shit I tell you every single day you knock on my door. UA had switched to paper documentation on all things regarding Midoriya. If you want to know what's going on, go figure it out yourself."

"Fuck you."

"Pass."

"Where is he? Can you tell me that much?" Bakugou snips.

Shinso lets out a long, pained sigh. He jerks his chin to the bedroom down the hall, located right by the stairs to the first floor. It's sat across from Todoroki's door, Iida's door right after it, then Shinso. Between Bakugou's door, right is right across from Shinso's, is Kirishima.

The door by the doors leads to an empty room, but Shinso's eyes linger on it. "He's moving in."

"What?" Bakugou shouts, not even meaning to raise his volume this time. "When? How do you know? Why on this floor?"

Shinso blinks slowly. "I don't know when, I just know he is. His mom was walking around and taking a tour with Aizawa-Sensei while you were doing who knows what. And it's this floor because there's no other open rooms without moving us all around. My guess is, Sensei thinks sticking all of us in close quarters will force us to bond."

"Fuck." Bakugou glares at the door. "This is bullshit."

"You'd much prefer he get a room on the roof? Makes it easier to jump, you know," Shinso leans against his doorway, giving Bakugou a bored look.

"You better hope I don't get my hands on that fucking cat."

"If you so much as breathe near Miss Baby," Shinso hisses, his eyes dark. "I will make you walk into oncoming traffic."

"I'd like to see you fucking try."

“Hey.” They both turn, lock eyes with Todoroki coming out of his dorm. “I didn't know we were meeting up again. Is someone in danger?”

“No,” Bakugou says, pushing away from Shinso’s room. “There’s no meeting up. We attempted a rescue together months ago; it’s not a regular fucking thing.”

Todoroki nods. “We should give our group a name.”

“This isn’t a group, Icy Hot.”

“We should call ourselves something cool. Like Kitten Enjoyers.”

Shinso rubs his eyes. “I’m going back to bed.”

“Oh, I was going to invite you to come see Midoriya with me.” Todoroki waves a hand goodbye. “See you guys.”

Shinso shoves Bakugou out of his way, sprinting to catch up. Bakugou shoves him back, and they wrestle down the staircase after Todoroki. He doesn’t say anything, just watches them as they roll over each other on the floor. Then he steps over them, keeps walking to the dorm exit, and out of it.

Motherfucker!

All three of them eventually find a way to function within proximity of the other. Which means that Todoroki walks between them, Bakugou walks beside the hall windows, and Shinso walks by the classroom doors. They don’t exchange a word—Well, Bakugou and Shinso don’t. Todoroki keeps suggesting group names that none of them listen to.

They eventually wind up in Recovery Girl’s nursing office. Todoroki slides the door open immediately, greeting Aizawa-Sensei inside. The teacher gives him barely a glance before his eyes lock on Shinso and Bakugou.

“Absolutely not.” He stands, hair already lifting. “Out. Both of you.”

“Why the hell does the fucking Zuko get free access and not us?” Bakugou snips. He hadn’t meant to say *us*, but Shinso doesn’t seem to complain.

“The kid is *resting,* I don’t need you waking him up!” Aizawa shoos them out, his voice a whispered hiss. “And his mother finally agreed to let him live here. Do you know how intensively I had to ensure her child’s safety? The two of you will throw that away in seconds. Out!”

“But—“

“OUT,” he whisper-yells, earning a nasty look from Recovery Girl. “Let him rest.”

“So he’s actually here?” Shinso asks, trying to peer over Aizawa’s shoulder. “Why is he in the recovery firm? Is he okay?”

“Do you two not have ears?” Aizawa says, finally grabbing both of them by their wrists and dragging them out of the room.

Todoroki, the fucking asshole, waves at them as the door slides shut. Bakugou’s going to throttle him.

“Listen to me,” Aizawa-Sensei says. “The kid has a shit load of injuries that need time to heal. His stamina was drained trying to fix it all, and if he doesn’t rest, then he can’t attend class tomorrow—“

“Tomorrow!” Shinso grits out, “Where was our notice of this? He’s just going to show up? Why didn’t you tell us?”

“Because I knew you’d both act like idiots,” Aizawa says calmly, guarding the door to the infirmary. “He’s been unconscious since I got him out of the police station and into the school. And he only came calmly because his mom asked him to. If you scare that woman off, then this whole thing goes to shit. She’s extremely hard to convince.”

Bakugou glowers. “So this gets sprung on us? Everyone else knew?”

Aizawa says flatly, “Yes.”

“How did you plan on getting him moved in without us knowing?” Shinso spits out, his brows furrowed. “Magically teleport his belongings in?”

Aizawa gives him a blank look. “He’s been moved in for days. Neither of you two noticed because I gave you extra homework to keep you busy.”

Bakigou’s mouth pops open in shock. “We’re on the same fucking side!”

“You lost that privilege the moment you snuck off to go confront him alone,” Aizawa-Sensei snaps back. “I gave you the chance to work with me despite already taking it away once, and you threw it away. I’m on everyone’s side, especially my students, and Midoriya is now a Class 1-A student. He will be respected a such, and two seem not to share a single respectful bone between you.”

“It’s not my fault Bakugou doesn’t know how to function like a human being,” Shinso says.

“Oh, fuck you!” Bakugou shouts, immediately getting the support scarf wrapped around his mouth to control his volume.

“See? He’s like a rabid animal. I can be plenty calm,” Shinso says blankly, face clouded. “He’s my friend.”

“Right now, he’s not anything,” Aizawa-Sensei says quietly. “He’s going to wake up in an unfamiliar environment, with unfamiliar people, and the last thing he needs is past history interfering with his first impressions of UA. We’ll be lucky if he doesn’t plan some way to escape the school by the end of next week, do you understand me?” He levels them both with a god honest deathly glare. “Do. Not. Mess. This. Up.”

“But—

“No buts,” Aizawa whispers, “You two can interact with him plenty when he’s awake and alert, but for today, just let him sleep.”

It’s Bakugou who says, keeping his voice quiet. “Can I just make sure he’s okay?”

Aizawa’s eyes soften, and he glances between the two of them. “Not a single word when you’re in there, do you understand me? If you want to talk, do it in the hall.”

They agree instantly, and when Aizawa slides the door open again, not a single sound is made between the two of them. He grabs a curtain in the back corner of the room, slowly reels it backwards to reveal Deku.

Bakugou has never seen him asleep before. His head his lulled back, chest rising and falling slowly. His eyelids flicker, and he twitches like crazy, but he doesn’t wake up. Todoroki takes the only open chair, not reacting even slightly to the dirty looks thrown at him. He’s not sure why Todoroki has been visiting Deku, but it sparks a kindle of rage inside him he hasn’t felt in a long time.

Still, he doesn’t talk.

Recovery Girl hobbles over, peers over at him and the machines reading his vitals. She speaks, her voice old and worn but gentle at the same time.

“His whole body had signs of trauma.” He’s not sure why she’s telling them this, but she still talks anyway. “His leg suffered a fracture that healed wrong, so it had to be rebroken and set again. Three broken ribs, crooked and broken fingers. Burn marks, trauma to the head. Most of his wounds had healed wrong, needed to be completely shattered and fixed again.”

She picks up Deku’s limp arm, flips it, flashes the hand marks forever burnt into his skin. “Couldn’t get this sucker up either. But he’s strong, I’m sure. He’ll heal fine.”

Bakugou swallows a lump in his throat at the sight of those burns. He didn’t leave those bruises or most of the scars. But those burns—he left those. Even worse, he doesn’t know when he did it. He’s always careful to make sure his Quirk is never activated when he’s laid hands on Deku. Maybe that’s a flawed ideology, but it’s something he’s lived by. He truly can’t remember when he burnt him. He hadn’t meant to, he knows that much.

Still, it’s hard to look at. Knowing he caused him pain, even without meaning to. Yazmin would have a fucking field day with a confession like that.

“What…” They turn, meeting the eyes of Miss Midoriya.

Aizawa immediately steps forward, apologizes. “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have—”

“Hitoshi?” she whispers, her eyes watering. “Katsuki? Oh, I was so worried about you boys. I haven’t seen you since I got here—I was worried I’d miss out on you.” She rushes forward, wraps her arms around them both.

Bakugou isn't keen on hugs, but he wraps his arms around her, holds her tight, despite also touching Shinso. Not his most ideal position, but at least she isn't furious with him.

She pulls back, grabs Shinso's face. "Izuku told me you've been distant. Are you alright, honey?"

Shinso nods frantically. "Yes, a-absolutely. I'm sorry I haven't been around." Bakugou flips him off behind Miss Midoriya's back, to which Shinso tries not to glare.

She smiles sweetly at him, then moves to Bakugou. She dusts his shirt off, pats his cheek. "And you? How are you, sweetheart? I'm sure you're shaken." Shinso sticks his tongue out, holding up two middle fingers as she squeezes Bakugou's face.

"I'm okay, Miss Midoriya." Someone snorts at his response; he's not sure who. "How are you? I've seen you so much recently, and never with the bowl of Katsudon I promised."

She waves him off, blushing brightly. "You are such a gentleman, Katsuki."

Another snort, and this time he's certain it's Aizawa or Shinso behind it.

"If you two boys are taking care of my baby," she says, smiling wide. "Then I know he's in good hands here."

Bakugou stink eyes Shinso the second she turns to Aizawa-Sensei. Shinso holds his fingers up and pretends to shoot Bakugou in the forehead. When she turns back around, both of them drop their hands and offer their sweetest smiles. Someone snorts again, and he sees it was Todoroki the entire time. Fucking asshole.

"Yes, Bakugou and Shinso are…" Aizawa clears his throat, "Model students. Midoriya will be seated right beside them."

"Oh, thank goodness! He'll have friends." She seems genuinely happy, but she turns to the two of them. Her cheeks are rosy, her smile still warm. "And if I hear that the two of you were anything but nice to my baby again, I will make sure you're dealt with properly."

Horrifying. This is why he's so nice to Deku's mom. One, because he actually respects her. And two, because he's fairly certain she could literally kill him if she wanted to. She kisses Izuku's head, and they decide to give him privacy.

When all four of them step out of the room, Aizawa gives them one final warning not to fuck this up tomorrow. Bakugou finds himself saying the same thing to himself at night, struggling to find sleep, knowing Deku is within the walls as him.

Don't fuck this up.

Chapter End Notes

Yay!

Chapter 39: Beginning

Chapter Summary

Midoriya has his first day at UA

Chapter Notes

Guys, I'm thinking I should change this fic's name because the current one doesn't feel right. Any suggestions? I have a few, but they're all evil >:)

When he was a kid, Midoriya had dreamed of the day he would attend UA. He drew pictures of his future classmates, talked endlessly to Mama about all the friends he'd have. He wanted, more than anything, to sit among his peers and feel equal to them. But this reality shatters, breaks, and he wakes up in a cold hospital room with the horrible realization that he never really escaped going to jail. He's in prison, but the bars just so happen to look like the fancy school gates.

He's stuck here.

Midoriya works at the stupid red tie to his uniform. He can't get the damn thing to look right, and the anger that's been boiling inside him has brought him to absolute frustration. He doesn't want to be here. He had planned to go after Tenko, and if Bakugou hadn't shown up, he would've had his brother's fucking corpse in his hands.

Instead, he's standing in his dorm room in front of a mirror, clenching his teeth and struggling with his tie.

He had thought he was going to die a week ago. He thought I would come down to racist police officers shooting him for being nothing but peaceful and cooperative. He had sat in a holding cell alone, cold, and when they finally bailed him out hours later, Mama was there to beg him to go to UA. To become a Hero the right way. To keep her safe, the legal way.

He's been seething since. He doesn't want to be a Hero, he decided. He wants to strangle his brother to death, he wants to bash his Dad's head in with the steel-tipped toe of his shoe. He didn't want to change his entire life and come to a school that never wanted him in the first place. Riddled with cameras, with Pros, with old friends who never really gave a shit about him.

He's furious. That rage settles inside him and pleads to be let out, to destroy, and he's been stifling it since he woke up in a hospital bed with all his pain gone. Wiped away. Medical care that he and Mama never had access to. Why doesn't the general public get free health care and a Recovery Quirk miracle worker kissing away their injuries?

Why do the Heroes get fucking everything?

"Fuck!" He rips the tie off, throws it across the room. He hates being angry, but all he is lately is a ball of rage, of energy. He's not an angry person; he likes to think this was a point he was driven to.

The killer of his friends is out there, and he's stuck playing pretend in a school full of liars.

Bakugou had said he came alone.

Midoriya slides down his wall to the floor, holding his head between his hands. How did he fall for it again? The apology did him in, the admission of guilt, and the devastated look in Bakugou's eyes. He called him by his real name, promised him a future that Midoriya hadn't known he ever wanted. And then they almost…

He doesn't know what came over him. Maybe sheer stupidity. Gullibleness. Naive memories. Something weak, something that shattered the moment a police officer pinned him to the muddy ground.

He's *done* with Katsuki Bakugou. Never again. Never again will he fucking trust him. He sat in that cold cell waiting for hours, shivering, tears streaming down his face. And it will not happen again.

A knock sounds on the door, and Midoriya stays curled into a ball on the opposite side of the room. Mama must've retrieved all his things, because the dorm is laid out almost identically to his home bedroom. Even Mama is here, housed on campus as a way to guarantee her safety and keep Midoriya enticed to stay at the school.

The knock comes again, and he glares at the door, wishing away whoever is on the other side. Of course, his wishes don't seem to work. They never have. A third knock, and he gets up, puts on his best calm face, and pries the door open.

All Might.

"Hello," he says kindly, hands tucked into the pockets of his dress pants. "Young Midoriya."

You're kidding, right?

"It's been a while since we've truly talked, face to face." All Might rocks back and forth on his heels. "I've come to escort you to class."

Midoriya's eye twitches. "I can find it on my own."

All Might corrects himself. "I'm here to make sure you don't flee the school the second you have the chance." When Midoriya doesn't respond, the man grimly smiles at him. "I'll give

you the truth, young Midoriya. Everyone is on the edge of their seats, waiting to see what you'll do next. Myself included. I can only imagine you're beside yourself about today. So I wanted to personally reassure you." All Might's blue eyes land on the scrap of a tie on the bedroom floor. "Do you mind?"

Midoriya sighs, swoops down to grab it, and slings it over his neck. He misses the comfort of his support scarf.

"I don't know how to tie it," he confesses.

All Might smiles, grabs either end. "I had to teach myself when I came to UA years ago. You'd think they'd teach you how to wear these things if it was going to be part of the uniform."

Midoriya says nothing, avoiding his eyes as he works at his tie.

"Your mom's room is located directly between mine and Eraser's. There is no safer location in the world for her." All Might crosses the ends, tucks a strand over the other. "Additionally, you'll be admitted to Hero courses at the start of next week. For now, you'll have the chance to get used to the school without the additional pressure of Hero classes."

He smooths the tie out, steps back. Midoriya feels it on his chest. It's a bit bulkier than most are worn, but it's a tie nonetheless, so he'll take it.

"Thanks." He grabs his backpack off the floor, empty of all his gear, which was seized almost immediately.

"Of course," All Might says, stepping aside so Midoriya can walk alongside his skinny form. "Not many people know about my true form, you know."

"Wouldn't want to scare them."

All Might bellows out a laugh. "You're funny, I like that."

"I wasn't joking."

"Listen," All Might tugs him to a stop when they make it outside the dorm buildings. He's already running late, so he doesn't really care for an additional lesson. "I need to tell you something."

"Does it pertain to giving up on my dreams and finding other places to put my talents?" he asks.

All Might winces but says, "Yes. That's exactly what this is about."

Midoriya huffs, crossing his arms. "Are you going to tell me how wrong you were and how deeply you regret it?"

"No," All Might says, and Midoriya blinks in shock. "I'll tell you the truth, and the truth is, I don't regret trying to turn you away from Hero work. While I regret the reason I gave you,

which was because you were Quirkless, it's only because that was a lie. Anyone can become a Hero, but not many can survive it."

He listens, face drawn.

"Anytime someone asks me if Hero work is the right path for them, I say no. I do my best to turn them away, though, admittedly, I do it in a less harsh way than I did for you," All Might confesses. "Truthfully, Heroism is a respected and sought-after career. But the reality is, some of my closest friends, people I consider family, have died in this line of work. I didn't turn you away because I didn't think you could do it; I turned you away because I feared that you could."

Midoriya stuffs his hand into his pockets. "You don't like your job?"

"I love my job," All Might says. "But I love my job because my job is my life, it's who I am. I love my job because without it, I'd have no friends. I love my job because without it, I'd be half the person I am today. But it doesn't change that I have not an ounce of time for myself, for relationships outside of work, for a family or kids, for anything." He holds Midoriya's shoulder in his grasp. "I have watched people I love die, time and time again, and have had to accept that if I continue in this field, it will never stop happening. You can't save everyone, and that's a fate I was trying to spare you from."

All Might lets him go, his expression dark. "I am sorry that I told you it was because you were Quirkless. But I'm not sorry I tried to turn you away; in fact, I wish I had succeeded. As happy as I am to have you as part of this institution, it will never change that I wish this institution didn't exist at all. I wish this were a world where Heroes weren't needed, where kids weren't put through school with the promise of fame and fortune only to grow old with nobody around to mourn them."

Jesus Christ. Midoriya rubs his head and feels a bit of that anger dissipate. All Might is surprisingly honest, and it's a relief like no other to have someone tell it to him how it is. No apologies and mushy words. All Might is genuine, even if the way he went about it was wrong.

"You feel it, don't you?"

Midoriya watches him. "Feel what?"

"The calling." All Might puts a hand over his heart. "I feel it in my chest. Every second I spend away from Hero work, away from helping someone. Every moment I give myself time to rest or recover. There's that feeling in my chest, begging me to do more, to be more."

Midoriya's eyes widen. Nobody has ever mentioned that before, the near-painful throb of his heart. The way his body begs him to move, to act.

All Might presses a finger over Midoriya's heart. "The heart of a Hero. You have it. And as mad as you may be that you are here, it's impossible to deny that this is what you were meant to be. No matter what, Izuku Midoriya, you were going to be a Hero."

His heart thrums. It beats loudly, his veins filling with blood. Pulsing, aching. Needing to be out and working, saving, helping, fixing.

Killing.

“Welcome to UA,” All Might says, smiling wide. “I hope it’s everything you thought it would be and more.”

Midoriya says, “What about All for One?”

And All Might laughs, hands on his hips as though he’s untouchable. “Against you? I fear he doesn’t stand much of a chance now.”

Midoriya can’t help the small smile cracking on his face. He’s not happy to be here, but All Might remains his favorite Hero for a reason. It’s just that now he can finally see him as more than an image of justice, a pillar of peace. All Might is just a man, and Midoriya’s heart had shattered knowing that this depiction of Heroism could be flawed, could make mistakes.

But he rather likes this new version of All Might. A bit awkward, shy, but still smart and morally correct. He’s human, and Midoriya has gone so long being treated as though he were anything but. So he gets it, this version of All Might, a man upheld by the ideology that he could never fall or let harm befall others. Midoriya likes to see beneath the costume, beneath the façade. Human.

“Now let’s get you to class before Eraser chews me a new one,” All Might says, ushering Midoriya along. “And if anyone gives you trouble, I trust you’ll whip them into shape.”

Midoriya nibbles his lip to keep his smile down. That fanboy admiration has started to return, dammit, and he already gave away all his memorabilia. Someone took it within seconds of him donating it, so he couldn’t get it back if he tried. And he’s debating trying now, his awe for All Might returning in full throttle. Maybe it’s the honesty, maybe it’s the confidence, but he can’t help the little kid inside him screaming about being in a school that All Might teaches.

So he heads to class, pelting All Might with the thousands of questions he’s had since he was a little boy. And he comes to the realization that he never really stopped being All Might’s fan; he was just mad at him. Mad at him for being flawed, for being different from the image he had conjured up in his head. But he’s not mad anymore.

And he wants that Quirk. He plans to get it.

When he makes it to 1-A, All Might promises to see him soon before heading off down the hall. Midoriya stands alone outside a very large door. He doesn’t let the nerves of going inside startle him. Instead, he grasps the open handle and slowly slides it.

Aizawa-Sensei sips coffee out of his cat sweater mug, giving him a very small smile. “Decent enough timing, I suppose.”

Midoriya fiddles with the strap of his bag, staring at his feet as he’s gestured forward.

“This is our newest student, Midoriya. You are to treat him as you would any peers—“

“MIDO!”

Midoriya jolts, looks up. Kaminari waves his hands back and forth, Sero smiling wildly. “Oh… hey.”

“YOU’RE THE VIGILANTE?!” Kaminari screams, laughing. “NO WAY! THE LOVE GURU IS A VIGILANTE?!”

Aizawa-Sensei’s eye twitches. “How do you three know each other?”

“Mido is awesome!” Mina chimes in from her seat in the center of the room. “He doesn’t know any internet references; it was the best interaction I’ve ever had.”

A tall, blue-haired man stands up. He adjusts his glasses, shouting, “Class, do not interrupt Aizawa-Sensei!”

Midoriya blinks slowly, unable to fully understand the dynamic at play here. Aizawa rubs his temples.

“This is Midoriya?” A boy with spikey red hair pipes up, “I can’t believe I missed that hangout. That’s not even fair. You met an internet-deprived famous vigilante who pisses Bakugou off with ease? How’s that fair?”

“Enough,” Aizawa says, eyes flashing. The class goes deathly silent. “Do not harass Midoriya. And if I hear the word ‘vigilante’ again, you’ll be expelled.”

Midoriya says, out loud, “Vigilante. Can I go home now?”

Giggles around the room that stop at Aizawa’s glare. “Go sit, problem child.”

Midoriya nods, taking the chance to look over the room as he heads to an open desk. It’s right behind Bakugou, go figure. To the left of Shinso, even better. Can he get any closer to hell without dying?

Very few students remain in this classroom. After the death of three of them, many others dropped out. It leaves an entire back row open, the students condensing to the front part of the room. He spots Todoroki, whose multi-colored gaze pins Midoriya. He never did get back to him about Endeavor, so Midoriya left it alone. Then there’s the girl from the woods, Uraraka, whom he has met only once when laying her in the bushes to ensure a psychopath didn’t eat the blood from her veins.

Mina, Sero, and Kaminari, all of whom he’s met before and enjoys. And a few others scattered around that he knows nothing about other than their names and Quirks from the stolen roster.

Class begins, and it’s the most bizarre situation to be in. He keeps turning around to talk to Ito, then sees the empty seat behind him and remembers he can’t do that anymore. Every time he’s bored, his fingers twitch toward his phone, begging him to text the group chat with

Sayori, Banri, and Ito in it. They'd always joke around, poke fun at each other. He didn't know how much he took that for granted. Especially not when class lets out, and everyone already has their own little groups they fall into.

He's quick to disappear, to move to the hall and rush to the lunch room. He walks alone, the ghost of who he's lost his only company. He will never again have someone defend him against bullies, have someone to tutor on chemistry or math, or have a small group of people who don't need to know everything about him to still care. It was an easy friendship, comfort found in four teenagers who were awkward and weird and got along just fine despite it. His first friends. And…

And Midoriya darts into a bathroom. He shuts the door, locks it, and slides down until he sits on the floor. Tears come fast, and guilt slams against his skull. Rin was a suicide, and while he never fully blamed himself, the seed of self-hatred that sprouted as a result of her death festered inside him. But Ito, and Banri, and Sayori, those were all his fault. And he won't ever get those memories back. Even now, they fade, melt into his mind. He can't remember what hand Ito used to scoop food into his mouth, or the color of Sayori's eyes, or the pitch of Banri's voice.

And these horrible images in his head, of their eyes, of their throats. The sound of Sayori gasping, using her last words to tell him she never sold him out. And he can't help but wish that she had. Can't help but wish he were in that house hours earlier, that Dad took him out, too. That he stopped missing these near-death moments and finally hit one head-on. He's so tired, and he's so angry, and he just wants to be clueless and oblivious again. He doesn't want to be a Hero anymore.

He just wants to go home. He doesn't want to leave this bathroom and eat a school lunch. He wants to go back to the apartment, taking home-cooked meals from Mama to school. Back to his nightly patrols where he busted small crimes, messed with Pros, had friends to sit with at lunch.

He feels so small, and he cries in a school that is so big. Why did it have to be him? Why couldn't he have just… just been a normal kid? With a normal family. And a normal Quirk. And a normal dream.

Why did they have to die?

Someone knocks on the bathroom door, and he wipes his face off as best he can. He splashes water on his skin, blows his nose quietly. When he opens it, he offers an awkward smile to the student on the other side.

"S-Sorry," he mumbles, and pushes past her.

She grabs his arm. "Are you okay?"

He looks up, meets her eyes, and… and it's the girl from the woods. Her cheeks have ovals of pink, her palms are padded with calluses.

Midoroya clears his throat. "Yeah, I just had to pee."

She laughs softly at that, and he flushes in embarrassment. “Izuku, right? Or do you prefer Midoriya?”

“Izuku’s fine,” he says, and she launches forward and wraps her arms around him in a hug.

He’s not sure what the hell to do; this is a completely insane situation, so he just stands there awkwardly.

Uraraka pulls away quickly, her face red. “I’m sorry, that was forward—you just seemed like you needed a hug. I know on my first day I was freaking out and—-sorry.” She pokes two fingers together, her face completely pink now. “I wanted to thank you.”

He blinks slowly. “For… what?”

“Saving me at the training camp,” she says quietly. “I woke up covered in twigs and leaves, and that crazy girl walked by me at least five times. You seriously saved my life.”

Oh. He had forgotten about that.

Uraraka's face falls. “You’re crying. Are you sure you’re alright?”

“Yeah, I’m just,” He wipes his face, unable to stop the tears. “I’m sorry, I’m not meaning to be so emotional. It’s just been a rough day—I bet you thought Viridant was some cool vigilante, not a crybaby, huh?”

She says, her voice honest and true. “I just thought you were kind.”

And he can’t help the sob ripping out of his chest. That’s all he’s ever really wanted to be, he thinks. Kind. In a world full of people who are mean, and wicked, and cruel. He just wanted to be kind.

“God. I’m sorry, I’m really not trying to cry,” he laughs out, trying to hold it in. “My friends just died.”

Fuck, why did he say that?

Uraraka doesn’t seem deterred by it, once again offering an awkward hug. He takes it, and she feels almost as warm as Ito did when he’d throw his arm over his shoulder. Almost as solid as Banri was when he’d shove Midoroya’s arm. Almost as gentle as Sayori when she'd flick his head or hand. And they weigh so heavily in his heart, drag him to the floor, and this random girl hugs him all the same.

Grief has got to be one of the feelings in the world. It takes up so much room inside him. It wrestles with anger like they’ve known each other this whole time. Like it’s all one big joke he’s not in on. He doesn’t want to hurt anymore; he just wants things to go back to how they were before.

“You know,” she says, still hugging him. “Missing someone—it means they mattered. Even if they aren’t here anymore, some part of them is immortal still; it lives inside us.” She

squeezes him, pulls away. “The feeling doesn’t ever go away. You’ll never stop missing them. But it dims, I think. It’s like a light, it won’t always be so bright.”

“Thank you,” he says, smiling at her, using his stupid tie to wipe more tears off his face. “I’m sorry to dump all of that on you. I’m usually… I’m usually more composed.”

She shrugs. “We’re all human. If you ever need a buddy, I’m here.” He nods, and she steps back, pushes open the bathroom door, and announces loudly, “I’m gonna pee.”

Midoriya belts out a laugh, his first real one in… in a long time. “You do that.”

She snickers, shuts the door, and he feels truly awful. He drags his feet to the lunch room, keeps his head down, and moves through the line. He takes only an apple, knowing it’ll be a miracle if he can keep even that down.

And he sits at a table alone. In a room full of people, he’s alone. And it’s painful, and it hurts, and he takes it for all of one minute before he stands and leaves. He’s not sure where he’s going, only that he can’t stop walking. He can’t sit at an empty table with people looking at him, watching him break and crack open.

He ends up at the training dome Hitoshi—no, Shinso took him too. He climbs it without thinking, sits at its top peak, and cries like a little kid.

He doesn’t go to his next classes. He sits up there, apple in hand, but unable to eat it. And wishes he could just go home.

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Aizawa finds the kid hours after school lets out. He knows he didn’t leave campus because of the high security, claiming they never saw him. So he shifted through cameras, searched endlessly for the speck of faded green. He had thought maybe the kid was exploring, or hopefully with new friends.

He finds him in the training arena. Aizawa climbs to the top, sees the kid lying flat on his back and staring up through the glass roof. Most of the tiles are frosted, but the one dead center, it’s pure glass. You can see right through it, stare at the clouds in the sky. But now that it’s night, and the dome has gone nearly pitch black, the little vigilante lies on his back and looks up at the stars.

Aizawa settles into a crouch at the kid's feet. “I heard you skipped the rest of your classes.”

“Oh no,” the kid says softly. “I guess you should expel me.”

He sighs, looks at the bottom of the structure. “I’m sorry that… that this is the way things ended up. I know you’re not happy, I know I didn’t go about it the right way.”

“Yeah,” Viridant—ah, Midoriya says. “You really fucked me up, you know?”

Aizawa elbows the bottom of his foot. “Tell me about it.”

“About what?” Midoriya asks, his voice a whisper.

“Anything,” Aizawa offers softly. “Anything you want.”

The kid says nothing at all.

So Aizawa speaks instead. “When I was a student here, my friend died.” The wind seems to stop blowing, silence descending in the dome. “I almost dropped out. Coming to school every day and knowing he wouldn’t be here, it was the worst thing I’ve ever gone through.”

“What was his name?”

“Oboro,” Aizawa says, looking up at the stars. “His name was Oboro, and he was… he was a good person. A really good person. It’s been over a decade, and there is not a single day that goes by that I don’t think about him.” Aizawa shakes his head, grabs the kid's calf, and gives it a gentle squeeze. “I know you’re mad at me, but I’m here for you. Anything you need, I’m here.”

And he doesn’t expect a response, but it comes anyway. “Does the guilt go away?”

Aizawa won’t lie to this kid, not ever again. “No.” He brushes a hand through his hair. “But it dims.”

“Like a light.”

“Just like that.”

“Eraser,” Midoriya says softly. “It was my fault they died. I had mentioned them to the league’s leader. I don’t know why I did it. But that’s why they died. It was my fault.”

Aizawa takes a deep breath, lies by the kid. He won't attempt to tell him it wasn't his fault. He knows firsthand that it doesn't matter what anyone tells you; it doesn't change that your friend is still dead. They both stare at the sky. “Any information on the league, it’s yours, okay? Every conference, I’ll make sure you’re included.”

Midoriya turns to him, his eyes rimmed red. “Why?”

“Because I know that feeling,” he says, starlight shining down on them. “And I know that there's nothing to plug that hole—but there are a few things that come close. So you’re part of our team now, okay? You’ll help us take these shithead outs, save lives.”

Midoriya’s face scrunches, curls, and his shoulders wobble and shake as he cries. And Aizawa does too. Grief does that, it ruins, it breaks, it enrages, and it hurts. And he wishes,

more than anything, that he could have his friend back. But he can't, so he'll do all he can to ensure that nobody else loses theirs.

And they lay there, two people reduced to children. And the sky seems to be full of stars, watching them. Waiting to see what they'll do next.

Chapter 40: Combat testing

Chapter Summary

Midoriya starts his first day of Heroics class.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Since we have a new student," Aizawa-Sensei says, hands deep in the pockets of his sweatpants. "We will again be combat testing to gather a feel of our new peers."

A few cheers, students excited for whatever combat testing is. Midoriya is nervous, honestly. His first week of school dragged by, and a weekend spent in Mama's new room recharged him. They both slept in her bed, watching movies and talking about anything and everything. He cried a lot, of course, and she held him the whole time.

And now it's a new week. His first start at Hero courses. The first Quirkless kid in UA, combat training against kids with months of hand-to-hand training.

Yay.

"It'll be a tournament bracket system," Aizawa-Sensei says, "Students will be randomly paired, winner faces off against the winner of another randomly paired match. I want to see no Quirks used, only the skills you've learned in combat."

He steps back, looks at all of his students. They've all changed into blue standard gym clothes. Midoriya wasn't used the new attire, finding the sweats and T-shirt fit him perfectly. He's not sure when his adjustments were added to UA databases, but it seems they've got him down perfectly now. Everyone else has their own variations of the same thing, and it feels more like a PE class than a Heroics course.

"First round," Aizawa-Sensei says, drawing names out of a basket. "Kaminari versus Uraraka."

"I'm cooked," Kaminari announces immediately, making a few people laugh.

He steps onto the mat laid on the grass of a training field. Uraraka follows after. They take up a standard fighting position, and the match is over in actual seconds. Uraraka knocks him on his ass immediately, shoving him out of the ring a moment later. Pure skill, strength, and some sort of internship with a Pro making her beyond skilled.

Midoriya watches carefully, mumbling notes to himself about the match. He'd kill to have his notebook right now. Still, he mentally calculates her skills. She's right-handed, but she swung

with her left, likely how she was training to ensure strength in both appendages. Combat training very rarely includes legs, so she likely has less experience on the lower half of her body. Still, her handwork is quick, calculated.

He purses his lips when Sero gives him a weird look. He must've been mumbling, a bad habit.

"Jirou versus Shinso."

He watches intently. It's a tight match, and Shinso pulls through just barely. His experience with a mental Quirk means he has more hands-on practice, as opposed to Jirou's heavy reliance on her Quirk in most situations. He was able to outsmart her rather than beat her with skill, a match completely different from the first—

"Bro," Sero says, elbowing Midoriya. "You're freaking me out."

"Sorry," he squeaks. "They don't let us take notes during this?"

"Uhh… nobody has ever asked," Sero laughs, looking around. "I'm sure you could get some pen and paper."

"Is there a reason you two aren't paying attention?" Aizawa-Sensei asks, pulling more names from a basket.

Sero keeps quiet, and Midoriya struggles to get words out. Eventually, the request leaves his mouth.

"C-Can I get a n-notebook? To take notes?" He's so stupid. "Or is that… not allowed?"

Aizawa's lips twitch. "It's allowed. I'm surprised it took over an entire semester for students to ask to take notes during a Heroics class. I was waiting to see how long they'd go."

Midoriya flushes when someone claps him on the back and congratulates him. When the next match starts, Yaoyorozu versus Iida, Midoriya's handed his old notebook. He doesn't have a moment to question it; instead, he takes notes quickly. He recaps the last few fights, adds this new one to it. His muttering doesn't stop, but it's far less loud or creepy.

Iida wins, and Midoriya notes his rigid fighting style.

"Next up," Aizawa-Sensei pulls two more names. "Kirishima versus Midoriya."

A few winces from students, and Midoriya's got a feeling they aren't on his side. That's fine, he's used to it. Sero holds his notebook and pen, and Midoriya timidly enters the ring with the boy with spikey red hair.

"Match set," Aizawa says, a hand in the air. He chops it down. "Start."

Midoriya makes himself look as small as possible, analyzing Kirishima's stance. His legs are wide, bracing his weight. With his Quirk activated, he's a well-balanced machine. Without it,

his center of gravity depends on how he carries himself. And he's a bit too stable to knock over.

Kirishima swings, the power coming from his legs. Midoriya easily dodges it, drops to the floor, and sweeps his leg out. He drags out Kirishima's left leg, and when the student hits the mat, Midoriya wraps an arm around his throat and drags him backwards. If the goal was to snap his neck or choke him out, it would be easier. But Midoriya has to drag him to the edge, flip him over, and shove him off the blue mat.

Not his quickest win, but a good one, nonetheless. Kirishima coughs, and Midoriya nibbles his lip. Was he too rough? Most kids fought clean, maybe he—

"Does anyone want to tell me why Midoriya's fighting style was different than the rest of yours?" Aizawa-Sensei asks.

Midoriya quickly goes back to his spot by Sero, thanking him for holding his notebook. He jots down notes as Aizawa calls on someone with a raised hand.

It's Yaoyorozu. "He's got real-life experience. Everyone in here is trained in combat that is somewhat friendly. Midoriya has fought real villains, criminals; he fights to live."

"Correct," Aizawa-Sensei says, nodding. "Midoriya's fighting style is aggressive, efficient. He doesn't focus too much on form and position; his body naturally knows how to best respond to attacks. His fighting style is adjustable, not trained or drilled into him. He responds to what's thrown at him, to how his enemy holds themselves. He doesn't follow a strict procedure or regimen."

Midoriya's face is so warm he can only imagine he looks like a strawberry right now.

"I highly suggest you all watch him very closely, learn a thing or two. This is the closest you will come to real-world experience before touching the field." Aizawa-Sensei nods at him. "Good work."

He draws two more names, and Midoriya nibbles his lip as Bakugou is called to go against Tokoyami. The fight isn't very evenly matched, but Tokoyami manages to hold up against Bakugou fairly well. His movements are defensive, as though expecting an offensive attack from Bakugou. It's no shock that Bakugou fights aggressively, and the battle drags on until Tokoyami is finally shoved out of bounds.

The next one is called: Sero versus Mina. Now this match has near identical skill levels. The two of them start laughing in the middle of it, which pisses Aizawa-Sensei off but has no real effect on the match. They take the longest out of any of them, pushing and pulling, until Mina finally knocks Sero out of bounds.

It leaves only Todoroki without a turn.

"Todoroki," Aizawa-Sensei says. "Since the number of students is uneven, you can pick who you'd like to go up against next."

Midoriya starts taking notes, waiting for Todoroki to choose his desired classmate.
“Midoriya.”

What?

He blinks slowly, “Yes?”

“You’re up,” Aizawa says, gesturing him forward. “He picked you.”

“What? He did?” Midoriya asks, and Sero laughs before holding Midoriya’s notebook.

He steps onto the mat, stands across from Todoroki. He really hadn’t expected to be picked, much less by Todoroki. Is it because his fighting style is weird?

Aizawa lifts a hand. “Match set.” He drags it down. “Start.”

Neither one of them moves. Someone laughs in the crowd of students, but it changes nothing. They stare at each other, and Midoriya realizes this is why Todoroki chose him. Midoriya is more reactive, rarely making the first move in a fight, which, apparently, Todoroki is the same. They analyze each other, take in each other's loose posture.

Even weirder, Todoroki *copies* him. Mimics his stance, his foot placement. He’s quick, the son of the world's number two Hero, he’s likely been trained since he could walk. Does Midoriya really stand a chance here?

But… If Todoroki was trained by his father, which Midoriya suspects he was…

He does his best to recall the fighting style Endeavor used. He was an All Might fanboy all the way, but to ignore Endeavor was stupid. There’s a reason he managed a close second place, and it’s because he’s a good fighter. He’s skilled with his Quirk, sure, but Endeavor is particularly brutal close up in fights.

So Midoriya moves first, circles, and Todoroki copies him. Endeavor swings wide; he wants his opponents to know he’s going to hit them. While Todoroki doesn’t seem to be as cruel as his father, his slightly wide arm placement hints at a similar upbringing. He swings wide, and his foot placement is somewhere between Kirishima’s wide stance and Uraraka’s steady and compact stance.

Which means his center of gravity isn’t in his legs or arms.

It’s in his chest.

Midoriya lurched forward, drives his shoulder into Todoroki’s stomach. He sets his feet between his, his red shoes blinding against the blue mat. Still, Todoroki loses his footing, goes down. But he's is well taught, and he lands a harsh kick to Midoriya’s stomach, giving him the time to stand again.

And they're back to circling, both of their stomachs likely aching the same amount. Midoriya can’t remember the last time he took a shoe to the gut, but he definitely didn’t miss it. Todoroki doesn’t seem to be pleased either, his brows drawn together, posture slightly

hunched. He wasn't expecting to be taken down, to be honest, Midoriya didn't think he'd do it either—

Todoroki swings, and it's wide, swooping. Midoriya moves on instinct, dodging the arm before grabbing it.

And snapping it against his knee.

The crack is loud, echoes, and he yanks on the broken limb to throw him across his body. Todoroki doesn't hit the floor this time, but he manages to stay upright only because he has space to stumble off the mat.

He holds his broken arm, teeth gritted. Silence fills the air, and Midoriya feels shame creeping in.

"I'm sorry," he says quickly, hands out, "T-That was brutal. I didn't mean to do that."

"Todoroki, head to Recovery Girl," Aizawa says, and Todoroki leaves without another word. Guilt eats at Midoriya, but before he can step off the mat, Aizawa asks another question to the group. "Who wants to tell me why Midoriya won that match?"

Iida is called on this time. "He didn't hesitate to win by any means necessary."

Aizawa nods, looks at Midoriya, then to the rest of the class. "At the beginning of this match, neither of them moved. Who can tell me why?"

And Midoriya doesn't look as Bakugou is called on. "They were waiting for the other to go first so they could learn to adapt to their techniques."

"Correct, good," Aizawa turns to Midoriya. "And why did you attack first?"

Midoriya picks a cuticle, stares at his feet. "His stance…"

"What about it?" Aizawa asks.

Midoriya takes a deep breath, unused to so many people watching him. "It wasn't like the others. Kirishima stands wide, placing his balance in his legs. Uraraka stands compact, making her balance around her chest and shoulders. But Todoroki was in between, his body weight evenly distributed. So his center of gravity would be located in his stomach."

Aizawa grins, and it must be a rare sight, because someone tries to take a picture and is immediately knocked upside the head with the support weapon.

"So you attacked first to throw him off, and…?" Aizawa prompts.

Midoriya swallows. "I knew he'd strike back, likely had an ego about his skill. Which h-he should, he's a good fighter. Uhm… I just… I knew he'd attack me back, and it would give me the opening to take his wide swing and use it against him. I hadn't meant to hurt him."

“It’s good that you did,” Aizawa corrects, gesturing for Midoriya to return to the crowd. “There’s been a major lack of bone breaking in my class, which isn’t nearly realistic enough for me.”

The matches continue, and Midoriya jots down notes as they go. He also writes down to check on Todoroki in the infirmary and apologize.

“Iida versus Shinso,” Aizawa announces, and Midoriya watches as they approach the match.

Size-wise, Iida should win. Though Shinso uses that to his advantage. He’s able to use the top-heavy weight to Iida to keep him off balance, applying pressure and then dodging a swing when Iida gets Shinso to the edge. Iida takes himself out, stumbling out of bounds. A quick match, but still a useful one.

“Bakugou versus Mina.” Another quick match. Mina was a bit too petrified, unsure of herself, and Bakugou has always been good at taking advantage of fear.

It leaves Midoriya to go against Uraraka, a fact that makes him absolutely horrified. This girl was comforting him a week ago, and now he’s got to take her in a fight? Still, the class seems interested, unsure who will win this match.

“Match set,” Aizawa slices his hand down. “Start.”

She’s instant. Kirishima charged, Todoroki lurked, and Uraraka overloaded. She swipes at him in seconds, her other hand coming up the second her left one drops. He’s unsure where to really look, and she uses it to her advantage, landing a harsh blow on his face.

Instinct kicks in, and he takes her next punch in stride, pivoting around her. He grabs the back of her neck, bends her down on his knee, and drives the bone home to her stomach. She's fast, taking the blow before throwing herself down. It changes the dynamic, switches their positions, and she nails him with a kick to the balls and a swoop of her other foot.

The second he’s down, she’s on top of him, swinging again. He had been wrong about her legs; she’s great with them. He takes a few punches to the face before slamming his head forward, mashing his forehead against her nose. Then he flips them, pinning her to the mat as best he can. He grabs her upper arm, pushes it back until her hand touches the grass outside the mat.

He’s declared the winner, which is drowned under his flurry of apologies as he helps her up. She laughs, tells him it was a good match, and skips out of the ring.

This time, Aizawa’s question is different. “Who wants to tell me why that match was different from Midoriya’s first two?”

He really hates this questioning thing. He returns to Sero, who snickers when Midoroya wipes blood off his face as he takes notes.

Yaoyorozu is called on again. “Uraraka took his fighting style into account. She knew that if she overwhelmed him right away, he wouldn’t have time to analyze her tactics. It allowed her

the upper hand.”

“Correct,” Aizawa says, “Now why did Midoriya win?”

Uraraka is the one to answer this. “Pain tolerance and instinct. Izuku didn’t react to any injuries from me or anyone else, indicating he can take high amounts of pain before it begins to affect him. Plus, his instinct from previous fights came into play. He was able to change objectives from fighting for his life, to getting me out of bounds. He knew all he had to do was get one part of me out, rather than a whole, and focused on that while taking the brunt of impacts.”

Aizawa nods again. “And why is this a poor choice?”

Midoriya rolls his eyes when Jiro answers. “Because it doesn’t work in the long run. The body can only withstand so much pain before adrenaline wears out. Or, one of the blows has a Quirk behind it that could kill him. He only knew he could rely on this method because Uraraka couldn’t cause him any permanent damage before he could get her out of bounds.”

“Yes,” Aizawa says, then looks at Midoriya. “It’s an unsustainable method. You hear that, problem child?”

A few snickers, and Midoriya’s embarrassed nod, and they move on to the final rounds.

“Midoroya, since you’ve done three matches instead of two, you can pick who you go against next.” Aizawa gives him a look that seems, funny enough, apologetic. “Two fighters remain. Bakugou or Shinso.”

Fucking fantastic.

Midoriya gives Aizawa-Sensei a flat look, and he gives him a ‘life is unfair’ look in return.

Midoriya thinks about it, and he’s not too sure who the hell to choose. He’s beaten Bakugou before, but that was almost a year ago. Plus, it wasn’t exactly under mint conditions or preplanned. Though the violence in him is dying to get its hands on Bakugou again, he’s not sure fighting in rage is a good way to go. He nearly killed him last time.

Then again, Shinso isn’t his top choice either. Midoriya had trained him; they’ve brawled and battled several times before. Midoriya’s always won those, but Shinso’s gotten damn close. And with months of Hero courses that Midoriya doesn’t have, he wouldn’t be surprised if Shinso has developed the same advanced skills that Bakugou likely has.

Shit.

He hopes he’s making the right call here. “Shinso.”

They meet on the mat. This is the first time looking him in the eye in months. His face is perfectly blank, his eyes deceptively round. Midoriya doesn’t trust it, unsure how to go about the peculiar way he looks at him. He can’t read what emotion on his old friend's face.

“Match set.” Aizawa jerks his hand down. “Start.”

They circle immediately. It’s seriously been so long. He knows Shinso feels guilty for what he did, finally working up the courage to sort through the messages and voicemails left for him. It consisted of a few apologies, a promise to give Midoriya as much space and time as he needed, and cat photos filled with thank yous.

Which means that… maybe…

Midoriya’s a crybaby, always has been, always will be. But what many people don’t know is that he can do it on command. So when tears prick his eyes, and his shoulders hitch, Shinso’s carefully blank mask breaks, cracks with concern and worry.

Midoriya moves quickly. A blow to the jaw, a shove to the chest. Shinso pushes him right back, and Midoriya grabs his arm, bends his knees, and throws Shinso over his shoulder. His spine hits the floor outside the mat, breath knocked from his lungs. For a moment, the two of them stare at each other. Shinso on the floor, Midoriya peering down at him.

Then he smiles, wicked, wide, and Shinso swallows harshly at the sight of it.

“Again,” Aizawa-Sensei says, “Why did Midoriya win that match?”

Midoriya heads back to his spot by Sero, who pats him on the back and congratulates him. He takes down a few notes, ignoring the eyes boring into him.

Bakugou answers. “Because he used a past history against him. He knew what would weaken his opponent, and he took advantage of it.”

Midoriya grits his teeth when Aizawa tells Bakugou he’s right. He’s given a small water break before the next round, since he’s done four fights now against Bakugou’s two. Either way, he doesn't doubt this final battle will be brutal, harsh.

When he steps into the mat, Bakugou’s got his eyes narrowed and pinned on him. He’s ready, antsy, and Midoriya can see that he’s been in need of a good fight. Maybe screwing over Midoriya wasn’t as fulfilling a he hoped? Or perhaps seeing him at UA, after insisting he’d never make it, irks Bakugou.

Either way, Midoriya can see the tension on Bakugou’s shoulders. The need to win, to fight. To release pressure before he explodes, before he pops. He’s frustrated, he’s on edge.

“Match set.” Aizawa looks between them, his hand in the air. With a sigh, he slices his palm down. “Start.”

Bakugou charges immediately, a swing ready—

And Midoriya steps back, off the mat. Match over. Bakugou wins. There’s confusion, questions shot out, but Midoriya can’t help the small smile on his lips. There is nothing more diminishing to Bakugou than an unearned victory. And he can see the sparks of anger flaring up on the bastard’s palms.

Oh well.

“Fight me,” Bakugou grinds out. “What the fuck was that?”

“I stepped out of bounds,” Midoriya says calmly, hands in his pockets. “Whoops.”

Bakugou’s eye twitches, and he inches forward. Aizawa puts a hand on his shoulder to stop his war path, and Midoriya hums and moves on. This will keep Bakugou awake at night while Midoriya sleeps peacefully, knowing he’s pissed him off. Who cares about a bracket? As far as he’s concerned, he won four times in a row; who needs another?

“For the remainder of class,” Aizawa announces. “We will be doing five-minute partner rotations. Find your first pairing, fight until the time is up, then move to the next. We’ve got an even number of kids now, so nobody should be missing a partner.”

Bakugou zeros in on him, but Midoriya turns to find someone else. It’s not hard, as several students immediately rush for him, pleading to work with him. He’s really not used to this amount of attention, and he’s truly embarrassed by it. Still, he does his best to agree to them all, working through five-minute rotations with each pairing. His favorite is Yaoyorozu, who just needs a bit more confidence. When she lands a nasty right hook on him, she’s just as shocked as he is, and she doesn’t seem so sad when she loses against him in the end. His least favorite was probably Kaminari, who almost won just because he kept making weird noises that made Midoriya laugh and lose focus.

And, when the time came for him to pair up with Bakugou or Shinso, he simply repeated an old partner. People were eager to spar with him, and he used it to his advantage. He feels only slightly bad, mainly because another match against Iida leaves them both winded.

When it comes to the last rotation, he picks Uraraka again, who absolutely hands him his ass. After a day of winning, he’s not at all upset when she tackles him out of bounds, effectively winning the match and sending them rolling on the grass. She cheers when she stands up, flexing, and Midoriya can’t help the stupid smile on his face.

“Good match,” she says, extending a hand to him. Memories of Bakugou flicker to life, and he blinks them away as he takes her hand. She hoists him up, her small form hiding the sheer amount of strength and muscle she has. A sleeper build if he’s ever seen one.

“You whooped me,” he confesses, rubbing his cheek where she hit him. “You should teach me how you fight like that. You’re so quick.”

“Oh!” She clasps her hands together. “I’d love to. But only if you’ll teach me how you get such a good read on opponents. I’m awful at it.”

“You got it,” he says, scratching the back of his head. “I’ll teach you everything I know.”

“Yay!” she cheers, bouncing up and down. “This is so exciting! I never have anyone who will spar with me after classes.”

“Well, you do now—“

“Deku.”

Mother. Fucker.

He turns, meets Bakugou's narrow-eyed glare. "Yes?"

Bakugou looks at Uraraka, clicks his tongue, then looks back at Midoriya. "Let's talk."

"Maybe later," Midoriya says, but Uraraka waves goodbye and heads toward the group huddled around Aizawa-Sensei.

Midoriya tries to follow, but Bakugou grabs his wrist. "Akatani—"

Sparks, fire, Midoriya shoves him off, leveling him with a wicked glare. "Don't call me that, you don't get to fucking call me that."

Bakugou stumbles back. When he catches his footing, he shoves Midoriya right back. "That's your damn name. Isn't it?"

"No," he says, "It's Izuku or Midoriya. I'd take Deku, but don't you ever call me that name again."

Bakugou's eyebrows wobble, furrowing in. He breathes deep through his nose, gaze dark and angry. "So that's it, huh? You're back to being pissed at me?"

"I never stopped," Midoriya snaps, retreating. "I'm done with you. I have no need for you. You're a liar and awful human being, I'll never forgive you for the shit you put me through."

"In the woods—"

"*Nothing* happened in the woods," he interrupts, eyes wild and wide. He keeps his voice low, backs Bakugou up as much as he can. If students overhear this, he can kiss his first impressions goodbye. "Nothing happened."

"That's not fucking true," Bakugou shoves him back, his hands shaking. "We almost—you and I—"

"Just drop it," Midoriya hisses. Panic sets in.

Bakugou doesn't; he never knows when to leave things alone. "We almost kissed."

Panic seizes Midoriya. It was a moment of weakness in the forest. It was childhood memories influencing his mind. He was exhausted after escaping Pros. His friends had died. He had just said goodbye to Mama. It was the heat of a moment that was never promised to them. Any logical explanation he can pull, he does. It was a full moon, the rain impaired his vision, he was cold and just wanted to be warm again.

He says, his voice absolute. "I'm not gay."

Bakugou freezes, his eyes wide. "That's not—I never said that—neither am I. I just—"

“Nothing. Happened.” Midoriya meets his eyes, trying to hammer this into Bakugou’s head, trying to change his perception of what happened. “It meant nothing.”

“Children.” A scarf wraps gently around Midoriya’s waist, tugging him away from Bakugou. He hadn’t realized how close the two of them were standing, and heat rushes to his face as he looks away. “Class was dismissed five minutes ago. Why are the two of you…”

Bakugou stalks off mind conversation. He damn near runs. His hands are stuffed in his pockets, his head down, and he retreats silently to the locker room to change back into his regular clothes. Midoriya doesn’t look at him a moment longer, mumbling an apology to Aizawa-Sensei before moving away as well. They don’t look at each other when they change clothes, not a single word is shared between them.

Midoriya takes a moment, when the locker room finally empties, to collect himself. He’s not sure why Bakugou keeps bringing these strong emotions out of him. Every conversation they have sends him spiraling for hours after, leaving him shaken and confused. He plans and accounts for everything—but he can never seem to be ready for any interaction with Bakugou. It’s not fair, it’s not fair at all.

It was just a moment of weakness. He just wanted comfort after what was arguably the worst night of his life. He just wanted to reconnect with the childhood friend he had, the memories they created. It had seemed so genuine, so honest. That’s all. It means nothing; it changes nothing. Bakugou has made a fool out of him too many times; he won’t allow this moment to be another chance for him to be ruined again. He’s got a good thing going at UA. Maybe it’s not what he imagined, but it’s *something.*

When he makes it back to his room, there’s a small Tupperware container sitting on the floor outside his door. The note on it reads,

“Izuku, I started cooking over in the teachers' dorms! They all love my food, and it makes me feel better about staying at the school. I’ll drop off dinner for you every day. I have to keep you fed and strong!

-Mama

P.S., before you tried to run away, I stole your phone from your pocket. I had planned to call Katsuki or someone to come get you, but your phone must’ve broken because it seemed completely different than what I remember. Anyway, I hope you can fix it. I love you!”

His… phone?

He takes the Tupperware, and hidden below it is the burner phone he had stashed in his pockets for when he was chased by Pros out of his apartment. He had thought it fell out when he made it to the river to think. He had intended to call Tenko, but when he patted his pockets and could only find his regular phone, he started to plan something else.

But this… this is the best thing that could’ve happened. No officers could seize it when they brought him in, like they did his gear and belongings. All Might let him keep his phone, so

long as it could first be searched completely by Heroes. When it was done, it was given back to him without second thought. They have no idea he's still got contact with the league.

Thank you, Mama.

Midoriya seals himself inside his room. Normally, he wouldn't contact Tenko anywhere that could lead to his location, but this isn't exactly the best of circumstances to be under. The phone should be completely secured if his original coding and VPN are held, but to be honest, he's not thinking very clearly at the moment. He can't help the slow trickle of rage coming back in, mixed with absolute glee as he sees the few messed calls and messages from his big brother.

Midoriya is going to kill him.

He's thought it all out, planned the death in detail. He's never laid out a murder scheme before, but he does now. Tenko Shimura is going to die for what he did, and Midoriya is going to be the one to do it.

So he unlocks the phone, giggling at the messages.

Tenko: I need information about another Pro.

Tenko: Answer the phone.

Tenko: Where the hell are you? Why aren't you answering?

Tenko: Whatever you want to know about Dad, I'll tell you. I just need all the information you have on a Hero.

Midoriya types, smiling wide.

Viridant: I don't want information on Dad, I want information on you. I'll give you the data, but I want to meet in person, talk about life.

The response is instant.

Tenko: I'm not coming anywhere near you, freakshow.

Viridant: Then I guess you can figure out your information on your own.

Bubbles, and Midoriya would say they looked angry.

Tenko: Fine. But I won't be alone.

Viridant: Works for me :)

Tenko: Every single thing you've got on Eraser Head, I want it.

His smile wavers, but that rush in his head is relentless. He feels guilty, sure, but not guilty enough.

Viridant: When can we meet?

The following message is an address, a date, and a time. Midoriya's blood thrums, and the image of his dead friends invokes a raw sort of instinct. He can't help the complete elation coursing through him.

He just needs to find a way out of this school.

***

Shinso knocks on the dorm door. He can't believe he's actually doing this. It took ages to work up the courage, days spent talking to Miss Baby to hype him up enough to approach. He's not too certain why the hell he's doing this at all, but after today, after seeing Midoriya's awful grin when he had nearly broken his back…

He's got to do this.

He knocks again, impatient. The door remains shut. He pounds on it. Finally, it's swung open, and Shinso comes face-to-face with pure anger.

"What the fuck do you want?" Bakugou growls out.

He looks awful, his hair is damp, mused and pulled at. He's already in pajamas, but it's six at night. His skin is red and raw, and Shinso can make out the patterns of what seems to be cloth. He must've taken a shower and scrubbed himself completely clean over and over again. Weirdo.

"Let me in," he says. He's gotten better at wording his questions as demands, saving whoever he's talking to from losing their mind. Literally. "We need to talk."

Bakugou laughs in his face, the sound breathy, manic. "Not the day for this riveting fucking conversation. Go find someone else to provoke."

Shinso shoves past him and into the room. "We need to talk about Midoriya."

"I will drag you out of here by your fucking ankles," Bakugou seethes, and he seems to be trembling. "Get. Out."

"You're more amped up than usual." Shinso looks around the dorm. He had expected holes punched into the walls or clothes strewn about. But the space is perfectly clean, the walls lined with All Might and band posters. There's a small shelf holding manga, and a lot of

crystals adorning the space. He hadn't thought that Bakugou would believe in things like that, but it weirdly suits him.

He eyes a green and orange nightlight plugged into the wall, deciding not to comment on it.

"What did you two talk about today?" Shinso asks, sitting on Bakugou's green and black bed. "He looked mad."

"Nothing," Bakugou says immediately. "Fucking nothing."

"You spent five minutes shoving each other and talking about nothing?" Shinso gives him a bored look. "I don't buy it."

"Get out." Bakugou shakes his head. "I can't fucking do this right now. Just get the hell out."

"He's… he's different," Shinso says instead of leaving.

He's certain Bakugou might try to pummel him, but the blonde lets out a pained sigh and plops down into his desk chair instead. He puts his elbows on the wooden desk, holds his head in his hands. Shinso sees that there's a small notebook in front of him. Maybe he was studying? Is he frustrated that he can't understand some kind of math problem or something?

"He's the same as he's always been," Bakugou says, his voice a low rumble. "His hidden parts have come to the surface; the more present traits from months ago have been buried."

"He's acting like an insane person," Shinso argues.

"He *is* insane," Bakugou informs him. "If you didn't see it before—then that sucks for you. He lost it years ago. He's just better at hiding it from some people. Why the hell do you care now?"

"Why?" Shinso asks. "What happened to him?"

"What the hell didn't?" Bakugou turns a page in the notebook, reading the next few lines of sprawling text. "His dad used to beat the shit out of his mom. That's how he and I met—they were running away from the guy. He's some kind of psycho; they had to change their whole identities to make sure he wouldn't hunt them down and slaughter them."

"Jesus fucking Christ," Shinso lies on the bed, his legs dangling off the edge. It's weirdly comfortable, the memory foam an unexpected sensation. He had thought Bakugou's bed would be stiff and hard, but this is more like a cloud than anything.

"He's Quirkless, spent his life trying to survive. His friends just died. He's a vigilante. He's seen more corpses than any reasonable human should. I could go for fucking weeks," Bakugou says gruffly, "He's analytical, cynical. The second you cross him, he can detach from reality and murder you if he wants. Emotions aren't permanent for him; they come and go, and if they don't benefit him, then he finds a way to eliminate the stimulus that causes discomfort. Whether it's finding the best possible route to run from class to avoid people, or fighting a villain, he endures as much as he allows, then he dismantles the issue."

“You make it sound like he’s some kind of threat,” Shinso says quietly.

“He *is* a threat.” Bakugou finally looks up at him. “If you aren’t his friend, or someone who doesn’t pose some sort of negative influence on his life, then he will find a way to eliminate you from his day-to-day. Haven’t you noticed the way he doesn’t even look at us? When he does—it’s like he sees right through us, isn’t it?”

Shinso smooths his hands over the sheets. They smell like caramel and are unbearably soft. He might need to steal Bakugou’s bedding, because this actually makes him want to sleep.

“Does he want us dead?” Shinso says in a whisper. “I’m a little put off.”

Bakugou snorts. “If he wanted us dead, then we’d be dead. You’ll know when the thought crosses his mind.”

“And this is just something we’re supposed to ignore?” Shinso sits up, suddenly angry. “I want to be his friend. I don’t want to lose him, and I don’t want him to lose himself even more.”

“Look.” Bakugou spins around in his desk chair, and Shinso suddenly sees how exhausted he is. Bloodshot eyes, skin pulling down on his face. “His mind is a fucking enigma. There’s a chance you two can be all buddy-buddy again, but you have to meet very specific, unpredictable criteria. He’s weirdly forgiving, but only if you know the right way to apologize. You can give it your best shot, but if you don’t nail a conversation with him in a perfect way, then he will wake up the next day and decide nothing between you ever fucking mattered!” Bakugou throws the nearest object on his desk, which is a pencil.

It embeds itself in the wall, and Shinso purses his lips while staring at it.

Bakugou pants, head in his hands. “Get out. Just leave me alone.”

“What happened today?” Shinso asks instead. “I’m guessing something occurred between you two that led to his capture? Something bad."

Bakugou glares. “It doesn’t matter.”

“Is that what he told you?” He rests his elbows on his knees, holding his face in his palms. “You know he tends to lie to himself about things that he wants to avoid.”

“Fuck you, I know that.”

“Bakugou,” Shinso gives him an unimpressed look. “*Everything* matters to him. If he told you that something is unimportant or irrelevant—it means it’s affecting him so much that he’s trying to cut it out. It’s just like you said, he eliminates emotions he doesn’t want to feel.”

Bakugou licks his teeth. “You don’t know anything.”

“He had a crush on Ground Zero,” Shinso confesses, and Bakugou goes shock still. “You wanna know why? You’re gonna love it.”

Bakugou narrows his eyes. “Enlighten me.”

“He liked his voice,” Shinso says, carefully watching the way the idiot looks away, back to the notebook. “Said it reminded him of someone and calmed him. He said he could fall asleep to the sound.”

“You’re lying.”

“I’m literally not,” Shinso snaps. “And I’m being nice to you, so fuck you.”

“Fuck you.”

“Fuck you!”

Bakugou doesn’t look at him. “I don’t fucking care how he feels about who.”

Shinso rolls his eyes. “I don’t care if you're gay, dude, it’s the most obvious thing in the world.

“No, it isn’t,” Bakugou shouts at him. “And I’m not fucking gay! That’s disgusting.”

Shinso blinks slowly. “*I’m* gay.”

Bakugou clicks his tongue. “Obviously.”

“The fuck you mean ‘obviously?’” Shinso seethes. “That’s a damn secret, you know. Nobody knows that!”

“Trust me, everyone knows that,” Bakugou says, sassy as ever. “Have you even looked in a mirror?”

“You can’t be serious right now!” Shinso stands, scoffs. “I’m being beyond nice to you, and you’re telling me I *look* gay!”

Bakugou thinks for a moment before he says, “Yes.”

“You’re an asshole.”

“You’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

Shinso storms to the door, rips it open. “Have fun rotting away in your own misery, dickhead. Don’t say I never fucking tried.”

He steps out, but Bakugou calls out to him, telling him to wait. Shinso does, only because he truly sounds pathetic. He turns, and Bakugou bounces his leg up and down.

“Go through his mom,” Bakugou says, gaze turned to his feet. “If she likes you, which she for some reason does, then you’ve got an automatic in with Deku. She’ll fix any broken bond in seconds, alright? Just tell her the truth.”

Shinso huffs out air. He steps into the hall, murmurs and thanks, and nearly shuts the door. For some reason, he can't seem to walk away, so he opens it back up again.

"He doesn't want to waste time on relationships, alright? He's absolutely horrified by the idea of being betrayed or made fun of. I'm not sure what happened the day he got captured, but you probably said or did something stupid to turn him away from you now." Shinso watches something bloom in Bakugou's eyes, dots connecting in the idiot's head. "It won't help, since you're definitely not gay, but I looked through the camera footage of his helmet, and he would always check on you at night while you slept. He knows where I live, and he has never once come to make sure I was nice and cozy."

Bakugou says nothing, peering at the notebook again. "Whatever."

"Bakugou," Shinso says, and he turns to glare. "Don't fuck this up."

Bakugou grunts out, "I'm not planning on it."

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 41: Brawl

Chapter Summary

Midoriya sets out to kill his brother.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya pushes open the support courses room door. The lab is empty on the weekend, giving him ample time to explore it. He was careful to run all around campus today, taking in every inch of it to appear on camera as though he was exploring. In reality, he's gathering intel for a possible escape. He wants to do this subtly, find an exit that allows him to go unnoticed in and out.

And it requires his gear.

He's uncertain where his vigilante supplies ended up. He knows it wasn't destroyed, and it's not at the police station. He knows UA must have it. Aizawa-Sensei had mentioned giving Midoriya his suit and headgear back as part of a Hero costume, but with how long it's taking, there's no doubt that they're studying it and trying to replicate it without his regular tech involved.

Midoriya carefully looks through the room. He's searching for Melissa's final project from last year. She had turned in a full set of Viridant gear for a grade, and if he can find that suit, then he can alter it to act close to his old one. It won't raise any alarms with the Pros who have access to his actual outfit.

He tries to be discreet, wandering around the shop as though he's just intrigued by it. He's not sure where they'd keep it—

"Midoriya."

He jumps, turns. "M-Melissa! Hey."

She pushes her glasses up on her nose, giving him a curious look. "I was wondering how long it would take before you came to say hi to me."

"I should've come sooner." He waves his hands in front of him. "I'm sorry."

Melissa shrugs, peering at the support course room. "Are you here to steal another scarf?"

"No!" he says, though he did check the hooks on the wall for any. "I'm just trying to look around at what the school has to offer. That's all."

She giggles. “I was just teasing you.” She enters the room, sits on top of an empty table. “How’s life at UA? I can’t believe you got caught.”

It didn’t take much time for Melissa to uncover who he was. You can only ask someone to guide you through sensor placement on a suit so many times before they get suspicious. He’s not entirely sure at what point during their many hour-long calls that she figured it out, but she hadn’t mentioned it until closer to the end of his vigilante career. Even then, she had still helped him massively with improving his gear.

And, in return, he’s done his best to help her with Rody. Kaminari might’ve been onto something with this whole love guru thing, because Melissa and Rody are happily together, coming up on a few months now. It all works out, he supposes.

“It’s… It’s fine,” he says, stuffing his hands into his pockets and leaning against one of the metal shelving units. “Just finished my first two weeks. I thought there’d be a lot to catch up on, but I’m pretty evenly paced.”

“Hmm,” she wipes a finger through some sawdust, her pink glasses catching in the light. “You’ve hung up your gear then, huh?”

Midoriya shrugs. “Not much of a choice.”

“Well, that’s good,” Melissa says with a smile. “I was worried you came in here searching for my prototype or something. Which would’ve been a waste of your time considering it’s kept locked in a storage room alongside other students' Hero outfits.” She reaches into the top drawer of the work table, pulls out a set of keys. “Funny enough, my professor left these keys to that storage closet in this drawer.”

Midoriya can’t help the twitch of his lips. “What a coincidence.”

“Isn’t it?” She twirls them around her finger before tossing them to him. “I took the cameras out this morning with Hatsume. She was all too eager to see if her new ‘baby’ could intercept electrical signals.”

He catches the keys, shoves them into his pocket. “Why help me?”

“Because I get it. They took away the little bit of security and power you had reclaimed for yourself. While I don’t necessarily agree with your practice, I can’t help but feel sorry for you,” Melissa says, offering a small smile. “The roof of the school has less security than the ground. If you can get to the top, then you can swing out and over the walls. The sensors are usually active… but I guess Hatsume’s device reduced their power. So weird.”

“Bizarre.”

“Crazy.”

Midoriya chuckles, heading for the door. “Thank you.”

“Thank you for treating me like a human,” she says back, kicking him lightly with her foot. “Go save the day, Viridant.”

He takes off running. With the cameras down—or at least the important ones down, he moves quickly. UA is a large school, but it's laid out pretty easily. Its four-tier formation allows different year level students to take each corner of the building. And, far left, is the first years. Classes, changing rooms, storage lockers, all of those rooms are stored in that back left pillar. Since he's already there, it's relatively easy to pin down the closet.

The keyring is full of keys, so he tries a bunch of them before he finally gets the door open. The room itself is small and condensed. There's different-sized lockers in here with glowing numbers on each one. There are letters A through C before each number, which happens to correspond to the number of first-year students in each class. He quickly finds his number, shoves another key into the lock, and pulls it open.

He's never seen this before, never even heard of it. But it seems the Support Course designs and makes all Hero suits come to life based on submitted criteria and measurements from the students. So Midoriya pulls out a flawless suit, made of a new and resistant material. Melissa outdid herself with it. The design is relatively the same, but the green is much darker, nearly black. She even custom-made him shoes for his feet, down to the size and shape alterations.

She's got an insane eye for detail. The entire suit is lined with sensors and excess padding to keep his body safe. His favorite addition has to be the built-in knee guards, or maybe the rubber padding on his gloves to allow him a better grip when climbing. He shuts the briefcase after taking the gear and double-checks that a new scarf has been added. It's a dark green, with streaks of black running through it. He'll miss his old support weapon, but this'll do for now. He slides the briefcase back into its spot, sealing away the evidence that he stole from it.

And when he's about to leave, he pauses before the door. He looks at the keyring, nibbles his lip. Technically, he has unlimited access to *every* costume for the first-years.

So…

He starts unlocking lockers. He won't take anything too obvious, but even little details matter in this situation. He hasn't seen too many of the students in their costumes, as Heroics class tried to keep them in their regular training clothes as much as possible. So he takes time to learn, to see what designs people had. From Todoroki's locker, he steals a small metal container of a healing liquid. He takes a grande from Bakugou. It's a little too easy.

And when it's done, he finds his way to the roof. There are more of those little security bots roaming around. He also sees a camera, though it's slumped and pointed at the floor. Melissa really did follow through. The camera system is totally down. Easier for him.

Only when he's found a spot away from the security bots and out of view from the camera does he change clothes. He stuffs his uniform into his bag, the fabric resting against the small Manila folder of information on Eraser. For a moment, he stares at that folder. This is truly revealing information; so much privacy is invaded by just carrying it around.

But if all goes well, then his brother won't ever touch this folder.

Midoriya takes a moment to look over his new suit. It's secure, and in the cold winter, the sensors immediately detect the low body temperature and begin to warm. His helmet is much

sturdier, less bulky, with the mask attached. A quick knock on the side of it, and he sees that Melissa even added his AI back into it. She must've altered it when she got her hands on his own costume, ensuring he had access to the same benefits as before. He spends a few minutes connecting the robot to his phone, and when the robotic voice welcomes him back, he feels like he can do anything.

He avoids the bots, launching out his new support scarf, and jumps off the roof. The suit is flawless, and the wind pressure feels like nearly nothing. He avoids laughing or whooping until he clears the large front gates and soars off the cliff. He dives into the city below, and the joy bubbles out of him. He's missed this, missed the freedom, the feeling of flying.

He's missed *himself.* The calling in his heart, the one All Might mentioned, it glows and throbs within him. He flies through the air and feels these parts of him that had been previously buried come back to life. The rage is still there, the grief, but it's impossible to deny the elation coursing through his blood. He's human again, and he missed the feeling of being alive.

He stops several crimes on his way over. The new AI is easy to work with, sending anonymous tips to police stations about petty theft or assault. He handles each case on his own, knocking out the assailants or abusers, but he doesn't tie them up. He can't let this get back to Eraser Head, and he promised he'd be much more careful this time, didn't he?

It takes a few hours to land at the new base of operations for the league. While he doubts this is truly where they've stationed themselves, he won't deny that it's peculiar enough not to raise any alarms. Instead of going East, the league relocated closer to Musutafu by going South-East. The warehouse he comes to is a few miles from Osaka in a town called Nara. It's not run down or anything; in fact, this place seems pretty well upkept.

The warehouse itself isn't particularly off-putting. It just seems like a regular storage facility. He scouts it out first, places zero members of the league outside. They must all be hiding within, which isn't nearly as helpful as if they had been dispersed.

"Rin," he says quietly, crawling up the side of a neighboring house. "Activate infrared."

"Infared activated," she confirms, and his vision flickers in his goggles.

He crawls along the paneling of the neighboring building, his support weapon helping balance his weight with an overhead chimney. His gloves find purchase in the slivers of bricks, the rubber keeping him latched comfortably. Midoriya pushes slightly off the side of the building, getting a better view into the warehouse window. He carefully peers through the smudged and dusty glass. It's dark inside, but he can make out at least three forms. The infrared confirms it: two regular heat signatures and a third that burns hotter than the others.

Dabi, leaning against stacks of boxes. Further down is Twice, who drums his fingers against his bicep impatiently. Himiko and the others aren't in sight, likely being kept far removed from these negotiations. He's certain that Himiko would be here if she could be.

Which makes this only easier for him. "

He grins, drops into the alley. A quick turn of the dial on his mask has his voice changing, altering, and he speaks loudly in a tone that isn't his own.

"I knew you'd come!" Himiko's voice, loud and clear. "Follow me, cutie. I'll lead you to them!"

He takes off down another path, doing his best impression of Himiko's giggles. It takes no time for the air to heat, warm, and he leads Dabi as far away as possible before circling back to the warehouse. Twice didn't leave, but he patrols around the front doors now, keeping an eye out for Midoriya.

It's easy to look through that window again. His brother is alone now, his artist's gloves on. He plays on a colorful handheld device, something Midoriya has seen sitting on shelves inside stores before. Did he steal that? Or did daddy buy him the newest gaming console? Was that before or after he slaughtered Midoroya's friends?

Slowly, he pushes open the window. Rage slams against his ribs, pulses within his core. He's spent too long holding it down, resisting the urge to break or bend. But it's here now, crawling along his skin like bugs. Silently, he sends his support weapon to the rafters, then lowers himself to the ground. Tenko looks up from his device, eyes slitted.

Viridant wastes no time. His scarf shoots out, grabs the handles of the front door, and wraps tightly around them. He doesn't need it anyway. Everything he plans to do to his brother, he's going to do with his bare hands.

"You lead the other two away," Tenko says, voice bored. "Clever. But they'll be back."

"Not in enough time," Viridant replies coolly. He drops his backpack on top of one of the boxes.

Tenko eyes it, then eyes him. "You aren't here for an information trade, are you, little brother?"

Viridant rolls his shoulders. "I'll get plenty of information out of you."

Tenko sets his game down, moves away from its place. He puts his back to the door, not that he could escape with the support weapon wrapped around it. Technically, he could just grab it and disintegrate the material, but there's no way he could reach the doors before Viridant caught him.

He seems to know this, too, his usually hidden eyes narrowing on him. "What the hell are you doing? Trying to capture me?"

"I don't have any interest in capturing you," Viridant tells him, slowly approaching. "I think you're well aware of what I'm going to do to you."

"And eye for an eye, then? You're mad I broke a few bones? Get used to it." Tenko circles him, that stupid hand still clinging to his face. "You make this mistake and you lose all access to Dad."

“I’ll manage.” He lurches forward, swings, and that hand goes flying from his brother’s face.

His brother isn’t some helpless idiot; he’s had years with Dad, he knows how to fight. Tenko swings back, and Viridant ducks below his arm and grabs it. His fight with Todorki flickers to memory, and he moves to break the limb, but Tenko is already a step ahead. He knocks Viridant’s kegs out from under him, and when he hits the floor, he drags his brother down with him.

“You made a new suit just to fight me?” Tenko asks, his chapped lips splitting into a grin. “I’m honored.”

Viridant hits him in the stomach. “You won’t be.”

They wrestle over each other, throwing the other down and delivering harsh punches. Viridant isn’t sure if it's his new gear or the adrenaline in his veins that keeps the pain at bay. He keeps thinking about how much agony his friends must’ve endured, and suddenly, every blow he takes doesn’t hurt at all. He bashes Tenko’s teeth in, grunts when a fist is jammed into his side. And when Tenko tries to rip his gloves off, tries to melt Viridan’t body, he pins his wrist down.

One of Viridan’t hands holds Tenko's left arm down, and the other wraps around his throat, squeezing. Tenko grits his teeth, eyes watering, and shoves at his face with his free hand. His lower mask breaks off, falls to the floor. Those artist gloves remain intact, preventing Tenko from killing him. But he’s begun to enjoy the way Tenko’s face loses color, and his damn assault on his face is giving him too much leeway. Tenko shoves on Viridan’t face, tries to shove him off, and Viridant drops his chin and opens his jaw. And when his brother pushes against his face again, Viridant catches his fingers between his teeth.

And bites.

Tenko screams, legs kicking, and Viridant keeps forcing his jaw to close. Tearing, ripping, until Tenko reels his arm away with two of his fingers missing. Viridant spits them out, the blood spattering on his brother's face. The doors shake, someone throwing themselves against them, but they hold strong.

Tenko flips them, kicks VIridant’s stomach before standing and retreating. He cradles his right hand, those missing fingers spouting blood. It pours down his arm, drips onto the concrete floor.

Viridant pants, crouches before him, planning the next attack, turning into the animal that seems to roam through his blood. Tenko is quick-witted, intelligent. He’s not an easy opponent to kill. Then again, Viridant hasn’t really been trying to kill him yet. He hasn’t endured enough torture, enough pain. He wants to rip his eyes out next, or maybe take one of those severed hands his brother loves so much and strangle him with it. It’s hard to decide.

“Why do you ruin *everything?*” Tenko screams, his eyes nearly glowing with rage. “I did you a fucking favor, and this is how you repay me!”

Someone shouts outside, slams against the door. It doesn’t budge.

His mouth tastes like blood as he answers. “You killed my friends. You sent Dad to kill me, told him the name I gave you.”

Tenko breathes heavily, eyes wild. “You gave me a real name?!”

Viridant tilts his head, circles. “Don’t act like you didn’t know.”

“I fucking didn’t!” He grinds out, ripping his other glove off with his teeth. “I thought you had lied, given me a fake name. I told Dad because I thought I was sending him on a fucking pointless tirade. How the hell would I have known you gave me real names?”

Viridant grins at him. “I’m going to kill you. You know that, don’t you, Tenko?”

Tenko’s eyes flash. “Then come fucking kill me.”

So he does. He reaches behind him, grabs that gaming device, and throws it at his brother's head. He rushes in after, slamming against the idiot's chest when he dissolves the electronic before it ever touches him. Viridant is careful of his now free hand, and when it nicks his arm, a small portion of his costume’s fabric melts away. The second the contact is lost, the disintegration stops. It barely touches Viridant’s skin, leaving a small patch of red behind.

He grunts when Tenko punches him with his bad hand, his three remaining fingers enough to land a nasty blow. He brings his intact hand down, and Viridan uses both his hands to grab his brother's wrist. His palm is inches from his throat, and he had underestimated how strong Tenko is.

“That rage you feel? The anger in your blood?” Tenko uses his bloody hand to push his palm closer to Viridan’t neck. “Isn’t it just awful? Doesn’t it drive you insane? Knowing it's never going to go away, that it can only be fed with violence?”

Viridant grinds his teeth. “He killed them. He tortured them, gave one of them a Quirk that was killing her.”

Tenko laughs at him and lays his hand on Viridan’t throat. It gives him the upper hand to throw his brother's weight off, send him sprawling on the floor, but the disintegration has already begun. He grasps the stolen healing solution from Todroki’s briefcase, popping the lid and dumping it on his exposed throat. Pain soars through him, blood bubbling from the wound, but it seals shut a moment later.

Viridant coughs up blood, his airway clearing of it as the wound stitches itself back together again. He throws himself over Tenko, blood pouring from his lips as he swings again and again and again. When that hand again comes for him, he grabs Tenko’s wrist, bends it backward until it snaps. He keeps going, grinning as bone breaks through the skin of his brother's wrist. Tenko screams, and the sound unleashes something inside of him.

Fire blasts at the door, the wood catching immediately. The door melts away, and Dabi steps through the flame, several versions of twice hot on his heels.

“I’ll kill you,” Viridant promises Tenko. “And when I’m done with you, I’ll rip Dad apart next.”

He grabs Bakugou’s grenade from his belt, pulls the pin with his teeth, and throws it at the villains who have entered the room. It holds true, detonating using the collected nitroglycerin from Bakugou’s palms. The explosion rattles the warehouse, smoke filling the room from both the bomb and Dabi’s fire. It spreads quickly, catching boxes and wooden beams, hiding the two of them within the smoke.

Viridant reels his arm back, punches Tenko. Again, again, again, again. Blood flies, and he can’t seem to stop himself. The violence takes control of him, splits his knuckles open, destroys Tenko’s face. It’s all he wanted—to kill him. To feel as the life drained from Tenko’s body as it had from Ito, from Banri, from Sayori.

“Stop,” Tenko says, throat clogged, “Wait.”

Viridant does for only a moment, grasping his brother’s face in either hand. He levels his thumb with Tenko’s eye socket, readies to dig it in and yank the cords loose. There is no skin on his brother’s face that isn’t covered with crimson, his eyes swollen, his nose sideways.

But Tenko coughs out blood, his body shaking. “Dabi, no!”

The AI couldn’t detect the heat signature behind him due to the flames surrounding the warehouse. Still, Dabi keeps a palm outstretched, blue flame searing the hair off Viridant’s neck.

“Don’t kill him,” Tenko gasps out, and Dabi doesn’t seem too convinced. “Just wait.”

“You want a dying monologue?” Viridant asks, his hands trembling.

Tenko snarls, his eyes hard. “We want the same thing.”

“I doubt that.”

“I’m going to kill Dad,” Tenko says darkly, his red eyes boring into Viridant. “That underground city—those people. He killed them as a message to me—to tell me saving those lives was wrong. He was,” Tenko grunts, chokes on his saliva. “He was angry. He wants me—wants me to be like Yoichi.”

Yoichi. Dad’s brother.

“What?’

“My Quirk—“ Tenko gasps out. “He gave me this—tried to tell me I was Quirkless before this—”

“You’re shoes—”

“He altered my foot,” Tenko rasps, his gaze hateful. “He wanted me to feel grateful for the decay Quirk, told me—told me I was Quirkless. But it’s not true. I-I had a Qurik.”

Viridant breathes heavily, crimson dripping off his lips. “What was it?”

Tenko says, his body trembling. “Float. I was born to fly. And he—he took that from me. He took *everything* from me.” Tenko coughs, his heart beating wildly. “I had—I had a sister. I had a dog, a mom—I had a life—I was *someone.”* He trembles, his ruined face hard to look at. “Everything I do—it’s a show. He can’t know that—that I figured him out. He’ll kill me—he’ll kill *us.*”

Viridant’s eyes water. “He murdered my friends. All those people in the city.”

“If you don't stop,” Tenko says, his voice ruined. “If you kill me, he’ll murder so many more.” Tenko lifts his ruined hand, lays it on Viridant’s arm. “We have the same goal—I hadn't known until now. I didn’t mean—for your friends, I never wanted them to die.”

Tears clog his helmet, a horrible knot in his throat. “You told them their names.”

Tenko breathes deeply. “I’m sorry.”

God dammit. God dammit. God dammit!

Viridant lets him go, shoving him down to the floor. Smoke had made the entire warehouse hazy, clouding the room with heat. Viridant stands in it, backs away from his brother on the hard ground. He snatches his mask up, quickly grabs his backpack and throws it on his shoulders.

Dabi doesn't attack, reeling his flame in and offering Tenko a hand up. His brother takes it, and Viridant sees the truth in that touch alone. A hand reached out to someone who was cursed never to touch again. Trust. Security. This league was built under the guise of taking out All Might, of destroying and weakening Dad’s number one enemy. In truth, it's a band of misfits, of society's rejects, all bonding together to destroy All for One.

He had gotten it all wrong. “I…” What does he say? He’s sorry? He wishes he could take it all back? His apologies don’t bring back his friends, it doesn't change that Tenko killed them. That Viridant did, too. That, ultimately, All for One was the one to do this.

Tenko looks at him, and his eyes widen. He holds his good hand out, shouts, “Twice, no!”

Viridant barley dodges the blow swung at his face, backing up. Twice pushes forward, and Viridant retreats—

Right into Tenko’s open palm. His brother doesn’t think, grabs his limb with his broken one, and shoves him away so Twice can’t hurt him.

And it was a few seconds too long. Blood sprays, a scream peeling from Viridant’s throat. And he can do nothing but watch, as his arm decays, melts.

And falls off.

Chapter End Notes

Lol ha ha

Chapter 42: Savior

Chapter Summary

Midoirya deals with the aftermath of losing his arm

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He runs.

Midoriya sprints out of the warehouse, collecting his support scarf to help him soar through the air. No one follows after him, only a trail of blood. His control of the scarf is awful, his brain too clouded with panic, and he can't seem to get a good grasp on it. He's right-handed, and that's no longer an option.

Red drips out of him, splashing onto the floor and sides of buildings. It stains his suit, pain screaming at him from the severed limb. Tenko had grabbed his upper arm, disintegrated the limb completely through in a band-like grasp. The lower half, his forearm, palm, and fingers, hit the floor of the warehouse. It left only his shoulder and a small bit of bone.

He curses, roaring pain searing through him. He feels hot and cold all at once, and blood pours out of the limb with reckless abandon.

His arm. His arm. His arm is gone.

Midoriya pukes as he swings through the air, losing his grip and hitting the side of a building. He crumbles to the floor of a street, sobbing, his gloved hand trying to hold the blood in. But he can't--there's too much. He's losing too much. He's going to die; his arm has disintegrated from his body. And it *hurts*.

He'd take the broken ribs or burn marks over this. He'd take *anything* over this. He sobs through his teeth, blood unwavering. The moon glares down at him, punishing and brutal. He never should've gone after Tenko; he never should've done this.

"Rin," he cries out, his voice ruinous. "Rin."

Tenko must've broken the AI when he knocked the mask off. She doesn't answer, and the realization that she's dead hits him all over again. She's dead, Ito's dead, Banri's dead, Sayori is dead. Everyone's dead. He's going to be dead.

He pants, trying to will the support scarf to cover the wound, but he can't get it to move. He rips it off with his other arm, sobbing as he tries to tie it to the nub of his arm. It slips off, the fabric filling with blood. It's no use, he can't fix it. He can't.

His sobs quiet down, his chest racking with them. He tries to keep quiet, tries to search for his phone in his pockets to call Mama or Hitoshi or Kacchan. He doesn't want to be alone. He doesn't want to be alone anymore

Instead, he hears the sound of a small child crying.

He shivers, blood loss beginning to set in. But the sound is undeniable. There's a little girl crying somewhere, and the longer it goes on, the louder her footsteps become. He forces himself off the floor with a grunt, stumbling into the street and—

And a small girl collides with his legs. She nearly knocks him down, but he manages to stay upright and lays a hand on her hand to keep her steady. Blood races down his body, pain following it in steady streams. But this little girl wraps her arms around his legs, holds him tightly against her.

Midoriya manages to slur, "Are you a-alright?"

She looks up at him, long white hair shifting. She's covered in bandages, her red eyes reminding him of Kacchan. The blood loss makes him delirious, but he's almost certain this little girl seems petrified. A small horn pokes out of her forehead, and when he blinks, she doubles in his vision. He doesn't have much longer.

"Eri…" a deep, slow voice drawls out.

Midoriya looks up, and a man seems to appear from within the shadows of an alleyway. Immediately, Midoriya is unsettled. Adrenaline pumps through him when the little girl grips his legs tighter than before, trembling to her core.

"Sorry about my daughter," the man says, his voice muffled by what looks like a bird beak face mask. His eyes are yellow, bright, so similar to Himiko's. But the intent behind them is indescribable. Himiko's eyes are full of light, of humanity, but this man looks… empty.

"Eri, come. Don't go causing trouble for… are you a Hero?" The man tilts his head, yellow eyes roaming to the blood running off him. "Oh, that's…" he rubs his gloved hands together, eye twitching as a few drops of red land on Eri's oversized shirt.

"She's shaking," Midoriya says, crouching down to her level. He can hardly see straight, but he still pushes strands of her hair behind her ear. She really does look like K-Kacchan. "For a child to shake s-so much, that's not normal, is it?"

The man eyes them before turning around. "Let's talk in private. She's nervous to be out in the street, I'm sure. I can get you medical attention."

Midoriya extends his good arm, wraps it around her waist and picks her up. She grips him tightly, nearly clawing at his suit to stay next to him.

"D-Don't go," she whispers.

The man waves over his shoulder, urging Midoriya along. It's an effort to walk, to function, but he carries Eri forward. His adrenaline keeps him moving, his arm beginning to stop

hurting. He's going to into shock, his emotions flying around wildly. He's not sure how much longer he has before his body shuts down, but…

But he can't let this go. If his last moments are spent protecting this girl, then so be it. He doesn't like the look of this man, and—

Eri slips out of his arms. She touches the floor, won't meet his eyes as she takes off after the man.

"Children are… unpredictable," the guy says, extending a gloved hand to hold her small one. But she doesn't stop shaking. "I guess we'll be on our way. There's a hospital down the road, Hero."

And for one moment, that little girl looks back at him. Her red eyes are full of tears, and the expression reminds him of Kacchan. Alone in the dark for days, no one to hear him, no matter how much he screamed.

And maybe she didn't scream, but Midoriya hears her all the same.

He taps a button on his phone in his pocket before the support weapon finally begins to respond to him. He launches it out, and the girl gasps as it wraps around her body and yanks her back to him.

The man turns, sighs. "I'm willing to let you go."

Midoriya grabs onto her, even when she tries to run back. "I was thinking the same thing."

Slowly, he grabs the latex glove on his hand, pulls it off. "So be it… Hero."

Midoriya doesn't know much about this situation, but that feeling in his heart keeps his blood pumping, his mind steady. He knows this is the right call, if the bandages and fear on the girl's face weren't signs enough.

He launches his scarf out, grabs onto a building, and flees. Eri screams, clutching onto him tightly as Midoriya throws himself into the air. He holds her tightly, adjusting his scarf to wrap around his waist rather than his neck. It'll keep him from hanging himself while he escapes, his remaining hand occupied holding the girl to his chest.

Blood leaks out of him, and the unmistakable sound of a gun going off fills the air. Bullets fly, one grazing him, and he keeps swinging despite it.

Eri sobs, "He'll kill you! Stop!"

"He won't," Midoriya promises her, grunting as he flies. "I've got you now. Nothing will hurt you anymore."

But Eri shakes her head, tries to wiggle out of his arms midair. She'd fall if she got loose, and the idea of hitting the floor dozens of feet below doesn't scare her.

“You’ll die!” she sobs, and Midoriya isn’t sure what she means. They’re getting away, aren’t they?

A small, yellow light emits from her horned forehead. Midoriya can barely see through it, especially not when it sparks, widens. Eri screams, tries to wiggle loose, but he holds tight. He won’t let her go, won’t let her fall to the ground below, or go back with that man.

It takes two more swings before he realizes his arm is back.

He stares at, wiggles his fingers, and comes to the horrible conclusion that Eri isn’t afraid of the man killing him. She’s afraid of herself.

She screams, claws at him, and the barely healed wound in his neck splinters open. Blood pours out for only a moment before it closes again, the patch of disintegrated skin on his shoulder opening and closing again. He thinks maybe she’s come kind of healing Quirk user, but a moment later, the wounds he healed from in the infirmary begin to fade in again. They had to reset the bone to ensure it healed properly, and the feeling of his ribs breaking, his leg shattering, his fingers snapping, is beyond excruciating.

And still, he doesn’t let her go. Bullets chase him, several different men in masks appearing on rooftops to shoot at him. He keeps moving, grunting as a bullet cuts through his leg, only for the wound to heal a second later.

She can rewind him. She’s restoring him to his previous state of injury; his guess is that she’s got some sort of powerful time-altering Quirk.

That’s… “Eri! Your Quirk is amazing!”

“Can’t… stop!” She sobs, trying to free herself, “I’ll hurt you! You’ll disappear!

Oh shit.

The pain of broken limbs and bruises that he just recovered from disappears. She’s rewinded him to a state of being before then, months and months before this point. He feels the callouses he gained at UA disappear, the extra muscle he packed on flicker out.

She’s going to erase him from existence.

A bullet shoots through his stomach, the pain cutting through him. It takes longer to disappear, Eri’s Quirk glowing brighter and brighter. But still, it disappears. Which means if he maintains constant injuries, then Eri’s Quirk will erase the most current form his body is in rather than rewinding him back to the beginning of his existence.

As he swings, he snaps his fingers to the side. Each time one heals, he breaks another, over and over again. Her Quirk moves quicker, so he breaks two at once. More and more until he jerks his wrist to the side and snaps it.

Eri screams, sounding as though this hurt her, too. That’s not what he wanted, that’s not even close to what he wanted, but… but he can keep her safe. And he’s going to do exactly that.

A form comes into view ahead, a white scarf throwing his body through the air. He knew notifying Eraser would prevent him from ever pulling this stunt again, but he thinks it was well worth it. They've already lost the guys with the guns by the time he and Eraser cross paths. Midoriya keeps swinging, the Pro following him, until he lands on a roof and rolls. He puts a hand over Eri's head, protecting her from injury as they take the rough landing. His arm shatters, and it only serves to save his life as she rewinds it.

"Eraser!" he shouts, and Eri trembles, grasping him tightly and uncontrollably. "Erase the Quirk!"

Eraser's hair floats, red eyes flashing beneath the goggles, and Eri's blinding yellow light winks out of existence. She collapses atop Midoriya's chest, body limp and eyes shut. He holds her tightly, still beyond ecstatic that he has an arm again.

He pants, shaking, holding her close to him. And then he laughs, hysterical. He saved her, took numerous bullets, lost his right arm, and still saved her.

"What did you do?" Eraser seethes, his hair still floating, his eyes bright and angry. "Why can't you ever seem to listen?"

Midoriya smiles at him. "She's got a rewind Quirk. Nearly zapped me out of existence."

His Sensei doesn't look impressed. "Whose child is this?"

"I don't know, I just grabbed her." When Eraser's eyes nearly bug out of his head, Midoriya corrects himself. "She was being abused! Look at her bandages, Sensei! I had to save her."

"What you had to do," Eraser says, approaching the girl and picking her up. "Was stay in your dorm, do your homework, prepare for class on Monday."

"I—"

"You aren't part of this life anymore," Eraser says, cradling the little girl in his scarf. "You are done with vigilantism. That was the agreement."

Midoriya sits up slowly. "I saved her life. There's no telling what would've happened if I weren't here tonight."

"There's no telling where you'll be tomorrow!" Eraser shouts. "I can't vouch for you, don't you get that? You broke a contractual agreement, kid. UA has kept you out of jail!"

Midoriya's heart drops, his body trembles. "You're going to turn me in for this?"

Aizawa-Sensei says, his voice hysterical, "What the hell am I meant to do? I have given you every opportunity to *stop this,* and you just can't seem to do it. This is illegal, don't you get that? This isn't me being a hard ass, you are committing a crime and I can't keep trying to convince people that you're not going to do it again."

Midoriya swallows. "I'll leave, okay? Take her to Recovery Girl and I'll—"

“No.” Eraser’s scarf wraps around his wrist, keeping him in place. “This ends now. All of it. The sneaking out, the patrols, it ends now.”

He shakes. “What are you going to tell the board?”

Eraser shakes his head, bouncing the little girl softly to keep her asleep. “We went out training, and we happened across this child in need of saving while working.”

Midoriya rubs a hand down his face. “Okay, okay, I can do that.”

“And you don’t say a damn word otherwise,” Aizawa-Sensei’s eyes flash. “And when we get back to UA, when we get this girl cleared. You will find yourself in a room with me to discuss what the hell I'm going to do with you.”

He nods softly, his voice sad. “I just wanted to help.”

Eraser shakes his head. “Get up. We have work to do.”

It’s late enough at night that most people at UA are asleep. When they get back, nobody is waiting for them. The little girl remains asleep, seemingly exhausted. Eraser keeps his weapon wrapped around Midoriya’s wrist the entire way back to the school. He feels like a leashed animal.

They go through the motions of fixing things. Eri is taken to Recovery Girl and given her own special room in the infirmary. While she takes care of her, Aizawa-Sensei tries to hammer out a report of the night. Midoriya is left to wait with Eri in her room, to take in the sight of what he’s done. It gives him time to reflect, and he’s not too sure he made the right call today.

He let Tenko go. He could’ve killed him, then and there; he could’ve beaten him to death. What would’ve happened then? He’d have to kill Dabi and Twice, too. Would Todoroki have been devastated? What about Himiko? Dabi seems to take care of her; where would she go without the three integral pillars of the League of Villains?

And what does he do now? Tenko is trying to kill Dad. He knows about the shoes, about his Quirk; his brother isn’t the idiot he pretended to be. He tested Midoriya, both his loyalty and his quick thinking. This whole time, he’s been trying to see whether or not Midoriya would serve as an ally or a hindrance. What does his brother think now?

What does Midoriya think now? Tenko never meant for his friends to die—and maybe Midoriya had been blaming him for it so he wouldn’t have to blame himself. He had just thought… he had just thought it couldn’t really be all his fault. But his friends are just as dead as they were when he left to kill Tenko. And there’s nobody to pay for it, nobody to fight for it. Midoriya was the one who gave them up, and maybe it wasn’t on purpose, but it doesn’t change that he’s the reason they were found.

And it didn’t stop with them. All family ties were destroyed. Ito, Banri, Sayori, and every single family member or friend were slaughtered that night. Sayori had a baby brother, Banri

lived with a few cousins; it didn't matter. All for One slaughtered them all. Nearly a hundred people died in one night.

And Midoriya would've been dead too if they hadn't saved him. If they hadn't kept their mouths shut about him, if they hadn't endured torture and brutality, if they hadn't protected him. If he had shown up any earlier, maybe even just a few minutes. But he failed.

And there's no one to pay for it. He's lost his road with Dad. The bond with Tenko is severed, ruined. He threw away his chance in a blind rage and…

And that rage is gone now. It'll come back, it always does, but deep-rooted exhaustion sets in instead. He realizes, as he sits in a chair and watches Eri go through an exam and get IVs plugged into her veins, that he wanted the anger to stop more than he wanted vengeance. He wanted the nightmares to stop, he wanted the fear to stop, he wanted to sleep at night without waking up screaming.

He was just tired of it. Of all of it.

"Problem child."

He looks up from his hunched position on the chair.

"Let's go."

He doesn't ask where. He follows Aizawa-Sensei to a meeting room. Inside of it sits all the UA professors as well as Nezu. He's not certain what's about to come from this, but he endures it all the same. He picks a chair, sits, and only remembers when several others stare at him that he likely looks awful. He's still missing the right sleeve of his uniform, having lost it alongside his arm. He's certain he's absolutely drenched with blood, but all scars or evidence of what he's been up to from the last few months has disappeared completely. He's younger now, just a few months, but the point still stands.

He checks for those burnt handprints, suddenly nervous that Eri rewinded him too far. But they're still there, and whatever panic had flooded him at the prospect of losing them dissipated. He isn't sure why they mattered so much, but he can't stand the idea of parting with them.

He blinks, and discovers he had missed part of the conversation happening.

"—yes, I'm aware," Aizawa-Sensei says, arms crossed as he sits in a chair. "It was poor decision-making on my part."

"This isn't just poor decision making, sir," a police officer says, one that Midoriya hadn't even known entered the room. "This is reckless endangerment of a minor."

Midoriya furrows his brows. What did he miss?

"I assure you, we had intended to cross no danger," Aizawa-Sensei argues, "It was meant to be a training session with support gear."

“That you forgot to call in?” Midnight prompts, face clouded with concern. “I’m lost, Aizawa, this isn’t like you.”

“It’s grounds to remove your license." There’s a man here with a suit that Midoriya also hadn’t noticed. He must be out of it, blood loss and fear clouding his mind. “An unauthorized training session with a student, then not calling in a crime or requesting backup? This little girl is now in the school’s custody with no guardian to file a report of abuse on.”

“That’s a little far,” Present Mic pipes up, looking way different without his usual hairstyle. “Pros make mistakes all the time. You’re going to place him on suspension for doing his job? The situation was handled, wasn’t it?”

“We have no evidence that this little girl was being abused at all,” The suited man argues, his expression blank. “The commission can’t take another hit from the media if this gets out. Too many corrupt Heroes are already coming to light. I’m afraid we have to take major action against Eraser Head to set an example.”

“This is bullshit,” Present Mic argues, and Midoriya has never heard him angry before. “You’re punishing a good Hero instead of the handful of shitty ones out there to save your own ass?”

“Hizashi,” Aizawa-Sensei mumbles, "Leave it. It’s fine. I’ll get my license back.”

“This is discrimination,” Present Mic snaps, “You wouldn’t pull this shit with any limelight Hero, let alone any straight ones.”

“I could sue for defamation from that sentence alone,” the man in the suit snips back, “The commission deals with instances on a case-by-case basis; this has nothing to do with your lifestyle choices.”

“Choices?” Present Mic fires back. “You’re seriously trying to sell me that shit?”

“I have no choice,” he says simply, shrugging, “The license will be revoked—“

“It’s my fault.”

Silence, eyes turning to Midoriya. Aizawa-Sensei gives him a shake of his head, a silent plea not to talk. But he can’t just sit here and let him take the hit for something Midoriya did. From what it seems like, Aizawa framed their time away from school as a training session gone wrong. Midoriya can work with that.

“I have nightmares,” he says, trying his best to make himself look vulnerable, weak. “Since I’m Q-Quirkless, I fear I won’t ever compare to my peers. So I have nightmares, and I asked Aizawa-Sensei for a l-late extra training session.” He looks down at the table, does everything he can to look meek and small. “He didn’t report anything about it because I was ashamed to ask for extra support; it’s my fault, really.”

“Quirkless?” The man in the suit spits it like a slur. “How did someone like you make it into this school?”

Someone opens their mouth to answer, Midoriya beats them to it. “Luck, sir, I’m very lucky.”

Midnight purses her lips, immediately catching onto his frail act but saying nothing about it. No one else speaks, and he comes to the conclusion that this room full of Pros are fully aware that he’s full of absolute shit. But it’s more important to save Aizawa’s career than it is to call him out for his act.

So he keeps going. “W-Well I had to use the restroom, so I wandered off alone.”

“What store let you in to use a bathroom this late at night?” the man asks, disdain on his plain face.

Midoriya knows the town like the back of his hand, always planning ahead. “2nd street, Yato’s cafe, it’s open until 2 with a public restroom.” He offers a sweet smile. “You can call and ask.”

Someone clears their throat to keep a laugh down.

“And when I came out, I… I heard a girl crying. I went to investigate and… and really it was my fault. I was too stupid to think to call it in.” He looks up from beneath his lashes, his best pathetic face on. “I’m so sorry, please don’t punish my Sensei for my mistakes.”

The man scoffs. “This is why Quirkless students shouldn’t be allowed in this institution. You make a mockery of actual Heroes.”

“You’re right,” Midoriya agrees, forcing his lips to warble. “I could never compare.”

He sighs, rubs his face. “We still don’t have any evidence.”

“I have a camera in my Hero suit,” Midoriya adds, “I can retrieve the footage as long as I have a laptop. W-Would that help, sir?”

“Why didn’t you say that to begin with!” The man shouts at him, standing. “Someone bring us a laptop, please.”

Midoriya is slid a piece of paper, asked for a statement, and he writes it as a laptop is retrieved. He sticks to his story, and when he’s done, he slides it to Aizawa-Sensei to add onto. They lock eyes for a moment, a shared look of understanding passing between them. While they wait for the laptop, he goes on his phone and pretends to be tearfully texting his mom when he’s actually editing the footage. He cuts off the section where he beats the fuck out of his brother, only keeping the footage from when he stepped into the street.

When he finally gets the laptop, he transfers footage from his helmet, making sure it ends when he meets with Eraser.

This is going to work, this is going to work.

The video goes on a screen in the room, and it’s reviewed in utter silence. The sound of bullets, of the girl sobbing, all on display. When it ends, the looks thrown his way are a bit

different.

“You broke your hand to negate the girl's Quirk?” The man asks him, eyes narrowed.

Midoriya purses his lips. “Yes.”

“And where did all this blood come from?” he demands.

Midoriya looks down, looks back up. “Uhm… I… got hit by a car.”

Dead silence.

“What?”

“Yeah, I didn’t even see it,” Midoriya lies. “My eyes are… not great.”

The man sighs, rubs a hand down his face. “You caused so much trouble for what reason?”

Midoriya laughs a little. “I kind of do that.”

The man stands, collects the paper statements. “Eraser, I can see you were put in an unfair situation. Having to work with someone like *that?*” He scoffs, places the statements within a folder and heads to exit the room. “I suggest this casualty be removed from UA before he ruins your record. This child can’t save anyone.” He gives one more glare to Midoriya. “Stay out of trouble, punk.”

“Sir, yes, sir.” Midoriya nods frantically, bowing. “Thank you.”

When the commission worker leaves, followed by a police officer, the remaining people in the room are plunged into silence. Nezu, who taps the tips of his fingers together. All Might, whose grin is so shit eating that it’s not even funny. Snipe, Ectoplasm, Vylad-King, and Midnight seem impressed. And Aizawa and Present Mic don’t seem to have words for what just happened.

“So uhh…” Midoriya clears his throat. “I’m gonna… go back to my dorm—“

“You snuck out, didn’t you?” Nezu asks, his voice squeaky. “And ran into some trouble?”

Midoriya looks at Aizawa, Aizawa looks at Midoriya.

“You won’t be in trouble,” Nezu adds, “Protecting a peer, whether out on the field or against a discriminatory force, is Hero work as far as I’m concerned. I only want a clear picture of what happened tonight.”

“I told you,” Midoriya says, “Car.”

“I think we’re done here,” Aizawa says, standing. “I will deal with the problem child accordingly as his teacher.”

Nezu nods, clasps his hands in front of him. “Meeting adjourned, then.”

People move in a flurry, eager to go back to bed. Aizawa-Sensei doesn't let Midoriya off the hook. He keeps his leash on him, literally, and drags him back to the 1-A dorms. Recovery Girl promised a more thorough update on Eri when she woke up, but for now, all they could do was allow her to rest.

When they make it to the common room, Aizawa has him hand in all of his gear. Helmet, mask, scarf. He asks how Midoriya managed to retrieve it, and is met with no response. He keeps his phone, but Aizawa isn't an idiot; he knows that Midoriya went out for something.

So he leans against the back of the common room couch, his arms crossed over his chest, and he asks. "Where did the blood come from?"

Midoriya doesn't answer.

"Kid," he sighs, palms braced against the head of the couch. "Give me *something."*

He doesn't have anything to offer. He knows it's not right. And he can't change a damn thing about it. What is he meant to do? Tell Aizawa-Sensei the truth? Risk his life? He can't lose another person; he won't.

So he keeps his mouth shut.

"I just…" Aizawa squints at the yellow backpack full of gear. He grabs it, and Midoriya doesn't move fast enough to stop him from pulling out the Manila folder.

"Don't!" he shouts, leaping forward.

He grasps it, pulls, and Aizawa-Sensei holds strong on his end. They tug it back and forth like children before his Sensei finally rips it away from him and turns his back to him. He flips it open, and Midoriya can see the precise moment his body goes rigid.

He backs away, quietly, slowly. Aizawa doesn't look at him, flipping through the file of personal information with an uncanny speed. Midoriya continues to retreat, faster and faster, until his back presses against the dorm doors. He grasps the handle, shoves—

The door is already locked.

"What…" Aizawa shakes his head, turns. "What were you doing with this?"

Midoriya swallows. "Nothing."

"Don't lie to me," Aizawa-Sensei says, holding the file in his hand. "Do you know what could happen to me if this information were given to the public? To anyone? This has my social security, my home address, my full name."

"I wasn't going to give it away," he promises.

Aizawa tosses it to the coffee table on the other side of the couch. His face is withdrawn, betrayed, and Midoriya can't help the knot of regret in his stomach.

“Convince me,” Aizawa all but begs. “Convince me to keep you here, kid.”

Midoriya says nothing.

“I’m at a loss.” It’s a confession and a plea for help. “I have done everything in my power to do things right with you. I lied for you, I almost lost my job for you. I vouch for you when no one else will, I find accommodations to keep your mom safe. I try to bond and apologize for upsetting you. I'm at a loss.” Aizawa jerks an arm out to point at the files. “I can understand if you're still upset about the Ground Zero operation, but this is beyond acceptable. I’m drawing a boundary, kid. I’m drawing a line in the sand here. I can’t keep ignoring all these awful things you keep doing.”

Midoriya takes in a shaky breath.

“Convince me, please, just convince me. Convince me you aren’t a bad person. Convince me you aren’t selling out my information, information you shouldn’t even have access to. Convince me I’m not making a mistake here, please.” Aizawa’s voice isn’t harsh; it’s mournful. As though he’s losing something precious to him. “Please.”

He’s not sure what to say. In all honesty, he can’t promise Aizawa that he isn’t a bad person at all. He left tonight to kill his brother, a family member. His life goal is to end the life of his Dad. He’s no Hero, he knows that. But there’s a sort of grief within him, a grief he shares with his teacher, with a man who has devoted his life to trying to save Midoriya before he flew too close to the sun. He’s unaware that Midoriya is already falling from grace, a living and breathing Icarus.

So he doesn’t know what to say. He doesn’t know how to fix this.

Aizawa nods at his silence, wipes a hand over his mouth. “Okay.” He seems honest to god heartbroken. “I’m turning you in.”

Midoriya trembles. “I-I’m sorry.”

“It’s not enough,” his Sensei says. “It’s not enough to just be sorry. This isn’t about solving petty crimes; this is about privacy invasion and information theft. This is a federal crime, this is something I can’t save you from, and I have *tried*.”

He looks down at his feet, fists clenched in shame.

“Give me *something,”* Aizawa begs, pleads. “Don’t make me do this to you, please, god, don’t make me do this to you, kid. You have so much potential, so much talent, so much intelligence. Please don’t make me waste that.”

Midoriya screws his eyes tight and hopes, with everything inside him, that he isn’t making a mistake.

“I’m in contact with the league of villains."

Aizawa doesn’t say a word, his face still twisted up with grief, his mouth still open.

“I… I’ve been giving them information on Pros. Whoever they name, I give them an entire file. I pull it from the Hero Commissions database.”

“Oh my god.” Aizawa sits on the head of the couch, palming his eyes.

“I-I send in an anonymous tip every time I do it,” Midoriya tries to amend. “I warn them—I tell them someone is breaching their information or trying to cause them harm.”

Aizawa can’t look at him, his elbows resting on his thighs, his head in his hands. Midoriya keeps going.

“I wasn’t going to give them your file; it was just a backup in case my plan didn’t go well.”

“What plan?” Aizawa looks up, his eyes bloodshot and wet.

Midoriya can’t find the words. He has to search inside him, pull them from the depths of his core. And all that leaves his lips is a pathetic excuse. “He killed my friends.”

Aizawa shuts his eyes. “You went after them to… to capture them?”

Midoriya doesn’t correct him; instead, he says, “Originally, it was an information trade. I’d tell them whatever they wanted to know about a given Pro… and they’d tell me about their leader.”

His teacher nods, his face still pulled with such a raw sadness that it sucker punches Midoriya in the gut. “Who is this leader?”

And he tells him. “All for One.”

A breath of silence. “All for One—All Might’s enemy. I did my research, they battled, All Might reportedly killed him in a fight.”

“He’s not dead.”

Aizawa-Sensei breathes in, breathes out. “Where did the blood come from?”

Midoriya looks at his right arm, flexes his fingers. “A member of the league took it off.”

“You saved that girl with a missing arm? Did you know she could give it back?”

Midoriya shakes his head. Silence again descends on the dorms; they look at one another. Two totally different people, now intertwined in a reality they can’t escape.

Aizawa says, his voice quiet, “Who else knows this?”

And Midoriya says, his throat bobbing. “Only you.”

“Your mom…?” Midoriya shakes his head. “Shinso? Bakugou?”

“No.” The word is a breath. “Only you.”

Aizawa nods his head, takes it all in.

And wraps his arms around Midoriya in a hug, squeezing him close, holding him as though he is a star about to wink out of the night sky. There's this weight that lifts off Midoriya, something heavy and dark and foreign, something that he wasn't aware had been ripping him open.

"In one month," Aizawa says quietly, "There is a provisional licensing exam. You will train until then, work your ass off, and have zero interaction with vigilantism. And when you take that test, you will pass, and in your hands you will hold a Hero's provisional license that allows you to act as a Hero only with permission from a Pro or in extreme circumstances." His voice is soft, unwavering. "And you will work with me as an apprentice. I will teach you everything you wish to know, and we will find a way, both of us, together, to take that son of a bitch out."

Midoriya's eyes water, and he hides his face in his Sensei's scarf. "If he knows about you, he'll kill you. If he knows about me—that's why he killed my friends, he thought I was with them—"

"He won't know a thing," Aizawa promises, squeezing him tightly. "But you're done dealing with alone. You and me, okay? We're taking this asshole down."

Midoriya smiles, wide and real. "Okay."

Chapter End Notes

:D

Chapter 43: Haunted

Chapter Summary

Shinso mends a broken bond, and Bakugou reads a notebook

Chapter Notes

Also i changed the title of the fic lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shinso knocks on the door. He's got Miss Baby in his hands, never going far without the cat by his side. And he's absolutely petrified. He tells the cat that she's got to be his good luck charm and fix things, because he's not sure he can do it alone.

The door creaks open, and Miss Midoriya peers out at him. She didn't seem mad the last time they interacted, and it's a relief to see that held. Her face goes from cautious to pure joy. She flings forward, wraps him in a big hug.

"Hitoshi!" She can't know that she was the second person to have ever hugged him before. Maybe that's a bit emo to think about, but it's completely true. The first was Midoriya.

She pulls back, looks at the small cat that's moved to stand on his head, and promptly screams. Every door in the teachers' housing unit flies open so fast that it's not even funny. Even All Might appears from thin air, his buff form solid and ready to attack.

"A kitty!" she squeals, and there's a series of groans as the doors click shut again. All Might gives him a smile and disappears. It seems like she is under very high protection here.

"This is Miss Baby," Shinso says, mentally pleading for his cat not to pull some stupid shit and be nice to Miss Midoriya. He hands her the cat, and it immediately eats her hair and scratches her face. Shinso cringes, but she seems to find it adorable.

"She's an angel," Miss Midoriya claims as the cat attempts to take her eyes out. "What a gift! You came by just to show me this sweet pea?"

Shinso rubs the back of his head. Class let out an hour ago, and he figured Midoriya would be busy with the little girl who randomly showed up at the school. It would give him free time to come see Miss Midoriya, and hopefully brainstorm a way to be his friend again. He's pretty

sure that child was a direct result of Viridant being back in action, but he's not saying shit to anyone about it.

"Actually," he says, clearing his throat, "I was hoping I could talk with you."

"Oh!" She scratches behind Miss Baby's ears. "What perfect timing, come inside!"

Perfect timing?

Aw fuck.

Midoriya sits on the tatami floor, fork poked halfway into a piece of pork. He doesn't have a single facial reaction upon seeing Shinso, and it unsettles him to his core. Bakugou was right, a statement Shinso never thought he'd think. Midoriya can detach and remove himself from people or things he doesn't want around. And it's very evident that Shinso is intruding.

The door shuts behind him. Miss Midoriya hums as she grabs another plate of food from the small table in the corner. She must cook in the kitchen and bring some food here to the room for her and Midoriya. She makes a plate for him, to which he knows better than to decline. Moms seem to have this bizarre infatuation with making sure every child near them eats, and she's no exception.

"Come sit," she says, plopping down across from Midoriya, forcing him to take a seat next to him. "What did you want to talk about?"

"That's a great question," Midoriya says, biting into his pork. "What *did* you want to talk about?"

This is going to suck.

He takes a seat next to Midoriya, smiling when the mom makes Miss Baby dance. "Uhh… thank you for the Christmas gift."

Midoriya doesn't blink. "Mhm."

"Izuku," Miss Midoriya warns, "Be nice."

"I'm finding it."

Shinso awkwardly eats the meat on his plate. It's good, savory. Dammit, he wishes he could cook anything more than mac and cheese. There are chore rotations for every student in 1-A, and every time it's his turn to cook, he just begs Aizawa-Sensei to order a pizza. Or he offers to trade someone else. The one time nobody helped him out, they had ramen noodles for dinner. And they weren't even fully cooked through.

It's not nearly as bad as Midoroya's turn to cook. He hasn't been here long enough to have more than one full chore rotation, but when it was his turn to cook, he set the kitchen on fire. They had to practice their fire drills, exiting the building, and letting the fire department put out the flames. He's been banned from the kitchen since, and the few times he's gone in to

grab a snack, whoever is in the common room lounge will make fire alarm noises as a warning. It's usually Kaminari.

"How uhh… how have you guys been adjusting?" Shinso asks. He adds, "It looks great in here."

"Actually pretty well!" Miss Midoriya says, "I really enjoy being so close to Izuku. I feel like we spend so much more time together! I do wish I could go back to work, but I've settled for cooking for everyone instead. And it seems we have enough money." She gives her son a knowing look. "Since someone stole All Might's money."

Midoriya doesn't look the least bit ashamed. "He didn't mind, especially not when he comes to visit you."

Miss Midoriya goes red in the face. "Izuku!"

"Oh?" Shinso prompts, chuckling when her face goes even more red. "All Might visits you, Miss Midoriya."

"No!" she squeaks out, fanning her face. "And call me Inko. You and Katsuki have such manners; it makes me feel old."

"That's what they're known for," Midoriya says sarcastically. "Their manners. True gentlemen."

Inko gives Midoriya a nasty look and he shuts up immediately. He just eats his pork silently, head down, and Shinso is left to carry the conversation.

"So you and All Might…"

"It's not like that!" Inko says again, embarrassed. "He's just a very kind soul. He wants to make sure I'm safe."

"Especially at night," Midoriya comments blandly.

"Izuku Midoriya, watch your mouth," Inko warns him. "He has nothing but good intentions."

"Oh, I'm sure," Midoriya agrees, biting into his pork. "I'm sure his intentions are very good."

Shinso purses his lips to keep from laughing at Inko's scandalized expression. She lays a hand over her heart, jaw dropped. Miss Baby tries to swipe some pork off her plate, and Shinso has to grab her to stop the evil thing.

"I'm not sure who taught you how to be so crass," Inko says, "But it sure wasn't me."

"Mama, you answer the door in pajamas! And not your ratty mumu, actually good pajamas!" Midoriya cries out. "You aren't slick! You don't even wear your bonnet!"

“My mumu isn’t ratty,” Inko argues, shaking her head when Midoriya scoffs. “I’ll have you know my mumu is very clean and I stitched all the holes in it last week.”

“Oh, last week? I wonder why you suddenly care about fixing it now.”

“You’re grounded.”

“How are you going to ground me, Mama? I don’t live with you anymore.”

“Grounded!”

“You sure you don’t want to ask All Might about that decision first?”

Shinso quickly snatches Miss Baby up from the floor as the two of them wrestle back and forth. He really doesn’t understand parent-child dynamics, but he wishes he did. It looks fun, poking at your parents and knowing they’ll still love you through it. Miss Baby watches, looking at Shinso like these two are lunatics. Shinso’s half convinced that they are.

When they’re done, Shinso sets his cat back down, and she immediately runs to Midoriya and starts swiping at his weird-looking red tie. He’s not sure why he tenses at the contact, unsure of how Midoriya will handle it. But his old friend swoops the cat up and kisses her head. Then he grabs his tie, undoes it, and drags the length of it along the floor for Miss Baby to chase. The cat came in clutch, who’d have thought?

“Oh!” Miss Midoriya stands, grabs their plates, “I should get these dishes done.”

“Mama—“

“I’ll be back!” she calls, quickly leaving the room with the dirty plates. It’s the most obvious excuse to give the two of them privacy, but Shinso takes it in stride.

Midoriya doesn’t say anything to him, dragging his tie along the floor and letting the little gremlin chase it. Shinso watches, hands folded in his lap. They sit in silence for a while, only the sound of Miss Baby’s feet thumping against the floor filling the air. It’s awkward, tense, and he’s not sure where to go from here.

Finally, Midoriya breaks it. “Did you help them find me?”

Shinso leans back on his palms. “Yeah. But only at the end. They said you were in danger, so I guided them to the second apartment you had secured for your mom.”

Midoriya nods, dangling the cloth and letting the cat jump for it. “You never told them anything else?”

“No,” Shinso says honestly. “They figured out everything else. I never said a word—I swear.”

He doesn’t respond to that.

“Midoriya,” Shinso says quietly, “I want to be your friend.”

“I’m so happy you came to that conclusion after ignoring me for months,” he says flatly, spinning the tie in the air for Miss Baby to chase. “Really makes me feel so important.”

“Kaminari asked me out,” Shinso says, and Midoriya doesn’t reply. “I said no. I felt too guilty trying to enjoy time with him knowing I was leaving you behind. Especially when he told me that you prompted him to ask me out.”

Midoriya shrugs. “Why should I care?”

“It was guilt,” Shinso admits, his heart aching in that familiar, agonizing way. “I learned about why UA rejected you, about Ground Zero, and all these stupid things. And I couldn’t pretend I didn’t know.”

“You didn’t warn me, you let me face all of that shit alone when you knew the entire time.”

“I was petrified for you!” Shinso shouts, and Miss Baby stops playing to look at him. She crawls into Midoriya’s lap, tries to hide under his shirt. “I thought the vigilante shit was cool at first, but you went off the deep end with it. I was horrified that I’d wake up one day and you’d be dead. I didn’t tell you anything because I wanted them to catch you. And I didn’t tell them anything because I wanted you to evade them.” Shinso sighs, picks at his cuticles. “That wasn’t a fair position to put me in.”

“You never told me that,” Midoriya snaps at him. “How was I supposed to know you weren’t comfortable with all this? You’ve been aiding me since the beginning, and now it’s my fault that you apparently hated it so much?”

“I didn’t hate it—“

“If it was such a burden on you,” Midoriya says, finally looking at him. His eyes are a bright, horrible red. “Then you should’ve told me that, you should’ve communicated. Instead, you left me in the dark when I *needed* you.”

Shinso can’t look away from those eyes. “I’m sorry.”

“You’ve done this to me before,” Midoriya says, his face hard. “You don’t get to do it again.”

“I’m not going to leave you alone, you know that, right?” Shinso says, honest and open. “You were my first friend, I’m not going to leave you alone.”

Midoriya slumps, lying flat on his back. Miss Baby sits atop him, licking a paw. “I thought you had used to me. The second you got into 1-A, you left me behind.”

“Jesus,” Shinso says in disbelief. “Do you always think the worst of absolutely everyone? Or do I just get hit with that bullshit? Fucking hell.”

“Fuck you, it all lined up,” he snaps, “It wouldn’t be the first time. I was trying to give you the benefit of the doubt, but you disappeared completely. I checked on you all the time, and you seemed to be doing just fine at UA.”

Shinso scoffs, shakes his head. “You know what? I think I know why you’re doing this.”

“Enlighten me.”

“You’re trying to push me away,” Shinso concludes, glaring down at him. “Right? Push me away because you don’t want to admit that you miss hanging out with me. I hurt your feelings, and now you're going to pretend I don’t exist at all. Are you done feeling sorry for yourself yet? It’s taking way too long.”

Midoriya sits up, carefully sets Miss Baby on the floor away from him so she doesn’t get hurt. “Do you think you’re that special?”

Shinso grins at him. “You do.”

Midoriya slits his eyes. “You’re an asshole.”

“So are you, dickhead,” Shinso snaps, but he’s smiling at him. “Do you want me to fix your awful hair dye job? Yikes.”

“Screw you.”

“Hard pass on that one.”

Midoriya shakes his head, runs a hand through his hair. “Is it really that bad?”

“Dude, it’s so bad,” Shinso leans forward, grabs Midoriya’s head and tilts it. Even better, Midoriya lets him. He’s very clearly not pleased, but he’s letting Shinso in after months of trying. So it’s a start. “You need your roots bleached again for sure, and I have no idea what dye you’ve been using, but it’s caused an oil buildup. We’ve got to get a clarifying shampoo.”

“How do you know so much about hair?” Midoriya asks, grunting when Shinso tugs him back again. “Ow.”

“Four foster sisters, remember?” Shinso asks. “I think I’ve bleached all of their hair and dyed it at least six times. And I had a whole emo faze in middle school, dyed my entire head black.”

“No, you didn’t.” Midoriya looks back at him, eyes wide. “Are you serious?”

“I’ll show you photos if you forgive me,” Shinso says, and Midoriya purses his lips. “They’re gold mines. I had a whole gacha faze too, I can’t reflect on my childhood without wanting to jump off a roof.”

Midoriya holds in his laugh. “Send me the photos, and if you ever betray me again, I’ll send them right to Kaminari’s phone. That’s the only way I’ll forgive you.”

They stare each other down before Shinso finally clicks his tongue and grumbles an agreement. He sends the photos, and it takes Midoriya a good hour to stop laughing. He nearly throws up, sobbing and snot-faced, rolling on the floor laughing. Shinso really was the most cringy middle schooler, and Midoriya confesses that he was one of those anime

cosplayers during his early middle school years. He doesn't show Shinso any photos, claiming that he destroyed all evidence, but that he had tormented Bakugou for *years* with anime poses and cringy dialogue.

It definitely doesn't take Inko two hours to wash plates, but she never comes back to her room. And when they finish talking about stupid things just like they used to, Shinso offers him a hand and they head out. Miss Baby wears a sparkly pink harness as they walk her out of the school. Scanning their student IDs gives them free range of the town, and Shinso takes them straight to a good hair care store. They spend the entire day fixing Midoriya's genuinely horrific hair, and when it's done, he looks almost exactly like he used to. Shinso does Inko's hair, too, who is beyond grateful for the help. Shinso goes as far as braiding some of it. He's not extremely familiar with black hair textures, but he used to have a foster sister who was black. So he learned how to do decent two-strand twists. But with how much hair Inko has, he doesn't even get through a quarter of it before his hands cramp and ache.

So he comes back the next day, eats whatever dinner she made, and talks to Midoriya. He lathers her hair in Eco Style hair gel, using a rat tail comb to section it. He can't do any of those cool designs he's seen, but just getting her hair styled and easier to manage seems to cheer her up. When it's done, she looks in the mirror. She tells him that she hasn't had her hair done like this since she was a teenager. There was never time or money to get it done, and she hadn't realized how much of her culture she lost in the aftermath of her husband's abuse.

He leaves when she starts crying, unsure how to really handle that. But Midoriya finds him hours later, and in the quiet of the night, they talk again.

"Izuku," he says, offering a shy smile. "You can call me Izuku."

Shinso replies, "I was thinking I'd call you 'Stupid idiot', but Izuku works."

***

Bakugou stares at the open notebook, the words blurring in his head. He's been nonstop reading Deku's writing for over two weeks now. There are so many fucking notebooks to go through, and he starts all the way at the beginning. Deku catalogs everything, reviews intently, his mind working in bizarre ways. And almost everything is about Bakugou.

It's so intensive, intrusive. He's not sure how to feel about it, but he's certain the warm feeling in his chest isn't the logical response. This is outright stalker behavior, and Bakugou isn't at all startled by it. Deku's always been… off kilter. He's a weirdo, a freak, and his peculiar way of life is what drew Bakugou in in the first place.

Still, reading passage after passage about how Deku wants to slowly peel the skin off Bakugou's bones, then another passage right after about how amazing and intelligent Bakugou is—it's alarming. And it's like that for every book; even the six books directly dedicated to everything about Bakugou. He's written several times over again that he can't get Bakugou out of his head. And it's neither a good nor a bad thing, but it seems he's been haunting Deku just the same way Deku has been haunting him.

Fucking hell.

Bakugou turns the page of another notebook, an in-depth analysis of Bakugou's course schedule following it. Deku doesn't like being left in the dark on anything, a trait Bakugou shares with him, but this is beyond a fear of lack of knowledge. This is downright psychotic. He talks about Bakugou's posture, how each time he sighs means he's feeling a certain emotion each day. He documents times Bakugou's gotten sick, the scores Bakugou's gotten on exams. Bakugou, Bakugou, Bakugou.

Though back then, his name was Kacchan in these journals.

And Dad was written as All for One.

He leans back in his desk chair, rubbing his hands down his face. All for One is Deku's fucking Dad. And he wants to kill him. Slowly, painfully, it's written in such excruciating detail that had Aizawa-Sensei landed a single notebook other than the one he did, then Deku would've been sent to jail or a psychiatric hospital or *something.* This is murder, detailed, planned out, fantasized about murder. Premeditated, eager, Deku fucking drooling at the mouth at the prospect.

Psychopath. Deku's a fucking psychopath.

And he thinks Bakugou has a nice jawline.

Dammit! Deku is *insane;* he needs to tell someone about this… or maybe he won't. He doesn't know! Why the fuck should he know?! He's off put, sure, especially because Bakugou is tied with All for One on the death threat category. But there are nearly three times as many entries that contradict it, that paint Bakugou like he's a god among men, like Deku's been worshipping him for years.

"What the fuck." He palms his eyes, chair squeaking as he leans back again. "This is so fucked."

And it changes nothing for him. Deku is still in his mind just as often. Bakugou thinks that if he had a notebook, it'd be just a fucking full of the same shit. Which is *wrong,* and illegal, and so horrifically honest that he's not sure what to do with himself. All for One is Deku's dad, and Bakugou can't bring himself to say a word about it.

Shit. He doesn't even *care.* He's too busy thinking about the passages that detail the slope of Bakugou's shoulders as though the bone and skin are something more than anatomy.

I'm not gay.

Bakugou groans.

I hate you. I fucking hate you.

But he *doesn't.* He doesn't hate Bakugou at all… or maybe he does?

Motherfucker. He can't tell. The notebook isn't recent enough—if he could just get his hands on the two that he's missing. One of which Aizawa-Sensei gave back to Deku for Heroics class, the other being one that Deku had bought when he lost the old one. Two more notebooks, and Bakugou might have an answer.

And Deku just so happens to be out on the town with fucking Eyebags. It had driven him up the wall to learn that at first… but this might work to his advantage.

Bakugou keeps up from his desk, stashing the notebook among dozens of others. He slips out of his room, eyes Deku's door at the end of the hall. People are still up and making noise in the common room, but Deku's door faces the stairs, not the railing. So long as he's quiet, then nobody will notice him.

He grabs a spare paperclip from his room and heads to Deku's door. You don't get locked in a closet for three days and *not* teach yourself how to pick locks after. Bakugou ensured he'd never get stuck in the dark again, and he's making damn sure to step into the light. He jams the clip into the lock, wiggles it carefully. Lock picking is a simple but careful practice. He applies gentle pressure to the door's plug, twisting and lifting each individual pin along the shear line of the lock. UA wanted to do a keycard system, but in the rush to finish the dorms, a simple key lock system was implemented instead.

Thank god for that, because the door clicks and Bakugou quietly pushes it open and seals himself inside. Thank fuck UA seized the freaky ass robot Deku had in his old bedroom, because Bakugou truly has no idea how he'd deal with it. Even better, regular dorm checks have been started since Deku came to school to ensure he wasn't hiding any sketchy shit.

Bakugou looks around the room, his heart racing. The bedding on the bed looks familiar, and Bakugou stares at it for a long time, trying to think of where the hell he's seen it before. It only serves to frustrate him, so he looks away from the orange stitching. He needs evidence that Deku either cares about him or won't murder him in his sleep. He'll take either at this point.

He starts with the bookshelf. The notebooks aren't there, but the rest of the romance manga's Deku gifted him for Christmas is. He sees that Deku has still been annotating and reading it, and Bakugou itches to reach forward and read his analysis. The first reread of 'Viridant's' thoughts on the manga was…. It was good, as much as he doesn't want to fucking admit it. Deku went in-depth on the story, bringing up points that hadn't even crossed Bakugou's mind. He found that he enjoyed reading what Viridant thought more than the actual damn manga. Stupid, so fucking stupid.

He ignores the shelf, peering at the small wooden dorm desk. It's cluttered with homework and notes for school, but no notebooks. Bakugou even searches through Deku's school bag,

comes up empty. Maybe the nerd is carrying the books on him? If it's sensitive information, he wouldn't be—

"One second, let me grab a shirt that can get stained."

Oh fuck!

Bakugou looks around, panicked, and dives for the bed. He shoves underneath it, grunting at the tight squeeze. He moves all the way against the wall, covering his mouth with a hand. He tugs a spare blanket over his body, yanking dirty clothes over his skin, hoping he looks like a pile of laundry.

The dorm door opens. Shuts. Red shoes come into view. Bakugou's eyes are wide, his breath seeming so loud as Deku walks around the room. He has to hold his breath as much as he can, breathing slowly and deeply, trying not to make a sound.

Deku mutters to himself, words that Bakugou can't make out. Slowly, the nerd goes to his desk. When he opens the top drawer, he lifts the bottom panel, pulls out a phone. It's a false fucking bottom. The desk has a hidden drawer.

Deku turns the phone on, stares at the screen for a long while. He doesn't type anything, just looks at it, then places it back in the drawer. He shuts it again, and Bakugou watches as he goes to the wardrobe next. He keeps watching, even when Deku grabs the back of his shirt collar and tugs the fabric off. His bare back is exposed, covered in scars and bruises.

Smooth, soft skin.

Bakugou accidentally kicks the bed with his knee, holding in his curse. He looks away instantly, praying to god that Deku didn't hear that. When he looks back, Deku's shoes are facing him. He stands at the side of the bed, red shoes pointed at Bakugou's head.

He doesn't bend down or look under. Just his shoes, facing him, as though he's just *standing there.*

What the fuck is he doing?

"Hurry up!" Shinso shouts from the hall.

Bakugou slowly looks at the foot of the bed, his breath in his throat. Deku is looking right at him. He left his shoes on the other end and crawled quietly along the top, dangling his head over the side to peer under. Bakugou can only lie perfectly still, praying that the blanket and laundry fully cover him.

Deku's face is obscured by shadow, his eyes dark, black pits. This is the most horrifying Bakugou has ever seen, and it's not even close. He doesn't move, doesn't react.

"Hello?" Shinso scoffs, "Hurry up!"

Deku slowly sits back up, shimmies into his shoes. "I thought I heard something, sorry."

“It’s fine. But I’ve got to get your roots done asap before I go blind looking at them.” The door clicks shut.

Bakugou doesn’t move for a very long time. He’s got no idea how Deku could be that fucking scary. He rarely admits when something scares him, but that left an awful feeling in his gut. Shinso had told him that Deku would often come by his house to check on him in his sleep, but Bakugou is beginning to wonder if he wasn’t just giving a glance through the window.

What are the odds that Deku was watching him sleep from within the house? Standing in his bedroom, staring at him without Bakugou ever knowing? He tries not to think about it, sliding out from under the bed.

He’s careful not to disturb anything in the room as he goes to the desk, opens the same drawer. It takes him a moment to figure out how to get the false bottom out, but once he does, he comes face-to-face with two notebooks and a phone that looks completely different from Deku’s current one. Maybe a burner?

He had listened to Deku and Aizawa-Sensei the other night. He’s well aware of what Deku was up to, but again, he wasn’t nearly as disturbed as he should be. This phone might be how he contacts the league. Bakugou grabs it, turns it on, and is met with message after message from ‘Tenko’.

Tenko: How’s your arm?

Tenko: It was an accident.

Tenko: Where did you run off to?

Tenko: You can hide forever, Akatani.

Tenko: We'll meet again, little brother. I’ll make sure of it.

Tenko: We have a lot to discuss.

Little…

Brother…?

Bakugou grabs the notebooks, reads through them quickly. The further in he gets, the worse the things are that he reads. Sketches of the bodies in the tunnel, in-depth notes of what it was like to watch that one little girl with flames for her hair have her eyes ripped out of her head while she was still screaming. Notes on the training camp, documentation of every conversation with ‘Tomura’, who is also written as ‘Tenko’. Deku’s been selling out information for months, writing guilty confessions but sprawling words after it about how it has to be done, no matter the cost.

Dad needs to die, over and over and over again.

Entries about Bakugou, about how much he hates him. Promises never to trust him again, plans to avoid him. And a just-in-case section of the notebook, detailing how to strangle Bakugou in his sleep.

So… Deku might be a little mad at him.

He carefully slides the notebooks back into place, the phone alongside it. When he exits the dorm room and goes back to his own, he jams his desk chair under the handle to his room. If the lock gets picked, the chair won't open unless extreme force is applied to the door. Even then, he'd wake up from the noise.

Still, he doesn't sleep well that night. He's not sure how to fix things with Deku; he's not sure it's possible. Eyebags implied Deku might think Bakugou was the reason cops showed up to arrest him, therefore making Deku hate his guts. He said Deku pushes people away, denies things. But Bakugou's memory is already playing tricks on him. Maybe they really weren't going to… to kiss in the woods. Maybe he imagined it, maybe he just wanted it to happen, and convinced himself it was real.

Is Deku trying to trick him? Could Bakugou really make that whole thing up? He wants to believe Shinso was telling the truth, but—

But he doesn't *know.* He doesn't know what to do here.

When he finally gets to sleep, his nightmares are different.

This time, when he's locked in the dark, they've put Deku in there with him. And for long hours, in the silence and shadow, Deku just stares at him. He doesn't say a word, doesn't move, doesn't react when Bakugou screams and begs for someone to open the door. He just stares, smiles, and Bakugou wakes up to the sound of his door opening.

But when he looks, the chair is still in place, the door is still locked.

And his window is wide open.

Chapter End Notes

:o

Chapter 44: Inherit

Chapter Summary

Provisional license exam summary

Chapter Notes

Baby chapter today :(I have exams coming up :((((

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Eraser Head!”

Aizawa takes a deep breath, shuts his eyes tight. He can’t ever catch a fucking break, can he?

“It’s been so long!” A woman wraps herself around his arm, and he does everything in his power not to look at her. “Remember me?”

“No,” he lies.

She belts out a laugh. “You’re still as funny as ever!”

He looks at his husband, who’s laughing at him from where he sits in the stands. It’s officially the provisional license exam day, and it combines all Hero schools into one location. Therefore, he’s stuck dealing with Ms.Joke and all her students from Ketsubutsu Academy. Wonderful.

“We should get married,” she says, her long green hair hidden beneath an orange beanie.

“I’d rather die,” Aizawa says.

She laughs loudly again, drawing unwanted attention. He gets his arm loose from her, shoves his hands into his pockets, and heads to the stands. She follows right after, still flirting even after he sits beside his literal husband.

“If I were your wife, I’d fill every day with unstoppable laughter!” Her obnoxiously colored shorts puff up as she sits.

“That sounds like an actual nightmare.”

Another howling laugh. Hizashi has to hold his own down, slinging an arm over the back of Aizawa's chair and doing everything in his power not to tease him. Hizashi, of course, finds the whole thing hilarious. He's secure enough not to feel threatened by Ms.Joke, and cruel enough that he won't save Aizawa from this fate and tell her that he's taken.

He loves him to death, but he might strangle him. If he were any better with physical affection, let alone public affection, he'd do it himself. But, alas, he'd rather deal with Ms.Joke twice a year than confess that he's been married since the second Hizashi could get a ring on his finger.

"Are you nervous for today?" she asks, smiling as she stares over the training field. "You have a lot fewer students than usual! Don't tell me you expelled an entire class again."

Aizawa says nothing.

"Please date me."

"Shut up."

She laughs again. "I hope your limited students can hold up! I wouldn't want Ketsubutsu Academy to show up the infamous UA High."

Aizawa folds his arms over his chest. "My students will succeed just as well as they allow themselves."

Ms.Joke hums, sits back in her seat. "I heard you got your hands on that vigilante."

Fucking hell, that's gotten out already? He's done his best to keep it under wraps. Even the grown adults in this line of work gossip like children; he has almost forgotten that. There's a high chance that Midnight was the one who spilled the information, always eager to one-up her rivalry with Ketsubutsu Academy. That school could've gotten access to the vigilante if they'd lifted their Quirkless ban, but you snooze, you lose, and what a loss it was.

Aizawa doesn't entertain her with a response, nervous about the exam despite his inability to show it. It's not that he doesn't think his kids will succeed; it's that he fears they'll do it by any means necessary. Midoriya's presence in the class has changed the dynamic completely. The students have turned brutal, for lack of a better word. Their combat has increased tenfold, and their attack methods are pristine and fluid. Midoriya has been training most of them outside of class hours, building friendships and bonds just as Aizawa had wanted him to.

Even better, he seems to be getting along with Shinso again. There are a few odd interactions with him and other students, like Todoroki or Bakugou, but Aizawa couldn't have gotten a better result if he tried.

Now, if he could just get the kid to attend his damn counseling sessions. He had assigned Midoriya a unique therapist who specializes in troubled youth, and she's reported that Midoriya has shown up to a total of zero sessions. Aizawa knows the kid didn't forget about them; he just can't convince the problem child to go. He'll purposely schedule training

sessions with peers or tutoring groups with other students instead, knowing damn well that Aizawa won't interrupt the bonds the kid is forming.

It's manipulative. Aizawa is well aware of it. Midoriya is smart, and he knows exactly how to play his peers with ease. There's no doubt in his mind that Midoriya cares for them, but he definitely knows how to use that care to his advantage. Uraraka is dying to know how to develop skills in hand-to-hand combat, so Midoriya makes sure to give her what she wants. He helps her improve while keeping himself from throat sessions. It works like that with all his classmates. Shinso and him work with support weapons, Ashido works with him on flexibility through dance, Kaminari focuses on prolonged use of his Quirk and snapping out of the mental state he gets into.

Manipulative yet caring. If that doesn't describe the vigilante, Aizawa isn't sure what does—

"You're… kidding." Ms.Joke stands up, peers at the large room that all students who finish the exam enter. "How is that possible?!"

Midoriya has finished it already. Not even ten minutes in, and he's the first one done. Aizawa can't help the grin on his face.

"Ha!" Ms.Joke points, "There's one of my kids. Maybe not the first, but second place is amazing for her!"

Aizawa isn't sure who the girl is that follows after Midoriya. She's in a black jumpsuit, curly brown hair sliding over her shoulders. She follows Midoriya into the building, skipping and doing cartwheels. The kid doesn't even notice her trailing after.

He turns his attention to the rest of the field. "We'll see who passes and who doesn't soon."

Ms.Joke laughs. "I never thought I'd see a day when you liked one of your classes."

Aizawa says flatly, "I don't." And sips coffee from his special cat mug.

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This room is empty. He's not sure why everyone else is taking their sweet time. He had finished the exam relatively quickly. Then again, nobody is really expecting to be taken out so effectively. He could've sworn Uraraka was right behind him, but she's nowhere to be found.

It's just him in here.

And this other girl, he supposes. She smiles at him, wiggles her fingers. He gives her a tight-lipped smile and looks away.

She approaches anyway, giggling a little. “Hello!”

“Hi.” He stares at her hat. “Are you from Ketsubutsu Academy?”

“Oh." She looks at her uniform. “I think she is!”

Midoriya blinks slowly. “She…?”

Her eyes are a bright, slitted yellow. Her canines are pointed, sharp, and Midoriya suddenly places that finger wave.

“Himiko?”

“I knew you’d remember!" She giggles, spinning. “Do you like my new skin? Her blood was so sweet!”

Midoriya’s eye twitches. “How did you… what…”

“Don’t worry, the chick’s okay,” Himiko waves a hand, and it’s surreal to hear her talk from an entirely different body and with an entirely different voice. “I’m just here on strict orders from the boss!”

“Tenko?” he asks.

She winks. “Bingo! I’ve collected so much blood! And, I get to come see you.”

“Great,” he grits out, peering around the room. “Did you want something?”

Himiko pouts. “You didn’t miss me?”

“I wasn’t aware I was supposed to?” Midoriya replies. “Aren’t you a little young to be sent on solo missions?”

She crosses her arms over her chest, her bottom lip puffed out. “I just turned fourteen in August!”

“Uh huh…”

“Oh well,” she frowns deeply. “I’m just here to give you a message from Tomura. He’s not very happy that you’re ignoring him. I’ll be sure to tell him that you have your arm back, though I’m not too sure how.”

Midoriya isn’t really sure he should be talking to her like this. “What does he want?”

“To talk,” she says sweetly. “You never told me you were brothers!”

Uh oh. “How much has he told you?”

“Plenty,” she says with a wink, “Plenty more than you, at least.”

“Himiko—“

“Do you not like me anymore?” she says with a frown. “I showed you my Minecraft world.”

What is he meant to say to that? He’s got a dozen questions in his head, the main one being how the hell she knew he would be here today. Following that is a flurry of questions about Tenko. He hates to admit it, but… but he’s begun to care for his brother. It’s awful, and one of the worst things he’s had to come to terms with thus far, but it’s completely true. More and more students begin to fill the room.

He’s dedicated his life to protecting Mama, his only family, and now that it's expanded, he isn't too sure what to make of it. Tenko has been reaching out, too, asking him bizarre questions and telling him pointless information. Like how he loves League of Legends, how he met Spinner through the game. How he found Dabi and Himiko at the same time. They’d been taking care of each other; it seems that Dabi can’t help but be an older brother, no matter who it’s for. How Dad had interfered with his life since before his creation, killing the man who birthed his sister and contorting his body to look like him. It was the most gruesome thing Midoriya had ever read. How he assumed that Tenko’s life was privileged, but it seems his brother never had a moment that was truly his.

Midoriya stares at her, unable to really find the words inside of him to explain all that’s been happening. Eri woke up, and she hasn’t said a single word since that moment. She doesn’t talk, she barely responds, she just sits in bed eating and watching kids' cartoons. Bakugou has been acting weird. Always keeping one eye trained on Deku at all times, watching him as Deku watches him. Shinso is back to being his friend, but there’s a small bit of conversation they avoid talking about.

And he’s not sure where his brother fits into this bizarre new life that Midoriya’s made for himself.

“You’re green,” Himiko comments, smiling with a face that isn’t hers. “I miss the red eyes and black hair, but I understand needing to change your appearance.”

“How’d you know I was here?” he asks, his voice a whisper. “Tenko sent you?”

“Rumors fly, you know,” she warns him. “The girl’s body I’m in—she told me that UA took on the vigilante. She heard it from a teacher. It wasn’t hard to connect that to you. Tomura’s flattered that you didn’t sell him out, by the way.”

Midoriya feels lightheaded. “I’ve taken a break from this vigilante stuff, okay? If I get caught again—“

“Then don’t get caught.” Himiko shrugs, twirling a long strand of brown hair. “This isn’t a life you can escape, you know. It doesn’t just go away, Viridant.”

“I know that.” But it was nice. It was different, being a UA student, straying away from this part of his life. This is what would’ve been had he gotten into UA in the first place. And

maybe he was relishing in that far more than he wanted to admit.

“I’m only a messenger,” Himiko says, smiling sweetly at him. “But this messenger doesn’t want to watch you die. And, unfortunately, Tomura isn’t a very patient person. He’s got your fake name now, you know. One word to All for One, and this new life of yours goes bye-bye.”

His blood runs cold. “I thought he was on my side?”

“He is,” Himiko says softly. “But he knows you're not on his.”

God dammit. “So that’s it? This is my warning before he sells me out?”

“I’m not sure what he’ll do. You’ve changed some plans he’s had hammered out for years. You’re our wildcard!” She wraps her arms around herself, smiling. “This would be such a good love story for us! A Hero and a Villain, sworn enemies to lovers.”

“Just,” Midoriya pinches his brow. “Tell him not to do anything stupid. I’ll contact him soon, okay?”

“Okay!” she cheers, clasping her hands together. “Can I get a kiss goodbye?”

“No.”

She pouts. “A hug?”

Midoriya glances at the new people funneling into the room. It’s beginning to get more and more crowded, and a few 1-A kids have been giving him and Himiko curious glances.

“Fine, but only if you tell Tenko exactly what I said.” He says.

“I pinky promise!” And she throws herself at him, wrapping her arms around him and squealing so loud that people look over immediately. “You smell so good. Almost as good as your blood taste! Type O is my favorite, you know.”

He pats her back, beyond uncomfortable. “That’s… great.”

“Oh,” she pulls back, giddy. “I forgot to mention. Kai Chisaki. He goes by Overhaul. I think you kidnapped his kid or something? I don’t know, I wasn’t really paying attention to what Tomura said. Anyway, he put a death bounty on your head.”

Midoriya goes pale. “What?”

“Yup!” She snickers, pulling away. “Bye, cutie!”

Himiko disappears into a crowd of students, leaving him stunned. When he looks around, he sees Sero and Kaminari both giving him looks that he doesn’t really understand. Shinso has the same look on his face, though, and that’s when Midoriya can place the utter confusion and disbelief. He had forgotten that Himiko looked like a random girl from another school, and she had just latched onto him in a hug before sprinting away.

Great, he can't wait to explain that one.

When the whole ordeal is finally over, and he's given his provisional license, he immediately finds Aizawa-Sensei. He doesn't even get a word out before his teacher all but runs away from the woman he's standing with to come talk to Midoriya instead. Present Mic is red in the face from laughing.

"I passed," Midoriya says, flashing his card. "See?"

Aizawa huffs. "Was that so hard?"

"A little—"

"Young Midoriya," All Might, bulked out and smiling, appears. Several students who also took the test from other schools began gasping and taking photos. They're smiling widely, beyond overjoyed to see the number one Hero in broad daylight.

Midoriya's happy too. "Yes?"

"Can I borrow you for a moment, young man?"

His smile widens. "Absolutely!" He excuses himself from Aizawa-Sensei, following All Might with the biggest grin on his face.

He's been playing his cards very carefully at UA. Every time All Might watches or participates in the Heroics course, Midoriya makes sure to put on a show. Flashy moves, quick thinking, efficient movements. It helps that he's taken a liking to Mama, too. Though Midoriya doubts she's interested in All Might for the same reason he is. Still, it helps.

Especially when All Might deflates to his natural form, and that smile still holds on his face. "I wanted to talk to you about something."

Midoriya holds down his excitement. "What could it be?"

He knows *exactly* what it is. He's purposely given cookies to faculty meetings, written essays on All Might and why his symbolism is important to Hero work. He's been planning this shit since he was forced to attend this school.

He wants that fucking Quirk. And he gets what he wants.

"Well," All Might says, clapping his hands together. "As I'm sure you know and have figured out, I am in need of a successor."

He feigns curiosity. "Oh?"

"See," All Might starts, and Midoriya has to stop himself from bouncing. "My Quirk—I inherited it from a long line of predecessors. Becoming the symbol of peace was not an easy choice, but a necessary one. This Quirk can be passed down, and I have waited a long time to find the right person to give it to."

Midoriya is trembling. “What do you mean?”

“Midoriya Izuku,” he says, his eyes gleaming. “You have the heart of a Hero. Your sense of justice, your morals, I truly believe that you will become a Hero who fights for what is right. And so I’d like to ask you to join me in my fight against the evil of this world.”

He holds a hand out, and color dances off his palm. It’s unlike anything Midoriya has ever seen. Flashes of beautiful colors, a lineage of a Quirk, passed from successor to successor. Strengthened over time, a bond curated from the spilled blood of another.

All Might bows his head. “Will you inherit One for All?”

Midoriya grins, his smile so wide that it nearly takes up his entire face. “I’d be honored.”

Chapter End Notes

:p

Chapter 45: Diagnosis

Chapter Summary

Bakugou goes to therapy

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Yazmin drums her dark fingers on her notepad, watching him with kind eyes. Her Quirk allows her to see which knee-jerk emotions are evoked in response to a question. It's an absolute pain in the ass to deal with. Even worse, she's well aware of Bakugou's feelings about whatever question she asks, and she'll still spend an entire session trying to get him to confess what the emotion is. If she knows it, then why the fuck does it matter what he thinks he feels?

She just likes to fucking torment him, he thinks.

"So, how do you feel about your result in the provisional licensing exam?"

Bakugou gives her a blank look. "How the fuck do you think I feel, Shrinkie?"

"I've told you I'm not comfortable with 'Shrinkie'. I'm not a shrink, I'm a licensed therapist," Yazmin corrects.

Bakugou says, "Shrinkie."

"I can see that the result of the exam has caused some distress," she says, tucking a strand of course hair behind her glasses. "Why do you think this causes you such discomfort?"

"I failed the exam to get a Hero license. Let's use our critical thinking skills here," Bakugou spits, arms crossed over his chest. "Do you think I feel happy, or do you think I feel sad?"

Yazmin presses her lips into a thin line. "Alright, let's change methods."

Bakugou rolls his eyes.

"Blue." She stares at him, watches his brows furrow. "Yellow."

"Fucking green," Bakugou says, "Are we naming colors now?"

"Did you say green because the color reminds you of Izuku Midoriya?" Yazmin questions, and it's such a change of conversation that he feels like she socked him the balls. "Oh, that was a strong emotional reaction."

Bakugou grits his teeth. “How did you get that from colors?”

“Sigmund Freud believed in a method of psychology called Free Association,” Yazmin answers, “the idea is that the client says whatever comes to mind without being prompted. I decided to alter that by adding a stimulus to evoke a reaction out of you.” She smiles at him. “So, Izuku Midoriya?”

Bakugou sneers, “None of your fucking business.”

“Your teacher informed me of your relationship with a vigilante who is now a student at UA,” Yazmin says, "From my understanding, this situation is a complicated one. And it’s a topic you’ve avoided time and time again.” She crosses her legs, pencil skirt shifting as she does. “I’m not here to cross any boundaries, and this is one you clearly set. But part of therapy is exposing yourself to vulnerable conversations.”

“I don’t want to talk about fucking Deku,” Bakugou shouts.

“Why not?”

“There’s nothing to talk about!”

She tilts her head, and he’s unsure what fucking emotion she’s gathering from him. He loathes it.

“Okay,” she says, folding her hands, “How about we talk about Viridant?”

Bakugou glares. “That’s the same fucking person.”

“Is it?” she asks, eyes glazed over as she reads his emotional responses. “You have two different reactions to the names I’ve said.”

He glances at the clock, seeing they’ve still got ample time to fucking waste on this bullshit. Yazmin pokes and prods in infuriating ways, getting on his nerves in literal seconds. Still, he knows she’s right. It’s the worst part about therapy. You can’t just go and expect to get better. If you don’t implement the bullshit they try to teach you, then you learn nothing at all.

He *hates* it. Everything else has a solution. Math has a given answer, Heroics has a correct solution, and every single other practice can be easily reached with a conclusion that makes sense. But this bullshit? It’s exhausting. It’s a fucking constant. Every thought has to be reworked, every emotion overanalyzed. It’s not homework that can be set aside and picked up later.

Look what you made me into. Look what you did to me.

“I don’t,” Bakugou says, taking deep breaths to calm himself as practiced. “Feel comfortable discussing this.”

Yazmin smiles. “Great work. You’ve implemented some of the breathing exercises we’ve worked on to set a proper boundary. Can you tell me what about this makes you uncomfortable?”

His knee-jerk reaction is to cuss her out. Instead, he takes another breath, tries to place why his first reaction to that question is anger.

“It makes me feel…” he starts, searching for the mental image of that stupid fucking emotion wheel she sent him months ago. “Defeated.”

Yazmin nods. “And defeat isn’t an emotion you enjoy. It makes you uncomfortable when you can’t succeed at something, even if it’s something as small as, let’s say, a plan changing last minute.”

Bakugou huffs. “Sure.”

“Okay, let’s try an exercise,” she says, placing her notepad on a low-rise table. “I’ll ask you a question or give you a prompt, and you tell me how defeated it makes you feel on a scale of one to ten. One is that it has no effect at all, ten is that it is a blinding amount of defeat.”

“Fine.”

“Okay.” Yazmin folds her hands once again, her maroon nail polish pristine. “You made plans a week in advance to get chores done on a Sunday, then when Sunday comes around, suddenly you are asked to do them on Monday.”

Bakugou’s eye twitches. “I don’t do my chores on Sunday.”

“Hypothetically.”

“I do them on Wednesday,” Bakugou informs her. “Every Wednesday, they’re always done by seven.”

Yazmin says, “Okay, let’s say someone asks you to do them on Thursday.”

Bakugou says, “10.”

Yazmin nods. “Okay. Now let’s say you’ve just taken a shower, and then you’re asked to go for a run.”

“I run before my showers,” Bakugou argues.

Yazmin presses her lips into a line. “Hypothetically.”

He bounces his leg. “10.”

She pauses for a moment before she asks, her brows furrowed, “Do you always feel… defeated when something deviates from your schedule?”

“No shit.”

“And when you’ve set a goal, and you don’t achieve it on time or in a particular way?”

“10. I fucking hate it.”

Yazmin hums. “Watch the face I make.”

Bakugou does, eyes narrowed. Her lips pull into a frown, her eyebrows crease, her eyes squint.

“What emotion was that?” she asks.

“Sadness?” he guesses.

“Okay. Now this.” She smiles, but her eyes don’t crinkle. “What emotion?”

“Uhh…” his leg bounces again. “Happy?”

Yazmin purses her lips. “Stay here.” She gets up, exits the room, and then comes back after a few minutes with a few sheets of paper. “Could you fill this out for me?”

He takes the sheets, eyeing them. “Is this some psychology test shit?”

“Just take it,” she says sweetly, handing him her pen.

“What’s this scored out of?” he asks, flipping through the pages.

“It’s not a score, it’s more of a personality test.”

Bakugou scoffs, looks at the first question:

“I prefer to do things with others rather than on my own.” He marks strongly disagree.

The next:

“I enjoy social chit-chat.” Strongly disagree.

Another:

“I am often told I am rude when I speak.” Strongly agree.

Again:

“I notice patterns or numbers very quickly.” Strongly agree.

He keeps going, marking absolutes each time. There are a lot of questions pertaining to social interactions, which only serve to frustrate him. Questions about his sense of justice, about his daily routines. One question is similar to what Yazmin asked him, about how much he sticks to his daily routines, and it’s an easy answer. Bakugou plans each day out to the exact time, and he gets things done in that order. Deviation from this norm is frustrating, and as this test asks, he often gets so frustrated or overwhelmed by these things that he lashes out or needs to take a shower or do *something.* Usually, it’s picking a fight, beating the shit out of someone. Shitty Hair has been his top pick since he can withstand explosions, but Bakugou would rather wear himself out with exhaustion than let Kirishima win in a fight.

When he hands Yazmin his test results, she reviews them with a blank face.

“We’ve tried a lot of medications for you,” she says, and Bakugou again rolls his eyes. “My first thought was intermittent explosive disorder or EDS.”

Bakugou clicks his tongue. “I know, I’ve been taking the damn mood stabilizers.” And she had called it a ‘breakthrough’ when he finally agreed to testing and medication.

“We’ve tried Prozac for potential OCD, Lexapro for anxiety,” she leans back in her seat. “And every time we do a medication check-in, you report that you often don’t feel much different, correct?”

“Yes?” he says, and that sense of frustration builds, the defeat low in his gut. “Only the stupid breathing shit helps.”

“And separating yourself from noise or stimulating environments,” she says, and Bakugou nods. “Well, as both a clinical psychologist and psychiatrist, I think I had you pegged wrong from the beginning. I imagine it’s been frustrating to take medication that doesn’t seem to be working?”

“Obviously.”

“Bakugou, how do you feel about people touching you? Germs?” she asks.

He shrugs. “It’s annoying most of the time.”

“Certain textures or sounds?”

“Some are fine, I guess,” like Deku’s hair, but only when freshly washed. Or bedsheets. “Others are fucking grating.” Like concrete, he fucking hates touching concrete. Or metal. “Any loud sounds are fucking irritating, but it comes with the Quirk, so who gives a shit?”

“And this goal you have to be a Hero,” she says, leaning forward. “Have you ever deviated from it?”

“No.”

“No other career you would’ve wanted?”

“No. It’s this. It’s always been this. It’s all I think about.”

Yazmin nods, leans back. “I think I was wrong about your diagnosis.”

“Okay,” Bakugou says, though that frustration builds again. “Then what the fuck is it?”

Yazmin smiles reassuringly. “I’ll need to run more tests first.”

“Great, I love not knowing shit that you dangle in front of my fucking face,” he snips.

“Do you often feel like being lied to or deceived is one of the worst possible things someone could do?” she asks again.

Bakugou huffs. “It is.”

“And the law—how strict are you on following it?”

He’d only broken it once, and it was to save Deku. And he was so pent up over the entire situation that he sobbed for the first time in years out of pure frustration.

“I don’t like breaking the law,” he says, but that’s just common sense.

“You’ve got a strong sense of justice, you’ve got a strict routine, you have your entire life planned out, and if things interfere with it, it causes you anger or frustration. You lash out, or you separate from others. And simple things to others, like going to hang out or having conversations, you don’t catch on to social cues like they do, right?” Yazmin asks, and Bakugou can’t meet her eyes. “But you’ve taught yourself how to read expressions, which is why when I looked disgusted, you saw my smile and assumed I must be happy.”

“So?”

“So,” she pulls out some photos from her filing cabinets, lays them flat. “Tell me each emotion that you think these people are feeling.”

Some of them are easy. Eyebrows raised, mouth open, eyes wide, that’s shock. Others are… not easy. Furrowed brows, smile, squinted eyes. He doesn’t know what they’re doing. He tells her such, and she takes notes. They go the entire session, asking bizarre questions and presenting situations. When it’s finally over, she tells him outright.

“I think you have autism.”

Bakugou blinks slowly. “What the fuck are you talking about?”

“I think you have autism,” she says again, tapping her pen against her notebook. “High functioning autism.”

“How do you cure that?”

“You can’t.”

He stares at her. “Then… then what? I’m fucking stuck like this?”

“Therapy and support groups can help you regulate—“

“I don’t want to fucking regulate!” he shouts, palms spasming. “I’m here so you can fix whatever is wrong. You’re telling me there’s no fix?”

Yazmin holds her hands up. “Deep breaths.”

“No, no, fuck you!” He stands, hands clenched into fists. “Fucking autism? Really?”

“Did the meds work?”

He shakes. “No.”

“It’s because autism can’t be treated with medicine. In some cases, it can prove to regulate emotions, but most instances of high functioning autism don’t have a form of regulation that doesn’t come from years of therapy or in-person treatment,” Yazmin informs him, her response perfectly clear. “There’s nothing wrong with you—“

“If there was nothing wrong, then you’d say I’m *normal.* Not *autistic.* I can’t be autistic. What Heroes do you know that are autistic?” Bakugou looks at the clock; a few minutes are still left in the session. And despite how badly he wants to leave, he can’t break the schedule. “I’m top of my class, I’m disciplined. I’m not fucking—“ he cuts himself off, runs a hand through his hair.

“You are normal,” she says softly, “There’s nothing wrong with being on the spectrum. It doesn’t make you any less than your peers; this isn’t something that is meant to isolate you. It’s a diagnosis that’s supposed to help professionals work with you on your mental health, not to separate you from your peers.”

Bakugou shakes his head. “You haven’t tested for anything else yet.”

Yazmin says, “Like what?”

“Fucking *anything,”* he seethes, smoke swirling from his palms. “Maybe it’s one of the other thousands of fucking mental disorders—you haven’t even checked. I’ll try other meds.”

“Bakugou—“

“I *can’t,”* he says, frustration boiling over. “I can’t just sit here and be told that there’s no fix for this, Yazmin. I can’t feel like this every day—that’s not fair. Why does everyone else get meds and quick fixes? You’re telling me I’m stuck like this?”

Her face is soft, gentle, and he can’t tell what emotion she’s feeling. “With regular sessions —“

“I DON’T WANT REGULAR SESSIONS,” he screams, trying to get it in her fucking head. “I want to wake up and not feel like I’m going to fucking explode! I want to—I want to stop being angry. I don’t want to be angry anymore. Every single thing just adds up more and more until I lose my shit and hurt someone—I don’t want to be this.”

Yazmin says, “Let’s talk more about this diagnosis. We can explore plans for the future. I know it’s not ideal, but it’s what we’re working with. This isn’t an easy diagnosis to hear. I should’ve waited for a more opportune moment. But I know you value honesty and transparency, so I acted with your best interests.”

Bakugou looks at the clock. The time's up, and he rushes for the door. Yazmin shouts something after him, but the clock reached its end time. He doesn’t need to stay anymore. He can have two hours of slotted free time before the next task, and even thinking about his perfectly procured schedule begins to drive him insane.

He needs a release; he needs to win something. He’s already lost everything. Deku, Viridant, his license, his fucking mind, apparently. He hasn't been sleeping, hasn't been eating. Paranoia has been following him around like a fucking shadow. Deku has been occupying every thought and driving him to the brink of fucking insanity. The last thing he needed was another shitty therapy session, especially not one following the failure of the god damn exam!

Autism. Fucking autism.

“Yo, Bakubro!” Kirishima waves when Bakugou enters the common room. “Hey, man—“

Bakugou grabs him by his wrist, drags him outside. Kirishima doesn’t complain, waving bye to whatever extra was in the room as he’s dragged from the building.

“I figured since it was after therapy, you’d want to fire off some shots at me!” Kirishima says cheerfully, “You always stick to your schedule, huh?”

“No,” he says, shoving Kirishima into the nearest training room.

Not a second passes before he fires off an explosion. Kirishima takes it in stride, his regular clothes singing and catching ablaze. It changes nothing; Bakugou keeps going. Rapid fire, blow after blow, until he can tackle him down and beat his face in. The idiot's Quirk makes him a fucking shield, an impenetrable wall, and Bakugou doesn't stop until one of them breaks.

Kirishima fights back, too, an opponent who matches Bakugou in stride. Punches, kicks, hooks, explosions, cuts, and scrapes. He’s amped up, and when Kirishima breaks his nose, he still doesn’t stop.

He thinks of Deku. Of how they had fought in the middle school halls, and Bakugou was so thrown off that he nearly died from it. Maybe it was because it broke the routine of who he thought Deku was, or maybe it was because for just a moment, Deku looked down at him like he was worth thinking about. And he hated him, wanted him dead, but just the idea that Bakugou had crossed his mind at all was enough.

Kirishima grabs his palms, folds their fingers together, and takes every explosion Bakugou melts at him. No matter the power, the heat, the idiot endures it.

“Hey,” he says, “Are you okay?”

Bakugou screams, and it’s no words in particular. Just a loud, anguished sound, before more fuel pumps out of him. Fire and heat and rage and smoke. He can’t stop it, his Quirk expanding and pinpointing. Kirishima grits his teeth, hardening until the pain stops touching him. And it’s nice, being able to unleash the worst parts of himself and cause no pain when that’s all he’s ever done until now.

He doesn’t realize he’s crying until Kirishima calls for a timeout.

“Bakugou, dude, what’s wrong?” Kirishima tries to grasp his shoulder, and Bakugou shrugs him off.

“Again, let's go again.”

“No,” Kirishima says, trying to meet Bakugou’s eyes. “I don’t care if you cry, bro. I still think you’re manly. Shit, I cry all the time.”

“I’m not fucking crying!” Bakugou shouts. “Let’s go again!”

Kirishima blows out a puff of air. “Okay, let’s go.”

Heat, anger, and Kirishima endures it all. Bakugou blasts him across the room, throws him into the walls, and Kirishima takes it. He screams, punches and kicks like a fucking child. Kirishima bears it. And only when he gets him pinned down, his hand pressed against sweaty skin and not solid rock, does he stop.

He won. He won.

He won.

He hits the floor, sits on the ground panting. Kirishima wobbles to his side. He maintained no injuries, but the exhaustion still wears on him. They sit there, on the floor of a random training facility, panting and huffing.

“Geez,” Kirishima coughs out, “You kicked my ass.”

“I won,” Bakugou says, mouth full of saliva. “I beat you.”

“Yeah.” Kirishima claps his back, and Bakugou cringes but doesn’t move away. “What’s going on, bro? Just needed to let off steam?”

“Yeah.”

“Shit, man, I get it,” he says, grabbing for his water. “You’re gonna kick ass in those remedial courses if you fight like that.”

“Yeah,” Bakugou nods. “I will.”

Kirishima wipes the water off his mouth that spilled. He hands Bakugou the bottle, who tips his head back and squeezes the water from the bottle.

“So,” Kirishima pants, palms flat on the ground behind him. “What’s going on?”

Bakugou doesn’t know why he tells him, but he does. “Autism.”

“Oof,” Kirishima knocks their shoulders. “That’s alright. We all got something, y’know?”

He doesn’t look at him, still panting. “What do you got?”

“Anxiety,” Kirishima says, laughing at the look he gets. “You wouldn’t think, right? Nah, I’m all fucked in the head. My moms think it started in middle school.”

Bakugou nods. “Fuck middle school.”

“Dude, *fuck* middle school.” Kirishima stands, offers a hand. Bakugou takes it. “Don’t worry about the autism, man. Changes nothing.”

“Don’t tell anyone,” he says, glancing around to ensure they're alone.

“I won’t,” Kirishima assures him. “Midoriya and Uraraka were in here for a bit, but they left pretty early on. So no one saw anything.”

Bakugou huffs. “What’s he doing with Round Face?”

Kirishima shrugs. “I think she’s got a thing for him. Midoriya is clueless, poor guy. But Sero’s pissed because Mido apparently draws in hella girls. Melissa, Uraraka, Camie, and she doesn’t even go to this school.”

Bakugou shakes his head. “Fucking fantastic.”

“He asked about you the other day.”

He turns, starts to leave. Kirishima follows. “What did he say?”

“Wanted to know how you were holding up after the provisional license exam. You guys have known each other since you were kids, yeah?”

“Yeah.”

“Huh,” Kirishima holds the dorm door open. “That’s weird.”

“What’s fucking weird?”

Kirishima goes for the showers while Bakugou goes for the stairs. Still, he answers before he slips into the bathroom. “He said that he was the one who got you out of the exam.”

Bakugou stares after the idiot even when the doors shut. A lot of his exam was spent getting his ass saved by Shitty Hair and Pikachu. It was humiliating, but unfortunately fucking true. He had assumed his three targets on his body had been hit while he had been under attack from this stupid potato-making motherfucker.

But Deku was the one to do it?

Fucking *Deku?*

He was one of the first ones to finish. Bakugou was one of the first ones to get out. He had asked him, months ago, in that alleyway in Chou City, he’d asked Deku if he’d really ruin Bakugou’s career.

And that motherfucker *did.*

Bakugou feels that anger, that rage, and he can’t stop himself from pounding on Deku’s fucking door.

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 46: Ground Beta

Chapter Summary

Bakugou and Midoriya battle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya jolts, whipping around to face his dorm door. It shakes, and he can hear someone hammering on it through his headphones. He tugs them out of his ears, sets his homework atop his desk, and stares at the shaking wood. Did Hitoshi forget something?

More pounding, it sounds like someone is trying to break it down. He could've sworn Hitoshi didn't leave any pot behind. Why the hell is he so eager to get in?

He grasps the handle, tugs it open—

Hot hands grab the collar of his shirt. Midoriya doesn't have a moment to shout before he's shoved backwards. The door shuts automatically, and he's slammed onto his desk. His back touches the upper wall, his legs dangling off the surface. His homework is wrinkled, pens and pencils and books scattered to the floor. And standing between his legs, still gripping his collar, is Bakugou.

"You," he says, palms smoking. "What the hell are you doing to me?"

Midoriya's heart beats in his throat. He grabs Bakugou's hands, tries to pry them off. It makes no difference.

"I'm losing sleep over you," Bakugou says, his voice worn and hysterical. "I'm going out of my *damn mind.* I can't think, I can't function." His eyes are wide, red-rimmed and bloodshot. "Because of fucking *you."*

Midoriya grits his teeth. "Let go of me."

Bakugou laughs in his face, grips his shoulder and neck, and throws him to the floor from the desk. Midoriya rolls, thuds against the other wall.

"Put your fucking shoes on," Bakugou says, tearing off his UA coat. He looks worse for wear, covered in scrapes and bruises, likely from his earlier fight with Kirishima.

Midoriya watches him rip the buttons off his uniform shirt, peel the top off. It reveals a black tank top beneath, and he waits for him to remove that next. When he doesn't, his face flushes, and he grabs his shoes to avoid looking at Bakugou.

“What is this about?” He slips one on, then the other. “I didn’t do anything—“

Bakugou grabs him by the back of his neck, rips him off the floor. Midoriya stumbles along, cussing. He’s already showered and slipped into his lounge clothes. He hadn’t planned for a run-in with Bakugou, let alone a violent one. Bakugou snatches the green and black support scarf from his wall, ignoring his obvious disdain for it.

The dorms are quiet, lights dimmed, most people heading to bed. Bakugou should be getting ready for bed too, but he’s deviating from his norm, dragging Midoriya through the halls.

“I can walk!” Midoriya shouts, and Bakugou shoves him forward. “What is your problem?”

“Walk.” His voice is a demand, his eyes clouded and dark. “Follow me.”

“Where?”

“Follow. Me.”

Midoriya does, slowly trailing as Bakugou leads the way. He’s not sure where in the world he’s being led, but he’s too nervous to leave this alone. Bakugou doesn’t look like himself, and considering Midoriya knows each one of his moods in excruciating detail, he’s unused to not being able to pin one.

They appear at Ground Beta.

Bakugou throws him the scarf, bends down, and stretches his legs out.

Midoriya holds it in his hands, looking around. It’s dark out, nobody is around. Winter is ending soon, spring begging to leak in, but it’s still freezing outside. He’s only in his shorts and a t-shirt, while Bakugou has a black wife-beater and sweats on.

He stands, stares him down as he stretches either one of his arms. “We’re settling this, right here, right now.”

Midoriya swallows. “What? You really want to do this?”

Bakugou doesn’t look away, tilting his neck side to side. “If you don’t want to get hurt, then punch back. But I guess you’ve switched to using kicks more these days. Didn’t you?”

“Come on, stop,” Midoriya retreats backwards. He can’t have Bakugou risking his career at UA. Aizawa-Sensei will kill him if he gets into any trouble. “This isn’t smart—“

Bakugou launches forward with an explosion. His right arm swings up, and Midoriya is certain it's a faint. Bakugou always swings right; he wouldn’t risk it now—

The blast comes from his right palm, and Midoriya barely swings away in time. Still, the hair on his legs and arms singes, smoke threatening him.

“You know your problem? You always overthink things,” Bakugou turns to him, watches him soar through the air. “Just fucking fight me!”

“You’re serious?” Midoroya says as he blasts into the air again. “You want a spar?”

He ducks under the answering explosion. Buildings shake, glass shatters. The two of them pass each other by in mere inches. Midoriya crashes against the ground below, taking the blow against his shoulder. Pain roars in his muscles, and Bakugou lands feet away from him.

“Why do you solve everything with violence?” Midoriya shouts at him, “Wait! Let’s just talk —“

Bakugou launches into the air, blasts an explosion at him. Midoriya narrowly misses it again, rolling across the floor.

“I told you to wait!” But Bakugou doesn’t stop.

Another explosion, and he slams against the side of a building. His head spins without his gear, and he uses his scarf again to swing away before another blast hits him. Bakugou gives chase, blasting shot after shot.

“Why?” Bakugou shouts at him. Midoroya ducks under another blow, evading. “Why?” He manages to grab Bakugou mid-air, place his hands on his shoulders—

Bakugou jerks his leg high, kicks Midoriya from underneath the chin. Blood pours into his mouth, and he’s again thrown back and onto the floor.

“Why?” Bakugou yells at him.

Another blast down to him, and Midoriya pushes off the floor with his hands, bending backwards and kicking up again in a back handspring. He barely misses the crackling sparks heading towards him.

Bakugou screams. “WHY?” And he falls backwards, tripping over his own feet. “Tell me!”

He hits the floor, scraping against the pavement. Midoriya stays still, panting from yards away.

“Why can’t you just get out of my head?” Bakugou says, his voice breaking.

Cold air leaks in, a breeze whips at them.

“How did someone like you get so far ahead of me?” he asks, and Midoriya sees tears in his eyes. “Everyone loves you—All Might offered you his power.”

Midoriya’s eyes widen. He didn’t know Bakugou was listening in on that.

“You were stuck to me, I couldn’t fucking get rid of you!” he screams from the floor, his chest rising and falling unevenly. “And then one day it all changes, you change. And maybe it was all under the surface this whole damn time—but why am I the last to find out?”

Bakugou pushes off the ground, hunches forward.

“I can’t get it out of my head!” He digs his fingers into his hair, pulls at it. “It’s like it’s constantly playing on fucking loop! I destroyed you. I did this to you. I made you into *this.”*

He grabs the collar of his shirt, meets Midoroya’s eyes with tears streaming down his face.

“I ruined *everything!”*

Midoriya breathes heavily. He aches, his heart beats wildly.

“I ruin—“ Bakugou sobs, looking down at his feet. “I ruin everything.”

He swallows, looking away. “Bakugou—“

“That’s not,” Bakugou says, pointing a shaking, trembling hand. “That’s not what you call me. I hate it. I hate it from your mouth, Deku, I hate it.” He sobs, shoulders shaking. “I hate it. I hate it.”

Midoriya says, “Let’s go back to the dorms.”

“No!” Bakugou grinds out, “Dammit—*fight me.”*

“I won’t!” he argues. “You aren’t in any headspace to fight with me!”

“You did this,” Bakugou snaps at him. “You and your stupid fucking Dad.”

His heart stops beating. “What?”

“You think I don’t know about it?” Bakugou says, swaying on his feet. “About All for One? About how fucking crazy you are? I know—I know all of it.”

“You—“

“I didn’t call the police,” Bakugou says, his voice cracking. “I didn’t do it. I didn’t call them there. I didn't lie to you, I swear to god, I didn’t.” He clenches his fists, prowls closer. “You just want a reason to torment me—that’s what it is. You just want a reason to justify driving me fucking insane.”

Midoriya furrows his brows. “It doesn’t change anything.”

Bakugou laughs, the sound a wheeze, “Then fucking fight me!”

He launches forward again, an explosion readied. Midoriya dodges right, kicks his leg up, and nails Bakugou across the jaw. He stumbles back, and Midoriya holds his fists up.

“I thought we were fighting!” he shouts, and Bakugou’s eyes spark.

He blasts up, spins, aims down for him. A hot hand grabs for his face. Midoriya swings out of the way, but Bakugou meets him in the air without a second thought. He launches another explosion, swings, and punches Midoriya in the stomach hard enough to send him flying into

the railing outside a building. He gets only a moment to catch his breath before grabbing the upper bar and throwing his body over it.

Bakugou lands against it a moment later, fire rattling from his palms. Midoriya avoids him, grunting as he hits the street in a roll while Bakugou slams against the metal rail.

“You’ve gotten…” Midoriya pants, wiping blood off his face. “Stronger. I have too.”

“What the fuck are you smiling about?” Bakugou flies forward, hands cresting a blast so bright that Midoriya can’t see through it. The blow comes to his face a moment later. “It’s one of the things I hate about you!”

Another blast. Midoriya soars upwards to avoid it.

“You think you can keep screwing with me?” Bakugou screams at him, waiting for his landing, chest heaving. “You won’t beat me—I’m not fucking losing! I’m going to be the best fucking Hero! I don’t care if you have All Might!"

Is that seriously what he’s thought this whole time? That he’s ruined everything, that Midoriya has some sick desire to surpass him? To make a fool of him? Someone who has always had so much more going for him—Midoriya had no idea this was going on inside his head.

“All Might might’ve been my Hero,” Midoriya says, running forward. “But you were the one actually in my life!”

He feigns a swing, and when Bakugou raises his arms to block, Midoriya raises his leg and kicks instead.

“That’s the reason I couldn’t leave you alone!” Midoriya shouts, sending Bakugou to the floor.

They separate again, two opposite sides of the road.

“Without meaning to, I’ve started to talk like you!” Midoriya yells, hands up into fists. “I’ve started to think of you with everything I do!”

Bakugou projects himself forward. Midoriya meets him halfway, screaming. He launches his scarf up, spins himself in the air and brings his foot down again. Bakugou barely misses it, sending out an explosion so large that the earth seems to shake. The stars watch them, the moon eager to see more.

Glass shatters, both of them flying backwards from the detonation. He scrapes against the asphalt, blood pouring out of new wounds and scars. The handprints on his forearms burn, ache. He’s up a moment later, launching himself off Bakugou’s recovering form into the air. He’s alone for only a minute before they’re fighting again in the sky. Just the two of them, just as it’s always been.

“You’re the best,” Midoriya screams, slamming his fist against his face. “That’s why I need to beat you! I thought you were incredible.”

Bakugou takes the blow, grabs his shirt collar. “I WON’T LOSE TO YOU!” One swift motion and he’s got them flipped. That cruel, wicked palm faces the open sky, and a final explosion sends them careening to the street below. Midoriya takes the brunt of it, agony rippling along his body.

Balugou’s on top of him, pinning him to the floor below. Smoke unfurls lazily in the air. And Midoriya can hardly breathe. Bakugou’s left leg holds either of his down, his right keeping Midoriya’s left arm stuck to the floor. He grips his wrist with one hand, the other holding his face down.

“I…” Bakugou pants, his body trembling. “*Win.”*

Midoriya coughs, shaking in all limbs. He couldn’t fight back if he wanted to. Bakugou has him entirely subdued.

“How could you lose?” Bakugou asks, chest heaving up and down, blood dripping from his nose. “All Might’s successor, Viridant the vigilante. How could *you* lose?”

His head throbs; still, he forces his eyes open to look up at Bakugou. He’s always been looking up at him. Debris and smoke line the air, but behind Bakugou’s head, the moon shines down like a halo. He looks, well and truly, like an angel.

He honestly fought with his all, and compared to Bakugou, it still wasn’t enough. He pants through the failure, excruciating pain lining his skin.

They stay there for a while, watching each other, breathing heavily.

Then Midoriya rips his arm loose, grabs Kacchan’s head, and kisses him. It *hurts,* even sitting up this much sends fire along his chest, but he does it anyway. Kacchan drops to his elbows atop him, and he tastes like blood and smoke and burnt sugar. This is reckless and stupid and, and—and he kisses him anyway, like he may never taste something so devastating again. They just beat the shit out of each other, covered in soot and dirt, and he can’t seem to stop himself.

“Who the hell,” They break apart as a form comes through the smoke. “Broke curfew?”

Shit. Midoriya shoves Kacchan off him, grunting as he tries and fails to stand up. He’s too late, because Aizawa-Sensei appears through the smoke a moment later. Hair tied into a bun, dressed in all black pyjamas.

“This never happened,” Midoriya hisses, finally getting off the floor.

Kacchan still lies on the ground, a dazed look on his face. “Uh huh..”

A white scarf wraps around them both, yanking them forward. They bounce off each other, avoiding as much eye contact as humanly possible. Kacchan still radiates heat, the caramel scent of skin intoxicating. Midoriya breathes out of his mouth instead.

“Why is it,” Aizawa-Sensei says, his eyes glowing an ominous red. “That whenever something goes wrong, it is *always* you two idiots behind it?”

Midoriya answers before Kacchan can. “Just some late-night training.”

“You destroyed Ground Beta,” Aizawa says flatly, eyeing them. “You caused each other injuries.”

Kacchan doesn’t say a single word, a lopsided grin on his face.

“We’re okay!” Midoriya says quickly. “It won’t happen again, Sensei. I’m sorry.”

“Midoriya.”

“Yes?”

“Is your arm broken?”

Midoriya looks down at it, and what do you know? It is. He must’ve broken it when ripping it out of Kacchan’s grasp. He hadn’t known, too busy using the broken limb to grab his childhood best friend and kiss him senseless. He didn’t even feel the pain of it. He was lost in soft lips and caramel.

“Ah,” Midoriya clears his throat. “How’d… uhh… how’d that happen?”

Aizawa-Sensei takes a deep breath in through his nose. “Who started this?”

“Me.” They both say, then proceed to give the other a withering glare.

“Midoriya, house arrest for three days. Bakugou, you got four,” Aizawa says, yelling in dismay. “I want the entire dormitory spotless. *Spotless.* You will both not be allowed in Heroics courses until then. And I want a written god damn apology for waking me up. For waking *everyone* up.”

“Yes, Sensei,” Midoriya says.

Kacchan blinks slowly. “What happened?”

Oh my god.

Aizawa-Sensei narrows his eyes into slits, looking between the two of them. “I’m not sure what caused this reckless act of pure stupidity, but it’s over now. Is that final?”

“Yes, Sensei,” Midoriya mumbles.

“Mhm,” Kacchan nods, “Whatever.”

“Go to Recovery Girl, Midoriya. She’ll deal with you. And she is *only* allowed to heal your arm. The two of you can heal from all the rest of your injuries naturally, your punishment for this ungodly hour.” Aizawa-Sensei yawns. When neither of them moves, even after he detaches his scarf, he shouts at them to go.

Only then do they detach from each other's sides. Midoriya all but runs to Recovery Girl, leaving Kacchan and Aizawa-Sensei to walk together to the dorms. He needs the time to clear his head anyway, to remind himself of how much of a fucking idiot he is.

That's all it took? Seriously? Kacchan didn't even apologise! He just looked at him with that soft face he always makes right before he does something stupid. And Midoriya didn't even let him do the stupid thing this time! He beat him to it.

"Stupid, stupid, stupid." He hits himself on the forehead. "Why did I do that? What am I meant to do now?"

Recovery Girl is not at all pleased to see him. She heals his arm enough to just barely set the fracture, but still causes him twinges of pain until it fully sets. Then she adjusts the curlers in her hair and goes right back to bed. It's fine. It's a needed punishment for his own stupidity.

He can't do that again. No more kissing Kacchan. What is he going to do if Kacchan tries to get involved in his life again? Letting Hitoshi back in was hard, and letting Kacchan even closer sounds like standing on a landmine. Any shift in weight will kill them both, and this isn't a situation where he can risk losing him.

He thinks of Ito. The hole driven into his neck. The lack of eyes in a socket. And his face flickers, morphs, turns into Kacchan's.

Midoriya can't do it. He can't do this to him. He can't drag him along and risk his life. There are too many people close to him, he can't allow himself to make another mistake. He can't lose anyone else.

But… but it was good. It was nice. It was excruciating and perfect and so undoing that he can't ever let himself risk that again. It was a bad decision—a beyond bad decision.

"How's the arm?"

Midoriya pauses at the top of the dorm stairs. Kacchan is leaning against his door, waiting for him, his arms crossed over his chest.

Midoriya waves it, slivers of pain running along his skin. "Functioning."

"Good." He approaches, steps steady. "We gonna talk about it?"

"Nothing to talk about."

"Sure." Bakugou leans down, captures his lips again. Slow, deliberate. Caramel and smoke, fireworks and stars. "Nothing at all."

Midoriya pushes him back lightly, his hands shaking. "It can't happen again."

"Why fucking not?"

"It just can't," he says, harsh, cruel.

“Is this about the Ground Zero shit?” Kacchan asks, grasping the hand pushing him away. “Is it about your dad?”

“No,” Midoriya says, tugging his hand away. “This is… it’s… I…”

“Come on, give me a reason.” Kacchan steps in space again, grabs his face. “Come on.”

“I-I don’t want you.”

“Try a little harder, Akatani,” he murmurs, “It almost sounded like you meant that.” He kisses him again, and Midoriya can’t stop himself from enjoying it, from chasing the feeling of it. “Come on, tell me you hate me.”

“I do.” But he’s kissing him again, in the quiet halls of UA, he’s kissing him again. “I hate you.”

“I know,” Kacchan says, pulling away. “I’m not leaving you alone, Greenie.”

“This won’t work out—it *can’t.”*

“What are you so afraid of?” he asks him, his voice a whisper. “It’s just me, Akatani.”

Blood, missing eyes, severed limbs. And this time, it’s Midoriya who killed them.

He shoves Bakugou away, removing himself completely from it all. It’s excruciating and agonising, and he does it all anyway. He will not lose anyone else.

“I told you not to call me that,” he snaps, his eyes dark. “I don’t want you.”

Bakugou scoffs. “Right, did you decide that before or after kissing me?”

“Fucking hell, Bakugou, am I not allowed to make mistakes?” he asks. The hurt that flashes on Bakugou’s face makes his chest ache. But it would hurt more if he weren’t here at all. So he shoves that feeling down, hangs onto that familiar anger, that familiar sadness.

“That wasn’t a fucking mistake, don’t sell me that shit,” Bakugou says, gesturing a hand out as though Ground Beta isn’t far from here. “I don’t buy that bullshit, Izuku, I don’t.”

“I’m not gay,” he says, “It was a mistake.”

“It didn’t feel like one,” Bakugou says, hands curled. “What’s wrong, huh? What the hell is wrong?”

He needs a reason. He needs *something.* Bakugou never leaves well enough alone. He never knows when to just give up, when to walk away. Bakugou knows it’s a lie; he knows Midoriya doesn’t mean a word out of his mouth. And if he won’t believe Midoroya’s lies—then he needs to doubt his own mind instead.

“I just wish you were a girl.”

Bakugou moves his mouth, but no words come out.

“You just keep falling short of what I need,” Midoriya says quietly. “I can’t move past what you did to me. And I don’t want this. I don’t want to be with someone that I’ll never stop resenting.”

He grabs his door handle, pushes it open.

“I’m sorry.” Shut.

Slowly, he slides down the wooden panel. He doesn’t cry.

He doesn’t feel anything. He doesn’t allow himself to. There’s too much to do. There’s too much he can’t risk. And maybe this was all a mistake; the two of them wouldn’t have worked anyway. Right? Bakugou—talented, intelligent, amazing, he can’t settle for this. For a kid curled up against the door of his room, half of what he used to be.

He’s got so much work to do. He’s got so much that he can’t risk.

So he doesn’t think about it, about the look on Bakugou’s face. He severs the limb, detaches from whatever part of him hurts the most. And he lies in bed, shuts his eyes.

And he sleeps.

Chapter End Notes

Lmao

Chapter 47: Lights

Chapter Summary

Eri finally speaks.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Kai Chisaki," Aizawa says, using a clicker remote to shift slides on a screen. "Thanks to Midoriya, we have a lead on the Shie Hassaikai yakuza organisation. We've been after these people for years, but could never directly pin them for a crime.

He looks at his student, who sits in a meeting chair, perfectly blank-faced. The location of the abused little girl, Eri, happened to fall in a district where Sir Night Eye's agency was in. Thus, the man himself is seated at this oval table, hands folded and completely composed. A student who is doing a work study beneath him, Mirio, is here too. He's the only one who looks beyond ecstatic for this planned operation. Everyone else is quiet and stoic.

Including Midoriya. The kid just got off house arrest, so maybe he's still pissed at Aizawa for disciplining him. But he's completely withdrawn, gaze vacant. It's unnerving.

"And have we gotten anything out of the girl yet?" Kirishima asks, and Aizawa was not pleased to have him involved in his whole operation.

Unfortunately, Fat Gum also had a nearby agency; therefore, Kirishima will be involved in this plan. It works out, he supposes, because the amount of bullets shot at and into Midoriya tells them that this organisation has gun power. They're heavily armed, lethal, and Aizawa wishes no children had to be dragged into this operation. But he promised Midoriya that any and all things involving the League of Villains would have his full inclusion. And considering they directly contacted only the kid, it was inevitable.

There's another student here, Amajiki, and Aizawa is pissed that this is the first time his students are meeting such devoted and talented third years. He wanted a proper introduction to the whole class, but he was waiting to ensure both Bakugou and Midoriya, arguably his top-ranking students, would be present in class for it.

"No." It's a shock Midoriya piped up, and Aizawa notes he didn't wear his contacts today. Red eyes shift around the room, hollow and vacant. "I plan to talk to her today, see her reaction to the name."

"Let's start there," Sir Night Eye says, hands folded before him. "We've got a general location of where the group is housed. But without a full admittance of abuse without any leading questions—there isn't much we can get them on."

“Kai Chisaki fired his gun at a fifteen-year-old boy, then gathered a handful of gunmen to follow him and do the same,” Fat Gum says, his large body taking up several chairs. “That’s not grounds enough?”

“This organization has funds and has gotten away with low-level crimes before. They can claim self-defense, or tell the courts they were trying to save the little girl from a kidnapper,” Sir Night Eye looks at Midoriya, his gaze hard. “Taking her wasn’t the right call. She put up a struggle against a rescue—she herself could testify against you and gain Chisaki full custody again. You’d lose your license and come out with a record on top of it.”

Midoriya doesn’t say a word; he doesn’t even look at him.

“It was reckless,” he says again, but the kid is a ghost.

What the hell happened to him? Is he nervous to be in the presence of another All Might fan? Maybe Sir Night Eye intimidates him?

“I’ll go talk to Eri,” Midoriya finally stands, Aizawa following. “She can give us an idea of what we’re walking into.”

When they make it to the hall, Aizawa walks by the kid’s side. He keeps his hands in his pockets, staring at the various scars on Midoriya’s hands. Most of his wounds aren’t visible beneath his school uniform, but new marks have appeared in the aftermath of his fight with Bakugou. There’s a nasty cut coming from his chin to halfway up his cheek. A few burns on the back of his hands, too. He doesn’t seem to care about the change in appearance.

Aizawa says, “What’s the problem?”

Midoriya says, voice devoid of any emotion. “Nothing. I didn’t sleep well.”

“You and Bakugou seem to get along after the incident,” Aizawa prompts.

Midoriya nods. “We’re cordial.”

Cordial? “You two will be working together for the rest of your lives as Heroes. Both in school and beyond, so cordial is a good start. Better than animosity, at least.”

Midoriya says nothing to that, eyes straight ahead as they keep walking.

“The league seems to want to maintain contact with you despite your admittance to UA.” He keeps testing different things, trying to evoke a reaction. “How do you feel?”

“Fine.” Zero emotion, detached from reality. “I plan to keep you informed of all movements.”

“Okay, what’s wrong, kid?” Aizawa tugs him to a halt by his elbow. “You’ve been a robot since you’ve been on house arrest. Did Bakugou say something to you?”

Midoriya finally looks at him, red eyes sliding across Aizawa’s face. Thinking, analyzing. He finally understands what Bakugou meant when he said something about this kid was *off*. It’s

not as though he's scary, just unnerving. Todoroki operates in a similar fashion, and Aizawa is certain it's a sign of abuse. What triggered it?

"I want to make sure Eri is alright," Midoriya finally says, tugging himself free. "We need to catch Overhaul."

And that's that. Aizawa gives the kid the space he clearly needs, following after until they stop before Eri's hospital room.

She doesn't want to come out of here, though they've tried to move her to a room more suited for a child. She won't say a word, only curls up on the bed. The few times they've tried to give her real clothes, she's refused them, holding tight to her hospital gown. There's a comfort in the items, Aizawa thinks, though he's uncertain why. She's an enigma, really. Quiet, sad, curled in on herself.

Midoriya enters first, still his stoic self. Aizawa comes in next, takes an open chair across the room from her. She doesn't do too well with people, especially not men. Just the two of them coming into the room has startled her, making her curl into a ball in the corner of the room where her bed sits.

He lets Midoriya take the lead.

"Hello, Eri," he says, and he's completely monotone. "I've come to visit you a few times now, do you remember?"

She eyes him, hiding behind a curtain of hair. Aizawa is certain that Midoriya's complete reality shutdown will scare her, but he keeps quiet for now. He'll stop it if it goes too far.

"We've gotten the name of the man who was taking care of you. Kai Chisaki." Midoriya doesn't fidget, doesn't even offer a smile. "We're going to capture him soon. And he won't be able to hurt you ever again."

She hides her face, a hand covering her small horn.

Aizawa sighs, "She's overwhelmed."

Midoriya nods. "I can try again later—"

"Where is your smile?" They both go still at the small, tiny voice. "You always smile when you come to see me."

Midoriya blinks slowly. "Right—I'm sorry." His lips part, a kind smile blooming. "Better?"

Eri shakes her head. "That's not a real one."

It drops off his face a moment later. Back to the vacancy, a ghost-infested house.

"Are you sad?" she asks, playing with the split ends of her hair.

He takes a moment to answer. "I think so."

“You don’t know?” Eri asks again, her round eyes looking up at him. “Sometimes, I don’t know when I’m sad either.”

Aizawa keeps as quiet as humanly possible. He’d leave to give them privacy, but he’s worried that any sudden movements will send her clamming up again. So he keeps his mouth shut, stays completely still, allows Midoriya to form a bond that no one has yet achieved. And all it took wasn’t reassurance and a promise of safety.

Eri needed to see humanity. She didn’t need to be told she was okay, that she had a new world to live in. She needed to see it for herself, see someone still try to connect with her even when they aren’t doing so good themselves.

“How are you feeling now?” Midoriya asks, devoid of many emotions.

She responds to it better than any act of kindness. “I’m tired. But not tired like I usually am. This new tired makes my body heavy.”

Midoriya nods, slowly approaches her bed. He sits on the end of it, carefully not to touch her or invade her space.

They still aren’t sure what, exactly, happened to this little girl. While her bandages seemed to indicate a few scrapes and bruises, it was the needle scars that were the most concerning. There were no traces of drugs in her system, but those injuries weren't from flu shots or injections. They had to come to the conclusion that her blood was being repeatedly drawn, filtered, put back into her. There was talk of a rape test, but it was shut down without her explicit consent. Still, it’s obvious she hates physical contact. Or is, at least, uncomfortable with it.

Midoriya says, “I’m tired too. My tired feels like… like the world is grey.”

Eri tucks a strand of her hair behind her ear, a sign of openness. “I feel like that sometimes, too.”

“How come?” he asks blankly, and if Aizawa didn’t know any better, he’d say the kid is trying to maintain this facade of detachment. As though he doesn’t want to be part of the world, of reality, of humanity.

“It was all grey,” she says simply, “And then we flew in the air, and everything was so loud and colorful.”

Midoriya hums. “Were you scared?”

“Yes,” she confesses, “I thought I would hurt you.” And she finally looks at Aizawa, her eyes gentle. “And then you made my power stop hurting.”

“Your power can’t hurt anymore,” Midoriya tells her softly.

“It won’t hurt you?” she asks.

And Aizawa realizes they have gotten it all wrong. She's not afraid to be touched; she's afraid to touch *others*.

"Not at all," Midoriya says, before slowly holding his hand out for her.

Eri timidly looks at it, then lays her small palm in his. Aizawa keeps his Quirk ready, his eyes sharpening and flickering. But she doesn't wield hers, too busy gaping at their connected palms.

And she throws herself at Midoriya, wraps her arms around his waist, and cries into his shoulder. Her Quirk flickers to life on pure emotional stimulation, so Aizawa negates it. His hair is tied into a bun, so she won't be able to tell he's even using it. But he gives this little girl the ability to touch someone again, to connect with someone again.

And he thinks, maybe he gave it to Midoriya, too.

The kid wraps his arms around her, his eyes suddenly watering. That wall he built breaks, shatters, and he cries just as Eri does.

"Don't be sad," Eri says to him, holding him tightly. "It's okay."

"That's what I'm supposed to say to you," he says, rocking them back and forth. "These are happy tears."

"You cry when you're happy?" she asks, pulling away. "I only cry when I'm sad."

"Well," he wipes his face, then wipes hers. "When I feel strong emotions, they make me cry. No matter what emotions they are."

"Oh," she says, and she puts a finger to her chin. "I cry when I'm scared."

"You don't have to be scared anymore," he says, smiling wide at her. "See me? I'm smiling. Because I'm not scared at all." He puts his fingers on her cheeks, presses gently into her skin to make her smile. "Now you're smiling, too."

Eri bounces up and down before sliding off the bed. She comes to Aizawa next, and gives him the same hug she gave Midoriya. Shit, *he's* going to start crying too. He just rubs her back, smooths out her hair, and then she pulls away to grab a child's book from off the floor.

"Will you read to me?" she asks Midoriya.

He takes it, reading the title. "Oooh, this is a really good one. I'd love to read it. Can you help me?"

"I can't read," she says, and Aizawa takes mental note that she has no prior education. "But I like the colors."

"Okay, okay." He flips it open. "Let's see some colors, then."

It goes good, beyond good. The book, titled ‘The Hungry Hungry Caterpillar’, seems to be Eri’s favorite. When it’s over, she grabs another, has Midoriya read that one. And it keeps going, more and more, until all the books are gone. He promises to bring her more and asks if she can tell him about what happened to her before now.

She seems hesitant, but explains it pretty well. “He would take me apart, and put me together again.”

Midoriya looks at Aizawa, who looks right back at him. They school their expressions into neutral states.

“What does that mean?” he asks, sitting on the floor with her and putting together a small puzzle. “He took you apart?”

She nods, then grabs a toy doll left for her. “Like this.”

Eri rips its arm off, then its leg, bending it and twisting until the doll pops. Then she lays it on the floor, quiet as she places each body part back into its original spot. The demonstration is horrific, but that’s why they provided her so many toys. Kids often reflect the behavior they experience in real life during imaginary play, and she’s no exception.

“And he would take my inside and put it in the metal circles,” she says quietly, grabbing the ‘Hungry Hungry Caterpillar’ book and opening it. She points at the caterpillar's head, red. “The blood.”

“Into metal circles?” Midoriya asks.

“Yeah,” she says softly, going back to the puzzle. “And the circles go into loud tools.” She looks at Midoriya, “You had one in your belly.”

Midoriya furrows his brows for a moment before it dawns on him. “Bullets. They put your blood into bullets.”

“Yeah,” she agrees, though she doesn’t seem to know what he’s talking about. “And they use them.”

“On… who?” Midoriya asks. She doesn’t answer, putting pieces of her unicorn puzzle together. “Do you know what your home looked like?”

“Only the room,” she says, and then points at the bed. “I had my room and my bed, and now I have a bigger room with you.”

Midoriya helps her find the spot for the next piece. “You only knew one room?”

“Yeah,” she tells him. “And sometimes we go outside, but I stayed in the room every day.”

“And when you found me,” Midoriya says. “You were running away?”

Eri nods. “I didn’t want to be taken apart again… it hurts. It feels like… hot blankets. Too hot.”

“And the man who does this to you, is he your dad—“

“No.” Eri slaps a piece into place. “Dad died because I touched him. Him and mom. I lived with grandpa, but grandpa is gone now.” She stares at the half-finished toy. “I don’t want to talk anymore.”

“Okay,” Midoriya says, “You are so helpful, you know that? You’re a Hero, you just saved so many more people by telling me all this.”

Eri shakes her head.

“We’re going to make sure that the man who takes you apart never sees you again, is that okay?” Midoriya asks her.

She says, “If the metal circles touch you, your power goes away.”

Aizawa tampers down the knee-jerk reaction to panic. He looks at Midoriya, who seems to be lost in thought.

“It can… erase Quirks.” His eyes glaze over, a distant memory taking over before he blinks back to reality. “Thank you, Eri.”

When they finally manage to leave the room, Mirio goes in after them to hang out with Eri. There’s a general consensus that keeping her company is a good idea, and Aizawa doesn’t have to worry about the third year getting struck by her Quirk. Instead, he follows after his problem child.

“What was that look?” Aizawa asks him.

Midoriya gives him a perplexed glance. “What do you mean?”

“When she told you the bullets erased Quirks, you checked out for a moment. Where did you go?” Aizawa pushes.

His student blinks slowly. “I was just thinking how horrible it must’ve been to endure. She likely knew they were using her blood to hurt people.” He shrugs. “And maybe it’s intriguing to me that Quirks can apparently be put into objects. I’m thinking of the science behind it. This has never been heard of before.”

Aizawa narrows eyes. “You aren’t thinking of doing something stupid, are you?”

“What could I possibly do?” Midoriya asks, eyes wide. “I’m Quirkless.”

He searches the kid's face for any sign of dishonesty. When he finds nothing but genuine confusion, he says, “We’ll work more with this plan to infiltrate the Shie Hassaikai yakuza organisation, but until then, catch up on sleep, alright?”

Midoriya nods. “Let me know if you need me at all.”

Aizawa still has this gut feeling that something about the kid has changed, but he ignores it for now. Instead, he heads to a training session he had planned with Shinso. And he forgets all about that look on Midoroya's face.

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"Magne's dead. The Quirk you mentioned lines up with her death."

Midoriya sits on his bed, phone to his ear. "Overhaul, then? Bird mask on his face, green jacket with purple feathers?"

"That sounds right," Tenko's voice crackles over the line. "Quirk erasing bullets, who'd have thought?"

"Quirk suppressant cuffs or boxes have already been manufactured," Midoriya says, theorizing out loud. "That was done by several people with similar destabilizing Quirks able to alter the chemical components of metals. But this? This is something new."

"If it hadn't been recreated in any other group," Tenko adds. "Then Overhaul's Quirk allows him to retrieve some inner essence from within Eri that others can't. There must be factors at play, like the victim being alive. It's the same reason Dad keeps the humans alive as he tears them apart to make a Nomu."

Midoriya stares up at his ceiling. "She's six."

Tenko pauses. "What are you thinking?"

"That Overhaul needs to die," Midoriya responds coldly. "She's a child. We need to eliminate the factor that allows this to be recreated before someone else gets their hands on the plan for it."

'Someone else' is code for All for One. With Overhaul's Quirk and the knowledge that inner anatomy can be used to manufacture weapons with given Quirks, he'd develop an arsenal of devices to deploy on others. It's the last thing they need, and Tenko seems to agree.

"You have the location of this base?" he asks.

"We're planning a coup to capture him." Midoriya thinks, adds, "If you attack the police escort car instead of the base, then it'll have no tie to us. You could kill without anyone suspecting our communication."

Tenko laughs. "Don't like getting your hands dirty?"

"I have my own mission I'll be completing," he says in response, a small smile pulling at his lips. "But if you don't kill him right away and give me some time to find you, then I can always offer a hand." He pauses. "Or two fingers."

“Fuck you, do you know how hard it is to do anything without my fucking fingers?” Tenko seethes. “And then you ran away, leaving me in the dark for over a month.”

“I’m contacting you now, aren’t I?” Midoroya asks numbly. “I’m giving you revenge for Magne, and a means to have more knowledge than Dad.”

Tenko sighs. “I’ll be ready to attack when you send the word.”

“Wonderful,” Midoriya says, “Be on the ready for my text then.”

“Try not to lose your arm.”

“Try to use Chapstick.” He hangs up.

Things have been… different. Midoriya still wears his school uniform, lying on his back in his bed. In his dorm. At UA. It’s still surreal to think about everything that’s happened—about everything that’s going to continue to happen.

When Overhaul is dealt with, Midoriya will have all the pieces he needs to take down All for One.

Including…

He lifts a hand, watches green light spark off his skin. Those glorious rainbow colors zigzag across his body, light the fingerprints on his forearms up. He watches the color glow, unsure how to control it at all. When he accepted All Might’s Quirk, he expected to feel different, to think different.

But then he swallowed that hair, and came to the haunting realization that nothing as changed at all. All he can manage at this point is a fucking light show, zero sign of All Might’s super strength or transformation.

And as depressing as it is to not have the Quirk show up all in one swoop… he can’t stop staring at the colors dancing along his skin. His room is dark now, and the vibrant colors light it up like stars. He’s taken intensive notes on it, watched the beautiful display every night before bed. Glorious, wonderful.

His.

He has a Quirk. Years of torment, of never being enough. It’s all over now. Why does he still feel…

You will always be Quirkless.

Rin was right. The light flickers out, dies, and the darkness of his room swoops back in. He thinks of Tenko, of the Quirk that was stolen from him. What would he make out of this—

“Ah!” He slams into the ceiling.

The ceiling?

Midoriya looks down, his eyes wide. The room is upside down, and his body is pressed to the roof. He slips, his back touching the smooth surface, skin sticking to the texture.

He's flying.

He's flying!

"Ah ha ah!" He laughs, moving along the ceiling. He crawls along the paneling, grabs his wardrobe, and uses it to pull his body downwards. His legs still point up, and he has to hold on to his wardrobe to stop himself from floating up again.

Is this One for All? How…

Nana Shimura. Her Quirk—she passed it on.

All of the holders must've passed on their Quirks. All Might has never done this before. How did Midoriya unlock this? He can't help the way he laughs as he thinks, reaching out to his bed frame. He claws at it, dragging his body to the floor, unable to turn the Quirk off. Colors dance along his skin. The room glows, the light coming from *him.*

He slides along the floor, grabbing his desk and chair to hold himself down. When he grabs his support scarf, he uses it to pull his door handle and open the bedroom door. He's got to get to All Might!

Midoriya climbs along the doorframe. He feels a bit like a spider, body lifting higher up as he floats into the hallway. He laughs, rolling over himself and pushing off the balcony. He plants his shoes on the ceiling, hunches, and kicks off the drywall. And he *flies.* He can't hold his laughs in, soaring through the common room, floating back to the ceiling, pushing off it again. He is lighter than he's been in years, flying through the air.

When he tires himself out, he uses his scarf to grab the dorm's handles. He pulls himself down with the fabric, grasping the handlebars and pushing them open. Weightless, he launches his scarf into a tree branch, pulls himself out. And surrounds himself in the night. Stars, constellations, the moon and clouds. Winter air blows at him, and he floats above it all. The scarf goes tight, and he realizes he's used the entire thing, stretched it out yards and yards away, floated higher and higher into the air.

He's flying. He had always dreamed about flying. He never thought it could be real.

"Young Midoriya!" He looks down, sees All Might's tiny form waving his arms. "Look at you!"

Midoriya laughs, waves. "I'm flying!"

He holds the fabric, reeling himself back to earth, meeting All Might there. He's smiling wide, but the grief on his face is impossible to shake. Midoriya dangles from his support weapon, wrapping it around his foot to stay upright, the other end holding strong to the tree trunk.

“I saw you from my window,” All Might says softly. “I couldn’t believe my eyes. But look at you, you’re flying.”

Midoriya smiles. “Nana Shimura, it’s her Quirk, isn’t it?”

All Might nods. “That it is. I didn’t know… it preserved her power.”

Midoriya’s arms extend weightless over his head. “I can’t really turn it off.”

He bellows out a laugh. “When I first inherited the power, I was unable to stop smashing everything I touched! Us Quirkless people; we don’t know how power feels. We’re as experienced as children who first develop their Quirks.”

“Can I tell you something?” Midoriya asks.

“Anything.”

“I think I love this.” His eyes water. “I think I love it, All Might.”

“My boy,” All Might says, his smile blinding. “I think I know exactly what you mean.”

“Tell me about her,” Midoriya pleads, a gentle breeze blowing against his skin. “Tell me the story of all of them, All Might.”

And so he does.

Midoriya is the ninth, and hopefully final, holder of One for All. There is a long line of death following the passing of the Quirk, of pain and anguish. But the story goes that All for One had given his baby brother a useless power of stockpiling, something to keep him complacent and easy to control. And that brother gave it away with his own, passable power. He escaped All for One’s cruel grasp to give the Quirk away.

And from there, it goes again. To Kudo, to Bruce, Hikage Shinomori, to Daigoro Banjo, to En, to Nama Shimura, to Toshinori Yagi.

And to him. Akatani Mikumo. All for One’s son. A near full rotation. A Quirk passed to Heroes, a line of humans fighting against an ultimate evil. And then to him, to a teenage boy who’s already been destroyed by it. His. His Quirk.

All Might tells him all he knows about AFO, and it’s nothing compared to what Midoriya already knows. To what he’s already lived. To what he’s already discovered.

“He wiped out the bloodlines of every user,” All Might says, guilt on his face. “It won’t happen again. This fight. It ends with you, Izuku Midoriya.”

He can’t know how right he is.

And how horribly, terribly wrong.

Tenko…

Bakugou. Kudo and Bakugou—they're related. Midoriya didn't look close enough at the family line, but he knows, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that Kudo's entire family was not fully wiped out. Somewhere, somehow, someone survived, created the Bakugou's.

Somewhere, AFO came after Nana Shimura. Her ultimate punishment followed her long into the aftermath, her grandson related to the monster who killed her. Was Dad trying to create a child that Nana would give her Quirk to? Was she already dead at that point? AFO wanted a kid with a Quirk, likely to steal it for himself, to strengthen him.

But at what cost? Did he leave Kudo's bloodline on purpose? Did Tenko just happen to be a hopeless subject, or was this planned?

He should ask Bakugou what he knows, see if…

When Midoriya looks back at the dorms, he sees that Bakugou is already there. Peering through the glass front doors, his hands stuffed into his pajama pockets. His face is hard, his eyes holding an emotion that Midoriya can't name.

Then he turns, walks back into the dark abyss of the 1-A dorms. The Quirk flickers off, and Midoriya lands on the floor outside.

"Are you alright?" All Might asks, grasping his shoulder.

Midoriya nods, looks at him instead of the spot Bakugou had been standing. "I'm better than I've been in a long, long time.

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 48: Burn it down

Chapter Summary

Todoroki comes to Midoriya for help.

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the day of uploading skipped! AO3 curse is real. Anyway, I hope you enjoy the long chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The plan is to attack the Shie Hassaikai yakuza organisation in exactly one week from now. In the meantime, Midoriya works with All Might to figure out what in the hell is going on with his Quirk. Turning it on is relatively easy; it's the turning it off that's a pain. He hasn't told anyone about it, not even Hitoshi.

Who sits across from him at the lunch table, stabbing noodles with a chopstick. "Kaminari asked me out again."

Midoriya chokes on his Udon. "What?"

"Yup," Hitoshi twirls his chopsticks. "I had to reject him again."

"Why?!" Midoriya shouts, earning several looks. He repeats, in a whisper, "Why?"

"I don't know," Hitoshi says, staring at the broth of his noodles. "I don't know if I can do this whole dating thing."

"You're so chopped," Midoriya says.

Hitoshi narrows his eyes. "Who taught you that? That was painful."

Midoriya frowns at his soup. "Sero."

"*Stop* repeating whatever those idiots tell you to say, it's awful to hear it," Hitoshi says.

"You're chopped unc 6 7."

"What the fuck did I just say?"

“Hey.” They both shut up, turn to Todoroki. He holds the same udon as they do, but his bowl has ice cubes floating in it. “Can I sit with you guys?”

They glance at each other before Midoriya scoots over and makes room for him. It’s not like it’s hard. He and Hitoshi sit together in a back corner of the cafeteria. Only them. Everyone else has formed groups and sits with friends, and the humiliation of trying and failing to sit somewhere isn’t worth it. So they find company in the ratty booth in the corner.

Todoroki twirls his udon. “You should kill my dad.”

Midoriya chokes mid bite. He pounds on his chest, trying to get the food dislodged from his throat. Todoroki gives him pats on the back that do absolutely nothing to help. When he finally clears his airway, people are looking at him with concern, and his face is flaming hot.

“Wow,” Hitoshi says, slurping his broth. “That’s great, Todo.”

Todoroki looks over his shoulder, confused. “Who is Todo?”

“You…” Hitoshi trails off. “Never mind. What do you mean we should kill your dad? I feel like I skipped a chapter.”

“I’ve been thinking about it,” Todoroki says, offering Midoriya a napkin for the liquid on his face. “I think he should probably die. Or maybe just… suffer a lot.”

“Uh-huh.” Hitoshi looks at Midoriya, points his chopsticks at his eyes. “What did you do, psycho? You tainted the baby.”

“I didn’t taint shit!” Midoriya squeaks. “I offered to do plenty of things to Endeavor, not all of those things included violence.”

“Most of them,” Todoroki pipes up. “Bro has got to go.”

“Who taught you to say that?” Hitoshi asks, eyes narrowed. “Don’t ever say that.”

Todoroki frowns at his soup. “Sero.”

“Okay,” Hitoshi rubs his temples. “From now on, do not repeat a single word that Sero, Kaminari, Mina, or Kirishima tells you to. It’s off limits, for both of you.”

“What if they say it to me, but it’s about someone else?” Todoroki asks.

Hitoshi takes a deep breath. “Depends what they said.”

“They said All Might has a BBL but to keep it lowkey.”

“What the fuck,” Hitoshi sighs, shaking his head. “Don’t… don’t say that.”

“What is it?” Todoroki asks, looking at Midoriya, who just shrugs. “Is this one of those TikerTokers?”

“Oh, it’s painful,” Hitoshi cringes, “It’s so painful.”

Midoriya decides to change the subject. “Todoroki, I offered to… deal with your dad months ago. What changed?”

He stares down at the udon. “I met with my brother.”

Midoroya’s eyes blow wide. “What? Why? How? Where?”

“I was walking down the street, and then I saw him. So I said hi, and he kind of just stared at me,” Todoroki explains, blinking slowly. “I think he tried to kill me, but I’m not too sure.”

“How are you not sure if he was trying to kill you?” Midoriya asks.

“The vibe was not it.”

“Stop,” Hitoshi hisses, “I know it was Mina who taught you that!”

Todoroki frowns. “I was certain I had used that one right.”

“Was your brother unc?” Midoriya asks.

“Both of you are fucking evil,” Hitoshi says, scoffing. “I’m going to throw up.”

Todoroki says, “Why would you throw up?”

“Let’s… go back to the topic. What happened?” Midoriya presses.

“Well, he stared at me, so I walked towards him, and he told me not to come any closer. So I stood there, and he asked how I found him, but I wasn’t looking for him or anything, I was just walking down the road—“

“Skip the unnecessary details,” Hitoshi says. “What happened next?”

“He said I shouldn’t have talked to him, and now he needs to eliminate me as a threat. And I said that I’m on his side and that I want to help him. And basically, he tried to set me on fire but also ran away, so I think he only half meant to catch me on fire,” Todoroki summarizes, then looks at them both. “Since you have connections to the league of villains, I was hoping you could invite him to come murder my dad or something.”

“Shhh!” Midoriya scrambles forward, clasps a hand over Todoroki’s mouth. “If someone hears you, we could go to prison!”

Todoroki inhales, and when Midoriya pulls his hand away, he says, “Your hands are sweaty.”

Hitoshi busts out laughing.

“You really want your dad to die?” Midoriya double checks, “I can make it happen, but I want to make sure you’ve thought this through. Do you know how he divvies up the will? What’s the situation with your mom? Your siblings?”

“Oof, let me use my face card,” Todoroki says.

“No,” Hitoshi snaps.

“Let’s mog him.”

“I will literally get on my knees and beg,” Hitoshi says, hands clasped as though he’s praying. “Please, please, I can’t take you saying these things.”

Todoroki sighs. “Okay, we won’t kill him, let’s burn the house down and… hmm, I don’t know, take his legs.”

“Uhh…” They all look up, meeting the eyes of a Class-B student. “…sorry…” she takes off, giving them a wary glance.

“How about we talk after school?” Midoriya offers stiffly. “My room, after class.”

“Okay,” Todoroki stands, “I’ll bring a gun.”

“Do not bring the gun!” Hitoshi hisses.

Todoroki purses his lips. “I’ll think about not bringing the gun.” Then he’s gone.

Hitoshi palms his eyes. Midoriya silently eats his food. He hadn’t exactly wanted Hitoshi to know about this faucet of his life. Only Bakugou knows about Midoriya’s… tendencies. And that crashed and fucking burned.

He just slurps the Udon, avoiding eye contact even when he can feel his friend looking at him. This is going to suck.

“Izuku,” Hitoshi says sweetly. “Is there something you’d like to share with the rest of the class?”

He doesn’t answer.

“The league of villains? Murdering Endeavor? What did you do?” Hitoshi kicks his foot under the table. “Answer me!”

“His dad is crazy abusive,” Midoriya says, “Raped his mom after he *bought her* just to produce a perfectly split Quirked kid. It’s fucked, okay? So I might’ve interfered and told Todoroki that his brother is alive and also a member of the League of Villains.”

Hitoshi blinks slowly. “Do you ever just… not? Are you physically capable of not doing something stupid? This means you hacked into the Hero Commission database.”

Midoriya laughs awkwardly. “Whaaaat? That’s crazy.”

“You know he’s seriously going to bring a gun, right? A real gun.”

“I will gladly take it.”

“Motherfucker. You will go to *jail,”* Hitoshi stirs his Udon. “I thought you were done with the vigilante stuff.”

“I am!” Midoriya assures him. “Mostly… I offered this months ago, okay?”

“And the league? I’m going to say you still have contact,” Hitoshi says, popping his head onto a fist. “Tell me I’m wrong.”

“Eraser knows,” Midoriya says, and it’s only a half lie. “I’ll deal with Todoroki, okay? You don’t need to be involved.”

“Oh, I’m gonna be involved,” Hitoshi argues, laughing a little. “You aren’t technically risking your life, right? So I’ll just tag along.”

Great. Midoriya loves dragging other people into situations that could cause them harm. It’s actually his favorite activity!

Todoroki is late to the meeting in Midoriya’s dorm. It leaves Hitoshi to look through all his things as if he hadn’t been in here a dozen times to smoke. He stares at the romance novels, looking at the bookcase that touches the ceiling. From there, his eyes trail to the shoe scuff marks. Midoriya doesn’t explain it, cursing himself for not finding a way to get the prints up.

The thought had crossed his mind, but he was relishing in the memories. He liked being able to wake from nightmares and see proof that he’s going to fix everything. Without them, it takes ages to fall asleep, and if he’s not watching Bakugou sleep, then it takes even longer to calm down. It’s a bad habit, honestly. He knows he should stop, but it’s hard to convince himself. If he can’t see with his own eyes that Bakugou is living and breathing, then he tricks himself into thinking Dad slaughtered him as he did everyone lad.

Thinking about Bakugou never goes well for him. He knows that, and still, the blonde never fails to occupy his mind like a damn plague. Constant, overpowering. In Midoriya’s worst nightmares, Dad is murdering Bakugou, Mama, and Hitoshi. In his best, Midoriya is weak, and they never left the UA halls that night. It’s selfish, so beyond selfish of him to wish he never did it. But as much guilt as he feels, he doesn’t regret it. Not when keeping Bakugou at arm's distance is the safest thing for him.

Maybe it’s the safest thing for Midoriya, too.

“Alright,” Hitoshi sits in Midoriya’s desk chair, spinning in circles. “Spill it.”

“Spill what?”

“You’re acting weird lately,” he says, the chair squeaking as he spins. “And my desk is literally right next to yours in class, so I’m burdened with seeing you and *Kacchan* look longingly at each other like this is some fuck ass romance.”

Midoriya purses his lips, plops onto his bed. “Nothing happened.”

“Did you guys hug and make up?” Hitoshi teases, “Did you two kissy kiss?”

Midoriya flushes, and Hitoshi stops spinning.

“WHAT?!” he screams, and Midoriya flings himself forward to tackle him out of the chair and cover his mouth. “YOU KISSED HIM AND YOU DIDN’T TELL ME?! WHAT THE FUCK!”

“Shutthefuckup,” Midoriya hisses, his face radiating heat. “I will strangle you!”

“You might as fucking well!” Hitoshi fake cries. “I can’t believe you didn’t tell me.”

“It’s not something I really wanted to tell anyone!” Midoriya snips. “Especially because I know you’re going to say something stupid!”

“So he’s a good kisser, then.”

“There it is,” Midoriya points at him. “Stupid.”

“That wasn’t stupid at all!” Hitoshi says. “What was stupid was kissing Katsuki Bakugou of all people. That sounds like actual torture.”

“It was,” Midoriya says, throwing himself back onto the bed. He buries his face in the pillows. “It’s killing me.”

“When did this happen? Are you guys dating now? Do we need to have ‘the talk’?” Hitoshi says each question like it’s some major scandal. “You guys hide it so well, I had no idea you were together.”

“We aren’t together,” he says softly. “It was a mistake.”

Hitoshi levels him with a look that says he thinks Midoriya is an idiot. “How badly did you fuck this up?”

He doesn’t respond to that, groaning into his pillowcase.

“You’re going to tell me everything.” Midoriya does, but only the briefest of synopses. He doesn’t mention much about Bakugou’s apology, only that it was a damn good one, and before Midoriya was arrested, they had nearly kissed. But it was Ground Beta that really did him in, because that time, he couldn’t blame the problem on anyone but himself. He had wanted to kiss Bakugou.

Usually, he’s better at resisting that urge. Fuck, he’s been resisting it for… a long time. But for just that night, it was like he was possessed. He couldn’t stop himself without drastic measures, aka, being a dick to Bakugou and then doing everything in his power to sever any string of emotion that is associated with him. It worked until Eri, who is weirdly emotionally intelligent. Midoriya, on the other hand, is well aware of the emotions he feels but god awful at doing the right thing with them.

Always too much or too little. He and Bakugou have that in common, far too extreme to have any normal or productive conversations. He can tell that, in the months at UA, his childhood

friend has improved and grown tenfold in his communication skills, but it doesn't change the core building of emotion. They get too amped up, too in their heads, too all or nothing.

So he did what he had to do. What was the other option? Try to date Bakugou? Try and make something where there was nothing? Bakugou doesn't care about Midoriya like that—he can't. What were all those years before now, before Ground Beta, what were they for if not to act as blaring, neon warning signs? He knows two things for certain: one, he *can't* risk Bakugou's life, and two, he can't allow Bakugou to risk his own life. He's got a bad habit of never leaving anything alone. A friendship with Hitoshi is easy because he can keep him removed from the darker parts of Midoriya's life. But Bakugou? Bakugou can't stay away from *anything.* He is either entirely involved or so far removed that he's unaware of what's happening.

So Midoriya is keeping him away. And it is miserable and he hates every fucking second of it. But Bakugou goes to bed at night and wakes up in the morning, and that's good enough. It has to be good enough.

"Besides," Midoriya says, still talking into his pillow. "He's just confused right now; it'll wear off."

Hitoshi blinks. "Confused..."

"Well, yeah," he gestures to himself, having changed into day clothes. Cargo pants, a t-shirt that says 'pants', a pair of Mama's socks that are sparkly unicorns from when she was a kid.

"You… don't think he's interested in you," Hitoshi says it like this is the most bizarre thing he's ever heard. "Are we talking about the same guy? Blonde, anger issues, so incredibly annoying that I want to slap the fuck out of him."

Midoriya nods stiffly. "Come on, Hitoshi."

"You can't be serious."

"Look at him." Midoriya gestures to the door, the hall, the dorm room Bakugou had sealed himself inside. "He's amazing. He's always been amazing. I'm just… I don't know. I'm sure he thinks I'm interesting, but it's only because of Viridant. He's got no actual interest in me. He's hated me since we were kids."

"How can you be the most intelligent person in this school but completely miss the mark here?" Hitoshi wheels the chair closer. "He did everything in his power to locate Viridant, he apologized for how he treated you, he *kissed* you."

"Things don't work like that for him," he says, shrugging. "This is a deviation from his norm—trust me. He hasn't shown interest in me once in fifteen years. There's no way this is anything more than, I don't know, picking on me? Maybe he's just trying to placate my feelings to keep me in UA and stop me from running off? I wouldn't put it past him."

Hitoshi scoffs, "You really do just think the absolute worst of everyone."

“I’ve known him for *years,* Hitoshi,” Midoriya says, his heart heavy. “I’d be surprised if he thinks of me at all, let alone romantically. I’m sure he’s going through something with his sexuality and just needed someone to experiment with. Or maybe it was just some heat of the moment. Or maybe it’s exactly as I said—he knows what he needs to do to keep me exactly where he wants me, and so he secures it by any means possible.”

“I can’t believe you’re actually saying this shit. You really convinced yourself this is true, didn’t you?” Hitoshi wheels away, shaking his head. His purple eyes flicker with a memory. “You push away anything that makes you uncomfortable. What are the odds that you know all these theories are bullshit, and it’s just your brain attempting to rationalize something that already makes sense? I’m serious.”

“People don’t change,” Midoriya says firmly. “They can shift a bit, sure, but this? You’re telling me he—he what? He’s got honest feelings for me? Since when? When he’d shove me into lockers? When he told me to jump off a roof? When he grabbed me just the other day and threw me to the floor? Where in his actions has he ever shown anything other than hostility?”

Hitoshi crosses his arms, suddenly serious. “I can’t believe you're making me a Kacchan defender right now.” He shakes his head. “The way that man looks at you is the same way sinners look when they beg for atonement in a church, Izuku. I think he’d grovel if you’d ask him to—christ—I think he’d do anything if you’d ask him to.”

“Come on.”

“I’m dead serious,” Hitoshi says. “I’m not saying it changed how he treated you, and it definitely doesn’t change how it’s affected you. But I honestly think you’re making a mistake here. I think you’re trying to save yourself from potentially crashing and burning. You don’t even know you're already on fire.”

“Poetic,” Midoriya says, giving him a small smile. “I know him, Hitoshi. I know he’s just… he’s just trying to figure himself out, alright? I’m sure this is all new and vulnerable for him, and I’m sure it’s pissing him off to no avail. He’ll figure it out, okay? This is a good thing. Keeping him far away—it’s a good thing.”

“For who?” Hitoshi asks. “You said shit to hurt him on purpose. What makes the two of you so different? He uses his hands and you use your mouth. Doesn’t it hurt all the same?”

Midoriya doesn’t get to answer before a knock sounds on his door. One look at Hitoshi, and he knows that he won’t say a word about what they discussed. Not at this moment, at least. Midoriya has a feeling that this conversation won’t be given up on for a long, long time.

Still, he opens his door, revealing Todoroki.

“Hey.” Midoriya opens the door wider, letting him squeeze inside. “We thought you might’ve bailed.”

“I was thinking,” he says, and offers no other explanation

Midoriya runs his eyes. “We need to come to an agreement that whatever happens today, we tell absolutely no one about, okay?”

“Sure,” Hitoshi says.

“Can I tell my mom?” Todoroki asks.

“Umm… sure, if you want. Okay, let’s get started—“

“Can I tell my sister?”

Midoriya pauses. “I mean… yeah, sure.”

“Can I tell my brother. The regular one, not the murderer.”

“That’s… yeah, that’s fine.”

“Okay.”

Midoriya pauses, waits for him to name anyone else. “So, I can contact—“

“Can I tell Bakugou?”

He palms his eyes. “What?”

“Bakugou, me, and Shinso all have a group where we do cool things,” Todoroki says, unaware that Shinso is shaking his head in disagreement. “So I thought he should probably be here.”

Midoriya’s eye twitches. “Are you two close friends?”

“No," Hitoshi says.

“We are best friends,” Todoroki says at the same time.

He’s at a loss here. What does he say to that? Including Bakugou in this—

“I think it’s actually a great idea,” Hitoshi suddenly says, changing his earlier opinion. “Let’s get Bakugou involved.”

Midoriya narrows his eyes. “This is a super private matter.”

“I’ll go get him.” Todoroki turns and leaves.

This fucking blows.

“Why would you do that?” Midoriya whisper-yells, his door cracked so he can watch Todoroki head over to Bakugou’s room. “This is so stupid. I can’t believe you’re trying to make this work.”

“Call me a chicken, because I’m your wing man,” Hitoshi says, immediately cringing when Midoriya stares at him. “Yeah, that was bad, sorry. I heard Mina say it one time and… Never mind.”

“I don’t need a wingman!” Midoriya hisses, “I need you not to be weird about this.”

“I’m not even weird at all,” Hitoshi says, crossing and then uncrossing his legs. He does it three times before he stops suddenly. “Maybe getting Bakugou involved actually wasn’t a good idea…”

Todoroki is already knocking on his door. Midoriya tries not to strangle either of them, peering through the door crack to watch the following interaction.

Bakugou swings it open, looks at Todoroki, and immediately tries to shut it again.

“The Kitten Enjoyers are banding together again,” Todoroki says.

Bakugou stares at him. “Do you ever think a single fucking thought? Or is it just empty in there?”

Todoroki shrugs. “You don’t want to be part of the group?”

“Why the fuck would I want to be part of the—there isn’t a group!” Bakugou shouts, his eyes bloodshot and hair mussed. “No! I don’t want any part of it.”

Thank god. Midoriya smiles, eager to get this done with. He’s been thinking about different things the three of them could do to—

“Okay,” Todoroki says, turning, heading back to the dorm room. “Midoriya, he said he’s not joining. We can do this without him.”

Bakugou immediately pushes into the hall. “What are we doing?”

Oh, mother fucker! That’s not even *fair.* Midoriya knocks his forehead on the door, ignoring Hitoshi's snickering. Todoroki pushes it open a moment later, attempting to shut it, but Bakugou shoves against it. Suddenly, his room is full of people, and not a single one is on his side, apparently.

Midoriya locks eyes with Bakugou, immediately turning away before allowing himself to attempt to discern the look in his eyes. Hitoshi is laughing. This *sucks.*

“Okay, let’s not get anyone else involved, please?” he says, looking at Todoroki.

Todoroki nods. “Are you comfortable with the group name Kitten Enjoyers?”

Midoriya takes a deep breath. “That’s… fine.”

“Great, because these two have no input.” Todoroki gestures to Bakugou and Hitoshi. “So what’s the plan to kill my dad?”

“Fucking what?” Bakugou asks, looking around at them. “What the fuck is going on?”

Midoriya wipes his hands down his face. “We aren’t killing your dad, Todoroki. You said you wanted to burn the house down.”

“Oh, right,” Todoroki says, “Burn it down and take his legs.”

“How does one take legs?” Hitoshi asks. “Are we hacking them off? Maybe you should give him frostbite or something.”

“Can we please just…” Midoriya grabs a bottle of pain meds for his headache. “Let’s just focus, okay? Our main mission is burning the house down, no legs involved.”

“Can we take his eye?” Todoroki suggests. “Like an eye for an eye, it’s poetic.”

“What the fuck is going on?” Bakugou repeats.

“Todoroki’s dad is an abusive rapist and we’re burning his house down. Also, Todo's brother is a member of the league of villains, keep up.” Hitoshi nods at Midoriya. “Continue.”

This is why he works alone. There are three too many people involved in this. Still, he takes the burner phone from the desk, holds it in the air.

“I’m going to call the league on this phone. I will ask *once* if Dabi would like to take part in this. If I get no response or a ‘no’, then we go alone,” Midoriya says, eyeing the reactions to the device. Hitoshi yawns, Todoroki is stoic, and Bakugou looks as angry as he always does. “This is the last vigilante stuff I’m going to do.”

A lie, but he can’t risk blabbermouth Bakugou spilling this shit to Aizawa-Sensei. Plus, keeping Todoroki and Hitoshi out of the loop of his plans is an ideal.

“Are we all on the same page?” Midoriya asks.

Nods, and he opens the phone up. He can’t believe he’s actually doing this. He feels like a parent asking another parent if their child wants to have a play date with his. It’s humiliating, but he stands for his beliefs. He made an offer to Todoroki to fix this, and he’s staying true to it.

“Wait.”

Midoriya hovers a finger over the call button. “What?”

Todoroki’s eyes dart around, the only sign that he’s nervous. “I thought of what else we could do.”

“Which is?”

“The files you said you have on him. After we burn the house down, you should make those public. I already asked my sister and brother—they said they don’t care what I do.” Todoroki stuffs his hands into his pockets. “Also, I brought a gun.”

“Why do you keep doing that!” Bakugou snips.

“Seriously, man,” Hitoshi mumbles.

Midoriya doesn’t look away from Todoroki, nodding his head. “Do you have a computer in your house?”

“Yes,” Todoroki says. “Second floor. You’ll have to sneak in; he’s got cameras by the front door to make sure none of us run away.”

Hitoshi cringes. “Shit, I’m sorry.”

Todoroki just looks at Midoriya. “I can get you in, but the only window big enough to fit you is in the master bathroom. You’re the smallest of us, so you’ll have to go alone.”

“No fucking chance,” Bakugou finally pipes up. “Send him into a house with a psycho?”

“Not your call,” Midoriya snaps. “I’ll get it done. I can use the home computer to access the files and send the documents on blast. You’re aware how much this can backfire, right?”

“I’m aware,” Todoroki says, “Let’s burn him down.”

Jesus. Midoriya smiles crookedly at him. He can appreciate that mindset. It’s nice to have someone who’s willing to do dirty shit to take down pillars of society like this. Maybe it’s for personal reasons, but not everyone gets the chance to stand up to an abuser. He doesn’t mind this side of Todoroki one bit.

Bakugou steps directly in his line of sight to Todoroki. “You can’t go in alone.”

Midoriya’s eye twitches. “I can, and I will. You heard him, the window won’t fit anyone else. I’m small enough.”

“We can burn a damn hole into the side of the house,” Bakugou argues. “One of us can distract him, the others can create an entryway for the rest of us. If the house is coming down anyway, then there’s no reason to try to preserve it.”

“Great point,” Hitoshi says, ignoring the glare Midoriya sends him. “You and Midoriya should team up to get him inside the window. I can distract at the door, and Todoroki can melt the alternative entry.”

“And Touya,” Todoroki adds, “His flames are hotter than mine; he can burn straight through the concrete.”

“Are we seriously trusting a villain for this?” Bakugou asks, “Hasn’t he killed people?”

“There have been charred remains found,” Midoriya says, “But no direct ties to Dabi. Honestly, it could be Endeavor. Or some other pyromaniac. Todoroki, would your brother kill someone?”

“Hmm…” he thinks, eyes to the ceiling. “Probably.”

“That’s… not fucking reassuring,” Bakugou says. “This is dangerous.”

“Then leave,” Midoriya all but begs.

Bakugou’s eyes darken, narrow, and Midoriya is reminded of the hallway that night. “I’m not going fucking anywhere, Greenie.”

Silence.

Midoriya looks away, holding down whatever emotions surge up first. Frustration and giddiness are tying right now, which is *so* not fair. He unlocks his phone instead of making eye contact, taps Tenko’s name, and puts the phone to his ear. One of the idiots tells him to put it on speaker, but that sounds like the worst possible idea, so he doesn’t listen.

“Why the hell are you calling me so much?” Tenko’s voice crackles over. “It looks suspicious. If Dad finds out, then we’re screwed.”

“Oh, shut up,” Midoriya snips, earning a few shocked looks. He turns away. “Just… I need to talk to… Dabi.”

Tenko pauses. “What?”

“Can I talk to Dabi?”

“Why the fuck,” his brother starts, and Midoriya mentally dies. “Are you calling to talk to Dabi? Do you know what you’re even asking? You think I’m bad, Dabi’s something else.”

“Has he killed people?”

“Who knows,” Tenko mutters, “Probably. I’ve never seen it, but he doesn’t take too well to people who piss him off.”

“Everyone pisses him off.”

“Exactly,” Tenko snaps. “No. You can’t talk to him.”

Midoriya takes a deep breath, looks at the people in the room. Bakugou is annoyed, arms crossed over his chest. Hitoshi is curious, leaning forward on the chair with his elbows on his knees. But it’s Todoroki that Midoriya locks on to. He just discovered his brother was alive, he wants to mend the broken bond between them, and he wants to ruin his dad’s life for what he did to them.

Midoriya can relate to it. Even if he couldn’t, he wouldn’t give up on this. No one deserves to go through what this kid did.

“Can I talk to Himiko?” Midoriya changes tactics.

A long, drawn-out pause. “Why on *my* phone? She’s going to say weird shit to you, really?”

“Give her the damn thing,” Midoriya pushes, “I’ll… trade.”

“Oooh, I thought you were too busy sucking UA’s dick.” Tenko’s steps can be heard over the line as he walks somewhere. “I wouldn’t want to get my poor baby brother into any trouble.”

“Please.”

“When I text you a location,” Tenko says, his voice a low warning, “You show up. No questions asked, full gear.”

“Done.”

“Have fun then, dipshit.” The phone is handed off, and he can hear a muffled conversation between Tenko and Himiko before she takes it.

“Cutie!” she screams so loudly that Midoriya has to pull the phone away. “Oh, oh, oh my god!”

“What the hell?” Bakugou asks, glaring at the phone as Himiko continues screaming. Midoriya just holds it on his lap, unwilling to blow an eardrum. “Who the fuck is that?”

He rubs a temple. “Our connection to Dabi.”

“Put it on speaker,” Hitoshi says, snickering. “She doesn’t sound like she’ll reveal anything.”

“She’s…” he searches for the word. “Energetic.”

“Is this the girl that Touya takes care of?” Todoroki asks, Himiko still screaming on the other end. “If you’re comfortable, I’d like to hear about her.”

Midoroya’s eyes soften, and Bakugou’s hands smoke for whatever reason. He puts it on speaker, the room filling with the sound of Himiko laughing and screaming in absolute joy.

“Hi, Himiko,” he says.

“VIRIDANT!” she shouts, “I missed you!”

“Uh huh.”

“Say it back,” she pouts, “I’ll tell you a secret.”

Midoriya rubs his eyes, sitting on his bed with nothing but absolute dread. “I missed you, too.”

“AHHHHH!” she’s screaming again. “I knew it! I knew you missed me! What did you miss the most?”

He shuts his eyes. “Umm… your… eyes.”

Himiko giggles. “You are so sweet!”

“Thanks,” he says flatly. “I need you to talk to Dabi for me.”

“But I didn’t tell you the secret.”

He looks up, meeting Hitoshi’s look that tells him he thinks Himiko is a bit of a nut case. She is, but Midoriya is weirdly defensive about the look on his friend's face. She’s been judged for way too long for little things. What’s the harm in what she’s doing right now? Being a teenage girl with a crush?

He sighs. “Okay, let’s hear it.”

“I got braces!” Himiko says, and his brows raise. “Dabi finally saved up enough funds! I told him I could find a way to help pay, but he was insistent that he would handle it. And now I have the cutest braces ever. I got pink bands!”

Midoriya huffs a laugh. “Send me a photo, I can’t imagine you with those.”

He ignores the three people in his room, eyeing the photo Himiko sent him. They actually fit her really well. They even fit her elongated canines perfectly. It hits him just how young she is, smiling widely and showing off such a big sign of adolescence.

“They look great on you,” he tells her.

She hesitates. “Are you just saying that? I feel like my mouth looks so gross and my lips puff out.”

“I’m serious,” Midoriya says. “You pull them off.”

“Do you think I’m cute?”

He refuses to make eye contact with anyone. “Yes.”

“Awww,” Himiko cooes. “That’s what I like about you, Viridant. You aren’t all self-righteous and peppy like all the other kids. I was so sad when you got into UA. I thought you’d leave us all behind, but you’re still the same old Viridant.”

Midoriya purses his lips. “Yup… that’s me.”

“So. You need Dabi?” she asks, humming to herself. “He’s actually in a good mood today! Hawks is here.”

Whoops.

Bakugou’s eyes nearly bug out of his head, and Midoriya quickly mutes the call before he shouts, “HAWKS?”

“It’s a double agent thing,” Midoriya assures them all. “Hawks works for the Heroes Commission. He’s pretending to be in the league when he’s not.”

Hitoshi laughs at him, vein popping on Bakugou’s temple. “Don’t go telling anyone, Kacchan.”

“Fuck you!” Bakugou snaps at him.

Midoriya shushes them all before unmuting. “He’s always in a good mood with Hawks around?”

“Oh, you wouldn’t believe it,” Himiko snickers. “You should see the two of them. Hawks keeps it friendly, but Dabi is *not* subtle.” The sound of her mini fridge opening, shutting, then a lid popping. “He’ll be in a good enough mood to talk to you, at least.”

Midoriya had the vaguest impression that Dabi didn’t like him. It seems like that’s true. Though he isn’t sure why. Sure, he stabbed Magne and then held Himiko at knife point to bargain for his friends' lives. Then attempted to murder Tenko by beating him to death after biting the fingers off his body… okay, maybe he gets it.

Still, Hawks and Dabi having some form of connection is a new and useful development.

“Can you put him on the phone, please?” Midoriya asks.

Himiko hums. “I can, but I’m not sure I want to! I only just started talking to you.”

Why does it always come to bargaining when the league is involved?

Midoriya grumbles, “I’ll buy you a computer.”

Himiko screams, and they all cover their ears. “WHAT!!! OMG OMG!!”

“Just… put him on the phone.”

“Okay, okay!” she cheers, “But you need to buy me a good microphone and headset! I want to troll grown men on Call of Duty.”

Midoriya pinches his brow. “Fine.”

“You’re so good to me, Viri,” Himiko giggles, then the sound of knuckles rasping on a door. “I really wish you luck, you know. Not just because you're helping me out, but because Dabi isn’t very social.”

“Thanks.”

The phone goes quiet, muted. He waits long moments before noise fills the other side. It’s soft, subtle, like the sound of a fan blowing in the distance. Dabi must run hot, must need a fan to cool off even in the dead of winter.

“To what do I owe the pleasure of your conversation?” Dabi says, his voice a sarcastic rasp. “Aren’t I just so lucky? A UA student—who wants to talk to *me.”*

Midoriya isn’t Dabi’s biggest fan, either. He eyes Todoroki, who is staring intently at the phone like he can crawl through the screen and see his brother face-to-face. He’s got to do this.

“We’re burning down Endeavor's house,” Midoriya says outright, listening to the long pause. “Me, Todoroki, and two others. We’re inviting you to be part of it.”

Dabi lets out a wheezing laugh, unable to produce a real one with the damage to his throat. “You keep screwing up my plans, vigilante.”

“I’ll be releasing all documentation of his abuse to the public,” Midoriya adds, rubbing a hand through his hair. “This is your one and only chance to be part of it. If you say no, I’m not contacting you again.”

A sigh. “I have a prerecorded video that covers the abuse. I had planned to publish it on my own later this summer, but here you are, butting into matters that don’t fucking involve you.” The flick of a lighter. “Did my genius little brother put you up to this?”

Midoriya eyes Todoroki, recognizing the small, almost imperceivable sadness in his eyes.

God dammit. “Fuck you, Dabi.”

“The fuck did you say to me?”

“I said fuck you!” Midoriya snaps. “Get over yourself. You’re either out or you're in; be grateful I bothered to include you in this. Your dad is going down, and it’s with your support or just your acknowledgment. Don’t take this out on anyone other than yourself for taking so damn long to make a move.”

“Jesus,” Hitoshi whispers.

Dabi snickers. “My family gave up on me *years* ago. Why the hell would I want any part of helping you now?”

Todoroki says, “We thought you were dead.”

He was *not* supposed to talk. Dabi goes quiet, but the sound of his rage is so loud that he doesn’t need a voice to express it. It can be felt through the line.

“I’m sure you did,” Dabi says, "What gave it away? The lack of a body? Or did dad just tell you I was, and you listened like the obedient little lap dog you are?”

“Maybe it was the fact that I haven’t heard from you since I was nine,” Todoroki says, his voice darker than usual. “Does your new family keep you enough company?”

“I’m going to kill you when I see you,” Dabi threatens.

“That would require contact, which I’m not sure you’re capable of,” Todoroki snaps, then he looks at Midoriya. “Hang up, we don’t need him.”

“Who the fuck do you think you are—“ Midoriya hands up the phone.

There’s an awkward silence, then Todoroki pulls the gun from his pocket. Bakugou ducks when it’s carelessly aimed around, Hitoshi cursing. But Midoriya stays still, catching it when

Todoroki tosses it to him. He pushes the safety on, sliding the magazine from the well. He counts the rounds, sixteen, before sliding it back into place.

He hasn't used many guns before. While he's spent some time practicing with them months and months ago, back when he was a vigilante, the idea of using lethal force never sat right with him. Not against low-level victims, anyway. He wouldn't want to draw a gun on anyone, wouldn't want to take a life with anything other than his bare hands. Or foot, apparently.

Regardless, he flicks off the safety, feels the sturdy metal weight of it in his hands. He slides it into the waistband of his pants, tucks his shirt over it. It'll be a quick draw if he needs it.

"When are we going?" Todoroki asks, his face drawn in. His voice has turned icy, and long gone is that aloof mask.

"Tonight," Midoriya says, ignoring his phone when it buzzes again. "I'm certain your dad has gone through intensive research to ensure your home is fireproof. So we'll need a lot of gasoline and a change of clothes." He looks between them all. "Bring a bag and clothes you don't mind dumping, shoes included. We can't have a single speck of gasoline on us when we leave, or we risk catching aflame."

Bakugou shakes his head. "This is fucking insanity."

No one tells him he's wrong. Truthfully, he isn't. What they're about to do is beyond illegal, life-threatening, but they're going to do it anyway. Even weirder, though, is that Bakugou isn't going to sit it out. He knows it's wrong, but as strong as his moral compass is, he's not giving up on this. It must be driving him up the wall, but he agrees all the same.

The plan is set to take place at midnight. Hitoshi reveals that he knows a way to sneak out of school that involves being sneaky, but they should be able to manage it so long as they are careful. It's agreed that they'll buy gas masks tonight, both to hide their identity and stop any smoke inhalation in case they don't get out in time. They stuck with Hitoshi's idea. Midoriya will go in first, Bakugou using his strength and his Quirk to launch him to the master bathroom window. Todoroki will work on securing an alternative entry and exit point towards the backyard, and Hitoshi will knock on the front door and draw away Endeavor's attention.

When the time comes, they all meet in Hitoshi's room, who has found a way to disable the dorm window sensors so they won't alert anyone that the screen has been removed. One by one, they hop out the window, land on the wet earth below, and start the long walk to the small escape location. Midoriya and Hitoshi both bring their support scarves to ensure faster travel. They've all worn dark hoods and sweats, cloth face masks to hide their identity. If they're caught on cams, which is unlikely, then nobody will know who they are. Of course, it'll automatically tie to Midoriya given his past history, but at least the other three won't go down with him.

The exit route is located at the far back end of the UA property. A large, motion-censored gate guards the school. But Hitoshi found a way to enable the scanners by attacking the wall through shrubbery. They have to push through bushes and trees, but it reveals a small hole that Hitoshi cut into the secure UA walls with who knows what. It's a tight squeeze, but

under the cover of night and foliage, they all manage to push through the gap and appear on the outskirts of the school.

“There are bots,” Hitoshi warns. “We need to swing off this hill and into the town below. It has to be silent.” His purple eyes flick over them before he grabs Todoroki’s sleeve and yanks him to his side. “I’ll take Todo, you and Bakugou meet us on the ground below.”

Midoriya’s lip curls. “Hitoshi!”

“No time to talk, sorry.” He holds Todoroki against his waist, wrapping some of the scarf around them to ensure they’re properly attached. Without another word, they swing off the cliff, spearing silently through the night air.

It leaves Midoriya and Bakugou alone together, onto the stars to keep them company.

He’s waiting for Bakugou to insist he’ll go solo, that his explosions can be controlled and maintained at a low volume. That he doesn’t need Midoriya to carry him through the sky and to the floor below.

Instead, he’s met with focused red eyes and a shit eating smirk since Bakugou tugged his mask down. “Aren’t you going to swing us down, Greenie?”

Midoriya’s jaw flexes. “You can do it on your own.”

“You heard Eyebags,” Bakugou argues. “Wouldn’t want to make any noise.”

What the hell is he playing at? That shit eating smirk turns into a lazy grin, and Midoriya isn’t sure what to make of him. Is he trying to mess with him? Test his patience? Midoriya could leave Bakugou at the top of the hill if he wanted.

But Bakugou knows he won’t. And it’s grating to know that he knows Midoriya all too well.

“Come on, Viridant,” Bakugou says slowly, “Swing us to safety.”

What the hell is he trying to do here? Get under Midoriya’s skin? Piss him off? It won’t work.

Midoriya stands close, wraps his arm around Bakugou’s waist. He’s warm, flush against Midoriya's side. He rests his arms over Midoriya’s shoulder, and the scent of caramel and smoke is addicting.

“Hold on tight,” Midoriya grumbles.

Bakugou snorts.

The scarf lurches out, wraps around a lamppost below, and then they jump. Those warm hands grasp Midoriya tightly, night air whipping at them as they fly. The moon paints them, and when Bakugou looks around, his grin wide, Midoriya squeezes him a bit closer.

They land, then they're up again a moment later. Buses won't take them down the right street to get to Todoroki's family home, and the bullet train gets nowhere near it. Unless they take a private car, which isn't an option, then they have to find an alternate yet stealthy route over. So they swing.

The two of them don't say a word, but the burnt sugar smell never evades Midoriya's senses. He thinks back to when Bakugou had saved him months ago from Dabi's flame after he escaped their hideout. They flew through the air, unaware of who the other was. Still, they soared above the clouds, just the two of them in the sky. Midoriya has no way to get so high again, and he mourns the loss of the view.

Mourns the loss of who he viewed it with. What would it have been like to count the stars from so close? It felt as though they could touch them, feel the warmth of them. Would Bakugou have gotten him closer, so he may finally know what it was like to hold one in his hands?

I think he'd do anything if you'd ask him to.

Hitoshi's gotten into his head with his nonsense. Midoriya shakes the thoughts from his mind, focusing on the task at hand. Bakugou has to be extra careful on this mission. If his hands spark, then the house blows. The same goes for Todoroki. One mistake, and they're dead.

It's easy to secure gas masks and several cans of gasoline. Hitoshi will cover the outer perimeter, leaving the others to tank the inside of the house with the liquid. When they land outside the home, each one with a red can of gasoline in hand, the air is heavy and weighted.

"Right here," Todoroki whispers, urging them along. He holds a hand out at the small surveillance camera on the side of the house. "We need to take that out, then hoist Midoriya into the window above."

It's a traditional, expensive Japanese home. The sheer size of it is massive, luxurious, and far too big to be filled with no one. Todoroki explains that the majority of it is training facilities, different wings dedicated to different things. A house that has wings and dedicated sections—he really is a rich boy.

Midoriya launches his scarf out, wraps it around the camera, and rips it off the wall.

"That works," Hitoshi snorts, gazing around the large yard they've snuck into. "I'll go grab his attention."

"And I'll go around back," Todoroki whispers, "If anything goes wrong, then meow very loudly."

"Why the fuck would we meow?" Bakugou whisper-argues.

"It's our code word," Todoroki decides. "It lines up perfectly with the name. Just meow." He's gone a moment later, and Midoriya and Bakugou are again left alone.

Midoriya stares up at the small window. There's nothing for his scarf to grasp onto, not even a roof panel or chimney to work with. It's small, Todoroki was right. He'll have to be launched up to grab the ledge, then slide the window open from his position.

"Okay," he whispers, "Give me a boost."

Bakugou doesn't move, crosses his arms over his chest. "Why are you doing this?"

Midoriya already has a headache; he can't deal with this on top of it. "Just hoist me up."

"Greenie," Bakugou says, his face twisted. "Todoroki isn't you. Taking his dad out—it doesn't change what's happened with yours."

"Just lift me up!" he hisses, "Why do you always pick at the damn wound?"

"So you admit there is a wound?"

"Oh my god," Midoriya palms his eyes. "Now is not the time to have a deep-rooted conversation about childhood trauma. I need to get into this house and fix things, okay?"

Bakugou stares at him for a moment before giving a curt nod. "You're right."

He's… right?

Midoriya opens and shuts his mouth, unable to find words to respond to that. An admittance of fault from Bakugou? What the hell?

He really is trying to mess with Midoriya's head.

Bakugou places his back against the wall, planting his feet and cupping his hands over a knee. "Put your foot in my hands."

Midoriya snaps out of his daze. "Thanks—"

"You'll want this."

They both jump, turning to a moving shadow. Glowing, blue eyes peer at them, and they discover it's not a shadow at all. Dabi's dark attire hides him in the darkness completely. And he tosses a lone flash drive from the bleakness. Midoriya catches it, turns it over in his hands, before shoving it in his hoodie pocket.

They stare at each other. Well—Midoriya thinks he's staring at Dabi. He honestly can only see his bright eyes, glowing in the absence of light. Dabi's looking right at him, though, and a moment later, the light dims.

Darkness.

"Todoroki will need your help around back," Midoriya calls out quietly, just in case Dabi is still out there. "If you still want a part in this."

Silence. Fucking horrifying.

Midoriya turns back to Bakugou. Quietly, he places his shoe into the palms of his childhood friend's hands. There's some irony there of Bakugou holding a Quirkless shoe in his talented hands, but Midoriya doesn't explore it. There's no time to reminisce.

"Don't do anything stupid," Bakugou warns, before yanking his arms up as Midoriya pushes off the floor with his other foot.

A small set of crackling sparks, and Midoriya gains a few extra feet of air, grasping the windowsill with ease. He holds onto the ledge with one hand, his other sliding the glass to the side. Carefully, he pulls a pocketknife from his pants, cuts a wonky hole in the screen. He doesn't look back at the ground as he pushes through the narrow opening and slips into the bathroom.

It's luxurious, a mound of wealth he'd never had access to. All the money he stole from All Might likely wouldn't cover the cost of just this bathroom. Sleek marble, a large tub, a glass shower with multiple jets. It's huge, a walk-in closet attached to it that has room for *seating* inside of it. This is the greed and gluttony they talk about in the bible. Midoriya isn't religious by any means, but he feels an uncountable envy as he looks around this room. It's spotless, likely cleaned by a maid.

Rich people are the absolute worst. This money could've gone towards important things. Life-changing things. And here it is, sitting and waiting in a golden bathroom.

Midoriya creaks open the bathroom door, holding down a gasp as he locks onto Endeavor. The man is exiting the room, silent as he goes to follow the knock on his front door. It allows Midoriya to push into the master bedroom, which is so large that it's unreasonable. The only person who could ever need this much space is the same kind of person who believes they take up an unordinary amount of it.

Todoroki's brief explanation of the floor plan of the house plays in Midoriya's mind as he pushes out of the bedroom. He's met with a huge hole in the center of the house, giving room to what looks like a plaza within the home itself. There's grass in here, a small water feature with koi fish. Beautiful, but completely unnecessary. So many people could've benefited from this money; what is Endeavor doing with it other than sitting on it?

Midoriya makes his way along the walkway, sliding open the next door and sealing himself inside. Endeavor's office is large, lined with bookcases full of information and knowledge. There's a desk in the dead center, neatly organised monitors and paperwork. Midoriya sits in the desk chair, annoyed by how comfortable it is. It seems to be custom curated to Endeavor's measurements, which is so incredibly stupid that it's actually unbelievable.

He gets to work on the computer. It's password protected, and it takes him not even a minute to bypass that. Quick fingers and flickering screens lead him immediately to Endeavor's personal social media accounts. Midoriya pulls the flash drive from his pocket, prays that Dabi isn't going to screw them over with a corruptor or virus.

When he plugs it into the PC, a folder opens, revealing only one video file. Midoriya scans through it, a hitch in his throat at the vulnerable footage Dabi filmed. He's shirtless, revealing his horrific scars. His hair is white, and he explains it was stress that made it this way. He reveals documents detailing the sham marriage of his parents, he showcases his lack of a jaw that's been since filled with metal casings to keep his face attached to his head. It's awful, truly awful.

And paired with the 911 calls that Midoriya posts online, it looks *terrible* for Endeavor. Good. It's better to keep the insufferable man alive so he can be tormented. Death was too easy of a route for him.

Midoriya sets it all to publish in an hour. It gives them enough time to douse the house in gasoline and get the hell out. Ideally, Endeavor's rage will spark the fluid and cause the home to burn. But—

A loud crash sounds outside, and Midoriya curses, logging off the computer. He takes his can of gasoline and dumps a good amount of the computer and bookcases. Burning books is awful in his opinion, but desperate times call for desperate measures. When it's done, he sees what caused the noise.

Todoroki secured the alternative exit, and Dabi waltzed right through it and into the large indoor plaza. Idiot.

"Anyone home?" Dabi calls out, and he's going to *ruin* this plan. "Dad?"

His voice is a song, a laugh hidden in the rasp of it. There's no telling what the hell he's about to do to Endeavor, but any flames are a huge risk. They need to get this place doused and escape before any of them can be tied to Dabi's sudden abrasiveness.

Midoriya dumps a trail of gasoline to the next room, mindlessly splashing it onto beds and flooring. The next, the next, until he's got one side of the upper floor covered. He moves to the next, gets halfway done, before bumping off Bakugou.

"We need to get the hell out of here, Greenie," he whispers, grabbing Midoriya's arm.

They peer over the ledge again, and Endeavor emerges from within the home. Todoroki is at his brother's side, trying to persuade him to get out, but it's a bit too late.

"This is going to go fucking bad," Bakugou hisses. "I knew this was so stupid."

"Shush," Midoriya says, "Did you cover the other side?"

"Yeah," Bakugou says quietly. "Eyebags was working on the other rooms after Endeavor shut the door in his fucking face. No idea where he is now."

"Fuck," Midoriya mumbles, then hands Bakugou his oil can. "Finish the upstairs, I'll go find him."

"Tch," Bakugou takes it, brows furrowed. "This is a *bad idea.* This whole place is going to blow if there's any confrontation. We have three unpredictable matches just standing down

there."

"Then I suggest you finish quickly," Midoriya hisses, sneaking off. "Don't set off any sparks."

He takes off, heading for the south stairs. There's talking in the center, and Midoriya looks long enough to watch a look of pure horror cross Endeavor's face. Dabi's really screwing this entire operation right now.

He sneaks down the steps, throws up the nearest door. When he sees ample gasoline and no Hitoshi, he starts to panic.

"Stop!"

Midoriya looks over his shoulder, eyes widening at the hot flame. Not from Todoroki, or his brother, not even from Bakugou.

Endeavor catches.

And the house explodes.

Midoriya peels his clothes off, hissing at the flames covering his skin. Idiots! They stashed their bags outside, and he's quick to escape, tearing through his backpack for his change of clothes.

And he's the only one out here. He stays for a few seconds, waiting, but nobody comes out of the flames. The entire place is caught, roaring flames shooting for the sky. Fuck!

He rushes back in, carefully to dodge the fire roaring. In the center, he can make out three forms. One blazes, roaring, and the other is covered in blue, forming a line. Dabi shields his brother, but the sheer amount of gas and smoke is burning this place so fast that there's no hope of getting out of here without any damage.

Midoriya secures his gas mask. "Hitoshi!"

The sound of wood groaning, walls collapsing. It's spreading too fast. Fuck!

"HITOSHI!" Midoriya screams, his heart racing as he covers the first half of the bottom floor. He can't lose him—he can't lose him. He can't, he can't.

He shoves another door open and is met only with fire and smoke. The next, the next. *Nothing.* The second floor collapses lopsided, one half sliding and falling atop unexplored rooms, the other barely staying upright. Fire surges in the center, and Midoriya can hear the sound of someone laughing.

Still, he searches for Hitoshi. He clears the unbroken part, then dives into the flames of the ruined half of the house. He jumps over inflamed podiums and load-bearing beams. His skin is slick with sweat and heat, his eyes watering. He doesn't know, until he's deep into the fire, that he's having a panic attack. His breath comes fast, sheer terror filling him. He keeps thinking of the bar fire, of how badly it hurt. How scared he was.

Hitoshi, Hitoshi.

His eyes land on inflamed fabric. Midoriya follows it, and sees the support scarf wrapped around the roof beams. Hitoshi was holding the ceiling up and—

And the other end of the scarf is wrapped around his throat, flame rushing for him. Midoriya shoves through a small, burning gap, gritting through his teeth at the fire grazing his dark skin. His shirt gets caught on a nail, pinning him between rust and wood. Midoriya grinds his teeth, pulls, but he can't get loose. The metal cuts into his skin, but the pain is minor compared to what could happen if he doesn't free himself.

"Hitoshi!" he screams, and his friend looks at him. He shimmies his scarf off, but it's entwined with his gas mask. The whole thing comes off, and the sheer amount of smoke makes Hitoshi gasp and cough.

Midoriya lunges for him, but he can't get off this fucking screw! It pushes deeper into his skin, agonizing. Fire hits Midoriya's face, and he curses as he tries to get loose.

"Greenie." Hands grab him, yank him away from Hitoshi. The screw comes loose, and the heat never touches his skin. "You need to get out of here!"

"Hitoshi." Midoriya throws himself forward and is yanked backwards again. Bakugou pushes him away, peers through the gap to Hitoshi.

The ceiling behind them collapses, and Hitoshi's coughs worsen. He stumbles forward, trying to cover his mouth with a hand, but doesn't get more than a few steps.

"I've got a better endurance," Bakugou says, shoving Midoriya back towards the exit. "I can take the smoke longer than you. Clear an exit, I'll get him out."

"But—"

"Clear the fucking exit!" Bakugou shouts, shoving him towards the fallen wood. "Go!"

Midoriya listens mindlessly, his eyes full of tears. He grabs wood, gloves keeping his palms secure as he yanks heavy materials from the path. There's the sound of an explosion, but a quick glance over his shoulder tells him it was calculated. Bakugou appears a moment later, dragging an unconscious Hitoshi from the room.

Midoriya throws the last piece of wood. "Come on!"

Bakugou tears his own gas mask off, slits it over Hitoshi's face. "Take him, I need to find Todoroki. He ran off."

"You can't!" Midoriya shouts through the roaring of the fire. "He's—"

"Fucking go!" Bakugou snaps at him, pushing Hitoshi into his arms. "I'm fine! Go!"

Midoriya grabs his friend under his arm and starts dragging. When fire races along the floor, he hoists Hitoshi onto his back and starts running. It's beyond difficult, sweat slick to his

skin, but he does it anyway. His heart races, chest rising and falling. Through flames and metal and wood scraps, he races for the exposed exit.

Cold night air hits his face, and he rips his gas mask off with a pant. He lays Hitoshi on the grass far away, grabbing water from his bag and dumping small amounts onto his face and neck.

Coughs, and Hitoshi's eyes creak open. Midoriya sobs, wraps his arms around him.

"Shit!"

He turns, watches Dabi come racing out. His skin has caught, blue flames unable to stop. Despite it, his hands are clear of fire, and he drags Todoroki's unconscious body from the house.

Dabi looks at them, and Midoriya acts quickly, dumping his remaining water onto his burning skin. Steam rises, and Dabi pants, his arms and wrists covered in red, exposed skin.

"My dad started the fucking fire," Dabi rasps, his voice smoke-riddled. Todoroki is limp on the ground. "I'll get us in contact with Kurogiri. We need to get the hell out of here."

Sirens sound down the road. Dabi pulls his phone out, brings it to his ear. Nobody comments on the grip he keeps on his brother's arm, his back facing the flames as though he can shield Todoroki from them.

But Midoriya looks around, his heart racing. "Where's Kacchan?"

The house buckles, collapses.

Dabi looks at it, shakes his head. "There's no way he's getting out of that—we need to fucking go."

"No," Midoriya says instantly, dodging the hand Hitoshi reaches for him. "He's still in there!"

"There's no fucking chance he's alive right now!" Dabi shouts at him. "Let's go!"

Black, swirling mist forms beside them. Golden eyes watch them from the smoky portal, and Dabi wastes not a second more. He tosses his brother in first, ensuring he's completely gone before snatching Hitoshi by his collar. He looks at Midoriya next.

"Kid, let's go!" Dabi snaps.

"I can't leave him," Midoriya argues, securing his mask again. "I'm going after him."

Dabi looks at him like he's insane. "You can't escape that! You aren't some fucking Hero!"

"I know." Midoriya takes off, ignoring the curse behind him. He steps foot inside, a burning piece of fabric headed for his head. It's melted away in seconds, blue flames obliterating it.

“I saw him over here,” Dabi calls, and Midoriya follows him as they sprint through the house. “Come on!”

“What are you doing!” Midoriya screams at him, his voice hoarse. “This could kill you!”

Dabi laughs, manic. “Let’s hope so!”

He grabs an engulfed beam with his bare hands, getting his teeth as he shoves it out of the way. Midoriya is hot on his heels, rushing through the house. They appear in the same room Hitoshi was trapped in, and Dabi leads them to the right of it.

There he is, unconscious, limp on the floor. Midoriya rushes to him, sliding along the floor and grabbing his head.

“Touya!” The house shakes with the sound of Endeavor's bellow.

Dabi is there one moment, then the next, red flames engulf him completely. Midoriya cries out as the villain catches aflame again. Those blue eyes lock onto Midoriya’s for only a moment before he turns away, chasing after the father who’s currently trying to kill them all. Midoriya doesn’t give him a moment more of his attention, focusing on Kacchan.

He peels his own gas mask off, coughing, only his face mask keeping the worst of the smoke inhalation out. He slides the plastic over Kacchan’s face, hoisting him up and against his chest. Tears stream thick lines through the soot on his face, sobs working their way out of his chest as he drags Kacchan towards the exit.

Fire, blue and orange, like beams of light as Dabi fights Endeavor. It’s awful, the smell of molten flesh making Midoriya gag and choke. He drags Kacchan through it all, his teeth gritted at the hot splotches of fire burning into his skin. Kacchan doesn’t move, eyes shut, and Midoriya takes him all the way to that portal.

Kurogiri watches him curiously, and Midoriya shoves his friend's limp body into the black abyss.

He turns back to that house, watches the last of it collapse as fire trucks arrive out front. The orange and blue flames are gone now, only smoke remaining.

But…

Fuck!

Midoriya rushes towards the house again. He’s weak, exhausted, dripping in sweat and red with his burnt skin. He keeps going despite it, a helicopter flying overhead as he rushes in.

He sees that scared, ruined hand and begins to pull. Dabi’s body is covered in wood, burnt nearly to a crisp. He drags him anyway. The idiot is coughing, laughing, ready to burn to death. Midoriya doesn’t let him, his muscles screaming as he drags him out of the flames.

He catches sight of Endeavor’s coughing body, pinned beneath hot drywall. Midoriya doesn’t care; he looks away, ignores the man’s screams for help. He drags Dabi out instead, coughing

and crying, and they both go through the portal.

Darkness. Smoke.

And Midoriya stumbles through to the other side, trips on a body, and falls against the counter of a bar. He heaves, tearing his mask off to vomit on the clean floor of the bar.

He trembles, nearly loses consciousness, but manages to stay awake.

“Ew.”

He turns, hair slick with sweat, skin red. Tenko makes a nasty face from his barstool, Himiko sitting next to him and sipping a Capri Sun.

“You look awful.”

Midoriya looks at the floor, where unconscious bodies are scattered. Hitoshi lost consciousness again, Kacchan’s body thrown carelessly and haphazardly on top of him. Todoroki is strewn about, limbs spread wide like a starfish. Dabi’s barely lucid, wheezing and laughing on the ground before it dies out as he faints.

Only Midoriya remains alert.

Tenko smiles at him. “I give it five seconds.”

“Four!” Himiko says.

“Three.” Spinner chimes in from wherever he was.

They don’t get to the next number before the exhaustion hits Midoriya full force. He stumbles, slumps, and the world goes dark.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Chapter 49: Kamino Ward

Chapter Summary

The League interacts with the Heroes

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shinso blinks slowly, his eyelids weighed down and heavy. His entire body feels sluggish, exhausted. Still, he forces himself to stay awake. He's not sure how long he's been asleep, only that he's woken up several times and fallen back asleep immediately.

He lulls his head to the side, peers at the floor he's on. He's lying on what seems like a sleeping bag, and beside him, Bakugou sleeps. He looks awful, hair seared and face red. Shinso remembers next to nothing but getting caught in one of the rooms as the house went up in flames. Still, the slightly red outline of a gas mask on Bakugou's face is evident.

What the hell happened?

He groans, tries and fails to sit up. With a coughing fit, he manages to find the strength to pull his body up. He's in a dark, cold room. Todoroki is at his feet, also asleep and much worse for wear than Bakugou is. His clothes are nearly completely charred, and what appears to be a band of a handprint is on his wrist. Someone, maybe Dabi, must've dragged him out of the house by the limb and burnt a scar into his hand.

Shinso coughs more, his lungs heavy, exhaustion pulling at him. The room is completely enclosed in concrete, empty of anything other than their sleeping bags and a bottle of water. He takes it, sips slowly, searching for a window or light switch. He doesn't find one, plunged into darkness with two other idiots.

Where is Izuku?

He shoves Bakugou's shoulder. "Wake up."

Bakugou grumbles, swats at him in his sleep. Shinso smacks him across the face, and the man sits upright instantly. It's followed by a coughing fit, to which Shinso hands him the bottle of water. He drains it, leaving nothing for Todoroki, who slowly creaks his eyes open.

The three of them are coughing like maniacs, all waking up in this room.

"Where are the lights?" Bakugou rasps quickly, scooting slightly closer to Shinso. "Why's it so dark in here?"

“Fuck if I know,” Shinso replies, giving Bakugou a side eye when he scoots even closer. “Personal space, Kacchan.”

“Where’s everyone else?” Todoroki asks, his voice completely shot. “Where are we?”

“I literally woke up ten seconds ago,” Shinso says, coughing into his hand. “We’ve all got the same amount of information.”

Bakugou tries to stand, slips on the sleeping bag. He curses, crawls to Todoroki. “Ignite!”

“We could have limited oxygen,” Todoroki argues.

“Fuck you!” Bakugou snips, before cupping his hands together. Sparks dance on his palms, casting the room in a shifting yellow light. He takes a deep breath, staring at the walls with whale eyes. “We need to get out of here.”

“Great idea,” Shinso says, slowly standing. “Wish I had thought that. Thank god Kacchan is here.”

Bakugou ignores him, shoving off the floor and rushing to the door. He’s eager, antsy, and Shinso shares a confused look with Todoroki. Obviously, they all want to get out of here, but it’s clear that wherever they are is safe. Someone has been tending to their wounds, if the bandages wrapped around them are any indication. The water was a help too, even the sleeping bags were better than what he’s gotten out of most foster homes.

The idiot grabs the door handle, twists and pulls it. It doesn’t budge, and he throws himself against it. Still, the door remains intact.

“Fuck!” Bakugou shouts, raising a leg and kicking the weak point of the door. “Fuck! Fuck!”

“Jesus,” Shinso coughs out, “Don’t waste your energy.”

“Fuck you!” Bakugou yells, his voice hoarse. He slams against it again. “Open this fucking door!”

“Turn off your explosions,” Todoroki murmurs, “We might be underground. It’s cold enough that it’s a high possibility. We need to conserve oxygen.”

“No,” Bakugou snips, sparks flying off his palm. “I’m going to explode the door.”

“If it doesn’t break with your body, then any blast extreme enough to take it down could kill us,” Shinso argues, “This whole room echoes—you’d shatter our eardrums and fill the room with smoke.”

Bakugou pounds on it, and Shinso remembers then that he’s afraid of the dark. Shit. He looks around, squinting at the walls. When he finds a small, almost invisible button, he presses it. An overhead light flickers, dimly illuminating the room in an old, orange color.

Those sparks die out, and Bakugou takes a deep breath, his shoulders rising and falling unevenly. The light allows them a better chance to look around. No windows, no other doors,

no food or extra water. Just the three of them and thick black sleeping bags.

Todoroki finally stands up, knocks on different walls. “Solid concrete, nothing hollow. The odds of blasting a hole out of here are slim. We’d die of carbon monoxide poisoning before we made any real progress.”

“OPEN THIS FUCKING DOOR!” Bakugou screams, pounding on it. It’s pure metal. “LET US OUT.”

“I’m sure you’re really convincing them,” Shinso says blandly, gazing around the space. “I think we’re going to have to wait this out."

“Fuck no,” Bakugou snaps, yanking the handle again. “This is bullshit.”

“Let me do the talking if anyone comes,” Shinso tells them. “I’ll grab their minds, get us an escort out.”

“This is the worst fucking idea ever,” Bakugou spits, but he plops onto the floor all the same. Shinso doesn’t miss that Bakugou sits directly under the dim light. Avoiding the shadows in the corner of the room.

A headache pounds in Shinso’s head. It’s followed by an ache in his lungs, the throbbing of his burn wounds. He can only imagine how Izuku is right now. If he made it out at all.

“Did any of you see Izuku?” he asks quietly.

Todoroki shakes his head. “I was out instantly. I hit my head, I don’t remember anything more than falling.”

They look at Bakugou, who stares at his boots with his teeth gritted. “Last I saw him, he was carrying you out of the fire.”

Shinso frowns. “Shit.”

“What?” Bakugou says, voice picking up an octave. “You two made it out, yeah?”

Shinso shakes his head. “He and Dabi went back in after you.”

“What?” Bakugou says roughly. “You let him?”

“I was dying of smoke inhalation!" Shinso shouts. “I couldn’t exactly stop him!”

“Did you see anything else?” Todoroki asks.

Shinso deflates, sagging from his spot against the wall. “No. They threw me into that portal thingy, and I woke up here.”

A blanket of silence falls over them. There’s a high possibility that both Midoriya and Dabi are dead. Throwing just the three of them into the portal could’ve led to their capture by the

league. Given what happened to Izuku in his brief time here, it's not the most amazing realization to come across.

Shinso pulls his knees to his chest, rests his chin atop them. Todoroki sits against the other wall, perfectly still and stoic. Even then, Shinso can see the slump of his shoulders. He's come to the same conclusion, his eyes pinned to one spot on the floor, avoiding looking at them. Bakugou's the opposite, insisting there's no way the others are dead and banging on the door over and over again.

They fucked up this whole plan. Endeavor was meant to stay at the door longer, but he opened it and saw Shinso, then immediately shut it again. Dabi was a wildcard, too. Rushing in and fucking it all up. Without him, though, Bakugou and Todoroki would both be dead. If Bakugou is here, then that means that at least one of the two of them made it out. He's unsure if it's Dabi or Izuku.

But judging by the room they're locked in, it's not the option that they want.

The door clicks, and they all turn as a small slit at the bottom opens up.

"Hello!" It's the girl, her high-pitched voice riddled with giggles. "Welcome back! We thought at least one of you would die."

"Open this fucking door!" Bakugou shots, kicking the metal.

The girl giggles. "No can do! Can't let you three Heroes go roaming around, can we? Don't worry, you'll be let out soon."

"Is Touya okay?" Todoroki asks softly. "Midoriya?"

"Alive enough," the girl answers, and then a plastic bag is shoved through the hole. It slides along the ground, through Bakugou's legs, and hits Shinso's foot. "Fill those for me. We couldn't risk doing this until after you recovered. Once those are done, we'll let you out."

The slot closes, and Bakugou curses before banging against it again. The plan to let Shinso do the talking was left behind, fucking idiots. Shinso just grabs the plastic baggie, his brows furrowed as he opens it and pulls out long syringes and needles.

Todoroki goes pale in the face. "Oh no."

How did he get paired up with the biggest wussies in the world? Bakugou is scared of the dark, and Todoroki is scared of needles. This isn't even fair.

Shinso grits his teeth, looking at the three sharp-tipped needles. He's well aware of what will happen with this blood. Bakugou seems to know too, because he takes one look at the long syringes and bangs on the door again.

"The quicker we do this," Shinso says, pushing the air from the syringe and lining the tip up with a vein in his wrist. "The quicker we get out."

"You're giving them your fucking blood?!" Bakugou shouts. "Are you an idiot?"

“The needle could be laced,” Todoroki argues.

Shinso pushes it into his skin, the slight sting of pain welcomed. “I’m getting the hell out of here. You two can fuck around all you want, but I’m finding Izuku.”

“God dammit!” Bakugou shouts, glaring.

Red fills the plastic container. This syringe is gigantic, and the thick crimson filling it only makes Todoroki’s face turn green. Bakugou looks grossed out too; his lips curled in disgust. Pussies.

Shinso breathes deep, slowly withdrawing more and more blood until it’s full. Only then does he tug it out of his arm, cap it with a red lid, and shove it back into the baggie.

He grabs the next syringe, looks between them. “Who’s next?”

Nothing.

Shinso narrows his eyes. “I’m sticking one of you, so either volunteer or I’m pinning you down. Who’s it going to be?”

“Not fucking me—“ Bakugou stops talking, eyes glazing.

Stupid.

Shinso approaches slowly, squats down. He grabs the moron's arm, digs the tip of the syringe into his pale skin. Bakugou doesn’t react, not even a twitch of the eye. Shinso slowly draws the blood out, fills the plastic to the brim, then withdraws it. He caps it, bags it, then smacks Bakugou harshly across the face again.

He’s enjoying smacking him.

Bakugou blinks back to reality, his face growing red with rage. Shinso ignores the curses flung at him, turning to Todoroki with the third syringe.

“Oh no,” he mumbles, shaking his head. “I’m going to be sick.”

“Come on,” Shinso says, cautiously approaching. “Sit still.”

“I can’t do this,” Todoroki says, his throat dry. “Knock me out, do what you just did with Bakugou.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes—“ and he’s gone.

It really shouldn’t be this easy to deceive people, let alone 1-A students. Bakugou flings so many curse words at him that Shinso lets them filter into his head as white noise. A trail of his own blood drips down his arm from the wound, but he ignores it. Instead, he grabs Todoroki’s not ruined limb, sticks the needle in, and starts pulling blood out.

“This has got to be a fucking trick!” Bakugou curses. “If we give that lunatic our blood—she’ll just leave us in here.”

“It’s leverage,” Shinso snips, carefully pulling back the lever of the syringe. “She likely can’t resist exposed blood very well. When she comes back, let me do the talking, *please.”*

“I can’t believe we’re doing this,” Bakugou says, face cupped in his hands. “This was stupid. This was so fucking stupid.”

He flicks the syringe when it’s full, warm blood sloshing inside. He caps it, then whispers a command to Todoroki. He stands instantly, unable to resist the order. Shinso watches as Todoroki approaches Bakugou, then punches him so hard in the balls that a wheeze works its way out of Shinso’s ruined throat. He bags the syringe, coughing and laughing as Bakugou holds his crotch in his hands and falls to his knees.

Todoroki blinks back to consciousness a moment later, confused. “What happened? Did you take my blood?”

“Yup.”

“Why is Bakugou on the ground?”

“No idea.”

“I’m gonna…” Bakugou squeaks out, “Kill you.”

“Okay!” Shinso shouts, slamming his palm against the door. “I’ve got your blood!”

The slot opens immediately, a silent demand. Shinso stares at it, the bag crinkling in his hands.

“You’ve got to let us out first,” he says, ignoring Bakugou cussing at him. “Don’t you want the blood?”

She doesn’t respond; her shadow is barely visible from the door slot.

“I’m an AB,” Shinso offers, “doesn’t that sound… uhh… yummy?”

She snorts. The slot shuts. He thinks this plan has gone to shit, but a moment later, the door clicks. Bakugou shoves it open, dashing into the hall. Todoroki follows, and Shinso goes last, glaring at the two of them. Both have gone perfectly still, which he follows suit.

She points Todoroki’s gun at their heads. “Give me the blood, pretty please!”

Shinso’s eye twitches. “Where’s Izuku?”

“It won’t work.” Izuku opens a door in the hall, appearing from who knows where. “She knows about your Quirk; she won’t fall for that.”

He glares at Himiko, and she smiles. “Hello!”

“You stole my gun,” he states, eyeing it. “Rude.”

“You promised me a computer!” she cries out, shifting the gun among the three of them. “Don’t think I won’t shoot one of them!”

“Oh, I’m sure,” Izuku says sarcastically. He approaches, grabs it from her, then snatches the bag from Shinso and tosses it to her. “Get out of here.”

She giggles, kisses his cheek as quickly as she can before Izuku shoves her off. Then she takes off down the hall. Bakugou looks like he’s going to chase after her, but Izuku holds the gun now, pointing it at Bakugou’s chest.

“What are you doing?” he grits.

“Let’s go,” Izuku says, eyes dark, “There’s no time for this.”

“You gonna shoot me, Greenie?”

“Walk.”

“Izuku—“ Shinso starts.

“Walk.”

Fuck. They do, turning and going in the opposite direction. That same purple gate meets them at the end of the hall. Todoroki steps through it mindlessly, and Shinso shoves Bakugou through before he can say any more stupid shit. Then he looks at Izuku, who keeps the gun level with Shinso’s forehead.

His eyes narrow. “Where is Izuku?”

The illusion smiles, tosses him the gun. Shinso catches it before Izuku places both hands on his chest and pushes him into the portal. As Shinso falls, Izuku’s face melts and morphs, slipping into a wet pile.

Shinso lands on his ass on the other side.

“What the fuck!” Bakugou shouts, "Where the hell did he go?”

“It wasn’t him.” Shinso stands, brushes himself off. “It was that Twice guy.”

“Where are we?” Todoroki looks around, his brows furrowed.

It’s sunset, meaning at least a day has passed, maybe more. They’ve appeared in the alleyway of a town. A few steps out, and they’re standing on the bustling streets of Kamino Ward. He looks around, is met with gasping and screaming.

He looks at a large Jumbotron, and immediately understands why.

***

“Akatani.”

Midoriya grumbles, his dreams shaking and melting away.

“Wake up.”

He blinks his eyes open, stares at a low rising ceiling.

“Come on, get up.”

He turns his head, coughing. He meets Tenko’s red eyes, his grim expression. The room he’s landed in is small, bland. He rests on a blue bedspread, the small bed holding his weight comfortably. There are pain meds and a glass of water on the nightstand, and a huge tub of Vaseline. It occurs to him it’s for Tenko’s ruined skin, a side effect of the Quirk he was never meant to have.

He’s in Tenko’s room.

“…what?”

“You need to go,” Tenko says softly, gesturing to the yellow backpack and red shoes he’s set at the end of the bed for Midoriya. “There’s no time.”

Midoriya shakily sits up, coughing. His brother grabs him some pain meds, offers the glass of water, and Midoriya warily takes it. He hasn’t seen Tenko since they fought. His fingers are still missing when hands Midoriya his shoes.

“What’s going on?” he asks.

Tenko stands. “You’ve been out for a day and a half. I thought it was best that you and your friends sleep.”

The door to the room opens, Himiko appearing. “Me and Twice just dropped them off in Kamino. Kurogiri is monitoring the situation before he swings back for Viridant.”

Midoriya furrows his brows, glancing around him. Tenko’s got a PC in the corner, a TV beside it with all sorts of gaming devices. He’s got no idea what any of it is, but there’s a lone beanbag on the floor for him to sit in while he plays by himself.

“What’s going on?” Midoriya asks again.

Tenko nods at Himiko, and she takes off running down the hall. Twice pokes his head in briefly, apologizes for trying to kill Midoriya, says he’ll do it again, then apologizes a second time for saying that. He’s off a moment later, and Tenko grabs Midoriya’s backpack, helps him put it on.

“I’m not sure we’ll be in contact anytime soon. If you don’t hear from me by the time OverHaul is captured, then you need to be the one to take him out,” Tenko says grimly, before jerking his chin to the hall. Midoriya follows after him, and they head down the same halls that he fled from when he was kidnapped. “Don’t reach out to me, alright? I’ll find a way to contact you when he’s done with me.”

“Tenko,” Midoriya grabs his arm, jerks him to a stop. “What’s going on?”

Tenko frowns. “Dads in town.”

Midoriya’s heart drops to his feet. “What?”

“The news,” his brother says, “Reported on a house fire and a full confession from Endeavor’s social media that detailed the abuse he put his children through. Dad saw it; he knows Viridant isn’t dead. He’s back in town—to kill you.”

His eyes glow wide. “Does he know that I’m…?”

“No,” Tenko says, then scratches the dry skin of his neck. “I don’t think so—if he knows Viridant is his kid, then I couldn’t begin to explain how. It doesn’t matter. You need to get out of here. He wants Viridant dead.”

“Why?” Midoriya asks, following after Tenko as he moves again. They head down the stairs. “What did I do?”

“You got away,” Tenko says simply. “He tries to kill you, what, two times now? Once in the Nomu tunnels, second in your friend's house. People don’t just escape him—you’ve got his attention now. And he knows I gave him a fake name.”

Midoriya breathes heavily. “What’s going to happen to you?”

“I’ve been putting off testing,” Tenko says, scoffing at the idea. “I’ll probably get work done to me by his damn doctor.” At the look on Midoriya’s face, he swallows. “Don’t worry about it—you need to get out of here.”

“Tenko—“

“This isn’t some fucking bonding time,” Tenko says, eyeing the swirling mist a black that appears in the room. “Keep your mom safe, pray to god that your friends didn’t wander far.”

“Wait—“ Midoriya grabs his arm, stopping him from backing him into the portal. “What if he hurts you?”

“It’s nothing I’m not used to,” Tenko says, his eyes growing hard. “Don’t come searching for me, you understand? I’m not fucking kidding, Akatani, he will eliminate you. You can’t die—not yet.”

“Let me stay,” he argues. “We’ll fight him together.”

Tenko hesitates, for only a moment. Himiko appears again, Dabi in tow, Twice on her other side. Spinner's there a moment later, and Tenko shakes his head at Midoriya. It occurs to him then, that at this moment, his brother already has a family. Midoriya isn't sure when he started to care about Tenko, but stupidly, foolishly, he does.

But Midoriya has Mama, has Hitoshi, has Kacchan, has UA. And Tenko has this small group of misfits, of people who never really found their place in society. And maybe Midoriya never found the right place for himself, either, but it seems to be a genetic trait—to survive. Tenko looks at him, and in the reflection of his eyes, Midoriya sees himself. A stranger, a casualty. Not his brother.

"I'll find a way to contact you," Tenko says, and he stands with his family, one he wasn't born into but that he found. People who look up to him, who take care of him, and who he takes care of in return.

And he shoves Midoriya through the portal.

"Hey." Hands catch him before he hits the ground. He's picked up, held between arms. "Thank god."

Midoriya wraps his arms around Hitoshi, hides the hurt in his chest. "What's going on?"

When he pulls away, he sees that Kacchan's gaze is locked onto the Jumbotron that stares down over whatever town they landed in. Todoroki's got a grim expression on his face, watching a scene unfold on the screen. Midoriya prowls over, Hitoshi holding onto his arm as they go.

All for One. Dad. He faces off against All Might. There are collapsed buildings, debris and dust clouding an overhead camera view of the scene. Helicopters circle the two of them, trying desperately to film the fight. A few go down, screaming and spinning out as All for One wipes them out. There are evacuation orders, people crowding around screens and waiting to see what will happen next.

Midoriya's heart races. He can only watch the fight go on, watch as they brutalize and beat each other down.

Shinso gasps, covering his mouth when All Might weakens, transforms. Murmurs fill the town square, the truth of All Might's appearance haunting everyone. Midoriya watches it all, his heart breaking, his idol *losing.*

He's going to lose.

A woman breaks her way out the debris trapping her, screaming something at All Might that the cameras don't pick up. And as the view pans around, and horrors fill Midoriya's chest, warmth slips into his palm. He doesn't have the strength to pull his hand away. Kacchan locks their fingers together, his hands soft and hot. It grounds Midoriya, bringing him back to reality as the fight continues.

“Come on, All Might!” They both scream, people chanting and yelling, pleading for the symbol to keep going, to keep winning.

Kacchan squeezes his hand, and neither of them looks away as All for One gets beaten down. Cars whizz by, evacuating in fear that that All Might won’t win. People run, scatter, and the two of them seem to be rooted in place. Begging, pleading.

And All Might wins. He’s crying when he points at the screen, a smile still on his face.

“Now, it’s your turn.”

Your turn. Whispers fill his head. He looks around wildly, searching for the cause. Voices, loud yet haunting, whispering yet mind-rattling. *Your turn.* Color dances on his skin, One for All activating, and the voices get louder, amped up. He squeezes Kacchan’s hand, his skin vibrating, his eyes rattling.

Darkness.

Midoriya can’t speak. He can’t feel his body. He’s in a dark room, only able to look around the complete emptiness he’s appeared in. There are eight others in here. Two face the wall, unwilling to look at him. One is a vibrant, blinding yellow, its glowing blue eyes only half-formed. Embers, and they look like All Might.

The other five stare at him from red chairs, people he’s only seen on the internet. Nana Shimura, long black hair and dark eyes. En Tayutai, his shirt collar covering half his face. Daigoro Banjo, hand on his hip and goggles atop his bald head. Shinomari Hikage, a scar sliced down his face.

And the last, a regular-looking man. But his eyes—rounded and wide, the same eyes Midoriya has. Yoichi Shigaraki, Midoriya knows who he is without a word being shared. His father's brother, the first holder of One for All.

Bruce Lee, and Kacchan’s ancestor, Toshitsugo Kudo, face the wall in the void.

Yoichi looks at him, his face pulled into a frown, his gaze heavy.

Now it’s your turn.

“Wake up!”

Midoriya’s vision returns, and he gasps, coughing, choking on his own saliva. Kacchan’s gripping his face, holding him upright. Todoroki and Hitoshi are watching from the side, their eyes wide. But Kacchan holds Midoriya up, his hands shaking.

“Where did you just go?” he asks.

Midoriya pants. “I don’t… I don’t know.”

Kacchan’s eyes are wide, trailing along the glowing colors on Midoriya’s skin. He touches a trail with his finger, the color humming and vibrating at the touch before flickering out

completely. Midoriya adjusts himself, his legs shaky, trying to stay upright.

His eyes lock on the screen, watching as All for One is loaded up in Quirk suppressant gear, shoved into a police van. All Might didn't finish the job; he didn't kill him.

Now it's your turn.

The holders of One for All. They know about him. They know who he is. They were watching him, waiting for him. Triggered by the depletion of All Might's power.

"Hey," Kacchan says, his voice soft. "Let's get you home."

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 50: Symbol

Chapter Summary

Midoriya is paranoid and gets comfort from his peers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the rush and commotion of All Might's battle, nobody noticed the absence of four UA students. They snuck back into school easily. The following classes on Monday were cancelled, allowing students proper time to recover from the downfall of two Pro Heroes. Midoriya hasn't moved from his bed since, haunted by what he experienced.

People knock on his door, talk to him. He lies in bed and stares at the ceiling. He hasn't been able to sleep, too afraid to go back to that place. There's no reasonable explanation for it other than pure insanity. He must've inhaled too much smoke—maybe he died in that house. Maybe he's nothing but a pile of ash blowing around in the breeze. He can't understand what he saw, how it's possible to have known these people he's never met. He's only seen an image of a few of them. But Yoichi, Midoriya has never seen him before.

And he *knew* who Midoriya was. Without saying it, Midoriya knows that he knows. He knows that he knows that he knows. Fuck! He's going fucking crazy. He's filled the rest of his notebook up with half-baked theories and questions. He's spent hours pacing back and forth. He's ignored anyone who knocks on the door or calls his phone.

He's horrified by what happened; he can't think about it. He's only stopped long enough to see the news, observing the aftermath of it all.

All Might retired, and the same day, Endeavor was pronounced comatose. His house burned down, a beam landing on his head and legs. Turns out, they did manage to steal the bastard's legs, as they had melted off his body before he could be recovered. Not that anyone truly cares. The Heroes Commission was outed as well, scrambling for restructuring and to locate the leak in this information. Protests have started in the streets, people line up outside of UA with signs and anger.

He's absolutely done for. The clock counts down his remaining time at the school before Aizawa-Sensei or Nezu come after him. He's going insane. He's going to jail. He can't get himself to get out of bed long enough to deal with the world as it comes crashing down. This is going to tie back to him one way or another. What was meant to be a night out to take out an abuser ended in the destruction of both the number one and number two Hero.

He's so done for.

He’s destabilized the entire world. This goes beyond Japan; the leaked documents from the organisation don’t just end there. The Hero’s Commission is a worldwide agency, not just in Japan. Though Japan's branch is the first to fall, America’s sector is wobbling now. The people are rioting for a document recall, and governments are challenging the commission as its own entity. Europe is a close second for crashing and burning, each individual branch weakening as more and more corrupt information comes out.

He had wanted to take down Endeavor—he was unaware that he was destroying the entire system. It was his goal—sure. But further down the line, when it couldn’t bite him in the ass. He can’t function. The amount of stress on him right now has sprouted white hairs. He’s weighed down by it. He hasn’t eaten or slept in over twenty-four hours. The flooring of his room has footprints worn in it from his pacing. He’s going to lose everything.

He sits on his bedroom floor, sticks a cigarette in his mouth. Breathes in, breathes out.

A knock sounds on his door, and he eyes the chair he jammed under the handle days ago. He’s already screwed with the sensors on his window, but without his full gear, he’s got next to nothing to escape with.

“Young Midoriya?”

All Might. He breathes in, breathes out.

“It’s just me. I thought you might need a pep talk. Seems like something big is coming your way.”

In. Out.

“You got to let me in, kid,” All Might says quietly. “I promise it’s only me out here.”

In. Hold it until it burns. Out. He coughs, swatting away the smoke in the air. His eyes are rimmed with red, dark circles lining them. His hair is greasy and messy; he hasn’t showered since he burned down Endeavor’s house.

“I’m dying.” He looks at the door, cigarette an inch from his mouth. “I’m dying, kid.”

Midoriya swallows, holds the stick between his lips and drags the chair away. Slowly, he squeaks the wood open, peers a lone eye out into the hall. It really is empty. He stretches the door open enough to fit All Might’s scrawny frame, shutting it immediately after and jamming the chair under again.

“Bad habit,” All Might says, then grabs a cigarette from the open box and lights it. Midoriya’s gone through an entire pack already, so he should be more protective of his stash. But he just watches All Might as he sits on Midoriya’s bed and smokes.

Midoriya leans against his desk, his lower back pressing into the grain. “What's the situation?”

All Might blows air out. “I’ve covered for you mostly, but Eraser still thinks you might have had a part in destroying Endeavor's home and career.”

“Awesome.”

“Your mom is losing her mind over All for One.”

“Even better.”

“And All for One has personally requested Viridant to visit him in jail. He has no idea who or where you are, but he just keeps asking.”

“Wow, can it get any better than this?”

All Might huffs out a laugh, knees bent and propped onto the metal bed frame. “I figured your involvement out pretty quickly. I’m sure you’re awaiting the downfall from others.”

Midoriya rubs his face frantically, trying to wipe away any trace of who he is. “I didn’t mean to cause this.”

“Jesus, I hope not,” All Might says, “I’ve been trying to dismantle the commission for years. You did my life’s work in a day. I’m a bit jealous.”

“Jealous?” Midoriya squeaks out. “I could face life in prison if I’m caught.”

All Might snickers. “It’s no fun if there’s no risk.”

“You’ve lost it too,” Midoriya concludes. “We’ve both lost it.”

All Might laughs again, coughing up a bit of blood. He doesn’t wear his yellow suit, just an old T-shirt and jeans. His hair has been cut, cropped closer to his head. He looks younger than he really is; his skeleton self is still hard to look at, but his humanity is apparent.

“You don’t join this line of work without a bit of insanity,” he says, eyes trained on Midoriya. “Especially not someone from your background.”

“My… background?”

All Might smiles at him. “Kid, you really think I don’t know who you are?”

Midoriya’s heart hammers wildly. “What?”

“He killed *everyone,”* All Might says finally, his gaze hard as he smokes. “My predecessor, my family, my friends. I dedicated my life to destroying him, to doing everything I could to fix the damage he’s done. The reason I’m number one isn’t because I’m an idiot.”

“I…”

“He’s had lots of kids,” All Might says finally, taking a deep inhale. “I’m lucky I found one.”

“How long have you known who I am?” Akatani asks.

“That night,” All Might says, voice low, “When you first met me in my natural form. When Eraser was chasing you across rooftops, and you jumped over the alleyway I was standing in.

We locked eyes—that's when I knew."

Akatani breathes heavily. "You never said anything."

"Didn't want to scare you off." His idol shrugs, "I meant what I said. You have the heart of a Hero. There is nothing more I believe is more true."

Akatani shakes, staring down at his half-finished cigarette. "Who else knows?"

"Just me, kid," All Might says. "And I suppose whoever you've told."

He nods slowly, a bit of the tension leaving his body. "You said UA will protect me?"

"Under the right circumstances," All Might says. "I'm willing to vouch for you. But like I've said, this can't tie directly to you unless you let it. The world is changing, but you don't have to go down for it unless you want to." He shrugs. "Maybe when you're older. But terrorism at this age? I'd wait a little. And, hey, weirdly enough, no one reported the exit route that Shinso's been securing for months. Bizarre."

Akatani can't believe what he's hearing. "You…"

"I was Quirkless too, you know," All Might says, winking. "I know what it's like to survive that, to endure that. I always wanted to be a Hero. Maybe I wasn't a cool vigilante, but man, I think I would've done the exact same as you if Nana never gave me her Quirk." All Might laughs. "I was worried you'd get hurt, but you have the heart of a survivor in you. I trusted you'd find your way to Heroism when it was right for you."

His eyes are wide. "You covered for me?"

All Might nods. "Like I said, there's a time when Heroism is right for someone. I just had to wait, watch, and there you were."

"You're…" he searches for the word. "Evil."

All Might belts out a laugh. "*I'm* evil? You're the one who's been plotting to take my Quirk!"

Akatani flushes, hysterical. "I didn't know you knew!"

"I don't know everything," All Might says, "But I know what a sneaky kid looks like. I *was* you. Maybe not under the exact same circumstances, but the same general feeling."

"This is insane!" he shouts, laughing loudly. "I can't believe—I can't believe this!"

All Might watches him jump around, vague amusement lining his face. He smokes silently, opens the bedroom window to vent it. He eyes the removed sensors and screen, snickering at them.

When Akatani is done, All Might holds a hand out. "Hand over the cigarettes. I've got to be somewhat responsible."

“Seriously?” he asks. All Might raises a brow, and Akatani huffs before slapping the box down in his hands. They stare each other down, and he huffs again before retrieving a second and third box. “I was starting to think you were cool.”

“I’m very cool,” All Might says. “Let’s get our story straight.”

It takes a good hour of talking, debriefing, structuring, to come up with a good cover story. They decide, with much guilt on Midoriya’s part, that Dabi’s taking the hit for Endeavor. Technically, the guy had planned to release all information to the public like this anyway. If he wants the heat, then he can have it. Midoriya doesn’t need any credit for the crime—that’s never what it’s been about. All Might seems to know that, more than willing to cover the brunt of Midoriya’s work.

Should it be alarming that his mentor is covering for Midoriya’s vigilantism? Yes. Is Midoriya put off by it? Not even a little.

But All Might—he’s not this perfect, untouchable man. He’s a Quirkless human; he’s someone who *gets* it. Someone who’s had the odds stacked against him and knows that any little thing can absolutely ruin Midoriya’s chances.

“Why didn’t you kill him?”

All Might’s dark eyes flicker to Midoriya’s, his voice taught. “Heroes don’t kill, young Midoriya.”

“If he gets out of that jail—“

“Which he won’t.”

“He’ll do all of this over again,” Midoriya says, the previously happy air turning grim. “He will kill and destroy everyone.”

His mentor sighs. “I stand for peace. I stand for safety and security. If I kill, then my power turns into the same kind that your father has. If I kill, then I am no better than him. He murders to ensure he stays on top, and if I do the same, then when the history books write our names down, nobody will be able to tell much of a difference at all.”

“So it’s about the public’s impression?”

“It’s always been about the public’s impression,” All Might tells him. “I am a Hero because I don’t want anyone else to have to be. I take the brunt of each blow, each battle, so others may feel safe and secure. It’s not my job, nor is it there’s, to hold the life of another human being in our hands and decide it’s unworthy of having.”

“But after all he’s done—“

“Young Midoriya,” he says, voice hard and absolute. “Murder is, and always will be, wrong. In any way, shape, or form. To see it as any alternative is inherently flawed. We are Heroes, we are not judges or jailkeepers. Our job is to save and protect, not prosecute.” He finishes

off his cigarette, digging the lit end into a small ashtray on the windowsill. “It’s imperative that you understand this.”

Midoriya grits his teeth, but nods. “I understand.”

“If you kill,” All Might says, hammering it in, “You are no better than the monster that made you. That made me. That made us.”

He deflates. “Okay.” Then the memories of All Might’s fight flicker to his mind. “Will the other successors be upset about this?”

All Might blinks slowly. “The… others?”

Midoriya nods softly before holding a hand out. Those colorful bands of power respond in kind, zigzagging across his palm and down his arms. Bakugou’s fingerprints light up, the burn mark outlined with raw power.

He tells All Might what he saw while his mentor attacked AFO. He talks about the void, the abyss. The figures watching him, waiting for him. The clear disapproval of Yoichi, the shame from Kudo and Bruce. The eager eyes, taking in his half-formed body. He tells All Might about his vessel, a yellow, glowing, wispy light. Those blue pupils hastily formed, as though the last embers of All Might’s fight with OFA had formed in the unending void of his mind.

When he looks up from his glowing hand, All Might makes a face. “That’s creepy.”

“What!” Midoriya shouts, reeling his hand back, color flickering out. “You don’t know what I’m talking about?!”

All Might shakes his head. “I have zero idea what you're referencing.”

Oh, god dammit! “I-I saw them! These vestiges—and they told me *now it’s your turn.* It was horrifying!”

All Might shivers. “You’re freaking me out.”

“All Might!”

“Okay, okay,” he holds his palms out, chuckling a little. “I suppose, in theory, since you have access to a previous user's Quirk, there’s a chance that you can communicate with the parts of these users who held OFA before you.” He frowns. “I’ve never… come across something like this before.”

“Can I ask someone about it?” Midoriya pushes. “Gran Torino—he came up in reference to Nana.”

All Might’s responding grief is palpable. “His funeral was two months ago.”

“Oh… I-I’m sorry, I hadn’t known.” His face grows hot, his shoulders sagging. “What happened?”

“He was old,” All Might says simply. “Fell over, had nobody to help him back up. I stopped by his home to ask him if he’d be willing to take you on as an apprentice. He’d been dead a few months, at least.”

“That’s awful,” Midoriya says, and his mind flickers to Rin. Lying alone in her house for months

Truth is, he’s not sure what happened to her or any of his friends. He hasn’t followed up on it, unable to. Aizawa-Sensei had told Midoriya he could come to him to talk about it, but Midoriya never did. He has no idea what became of their corpses. He doesn’t even know if there was a funeral or cremation. He can’t bring himself to look into it. In his head, the images of his friends are horrible and terrifying, but still painted in color. He fears that if he sees their bodies, or the stupid patch of dead grass that they lie beneath, then that color will fade.

He only has his fleeting memories to cling to—and he’s far too good at clinging to things that have never done him any good. Four people he used to know are dead—and he knows nothing more than that simple fact. The shame of it eats at him, but still, he can’t bring himself to see what’s become of them.

“What was Gran Torino like?” Midoriya asks, because he would’ve loved to tell someone what his friends had been like.

All Might chuckles. “A hard ass. He had that awkward old person humor and was relentless in training. Used to scare me shitless but... I don’t know, I respect him now. He was only strict because being anything other than that would’ve killed me.”

Midoriya smiles and says, "Tell me more about him.”

And All Might does. He spends a long time listening. He learns that Gran Torino loved Nana like a daughter, and the two of them spent long years working side by side. He had to pull All Might away from her before AFO killed them both, and All Might had resented him for years for it. He says he understands it all now, but that he wishes I could’ve still been different.

Midoriya listens the whole time, curled up into a ball on the desk chair. All Might talks about his glory days, of the Hero he used to be. He talks about Nana, about the family she left behind to keep AFO away. All Might had searched for her son, and Midoriya doesn’t have the heart to tell him what the man’s fate was.

Instead, he learns about the Quirk from a perspective other than his own. Midoriya’s goal had always been to take Dad out, to change the world's oppressive ways.

All Might just wanted to make his mom proud. It hits Midoriya like a punch, the way he feels as though he’s staring into a mirror at one of those haunted houses. The glass is warped, altering his appearance, but for a moment, he and All Might look exactly the same. Two sides of the same coin, two people who just want to make their mom proud.

“There was a time,” All Might says, his eyes distant. “Where everyone was just so scared. All the time. Every day. The time of civil unrest, a time spurred on by All for One. And I told

myself that no matter what, I'd find a way to change this fear. I'd find a way to ensure no one like my mom could ever be impacted by it again." He laughs, shakes his head. "I wonder what she'd think of it all now."

"You've lost a lot of people," Midoriya says.

"It comes with the job," All Might replies, and he smiles through the confession. "There will come a time, Midoriya Izuku, where you think you've lost it all. You must know, as I must warn you, that there is never a rock bottom you hit that doesn't hurt any less than the last one. You are going to lose people—friends, family, lovers, you're going to lose them. I wish someone had been more honest with me, so I'll be more honest with you." He leans forward on the bed, meets Midoriya's eyes. "There is no way out of this life that ends with comfort. There are only moments and instances, memories of when times were good. But those, too, will fade. Just as everything does."

Midoriya stares down at his socked feet. "Would you change anything if you could?"

"Oh," his mentor says, staring out the window, at the dark world beyond. "I know I should say I wouldn't. I should set a good example. But if I could go back in time and change things, I don't think there's a single thing I wouldn't try to do over."

"Should I be scared?"

"You should be absolutely terrified," All Might says, placing a hand over his heart. "It should shake you to your core; it should keep you up at night. Those who aren't afraid to be a Hero are those who will die doing it. Maybe it's cruel to say, but I won't lie to you. I won't sell you a story that isn't true. I wish—" he cuts himself off.

"What?"

"I wish," he starts again, clearing his throat. "That the system could change. The world is reforming now, I just wish it would change places like UA, next. A school full of children being trained to fight in wars. You're all too young, still too wide-eyed, just barely learning how to walk." All Might shrugs. "Maybe you can rattle and shake that into the world next, Young Midoriya. Stop this universe from destroying our children."

"I didn't expect you to be so anti-Hero," Midoriya said softly.

"I'm not anti-Hero, I'm anti-violence," All Might corrects. "I'm anti-death, I've seen too damn much of it. It gets old, it gets tiring. I fear you'll develop the same exhaustion as me and my peers. I wish I could prevent it, but I think I'm cursed to only encourage it."

"I'll change it." Midoriya decides then. "My friend—she hated the idea of it too. And maybe someone should start doing something about it."

"If anyone can," All Might says. "It would be you."

When All Might leaves for the night, Midoriya's nerves over Endeavor have settled. Still, that weight dread lines his stomach. All Might was right, and it's a scary thing to know, but

it’s undeniable.

He hates it. He keeps thinking of Dad getting out of prison, hunting him down at UA, and wiping the entire school off the damn grid. He knows Tartarus is a highly secured, near-impossible prison to escape. But he can’t shake the feeling that something is *wrong.* Happy endings aren’t just handed out; they’re earned. And the general positivity and upbeat environment unsettles him.

It’s been over a day, and he has heard nothing from Tenko. Midoriya listened to his request not to call or text, but that’s it. He’s stolen a laptop from UA’s technical rooms and started working tirelessly on it to get an IP off his brother’s phone. So far, nothing. But he’s a very patient person, and he’s going to find Tenko.

He sits at his desk, mumbling to himself as he searches through different WiFi pings. Tenko is thorough, his location is nearly impossible to trace. But Midoriya can’t give up on this—on him. If Dad is in prison, if the threat of his presence is truly eliminated, then where the hell is his brother? He hasn't been able to contact Himiko either, nor has he gotten a hold of Dabi. The other members of the League are more distant, but he would’ve thought *someone* would reach out to him.

He can’t stand it. He can’t.

When his phone buzzes, he all but launches himself over to it. But… the message on the screen is a far cry from what he expected.

Ground Zero: What are you up to, Greenie?

That’s a new addition, too. He can’t, for the life of him, shake Bakugou off. He’s latched on, likely seeing Midoriya’s dismissal as a challenge. It’s alarming, not to mention distracting. He’s uncertain why Bakugou can never seem to leave him alone, and he can’t help the guilt surrounding it. He’s done his best to pull away, to stop tormenting his childhood friend for what happened in the past. But it seems Bakugou’s grown anxiously attached to the behavior.

Which isn’t good *at all.* It makes it very hard to detach from him when he’s so constant. Midoriya again longs for and misses the comfort of the apartment, of distance, of silence. Bakugou was far from his mind then—at least, Midoriya convinced himself of that. He’s not certain he’s ever not thought about him, and it’s as difficult to accept as it is to change.

The infiltration of the yakuza group has been pushed back momentarily. Though plans to attack and take out the leader, Kai Chisaki, still hold strong. It’s just that, with so much media attention, Viridant's supposed involvement in the fire is a trending theme on the internet. While it's only rumors and speculation, people tend to associate his actions with fire and anti-Hoerism. Aizawa-Sensei won't be pleased about the betrayal from Midoriya, even if All Might barely covers it up. But having Midoriya so occupied and kept safely on school property will do wonders to improve his Sensei’s mood.

The stress of being a walking, glowing, neon target is eating away at him. He misses his old self. So assured, lost in the dark secrets of the world, with a presence so minuscule and small

that he could get away with anything.

But everyone's watching him now, and—

His phone buzzes again.

Ground Zero: Anything fun?

He never got around to changing Bakugou's contact name. And there's a hit of elation at the prospect of going back to how things were *before.*

Ground Zero: Knock knock.

Midoriya swallows a tight breath as knuckles rasp against his dorm room door. It's not the harsh rattling it was before when Bakugou had all but dragged him to Ground Beta. It's gentle, soft, a plea wrapped in a simple sound. He doesn't open the door.

Ground Zero: I will stand outside until you open the fucking door.

Fuck!

Midoriya grabs the handle, pulling it only a sliver open. Bakugou shoves in through the gap immediately, ignoring the hiss Midoriya lets out. He shuts the door, locks it, and faces Midoriya with a small plate of food in his hands.

They stare at each other.

"Eat."

Midoroya's eye twitches. "I don't need you to tell me what to do—"

"Eat the damn food, or I will pry your mouth open and shove it down your fucking throat," Bakugou threatens quietly, handing him the plate. "You haven't left your room since we got back."

Midoriya doesn't ask him why he's been monitoring his room activity. He takes the plate instead, grumbling at the steaming food piled onto it. Mama doesn't usually cook katsudon, sticking to chicken or fish, but he supposes she's got time to try new recipes. And it's absolutely delicious. It's his favorite food, and he swears Mama cooked it more flavorful than usual.

He inhales it, sitting on his bed and shoving the pork and rice into his mouth with chopsticks. It's the best she's ever cooked—he'll make sure to thank her for it.

Bakugou doesn't say a word until it's completely gone. "Good?"

"Oh my god," Midoriya mumbles, "I think this is the best thing I've ever eaten."

The arrogant grin is impossible to miss. "I tweaked the recipe you gave me for Christmas. Of course it's fucking good."

“You… you made me this?” Midoriya asks, his stomach suddenly churning. “Why?”

Bakugou gives him a bland look. “You can’t be serious.”

Oh! Oh, now he gets it. Bakugou must feel as though he owes Midoriya for saving him from the house fire!

“A-About the fire,” he starts, “it’s nothing—we’re even, okay? You saved Hitoshi, so you don’t owe me anything.”

Bakugou blinks slowly. “Did the hair dye and bleach fry your damn brain cells?”

“I’m serious!” he says, laying his chopsticks in the empty bowl and setting it on his windowsill. “I really appreciate what you did.”

“I didn’t do it for you,” Bakugou snaps. “It’s what Heroes do. We save people. And Eyebags —that’s a death no one deserves to feel.”

Midoriya’s eyes slide along the outline of the gas mask still burned into Bakugou’s face. It’s faint, a tinge of pink against his usually pale skin. The flames must’ve burnt the mark into his flesh, but it’ll dissipate.

“Right.” Midoriya nods. “Has he thanked you yet?”

Bakugou doesn't respond to that, narrowing his eyes. “Are you still hungry?”

“No—“

“Then go take a shower. Your room fucking stinks. You’ve been smoking.” Bakugou crosses his arms over his chest. “Are your wounds healed?”

Midoriya has no idea what to make of this. “Uhh… yes. They’re tender but—“

“Let me see them.”

“No.” He holds his hands out, swallows. “Really, they’re fine.”

Bakugou’s eyes slit impossibly smaller. “Have you slept?”

“Not yet—“

“Shower. Then bed.” Bakugou grabs the empty bowl. “I’ll wash this and air out your room.”

“What—“

“Go, dumbass!” Bakugou shouts at him, and Midoriya stands on pure instinct. “Hurry the hell up!”

He has no idea what’s happening, but a shower suddenly sounds beyond nice. Burn wounds and hot water don’t mix too well, but he’s eager to get washed up. So he listens, mind spinning from all the information he’s learned and uncovered today. When he steps into the

hot shower and his wounds sing with pain, he keeps thinking about how *good* that katsudon was. He can never confess to Mama that Bakugou's cooking is better—he can't believe he betrayed her like that.

He washes soot and ash off his face, his hair slick with it. It takes ages to get all the gunk off of him, careful not to irritate any of the burns he's maintained. Luckily, it seems the worst of it was on his neck and jaw from when he got pinned on that damn screw. Even then, it's not nearly as visible as he thought. He's left all his first aid in his room, so he sticks with a pair of pyjama pants and towel dries his dark hair.

When he makes it back to his room, it's been completely cleaned. Another steaming bowl of katsudon waits for him on a pair of fresh bedsheets. Bedsheets that *aren't* his. He stares at the green and black pattern, brows furrowed. He's certain this is his room…

"You're a fucking slob." A hand shoves him to the sheets. "Eat."

"I just ate."

"Then eat again!" Bakugou doesn't look at him, pointedly staring in the opposite direction. "Your regular bedding is being washed, so are all the dirty clothes and shit you shove under your bed. Disgusting."

Midoriya takes the hot bowl when it's handed to him. He's still absolutely confused by what's happening, but the smell of the pork and rice is making him dizzy with hunger. He chews slowly, savoring the meal, watching Bakugou move around the dorm room with a wary look.

He cleaned the footprints off the ceiling, opened the window, and plugged an air purifier into the wall. Midoriya's ashtray is gone, too, and a sly glance at his desk tells him that Bakugou stole the hidden fourth pack of cigarettes. Dammit.

Bakugou grabs a first aid kit from atop the wardrobe, and Midoriya is too lost in food heaven to ask him how he knows the layout of his dorm so well. Bakugou sets the small red box on the bed beside Midoriya, then flips it open.

"What are you doing?"

He ignores him, pulling out bandages and burn cream.

"What…" He doesn't move, holding his breath when Bakugou carefully dabs the white cream onto Midoriya's dark skin. He stays perfectly still, brows furrowed, a thousand different emotions swirling through him.

One by one, Bakugou covers each burn and then bandages it. His hands are warm, gentle, steady, and sure of themselves. Midoriya *really* needs to sleep, because he's delirious enough to allow this. He keeps eating the katsudon, unable to stop himself from shutting his eyes and just enjoying the warmth and comfort.

"What happened with your Quirk?" Bakugou finally asks, his voice so quiet that Midoriya doesn't respond for fear that he imagined it. "Are you fucking deaf?"

“Oh, uh,” he mumbles, eyes still shut. “Nothing.”

Bakugou scoffs, then his hands still. “Fucking hell—you never got the wound from that screw stitched up?”

“Huh?” he asks, still eating his rice. “What wound?”

“You got stuck on a screw when trying to save the other idiot. It looks like you’ve just had gauze slapped on it; it’s still open.” Bakugou touches the skin near Midoriya’s upper shoulder, and pain shoots through him. “It’s starting to get an infection.”

“I’ll just wrap it,” Midoriya says, attempting to stand.

Bakugou grasps his shoulder, shoves him back down onto the bed. “Sit still. Eat your damn food.”

“But—“

“Unless you want me to inform Aizawa-Sensei about the other night, then I suggest you fucking listen to me.” More rummaging in the first aid kit. “This isn’t going to feel good.”

Midoriya eyes the small needle and thread that Bakugou pulls out. As well as the bottle of disinfectant. He keeps quiet, gritting his teeth as the liquid is slowly poured onto the wound then dabbed up with gauze. Bakugou asks if the screw had any rust, to which Midoriya assures him it didn’t. Honestly, he’s not sure if it did or not. For a home so beautiful and lavish, it’s unlikely that the screw was anything other than pristine.

He tries not to move other than to shovel hot food into his mouth. He chews quietly, shutting his eyes as the needle pokes into tender skin, the thread slowly flowing through the new hole.

“Tell me about the Quirk,” Bakugou says again, his leg barely touching Midoriya’s. The feeling of it alone has Midoriya squirming away, earning a harsh smack to the back of his head and an order to stay still.

“There’s nothing to say.”

“You went somewhere,” A warm breath caressing his shoulder. “What happened?”

Oh, he can’t do this. He’s going insane. “What?”

“Are you listening to me, Greenie?” Bakugou snips, another twinge of pain as the thread reaches the other side. “When All Might was fighting, your Quirk activated, and your eyes rolled to the back of your damn head. Creepiest shit I’d ever seen. I had to hold you upright.”

“Oh, I’m sorry,” he mumbles, poking at the pork. “I didn’t know.”

“So where did you go? What happened?”

He had gone to a black abyss in his mind where the past holders of One for All looked at him and weighed how disappointed they were with All Might's choice. He doesn't say that. Instead, he grips the wooden bowl, pain lancing from the wound.

"Just got overwhelmed, I guess," he says quietly. Bakugou doesn't respond to that, pushing the needle through the skin once again. "Thanks, by the way. I know you saved Hitoshi for other reasons, but I don't know what I would've done if I had lost him."

Bakugou says, his voice a whisper. "Are the two of you dating or something?"

Midoriya's eyes widen, and he bucks out a wild laugh. He leans forward, much to Bakugou's dismay, and shakes with laughter. "No! No!"

"It was just a fucking question!"

"Oh my god." Midoriya wipes his eyes, still snickering. "I can't believe you asked me that. I've got to tell him! He'll throw up."

"Fuck you!"

Another laugh, his shoulders shaking. "You seriously thought we were, Kacchan?"

Kacchan.

The laughter dies out. Silence descends again, and Bakugou keeps stitching him up.

"We aren't," Midoriya says then, setting his empty bowl aside. "He's got a thing for Kaminari. Even if he didn't—I'm not—we aren't—relationships aren't in the cards for me at the moment."

Nothing.

Thread. Needle. Winter air.

"Okay," Bakugou says, then adds, "And IcyHot?"

"What about him?"

"You tell me."

Midoriya pauses, his eyes wide. "No! I'm not—I'm not dating *anyone.* That's—are you trying to make fun of me?" A small snort, and he elbows Bakugou. "You are! So mean!"

"You whine a lot."

"No, I don't!" Midoriya whines, elbowing him again. "Are you almost done?"

"Mhm." A small tug to the thread. "Just finished, let me wrap it."

He stays still again. Bakugou's fingers work quickly, pressing gauze to the wound and wrapping it in medical tape. When the warmth of his touch finally leaves, Midoriya finds

himself missing it. It's a stupid, selfish feeling, but it's there all the same. Still, he says nothing about it.

Bakugou packs up the first aid, dumping all scraps in the small trash can by the desk. He takes the empty bowl, shuts the window. Midoriya watches him through it all.

"Go to bed," Bakugou orders, glaring at him. "Now."

"But—"

"Sleep." And Midoriya listens for some odd reason. He pulls the bedsheets up, slips beneath them. Caramel, sugar, warmth. "If your wounds start to bleed, come get me."

Midoriya nods, eyes already drooping. "Okay."

Bakugou opens the door, flicks off the light. "Don't get out of the damn bed until you've slept at least eight hours, you fucking hear me?"

He smiles, dopey, already half asleep. "Okay, Kacchan."

Bakugou offers a sassy reply to that. "Idiot."

Midoriya snickers, shuts his eyes. "Thank you."

In the echoes of sleep, he swears Bakugou says thank you right back. Caramel, smoke. He gets the best sleep he's had in his life. He's warm, safe, and his dreams are filled with narrowed eyes and warm food.

"Goodnight, Akatani."

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 51: Two for one

Chapter Summary

Bakugou reveals his project

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Geez, man." Kirishima pulls at the grass outside the dorms, playing with the green strands as they talk. "And you're not deterred in the least bit?"

"Fuck no," Bakugou says. His arms are crossed over his chest, back pressed to a tree. This spot on the hill overlooks an outdoor training yard where Deku spars with several other 1-A students.

"I mean," Shitty Hair starts, "If someone said that shit to me—I'd be pissed off, y'know?"

"I am," Bakugou admits, eyes tracking each takedown the idiot lands. "But he's full of his own shit. I talked to Yazmin about it—she agrees that it seems as though he was just lashing out."

"And your therapist thinks this is a good idea?" Kirishima asks. "To keep going after Midoriya?"

Not in the slightest. Bakugou finally managed to open up about some of the shit he's gone through with Deku. Yazmin was perfectly composed, listening as he talked and talked and talked. He spent long sessions just doing that—talking. It's not as though he's avoiding the autism diagnosis; he just needed someone to talk to and clear his head about what he was losing his mind going through. Now that his weekends are occupied with remedial courses and dealing with Todoroki and two other fucking idiots, he needed to talk to anyone who could offer him some insight.

And even if she's getting paid for it, Yazmin does a decent enough job at organizing thoughts in his head. She puts them in order, categories, attaches emotions and responses to each thing. It makes it easier to figure out later on and make plans out of. He obviously can't tell her everything, but even getting some of it off his chest makes things… less heavy.

But she does *not* agree with his approach to Deku. Trying to mend a bond, sure. Anything else? She thinks he's latching onto a goal with the hopes of achieving it. Technically, she's right. But she can't even begin to understand how much Bakugou *needs* to work for something right now. He knows Deku's full of shit—and he's going to prove it true.

“Bakubro, don’t get me wrong, I think you’re manly as shit. But Midoriya seems… I don’t know.” Kirishima tugs up more grass. “It seems like everything he said to you after Ground Beta came from his heart, bro.”

Bakugou shakes his head. “He’s an idiot, that’s all.”

Kirishima huffs out a laugh. “Hey, if you’re sure that he’s the one. Then by all means, man. I didn’t know you were gay.”

“I’m not fucking gay.”

Kirishima gives him a look. “You are actively trying to land a date with a man.”

“So?”

He purses his lips. “Kudos to you for not using labels, I guess. I don’t like em’ either.”

“What labels could you possibly use, Shitty Hair?”

“Trans?” Kirishima offers.

Bakugou blinks, furrows his bros. “You’re transitioning?”

“Bro, I did already.”

“What? When? You started estrogen?”

Kirishima snorts. “Female to male, Bakubro. I was born a girl.”

“What?” Bakugou looks him up and down. “The fuck? You look like a guy.”

“I *am* a guy,” Kirishima chuckles. “I can’t tell if you’re being supportive or not.”

Bakugou scratches his head. “I don’t give a shit what you are. I never once thought you weren’t a man.”

“Aww.” Kirishima lays a hand on his heart. “Look at you, so nice to me.”

“When did you…” Bakugou waves a hand at him. “Transform?”

“Dude! Transform? That sounds way cooler than transition. I’m saying that from now on,” Kirishima laughs, tugging up more grass. “Medically, I started in middle school. Mentally, I’ve always kind of just… I don’t know.”

Bakugou eyes him, then looks back down at the training field. It’s after-school hours, and the nerd still can’t lay off the exercises. Always working, always scheming.

“You uhh…” Bakugou clears his throat, searching for the words. “You’re pretty manly.”

Kirishima grins at him. “Did your therapist teach you how to be nice to people?”

“Go fuck yourself.”

“Thanks, man, honestly," Kirishima says, suddenly turning serious. “I haven’t really told anyone, y’know? Mina knows, since we went to middle school together. But it’s kind of…”

“I won’t say anything,” Bakugou swears, meeting his eyes. “That’s your shit to share.”

“I won’t say nothing about Mido,” Kirishima responds, immediately perking up. “I’ll help you land him!”

“No way in hell—“

“Oh, bro, I’m so going to be your wingman.” Kirishima stands, pointing down the hill. “I’ve *got* this, dude, let’s get the whole Bakusquad in on this.”

“You just told me you wouldn’t fucking tell anyone.”

“Oh, right,” Kirishima purses his lips, looks around. “Damn. This is way more interesting than Denki getting rejected by Shinso.”

“Oh that’s…” Bakugou shakes his head. “Shinso’s into him. Not sure why he’s fucking rejecting—“

“Wait. Pause.” Kirishima says, standing suddenly. “What do you mean Shinso’s into Kams? How do you know that?”

“Deku told me.” Bakugou shrugs. “That’s the closest you'll get to a confession from Eyebags. If Deku knows it, then it’s true.”

“No fucking way!” Kirishima shouts, and all the people at the bottom of the hill glance up at them. The idiot waves, then grabs Bakugou’s shoulder and backs them out of sight. “Dude, you’ve gotta tell Kams. Bro is heartbroken.”

“I couldn’t give less of a shit.”

“*Please* bro.” Kirishima shakes Bakugou by his shoulders. “It’s for true love!”

“What’s for true love?”

Kirishima screams, Bakugou flinches. Deku appeared out of thin air, his eyes a bit wide.

“Holy shit, Midobro,” Kirishima laughs out, grabbing Bakugou’s shoulder again and standing at his side. “You scared us.”

Deku's eyes, an off-colored emerald from his contacts, lock onto where Shitty Hair’s fingers rest on Bakugou’s shoulder. They stay there for a moment, before slowly dragging up to Kirishima’s actual face. His lips stretch into a smile that doesn’t reach his eyes.

“Sorry! I can be a bit scary sometimes,” he says, scratching the back of his head.

What the hell emotion is the nerd wearing? Bakugou can't pin it.

"Uhh…" Kirishima keeps his grip on Bakugou's shoulder. "We were talking about Kams and Shinso."

Deku tilts his head, presses a finger to his chin. "Were you?"

"And Bakubro was talking about how much he likes your smile," Kirishima adds.

Bakugou turns to the idiot very slowly, unblinking. "The fuck?"

Deku immediately backs away. "That's… sweet."

"Was there something you wanted?" Kirishima asks then, snickering.

Those off-colored eyes just can't seem to look away from their skin contact. He can't find words, but he seems to be stuck in his retreat. As though he wants to run away, but something compels him to stay here. It clearly troubles Deku, because he rocks back and forth on his heels, gaze trained on Kirishima.

Bakugou can't help the slow tick of a smirk spreading on his face. "I *do* like your smile."

Deku gives them a wide-eyed look, slowly retreating more and more. Still, he seems a bit caught up on the hand Kirishima rests on Bakugou. It's as though he's angry, judging by the flash or furrowed brows and a curl of the lip. But it's gone a moment later, replaced with a smile that leaves room for authenticity. What emotion is he wearing, dammit! Bakugou can't tell.

"Thanks… um," Deku turns, shaking his head.

Kirishima snorts, and when those green eyes land on them for just a moment longer, Shitty Hair decides to rest his chin on Bakugou's shoulder. *Gross*. He moves to shove him off—

"Kacchan, can I talk to you?"

Bakugou goes still, brows raised. "What?"

"In private," Deku laughs out, but it's one of those scary fake ones he does. "Pretty please?"

"Wing man," Kirishima whispers, then pulls away and gives Bakugou a shove forward. "Catch you later!"

The idiot all but runs away. Bakugou doesn't miss that he goes right to Mina's side, the two of them immediately laughing about something. There's an emotion Bakugou can finally pick up on. Scratching the back of his head, red in the face, dopey smile. Raccoon Eyes and Shitty Hair—Bakugou will torment them later.

For now, he's got Deku to worry about.

"What?" he asks, hands dug into his pockets.

This small hill is the same one that Deku had clung to when he first began to fly. Bakugou had woken up that night, as he always does, to nightmares. And when he heard those laughs from the hallway, he had to investigate. Deku was flying, shooting off the walls of the dorms like it was natural for him.

And Bakugou just watched, listened, and came to the horrible conclusion that he's never heard Deku laugh like that before. There were moments Ground Zero elicited laughs from Viridant—but those people, those two anonymous souls, no longer exist. He misses it, and maybe it's a selfish thought, but he misses those long months more than anything. When it was easy to talk to Deku, when there wasn't so much between them.

"Oh… uhh…" Deku looks around frantically, as though he hadn't actually expected to talk to Bakugou at all. "You and Kirishima seem close!"

Bakugou shrugs. "We get along."

"I can tell," he says, rocking back and forth. "You let him touch you."

"What?"

"You only let some people touch you—and only in certain situations—I was just observing that."

Bakugou narrows his eyes, his lips lifting. *Now* he can place that emotion on Deku's face. "Are you jealous, Greenie?"

His eyes blow so wide. "No! No! I-I'm not! That would be—that would be selfish."

"It's alright," Bakugou says, "I don't mind you being a little selfish."

But Deku retreats more, face red. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have bothered you two."

Bakugou rolls his eyes, leans against the trunk of the tree. "We aren't together. He's my version of Eyebags, alright?"

Deku pauses, nodding. "Okay."

"You feel better?"

"Yes—I mean, no, there's nothing to feel better about," Deku says, trying to rationalize.

It stopped pissing Bakugou off so much when the nerd blabbers. After he pinned the cause, he gave up on the anger that came with it. It was hard to unlearn, but Yazmin and he worked through healthy ways to process extreme emotions. As it turns out, Deku brings out such strong emotional responses in him that it causes him to get frustrated, to latch onto those feelings of a lack of control. He's *always* in control, so losing it so frequently for reasons he couldn't understand—it drove him insane.

He understands it now, though.

“I told ScarFace and Eyebags that the league must’ve used some flashy Quirk on you the other day,” Bakugou confesses, “I figured you’d been avoiding them because you didn’t know how to explain the light show you put on with your new Quirk.”

Deku takes a deep breath, pushes it out, and some of the tension in his shoulders disappears. It’s the same as it was when Bakugou fed him, cleaned the room, and insisted he go to sleep. Like all Deku needed was *someone* to help lighten his heavy load. They don’t share much with each other, have next to nothing in common, but that one, small thing. He knows how hard it is to ask for help, for support. How easy it is to convince yourself you don’t need it. So he gave it, as best as he could, he gave it. And he’s never done that before, but he found he rather likes that feeling. It feels like he takes back some of that control, like he can do something good on terms that he sets.

Yazmin would be screaming with joy right now if she knew what he was thinking.

“Thanks,” Deku says softly. “I was dreading that.”

“I figured,” Bakugou responds, eyes trailing over Deku’s form. “How are the wounds?”

“Good!” He rubs his shoulder where the stitches are. “I had no idea you were so good at those!”

“Can I check them?”

“Uh…” Deku nibbles his lip, looks around. Come on, come on. “Sure.”

Bakugou has to tamper down the victory bouncing off his chest. He approaches carefully, ensuring he doesn’t scare Deku off. The idiot is skittish, and Bakugou’s began to figure his confusing brain out. Shinso had said months ago that the only way to catch Deku was to pray that he slipped up. And while that’s close to the truth, Bakugou uncovered his own method. Disorient. Deku never sees half the things coming that Bakugou says. Weirdly enough, all he has to do is be honest. And without fail, Deku is thrown off by it.

He slowly lifts the back of Deku’s uniform, eyes locked onto the wound. It’s far less tender, but still an angry pink. There’s no way to convince the dipshit to get meds for it, so Bakugou will drop off some disinfectant at Deku’s dorm door, pretending it’s from the idiot's mom. Miss Midoriya—uhh—Inko, seems to love when Bakugou cooks with her, especially when they leave meals for Deku. She even agreed not to tell him, which is a miracle in itself.

Bakugou can plot, too, and plot he does. “It looks better. Still swollen to shit, but you won’t die.”

“I told you it wasn’t a big deal.”

“You think most things aren’t a big deal, dipshit,” he says, tugging the fabric back down. “I wanna ask you something.”

Deku turns, and just as Bakugou planned, they are inches apart now. With Greenie’s back facing the tree, he’s got nowhere to run. The idiot seems to know it too, eyes darting around

wildly to pinpoint an escape. Always looking for an escape.

Bakugou takes it from him. “My mom has an artist she knows, he does similar work to what Rin used to. I’m not forcing you or any of that bullshit, but if you and your mom need an appearance change, let me know.”

Deku opens his mouth, shuts it.

“And uhhh…” Bakugou looks away from him. “My mom sent me to get your mom's number. She wants to have tea dates or something.”

Deku’s eyes go soft, the same way they did before he kissed him. “She does?”

“Yeah,” Bakugou says, and it’s the honest truth.

For Mom to admit she wants to bond with someone—let alone to ask Bakugou for help—it’s not a small deal. She’s started therapy as well, once she saw how well it worked for Bakugou. They’ve never been… affectionate. But Mom calls him often now, almost as often as Dad does. They don’t really talk about anything, but she calls anyway. He never thought he’d be the kid who has a Mom who calls—it’s not that she’s terribly mean or anything. They just never really connected, always missed the mark. And after the incident, neither of them really wanted to.

So when Deku takes his phone out, has Bakugou copy down the number, that, too, feels like a victory. Small victories—Yazmin had said that’s all that baby steps are. Having a big goal to achieve is always an ideal, but creating a solid plan to get there, completing each step, those are the wins that really get you somewhere. He can’t believe therapy is something he actually agrees with—

“You’re different.”

Bakugou blinks slowly. “What?”

“You’ve been.. Softer,” Deku says, his muddled eyes bouncing between Bakuhou’s. “I noticed it months ago in Chou City—when we stood on the roof. But it’s really evident now. You’re still you, but…I don’t know, you seem happier.”

“We go to school together again,” Bakugou blurts out. He could’ve named a thousand other factors for his behavior change, but that seems to be the one that holds the most true. He confesses, “I missed you.”

Deku swallows, “This… we can’t—“

“I left my cellphone at the league's base,” Bakugou interrupts.

Deku pauses, looking up at him from beneath thick lashes. “You… you did?”

“I figured I could always buy a new one, but we couldn’t always find the league's base again. So I left it in whatever freaky room me and the other idiots woke up in.” He takes out his new phone again, taps the screen, and shows Deku the pinged location. “We can track my old one.

Get a pin on the base. You were trying to find them the other day, right? I saw it on your laptop."

Deku tries to take the phone. Bakugou shuts it off immediately, buries it in his pocket.

"We're doing it together," he says, shoulders set. "Just like we used to."

Immediately, Deku shakes his head. "No way."

"Then good fucking luck." Bakugou turns, walks away. He's already grinning before Deku calls out to him again. Still, he turns, waiting patiently.

"Fine." Deku isn't at all happy to say it. "We'll need to get our suits somehow."

Bakugou was hoping he'd say that. He leans forward, grabs Deku's sleeve, and then they're running. The nerd asks them where they're going, but Bakugou doesn't answer, snickering as he drags him from the hill. Deku doesn't mind; he follows after him all the same. They pass the students training, Kirishima giving him a nod and a cheer. Bakugou ignores it all, his mind locked on the slight touch they share.

He leads Deku inside the dorms, up the stairs, and shoves him into his room. There's a line of nerves in his stomach, as he's never had Deku standing in his space before… while he was awake, at least.

"Sit." Bakugou shoves him into the desk chair, jittery and excited.

Deku, despite being tentative, is smiling. "What's going on? I've never seen you so hyper."

He doesn't answer. Instead, he drops to the floor and digs under his bed. Deku was onto something by hiding his shit under here. Bakugou feels around, grabs the two cardboard boxes he's stashed, and yanks them forward. He also grabs a grocery bag, his ears tipped pink as he reveals the contents of it to Deku.

"You have my notebooks?" Deku squeaks out, snatching them immediately. "How?"

"Found them," Bakugou lies, unwilling to sell Inko out. "Read them already."

"Oh my god." Deku hides his face in his hands. "How dare you! That's such an invasion of privacy!"

"If most of the content is about me, then I think I have a right to it," Bakugou argues flatly, grinning when Deku fake cries. "You think my shoulders are nice?"

Deku shakes his head rapidly. "I have to kill you now. You've seen too much."

He *loves* this. The jokey air, the comfort found in discomfort. The two of them goofing around. Deku in his room, red in the face and smiling a real smile. Bakugou loves this. He doesn't want it to go away. They feel *right.* Doesn't Deku feel that?

“I’ve seen the two in your damn room, too,” Bakugou confesses, tugging out one of the cardboard boxes. “I had to go back and pull some references and data from your notes. But I think I fucking nailed it.”

Deku goes quiet when Bakugou pulls fabric from the box. It took *ages* to get it all together. He explains it to Deku as he empties the cardboard. He managed to find the right fabric for Deku’s vigilante suit through Shinso. Working with the idiot was painful, but he walked Bakugou through the entire thing. Taught him how to program the AI in the mouthpiece, how to connect the bot to programs, and back up its data. It was difficult to convince the dickhead to agree to teach him how to code, but Shinso seemed to think Bakugou just wanted to impress Deku. Technically, that’s true, but Bakugou was actively recreating the suit piece by piece.

He explains how he talked to Blondie in the support course, got a basic explanation on sensors and laser cutting techniques. Then he came back to his room and spent weeks building the suit from scratch. While Deku’s notes were detailed and helpful, Bakugou strayed from them a bit. Mom wouldn’t let Bakugou get by without ‘necessary skills’, so sewing and stitching the costume together was easy. He even fixed the awful, vibrant green that Deku stuck with, replacing it with a duller and sleeker design.

He *killed* it. He knows he killed it. Deku seems to know it too, gently taking the fabric and stroking his thumbs across it.

“I figured if we keep it hidden in my room, then there’s no chance your dumbass gets caught with it again,” Bakugou says. “And I can repair it when you inevitably damage it. I’ve got enough experience with my gauntlets to put it back together pretty easily.”

Deku doesn’t respond. His lips are parted, eyes dancing along the intricate designs. Bakugou pulls out the second box, wiping his sweaty hands discreetly on his pants before they begin to smoke. He tugs out the next few pieces of fabric, lays them out. He built a suit for himself, too. Orange and black, the same material as Deku’s, but with zags or x’s stitched across. He even added his own little mask thing that the idiot likes, a matching headset, and eyewear so they can communicate easily. It should be able to reflect his vision to Deku’s goggles, and vice versa, just in case. It was Bakugou’s personal touch. He explains all this, and Deku still doesn’t respond.

“It—“ Bakugou clears his throat. “It’s a precautionary measure. I know this stupid shit is important to you, so I figured it probably sucked to lose it all. But now you can do all that vigilante garbage again, just don’t get caught. These took for fucking ever to make—“

He grunts when Deku collides with him. He’s not sure how to respond when the nerd wraps his arms around Bakugou’s neck. His weight is on top of him, and Bakugou’s spine touches the floor from the force of it. He’s never been big on touch, but he finds his arms wrap around Deku’s sides all the same. He holds him tightly, closely, breathing in the scent of his skin and shampoo. Fruity, sweet, sugary.

“Thank you,” Deku says, his voice wobbling with tears. “Thank you, Kacchan.”

Kacchan.

Bakugou grins at the ceiling. “Anytime, Greenie.”

Chapter End Notes

Need some good fluff before it all goes downhill again :D Happy Thanksgiving to those who celebrate!

Chapter 52: Crimson rain

Chapter Summary

Midoriya fights Overhaul

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's decided that once Overhaul is dealt with, then Midoriya and Bakugou will go hunt down Tenko. But with all the stress of this mission and the sheer amount of planning that goes into capturing the villain, there isn't a moment to waste. Midoriya is excited, if he's honest. This is a huge step in his fortified plan, and he can't believe how close he is to finally being done with this. Even better, he enjoys working with Pros; he feels so official!

"You ready for this, bro?" Kirishima asks, bumping shoulders with Midoriya. "I'm kind of jealous of you. You get to be on recovery."

"You're literally a human riot shield," Midoriya says back, laughing when Kirishima blows him a kiss. "You're essential to the mission."

He likes Kirishima. There was a brief moment, when he was sparring with classmates and caught him and Ka--Bakugou together, that Midoriya didn't feel any semblance of positive motion towards Kirishima. He had let his admiration for Bakugou get in the way of his intelligence, acting on a nasty feeling in his stomach to get Kirishima and Bakugou as far from each other as possible. But the two of them aren't dating, and Midoriya will be sure to push Mina and Kirishima a bit closer together to ensure it stays that way.

It's not that Bakugou can't date other people--Midoriya just… just wants Kirishima and Mina to have their happily ever after. What's so wrong with that? They're his friends.

Anyway, the mission is being split into teams. Midoriya and Mirio are team recovery, set to sneak around inside and search for any more children that might be inside the building. Sir Night Eye, and other Pros like Eraser Head and Rock Lock, are team intelligence gathering. Their mission is to locate or learn of any other bases quietly and discreetly. Then there's team battle, which consists of Kirishima, Amajiki, two Pros called Centipeder and Bubble Girl. Another agency, one that Midoriya has already fainted over when told that they'd be joining the fight, is here as well. The Pro hero Ryukyu, and her two student take-ons, Uraraka and Nejire. They're focus is perimeter guarding and civilian transporting. If any other children are here, or any arrests can be made, then these three will be the ones to handle it.

Midoriya has already gotten everybody's autograph five times over.

“I’m kind of nervous,” Uraraka says, approaching from her position outside. They’ve got the entire building surrounded and a warrant for any arrest they need. Eri’s full confession was all the courts needed to grant access for a raid.

“You’re not even in the action, how could you be nervous?” Kirishima asks, rubbing the back of his head. “I caught a guy fleeing the scene that correlated to the group. Since I took one of the Quirk-stealing bullets to the chest no problem, they’ve decided I’m going in as a literal shield.”

“This is all so crazy! I know the hands-on experience is a good thing, but I’m still a kid, you know?” Uraraka says quietly, and Midoriya makes a mental note to talk to Principal Nezu about the age of students being allowed to work in the field. “You don’t seem nervous at all, Izuku.”

He’s not. He tends to go into a calm state of mind before all hell breaks loose. He did the same thing in the Nomu tunnels. “We either make it out, or we don’t. I try not to stress out when I know we’ve got a guaranteed outcome.”

Uraraka nods, patting her red face to take her nerves away. “You’re right! You’re going to be the target of their attacks, and somehow you’re still calm. Let’s do our best today!”

“Yeah!” Kirishima cheers.

“Plus ultra!” Midoriya laughs out.

When they separate into groups, Midoriya still isn't nervous. He spent a good few hours yesterday hacking into the city database to locate blueprints for the building of this base of operations. He knows the entire layout as though he constructed it himself. More so, he knows that there are no other children inside. Not only did Eri confirm it, but just her connection to Overhaul and the organisation's goal as a whole confirms that no other children will be at play here. Eri was drained of her Quirk to start a new wave of anti-Quirk functionality. Overhaul wanted to eradicate the world of Quirks and the need for Heroes, and he had his means to do it. There’s no reason for any other child to be inside.

The Pros still insisted on it, which is why it’s great that Mirio took those orders seriously. Midoriya sees it for what it really is. A way to keep him--Kai Chisaki’s target--out of sight and trouble. If they find children to save, even better, but Midoriya isn’t an idiot.

The front doors are breached, and the battle group is rushing in. Immediately, arrests are made, pathways are deemed clear, and Midoriya and Mirio are sent in. To be fair, he does have every intention of recovering important things. The first few rooms are empty. Those that aren’t are easy to clear, to knock out whatever idiot is inside. It’s even easier to grab their guns, pop out the magazine, and guarantee the bullets aren’t special. They’re all under strict orders to destroy any and all Quirk-erasing bullets.

One after one, he and Mirio take apart rooms with ease. Mirio zips through walls and doors with his Quirk, clearing a room faster than Midoriya can. Still, he keeps up, working down long halls and--

The building shakes, glass shattering.

“That came from the West,” Mirio says, turning to Midoriya, “Sir is in trouble.”

“We have orders to clear the rooms,” Midoriya argues. He still hasn’t found what he needed.

“You can stay, but I can’t stand here when someone else needs my help,” Mirio says, spinning for the end of the hall, his red cape flowing. He takes off, and Midoriya huffs before following after.

Mirio was right, Sir Night Eye needed help. They come across a large hole in the wall that leads to what can only be described as a cave-looking room. Spike pokes out of the ground, jutting toward the open ceiling. The entire room is warm, the scent of human skin intense and palpable. It's a far cry from those narrow, dark tunnels. Sunlight streams into the room, illuminating OverHaul and Sir Night Eye brawling. The former seems to have grown more limbs, arms and hands jutting out of his body like that deceased 1-A student.

Sir Night Eye faces off against him, his usually composed appearance looking frantic and messy. His Quirk, to see his opponents' movements, is a huge and powerful ability. It's a shame he's chained to desk work and stubbornness. His movements now are efficient, liquid, and he works around OverHaul as though it's a dance. Predicting movements, spike manipulations, and calculating battle strategy. Mirio calls out to him, and the sound draws unwanted attention.

Light catches a small form in the corner, its plague mask obscuring its face. The tiny villain holds a gun, aimed directly at Midoriya. Even from this far away, the room shaking with the force of a fight, Midoriya can see that the gun has a small marking on it. The bullets. It must have the Quirk erasing bullets.

The villain steadies his hand, his finger twitching for the trigger. Midoriya jolts to the side, hits the floor when the bang of it echoes in the room. He can’t lose One for All; he only just got it

Sorry, Mirio.

The bullet rockets through Lemillion behind him instead. He takes it in stride, chasing after Overhaul while Midoriya locks onto the gunman. The room rattles and shakes, and another bullet is let loose that narrowly misses Midoriya’s head. He’s *wasting* Eri’s bullets, her talents.

Midoriya throws himself at the small gunman, wrestling him to the floor. He knocks the ridiculous mask off, slams the idiot's head into a wall. And when it’s done, he grabs that gun. One quick movement and the magazine is slid out, revealing twelve more pristine bullets. They’re all being held to the same standard to destroy all Qurik erasing bullets.

Instead, he slides the gun into one of his deep pockets, unable to help the smile on his face.

When he turns back around, the fighting has only gotten worse. No Pros have come for backup, likely tangled in their own messes. Sir Night Eye is worse for wear, covered in long

scrapes and slices. Midoriya gets barely a foot ahead of him before Overhaul launches another attack. And in Sir Night Eye's effort to shield Mirio from it, he takes a serated spike through the stomach.

Mirio screams, and Midoriya takes off into the scene. He rushes for Sir Night Eye, peeling off Mirio's cape as he passes by. He might be able to clot the wound, but without immediate medical attention--

Shaking and rattling. He's hardly seen Overhaul yet, and the man manages to destroy the scene with ease. Midoriya launches his scarf out to avoid a hole forming in the floor. He lands by Night Eye's side and… and he's already dead. No pulse, mouth and eyes wide open.

Where the hell is everyone else? This plan was solid, concrete. How has it all gone wrong? Midoriya launches himself away from the dead Pro when a spike goes for him next. Mirio is still fighting vigilantly, but his bullet hole slows him down.

Finally, soaring above the mess below, Midoriya can see Overhaul again. His limbs are bulky, large, and he uses them to destroy the makeshift arena they've landed in. No wonder Eri is petrified of him—he's far stronger than Midoriya thought. It must've been pure luck that he had escaped him the other night.

And Overhaul is not happy about it. Mirio goes flying with a harsh blow, landing against a rock. He's still conscious, but the pain he must be enduring is disabling. Overhaul raises a large arm over where Mirio landed, and Midoriya throws his scarf out. The fabric wraps around the limb, giving Mirio a split second longer to move out of the way before it comes smashing down on him.

"Sir?" Mirio shouts at Midoriya as he rolls free of the debris.

Midoriya shakes his head.

Tears fill Mirio's eyes, and he trembles as he rushes into the fight again. The essence of a Hero, through and through. He fights, and Midoriya does everything he can to negate Overhaul's counterattacks. His support scarf only gets him so far, but it's those extra seconds that Mirio needs. Now Quirkless, enraged, he faces this psychopath with a vengeance Midoriya has seen reflected in the mirror.

And he loses.

Mirio slams into another wall, body going limp, blood pouring out of him. Midoriya isn't sure if he's dead or not. He doesn't have a moment to care as Overhaul looks at him now.

"You." His golden eyes are dull and wide. "You're the one who took Eri."

"My bad," Midoriya says, retreating when Overhaul prowls closer. "I'd say I'm sorry, but I'm not really. Grooming kids is kind of weird, you know?"

"Where is she?" he asks, and Midoriya's back presses against a new spike. The tip of it pokes his neck, and he's all but certain Overhaul is one wrong answer away from killing him.

He can't reach his gun without being impaled, and he's got no backup.

"Quirkless," Overhaul hisses. "That's what you are, that's what the world *should* be."

"And we were just supposed to sit by while you made that choice?" he asks, gritting his teeth when that spike again presses into him.

"Don't you see how wrong things have become?" Overhaul asks, eyes bright compared to his dark face mask. "How awful this world is now that it has Quirks? Don't you see that *hate* you're defending?"

"It's only hate when a standard is forced," Midoriya argues. "Quirks aren't inherently flawed—it's the lawmakers, the commission—*that's* who's hateful. You're attacking the wrong end."

Overhaul tilts his head, inches away now. "You Heroes never fail to find something other than yourselves to blame. You are part of the system now, vigilante. You are exactly what you claim to hate. You're a hypocrite."

Says the guy who's using his Quirk to weaponize another.

Midoriya needs an entry; he needs a chance. If he can get to his gun, then he can take this motherfucker out with ease. He just needs a moment, an opening. With how close Overhaul is, a quick punch to the jaw or stomach could give him the room he needs.

He draws his arm back quickly, body shaking with adrenaline and—

And One for All flickers on. Colors—glorious, beautiful colors. They wrap around his skin, his fingers, zigzag along his body. He gets not even a second to register it before following through on his punch, the hum of power vibrating his bones. He just needs a small opening…

Overhaul *explodes*.

Midoriya has spent so long annoyed that All Might's super strength didn't seem to show up that he hadn't registered it when it finally did. The punch lands on Overhaul's cheek, and the resounding destruction of his body was unexpected. His face implodes, blood flies, bones decimate. The remaining part of the villain's body slams against the wall yards away, just his legs, before peeling off the concrete and squelching on the floor. Nothing else remains but broken skin and gore.

It rains crimson. Hair. Teeth. Skin follicles. Earlobes. Muscle cords. Bone fragments. He can hardly move as Overhaul's body comes pouring down from the punch. Decimated. It was so fast, so quick.

And pain rips through Midoriya's arm. The entire thing has gone limp and purple. One poke and he knows it's shattered completely. The damage done to his body from using All Might's Quirk is minor compared to the red rainfall of Overhaul's corpse. He killed him. Just a casual right hook obliterated the villain's body.

Hot, dark rain.

Midoriya's eyes roll, and the world goes black.

When he wakes again, hours later, he's in Recovery Girl's office. His arm is wrapped and bandaged, perfectly healed. Still, he can't seem to bring himself to feel any emotion over it. He lies in bed and stares at the ceiling; the haunting realization of what he's done is eating at him. It's not as though he hadn't planned to kill Overhaul. It's just that it wasn't meant to be so sudden. Or by using a Quirk that has a sworn promise of peace and protection.

He's not sure why he's so vacant. He's not sure why this scared him so much, only that he doesn't feel right anymore. He's not sure what to do with himself. When his Quirk flickers to life in the dark room, glowing and illuminating the space in rainbow, it only brings him dread. He didn't mean to use it—and he's *scared* of it.

He's scared to get out of bed, or to grab a door handle. Or, or, or how will he hug Mama? What if it turns on by accident? Training with Hitoshi, sparring with Uraraka. He's *scared*. He hates being scared.

He needs control—he needs to know how to stop the destruction before the worst of it happens. He needs someone who gets it, someone who can—can—

Someone who knows how to control a destructive Quirk.

Why is it always Kacchan?

Midoriya makes it to the dorms, still glowing and absolutely petrified. He opened doors with just his pinky, beyond careful not to break anything. Even then, he left a dent on the door handle. He's unable to touch anything with his hands, even using his elbow to pull open the dorm doors and ripping the handle clean off. When he knocks on Bakugou's door, it's with his forehead.

His eyes are watery when the wood tugs open. Bakugou looks pissed to be woken up in the middle of the night, but the angry expression drops when he sees that Midoriya was the one who knocked. Then it morphs into anger once again at the tears on his face.

"What—"

Midoriya steps back when Bakugou reaches for him. "Don't touch me."

Bakugou's eyes take in the green sparks, the bright colors lighting up the hall. "What happened?"

"I can't turn it off," Midoriya says, voice hysterical. "I-It activated during my fight with O-Overhaul. He's dead."

Bakugou takes a deep breath. "I thought his Quirk did him in? Aizawa-Sensei said the likely cause of death was his own Quirk."

Midoriya trembles, shakes his head. "I didn't mean to, Kacchan. I couldn't turn it off in time."

Bakugou only nods his head, looks around to ensure the halls are empty, then stretches his door wider open. “Come on.”

“What if I hurt you?”

He snorts, offers a smirk that falls short at hiding his nerves. “I’d like to see you try.”

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 53: Heart

Chapter Summary

Bakugou helps Midoriya

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya sits on Bakugou's bed slowly, carefully. This is the second time he's been in this room while Bakugou was aware. If he weren't currently a husk of emotion, he's certain his nerves would be eating him alive.

Bakugou grabs a water bottle from the desk, hands it to Midoriya. He takes it on instinct and ends up squeezing the thing in half. Water sprays through the room, and he starts crying. Bakugou just purses his lips, walks to his desk, and opens a drawer.

"When I was a kid, I needed a release for my explosions. There wasn't exactly an easy fucking options for it, but not letting it out was excruciating," he says in a grumble, yanking out a metal tube from his desk drawer. "So my mom bought me this to help with the pain."

He extends to Midoriya, who only stares at it.

"It's a metal water bottle. It's thick enough that you won't break through it so long as you're careful." Bakugou jiggles it. "Take it."

Midoriya does. He's beyond gentle, holding it in the softest touch and drinking from it.

"Every Quirk," Bakugou says, plopping onto his desk chair. "Has an overuse point. My hands cramp and spasm. Dunce Face goes all stupid. Round Face throws up. It's only natural that overusing your Quirk would cause some sort of backlash."

"My arm broke," Midoriya said, though shattered is a better word. "But it activates on its own."

"Hmm," Bakugou bounces a leg, staring at the bandages on Midoriya's arm. "Emotional stimulation, then. You're nervous as hell, so the Quirk responds. It's like when a kid hides under a blanket when scared. You've got your safety blanket on."

"How do I take it off?" he asks, hysterical.

"Deep breaths, Greenie," Bakugou says, mimicking taking deep breaths. "In and out. Do it."

He does, still shaking, still jittering. He breathes and breathes, and it does help just a bit. But his Quirk is still pulsing along his skin, a mismatched kaleidoscope of colors.

“You’ve got to trust yourself,” Bakugou says, holding his palms up on his lap. “Your foundation of Quirk control—it’s trust. If that wavers, the whole damn thing fails. Stop panicking, I *will* turn off, it can’t go on forever.”

Midoriya nods, but the light doesn’t dim.

“Tell me what happened today,” Bakugou says, wheeling the chair to the bed. “It activated on accident?”

“I was just trying to create any opening to fight him off.” He shuts his eyes. “I couldn’t turn it off in time. And I punched. And he’s just—just turned into mist. And I was going to kill him, I was, but—but on my terms.”

Bakugou listens quietly. “So what scared you? The fact that you killed him by accident? Or that you might do it again?”

Midoriya keeps his eyes shut, breathing deeply. “If I hurt someone—what if the Quirk turns on when I’m trying to hug Mama or—or what if I hurt someone with it?”

“You won’t,” Bakugou argues, and a small pressure touches his palm. Midoriya’s eyes shoot open, and he jerks his arm back from Bakugou’s touch. The color flares, brightens. “It was just starting to dim.”

“Don’t touch me,” Midoriya says. “I could’ve hurt you!”

“Trust yourself,” Bakugou bites back. “You aren’t an atomic fucking bomb.”

“But—“

“Give me your hand.”

“No!”

“Give me your hand or I’ll take it my fucking self.”

Midoriya mentally curses himself for coming to Bakugou’s room. He’s a stubborn asshole. Why did he think this was a good idea? Still, he holds his hands out, face scrunched with worry and tears. His palms emit a soft light, and Bakugou takes his hands gently by the wrists and guides them to rest in his lap.

Slowly, Bakugou grabs one hand and presses his thumb into Midoriya’s glowing palm. He pushes softly, fingers working, massaging the callused skin. It’s nice, and he’s weirdly good at this.

“My dad did this,” Bakugou mutters. “Whenever I’d get pain from my explosions. He’d massage my palms.”

Midoriya swallows, watches the light begin to dim. “How long have your explosions hurt you?”

“A while,” he says softly. “I don’t have very much feeling in my hands. To match damage to the nerves. My body is adjusted for the heat and sound, but too strong of explosions still screw my hands up pretty bad. That’s probably what happened to your arm.”

“I went too hard,” Midoriya theorizes. “I don’t have control yet, so I must’ve let out full strength.”

“Most people’s full strength isn’t anything special, but that’s only because Quirks develop young. You skipped the age step, and that power's been fucking stockpiling for what? Seventy years?” Bakugou clicks his tongue, fingers switching to the next palm. “No wonder you lost control. You need to be releasing the pressure regularly. The more you let out, the easier it’ll be to control. Think of it like—“

“Stars,” Midoriya says, eyes wide. “Like a supernova. The core collapses and makes shockwaves. If I don’t release pressure, it’s like my gravity has altered.”

Bakugou watches him, hands still working. “That’s how I imagine my Quirk, too.”

“You do?” Midoriya asks. “You imagine stars?”

“Yeah.” Kneading, massaging. “Look.”

The light’s gone out. He feels it in his chest, the lingering of the power. It settles, waits, ready to be called upon at a moment's notice. It felt different than Nana’s floating Quirk. That one made him giddy, loose, made him feel airy and weightless. This one weighed heavily, tender like a fresh bruise.

“You just needed to trust yourself,” Bakugou says, letting him go. The warmth of his touch flickers away, but the caramel and smoke scent remains. “You know that you can’t just kill people, right?”

It’s such a turn of conversation that his eyes blow wide. “It was an accident.”

“The first time wasn’t,” Bakugou says flatly.

That’s true. Midoriya had slaughtered the muscular guy at the training camp. It was so inconsequential in his mind that he nearly forgot about it. He killed a guy and didn’t even remember it. That's awful, really.

“Listen.” Bakugou's voice is rough. “I understand why your Dad has got to go six feet in the fucking ground—but you can’t just take out every d-lister that comes your way.”

“I know that,” Midoriya grinds out. “I don’t need a morality lesson from you, of all people.”

“Well, you’re fucking getting one. You came into my room for damn comfort and support, and what—now it’s not good enough?” Bakugou snips. “Make up your mind, Greenie. Do you hate me, or do you want me around?”

Midoriya stands, face hot. “I just needed to learn how to turn the Quirk off.”

“You are so full of your own shit.” Bakugou stands too, glaring at him. “Use me whenever you feel like it? I’ve been a damn saint to you.”

“Do you want me to write you a thank-you card?”

“A little honesty would be fucking nice.”

“What the hell do you know about honesty?”

“You came to me because you feel safe with me.”

“Oh my god.”

“Admit it.”

“No!”

“Why not?”

Midoriya grasps the door handle, his ears red. “If I’m getting an interrogation every time I interact with you, then I’ll stop bothering.”

He grabs the handle, twists. The door doesn’t open. He yanks, nothing.

“What the fuck…?” Bakugou mumbles, and Midoriya follows his line of sight to the slim, black and green tendril that buzzes from his back. Its length slides under the door, and if Midoriya focuses on it, he can feel that it’s wrapped around the door handle on the other side.

He panics, swatting at it and trying to get it loose. But the appendage is firmly attached to him. It retracts from his reach, moving to an alternate spot that he can’t touch, maintaining its grip on the door. It won’t let him leave.

“You developed another fucking Quirk,” Bakugou bites out, poking at the thread. “What the hell is it?”

“Black whip,” Midoriya mumbles. “If I remember correctly, Daigoro Banjo wielded it to climb or manipulate his body in air.”

Bakugou again pokes at it. “What the hell *is* it? Energy? Matter? It feels solid, but if I push hard enough, my hand goes through it.”

It feels fuzzy like static. He can feel Bakugou touching it as though it were an arm.

“It’ll go away as long as I’m calm, right?” Midoriya asks, grabbing the middle of the long thread. “What spurred it on?”

He again tugs the door handle, and the whip sharpens.

“Go away,” Midoriya hisses at it. “Let go.”

“It’s not an animal,” Bakugou snorts.

“I just want to leave!” he yells at the damn thing. The thread seems to give him a nasty look before another strand shoots out of his back, slithers under the door, and holds it shut.

This is ridiculous! His Quirk is actively working against him! It’s misbehaving like a child, holding a door shut. Maybe it reflects his true feelings? Or maybe Kudo’s essence can sense the family bloodline, a tie to Bakugou.

“What—“ Midoriya turns, gasping when Bakugou is ripped out of the wheelie chair and slammed against his side. Blackwhip shoots out in tendrils, wrapping the two of them up like rope, keeping their bodies pressed against each other.

You’ve got to be kidding.

“Reel it in!” Bakugou shouts, tripping over the green and black static. “Turn it off!”

“I don’t know how!” Midoriya says back.

The bindings tighten, and they topple to the floor. This is the worst possible scenario. They lie back to back, trying to wiggle free or break the grip of the Quirk. It doesn't loosen, keeping them flush.

“Go away, Daigoro!” Midoriya pleads.

“This is fucking unbelievable,” Bakugou grunts out. “It’s all in my damn hair.”

Midoriya flushes. “I-I can’t make it stop!”

Bakugou sighs, rests his head on the floor. The tendrils caress his face, slither through his hair like a snake. On Midoriya’s side, they try to yank his hands over to grab Bakugou behind him. He fights it, jerking its hold left and right. Still, it holds true.

“Did you mean it?”

Midoriya grunts, trying to break free. “Mean what?”

“That you wish I were a girl?”

His heart hammers, the Quirk tightening. “Now isn’t the time!”

“That you’ll always resent me?” Bakugou pushes.

Midoriya gives up, puffing out air and letting the stupid tendrils bind his wrists. He lays his cheek on the floor, frowning. “It won’t work out, you know this.”

“Why?” Bakugou demands. “Why the hell not?”

“I’m not interested,” Midoriya lies.

And Blackwhip unfurls another tendril. This one comes from Midoriya's chest, right over his heart. It juts out to the ceiling, curling along the panels. Messily, in his awful handwriting, it spells: *Liar*

No fucking way he's about to get sold out by a guy who's been dead for over twenty years.

"I think your Quirk is being honest with me when you fucking can't," Bakugou laughs it out, tendrils tracing his lips. "I can't believe it."

"It's not!" Midoriya argues.

It spells: *Yes I am*

"Don't listen to it!" Midoriya writhes and wiggles again. "If we work together, we can get loose!"

Instead, Bakugou asks, "So do you like my shoulders or not?"

"No!" *Yes.* "Stop asking questions!"

"Do you miss calling me Kacchan?"

Yes.

"Stop it!" Midoriya kicks him hard, and Bakugou kicks him right back. They keep kicking and elbowing until the tendrils loosen, letting them go. It lasts for only a second before they extend from Midoriya's back, flip him, and pin him and Bakugou together chest-to-chest.

Uh oh.

"Please," Midoriya begs, "Let's just get out of the bindings and call it a night."

Bakugou narrows his eyes. "Why did you say those things after Ground Beta?"

"Please," Midoriya whispers. "Don't."

Bakugou looks up, eyes drifting over the words. *Scared.*

Midoriya shuts his eyes, gives up. Those tendrils slide away, disappearing back into his skin with no issue. The fuzziness is gone, leaving just the two of them on the floor. He's exhausted, oddly enough. He just wants to go to bed. He knows he wouldn't be able to sleep, but he still wishes he could just lie atop his bedsheets. He never got around to giving Bakugou his spare blankets back.

Maybe he just liked how they smelled.

"Is that why you're doing this?" Bakugou asks, voice soft. "Because you're scared of what could happen to me?"

Midoriya keeps his eyes shut. “Everyone is dead.” The buzz of the air is the only noise. “I’m just tired of losing people. And if I lost you…” his voice trails off.

“If you lost me?” he asks.

“Then I’d lose myself.” All those memories. Those years in school. The days on the playground. The nights beneath the stars. “I can’t lose you. Don’t you get it? There’d be nothing left.”

Bakugou doesn’t say a word. Midoriya creaks his eyes open, meets the soft yet calculating expression on his face. Those red eyes slide up to meet his, furrowed blonde brows and thick lashes framing them.

“I get it,” he says quietly, “I still think it’s stupid.”

Midoriya huffs a sad laugh. “You think everything is stupid.”

“Everything *is* stupid,” Bakugou claims. “Especially logic like that. Wouldn’t it hurt all the same if I died?”

“Not if I could’ve prevented it,” Midoriya argues.

Bakugou sighs. Their eyes never leave each other's faces. As though they are still bound by the Quirk, forced to lie inches apart.

“We never manage to get it right, do we?” Bakugou asks him softly, lifting a hand to stroke a finger down his cheek. “Always too much or too little, huh?”

“Yeah.” Midoriya’s smile is forced. “I meant what I said months ago, you know. I don’t think you’re broken at all.”

Bakugou shrugs. “I meant what I said, too.”

“What did you say?”

“It doesn't matter to me that you’re Quirkless—it never did.” Bakugou looks terribly sad as he says it. “I’ve always—I’ve always had a thing for you, I think. I couldn’t ever get rid of these awful things you’d make me feel, and it pissed me off so much that I took it out on you. But it never made me feel better, you know? Just made me more angry.”

Midoriya confesses, “I know.”

“Of course you do,” Bakugou says, shaking his head. “You probably knew since the beginning, you asshole.”

“I tried to convince myself it wasn’t true,” Midoriya claims. “Never really stuck, though.”

“It never does with us.”

Silence.

“One thousand, five hundred, ninety-two,” Bakugou says suddenly.

“What?”

“That’s how many I last counted.” He turns, looks up at the window where the stars are just barely visible over the frame. “I lost track, started to count again. Eventually fall asleep. I do it every night.”

Midoriya looks up at the window. “I got to three thousand last night. Must be a skill issue.”

“Okay, fuck you!” Bakugou sits up, jabs a hand into Midoriya’s side. “You’re a dick!”

Midoriya laughs, tries and fails to fight him off when he keeps jabbing his sides. “I was trying to be funny!”

“Oh, were you?” Bakugou holds him down, tickles his sides. “Ha ha ha. See, we’re laughing.”

“Stop!” Midoriya wheezes out. “Kacchan, stop!”

“*Kacchan, stop,”* he mocks. “I’m an emo little loser, I’ll never have true love. Waa waa.”

Midoriya kicks his feet, throws himself up and over, and digs his fingers into Kacchan’s sides instead. His laughs are evil, and they delve into wrestling quickly. He feels like a little kid again, rolling over his childhood friend and trying to pin the other down. Stupid, reckless, and they’re trying to tackle each other all the same. At some point, one of them stands. The other follows, and they circle each other, tackling one another to the floor and rolling again.

They’re certain everyone’s woken up to their scrabbling, but nobody knocks or complains. Just the two of them poking fun and fighting, *laughing* like it’s natural. Like there aren’t years of pain, of misunderstanding between them. Inferiority, denial, loathing. And, somehow, attraction, honesty.

Love.

It hits him in the gut, and Kacchan takes the upper hand to get him pinned to the floor. “Ha! I win.”

He pants, stares up at him. “You did.”

Kacchan snickers, lets him go and gets off. He holds out a hand, and Midoriya takes it shakily. They stand inches apart, the nighttime their only companion.

“Stay.”

Midoriya’s brows rise. “What?”

“Stay.” Kacchan digs his hands into his pockets, licks his teeth. “Let’s count the stars. Build a fort. Go to sleep.”

“In your room?” Midoriya squawks out.

“Yeah.” Kacchan shrugs. “Stay.”

Stay.

“Okay,” Midoriya says, stupid in the head. “But this isn’t—“

“Of course not,” Kacchan snips. “I’m not gay.”

“Me neither.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

Kacchan taps a foot, grabs a pillow, and smacks him across the face with it. “Let’s see if your fort-building skills are as good as your star counting, jackass.”

So they build a fort like their four again. Maybe they’re missing the special soup and matching All Might onesies, but they build it all the same. And they do the weirdest thing—they talk. About life, about school, about upcoming tests, about homework, about their moms and friends. And they tack blankets to the wall, toss pillows around, and build a bed on the floor to sleep on.

And they talk about their vigilante suits, about how the stars shine extra bright tonight. They count them, alternating numbers, losing track and shoving each other. And it’s perfect in an awkward, silly kind of way. He forgot how young they are. Kacchan turns sixteen in a few weeks, Midoriya follows in a few months. And they really are just kids, counting stars and telling stories in ways they’ve missed out on for years.

And when Kacchan loses count, voice slurring and eyes shutting, Midoriya lets him fall asleep. He spends long moments watching his chest rise and fall, pushing strands of hair out of his face, trailing his fingers over exposed scars. The nightlight must’ve gotten tugged out of the wall at some point, leaving behind darkness that Kacchan isn’t afraid of. Peaceful. Gentle.

Human.

Midoriya leans down, cups his cheek, and presses a kiss onto his lips. “I love you.”

Then he grabs those boxes under Kacchan’s bed, takes his new suit from it. He downloads the data from his phone. He doesn’t look back as he slips out of the dorm room and into his own. He packs his bag, eyes full of tears. He takes his scarf, some clothes, and leaves notes for each one of his classmates and friends. Hitoshi, for Todoroki, Mama, for Eraser Head, for All Might.

And one for Kacchan, too.

Then he works his way through the small gap in UA's fence, his phone pinging for Kacchan's missing one.

He won't lose anyone else.

Chapter End Notes

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Chapter 54: Answers

Chapter Summary

Aizawa searches for Midoriya.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“I hope you aren’t too upset with me. I know you’ve forgiven me for my crimes several times before, and it’s likely that you never will again. But I still thought I should give you the full confession, so you might understand why this isn’t something I can just let go. My real name is Akatani Mikumo. I am one of two of All for One’s remaining children. The other child being Tomura Shigaraki, otherwise known as Tenko Shimura, the leader of the League of Villains. We were wrong about them; they aren’t the bad guys at all. They want to save the world from my dad, and as disappointed as I know you’ll be, I can’t help but join them. This is a world that will not survive the wrath of someone with power. He cannot be jailed, cannot be kept at bay. Just as I cannot sit idle and wait. Please keep my Mama safe, and the wonderful classmates and friends I’ve made.

Thank you for being someone to show me there’s still some good left in the world. There are flawed Heroes within a flawed system, but you remain the most human among them.

-Your most problematic student, Izuku Midoriya”.

Aizawa takes a long swig of coffee, the heat of it burning his throat as he swallows. He stares at the note in his hand, exhaustion pulling at his face. Midoriya didn’t attend classes today, and Aizawa had thought maybe the kid was sick or mourning.

Turns out, he ran away.

His dorm room is tossed about. Clothes strung randomly throughout, books knocked off the shelf, a desk drawer half open. Aizawa nods, his lips pressed together, looking around the empty room.

And then he cries.

And it's pathetic, really. He never cries. But he can’t hold it in. This terrible sadness, the pit of dread in his stomach. He feels like an idiot, unaware and blind. He thought UA would be enough, would deter the kid from this. He should’ve known that old habits die hard, that there is no escaping your past.

Hizashi finds him relatively quickly. His key slots into Midoriya’s door, pushes it open, and then his husband is there. His arms wrapped around Aizawa, holding him together on the

floor of this dorm room. It's almost enough, almost.

It's been a long week. They just got back from visiting Oboro, whose body was turned into one of the god awful *things*. This whole time, Aizawa had found comfort in knowing his friend's death was quick and painless. And this whole time, he'd been so horribly, awfully wrong. He's got his own gripe with All for One, but his lead to the man is gone. Prison isn't enough to contain him, apparently. Tartarus is on high alert—and it's not enough.

The kid is gone. A year of work, of trying. And it's gone because of Aizawa's own stupidity. He thought it was enough; he thought he had all the kids' plans figured out and solved. He thought—

He thought it was *good* enough.

How is he supposed to tell his mom? His friends? How is he meant to do this? They have no leads, no real way to locate him. He's left behind no trace of his whereabouts—

What the hell do they do now?

"I can't believe," Aizawa says, his voice a shudder. "That I lost another one. I told myself it was the last kid I'd lose—I just—"

"You didn't lose him, Shouta," Hizashi says softly, kissing the top of his head. "We'll find him. We always do. This will all work out."

Aizawa shakes his head, curls in on himself. "I can't believe I didn't pick up on it. I should've known better."

"There is only so much you can do." Hizashi rubs his arms. "You are doing the best you can. You need to go easier on yourself."

"What I need," Aizawa says, voice hoarse, "Is a goddamn lead."

The door clicks. Both of them turn, watch it jiggle and jolt. Metal scrapes on metal, then the lock turns from the outside, and the door carefully creaks open. Aizawa wipes his face of tears, suddenly embarrassed despite catching a student breaking and entering.

Bakugou slides into the room, eyes scanning the scene before landing on the two of them on the floor. He purses his lips, looks back at the hall.

"To be fair," he starts, hands up in defense, "usually, the room is empty when I break into it."

Aizawa almost laughs at the blatantly disrespectful honesty. "Are you looking for him?"

His student nods. "We had a… run-in last night. I figured he was hiding out to avoid me. I should've checked Eyebags or his mom first."

Bakugou takes in the messy room, the haphazardly thrown-around clothes and items. His eyes lock on the spot by the door where Midoriya's backpack and shoes usually sit. Gone.

Aizawa takes in a tight breath. “He’s gone, kiddo.”

Bakugou blinks slowly. “He’s… where? Where did he go?”

“I don’t know,” he says honestly. “Left us all notes. Snuck out sometime last night.”

Bakugou moves wordlessly, his steps so soft it’s as though he’s floating. His fingers scrape against the desk, grasp the letter with his childhood nickname on it. Aizawa watches him open it, pull out a sheet of paper. Those red eyes scan the short scrawl, and when he’s finished, his face his completely empty.

“Did you know?” Aizawa asks.

“Which part?” Bakugou asks, already leaving the room. Aizawa stands immediately, following after. “That he’s a fucking lying son of bitch? That he was going to stab us all in the fucking back?” His student shoves open his own dorm door, and Aizawa takes in the large pillow and blanket fort. “That he’s a selfish, greedy little bastard?” He yanks a cardboard box from under his bed, though it’s empty. Bakugou throws it harshly against the wall, his palms smoking and sparking.

“If you know something,” Aizawa says, clearing his throat or tears. “Then tell me.”

Bakugou laughs, pulls his phone from his pocket. “Wiped my damn data. Oh, I’m going to fucking strangle him.”

“Bakugou,” Aizawa warns.

His student looks at him, eyes wild and wide. “Does Eyebags know he’s fucking gone?”

“I haven’t told—“

Bakugou is already out the door again, pounding against Shinso’s in a heartbeat. He doesn’t stop banging against the wood until the door opens. Only then does he stop, grab Shinso’s collar, and shove him against the wood of the door.

“Bakugou!” Aizawa snips, hair lifting, scarf unfurling.

“You’ve got five god damn seconds to tell me where the fuck he went,” Bakugou says, his voice low. “Or I’m going to throw you to the floor and beat the fucking answer out of you.”

Shinso glares, scoffing, “Let me down.”

“Where is he?” Bakugou demands.

“Izuku?” Shinso questions, eyes roaming over the three of them. “Did something happen? You’re more pissy than usual.”

“He went missing last night. Left some shitty god damn letters apologizing. He didn’t say shit to you?” Bakugou asks.

Shinso's eyes go wide. "No—he left the school? Where did he go? He didn't say anything to me."

Bakugou lets him go, ignoring him when he stumbles. "You're useless."

"Fuck you, asshole!" Shinso shouts at him, his panicked face making Aizawa uneasy. "If he left, it's probably because you did some stupid shit!"

Bakugou ignores him, pulls his phone out. "Can you recover deleted data?"

Shinso pinches his brow, but Aizawa is locked onto the phone. "Why do you need removed data?"

"Because," Bakugou says, gritting his teeth as he confesses. "I left my old phone in the home base of the League of Villains. And that *stupid dickhead* wiped the data from my phone and is after the damn pinned location."

Shinso immediately takes the phone, propping his door open with a spare slipper so they can all come inside. Miss Baby meows at them in greeting, and Hizashi places her on Aizawa's shoulder to calm him down. The cat definitely helps, though not by much. He's too busy connecting several horrible dots in his head.

Endeavors' house burned down a week ago, which he had at first thought was the work of Viridant. When it was pinned on Dabi, a member of the League, Aizawa was iffy on the idea. But All Might backed it, insisting the eyewitness account of five masked figures entering the home had to be a bullshit report. He had, foolishly, thought that his coworker and students wouldn't actively deceive him.

Shinso connects Bakugou's phone to a beat-up laptop with a black wire. He starts typing, coding, and silence fills the room.

"You idiots started the fire, didn't you?" Aizawa says softly. Five people. Dabi, Viridant, Bakugou, Shinso, and likely Todoroki. "The League rescued you."

"It was stupid," Bakugou says, "But—"

"No," Aizawa cuts him off. "No, I don't think I want to hear the bullshit excuse you're about to give me."

"We've got a lead now," Bakugou argues. "And the fire was reckless and damn stupid—but it started the downfall of Hero society. It was an inciting incident; it had to happen."

Aizawa nods slowly before he says, "Shinso, you'll be handing over your provisional license immediately. Bakugou and Todoroki will both no longer be permitted to finish the remedial courses."

"Oof." Aizawa turns and glares as Todoroki enters the room. "Major yikes."

"Stop talking like that," Shinso orders, still rapping away at his keyboard. "I'll take the loss of my license. It was worth it to bring that asshole down."

“How did you get out of the school?” Aizawa grits, looking between the three. Not a single one of them fesses up, so he takes the next approach. “How did you get All Might to cover for you?”

Silence.

That's fine. That’s fucking fantastic.

“Do not let a single one of these inconveniences leave this dorm room,” Aizawa says, voice lethally quiet. He looks at his husband, who nods. “I’ll be back in one moment.”

He sets off down the hall, snatches two letters from Midoriya’s desk, then stomps down the dorm stairs. It takes no time to make it to the teachers' dorms and lounge, ignoring Midnight when she says *oooo someone’s in trouble.* He goes straight to the door at the end of the hall, knocks gently and kindly.

When All Might opens the door, Aizawa punches him so hard on the jaw that it’s a wonder he doesn’t drop to the floor. He shoves a letter against the idiot's chest, his hair sticking up, eyes flashing.

“Go ahead and read that for me.”

All Might rubs his jaw. “What’s going on?”

“Read the damn letter before I shove it so far up your ass that you taste the ink,” Aizawa hisses.

All Might listens, still clutching his jaw as his eyes skim the brief note written for him. He doesn’t look the least bit shocked, but does swallow in nerves, his Adam’s apple bobbing.

“You covered for him,” Aizawa concludes, anger roiling through him. “All for One’s *son.* Tell me you didn’t fucking know, Toshinori.”

His coworker looks grim as he confesses the truth. “I’ve known since the beginning.”

Aizawa clocks him in the stomach, right atop that horrible battle wound. All Might chokes, blood spurting from his lips. “How long have you been knowingly leading my investigations away from the kid? Every time you told me you didn’t know who he was—did you know this entire goddamn time?”

All Might dabs his mouth, puts some space between them. “He needed time to come into the light on his own.”

“Oh, really?” Aizawa asks. “The *fifteen-year-old* needed more time to take bullets and knife wounds to his fucking body? That’s the story we’re going with?”

“Look what good forcing him to stay here did!” All Might says, his brows furrowed. “You cannot tame a spirit like that—I was trying to gain his trust.”

“Fucking ingenious!” Aizawa laughs out. “You never fail to absolutely disappoint me, you know that? Anything else you care to admit before I figure it out on my own?”

All Might shakes his head. “No. Maybe a warning about the Quirk, but—“

“What Quirk?” Aizawa interrupts.

The blood drains from All Might’s face. “I had thought—it’s not important.”

Aizawa smiles at him, another laugh bubbling out. Then he shuts All Might’s door, slowly wraps his scarf over the handle, stuffing the remaining length under the door crack to ensure no sound leaves the space. He slowly ties his hair into a bun, his Quirk rendering All Might a twig.

“Let’s—let’s not make any hasty decisions,” All Might says.

“Oh, trust me, I’ve been *itching* to get my hands on you,” Aizawa assures him, his eyes glowing. “What. Quirk?”

All Might gives him a look. “We’re grown adults; this is unbecoming.”

“You’re right,” Aizawa says, cracking his knuckles. “How embarrassing.”

“Aizawa—“

“You’re going to tell me what the fuck you know. And I am going to go get my god damn student. And if you do not tell me every single thing I ask, then I will break every bone in your fucking body,” Aizawa promises, prowling closer. “Let’s hear it.”

All Might, too his credit, looks vastly uncomfortable. He holds his hands up in innocence, waving them back and forth. “I don’t want to fight you.”

“Nose it is.” Aizawa clocks him, the bone snapping to the side in All Might’s nose. The man holds onto it, choosing peace rather than violence, backing away. “You want your arm next?”

“Please, this isn’t necessary!”

“Are you a righty or lefty? Just want to make sure I inflict as much damage as possible.”

All Might sighs, stares down at his feet. “I gave him my Quirk.”

Aizawa’s jaw ticks. “What?”

“My Quirk—it comes from All for One. It’s transferable. The reason I was looking for Viridant was because I needed a successor. So I gave him my Quirk.”

The day of the provisional license exam. When All Might had asked for a moment with Midoriya. The kid had seemed so eager, so happy. Aizawa thought it was because he was a super fan or something. In reality, the little shit had been *plotting* this, preying on All Might’s stupidity.

And he got what he wanted. A Quirk—the son of a world-famous supervillain got the Quirk of a world-renowned superhero. A combination of two higher, greater forces. All for One's brains and One for All's brawn. He could level the fucking planet if he wanted.

And he *will.*

"His brother is the leader of the League," Aizawa says, eyes wide as he takes it all in. "Tenko Shimura."

The blood drains from All Might's face. "He has a brother? Shimura?"

"I imagine he left that part out?" Aizawa asks, grabbing his scarf. "He played you for a fucking fool. And what a fool you are."

All Might shakes his head. "Let me help—"

"Sure," Aizawa says, pulling another letter from his pocket and handing it to All Might. "You can go and tell his mom that we lost him. I'm sure she'll love to know your involvement."

All Might takes the letter with shaking hands. "I'm sorry—"

Aizawa is already out the door. He's got no time to waste on pathetic wastes of space; he's got a fucking kid to find. All Might is an idiot; he always has been. He's under the impression that things can change immediately, that progress is a mindset and not an endurance test. He gave a *child* a Quirk and led away an active investigation to keep the kid from danger. Midoriya has come nose to nose with death so many times, and All Might was the one to keep it happening. He'll have a long talk with Nezu when he gets his student back, because he *will* get his student back, and ensure that Toshinori Yagi comes nowhere near Aizawa's kids.

When he makes it back to Shinso's room, he finds the door is shut. He works it open, eyes landing on his unconscious husband. Miss Baby licks at Hizashi's wound, which seems to be some sort of blunt force impact. He sees Shinso's scarf wrapped around a desk lamp. Though the student didn't get far in his attempt to take out Hiazshi and go after Midoriya. He lies on the floor, a red handprint over his mouth and nose, indicating Bakugou grabbed him and used his smoke to knock him out. Todoroki, at least, managed to fight back, but an explosion wound peels at his face. It's nothing that will cause permanent damage, but it works efficiently to leave all three unconscious.

Shinso's laptop is gone, and one glance into Bakugou's room reveals a second empty cardboard box. Aizawa's phone gets a notification alerting him that someone just tripped a motion sensor over the gate. He moves before he gets to read the word burned into the wall:

"Sorry."

***

Midoriya grits his teeth as he throws the man to the floor. Kyudai Garaki, who calls himself Daruma Ujiko, is the doctor responsible for both the creation of the Nomu's, and the disappearance of Tenko. Finding him within the League's abandoned base was pure chance, and Midoriya is honored to be so damn lucky all the time!

He grabs the doctor's collar, leaning over him. He draws his fist back, punches. Those round glasses go flying, then his nose breaks, then a tooth pushes through his lip. Midoriya isn't the type to draw out a death. He likes it quick, keeps casualties from getting away or recovering. But he takes his sweet time with Dr.Garaki.

It's almost as though he can't help it. He's smiling, having pulled his mask off to get a better look at the man. He beats him, and he *loves* it. The blood, the cries for help, the pleas to stop. This man is responsible for the death of thousands, for the little girl in the Nomu tunnels, for the destruction of those two 1-A kids. He had looked Midoriya in the eye as a four-year-old and told him he'd never amount to anything, that the extra joint in his toe makes him useless.

He had wanted to turn Kacchan into a Nomu.

Dr.Garaki screams when Midoriya digs his finger into his eye socket. He has taken his gloves off in preparation, eager to feel every bit of contact between them. He feels it now, his finger slitted into the man's right eye socket. Wet, slippery, and his thumb and pointer finger squeeze around the eyeball.

Midoriya yanks it out.

The man claws at him, screaming and kicking. Where are the Heroes?

"Please!" he sobs, saliva wetting his lips, blood pouring from his eye socket.

Midoriya easily severs the optic nerve that attaches his eye to the chiasm. He lets the man go, swings the eyeball by the cord in the air, watching the doctor writhe and sob. He's pissed himself, trembling in all limbs.

"Please—What do you want from me?" he asks. He pushes himself backwards until his spine thuds against the wall. "Y-You're that vigilante, aren't you? Just turn me in—I'll go peacefully."

Midoriya tilts his head. "You think I'm here to play Hero?"

He takes a step forward, and the doctor holds his hands out, flinching away. "P-Please!"

"I don't think you understand," Midoriya says softly, crouching down in front of him. "You aren't going to come out of this alive."

"Plea—" Midoriya hits him harshly before gasping his face with his left hand. It's still gloved, and the claws that Kacchan added do wonders, digging into the man's flesh.

“I’m going to kill you,” Midoriya tells him, ignoring his resounding sob. “But it’s your decision whether I make it quick, or whether I drag it on. I’m a very patient man, Doctor. The choice is yours.”

Those claws tip deeper into his cheek and chin, pushing against bone.

“What do you want?” he sobs, blood staining his mustache. “I’ll give you anything. J-Just don’t kill me.”

“I’ll ask once,” Midoriya says, red eyes wide. “Where is Tenko?”

The doctor looks at him, shakes his head.

Midoriya smiles.

The scream that comes out of Dr.Garaki is more animal than it is human. It echoes in the little underground dungeon that the League has, painting the walls with sound. Still, Midoriya pokes his claws clean through his cheek, shoving his fingers through the man’s gums and ripping a tooth clean out of his head.

Only when it clinks against the concrete floor does Midoriya pull his hand free. He takes those knife ears Kacchan made him and stabs one through each palm, pinning the Doctor’s hands into the concrete. He makes sure to hit veins, decimating the man’s ability to use his hands ever again. Midoriya keeps thinking about that little girl, kicking and screaming, before her eyes had been torn out of her head. No one had come to save her.

He levels the man with another sweet smile before stabbing his handy-dandy pocket knife between the doctor's legs and into his crotch. He *drags*, blood spurting, and the doctor screams so loudly that his ears ring. Did Midoriya not warn him? This guy is acting like he wasn’t given a chance!

He pulls the knife loose, jabs it into Dr.Garaki’s thigh for safekeeping, and moves to the next part of his body. He’s never tortured someone before, so he’s unaware of what to really do next. Maybe cut off a few fingers? Break a few ribs?

“Kamino Ward,” he gasps out, his one remaining eye rolling. “H-He’s in Kamino Ward. I ha-have a lab.”

Midoriya nods, pinpointing an exact address with just another twist of the knife. It’s still nighttime, he’d only left Kacchan’s side two hours ago. The smell of caramel is still strong on his skin, the warmth of their blanket fort still lingering in his blood. And this *asshole* was going to take Kacchan away from him.

"Are there any more Nomu locations?" Midoriya asks.

"Yes," the doctor shudders. "I have more labs, o-orphanges where I harvest people. I'll te-tell you where they are."

There's a cold and quiet rage as Midoriya writes down dozens of locations in his notebook. He had foolishly thought that there were only a few underground cities dedicated to Nomu

body collections. In reality, those cities were a newer installment. This piece of shit has been harvesting people--children, for years.

“You said—“ the doctor struggles to form words. “You’d make it quick if I told you.”

“Oh,” Midoriya laughs a little, tears the knife loose. “I lied.”

Chapter End Notes

We are nearing the end of the fic! I finally caught you guys up to where I'm still writing the next few chapters to finish the fic. I hope you've all been enjoying :)

Chapter 55: Like mother like son

Chapter Summary

Bakugou goes after Midoriya

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The league's base is less like a calculated, hidden location and more like a two-story house. Bakugou's phone pings for the basement, but he enters the house through the ajar front door. His face mask covers his mouth, eye guard keeping his vision sharp. Infared scanners alert him of no other presence in the home. None with a heat signature, anyway.

Slowly, he creeps through the place. It's ordinary enough looking. A living room, kitchen, two bedrooms downstairs for whoever the fuck lives here. He eyes the basement door, reluctant to go there just yet. There's a chance he gets trapped like last time, so he at least needs some leverage before then. He goes upstairs instead, eyeing the long halls and doors.

Bakugou opens a few of them, peering inside at the various different personalities housed here. Dabi's room has four different fans in it, black bed sheets, and a wooden board drilled into the wall where knives and red feathers stick out of the pallet. Hawks. He must've been here recently, or recent enough to have left his feathers here.

Further down, he opens Himiko's door, pink spattered onto the walls, and a fridge stocked to the brim with blood. He moves deeper, slowly creaking open a bedroom door that must belong to Shimura. Blue bedsheets, gaming equipment, and a laundry basket that still has dirty clothes in it. This is Deku's brother, isn't it? The nerd had written it in his notebook. Even if he hadn't, the air in the room feels the same. Full, soft, and pressureized at the same time. Bakugou would know the location of Deku even if he were blind. It's one of those things you just *know*, in the core of your body, you just know it.

He steps inside. Slow footfalls carry him to a desk with a computer. He wiggles the mouse, being met with a password-protected screen. Eyebag's training paid off, because Bakugou cracked the code in only ten minutes. It wasn't easy by any means, but he's starting to get the hang of this vigilante shit. It's fulfilling, adrenaline-inducing; he understands why Deku did it. He just wishes he hadn't left Bakugou behind.

Again.

He expected secrets and horrible crimes to be painted on this PC. In reality, it's just a bunch of video games. Bakugou doesn't waste his time on this shit, but he's still able to recognise some popular game names. He sees that Shimura spends a lot of time playing alone. The computer mouse has been altered, a chunk of metal hot-glued onto the side for his finger to

rest on without damaging the tool. Bakugou leaves the device alone, gazing around the room for any clues.

But if this is Deku's brother...

He kneels on the floor, peering under the bed. He drags out dirty laundry and blankets, and there, buried below clothing, is a small box. Idiots.

He tugs it forward, pulling out the inner contents. It seems that Deku and Shimura share many of the same traits. They both hide shit the exact same way, they both take up the same kind of space in a room. And they both take notes on *everything.* Bakugou reviews the notebooks in the box, frowning at the different handwriting and ink used. Shimura must have someone else write for him, unable to do it himself without risk. Still, the scrawl is intense, detailing Deku's life in detail. Bakugou spends a long time on the floor of the bedroom, reading and reading.

Three hundred and eighty-five. Deku had three hundred and eighty-five siblings. Every single name and location is written for each one, detailing their deaths.

"Fucking shit," Bakugou murmurs, eyeing the family bloodlines wiped out. So many women, so many children. All for One is a sexist dickhead, taking advantage of young and impoverished women, killing them and their children when they yield no Quirked child. Until Tenko Shimura.

But it makes no sense. If All for One was going to keep having kids until he got a Quirked one, and he got Tenko... then why did he have Deku?

Shimura doesn't seem to understand either. Long passages filled with questions about Akatani, about why he was created, how he managed to get away. But *why?* Tenko is the older brother. He claims that All for One can tell if a child would have a Quirk from birth. So... So why have another kid? Where does Inko come into play here?

The answer is a few pages down. Bakugou is unable to breathe properly at the old polaroid photo taped into the notebook.

In a middle school uniform, smiling shyly at the camera, is Inko. And at her side, a middle finger up and her tongue out, is Mom. The two of them can’t be older than fourteen. An arrow points at Mom’s head, and in red ink, someone wrote, “Kudo’s blood.”

Kudo. In Deku’s notebook, he had written that Kudo was the second holder of One for All, having picked it up from Yoichi, All for One’s brother. But that means--that means--Bakugou forces his breathing to remain steady, his hands not to shake. He keeps reading Shimura’s notes, disturbed by the conclusions drawn. All for One wasn’t after Inko; he was after Mom. The family tie to Kudo. The reason Inko left their small town and moved away immediately to be with All for One, the reason she left behind all her friends, the reason she severed all contact with Mom. She was protecting her, the same way Deku has been protecting him. It’s why Mom ever had access to Rin, to fake IDs and social securities. She knows how to disappear.

“Rin,’ Bakugou says quietly, “Call Mom.”

“Calling Mom., The robotic voice says.

The call connects after a few rings, Mom sighing into the line, “Katsuki, I’m in the middle of work--”

“Who is Kudo?”

Her voice dies out, replaced with a static of uncertainty.

“Mom,” Bakugou’s voice wavers, “Tell me what happened.”

She lets out a slow breath of air before she speaks. “Did you figure it out on your own, or did Izuku tell you?”

A jolt of rage. “What the fuck are you saying? He knew about all this?”

“Honey,” Mom says, her voice suddenly exhausted. “Izuku came to me months ago about this.”

He’s going to throw up. He feels sick, his body hot and cold at once. He hadn’t known this; how could he have possibly known about this? How could they keep this from him?

“It’s a sad story,” Mom says quietly. “I had a stalker when I was a kid. I couldn’t ever get rid of the guy, and then one day, Inko tells me she’s taken care of it. We were just a few weeks from finishing middle school, so I was excited to be done with him. I didn’t question it, I let her take care of it, and when it finally came time to graduate high school… she gave me all this money I had no idea how she got, and she insisted I run away and hide. My entire family went into hiding at just her request. Turns out, she had gotten with my stalker and moved away in an attempt to spare me from it. Pretty fucked up, huh?”

Bakugou holds down vomit. “Izuku..?”

“His attempt to get her to sell us out, I think. She doesn’t regret it, not one bit. And when she came back into my life, I tried to repay the debt, tried to change her identity and…” Mom’s voice turns quiet, unlike anything he’s ever heard. “Izuku told me months ago what the truth really was. I’m sure he left some of it out for my sake, but I knew enough. That stalker was some guy out for revenge, I guess we had a Hero down our family line that wronged him. If Inko hadn’t taken the hit for us, then we would’ve been dead.”

Inko was fourteen. At the same age, Deku started his vigilante streak. To do not what was right, but what was necessary. She sacrificed herself, built a life with a man who was only using her. And she was using him in return. She endured years of abuse, of neglect, of starvation, just so her best friend wouldn’t have to.

“It’s kind of funny,” Mom says, her voice a whisper. “That, somehow, you and Izuku wound up in each other's lives. It’s almost like fate.”

Is it? Or has Deku and Inko been protecting his family long before they ever knew? Viridant's patrol routes were always outside of Bakugou's house; they always shared a class and took the same walk home. Deku came for him at the Training Camp, knowing his dad had compromised Bakugou's identity and place at UA. This whole time, he's been keeping Bakugou in the dark, knowing the tiniest hint at this reality would've brought him too close to the battle.

"I should've told you," Mom says, "I just… I just struggled to accept this shit, you know? The idea that I could've been so unaware, it pissed me off."

Bakugou sets the papers back into the box. "I got to go."

"Kat--" He hangs up.

There are too many things in his head right now. The reality he's found himself in is foreign and lopsided. It's wrong, and he's not sure how to set it straight. So he goes back to hunting.

There are a few more rooms, all devoid of life. The bar, where Bakugou knows Deku was tortured and beaten. They cleaned the blood up well, but a small splatter still lies against the wooden bar.

When the house is cleared, Bakugou goes to the basement. It's pitch black down there, and as horribly as he shakes, he still descends into it. Night vision keeps him company, guiding him to a series of doors, all with slots and locks. How often do they keep people in here?

A wet, gnarly sound pricks his ears.

"Heat signature detected in five feet," the robotic female voice says.

Bakugou stares at the almost imperceptible discoloration of body heat. It looks more like a dimly lit blob than it does a person. Still, he carefully follows it, eyeing the trail of blood leading to a final doom. The door is locked from the outside, the keys are carelessly tossed onto the floor a few feet away. He picks them up, jams them into the lock, and pries the door open.

That horrible sound amplifies, and Bakugou presses the button for the light switch. When the shadows are stripped from the room, and his vision returns to normal, he comes face to face with the cause of the sound.

A man, fat and short, has been pinned to the wall. He gasps, trying to breathe through the slit in his throat. Bakugou approaches him silently, looks him over. Both eyes are torn out of his head, his mustache caked in blood from the destruction of his face. He's missing fingers, both hands stabbed into the wall with sharp knives that Bakugou recognizes. The slit on his neck indicates that whoever did it wasn't delivering a final blow. They wanted the man to suffer, to slowly choke on his own blood until he could no longer breathe through wet lungs.

Bakugou narrows his eyes, gaze trailing down to the man's exposed feet. His shoes were taken off and carelessly thrown, socks ripped. And missing from both feet, is the pinky toe.

Deku did this.

“Please,” he wheezes out, blood sputtering from his mouth. “I told you—where Tenko—was.”

Tortured. Brutalized. So near death that his entire body is cold and trembling. He’s turning blue. This amount of gore should scare Bakugou, but he finds that he’s just hollow inside, only a rage rattling within him.

“Where is the man who did this to you?” Bakugou asks, voice gravelly and ruined with the voice modulator.

The man coughs, trembling. “Please, help me.”

Yeah fucking right.

Bakugou puts a hand on his chest, Quirk bursting and flaring like a shooting star. Heat pushes out, luxurious and blinding. The man screams, gurgling blood as Bakugou burns him.

“Where is he?” Bakugou repeats.

“I don’t—know—“

“Wrong.” Hotter, brighter, small explosions making the room smoky. “Where is Viridant?”

“With—Tenko. In the lab—my lab—in Kamino.”

“Kamino,” Bakugou repeats, vague memories of the town filling his mind. “Kamino Ward.”

“Yes,” he says, sobbing red tears. “Please, help me.”

Bakugou pulls his hand away. “You made the Nomu’s.”

“Yes.”

He snorts, stands. “Nobody is coming to save you.”

“Please—“

Bakugou shuts the door, ignores his gurgled pleas for help. He locks it again, melts the keys until nothing remains but molten metal. And when it’s done, he climbs those stairs again, exits the house, and perches on a nearby roof.

Then he holds his hand out, and blows the entire house down. It crumbles, groans, shattering and splintering. Fire roars over it, heat filling the air, smoke rising. The basement is buried beneath its flames, forever forgotten. Bakugou spits on the floor below it, before launching into the air.

It’s wrong. It’s illegal. It’s disgusting and shameful, and he’d do it a thousand times over again to ensure Deku gets away with the crime. Stupid. Risky. Making him frustrated and

antsy and nervous. And he leaves all the same, the smoke unfurling in the sky like a calling card.

He goes to Kamino Ward. It really isn't hard to get by with his explosions. He slings himself through the air, leaving behind any previous trace of himself. He's certain Aizawa-Sensei will catch up eventually, but for now, Bakugou is alone. He soars through the daylight with only his suit and explosions to keep him comfort. It was meant to be a suit he wore with Deku. A sign of their bonding.

A sign of *them.*

His note had only a few words. The message was brisk, hastily written and absolutely fucking bullshit.

I love you. I'm sorry.

A calling for carnage lines his skin and bones. His eyes are wide, darty, latching onto buildings and people. Bakugou isn't sure he could stop his pursuit is he wanted—which he doesn't. He's going to find Deku, slam him against a few walls, insist that he can handle himself. And fix all the wrong that's happened, turn the world right side up again.

Kamino Ward is as busy as ever. Couples walk down the streets, leashed dogs licking children's hands. It's a clear day, an incoming spring season shoving away clouds. Jumbotrons and screens project ads at the general public, and his eyes briefly flicker through throngs of people. He should've gotten a more precise location.

"Hello."

Bakugou turns, hidden in the shadow of an alleyway. A large overhead screen has gone static, an alternate video taking over. One by one, each Jumbotron and screen cuts out, an alternate video playing instead.

"Why are you doing?" Bakugou whispers.

People stop to watch, pointing at Viridant on the screen. Except this time, his mask is off, held between two hands. And staring at the camera is Akatani. Black hair, red eyes.

It occurs to Bakugou then that he had wanted that doctor to be found, to be recovered. He had set a trap. Created a trail. He wanted to get caught.

"My name is Akatani Mikumo," he says, voice echoing across a frozen plaza. He nods at the camera. "I have been fighting my whole life for one goal. And I feel that it's about time that someone stops doing what's right, and instead does what's necessary."

All for One.

Akatani smiles wide, unwavering. "Come and get me."

Sirens blare immediately after. The camera footage cuts away again, pans to news stations. Citizens are warned to hide, to disappear inside their homes, or flee the city. Tartarus has

fallen. The announcements are quick paces and frantic. People flee the plaza, horrified.

Bakugou stares at the screen. He listens. He learns. All for One left quickly, causing no injury to anyone else imprisoned. Akatani did it on purpose. He knew that the villain would escape, so he egged it on, drew him out in a way that wouldn't harm anyone else.

A trap. A trail. He wants to get caught.

So where the hell is he?

***

Akatani screams, swinging a heavy pipe into the glass of a tube. It cracks. He winds back again, grunting, shattering the surface with hard metal. Fluid leaks out, and Tenko falls forward from the tubes' confinement.

He catches his brother, liquid soaking into his clothes. Carefully, he lays him on the pristine floor of a lab. The doctor's location confession was surprisingly easy to drag out of him, and all the blood soaking his clothes was a worthy sacrifice to make. Tenko shivers, breathes heavily, his eyes fluttering. Akatani carefully wraps his brother's hands with some spare cloth he brought, eyeing the new fingers he has. They're darker than Tenko's natural skin color, and Akatani is unsure what person they belong to. Likely a body part stolen from an unwilling victim before they were turned into a Nomu.

"Tenko," he whispers, brushing long strands of white hair from his brother's face. "Wake up."

There are more Nomu's encased in here, but no sign of other league members. It leaves just the two of them on the floor. Akatani shakes his brother again, eyeing his dry skin. His face has cracked and dried out, long bands of dry skin crawling from his lips and eyelids. Akatani takes out a small tin of Vaseline he bought. Gently, he smears the texture on Tenko's splitting wounds.

"What…" Tenko's eyes slowly blink open. "What's happening?"

"Dad's coming," Akatani says quietly. "We need to run."

Tenko sits up, his weak arms barely supporting his weight. He looks around the lab, flexes his new fingers. He doesn't say anything about the fabric wrapped around him; instead, he runs a palm down his tight fitted clothes. He shakes his head.

"I told you not to come after me."

Akatani rolls his eyes, stands and offers a hand. "I'm not very good at following directions."

Tenko eyes his hand wearily before taking it, grunting as he's pulled up. Silently, they begin to leave. Akatani already stole all the data he needed; he even managed to bypass that damn self-destruct. Now he just needs to get out of here, let Dad come across the mess left behind.

Akatani keeps an arm around his brother's waist, holding him upright as he stumbles. Tenko can walk, but over a week of being suspended in liquid tends to decay the muscle a bit.

“What happened to you?” Akatani asks, guiding his brother through unground tunnels.

“Dad wanted to amplify my Quirk,” Tenko responds, his voice rough. “I got the other idiots out in time, but there’s no stopping him from getting me. This was a punishment.”

“Are you hurt?”

“I’ll give you three guesses.”

Akatani scoffs. “Where’s your new hideout?”

“You’re not going to like it. If UA found out—“

“I’m done with UA,” Akatani confesses, ignoring the look from Tenko. “This was my last chance not to fuck up my time there.”

Tenko is silent for a moment, finally managing to walk straight. “You threw it away?”

“I did.”

“For me?” Tenko asks, swatting him away when he tries to help him walk after he stumbles. “Are you stupid? There’s no fucking chance they’ll let you be a Hero now.”

“I’m no Haro,” Akatani tells him, grasping the ladder that leads out of here. “I never have been.”

It seems Dad likes his tunnel systems, and they’re beyond easy to move around in the blink of an eye with Kurogiri. So Akatani climbs up a small metal ladder, pushing at a manhole cover. It reminds him too much of the Nomu tunnels from months ago, another lifetime ago. He helps Tenko out when they make it to the top, peering around at the outside.

“Come this way,” Tenko says, guiding them in the opposite direction.

“One second.” Akatani crouches down, pulls out a laptop from his yellow backpack. A few taps of a button, and he slides it back into place. He grabs his brother's wrist and takes off running, neither one looking back as the self-destruct protocol is activated in the tunnel.

The lid pips, smoke leaking out before it settles again. All the Nomu’s are dealt with, a fact that seems to calm Tenko as they run. His brother steals as they go, bumping off people and pulling their wallets loose. Akatani follows suit, stuffing his pockets with wallets, yanking loose any cash, and then tossing the leather to the street.

“This way,” Tenko urges.

The surrounding area grows more and more familiar. A pit of dread fills his stomach as they turn down another street. Akatani knows where they are the moment they arrive.

The city never bothered to repair the apartments after the explosion that took off nearly the entire top floor. His eyes lock on the gaping hole left in the side of the building. Mama had bombed it with gas and aluminum foil. Since then, it's been vacant, and he stares at the ghosts still haunting it.

"I found it when I was looking into you," Tenko confesses, dragging Akatani inside. "Lots of homeless camp out in here, but I managed to snag a unit."

It's like Deja vu. The apartments aren't tall by any means, built more like a motel than a complex. But these balconies haunt his worst nightmares. Doors facing other doors, small halls and concrete stairs. He spots his old unit as Tenko leads them through the jungle of buildings. It's burnt to all hell, walls crumbled and debris riddled. Where did all the people go who used to live here?

Tenko heads for a set of stairs, stopping when Akatani stops moving. "Come on!"

"Give me… give me a minute."

"You idiot! Let's go!"

Akatani doesn't listen. His body moves without thinking. His red shoes carry him up an alternate flight of stairs. In no time, he stands before the apartment he spent four years in. The door is still there, hanging on one hinge, the top half blasted away.

He goes inside, hands trembling as he walks through soot and ash. The faux wood caught and melted, but the base of it still remains. A fractured skeleton, a hollowed-out shell. He can trace memories of Mama, still hear the sound of her cracking jaw. And, without thinking, he stands before that small hall closet.

It's folding doors taunt him. An explosion, a fire, and the closet still held. The only room in the house that didn't fall. He creeks its doors open, peers a the small space he had spent long nights trapped inside. And his gaze falls onto the wooden slats. He stares for a long time, understanding dawning on him.

There was never a lock.

He drags his fingers down the sloppily painted wood.

There was never a key.

He steps inside, shuts the sliding doors. This entire time—Mama never locked him away. This entire time—it was him. Too afraid to open the doors. Too afraid to save her, to help her. This entire time—he had thought he had tried his hardest to get to her, to help her.

In truth, he is just as much a coward as he was when he was four. He doesn't want to open these doors. He doesn't want to face the world, face his Dad. He's scared, he's just a kid and he's *scared.* He doesn't want to do this alone. He hates being alone.

Akatani curls into a ball, sits on the floor. He can see through the narrow gap in the door, can see the sky moving and shadows creeping in. Still, he sits there, shaking in all limbs. Dad is

coming for him, and the feeling of helplessness follows him all the way home.

Thuds. Steps. He trembles, unable to look a moment longer. He curls into a ball when the doors squeak open.

Warm, gentle hands stroke through his hair.

“Found you, Greenie.”

Akatani lifts his head enough to see him. Crouched down before him, in his new suit, is Kacchan. He’s angry, but an undertone of softness, or understanding, lingers in his gaze.

It’s him. It’s always been him. He found him, just as he always will.

“I thought there was a lock,” Akatani confesses.

Kacchan looks at him, head tilted. “There was.” He taps a finger against Akatani’s forehead. “Right here.”

“I was a coward.”

“You were four,” Kacchan corrects. “You were four, you didn’t deserve this.”

“He’s coming, Kacchan.”

“Yeah.” His childhood friend leans back, peers out of the large hole in the apartment. “Let’s do it, then.”

“Do what?”

Kacchan looks at him, the red of his eyes glinting. “Let’s kill this motherfucker.”

Chapter End Notes

Rawr XD

Chapter 56: Plotting

Chapter Summary

Midoriya and the League break out to take down AFO

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“You’re kidding, right?”

Kacchan narrows his eyes at Dabi, who gives him a grin in return before tugging Himiko behind him. The tension in the room is awful, probably because Midoriya just dragged Kacchan into the current hideout of the League with zero warning. He couldn’t give a warning if he wanted to—he would’ve backed out of this plan if he didn’t steel himself and force his feet to carry him here.

“Just listen to what I have to say,” Midoriya says, shielding Kacchan with his body the way Dabi shields Himiko. “We’re all on the same side.”

“My side is one on the run from Heroes,” Spinner pipes up, twirling a katana in his hands. “You two seem to have the opposite idea.”

“Let him talk, Spinner,” Tenko says, sitting on the floor. He rests his elbows on his knees, plopped right by Twice’s side at the only not-shattered window in the room. Twice has his mask off, a cigarette hooked between his lips as he smokes into the air.

If Midoriya has this system figured out, then the dynamic at play here is pretty simple. This group is close, a family found in abandonment. The League itself is a huge group, but these core five are closer than the rest. The leaders and instigators.

“We’re going to kill All for One,” Midoriya says, and hates the *we* that he forces out. “It’s going to happen today. If you want in, then by all means. But I’m giving you the chance to back out. There’s a high possibility that we’ll all be dead this time tomorrow."

Shared glances, then Spinner pipes up again. “How can we trust you?”

“He was pretty efficient with Endeavor,” Dabi says, head tilted. “Followed through on the aftermath even in the wake of All Might’s downfall. How *is* my baby brother?”

Kacchan pushes forward. “We don’t have time for this bullshit. It took me a few hours to track you morons down, I can only imagine the old man won't waste that much time. Let’s make a fucking plan and get on with it.”

Tense, dark air. The apartment that they snagged is a rundown two-bedroom. They've got sleeping bags and canned food, but nothing pricey compared to the hideout provided by Dad. Kurogiri is missing, his presence noticeable in the confined space. So is Mr.Compress. Midoriya doubts that any of them want to live this way. But the sad truth is, even when Dad is taken care of, they'll all be stuck in the same exact situation.

"I'm taking Heroes down, too," Midoriya adds, meeting their eyes. "All for One will drop, but so will the Commission. I can't guarantee that change will happen fast—but I'm going to do the best I can." More shared looks. Kacchan hands Midoriya a laptop he brought with him, and it's easy to tap into Midoriya's coding system. "I-I've already got it loaded up."

He calls the program Reformation. He'd been meticulously leaking Hero societies' corrupted Pros for months now. Slowly weakening the Commission's authority and reliability. He had been planning to, one day, release mass documentation on the Commission in an effort to take the entire organization down. At first, the plan was to do this after Dad was dealt with to avoid mass instability. But… it might work in his favor to release the documents much sooner.

He explains such, scrolling through the data and code key waiting for input. Only when it's revealed does the League agree to join in. A room of people, and he's got them all on his side…

Except—

He meets Kacchan's heavy gaze. This is the first time he's seen Midoriya without the hair dye and contacts. The two of them are in their most natural forms, and Kacchan hasn't stopped staring at him since he pulled him from the ash-ruined apartment. They need to talk about so much shit that Midoriya can't think of right now.

Still, Kacchan gives him a nod, and the plan commences.

"We'll break into teams," Midoriya starts, "Twice and Himiko, you two will cover the other labs where Nomu's are housed. Your goal is to destroy *everything.* Leave nothing behind, bomb the building, if you have to. We can wipe out all of All for One's creations."

Dabi is reluctant, but when Kacchan offers Himiko his wrist, that hesitation dies. Himiko's been training her Quirk, now able to partially wield the powers of whoever she shifts into. Midoriya shoves down the nasty feeling in his gut when Himiko latches onto Kacchan's wrist, drinking the crimson straight from his veins.

"Spinner and Kacchan will handle luring Pros away. We need the scatter the Hero force across Japan, drawing them as far away from these apartments as possible while keeping them separate from each other. Kacchan can get most of them away while Spinner keeps them directed and pinned at a central location," Midoriya says.

"We can get more members out there," Tenko offers. "I can call for the same numbers we had at the UA attack. We'll use our size to lure Pros out and away. Without Kurogiri, it'll take a bit longer, but our people are pretty spread out as it is. So it won't be hard. Compress can help too."

“That’s perfect,” Midoriya agrees. “Find anyone who is willing to play tag with Pros. We don’t want to start any fights; we just need the Heroes distracted.”

Tenko is up immediately, taking the phone Midoriya tosses to him and stepping into the opposite room to make some calls. It leaves Dabi, who seems particularly annoyed. He’s more burnt than usual, his once black hair has gone grey and white.

“You’ll be our beacon,” Midoriya says to him. “Your flame will draw him out, lure him to apartments. When he gets near, I need you to act as a barrier. Flames around the entire apartment complex perimeter. It won’t keep him in, but it’ll keep everyone else out.”

Nods, murmurs, a general agreement spurring up. Himiko unlatches from Kacchan's arm, wiping her mouth of blood and skipping back to Dabi. There seems to be goodbyes going around, this odd collection of people wishing the others luck.

Kacchan pulls him into one of the rooms, quietly shuts the door. The sound of the League still discussing and talking is audible, but dulled by the look in his eyes.

“I love you. I’m sorry.” Kacchan’s harsh delivery of Midoriya’s letter makes his gut churn. “That was it? That’s all I got?”

Midoriya shifts from foot to foot. “Now’s not the time—“

“It’s *never* the time for you,” he says, shaking his head. “When were you going to tell me about Kudo?”

Midoriya isn’t shocked that Kacchan figured it out. “Eventually.”

Kacchan shoves him backwards. “Bullshit.”

“I was!” Midoriya argues, stumbling over his feet. “Once this was done—“

“Well, aren’t you fucking generous?” Kacchan asks, pushing him back again until his shoulders thud against the wall. “This is my blood, my family. And you were going to keep me out of it for your own self-righteousness?”

“Nothing about what I’m doing is self-righteous!” Midoriya argues. He attempts to shove him back, but his hands are immediately caught and held in Kacchan’s grasp. “I’m sorry, I don’t want you involved.”

“I’m coming back,” Kacchan informs him. “I’m leading away Pros, then I’m turning back around and fighting by your damn side.”

“Kacchan—“

“You don’t get to tell me no,” he snips, brows furrowed. “This is my battle, too. You’ve spent years keeping me out of it. I won’t take it for a second fucking more.”

“I—“

“And you’re going to confess every fucking secret you’ve got rattling around in your head once this is all over,” Kacchan demands, tightening his grasp. “I can handle myself.”

Midoriya breathes deeply, his senses assaulted by caramel and smoke. There is no keeping him out of this anymore. He’d find Midoriya no matter where he went and… and he’s right. As much as it pains him to admit it, Kacchan is right. He deserves the chance to bring an end to a man who tormented his family. More so, he deserves the truth.

He’s going to do it. He’s going to let Kacchan in on this. And it makes him terrified, makes his gut turn, but he thinks it’s the right step. The right move. Kacchan wants to be here—and Midoriya is *tired.* Tired of doing this alone, tired of lying to everyone, tired of trying to pretend he doesn’t want Kacchan here just as much.

“Okay,” Midoriya whispers, nodding softly. “Okay, Kacchan.”

“I’ll be back here at 3am,” he says, “It gives me three hours to lure Pros away, then I’m back with you.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.” Kacchan shuts his eyes, still holding Midoriya’s hands within his own. “Did you mean it?”

“Mean what?”

“That you love me?” His eyes open, red latching onto Midoriya’s own. “Did you mean it?”

Midoriya’s heart thuds as he nods. “Yes.”

“Then say it.”

He flushes, yanks a hand free to swat at Kacchan. “Stop teasing me!”

Kacchan grins, snickering when Midoriya hits him. “Can I get a kiss goodbye?”

“Oh!” Midoriya shoves him. “Shut up! You’re so mean!”

He yanks the door open, ignoring Kacchan laughing as he follows him. The group in the room gathers for only a moment longer, then disperses into the given teams. Himiko’s form twists and shines as she turns into Kacchan, offering her little finger wave and a wink before she shoots into the air using those explosions. It does peculiar things to him to see Kacchan wink, even if it wasn’t his actual body.

Moving on from that.

“Tenko, you should go with Spinner and—“

“No,” his brother immediately argues, giving him a flat look. “I’m staying with you.”

“Good idea,” Kacchan says, betraying Midoriya. “Stay with the dipshit. I’ll keep you updated through our headsets. If anything goes wrong, alert me fucking immediately.”

“Same with you,” Tenko says, tilting his head towards Spinner. “If you fuck up, I’ll cut your damn hands off.”

“Can you even hold a knife?” Kacchan bites back, ignoring Tenko’s glare and Twice’s obnoxious laugh.

The room clears out quickly, Dabi leaving to secure the perimeter while Twice starts creating duplicated versions of dozens of villains. Those labs will go down in no time. Tenko lingers for only a moment, eyeing the two of them. He gives Midoriya a look, who gives him a look back. Then he’s rolling his eyes and leaving the two of them alone.

Kacchan stares out the window at the dark sky. “I’ll make soup for you.”

Midoriya laughs a bit. “You’re still not over the Christmas gifts, are you?”

“Fuck you.”

He laughs harder. “Soup it is. Call it a date.”

“I will.”

He stops laughing, elbowing Kacchan. “If we make it out of this, you actually want our first date to be making soup?”

“I do,” Kacchan says. “And counting stars. Shit, I’ll pull out my All Might onesie.”

Midoriya shakes his head, but he’s smiling wide. “Fine. But I’m an awful cook.”

“You’ll be the taste tester, no way in hell am I letting you touch my cooking supplies.”

“What! I bought you those!”

“And you’ll curse them.”

“I can’t believe this!”

Kacchan hums, heads for the front door. “I’ll see you when I’m back.”

Midoriya wobbles from foot to foot. “What? No kiss goodbye?”

His lips tug up. Midoriya braces himself when Kacchan slowly prowls forward, setting his hands on Kacchan’s waist when he grasps his face. They kiss, and it’s just as sweet and undoing as the few before. It’s *right,* they’re right, they always have been.

“Goodbye, Greenie,” Kacchan murmurs, then he pushes away and launches into the sky. Those explosions carry him fast and far, nothing more than glorious light on the horizon.

Midoriya is still smiling like an idiot when he leaves the apartment. Tenko gives him a look, offering a cigarette from his pack that he eagerly takes. They head out to the decimated apartment located a bit of a walk away. No place is more likely to draw out Dad than that.

“Himiko’s gonna be pissed when she finds out you’ve got a boyfriend,” Tenko informs him, sucking on his cigarette.

“I don’t have a boyfriend,” Midoriya argues, but he’s still red in the face.

“Of course not. I also kiss my friends goodbye before I kill my Dad. Typical Tuesday.” Tenko turns, kicks open the ashy front door.

“Shut up,” Midoriya says. “You don’t know what you’re talking about.”

Tenko snorts, offering a lighter for Midoriya’s cigarette. He takes it, flicking it on and lighting the end of his stick. They stand in the center of the decimated apartment, Tenko gazing around the room. There’s still a bloodstain on the wall, he frowns at it.

Midoriya tells him the story. The real one. About Mama, sacrificing everything. About him, wanting to save the world. About Kacchan, who he is and what he means. For a good hour, they smoke and talk, like they’re real brothers. Not two strangers forced together in an unpredictable way. People. Two people.

“I can’t believe this is really happening,” Tenko says, back pressed to the kitchen island. “I always planned for this, but it never seemed like something I could pull off.”

Midoriya listens, smoking slowly.

“I used to have a dog,” his brother says, looking at him. “And a sister. And a mom.” Smoke, flaky skin. “I had always told myself I’d avenge them, but if I’m honest, I don’t think I ever expected to make it that long.”

“Look at you now,” Midoriya says quietly, fiddling with his suit's pockets. “You dealt with him for years. You don’t have to do this, you know.”

Tenko shrugs. “I can’t let you do it alone.”

“I know,” Midoriya mumbles, staring out the window, watching the groups of people hard at work. Pro's fly in the sky, chasing after villians. News outlets are urging evacuations. A massive *League Attack* is painted for the world. “The whole town is evacuated. It’s a good time to get out of here.”

“It’s my battle too,” his brother argues. “If you're dying, I’m going down with you.”

Because that’s the reality they face. In all likelihood, they won’t make it out of this alive. Or, at least, they won’t make it out intact. Something is going to give, it always does. He’s just not sure what it is yet. But that pool of dread, that feeling in his gut that *something* bad is coming—he can’t shake it. He knows, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that you can’t win without losing first.

“I hope it leaves,” Tenko says quietly.

Midoriya traces his pocket. “What?”

“This Quirk.” His brother holds a naked hand out, staring at the exposed skin. “I hope to god it leaves. I’d do anything, honestly. To be able to touch again, to sleep without ruining the blankets, to pet an animal without… I know it’s selfish compared to your situation, but I wish he’d just taken the float Quirk and been done with it.”

Midoriya shakes his head. “It’s not selfish.” He inhales, exhales, smoke burning his lungs. “There’s no guarantee, you know.”

“I know.” Tenko shrugs again. “Maybe I’ll have you bite my fingers off again.”

It’s meant as a joke, but Midoriya feels the genuine intent in the statement. His brother would do anything he could to get rid of this Quirk, to bring his life back.

“Greenie.” Midoriya's sight flickers as Kacchan connects their vision through the goggles. “I’ve got a handful of Pros located a few towns over at the marked point. No eyes on Aizawa-Sensei.”

“Mama?” he asks.

“Himiko’s finished her half of labs and breached UA, she confirmed your mom is inside. But most students—they’ve been pulled out and put on the front lines in anticipation of an attack,” Kacchan says, the sounds of his explosions soft against the noise suppressant functions. “I’m gathering a few more, then I’ll loop back to you in a couple of hours.”

Midoriya watches, from Kacchan’s eyes, what it looks like to fly. Glorious stars, an overhead view. Everything he’s ever wanted. Located far and safe from Dad’s attack point. Kacchan will help him—but everyone else?

“I’ll see you soon,” Midoriya says, disconnecting their vision.

Tenko smokes idly, gazing out the window. Waiting, just as Midoriya is. His brother doesn’t notice when he fiddles with his pocket, pulls out that Quirk-erasing gun, and aims it at Tenko. He protects those he cares for; he protects his family. Tenko’s no exception.

He pulls the trigger.

A scream tears from Tenko’s throat, and those blue flames outside flicker at the echo of the gunshot. The bullet ricochets, cuts through his brother’s shoulder. In seconds, blood pours, and the bullet lodges itself into bone.

“What did you do!” Tenko shouts, grabbing the counter to support himself.

They both stare at the granite countertop. His bare hand rests against its surface, and the slab remains standing. No cracks. No decay. Solid. Sturdy. His hand drags across it slowly before covering his wound.

The front door bangs open. “What the fuck happened!?”

“He’s injured,” Midoriya says, sliding the gun back into his pocket. “He can’t fight.”

Tenko’s eyes blow wide. “What are you doing—“

“Touya,” Midoriya turns to the scared, tall man. “My brother—I can’t let my brother get hurt. He’s not at full strength; he needs help.”

Touya’s blue eyes flicker between them, settling on the wound in Tenko’s shoulder.

“Todoroki is on the front lines,” Midoriya says, switching tactics. “He needs you. Tenko needs you.”

His brother grits out, “Stop—“

“*Please*,” Midoriya begs. “You’ve got to save your family, Touya.”

All Might had mentioned the heart of a Hero, and he hears the thumping of it in Dabi’s chest. It’s wrong to use his trauma and family members as leverage, but Midoriya is desperate. He can’t risk anyone else, even if they hate him for it.

Dabi moves, grabs Tenko’s good arm. “Let’s go.”

“No! No, this is bullshit!” Tenko screams, trying to pull free when Dabi drags him. “What the fuck, Akatani!”

“I’ll let you know when this is over,” he says quietly, frowning when his brother latches onto doorframes and walls in an effort to stay.

“You don’t get to do this!” Tenko shouts at him, Dabi dragging him further and further away. “He ruined me. How *dare you!* You can’t take this from me!”

Akatani leans against the counter. He smokes while Dabi disappears, his brother’s screams dying out as he succumbs to his blood loss. He’ll survive, Quirkless and far from here. And that’s enough for now. He’s already risking so much.

His Quirk flickers to life, colors swirling along his skin. It brightens the apartment, the view of his smoke hidden beneath the hum and thrum. When a few minutes have passed, he emerges from the apartment and carefully calls forward those Quirks. He’s unfamiliar with most of them, but Blackwhip seems to be on his side. Tendrils whip free of his skin, jutting high into the sky, waving in the breeze. Those rainbow colors dance along the whip, a glowing sign of power.

All for One will see it, it’s impossible not to. And he’ll come to Akatani to destroy him, to kill him, to retrieve All Might's Quirk. But he and Kacchan will be waiting.

Three in the morning rolls around. He watches the sky, waits.

Kacchan doesn’t come.

“Rin, call Kacchan,” he says, and his stomach twists and aches.

“Call can’t connect.”

Akatani stares at the night sky, tugging his phone loose and tapping the screen. Maybe the AI is faulty? He hits Kacchan’s name, puts the phone to his ear.

“The person you are trying to reach is unavailable. Please leave a message.”

He calls again.

“The person you are trying to reach is unavailable. Please leave a message.”

Again.

“The person you are trying to reach is unavailable. Please leave a message.”

He looks at the sky again, body trembling. Where is Kacchan? He’s never late, not to anything. Where is Dad? He escaped the prison hours ago, so where is he? Why isn’t he coming?

Akatani pulls Kacchan’s location instantly, but his feet are rooted in place. Dad could be here any minute—he can’t just throw this chance away. There are hundreds of people at play here, luring Pros and Heroes away. If he doesn’t stay at these apartments, then there’s a chance he misses Dad.

But…

“The person you are trying to reach is unavailable. Please leave a message.”

He curses, staring at his phone. Something might be wrong with Kacchan, but he can’t throw this chance away.

Who the hell is he kidding?

Akatani shoots off the ground, adrenaline coursing through him. Black whip works perfectly, Kudo’s Gear Shift lurching to life in his panic. He flies through the air, heart beating. He needs to find Kacchan—

BOOM!

Explosions shatter along the horizon. Akatani throws himself after them.

Chapter End Notes

:p

Chapter 57: Supernova

Chapter Summary

Bakugou fights All for One

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bakugou surveys the location picked to lure Pros to. Twice and Himiko have already begun their second command to distract Pros. Hundreds of duplications of villains, mingled with *actual* villains, line the streets below. The entire city has been evacuated, allowing Pros and villains to fight. It's painted as a villain splurge, an attack on humanity. The reality is somehow worse. The villains are *protecting* the people. Who'd have thought?

It's a half hour before he flies back to Deku, and his mind is locked on the promise of a soup dinner and that kiss. He can't help the victory already running through him. He got Deku, he fucking *got* him. Ha!

"Problem child."

Oh fuck.

Bakugou turns from his crouched position on a roof edge. Aizawa-Sensei is on the opposite end, standing just far enough away to not trigger the infrared scanners. Even then, he seems unprepared to have found Bakugou here.

"You… Bakugou?" Aizawa says, lips tugged into a frown. "Why the hell do you and Midoriya have matching vigilante suits?"

Bakugou looks down at himself, looks back up. "Halloween costumes."

Aizawa-Sensei glares.

"Why the fuck do you think?" Bakugou asks, standing and backing away. "I've got somewhere to be, do me a favor and don't follow me."

"So that's it? I lose two students at once? Not even a note from you?" Aizawa-Sensei asks, goggles covering his eyes. "What the hell is going on?"

A rooftop is not the place for this conversation. But there aren't exactly any better fucking options. The street is littered with people, good and bad. In the distance, Blackwhip whirls and sparks; there's no time to sit here arguing. Bakugou needs to get the hell out of here, *alone.*

“Stay here,” Bakugou starts, “I’ll bring Deku to you when this is over—“

Screams.

They turn, looking over the town as plumes of thick debris and smoke fill the air. He braces for it, holding onto the building as darkness envelopes the city. What the fuck is going on?

A glowing, bright form floats in the air. Its body is almost indistinguishable, but Bakugou feels the presence in his core. All for One. *Here.*

Shit!

He leaves Aizawa-Sensei on the roof, blasting off. One thought, and he knows he needs to call Deku—

“Bakugou!” He turns, meets Kirishima’s eyes. He lands a moment later on a deserted ity street, running towards him. Kirishima grabs his shoulders, yanking him. “We need to get to the others!”

“What’s happening?!”

“He’s going after our class!” Kirishima screams, running with his hand still on Bakugou’s arm. “We need to go!”

They navigate the debris-riddled city with quick steps. Several of the villains, alongside Twice’s illusions, are already dead. Tendrils of sharp spikes wind through the air. They skewer, pierce, cutting clean through people. Kirishima hardens, stopping one from cutting straight through Bakugou’s forehead.

This isn’t right. All for One was supposed to go to Deku, not *here.*

“Aizawa is trying to get us all to retreat, but I can’t just leave!” Kirishima says, pushing Bakugou along. “And you’re the strongest of us; we need you.”

“Where is everyone else?” Bakugou shouts.

Kirishima brings him to a clearing. They join up with a few students, Uraraka and Mina. The former has started to raise rocks into the air to act as a cover. The latter lays acid traps, eliminating the spikes before they ever touch the group.

“You all need to fucking go!” Bakugou snaps. “Leave this for the damn Pros.”

“No way!” Uraraka argues. “The Commission called us to help, we’re Heroes, aren’t we?”

Of course, the Commission called teenagers to the front lines. Those documents are set to release tomorrow morning, and they are unaware that by trying to save their more seasoned Heroes from action by throwing literal children into the chaos, they are effectively sealing their fate.

“This isn’t some random Villain,” Bakugou says, but it’s like arguing with a wall. The seriousness of the situation isn’t hitting these idiots, or maybe it is. Maybe they just want to help so badly that they aren’t aware they’re glowing fucking neon sign targets. AFO must've learned that Deku is a UA student; he's trying to inflict as much damage as possible on his kid. Fucking psychopath.

Panting, then Yaoyorozu appears, sliding across the floor and landing in the center of the group. She’s covered in dirt, awful-looking. Blood smears across his skin, her eyes wide.

“The whole city,” she says, grunting as she holds a wound shut with her hand. “Buildings are falling. That glowing guy—he’s crushing everyone like bugs.”

“Oh my god,” Mina whispers, “What the hell is going on?”

“We need to *leave,”* Bakugou says, and they finally seem to be on board. “I’ll cover the front, Kiris,hima guard our back. Mina and Uraraka help support Yaoyorozu’s weight.”

“I can’t believe this is the moment you use our actual names,” Mina cries out, slinging Yaoyorozu’s arm over her shoulder. “This is awful.”

“Let’s go!” Bakugou pushes out of their makeshift fort, explosions readied. Kirishima grunts as he takes the impact of one of the deranged tentacles, but nothing else harms them.

They weave through streets, passing by bodies and fallen buildings. The ground shakes with the impact of All for One’s Quirk. He’s not even fighting, the bastard. He floats above it all, squashing and eliminating *everyone.* It’s a damn blood bath.

He spots an opening, heads for it—

A scream, and he turns to watch that tentacle bypass Kirishima. It comes from overhead, and there’s no moment to react before it points down and skewers Yaoyorozu through the top of her skull. She’s jerked up by the tendril, blood pouring out of her head, and yanked into the abyss of debris.

“No!” Bakugou grabs Uraraka, holding her tightly when she kicks and screams. “She’s already dead! We need to go!”

“Momo,” Mina sobs, Kirishima grabbing her arm and dragging her through the bloodied street. “Oh my god.”

“Let’s fucking go!” Bakugou shouts, jerking Uraraka along. “Come on!”

It’s brutal, exhausting. He’s covered in soot and sweat, working around fallen beams and jumping through windows. They trek through a fallen house, jumping in through a window and pushing out on the opposite end through a door.

“Rin, call Aizawa-Sensei,” Bakugou grits out.

“Calling Aizawa-Sensei.”

He picks up instantly. “Where?”

“North, we’re in a fallen building. I’ve got Kirishima, Mina, and Uraraka. Yaoyorozu’s dead.”

“Fuck!” Aizawa-Sensei swears. “I’m on the same roof with Monoma. We’re doing everything we can, but he’s got too many Quirks; we can’t negate them all.”

Bakugou cusses. “The Pussy Cats?”

“Mandalay is in route, send me your location and I’ll have her send a message to meet there,” Aizawa-Sensei says, grunting. “Where is Midoriya?”

“Just get people here!” Bakugou says, hanging up.

He lays Uraraka down against a fallen cubicle of another broken building. It’s easy to have Rin send Aizawa-Sensei his location. Kirishima tries to console Mina, but the three of them are all out of commission. Yaoyorozu’s blood coats them all; the vision of that spike digging into her skull is haunting. That must be what created those holes in Ito, Sayori, and Banri’s throats. Fucking awful.

“Kiri,” Bakugou grabs his arm. “Stay here.”

“Fuck no,” Kirishima stands and shakes his head. “You can’t go back out there.”

“I can’t just fucking stand here!” Bakugou argues. He hands Kirishima his phone. “When it’s safe, call Deku. Aizawa-Sensei is guiding people our way. If any villains come in, don’t harm them. They're on our side.”

“But—“

“Trust me,” Bakugou pleads, shaking him a little. “You’re the last line, Kiri. Please just fucking trust me here.”

Kirishima nods, taking the phone with teary eyes. “Hurry back.”

He’s gone a moment later, blasting through the air. He dodges tendrils, his mind echoing with Mandalay's telepathic abilities. It’ll hit everyone, villains included, guiding them to the safe building. It leaves only one person who needs to be kept at bay. He swings around another spiked tentacle, the Quirk cracking against his helmet, shattering it. He rips the technology off, blows himself higher into the air until he's above the smoky darkness. All for One, glowing, hovering above it all.

“Howitzer!” Bakugou screams, his palms heating, aching. “*IMPACT.”*

Light, power, heat, fire. His strongest move, his most powerful weapon. Explosions rain down on All for One. The smoke and debris clear for a moment as shock waves roll over the city. Glass shatters, his eyes rattle and vibrate. Buildings shake, stars shine, Bakugou’s body launches upward at the explosion.

All for One disintegrates, explodes.

And *survives.*

The man looking at him now is young, maybe in his forties. A far cry from the older bastard who lost his face after a battle with All Might. He's age-regressed, as if he has…

Eri's Quirk.

He smiles at Bakugou, his suit melted away and leaving only scraps for pants. Then those tendrils shoot out, aiming for him. He moves quicker, blasting in different directions. His palms ache, his ears ring. He can't take explosions of that impact repeatedly without damaging his nerves. But he'd be damned if he loses here.

Another attack, one he can't dodge—

Ice and fire races for him at once. A large glacier rips out of the ground, shielding Bakugou from the spike. At the same time, blue flames rush for All for One. Fire rages so hot, so bright, that when All for One emerges again, he's a few years younger. He's keeping himself alive with Eri's Quirk—or at least, a version of her Quirk. He must've gotten his hands on those bullets somehow.

Bakugou hits the ground, hands aching terribly. He massages his palms, catching his breath as Todoroki appears. He's got Sero on his back, whose tape dispenser are gone. His Quirk was stolen.

"Bakugou!" Todoroki says, covered in scrapes and bruises. "Kaminari and Shinso made it to the location."

"Will your guys kill us?" Dabi asks, suddenly appearing. "I need to drop Tenko off."

"What?" Bakugou turns to him. "He's supposed to be with Deku!"

Dabi shakes his head. "Just tell me if I need to find a new fucking spot!"

His head is spinning when he answers. "No! They'll take you, go!" He turns to Todoroki next. "Stay out of the fight—"

"Where is Midoriya?" Todoroki cuts him off.

Bakugou swallows. "I don't know."

"Fuck," Todoroki adjusts Sero on his back. "I'll be back."

It leaves Bakugou alone again. He takes it in stride, launching into the air once again. That splintering pain climbs along his skin. He moves despite it, drawing All for One's attention once again. Those white eyes seem to lock onto Bakugou's explosions, tracing his movements. Bakugou abandons any patterns, making himself unpredictable and flashy.

It gives room for Tokoyami behind the villain. Dark Shadow lashes out for the first time in months. Tokoyami had been too afraid to use his Quirk, lest it hurt another classmate. That fear seems to be gone now as he screams, his chest rattling with a roar. That shadow leaches out, its body expanding and growing, its jaw wide and gaping. It snaps down on All for One. He comes out of it younger, just by a few years.

Bakugou levels another explosion at him, but All for One is quicker. Tokoyami is yanked forward by his shadow, his body torn messily in half by a strength Quirk. He's dead before his corpse hits the floor. There's no time for grief. Bakugou flings himself in an arc, catching up with the idiot when he attempts to fly away. He's *fast*, hands hot, bones aching.

He crashes into All for One, the two of them smashing through the side of a building. They catch air again, spinning and whirling.

"Left!" Bakugou turns at the sound of his own voice, eyes widening as Himiko tackles All For One to a rooftop. She's up a moment later, her body morphed into Bakugou's, explosions shooting from her palms.

Midair, she trembles, thick goop whirling off her body as she morphs, changes. Instantly, she takes Todoroki's form, and fire and ice launch out of her palms in sync. All for One is buried beneath it, fire trapped in a chamber of thick ice. Bakugou catches her body when she turns again, her face gritted with pain.

"Too much iron," she says, shaking like a leaf. "I've got barely enough blood left."

"There's a safe—"

"I know," she snickers, "but where's the fun in that?" She winks, her body lurching and morphing. Uraraka is before him now, though her eyes hold that vibrant yellow. "See ya!"

She takes off, careening to the ground. Below, Twice catches her, and the two of them take off. He's unsure where the hell they're—

Pain rockets through his stomach. He grits his teeth as one of those spikes pierces clean through him. He was too distracted, and it's screwing him. That tendril digs into him, latches against his skin, and jerks him closer. He tries to sever it, barely making it before All for One has him in his hands.

Bakugou grunts, trying to get loose as the asshole holds him upright.

"Kudo's blood," All for One says, his eyes pure white, angry. "Of course, he yielded such a powerful lineage. I thought I *killed* you all."

Bakugou spits on his face. "Fuck you."

A palm lands on Bakugou's face, a flicker of red light emitting from a hole in the palm. Pain, unlike anything he's ever felt, wrestles with his DNA, strokes fingers along his Quirk, sends agony—

All for One's eyes flicker behind him, and Bakugou takes in the bodies *floating.* Himiko followed through, and *thousands* of copies of Twice fill the air. Each and every single one headed towards them. The effort to steal Bakugou's Quirk is lost when those bodies land atop them. He squeezes loose of that awful spike, blood pouring out of his stomach.

His palms flow with power still, a small, flickering explosion resting in his hands. He pushes through the throngs of Twice, coughing up blood. Quickly, he stumbles off the building. He flies, higher, further, retreating.

When All for One emerges from the barrage of Twice, he looks to be in his mid-twenties. This time, he doesn't search for a way to cause destruction. Instead, those horrible eyes lock onto Bakugou, and he *chases after him.*

"Fuck!" Bakugou shoots off, faster and faster, and the bastard stays on his trail. He wants his Quirk, wants his death.

Bakugou loops him, spinning and whirling through air. Blood flies from his wound. He rockets into the pile of Twice again, dragging All for One with him. It's an effort to avoid those spikes, the blows intended for him. The villain is quick, but Bakugou is quicker.

Red feathers shoot by, embedding themselves into All for One's body. It gives Bakugou a chance to catch his breath, landing harshly against a rooftop and rolling. He chokes on blood and saliva, sucking air through his teeth at the wound. Hawks fights All for One, his feathers working as both a shield and a sword. Bakugou observes as his palms spark and heat.

"Left, up, faint," he mumbles, memorising All for One's techniques. "Right, up, left, down."

His palms are blindly white, and his mask is half torn. Still, he watches, even when he lays a hot palm flat against his skin. Searing, awful pain burns into his skin. He sobs through it, memorising those patterns, burning his wounds shut. He *will not lose.*

When Hawks falls, his Quirk stripped away by a too-long touch, Bakugou rockets in. He swoops Hawks up before he hits the ground, intending to hand his unconscious body off to Twice. Instead, another spike comes down, and Twice takes it to the skull so the two of them can blow by with no damage to themselves. Bakugou doesn't get a spare moment for grief, not when all those Twice replicates melt and dissolve. They just lost their backup.

He flings Hawks down at Todoroki and Dabi, who have both appeared from who fucking knows. He's leading All for One away again a moment later, burning hotter and brighter. It *hurts,* but he's got to lead him away, got to keep fighting. Left, up, faint. He spins, shoots away. Right, up, left, down. For Akatani, he's got to give him a chance—

But Blackwhip is gone. Those sparkles of colour, Deku's power, are gone. He must be coming, he must be—

Bakugou's breath lodges in his throat as All for One catches up. His eyes go wide, pain roaring through him. Hot, cold, his skin erupts in goosebumps as a new wound opens.

As a spike goes right through his heart.

“I told you, Kudo,” All for One says, dragging that spike down, slamming Bakugou against the hard floor below.

He lands at his side, peering down at his limp form. Bakugou can’t fight back. He can hardly move. Blood gurgles out of his mouth, and he can’t seem to do anything more than choke on it. He’s unsure where they landed, only that it’s far enough away to ensure no one else will get caught up in this.

Only him. And that’s good. That’s enough.

All for One looks down at him, barely twenty years old. “Didn’t I tell you?”

Bakugou chokes on blood, head spinning.

“That you shouldn’t touch things that don’t belong to you?” All for One asks. “Where’s my son?”

Safe. Far away. And that’s enough.

“Oh well.” He crouches down, lays a palm against Bakugou’s face. The hole in his palm swirls with red, colour dancing out, dragging along his face. “I suppose if you're going to die, then there’s no need to take your Quirk."

Bakugou’s eyes flicker, his heart pumping blood that rushes off his skin.

“When my son finds you, which he will, I hope he comes at me angry,” All for One says, smiling at him. “So when I kill him, it’s because he’s only thinking about you.”

Clouds gather overhead, and drops of rain come down. It’s only a drizzle, but it’s enough to cover all the stars in the sky. When All for One walks away, launching into the sky, it leaves Bakugou alone.

He hates being alone. In the dark. In the rain. With no stars to count on. He’s scared. He’s scared, and he’s cold, and he’s shivering.

“Aka—“ he chokes, eyes rolling. “Akatani.”

And it doesn’t matter what he says. Nobody hears him. His eyes bubble with tears, terror seizing him, agony rippling along his skin. He’s alone. He’s afraid.

He gasps, but no air fills him.

Bakugou stares at the sky, rain pouring down. There are no Heroes to save him. Panic and pain flicker, peak, then plateau.

His head lulls, eyes still open, as his heart stops beating.

A star flickers out.

And dies.

Chapter End Notes

:3

Chapter 58: Rain

Chapter Summary

Midoriya finds the body.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya lands outside a building. Peering in through the window, he sees some of his classmates, dozens of villains. The building is swamped with people, and he shoves in through them. His eyes are frantic, scanning.

“Kacchan!” he screams, pushing by people. “Kacchan!”

“Midoriya!”

He stops, turns to Kirishima. “Where is he?”

“He’s not with you?” Kirishima panics, “He went back out to gather survivors.”

Midoriya rushes for the door, jerked back by a hand. Hitoshi holds him in place. He looks truly awful, covered completely in blood and debris. Midoriya doesn’t have a moment to question what the hell happened.

“Todoroki last saw him flying West. I’m following after you with Recovery Girl.”

“Thank you—“

“Go!” Hiroshi shoves him out the door. “Hurry!”

Midoriya does.

He doesn’t think about the missing faces in the crowd of people there. He doesn’t wonder about his brother, about the League. He doesn’t wonder about his old classmates, about his Sensei. He only thinks about Kacchan. About the lack of input from him. The radio silence. The rainfall pouring down. Kacchan hates the rain.

His Quirk lights him up, color rendering him the ability to fly, to soar. He’s never moved this fast, and for once, he’s grateful for his lack of control in his Quirk. Emotions activate power, and his Quirk responds well to his panic, launching him faster and farther.

“Kacchan!” he screams, voice ruined and raw.

The battle has stopped. Whatever happened here—he missed it. He had sent everyone so far away, so distant. He only made it right at the end, having locked onto Mandalay's telepathic calls for help or assistance. Of course, Kacchan would go back out; he can never leave anything alone.

What happened?

Midoriya soars overhead, Blackwhip keeping him steady as he uses momentum to jump from roof to roof, peering down alleyways. Was this Dad? Or was it Nomu's? Or did the League betray them? He wishes he could just get an answer. Instead, he's soaked through with rain, searching and looking for *anything.*

He spots a few people, helps tug them loose from debris, or guides them to the safe building that's been discovered. Sometimes, he sees League members helping civilians get free. Other times, he sees young children being picked up and run to safety by people who don't know them. The community comes together, hand in hand, guiding each other to a safe point.

Midoriya spots a cluster of toppled buildings. It's made a sort of clearing, and he swings himself to it. "Kacchan!"

Rain sleets off his clothes. His voice is drowned in the weather.

"Kacchan!"

He keeps looking, squinting his eyes through the gloom.

"Ka…"

There's a corpse on the ground.

"K… Ka…Kacc…" he can't get the words out, stumbling forward, approaching the limp form.

Kacchan.

"No, no." He drops to his knees. "No, no, no, stop it." He places his hands over the gaping wound in his chest as though he can stop the bleeding—as though he can put Kacchan back together again. "No, no, no."

Hot tears run down his face. Blood smears across his palms. Kacchan's eyes are open.

"No, you can't," he says, grasping Kacchan's face in his bloody fingers. "No, no, we didn't even—we didn't even have our first date yet. You can't—you can't do this, Kacchan, wake up."

He shakes him.

"Wake up! Wake the fuck up!" He slams his fist down on his chest. "Wake up!"

Kacchan doesn't.

Something inside him splinters open. Breaks. He's unsure what it is; he only knows it can never be fixed again. He's lost something—something that was living inside Kacchan's heart.

"Let me—" he shudders with a sob. "Let me do it over. Let me—let me fix it." He cracks, breaks. "Please." He rests his forehead against Kacchan's. "Just let me—"

Rain. Thunder. Lightning.

"We were supposed to be Heroes together," he tells him. "We were supposed to be *something* together. Me and you."

Midoriya curls up next to him, holding Kacchan against his chest. He doesn't mind the blood; he just holds him. He can't believe he spent so long never holding him. What a waste. What was he thinking?

He never should've gotten him involved. He knew better. And he still did it. He did this.

"I'm so sorry," Midoriya whispers, staring up at the sky. "I just thought… I just thought it would turn out okay."

He can hardly see straight, can hardly think.

"I can't do this alone," Midoriya tells him, crying. "I can't do it. Not without you."

Black whip gently pulls from Midoriya's chest, running along Bakugou's heart. He can feel the coldness, the wetness of the organ. Still, he can't stop his Quirk from wrapping around it, trying to hold it together again.

"I love you," he confesses. "All of this—this Hero bullshit. It was all for you." He lays Kacchan back down, wipes away the blood on his face. "It was always gonna be you."

You.

Midoriya strokes a hand down his soft, rain-soaked cheek. He's so tired. He wants to go home. He's all done being a superhero; he just wants to be a kid. He wants to play video games, and study for tests, and celebrate Christmas. He doesn't—he doesn't want to do this anymore.

Not without Kacchan. Not without these missing pieces of himself, buried within another. He hadn't realized how much of himself was here, right here—right in Kacchan's chest.

He can't be dead. He *can't.*

His eyes are wide, unseeing. Midoriya shuts them softly, strokes a thumb across his cheek.

"It was you," Midoriya whispers. "I was never really counting the stars—I was counting the number of times I had thought about you. I can remember the exact moment I first met you, and I'd count from that point forward the number of times you'd occupy my mind." His tears mingle with the rain. "It was always you."

He leans down, presses a kiss to Kacchan's lips. A promise, a hope, a calling. When he pulls away, the rain is still falling.

Midoriya again strokes his face. He can hear people moving, sirens going off. Help is coming for Kacchan. It's too late, but it's coming. With help—comes Heroes. Being a Hero is awful. All Might had told him so, and he had experienced it firsthand, but he never really expected it this time. He's not sure why. Maybe he just thought he had already lost enough. What more could the world possibly take?

"I love you," Midoriya tells him again. "I'll see you again."

He backs away, readying his support scarf, suddenly unable to do anything more than that. He latches it onto the side of a building, staining the fabric with his dark hands. He stares at Kacchan as he goes away, watches that powerful form get smaller and smaller. There is nothing inside him when he lands on a roof, when he walks away.

And when Kacchan is out of sight, *rage* begins to trickle in. His scarf withdrawals, green sparks dancing on his skin. Adrenaline shoots through him, colors dancing on his skin. He jumps, and, without meaning to, launches himself miles into the air. Black whip juts out, swinging him wide, and he *flies.* Over the cities, through the air, across Japan.

And when he is above the clouds, he sees, miles away, a glowing form waiting for him.

Dad.

Chapter End Notes

:p

Chapter 59: Return

Chapter Summary

Midoriya fights All for One

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He missed this rage.

Viridant looks his father in the eye for the first time in years, and the only thought that crosses his mind is how, exactly, he's going to kill him. The smart choice his father could've made would've been to hide, to recover. Or to not kill Viridant's fucking boyfriend. Either worked, really.

Instead, the two of them stare at each other, floating above the clouds. Then Viridant *moves*. Fast, beyond fast, his body a whirlwind of color as he slams against Dad with the full power of his Quirk activated. His arm shatters, and it's worth every second when Dad slams miles down onto the building below. His body careens through the roof, piercing through floors.

Viridant follows after, knowing damn well it takes a lot more than that to kill Dad. Still, he looks a bit younger when he again faces Viridant. They stand on the floor of an office building, cubicles littering the way. Large, rope-like spikes jut out of him. They're easy to avoid, Viridant twirling and bending out of the way. Green sparks dance off him, a buzzing in the back of his head warning him before a single bristle touches him. Danger sense, Hikage Shinomori. Viridant bends backwards, hands on the floor, spinning and sliding out of the way before those spikes ever touch him.

And as he goes, he pulls out that gun. And shoots.

Dad stills when his spiky tendrils disappear, dissipate. Forever erased, forever gone. He didn't think he was the only one who used Eri's Quirk, did he?

Viridant uses Black whip, wrapping it around Dad's skull before slamming his body against one wall, then the next, then the next. He whips him around, burying his thick skull into concrete and throwing him through cubicles. He bounces right back, and Viridant leaps over large cubicle walls to escape several different powers thrown his way. He throws random items, mice and keyboards and pencil holders, keeping his vision obscured before tackling Dad out of the windows.

Face to face, spiraling for the floor, Dad smiles at him. "Are you angry?"

Tears prick Viridant's eyes. They go down, down, down.

“I had expected more,” Dad tells him. “What a waste of time.”

Dad flips them, and Viridant hits the floor instead. Float and Blackwhip keep him protected, bracing his fall, but Dad’s already begun his next onslaught of attacks. Only, he doesn’t go after Viridant.

All for One shoves through the window of an apartment building. Viridant is up the next instant, but screams have already started. There’s only so much he can do to catch up, flinging himself through an apartment, coming across bodies of whoever lived here. Parents, children, pets. He knows what to go after to hurt Viridant, so he does.

He needs to keep Dad away from people.

Blackwhip works again, grabbing Dad by the head and throwing him through the brick siding of the building. Viridant crawls along the paneling, running up the walls like an animal. He shoves himself into the air, using the momentum of the jump and float to get high in the air again. They break clouds, alone with the stars. Viridant bashes his helmet against Dad’s face. He’s got no intention of losing.

Quickly, he cocks his gun, pops two bullets into All for One’s side before he can react. It doesn’t stop Dad's arm from building up, some type of Omni-factor Quirk usage. One swing and Viridant goes flying, his helmet shattering at the strength. He still keeps his hold on Dad’s head with Blackwhip, using the power to rear Blackwhip down, snapping Dad’s neck.

One for All rewinds again, now younger, watching him with angry eyes.

“Come on!” Viridant screams at him. “I thought you were supposed to be the best!”

Dad’s lip curls before he’s shooting at Viridant again. The sun peaks at the horizon, part of the clouds colored red and pink. It’s nothing compared to dozens of colors lining Viridant’s skin. All for One swings, hitting him harshly in the stomach with a blow that nearly rips Viridant in half. He thinks of All Might’s injury, of the horrible wound that renders him weak.

Viridant grunts, grasping the hand, and tearing it right off. Dad rewinds, gains the limb back, but he’s nearly Viridant’s age now. White hair, white eyes. One of his Quirks must’ve changed the color, and Viridant is almost overjoyed by the idea. His eyes are his own again, and the thought has him screaming, landing a smash against Dad’s face with his already shattered arm.

They go flying. Sunlight breaks over the clouds, blinding rays of light coloring them the same. No longer two sides of the same coin. If anyone were to look at them, they’d see they don’t look so different at all.

All for One bashes downwards, and Viridant careens dowto the floor. He gasps, colliding with the side of a building. Pain rockets through his body, his leg snapping sideways. Still, he raises his gun limply, shoots off a few more bullets into Dad’s body. Technically, the man should be getting the Quirks back after he regresses in age. But if he modified Eri’s bullets like Viridant thinks he did, then it’s possible the effect of Eri’s Quirk can only go after his

physical body and not the Quirk's essence. By his Dad's own stupidity, he's negated the ability to get those Quirks back.

Viridant laughs, coughing up blood from his spot in a pile of bricks.

"This is funny?" All for One asks him, shaking debris off him.

"You're losing to a fifteen-year-old? Yeah," he laughs again. "Kind of embarrassing, actually."

Dad swings for him. Viridant zips out of the way, letting the punch collide with the birck siding. They've smashed into another building, though this one seems to be under construction. Even better. He grabs a brick, mashes it again Dad's temple, the two of them landing blow after blow on one another.

"I hope you weren't too mad about your little friend," All for One says, beating him down, shoving him through the floor to the next level of the building. "He's a bit of a crybaby, you know."

Anger, crimson-wrapped rage.

"And your poor mother."

Viridant's heart drops. He dodges a blow meant for his heart, Dad's fist lodging into the floor when he was only a moment ago. Viridant uses the chance to kick his side forcefully. All for One's arm detaches, blood flying. He rewinds, and he has to be Viridant's age now.

"Mama is fine," Viridant says, black whip adhering to his body like a second layer of skin.

"Not for long," Dad tells him, dodging another punch for him and landing a hard one across Viridant's chest. "I had planned to make you watch as I peeled the skin off her bones, but I'm beginning to think it might not be worth the effort." He throws Viridant through the wall, his body crashing against the scaffolding in the next room. "I could always just use your mind, you know. You'd make an excellent Nomu. I feel bad letting you go to waste."

Viridant takes off, throwing himself at All for One and ripping a chunk of his neck out. The asshole rewinds again, and morning light reveals his grin. All for One's *enjoying* this, eager to see how long it can go for. He's aware that he's losing, and he's letting it happen for a perfect, satisfactory moment of victory.

Another three bullets, then Dad grabs the gun, bends it in half. He picks Viridant up by his neck, slams him down into metal. Rebar pokes through his stomach, the rust swirling inside him.

"When I'm done with you," All for One says, "I'm going after your fucking brother next."

"Oh, I'm sure," Viridant says, trying and failing to get off the metal. "If you can find him."

"I'll find him," Dad assures him, peering down at him. A fifteen-year-old, just as he is. "The same way I found you."

Viridant breathes shallowly, sneering when All for One peels his face mask off. Dad looks at him, really looks at him, and there isn't a single flicker of emotion on his face. Calculating ambition, predatory ideology, and that's it. Viridant hates his father, but it would be a lie to say some part didn't long for one. For those childhood memories he could've had, for something that could've gone *right.* Instead, he was stuck with this. And maybe it's selfish to admit that, even now, he wishes he had a father.

"You were useful," Dad says, face splitting into a smile. "I've been *waiting* to get these Quirks back."

He lays a palm flat on Viridant's face. Red light emits from the hole in his hand. Smokey light touches Viridant's face.

And nothing happens.

"What…" Dad pulls his hand back, looks at his palm. "You… you already gave it away?!"

He rips Viridant off the rebar, shoves him against a wall. His eyes are wild and wide, and he shakes Viridant forcefully when he laughs.

"Who?" Dad demands, "The embers are still in you, you're still at nearly full power. You must've just given it away." Viridant doesn't fight back. "Who has my power?"

BOOM!

Light.

BOOM!

Power.

BOOM!

Heat.

BOOM!

Fire.

Kacchan.

He doesn't explode through the building. His body is so hot, so charged, that he *melts* through the wall, colliding instantly with All for One. Midoriya hits the floor, still laughing, while Kacchan slams Dad through wall after wall after wall.

All for One hits back, of course, he does. He flings himself forward and out of the open wall, fleeing into the air. He's fast, moving as quickly as he can, rocketing through the air. And it's not fast enough.

Kacchan appears a moment later, neon orange x's crossing along his skin. Blackwhip swirls out of him, orange and black tendrils wrapped around his heart, holding it together again. They lock eyes for only a moment, the colors of power staining their skin. Then they take off. Kacchan blasts through air with his explosions. Stronger than before, louder than before, the earth rattling with his strength. Midoriya keeps pace at his side, red shoes pushing off buildings and flinging him through air.

The embers of All for One flare and sing, call to him. Voices rattle in his head, urging him forward, begging for more. So that's what he gives them.

He and Kacchan work in sync, exact matches in speed, in power. Midoriya grabs onto a building further down with Blackwhip, launching himself forward and grabbing Kacchan's hand as he whizzes by. Gear Shift fizzes to life, and with a shout, he throws Kacchan. An orange blur of pure power, laughter and whoops of joy. Kacchan catches up to All for One, burning through buildings, concrete and bricks touching him like butter to a hot knife. Dynamite. TNT. A human bomb.

Midoriya is right after him, swinging himself in circles through the air. Faster, faster, spinning in circles, black whip circling. When Kacchan retrieves All for One, blasts him backward, his young body catches in the makeshift wind channel Midoriya's made. A tornado, Dad's body whips around, slamming against the ground below.

"Howizter!"

"One for All!"

They aim down, All for One rewinding, several years younger now.

"Impact!"

"One million percent!"

Colors. Orange and green, mixing and intertwining. Sparks fly, rays of pure light, power, sear into the floor below. The world rattles and shakes, the ground caving in and opening. The pain of the blows is distant, only the colors of their souls shattering the sky.

Wind pressure blows them back, but Midoriya grabs Kacchan's hand, keeping them rooted to the earth with Blackwhip. Kacchan's laughing the whole time, and Midoriya can't help the resounding smile on his face.

When they land on the floor again, All for One is a teenage boy. He's barely their age, likely a bit younger. He's panicked, enraged. He knows he can only rewind so much further before he can't recover. So he switches tactics.

"Wait, wait!" He backs away from the two of them, a scraggly boy. "What do you want? Name it, I'll give you it."

Midoriya hesitates. "You… will?"

“Yes,” All for One tells him, eyes dancing between the two of them. “A Quirk—I’ll give you a Quirk. You’ll need one now, won’t you, son?”

Son.

Midoriya tilts his head, approaches. “What Quirk would you give me, Dad?”

“Anything you want,” he promises him, his eyes back to their horrible red. “Name it, and it’s yours.”

He looks back at Kacchan, and he offers him a smirk.

“I mean, how could I pass this up?” Midoriya asks him. When he turns back to dad, he’s smiling wide. “Why not just kill you instead?"

All for One says, "Heroes don’t kill.”

Midoriya tugs a knife loose from his pocket. “I’m no fucking Hero."

He drives it home. The blade pierces clean through All for One’s eye, digging deep into his brain. Quirkless, with his bare hands, Midoriya killed him. Just like that. A knife to the brain.

Blood puddles on the floor.

Kacchan stands at his side, extends a palm, and burns the remains to a crisp. He doesn’t stop until only ash remains, the wind carrying it away. A black smudge is left on the floor, the end of All for One. His power, his legacy.

“That wasn’t nearly as fucking satisfying as I thought it would be,” Kacchan says, clicking his tongue.

And then—colors. Hundreds of glorious, beautiful colors. They come out of the ash in vaguely human-shaped blobs, swirling in the air before rocketing off in different directions. The stolen Quirks—they’re going back to their owners. Midoriya spots a light blue wisp, blowing like a fresh breeze, taking off into the air. Tenko’s Quirk.

He watches, eyes wide. They seem joyful, magical, unlike anything he’s ever seen. They soar, shoot, spin and twirl. Those that no longer have an owner fizzle away, dissipate into the air.

“Shit,” Kacchan mutters.

Midoriya turns, watches the beautiful orange sparks pull loose from Kacchan. He holds a hand over his heart, face a grimace as the rainbow color slowly rises from him. But the wisps don’t leave him; they wait.

“Your heart—“

“Recovery girl healed me enough,” Kacchan assures him. “She’s gonna be pissed, but I’ll be fine. But you—“

Midoriya gasps at the sudden pain in his body. It's deep-rooted and *everywhere.* It feels like he's being ripped apart. He swallows a screen, skim lit up and hot. Color peels off him, one by one; the Quirks slowly leave his body, mingling with the other specks of color. Still, a thread of white courses along his scars and bruises, along his bones.

And he hears a whisper that sounds an awful lot like Yoichi. *Thank you.*

His body can't handle the sudden loss. His injuries meet him head-on, and the agony of losing his Quirks, the adrenaline—it hits him all at once. Kacchan catches him before he falls. Not that he's aware of that.

Everything goes dark. Quiet. Numb. For the first time in years. He's at peace.

He doesn't wake up for a very, very long time.

Chapter End Notes

;D

Chapter 60: Time

A P R I L.

Chapter 61: Never

M A Y...

Chapter 62: Seems

J U N E.

Chapter 63: To

J U L Y.

Chapter 64: Stop

A U G U S T.

Chapter 65: Passing

S E P T E M B E R.

Chapter 66: Sleep

Chapter Summary

Bakugou thinks about everything that's changed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Yo, Bakubro!" Bakugou stops his retreat to Recovery Girl's office. He stands in the UA halls, letting Ejiro catch up to him. "Hey, man. You going to QEP in Mustafu tonight?"

Bakugou shrugs. "We'll see what the old fucking lady says."

"Oh shit, that's today, huh?" Ejiro rubs a hand through the back of his head. "Sorry, I got distracted with all this Mina stuff going on. You need me to come with you?"

"No," Bakugou says, ignoring the kind look Ejiro gives him. "I'm fine, shitty hair. Go hang out with your girlfriend."

"You know where to find me, yeah?" he asks.

"Yeah."

When Ejiro leaves, Bakugou keeps on down the hall. Things are different now. Quieter. In the absence of Deku—uh, Izuku, it's been… lonely. It's not to say there aren't people here and friends constantly surrounding him. But it is to say that the world has gone silent.

He holds a hand over his heart as he walks. Today is his six-month check-in with Recovery Girl. She's been a vital tool for the past half year, single-handedly keeping Bakugou alive. Well, her and Izuku. One for All had saved Bakugou's life, the power wrapping around his heart and holding it together. Recovery Girl's kiss had mended most of the wound, but it was those accumulations of Quirks that kept him alive.

He wishes he could thank Izuku.

The beat of his heart is a bit sporadic. He's got a pacemaker now, Melissa and Hatsume putting together some kind of metal device that makes up for the missing half of his heart. In an effort to keep himself from a heart attack, he's been calmer than usual. Quiet, silent.

They lost two 1-A kids in the attack months ago. Countless 1-B. UA has the lowest student population since its creation, not that much focus has been put on that. Izuku's preprogrammed document release followed the death of All for One exactly as promised. And the world has shattered.

The Commission fell. For a long while, there were no classes, no coursework. Hero society toppled over and disappeared. Pillars of the world broke open, mass documentation of abuse destroyed public image. Even more, Izuku didn't only take down Japan's Commission. He hit *everywhere.* All seven continents, he attacked. He put Viridant's name on it all, and for long months, a call for his retrieval was sent out from every nation of the world.

It's all gone now, though. Six months, and things have… fixed. The QEP was founded, otherwise known as The Quirk Expansion Project. Funded by UA, backed by All Might, and thousands of other Pros, the QEP acts as its own branch of government. To enable corruption, lawmakers and politicians must take a vote directly from the people in order to alter or change anything within the project. It works a lot of the same way the Commission did, but its ways have been completely altered.

For one, children are no longer allowed to become Heroes. UA will take enrollment for high school, but until a child is a legal adult, they are not allowed in the field. At least four years of schooling are required. This isn't just for the safety of the children, but for the people. Entrusting human lives with inexperienced teenagers was a flawed and inherently abusive system. No longer are children allowed within Hero work. They can have apprenticeships under Hero agencies, they can earn provisional licenses within a year of adulthood, but they can't act as Heroes.

Laws around discrimination have lifted exponentially. The entrance exam to Hero schools has been changed to account for inclusivity. Each test will be catered to the unique Quirks, or lack thereof. Hero ranking systems have been abolished, and an entire reformation of the system has been conducted. All current Pros have to retake their final tests to earn their Hero license back; any with a previous record or release of abusive documentation were eliminated from the field and arrested.

Izuku got exactly what he wanted. He ended the corruption of Hero society. He reformed all legal systems. He abolished discriminatory laws. And he isn't even awake to see it.

Bakugou slides open Recovery Girl's office door. She's waiting for him, smiling sweetly. Her wrinkles pull at her face, her grey hair tied into a bun.

"Good afternoon," she says kindly.

Bakugou offers a nod in return, plopping onto a stool left open for him. On his right, the wall is lined with machines and technology. On his left, Izuku lies unconscious in bed. They know better than to try to keep Bakugou away from him. So his exams are held here, within a few feet of Izuku.

He looks awful, he always does. Weak. Small. He's got one of those clear masks that cover his mouth, a tube down his throat that helps him breathe. Heart monitors, IV, weekly CT scans. He's a corpse kept alive by modern medicine. His brain activity is limited, if there's any at all. Even if he does wake up, it could take months, maybe years, of physical therapy to bring him back to his regular muscle mass. Recovery Girl has kept him up as best she can, but Izuku's resorted back to the scrawny teenager he once was.

“How’s the heart?” Recovery Girl asks, grabbing a metal wand. She lays it against his chest, and it retrieves all data stored within.

“It’s fine,” he says softly.

It can’t be anything other than fine. Spikes in the device alert him, Recovery Girl, Aizawa-Sensei, and both his parents. If anything was wrong, the entire fucking country would know. Still, he has checkups.

“Your remote checkups look good. No issue with the battery or pacing thresholds,” she says, pulling up his data on a little screen she keeps handy. “And you’ve been doing much better with regulating your heartbeat.”

Of course he has. What does he look like? An idiot?

He doesn’t say anything.

“And your hands?” Recovery Girl asks, taking his palm. “How have the spasms been?”

“Fine,” he says again.

Quirk overuse has rendered his arms nearly useless. He spent a few months in physical therapy, trying to regain the ability to open and close his hands. His mobility is still off, but he practices on his own time. Grip weights, pull-ups, he manages well enough. And if sometimes he trembles and holds back tears when he can’t do the simple task of tying his shoes, then no one is the wiser. He can still use his Quirk, can still touch and feel things, so he’s fine enough. He’ll regain the rest of his movement with time.

She rotates his wrists for a while, pressing on different parts of his hands and asking if he feels any pain. He tells her no, letting her run her full exam while he watches Izuku.

They don’t know why he won’t wake up. The general theory is that his mind has shut down as a direct result of the trauma induced on his body. His brain is trying to protect him from pain, so it just shut off completely. All Might was the one to explain it all, the guilt of the confession so palpable that Bakugou can taste it even now. Izuku might never wake up, nothing more than scars and bones. He’s changed the world, and he’s not even awake to see it.

When the examination is done, Recovery Girl sighs. “I want you back in another six months, or the moment you feel like anything is off.” He nods. “I assume you’ll be at the QEP tonight?” Another nod. “Remember to take it easy.”

“Okay.”

Another sigh, and she follows his gaze to Izuku. “I’ll give you a moment.”

When she leaves, the room is filled with only the sound of Izuku’s beeping machines. The soft whirling of an oxygen tank. The repetitive click of his heart monitor. Maybe Bakugou is quiet because he’s already begun to grieve. He still holds hope that Izuku will pull through, but every day he comes to see him, Izuku looks more and more like a corpse.

He stands, heads over to the hospital bed. He's fresh from class, so he holds his school bag and pulls out a notebook.

"I took notes for you," Bakugou says, flipping through pages. "They're not as detailed and fucking psychopathic as yours, but it's enough to get you by." It took ages to hold a pencil properly. In the end, Melissa made him a device that essentially tapes the pencil to his forearm using metal prongs.

Nothing.

Bakugou touches his face softly. Izuku's skin is cold.

"I'm kind of mad at you," Bakugou tells him. "You really had to go and die in the lamest possible way."

The hum of a machine.

"I'm headed out to the QEP in Mustafu tonight. This weekend I'll go to the one in Tokyo, they could always use an extra hand." He pushes black curls out of Izuku's face. "Whenever you're ready to wake up, I'll take you to one. You'd love it."

He really would. It's one of the best things that came out of Izuku's information drop. The founding of facilities called QEPs. Japan started them, but other countries have quickly followed through with their own. In the effort to eliminate pollution and waste, Japan has refurbished abandoned buildings across the country. The first building they went after was the one that Izuku always took home in his vigilante days. It's been changed from a dusty, run-down place, into a fully operating Quirk facility. Anyone and everyone can show up to release the pressure of built-up Quirks. Bakugou didn't forget those childhood days where his hands ached so terribly from the lack of use. Izuku demanded that it be built in the mass documentation he released. Demanded that anyone of any age or any Quirk has a place that would accept them.

It's gone a step further in recent months. Centers are now run through them as well, and those with less convenient Quirks can request supplies they need free of charge. Bus routes have been added, funded entirely by the government, with a route to the QEPs without cost. Free access to medical care Quirked people have needed for years. Six months, and Izuku accomplished what Pros couldn't in his sleep.

There was a long debate over what these buildings should look like. Bakugou had piped up instantly, telling everyone who would listen that they should be green. And so, thousands of green buildings were made, a safe place for women, men, children, anyone.

Bakugou strokes a hand down Izuku's face again. "I'll see you after, keep you updated on everything."

Nothing.

He presses a kiss to Izuku's forehead, tries to give him some of the wavering strength he's got left. It doesn't work. He leaves the room with a bit of a weight on his shoulders. Despite it, he

takes the bus to the QEP. The world is at ease. The bus is quiet and content.

When he gets off at the green building, he stands and stares at it for a long while. There's a plaque by the door, the words *Viridant's Home Facility* scribed onto the metal. Izuku would really love it. The pale green exterior, the clean and welcoming inside. The free bus routes, the supplies given without judgment.

A girl walks out the front door, short blonde hair falling against her shoulders. She's got a paper bag in her hands, stamped with the QEP logo of an emerald rabbit. When she sees him, she smiles wide, sharp canines flashing.

"I totally thought I missed you!" Himiko cheers, wiggling her bag. "I just ran out of stock, so I had to get some new bags."

Bakugou snorts. "Type O?"

"It's the best," Himiko insists. "Though they water it down so I don't get iron poisoning."

"How dare they."

Himiko giggles, approaching him. "Any updates?"

"Still asleep," he says, and her resounding frown is meager. "You could always see him yourself."

She snickers. "You and that homeless teacher keep trying to get me into UA."

"You have the skill," he goes on, "The brains. The talent."

"I liked it better when you were mean!" Himiko snaps, a hand on her hip.

She's changed out of her schoolgirl attire, taking on a pink sweater and black skirt. It really suits her, and he knows the pink is an ohm to Uraraka. Still, the change in clothing is a sign of her growth, her improving mental health.

The League of Villains was a peculiar situation to navigate. In the end, Izuku saved them as well. Most of the thousands of members have been pardoned and forgiven for their crimes, having singlehandedly saved dozens of civilians during the attack months ago. A few have come forward and been given housing in homeless shelters; others were just regular members of society. But almost all of them benefit from the QEPs, including Himiko. It's where she gets blood from, no longer judged for needing it. Or—she is. Discrimination doesn't just end when laws are hammered out against it. People are still just as awful, but now she's got support to get through it. The organisation provides therapy, Quirk support, and Himiko is here often. Not just to get blood, but to learn how to manage her Quirk properly, and, even more, to volunteer.

She's one of the many volunteers who come in to work with the children who stop in. She's here every day, helping kids, participating in group therapy. Aizawa-Sensei has been trying to get her into UA for months now, but she's reluctant to apply for the Hero course. They don't

push her too much, let her find her own way in the world, given opportunities she's never had before.

"Oh. I almost forgot!" Himiko says, giddy again. "The court hearing is next weekend. Will you be there?"

"Shit, already?" he asks, but he's already nodding. "I'll be there."

"Yay!" She launches forward, gives him a tight hug. "I'll see you around!"

She's gone a moment later, humming as she walks down the street. A normal member of society. No longer a reject, but a functioning human being. It's peculiar to see.

The court hearing pertains to Touya Todoroki, who has been fighting tooth and fucking nail for custody of Himiko, Tenko, and Shoto. The courts are resisting it, only granting him partial split custody with Aizawa-Sensei. So long as he shows up to visitation, has zero issues with pickup and swapping the kids from Aizawa's home, then he should be golden to finally get full custody. Aizawa is more than helpful with the whole thing, eager to get three of the five children out of his damn house. He's already taken in Hitoshi and Eri; having three more troublemaking children has been exhausting him.

He never complains, though. He does the whole process legally, talking Touya through the steps. Touya finally managed to finish school, his GED awarding him the right to work. He, too, was a victim of Aizawa-Sensei's endless attempt to get him to try out Hero work. In the end, Touya refused to do it, instead finding a steady job in the most difficult field he could've picked.

When the Commission fell, and government workers and Heroes were given warrants for their arrest, a lot of them fled or went into hiding. Touya works with Japan's police force as a sort of bounty hunter. He gets paid to hunt the corruption down and bring them in. The psychopath *loves* it, and it's a steady enough job to grant him partial custody. Bakugou's seen the apartment the guy has landed. Four bedrooms, clean, food-stocked pantries. He's doing the best he can. And when Bakugou had been interrogated months ago about the League and asked about Dabi's potential murder streak, he didn't say a damn word. He'd be a bit of a hypocrite to sell the guy out after all he's done.

Touya got probation for suspicion of aiding in a crime. Nothing he was pinned for, and nothing that could taint his record. And he's truly turning it around. Through Himiko, Bakugou was able to get the guy in contact with one of his mom's artists. His scars aren't entirely gone, still a soft red, but his face is entirely intact again. He actually looked completely normal last time Bakugou saw him. He had dropped his arsenal of children off at the QEP, and Bakugou didn't even recognise him. White hair, with new, red roots growing out. The same blue eyes, but with soft and clear skin. He looked like a normal guy.

He *is* a normal guy. It occurred to Bakugou, through many therapy sessions, that this League of Villains were all just normal people who wanted to live without fear. Spinner teaches martial arts, Compress joined a fucking circus. It's the most bizarre thing to have ever happened. The Nomus are all gone, Kurogiri finally being laid to rest in a grave right beside Twice.

It’s good. It’s better than good. It’s just missing Izuku.

Bakugou goes inside, immediately greeted by a friendly front desk lady. He passes her by, gazing into the large arena-like space where dozens of people are allowed to release their Quirks as needed. He immediately spots Ejiro, who guides a little boy through a transformation Quirk. The kid gets stuck in alternate forms, and Ejiro knows firsthand how to stop the body physics from working against you. Mina’s here too, though she teaches dance classes here in her spare time. She’s insistent that making the place a welcoming and fun environment will draw in more kids; no one argues against it.

And then there’s Tenko.

“You feel right here?” he asks, voice quiet and soft. “What are these called?”

“Callouses!” Eri says, holding her hand up. “And when I touch, as long as my horn isn’t on, it won’t hurt anyone.”

Tenko’s eyes dart to Bakugou, narrow, before he looks back to Eri. “And you know how it feels when your Quirk is on.”

“Warm!” she says, holding Tenko’s hand. “See? You’re still here!”

He smiles at her, “I’m still here.”

Tenko was the first volunteer at the QEP. He was the only person willing to help a child whose Quirk could turn people to stone with just a touch. No one was willing to work with the kid, too nervous, too inexperienced. Then Tenko stepped up and changed that kid's life. Aizawa-Sensei has tried to recruit the kid to the Hero course, as he has many others. Tenko’s on the fence about it. From what Bakugou understands, he’s torn between Hero work and mental health progression. He’s unsure if he wants to be a therapist, specializing in child and adolescent development, or a Hero, specializing in rescue and rehabilitation.

“Go see Mina,” Tenko says, parting Eri’s hand.

Eri runs off, headed for the dance lessons happening in a room a little ways over. It leaves him and Tenko alone, who has also undergone an appearance change. His hair is white now, some sort of side effect of All for One. But those cracks and chapped skin are gone, only small slivers of scars remaining. He’s missing two fingers and refuses to tell anyone why. But aside from that, he is just as normal as the rest of them.

“Is he still out?” Tenko asks, his voice no longer raspy and ruined. “It’s bullshit that he’s housed in UA. I want to visit him without a pat down.”

“They found four knives on you,” Bakugou says flatly. “The pat-downs are needed.”

Tenko rolls his eyes. “How’d the checkup go?”

If Izuku knew that Bakugou’s become good friends with the leader of the League of Villains, he’d probably cry. But it is, unfortunately, true. Bakugou likes Tenko. They get along well enough, when the idiot isn’t pissing him off.

“Fine,” Bakugou says, knocking a hand against his heart. “Still beating.”

“Unfortunately.”

“Go fuck yourself.”

“And your hands?”

It’s something he doesn’t talk to anyone but Tenko about. While Bakugou knows his peers often feel painful side effects for their Quirks, it’s nothing compared to the loss of confidence he’s undergone. He feels a bit… weak, if he’s honest. Therapy with Yazmin helps, sure, but fixing his mental state doesn’t change his physical one. He can hardly write, hardly open doors or lift weights. He had to cancel his driving license test because he wasn’t able to grab the steering wheel.

It’s humiliating. It would be a lie to say he wasn’t absolutely angry about it. It’s just that these days, anger is weighed down by… by everything else. He still feels frustration, gets overwhelmed or overstimulated. But he knows how to calm himself down, how to work through episodes of emotional peaks. And it leaves him feeling… incomplete. He can’t hold onto things anymore, it seems. And nobody knows that feeling better than Tenko.

“It’s fine,” Bakugou says.

Tenko gives him a flat look. “Physical therapy?”

“Dropped it,” he confesses, ignoring the bitter expression on Tenko’s face. “I practice alone to maintain progress. I don’t—“ he looks away.

“You don’t want anyone to see how hard it is?” Tenko finishes for him, clicking his tongue. “Idiot.”

“Fuck you! You avoid All Might as much as I avoid PT, so I don’t want to fucking hear it.” Bakugou enjoys these moments of bickering. It’s better than feeling nothing at all.

Tenko gives him a nasty look. “That’s totally different.”

“Okay, Floater.”

“*Don’t* call me Floater. You know what a Floater is? It’s poop. I *fly*, it has nothing to do with poop,” Tenko snaps.

“Whatever you say, Floater.”

“That’s a disgusting fucking nickname!”

“Floater.”

Tenko scoffs, looks out at the odd collection of Quirked people in the room. He really has been crucial to the QEP. He’s a Quirk rights activist, showing up at protests and speaking out at every chance he’s given. The kid aces online school—unwilling to attend in person, then

spends the remainder of his time here or playing video games. Unlike Himiko, who is just as much of an activist, but is thriving at in-person school. Last Bakugou heard, she's got a huge friend group of girls that all come over and torment Touya or Aizawa-Sensei during sleepovers.

Tenko looks back at him. His red eyes are so similar to Izuku's that Bakugou finds himself holding eye contact just so he can kid himself into thinking Izuku isn't alone in some cold hospital room. He's here, living within the souls of every single person he saved. Living.

"When he wakes up," Tenko says, voice quiet, "You think he'll still want to be a Hero?"

Bakugou doesn't know. He really doesn't. Some part of him likes to believe that Izuku will go into Heroics, just as he always dreamed of. But another part of him knows that Izuku never really wanted to be a Hero at all. He just wanted to protect his mom, to protect the world. And while that seems Heroic in the eyes of the world, he doubts that Izuku ever thought the same. He's the kind of person to do things because it's what's needed, not because it fits under some morally correct label.

So he doesn't know. When Izuku wakes up—because it is a when and not an if—Bakugou is certain that nobody will ever be fully prepared for what he does next. Odds are, Izuku himself doesn't know. In all those notebooks, there was never a plan for after. For what came next. Bakugou likes to think it's because Izuku was hell bent on this goal and could only focus on it, but the truth is worse. Izuku didn't plan to survive it. Technically, he didn't, brain-dead in a hospital bed miles from here. But, at the same time, a bit of his soul remains intact.

Bakugou says, "I'm sure whatever he chooses to do will be just as stupid as what he did before."

Tenko snickers. "You'll keep me updated, won't you?"

"No shit."

And they move on. Izuku is a quick conversation, a hope held by people with green-stained skin. What a difference this symbol of justice made, huh? Left a mark on the world he's not even here to see. Changed everything—everything but himself. Same old Izuku, haunting the narrative like the ghost he is. Some days, Bakugou wonders if Izuku can see them all right now. If, even on his deathbed, he's protecting them all. Other days, he hopes that one of the thousands of religions is real. Bakugou never believed in a god before, but he finds himself praying, or maybe just wishing on stars, that Izuku will wake up. This slow death, a dragging of the feet, it's a weird limbo to live in.

Regardless, he spends the rest of his day with children. Talking through Quirks, teaching control, and explaining the biology behind it. A mom hugs him, in absolute tears, when he helps her little boy with his power. Bakugou can't raise his arms enough to hug her back, and he wonders if this is some sort of sick karma. He hadn't taken Izuku's hand years ago, and now he won't ever be able to. For all the torment he put that little kid through, for the life he ruined—this has got to be some sort of punishment.

The night ends. He stops by Izuku's bedside to recap the entire day to him, just as he always does. Then he goes to bed. And his nightmares are no longer in darkness. But in glowing, beautiful light. It dances through the air, painting Izuku in rainbow. He’s young, maybe four years old, and when he holds a hand out for Bakugou, he’s unable to take it.

He wakes up screaming. Izuku doesn’t wake up at all. And the world keeps moving.

Chapter End Notes

Almost at the end of the story!

Chapter 67: Window

Chapter Summary

Aizawa breaks the bad news to his class :(

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Aizawa typically hates losing kids, but today—today is a good day to lose them. He walks out of a courthouse with sadness in his heart, but twice as much joy. He knows firsthand that family is something you earn, and he knows that Touya absolutely earned it. The ex-villian has attended every visitation session, every therapy appointment, turned in every single rent payment on time—very rarely do you find young men who are willing to step up as not just a parent, but a Hero.

But here's one. So Aizawa is sad, sure, but it's one of those bittersweet moments. It's knowing that the right thing has happened, and that might not always feel 100% good, but it doesn't change that it's the right thing to do. He goes home to a house far from empty, but still a little less full. It's been a rocky six months, and he'd live the whole thing over again without second thought.

"Oh god," Hizashi says, smiling at Aizawa's dirty look. "You're getting that sad look you get when you want to look after another kid. I let you talk me into five once, but if you think I'm doing that much laundry or dishes again, you've lost your mind."

Aizawa can't help the small laugh that peels after him. He's seated on their living room couch, sipping a cup of coffee, one of his many cats curled up on his lap. Hizashi just got Eri down for bed, Hitoshi out doing who knows what. They try not to be overbearing with the kid and give him freedom. Typically, he's in his room binging shows or ignoring the world. On the rare days he wants to go outside, neither Aizawa nor Hizashi says a word against it.

"I just miss a full house," Aizawa says.

"You have two kids, a very attractive husband, and nearly thirty cats. Miss a full house *my ass."* Hizashi grabs the coffee pot from the kitchen, fills Aizawa's cup up. "What's going on with you?"

"I got a call from Recovery Girl," Aizawa says, eyes shut. "Midoriya's brain activity spiked then plateaued."

For most people, this would seem to be some sort of sign. Evidence that the kid will wake up, will get better. In reality, the human body often does one last little hurrah before giving out

completely. The kid is already nearly brain-dead. Flare-ups like that aren't positive, no matter how much it seems like they should be.

"Is it horrible that I keep thinking he's going to wake up?" Hizashi asks him, leaning against the staircase banister. "I like to think it's hope. But I'm beginning to think it's just denial."

"If it makes you feel better," Aizawa says, "I keep thinking I need to message the kid and figure out what vigilante shit he's up to so I can back him up. Then I remember he hasn't moved in six months. You'd think I'd know when to give up."

Hizashi frowns. "His mom?"

"You couldn't convince that woman to pull the plug if you had a gun to her head," Aizawa says, eyes shut. "I'm not saying she should. I'm just saying that I'm not sure there's a life for Inko that doesn't revolve around looking after her kid. I just wish… I don't know. I wish it were easier, I guess."

Easier. Wouldn't that be a fucking dream? If anything was easy these days, then something would be wrong. The entire world has changed, politics and culture, and everything that's ever defined the nation. It's not to say it's wrong, it's far from it. But it's hard, it's difficult. The world has never been so quickly divided then pushed back together again. It feels like drowning, but there was never any water. This whole time, he could breathe if he wanted, but some part of him is still unable to.

"I get that," Hizashi says, approaching so he can sit on the couch and curl up at Aizawa's side. "Easy would be nice."

"I can't believe I let Midnight talk me into teaching. I must be a masochist." Aizawa rests his head atop his husband's. "You think they'd let me retire a few decades early?"

Hizashi snorts. "If you leave, then all those kids leave with you. I don't think you have the heart to walk away."

"You're a sap."

"You love it."

Soft steps, and Aizawa opens his eyes to Eri on the stairs. She rubs her hands together, nervous. Her eyes are teary, sad, and Hizashi is up immediately.

"Nightmare?" She nods, lips wobbling. "How about you come sit next to us, and we'll watch a movie together?"

She's there instantly, her red blanket in tow. They all make a puddle of limbs on the couch, clicking on whatever kids' movie Eri asks for. Aizawa is certain he's seen this one a dozen times with her, but he watches it all the same, stroking long fingers through her hair until she's asleep. His dipshit husband is out a moment later, a few cats swarming him and sleeping beside or atop him.

It leaves Aizawa awake, sipping a coffee and watching the silly kids' movie. When the front door opens and then shuts, he turns to greet the second child he's taken in. But Hitoshi looks awful. His eyebags have gotten darker, hair mused, face pulled down with grief. Most students have begun to recover and grow after the attack. Grief never really goes away, but therapy helps you through it as best it can.

Not Hitoshi. He's taken it hard.

"Hey, kiddo," Aizawa says. He wiggles loose from the cuddle puddle on the couch, approaching the kid. "What's wrong—"

Hitoshi wraps his arms around him, hides his face in Aizawa's chest. And for how tired Aizawa is, how defeated, how sad, it all feels feeble compared to moments like these. He rubs Hitoshi's back, trying to will away the pain he knows the kid is feeling. The tremble of his shoulders, the held-down sobs.

For the first few months following Midoriya's comatose diagnosis, Hitoshi took it remarkably well. His grades slipped a bit, and his interest in school or hobbies went as well. But he seemed okay enough. He still went to class and hung out with Eri. He seemed to be coping well. Then all students were moved off campus again as the threat to their safety was eliminated, making it optional to stay in the dorms. Hitoshi came home with Aizawa, and while moving his belongings over, Aizawa came across a stash of pot. Turns out, the kid wasn't coping at all. He was high every single second of every single day. And when Aizawa took the stash away, that facade of calm crumpled.

He is unsure how long Hitoshi has used weed to get through hard days, but the fallout from it was massive. Screaming fights, slamming doors, sneaking out and going who knows where. But they pulled through as well as they could. At the end of the day, Aizawa knows that grief is well and truly awful. It's gutting, destructive, and he'd avoided it for a while, too. He knows what it feels like to lose your friend, so he was never too harsh with Hitoshi. He just hated looking at this mirror of himself, another person he failed and saw his own guilt in.

Hitoshi doesn't have any other friends. He doesn't allow himself to. When you spend so long alone, it's easier to stay that way. So he eats lunch alone, hiding out under staircases or in an empty classroom. He doesn't talk to anyone unless he has to. And Aizawa gets that feeling, too. Isolate. Hide away.

So he hugs him tight, holds down his own tears when his kid sobs and shakes. Aizawa wishes he had someone to comfort him through Oboro's death other than Hizashi. He does the best he can. Tries to say all the words he wishes someone had said to him. It's not enough, it never will be.

They all end up on the couch again. Hitoshi has awful insomnia, so Aizawa knows he isn't asleep when he rests his head on his shoulder and goes quiet. They still sit in silence anyway, watching a stupid movie. Aizawa never stops rubbing his back, giving hollow promises that it'll be okay. He's not sure it will be.

When the next morning rolls around, and he's forced to teach his class as though last night wasn't horrible, it's hard. There's a sea of open seats. Students he's failed. His class is

emptier than it is full. He hates it.

He sips coffee from his cat mug and watches his students chatter and talk before homework starts. It's beyond difficult, just another one of those things that can't seem to be easy. All the students are spread out, refusing to take the spots of their missing peers.

When his phone rings and the class goes quiet, he urges Tenya to watch over the students. Everyone is on a first-name basis these days, bonded by experiences they never should've had to endure. Regardless, the class rep agrees, and he steps into the hall with his phone.

Phone calls are never good. He hasn't gotten one in months. He answers despite this knowledge, walking a bit of a way down the hall so his eavesdropping students don't overhear.

"This is Aizawa," he says quietly.

Recovery Girl's voice is worn and tired. "I've never had a situation like this, so I'm not so sure how to break this news."

He shuts his eyes, nodding his head. "Just say it."

She does. "He's gone."

He knew it was coming. Really, he knew it was going to happen. He had mentally prepared himself and written down how he'd tell his students. It doesn't change the way his eyes sting, the ache in his chest.

"When?" he manages to ask.

"A few minutes ago. I stepped out to get lunch and came back, and the kid was gone," she sighs. "I called you first. I was going to do his mom, but…"

"I can tell her," Aizawa offers, clearing his throat. "I'll uh… I'll tell her."

Recovery girl sighs again. "I just can't believe it. Six months and he does this?"

Aizawa winces. "A bit harsh."

"Harsh!" she squawks. "The brat broke my window!"

He pauses. "He… what?"

"He's gone!" she snips. "Ripped out his IVs, smashed my damn window, and I've got no clue where to even begin looking—"

"Hold on," Aizawa cuts her off, "You mean *physically*, he's gone? He's not dead?"

"Oh," she laughs a bit, "I guess I should've worded that better. He was in and out of consciousness all day, but I figured it was just his brain activity spiking again before the final giveout. Nope! He must've jumped out the window and run—"

Aizawa hangs up. He's unaware that he's grinning, sprinting back to his class. He pauses outside, hands shaking. When he opens the door, the tension in the air is thick.

Bakugou's already standing, waiting for the bad news. Hitoshi doesn't look at him.

"We'll be having our Heroics class early today. Today's focus will be a field study," Aizawa says, grabbing his support scarf. Students murmur, stand, and get ready for an assignment. "A few moments ago, Midoriya woke up from a six-month coma and escaped the school. Whoever finds him first gets fifteen points of extra credit."

If they weren't already rushing the doors, then they are now.

Muscle deterioration means Midoriya is weak. He's got no support gear, no ability to get anywhere, and he's likely still in a hospital gown. The kid couldn't have gotten farther than a few blocks, if that. Even then, he'd have to crawl or push through unbearable amounts of pain.

On second thought, he might be miles away. That idiot has a pain tolerance beyond normal limits.

This time, when he looks at his empty classroom and sips from his cat mug, he can't help the absolute joy within him.

Chapter End Notes

six seven

Chapter 68: Found

Chapter Summary

Midoriya is found

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya sits alone on that log over Kacchan and his creek. He's better hidden this time, staring down at the passing water below. It's cold out, and his body feels weak from how long he's been lying in bed. Still, he sits on that fallen tree trunk, watching water slowly creep by.

What a way to leave an impression. Someone will come after him soon, he's sure. Fresh out of a six-month coma and he's here.

He's here.

It's quiet out. Birds chirp softly, water flows idly by. He feels hollowed out, empty. He had planned to run further, to get out of this town and lay low. To avoid any and all repercussions for his actions. He remembers it all. He felt catatonic, lying in that bed for months, listening as friends lost their hope, as Mama cried every day. Updates from Kacchan, silence from Hitoshi, the scent of pollen from fresh flowers as though they were already preparing to leave them atop his gravestone. He doesn't blame them. If he's honest, he thought he'd die too.

He was supposed to. He knows it with every part of him. He was supposed to die. But someone, some higher force, maybe the old users of One for All, decided against it. They dragged his life out, left him breathing, left him seeing. He's never wished to be blind before, but it's here now, a terrible feeling to stomach. Sometimes, death is a better alternative than prolonging the inevitable. Everyone dies, and he knows, more than anything, that he's been evading it for far too long.

He supposes that he just feels… off kilter. He's lopsided, too heavy and too light. He can't make up his mind. He's unsure if he enjoys looking at the rushing water below or if he just likes to think about how quickly he could sink in it. Maybe that's a bit selfish, a bit pitiful, but he feels it nonetheless.

The handprints on his arms are visible in his hospital gown. Despite how dark his skin is, the wounds seem to blister brighter than ever. How is it that through broken limbs and scars, they never seem to leave? He's covered in still-wet mud and grass, having dragged his small body across the forest floor once his legs gave out. He trembles in all limbs, feels lightheaded and sick, droplets of blood poking from his veins where he tore his IV.

It's bright outside. He wishes he had never got to see it.

“Hey.”

He doesn’t respond. There are soft footfalls against wet grass. Then a lanky body plops next to him on the log. The two of them watch the water pass below.

“Kacchan said you’d be here,” Hitoshi says quietly. “I couldn’t believe it. We heard you woke up and disappeared. I thought he’d come over to you, but he insisted I go instead.”

Midoriya nods softly. “He’s smart like that.”

“He is.”

“So you came.”

“So I did.” Hitoshi sets his palms flat on the tree trunk, sits back. “Tell me what’s going on in your head.”

Midoriya shrugs. “You aren’t going to usher me back to bed or hug me until I can’t breathe?”

“I could,” Hitoshi offers, bumping their shoulders. “Or I could be the listening ear I know you need.”

Cold, gentle water. “Can I tell you something selfish?”

“Anything.”

Midoriya kicks his feet slowly. “I wish I never did any of this.”

Hiroshi listens quietly, gazing at the river below.

“I woke up today, and I remembered all these amazing things,” Midoriya tells him. “About Quirk expansion projects. About Himiko and Tenko. About Touya. About you. I mean, these things I’ve always dreamed of. A more accepting world, a program for those who need it.” Midoriya shakes his head. “And I kept thinking, how do I fit into all this?”

His friend doesn’t judge him. He waits, silent.

“And it’s so… so messed up,” he says, eyes full of tears. “Because when I was in that coma. There were these blissful moments where I’d finally sleep. I had this dream. And it was the best dream I’d ever had. I was floating around in space, and I was glowing with all these colours, and my pockets were stuffed to the brim with shooting stars.” Midoriya shuts his eyes tight. “And then I woke up. And realised I will never fly again.”

He looks at Hitoshi.

“I just wish… I just wish I didn’t wake up. Or that if I did, it was in a world where I was content to be this again. Quirkless again. Me, again. I just wish I could go back to the night before I left. Me and you had laughed so hard during lunch that day, and Todoroki sat with us, so we poked fun at him the whole time. And maybe it went bad with the Overhaul mission, but that same night, I built a pillow fort with Kacchan. And it’s the stupidest thing to

think—but I'm not sure I've ever been happier than I was that night." Midoriya wipes his face, "Or even before then, when we'd talk about our crushes, and I'd sneak out to stop low-level crime. Or when my worries were about studying or doing the dishes. I just—I just wish I could feel like me again without these awful days in between where I'm someone else."

Hitoshi nods a bit, clearing his throat. "I can't say I know how you feel, because I really don't. I haven't done half of what you have. But, sometimes, when I finally manage to get sleep, I never have dreams. And it's this peaceful moment in time where there isn't anything at all. Just darkness. And waking up from that—going back to the mundane. School or work, the god awful world we live in, facing all these horrible things every day. I get that. I get that feeling."

Midoriya blows out a breath of crisp morning air. "I never imagined I'd live through this. I guess I never really planned this far ahead. And now I'm here, and all I can think about is how much I wish I was back to those planning days. Movie nights with Mama, stealing wallets to get by. Or maybe I just feel like I worked so damn hard to get half as far as everyone else, I'm just tired of it." He looks at Hitoshi. "I had… I had *everything.* I had a Quirk, I had a purpose. I had a goal and a dream, and it was supposed to end when I achieved it."

Clouds pass by, water streams below,

"You'd think after a lifetime of advocating for people like me, I'd learn to believe what I preach. All people are equal, everyone deserves equal chances, no matter your Quirk or race—you are just as much as those around you." Midoriya shakes his head. "I guess I thought that when the world finally believed it, that maybe, just maybe, I would too. And when I didn't, I was ready to be done."

You will always be Quirkless.

"And here you are."

"Here I am."

Hitoshi runs a hand through his hair. "That sucks for you, man."

Midoriya lets out a watery laugh, elbowing Hitoshi. "You're so bad at comforting me."

"I can't comfort you," he says honestly, "You've got to comfort yourself. I can listen, and I can offer advice. But it's you that's got to live this."

"Okay," Midoriya says, "Then offer me some advice."

"Go to school," he says simply. "And feel like you're walking through syrup every day, or like someone has thrown an extra fifty pounds into your backpack. Everything is gonna be heavy, and maybe therapy or meds can alleviate that. But if I'm being honest, the only thing that's going to make your life any better is if you learn how to live it."

He says, voice a whisper, "I'm not even sure I want to be here anymore."

“In UA?”

“In the world,” Midoriya says. “And I haven’t wanted to be here for a very long time—but back then, there were all these things holding me here. And I feel like… like maybe now’s a good time. You know?”

“I’m not going to tell you you’re wrong,” Hitoshi says sadly. “But I won’t tell you you're right either. I know first-hand that there’s no swaying you either way. But I’ll tell you, it would really suck to eat lunch alone. Nobody would get my jokes like you do, and I’d definitely never ask Denki out.”

Midoriya chuckles. “You’re trying to make me feel guilty.”

“Yeah,” Hitoshi admits, staring at the trees. “But I’m also trying to tell you—you’ll find a spark. Or maybe you won’t. Maybe you’ll live the rest of your life miserable if you stick around. Maybe you’ll never feel like you again, and you’ll spend years thinking about what could’ve been.”

“Or?” Midoriya asks.

“Or… you’ll feel good again,” he says, moving to fold his hands in his lap. “That weight will lift, and you’ll find these things about life that you love. You’ll make a new goal, hundreds of new goals. And you’ll spend years trying to achieve them. And every time you do, you’ll wake up the next morning feeling just a little bit better than the night before.” Hitoshi bumps their shoulders. “I don’t know. I’m still waiting for those better days. But if I’m honest, I think I’ve already had my lows, so even if right now I’m not at my high. That’s okay. I can be medium for a while, because those good days will come. I’ve had plenty of good moments, and one day, it’ll last.”

“All Might told me,” Midoriya says, “That being a Hero means that you will lose people. That what you think is rock bottom is only a scratch on the surface. So what if it gets worse?”

“All Might was right,” Hitoshi tells him. “For his world, he was right. But this is a new one. So… what if it gets better?”

“You’re ruining my suicide plot line, Hitoshi.”

“Maybe whoever’s writing our story is getting better, too.”

“Ugh,” Midoriya palms his eyes, “Stop being poetic, it makes me sick.”

“Give it a year,” Hitoshi suggests. “A *good* year. Do all this shit you’ve always wanted. Start therapy. Go on dates. Give it a good year. And in 12 months, let’s meet back up, and I’ll sit here and talk you into 12 more again.”

Midoriya looks at him, really looks at him. And then he nods, stands, using Hitoshi’s arm to hold his weight. “A good year.”

“Just one.” Hitoshi stands, and they head back to the grass of the forest,

They walk quietly along a footpath back to the break in a fence.

“And this,” Hitoshi says, suddenly stopping, gesturing around them. “For me. This is a *good* moment.” Midoriya’s lips warble when his friend pulls him into a hug. “I missed you so much.”

“The amount of emotion you’re showing today is making me sick,” Midoriya tells him, but he’s hugging him back, teary-eyed and snot-nosed. “You never came to visit me.”

“I couldn’t do it,” Hitoshi confesses. “I came that first day and couldn’t shake the dread from seeing you like that—being told there was little hope. I couldn’t do it. I knew if I spent another day looking at your corpse that I would become one myself.”

“So you distanced yourself.”

“I’m pretty good at it,” Hitoshi says, offering a soft smile.

“You’re pretty good at being an idiot—“ Midoriya’s words die with his breath when his first friend tugs him into another hug.

This one is tighter, desperate. He feels every inch of that dread, of the terror, of the withering of Hitoshi’s soul and mind. He doesn’t have much strength, but he uses what little he has left to wrap his arms around his friend. When Hitoshi cries, silent, his shoulders shaking, Midoriya finds another reason to hang on as long as he can. Hitoshi never uses many words, unable to hold a conversation without accidentally using his Quirk. But this is one of the moments that don’t need words, that don’t need sound.

Just the two of them. The first people to ever give the other an honest shot at friendship, to defy all the odds stacked against freaks like them. Midoriya realises, right at this moment, covered in mud and holding onto the one person who has never seen him as anything other than what he is—that he doesn’t mind being a freak so long as he’s got this weirdo at his side. Maybe fitting into the mould that society created was more important to him than overthrowing it, and this whole time, he’d been convincing himself of the opposite. But, if he’s honest, he’s always wanted the life he’s trying to escape. He’s always wanted to be a Hero, to have so many friends that he couldn’t count them all on his hands, to look in the mirror and not only like what he sees—but feel as though maybe it suits him just right.

Maybe he can do this.

So he hugs his friend, and when they eventually make it to the street again, Mama and Eraser Head are already waiting for him. Mama is a puddle of tears, burying her face into his shoulder and sobbing. She rocks them back and forth, and he feels a little bit like a kid again. When he looks at his Sensei over her head, and meets his genuine smile and nod, he remembers that he *is* a kid. Sixteen, and he’s beaten the odds twice now.

Why not do it a third time?

Finally, he sees Kacchan. He’s not sure what kind of reunion they should have. A kiss seems a bit much, a hug too foreign for them. In the end, Kacchan gives him the same look he

always does, as though he can see something within Midoriya's soul that he himself is unable to.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the week of silence! It was finals week, and being a STEM major is actual torture. I hope you all enjoyed! One more chapter after this!

Chapter 69: Spark

Chapter Summary

Christmas timeeee

Chapter Notes

I love writing christmas time bro

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He's gotten the hang of this whole wheelchair thing. Denki taught him how to do wheelie's, Ochaco wrapped the whole thing in brightly colored duct tape, and everyone signed the railing and wheels and backing. A lot of work went into ensuring he could have decent enough mobility. Melissa and Hatsume designed padding and efficiency, Kacchan insisting on a secret compartment where Midoriya may or may not have a gun stashed. Who's to say?

He woke up two months ago, and if you thought he'd miss being the best gift giver for Christmas two years in a row, then you're insane. He's giving it a damn good year, and it started the moment he made it back to UA after his final attempt to run away.

He's hung up his vigilante suit, he's started therapy, both psychologically and physically. He's on meds for anxiety, and for the first time in years, his brain has slowed. It doesn't stop running, he's uncertain it ever will, but the feeling of constantly being under attack, of being stalked or chased, has dimmed substantially. He doesn't plan anymore. He doesn't enter a room and pinpoint all potential exits. When he lies down at night, he sleeps better than he ever has. He likes to think that maybe he's getting better.

He's projected to be mostly healed in fourteen months time. In a few months from today, he'll be on crutches. After that, a cane. Then, hopefully, maybe, back to his regular self. He'll be able to use stairs again, to stand longer than a few minutes at a time, to participate in Heroics class, and…

And go on that date he was promised.

Maybe the anxiety went away, but the shame didn't. Truthfully, he's embarrassed. And despite Kacchan's clear interest, he hasn't spoken more than a few words to Midoriya since he woke up. He's waiting for Midoriya to talk to him first, to make the first move. And until he's able to stand, let alone cook, Midoriya won't burden him with the mental turmoil that

comes from his lack of ability to properly function. He hates being confined to a chair, unable to do more than watch from the sidelines. He endures it all the same.

Being wheelchair bound doesn't mean he's going to lose the best gift-giving contest this year that he made up in his head. He can't do much else—but this, this he can do.

He starts with Hitoshi.

"Okay, open!" Midoriya says.

It took ages to get up Aizawa-Sensei's stairs, but when he finally made it to Hitoshi's room, he gave it the makeover it was in desperate need of. Pinpointing Eraser Head merch was so god damn difficult that Midoriya nearly gave up. But there's an active underground community that managed to land a few signatures on custom-made merch, rumors of the mysterious posters of autographs floating around. Midoriya found them, stole—uh—bought them from very willing subjects, and hung them in his friend's room. Are they actually worth anything? Not at all. But the way Hitoshi's face lights up when he opens his eyes and takes in the room is worth it all.

"You didn't." Hitoshi steps to the nearest one, carefully running a finger along the ancient signature. "You son of bitch, how the hell did you do this?"

Midoriya shrugs, unwilling to tell him that Denki might've been willing to do some dirty work and sneak into some houses to steal the posters for Midoriya. It really wasn't hard to convince him; all he had to do was say Hitoshi's name, and the idiot was ready to go. In return, Midoriya explained what the difference between veganism and lactose intolerance was, to which Denki smacked his forehead, then proceeded to make gluten-free brownies as if that was even slightly close to what Midoriya said.

Hitoshi stares at the large poster of Eraser Head. "I'm so excited to out-gift you, it's not even funny."

"Oh, I'd love to see you try," Midoriya says, chin popped onto his fist against the railing of his chair. "A mystery gift that I won't receive until 8 sounds absolutely awful."

Hitoshi snickers, exiting the room and pushing Midoriya's chair. "You're in for a treat."

"Are you just trying to distract yourself from Aizawa-Sensei's gift because you're nervous about it?" Midoriya asks.

"I'm shitting bricks," Hitoshi admits, glaring when Midoriya belts out a laugh. "He'll be home any moment with Yamada, and then I'm cooked."

Midoriya grips the stair railing, gritting his teeth as he forces his legs to stand. His joints pop and ache while Hitoshi carries his chair down, then comes back up. He wraps a long arm around Midoriya's waist, helps him down the stairs and back into his useless chair. They don't mention defeat, thick in the air.

Instead, they focus on the front door opening, revealing three different people. Eri comes whizzing inside, immediately climbing up the footrest and plopping herself down on Midoriya's lap. She's in a little Santa outfit, waving around a caramel apple she got from a Christmas parade in downtown Tokyo. Hitoshi rejected the offer to go, too nervous to be around Aizawa or Mic, and also hating people and noise and happiness. Aizawa-Sensei appears to be in the same boat, worn with exhaustion that follows social interaction.

"Merry Christmas!" Midoriya says, earning narrowed eyes from his Sensei and a cheer from Eri. "Come on, Sensei, smile!"

"I will expel you."

"Boo."

"What is that?" Eri slides off his lap, peers out the window to the backyard. "A tree growed!"

"Grew," Aizawa-Sensei corrects, peering out the glass. "Why is there a tree in my backyard, problem children?"

"Apple tree," Hitoshi pipes up, trying and failing not to smile at Eri's excited gasp. "A gift straight from Santa."

"SANTA!" Eri screams, running for the back door.

Mic chases after her, explaining that apples will grow in a few months. It doesn't stop her from immediately climbing the thick base of the tree, scrambling up branches and ignoring Mic when he tries to get her back down again.

It leaves the three of them. It takes Eraser not even a second to narrow his gaze on Hitoshi, who seems completely composed and neutral. Only the wobbling of his feet, back and forth, gives away his nerves. His friend looks at him, Midoriya looks right back, then he's urging Aizawa-Sensei to sit on the couch. When Present Mic comes back inside, laughing at Eri, who is still sitting in the tree, Midoriya urges him to sit as well.

He's tempted to leave, give the three of them privacy, but Hitoshi all but begged him to stay so he wouldn't lose his nerve.

"Oh no," Mic says, taking in the stoic expressions around him. "What happened?"

"Did you get someone pregnant?" Aizawa immediately asks, lips twitching at Hitoshi's scandalized face.

"Did someone sell you drugs?" Mic asks right after, giving away how funny he thinks this joke is by laughing. "What did we tell you about cocaine? Only at parties."

"You guys aren't even a little funny," Hitoshi informs them blandly, but his jaw ticks in a way that hints at him holding down a laugh. "I have a gift for you."

Midoriya hands him the folder from the kitchen table. Hitoshi's shaking when he hands it over to the two Pros, which only makes them all the more nervous. Jesus, *he's* getting nervous, and he's not involved in this! Of course, he did a lot of the work to ensure this gift worked out, but it was Hitoshi who came up with the idea and is ultimately affected by it.

His friend had a big speech planned for this, but it seems he's unable to say it. He instead digs his hands into his pockets and tells the two of them to open it. Midoriya backs up, slowly leaving the room to give them all privacy. He heads outside to Eri, perching his chair under the apple tree. What a miracle that Santa somehow planted an entire tree in the backyard. What a great, and top-tier gift. Definitely can't be beaten.

Despite promising privacy, Midoriya peers through the backyard window. Eri jumps out of the tree, lands on him, also looking through the window. They're nosy, cautiously looking through the glass. Inside, Hitoshi looks anywhere but at Aizawa and Mic on the couch as they open the folder. They pull out a single piece of paper, reading the document. It took *ages* to work through the legal system. Midoriya definitely didn't threaten the county's office with blackmail to get them to complain to a minor changing their legal name without a guardian's consent. Weren't the forged signatures of Hitoshi's adoptive parents enough?

"They're crying!" Eri whispers, holding and shaking Midoriya's shoulder without fear. "Are those the happy tears?"

Midoriya smiles. "Yes, they are."

Hitoshi felt no connection to his family name. His parents gave him up when he was a baby, so what was the point in keeping his last name as Shinso? When he came to Midoriya, asking him to help him change his last name to a hyphenated Aizawa-Yamada, Midoriya was quickly on board. It took a few weeks to get the legal work done, but it's official. Hitoshi Shinso is no longer—replaced with Hitoshi Aizawa-Yamada.

"They're hugging now," Eri commentates, eating her caramel apple. "I'm gonna hug them too!"

"Go, go, go!" Midoriya urges her, making her giggle and sprint away.

When she runs inside and flings herself into the pile of crying people, Midoriya shuts the back door. He wheels around the house so he won't disturb them, quickly heading down the street. He's certain there's no need for him to steel his friends' nerves anymore. As he told Hitoshi a thousand times over—there was no possible way he'd get rejected from this family. It was his to keep.

He doesn't mind using his chair to get around. Melissa designed him his own little remote for it, the button that makes it move modified by Hitoshi within moments of receiving the chair. This thing gets up to eighty miles an hour if Midoriya floors it, which he only does when nobody is around to catch him. But today, he takes it slow and easy. It's Christmas, the snow piled high on the road, flashing lights and smiling families lining the street.

He spent the morning with Mama, opening gifts and watching movies together just as they always do. They'll get back together tonight to go look at lights, but he has a lot of other

plans to attend to in the meantime. Plus, he wanted to give her and All Might time together, since he spent a good few hours pretending he didn't know his mentor was hiding in Mama's closet. With Dad dead, she moved back into their little apartment, and clearly hadn't expected Midoriya to show up unannounced to cook breakfast with her. He likes to think he scared All Might into treating Mama like a queen, and he'll be sure to react with the utmost shock when the two of them decide it's the right time to tell him they've been together for months now.

Kacchan can never keep his mouth shut, really it's his fault that Midoriya knows. Though, in his defense, Mama and All Might are like teenagers trying to be discreet. He feels stupid pretending he hasn't caught on.

Regardless, he wheels down the road, humming as he stops by his next destination. He's in and out in thirty minutes, grabbing another gift, then he's wheeling down another road. When he makes it to an apartment complex, he texts Touya that he's arrived. The front door to the apartment opens as quietly as possible, then a hand reaches out and carefully takes the gift from Midoriya. The door shuts again, then opens a few minutes later once the gift is stashed away.

Touya holds it open, giving Midoriya a wide berth. If you'd asked Midoriya who he thought would be the most petrified of him following the death of AFO, never in a million years would he have guessed Touya Todoroki. But the ex-villian is absolutely petrified of Midoriya. He refuses to be alone in a room with him and hides the knives every single time Midoriya comes over. Himiko, Tenko, and Shoto find the whole thing hilarious. Midoriya finds it a little funny, too, if he's honest. Touya does not.

"The little murderer!" Hawks cheers, snickering at Touya's discomfort. "Wow, my first Christmas is so full of personalities."

"You're so emo, Hawks," Himiko giggles, giving Midoriya her token finger wave. "Besides, Midoriya only killed one guy."

"Four," he corrects.

"What?"

"Who's ready for presents!" Midoriya claps his hands, and the volume of his voice must've reached Tenko's room, because his door squeaks open a moment later.

Tenko is happy that Midoriya is awake, a fact that Midoriya only knows because Kacchan confirmed it. His brother hasn't said a word to him in two months, and Himiko informed him that he's still very upset that Dad's death was kept from him. Midoriya hasn't apologized for sabotaging it, and he won't. He kept his brother safe, and if that means that Tenko won't speak to him again, then so be it. He can be angry all he wants. At least he's angry and alive instead of dead.

Tenko still doesn't say a word to him, eyes latching onto Hawks. "Why are you still here?"

Hawks makes a dramatic frown. "So mean."

“He asked me the same thing every day for five months,” Shoto pipes up from the kitchen, approaching with cups of hot cocoa. He passes them out. “I literally live here.”

“You’re a legal obligation,” Tenko informs Shoto, then points at Hawks. “He’s a fling.”

“Tenko,” Touys snips, smacking him against the back of his head. “Shut the fuck up. It’s Christmas. Keigo’s never celebrated before.”

“Emo.”

“That’s what I said!” Himiko laughs.

Midoriya doesn’t say much, soaking in the bizarre dynamic formed in this house. Himiko has added him to the *evil dads* group chat, which consists of her, Shoto, and Tenko. In which they share real-time updates of every single interaction between Touya and Hawks. According to them, it’s some weird relationship where neither of them can really act on their feelings due to trauma or whatever “emo” reason given. It doesn’t change that Hawks all but lives here.

Such a weird dynamic. Almost as weird as seeing Shoto. Midoriya still isn’t used to the absolute change in appearance he’s undergone. Kacchan must’ve gotten him in contact with the same model artist he got Touya in with, because Shoto has fully changed his appearance. His hair is now a permanent, soft brown color, and that awful scar around his eye has been wiped away. Aside from his multicolored eyes, he looks perfectly normal. It suits him, his appearance less known by the media, giving him privacy he’s never had before and distance from his parents. No longer two halves of unstable people, but his own person.

Midoriya sips his hot cocoa, smiling to himself at the bickering and laughter in the room.

Himiko finally says, “Dibs on going first!”

“Dibs on second,” Tenko says.

Midoriya swallows the liquid. “No, you have to go last.”

Tenko levels him with a glare so visceral that it makes him sick to the stomach. “What are you gonna do, shoot me?”

“Yikes,” Shoto says, “Do you get it? It’s because you shot him so you could murder your dad without him.”

“Yep, thanks, Shoto.” Midoriya pinches his brow, ignoring Himiko’s snicker. “Just go last, Tenko.”

“No fucking way—“

“Okay, I’m opening now!” Himiko interrupts.

She grabs Midoriya’s present immediately. They had all opened stockings and smaller gifts this morning, and now that he’s here, they open bigger gifts and more personal presents. Touya literally filled the entire apartment with presents; apparently, it’s his favorite holiday

and he's been unable to celebrate for a while. As much as he tries to hide it, he's the most excited out of anyone, finally having a family to open gifts with.

Himiko rips pink paper off her present, sharp nails tearing open the box. She screams when she tears open the cardboard and reveals the new PC inside. He promised her ages ago that he'd get her a nice one, and he kept that promise. He spent days building it with Hitoshi and researching good headsets and keyboards for it. Touya handled the desk, gaming chair, and monitors. She's throwing herself onto his chair and hugging him the second she's got the box open. Then she's patronizing Tenko and insisting she'll kick his ass at any of the games they play together.

It moves on from there, circling around the room. Shoto unboxes a year-long fully paid membership to an all-you-can-eat soba buffet. Hawks gets a photo album filled to the brim with baby pictures of Touya, to which he sends with his feathers out the window before it can be burnt to a crisp. Then Touya, who unboxes a state-of-the-art, super-powerful fire extinguisher. Shoto isn't the type to laugh or smile, but he wheezes so harshly that his face turns red.

When it's Tenko's turn, finally, he refuses to open Midoriya's gift. He opens an alternate one, and it circles like that for a while. Round and round, until every gift is gone, and Midoriya has boxes full of sweet gifts from them all. Himiko made him a bracelet that he will wear for the rest of his life. Shoto got him an All-Might plushie to match his own. Touya got him a *very* fancy butterfly knife that is definitely illegal to own, and Hawks got him an All Might signed shirt from their days working together.

Tenko got him nothing.

When it finally wraps up and Tenko has only his gift left to open, he still refuses. Himiko slips into her room to set up all her new stuff, Shoto taking the hint for once and disappearing a moment later. Hawks goes after the photo album, and Touya heads to his room.

"You're going to want to open it," Midoriya says, wheeling towards the bathroom where it's been hidden. "Trust me."

"I don't," Tenko says. He stands, barely gives Midoriya a passing glance before heading to his room. "I don't trust you."

Midoriya's hand holds the doorknob tightly. "Come on, Tenko."

"No, you know what? Fuck you." His brother's lip curls. "How was that fair? He didn't even *touch* you. You got away, you and your fucking mom. How dare you take that vengeance away from me?"

"I wasn't—"

"I've heard every fucking excuse from you," Tenko snips. "You know what I haven't heard? An apology."

Midoriya purses his lips together, drops his hand to his lap. "Sorry."

“You didn’t even mean that!”

“Of course I didn’t!” Midoriya shouts. “I’m not sorry, so I won’t give you a real apology. I don’t regret it, not for a single second. So if you want to be mad at me, then go ahead. At least you’re alive. And I won’t apologize for ensuring that.”

“You are a selfish, lying asshole,” Tenko spits at him. “You threw away my chance at closure for your own peace of mind.”

“You’re right,” he says simply. “And I don’t regret it for a single second. I’d do it again.”

“It wasn’t your decision to make!” he says, throwing his hands out. “I have lost everything—I deserved to—to take him out. That was my debt to collect. Not yours.”

“I know.”

“My family, my friends,” Tenko shakes his head. “My entire life was built by him. How is it fair that you get to kill him?”

Midoriya sighs. “I don’t know what you want me to say, Tenko. Would it really have changed anything if you’d gotten the final blow? What peace could come from taking his life?”

“The assurance,” Tenko says. “Knowing that he’s really dead, that he’s not coming back to take all this away again.” Tenko shoves open his bedroom door. “You took that from me. I won’t ever forgive you for that.”

His brother bends down, grabs a box and tosses it to the floor. It slides against the hardwood, bounces off the footrest of the wheelchair.

“Merry Christmas.” Tenko shuts the door.

Midoriya stares at the wood grain for a moment before bending over and grabbing the box off the ground. It’s heavy, and when he settles its weight onto his lap, he knows what it is before he opens it. Still, he lifts the lid, peers inside. Two red sneakers, new, fresh, Quirkless brand. He hasn’t had new shoes in… in a long time. His current pair is ragged, stained and breaking. But Tenko found the model and make, bought them despite how pricey they are, just so he’d have new shoes to walk in when he finally got out of this chair.

Midoriya shuts the box, rests his forehead on it. Dammit.

“Your Quirk,” Midoriya says, shoving his brother's door open without so much as a knock. “You want assurance he’s dead? There it is. You can fly again.”

Tenko narrows his eyes from his spot on his bed, a gaming device in his hands. “Get out.”

“And my Mama and I didn’t get away,” Midoriya says, brows furrowed. “He didn’t kill us because my mom had access to the bloodline of a past user of OFA. I’m only alive because he wanted to kill my… my friend.”

“Great, shut the door on your way out.”

“And you know what?” Midoriya says, brows furrowed. “You aren’t the only one with a fucking sob story. You were never starved, never beaten, never weak. So fuck you, Tenko. I deserved my peace just as much as you did, at least you get a Quirk out of it.”

He slams the bedroom door, wheeling away to the front door. Loud, angry stomps, then Tenko rips his door open again and glares.

“My entire family died by my own hands!” Tenko screams. “*He* did that to me. Don’t tell me you deserved that death because you’ve never even fucking seen it before.”

“Oh my god, is this a contest for you?” Midoriya asks. “Do I have to keep trying to prove my hardships to you so I’m worthy of taking his life? Is it not enough that I just wanted to keep you out of harm's way?”

“Such a god damn Hero, huh? Always saving people who don’t fucking need it. You think I didn’t have what it takes to kill him—“

“No. I don’t.”

Tenko goes quiet, his rage loud enough to take the place of his words.

“I don’t think you had what it took to kill him. And you can be as mad as you want, but I think that if it came down to it, you couldn’t have done it. You wouldn’t have killed him even if that opportunity was right in front of you, which I’m sure it had been plenty of times. Some part of you wanted a family, wanted a dad. So no, Tenko, I don’t think you had what it took.” Midoriya holds his gaze, shakes his head. “He needed to die, and it needed to be me who did it. I will not apologize for taking the chance that you never would. You can be angry, but we both know it’s not me you're angry at.”

Tenko looks away, flexes his jaw. “You have no idea what it’s been like for me.”

“I know,” Midoriya says. “I can’t imagine what you’ve endured. I wish I could’ve been there to prevent it, but I wasn’t. And when I was, I did what I could to end it.”

His brother says nothing for a long while. When he does talk, it’s not about Dad. “What’s the gift?”

Midoriya holds his shoe box, nodding to the bathroom door. “I had Touya sneak it in.”

Tenko rubs his nose, clearing his throat of what seems to be tears. It’s the closest the two of them will get to an apology and forgiveness. Even then, it’s not much, just a small hand extended.

His brother twists the knob, opens the door.

And a dog waddles out of the bathroom. It’s a corgi, a bit of an older girl. Midoriya found her at the shelter, and when learning her name, thought it must be some bizarre twist of fate. She’s missing an eye, having gone through a bad past, but she’s still a good dog.

Tenko stares at it, face blank.

“Her name is Hana,” Midoriya says, smiling when the corgi’s tail wags. “That was your sister's name, right?”

Tenko’s face cracks, scrunches, and he lets out those horrible sobs he was keeping in. He wraps his arms around himself, crying and crying. The dog jumps on his leg, tries to get his attention, and Tenko jolts away so quickly that the poor thing falls down. Its tail is still wagging, and it tries again, standing straight up and licking at Tenko’s arm.

Still, his brother won’t touch it.

“You won’t hurt her,” Midoriya assures him, slowly wheeling over. “You can pet her, Tenko.”

“I can’t—“ his brother sobs. “I don’t want her to—“ he can’t get the words out, but the meaning is clear as day. He doesn’t want to harm the dog by mistake; he doesn’t want to kill her.

“Well, if you won’t pet her, then I guess I've got to give her back to the shelter,” Midoriya says, moving forward with a grin.

His brother immediately squats down to the dog's level and uses his elbows to block her. “No, no, don't take her away.”

“I don’t know, it doesn't seem like you really like her,” Midoriya teases.

“I do, I swear,” Tenko says, crying when the corgi jumps on him again and licks his face. “I’ve got to get her boots for the winter and—and maybe a sweater so I can take her on walks.”

He snickers, watching the idiot pet the dog with his elbows or pinkies. He’s not sure how long it’ll take before his brother can pet the dog with his full hand. Trauma manifests in the weirdest ways, and despite the near year of being relieved of his destructive Quiek, Tenko seems to live with the same fear as when he had it.

Midoriya moves away quietly. He’s got to be back at UA by 8 for Hitoshi’s gift. And if his brother is anything like himself, then he knows that the best move now is to give him space. Let him recover, let him think, let him feel whatever the hell he needs to feel to work through this. So he leaves him alone with his dog, and something is lighter on Tenko’s face than it’s ever been before.

It’s a bit of a gift to himself, too. He’d wanted to give his brother a dog for a while, ever since learning how much he missed his old puppy who passed away. Since he missed Tenko’s birthday, now seemed like a good a time as any. And maybe he doesn’t mind having a new pair of shoes, let alone coming to equal grounds with his brother. Honestly, Midoriya’s always wanted a sibling. A built-in friend sounded amazing to him when he was a kid, and he’d do anything to mend the shattered bond between him and Tenko.

He wheels away, sighing at the bumpy sidewalk cracks he gets stuck in or the jammed streets he’s unable to navigate. He really does hate being in a wheelchair. He feels weak, useless,

always in the way. It's not as though he believes other people bound to a chair are that way, but he's always been his best critic. He sees how much he's lost, and it drives him insane.

When he finally makes it to UA, it's only a half hour until eight o'clock. It's dark out now, and he'll need to head back home to Mama in a few hours to make it to the Christmas lights. The front doors to the dorms open as students file out.

"Izuku!" Ochaco hustles over, smiling kindly at him. "I'm so glad you came! Katsuki was right, we only needed Hitoshi to convince you."

Midoriya raises a brow. "What?"

She giggles, hands him a small green box. "Merry Christmas! My family doesn't have a lot of money, so the gift is homemade. I hope you like it."

He takes it with a thank you, carefully listing the lid and peering inside. She's crocheted him an All Might beanie, the long ears flopping down. It's probably one of the best gifts he's ever gotten. He immediately plops it onto his head.

"I love it."

Ochaco laughs again. "I'm glad. There are more gifts from the others, but I hope mine's the best."

Slowly, the remaining students of 1-A have him open their gifts. They all opened his gifts this morning, and it's so bizarre to see how well these people know him. New notebooks, compression sleeves, a couple of Hero comics and novellas. Everything is thoughtful, beyond sweet, and he's unsure how to navigate that warm feeling inside him.

It's been a good two months. Two out of twelve. Some days are still harder than others, but it's hard in a way unlike before. He searches for things to hang onto, works through problems head-on rather than avoiding them. Some days he has zero recollection of ever living through; others are in perfect clarity. Sometimes he'll rewatch the rare footage of his battle with AFO. Nothing that reveals his identity, as it's taken by a shaky civilian phone camera. But watching that streak of green lightning whizz by, glorious colors dancing in the air—it reminds him of everything he's fought for.

When the students leave, and he sits alone in the snow outside of UA, he mourns the version of himself that was a little more assured. The version that knew what came next, how to achieve it. A version of himself that followed through on plans, that did things to closer its end goal. He likes to think he'll get back to that person again, that it wasn't ripped from his soul as the embers of his Quirk were.

He stares at the snow, listens as the dorms' doors squeak open one more time. Soft, yellow light leaks out from inside, painting him in its glow.

"Hey, Greenie," Kacchan says, leaning against the doorway. "Come on in."

“I’m supposed to meet Hitoshi at 8…” Midoriya trails off at the amused smirk on Kacchan’s face.

Now it makes sense what Ochaco said. Hitoshi knew that Midoriya would only come to the dorms if he were the one to ask. Any odd chance of running into Kacchan is something Midoriya doesn’t risk. He’s ashamed, embarrassed, sitting in a wheelchair and looking up at him like he always has.

“He’s not here, is he?” Midoriya asks.

Kacchan shakes his head. “Just me and you.”

“Why?” he asks.

Kacchan shrugs, hot air curling from his lips and whirling into the night. He’s got a simple long-sleeve shirt on, likely freezing in the frosty air. Still, he waits at the door. Waits for Midoriya. Would he stand there even if he wheeled away?

Dammit.

“Kacchan… I…” *I can’t talk to you without feeling like I’m weighing you down.*

“Come on, idiot,” Kacchan says softly, no real bite to his words. “I spent all day preparing this gift for you.”

“But—“

“Do I need to push you inside?” Kacchan asks, head tilted. “I will.”

Midoriya huffs before pushing the button on his chair. The tires tread through the snow, spinning and grinding him forward. Kacchan holds the door open wide, letting him squeeze inside and into the warm, heated common space of the dorms. It looks entirely different.

The couches and dining sets have been moved away, replaced by low tables. Atop them is an electric cooker, pots and pans, a mini fridge filled with meats and broths and vegetables, and so many spices it’s hard to count. Then, front and center, is his Mama’s recipe book that he gifted Kacchan. It occurs to him then that all the cooking supplies are what Midoriya bought him years ago.

Soft music clicks on, a Bluetooth speaker set on the mantle above a roaring fire. The air fills with the gentle sound of Christmas music, and Kacchan takes the many gifts piled on Midoriya’s lap and sets them aside. His hands are shaking as he does, fingers struggling to bend.

“You can’t reach the kitchen counters in your wheelchair,” Kacchan says, approaching him again and gesturing to the room. “So I brought the kitchen out here. It should be just below elbow height for you, if the wheelchair measurements from Blondie are right.”

He… brought the kitchen out here?

Midoriya looks at it, swallowing thickly. “You did this for me?”

Kacchan shrugs. “Had to get a shit ton of help from Eyebags since my hands don’t work properly. He set the room up, dealt with me yelling at him the whole time.”

He holds back tears, shakes his head. “Kacchan, I can’t—“

“I haven’t cooked in eight months.” Midoriya looks at him, meets his soft yet serious face. “I can’t hold a knife, I can’t mix ingredients. But you? You can.”

“So?”

“So you’ll be my hands, and I’ll be your legs,” Kacchan says simply, fists in his pockets. “Your legs can’t support your body weight, so you’ve been chained to that chair. But your arms have regained a lot of strength. I checked with Recovery Girl—she cleared this.”

It’s thoughtful. All parts of this operation are so damn thoughtful that he wants to scream. He’s not sure what to say, what to do. This whole time, he had thought Kacchan was waiting for Midoriya to make the first move. Maybe he was. Maybe Midoriya had just forgotten that Kacchan is as impatient as they come, and when he sets his mind to something, he gets it done.

Shame eats at him, embarrassment making his face red. Still, he says, “What are we cooking?”

“Soup,” Kacchan says, “the recipe your mom makes, though it won’t be slow-cooked.”

Midoriya nods, bites his lips. “Okay.”

“First step,” Kacchan says, "Wash your hands.”

He laughs. Kacchan follows him to the sink and guides him, step by step, on how to thoroughly wash his hands. It’s a bit patronizing, but it makes Midoriya feel warm in all the ways he never has before. When it’s done, Kacchan plucks off his All Might beanie so the ears don’t drag through any of the food. He’s insistent that Midoriya’s jacket needs to go next, so the sleeves don’t get gross.

Nervously, Midoriya agrees and tugs the fabric off. It reveals one of Kacchan’s gifts, the full view of it out in the warm air. He spent weeks sketching out the exact shape of Kacchan’s explosive sparks. His Quirk almost looks like thousands of stars, orange and vibrant. So, extending from the handprints on Midoriya’s forearms are hundreds of sparks and stars. He’s not sure why the idea came to mind, but he likes that it did. It turned the destructive burn on his skin into something glorious and beautiful.

Kacchan stares at the tattoo, throat bobbing. “When did you get those?”

“Few days ago,” Midoriya tells him, tracing a finger over the mark. “Give me your hand, you can feel it.”

Kacchan does. Midoriya guides his fingers, drags the print of his hand along the raised and bumpy skin, feeling the tattoo.

“Do you like it?” Midoriya asks.

Kacchan nods. “Doesn’t look totally awful.”

“Such a word with words.”

“Shut up.”

He laughs, eyes trained on Kacchan’s face. He’s gentle, a small smile blooming on his lips. He likes the tattoo, whether he’ll admit it or not. Midoriya doesn’t plan on ever getting those handprints removed, the idea making him sick. But he knows how hard it is for Kacchan to see a mark he left. So he thought if there was any way to turn it into something positive, he’d do it.

“The lady who did it used white and neon orange ink so it would show up on my skin better,” Midoriya tells him, savoring Kacchan’s feather-soft touch. “I wanted them to stand out like you do.”

“God, you’re such a—“ he cuts himself off with a shake of his head. “Always have to one-up me.”

Midoriya winks. “It’s what I’m good at.”

“Wait here,” Kacchan suddenly says, backing away. “I’ve got another gift to torment you with.”

“What! That’s not fair! I only got you two!” Midoriya shouts.

“Boo-hoo.”

Kacchan sprints up the stairs. There’s an echo of him struggling to open his door before he finally gets through to his room. Silence. When he appears again, he’s got another gift in tow. He plops the large box onto Midoriya's lap and grins.

He opens it, eyes wide at the support scarf within. It’s been stitched with reflective, colorful fabric. The whole thing is lit with greens and oranges and blues and reds. It resembles what his Quirk looked like before he lost it, a cacophony of glorious colors and tendrils.

“You are so mean,” Midoriya says, face curling with tears. “I was supposed to have the best gifts this year.”

“You tattooed me forever onto your body and annotated fifteen of my favorite romance mangas,” Kacchan says flatly. “That beats rainbow scarf and miniature kitchen by miles.”

“No, it doesn’t,” Midoroya says, holding the scarf to his face and inhaling the smell of caramel. “I’m going to whoop you next year.”

Next year. Fourteen months from now. Over a year.

Kacchan rolls his eyes. “Yeah, I’m sure you think you will. Let’s go cook now, I’m fucking starving.”

“Kacchan.”

“What?”

“Thank you,” Midoriya says sweetly, smiling wide.

Kacchan looks at him and says, “I love you.”

Midoriya goes white in the face. “Huh?”

“What? You wrote it first months ago, no way in hell was I gonna let you say it first, too. I win.” Kacchan turns away. “Let’s start with flavoring the beef.”

“You can’t just say that and move on!” Midoriya shouts as Kacchan walks away. “I love you more!”

“I love you most,” Kacchan insists. “And that’s just a fact, so let’s not bother going back and forth. Come over here and measure flour, we need to make a breading.”

“That—“ Midoriya rubs his temple. “I’m only dropping this because I’m hungry.”

Kacchan snorts. The two of them spend a good two hours in the kitchen. Cooking is *hard*, and Midoriya is truly awful at it. Kacchan guides him as best he can, and isn’t nice enough not to comment on the uneven chopping of vegetables or meat. No matter how many times he tells Midoriya how to cut food, it doesn’t seem to stick. Regardless, the two of them spend a while bickering and cooking. And it’s absolutely perfect. They argue over the taste of the broth, the skin of the potatoes, the heat of the electric cooker. And the whole time, those words keep rattling through Midoriya.

I love you.

He forgets about the wheelchair, about the shame. Lost in the laughter from them at just how horrible he is in the kitchen. Kacchan sits on the countertop, guiding him and dragging a hand down his face at the painful methods used. Somehow, someway, they come up with a soup at the end of it. They eat it on the couch in the other room, an old All Might movie on TV. The soup is awful, Midoriya may or may not have added too much pepper and garlic and undercooked the potatoes.

They eat it all the same, sitting side by side on that yellow couch. They curl up under a blanket, making jokes about how cheesy the movie is and scooting more and more close together. Midoriya eventually slings an arm over Kacchan’s neck, rests his head against his shoulder.

“I have to go see Christmas lights with Mama,” he tells Kacchan. “You can come, if you’d like.”

“It’s alright, Greenie,” Kacchan says, breathing deeply, his body radiating heat. “That’s a special thing you do with your mom. Go have fun. You know I’m not going anywhere.”

“I’ll be back after,” Midoriya says, slipping off the couch. “We can watch another movie, I’ll even get my onesie.”

“Oh my god,” Kacchan groans.

“You better be wearing yours!” He slides into his chair.

“Fine.”

“Oh, and close your eyes!” Midoriya says suddenly, wheeling forward. Kacchan does without protest, and Midoriya quickly pecks him on the lips. “First kiss since I woke up. I win!”

He wheels away as fast as he can before Kacchan chases him.

When he makes it to Mama’s apartment, it’s with so much joy in his heart that he can’t keep a smile off his face. When Kacchan went out of his way to ensure Midoriya could cook and operate at a comfortable level, while also confessing his own inability to do something he loved, it felt vulnerable. Raw. Honest. Maybe he just needed someone to be as open as he was, their newfound struggle as on display as he is.

Or maybe he just really missed being so close to Kacchan. It’s not as though they’ve been distant, just quiet, patient, and he’s happy that the silence has been breached.

“Hi, baby,” Mama says, kissing his forehead when he wheels inside. “Are you excited for Christmas light hunting?”

He snickers but nods, pushing further into the apartment. Mama’s working on homemade hot cocoa on the stovetop, their colorful Christmas tree glowing from the living room. It’s cozy and warm and so beyond anything he ever thought the two of them could get to. Mama is safe, she quit her day job to go back to school and get a degree like she’s always wanted. She goes to the gym, cooks every day, and has made friends with a few of her classmates. She's *happy.*

It’s not to say she wasn’t happy before—of course she was. But this is a happiness rooted in the core of her being. She is *free.* And while paranoia and abuse symptoms don’t disappear overnight, it’s impossible not to notice the peace radiating off her. He’s still learning how to find that peace that seems to come so easily to others, but he hopes it looks a bit like Mama’s smile.

“Here, Izuku.” She fills a mug up with the hot cocoa, his second cup of it today. He takes it from its spot on the counter and is drowned in the smell and taste of it. Only on rare occasions could they afford hot chocolate, let alone from scratch. But it’s just as good as his old memories of it. Cinnamon-y, spiced with some paprika, milk chocolate warmth.

“Thank you.” He drains the cup, asks for some more, and Mama refills it with a small dip to her smile. “What’s wrong?”

“I… I wanted to talk to you,” she says. When she sits at a barstool by the counter, nervously folding her hands into her lap, he’s immediately on edge.

“What is it?”

Mama takes a deep breath, exhales. “I had you when I was barely eighteen.”

Midoriya listens, his mug warming his hands.

“And I know I’ve done my best to raise you, but I can’t help but feel I might’ve fallen short —“

“Mama—“

“Let me finish,” she says quietly. “Izuku, you've turned into a person that I can’t take all the credit for raising. Somewhere along the line, I got lucky. Because I’ve got a *good* kid, a real good kid.” Mama brushes his hair from his eyes as though he’s still just a baby she held in her arms. “I tell you that I love you, that I trust you, that you’re strong and kind and a thousand other things. But I want you to know, really, that I’m so proud of you, baby.”

Midoriya’s face scrunches a bit, and he fights back tears. “Where’s all this coming from, Mama?”

“I’ve always wanted to say it, I just never worked up the nerve,” she laughs a little, “I admire you. Maybe that’s silly for a parent to say, but it’s true. I’m not sure when, but you became my little Hero. And I wanted you to know that I’m proud of you. I know this isn’t an amazing life, and I’m not some shining star of a person, but I want you to know I'd do it a thousand times over. I wouldn’t change a thing, not if it meant I wouldn’t get to have you.” Mama hesitates, swallows. “And… and I wanted to thank you, too. I know we don’t talk about what happened… but I don’t take what you did lightly. I can’t imagine it was easy.”

He nods, sucking his lips in.

“Oh, baby,” Mama says softly, and the dam breaks.

She wraps her arms around him as best she can, and he cries into her shoulder. He hadn’t known until just then, in this exact moment, that she’s right. It wasn’t easy, shit—it was the most difficult thing he’s ever done. He lost limbs, he lost friends, he lost himself. And he’s stuck trying to piece together these scattered pieces of himself that were dispersed on this journey to fix what was wrong with the world.

He gave Tenko so much shit for not being able to kill Dad, but if he’s honest, Midoriya can’t believe he was able to do it. Not just the physical fight, but the mental turmoil. It would be a lie to say that he didn’t want a dad. One who came home from work and ruffled his hair, or took Mama on dates, or showed up for his school events. And it is so selfish and wrong, but he’s beginning to realize he didn’t want to kill Dad at all.

He just wanted him to hurt, to regret, to feel guilt, to look at his son and decide all of his past never mattered in the face of his child. But it wasn’t enough, and he’s dead, and Midoriya

wishes it didn't have to be this way at all. He wishes Dad weren't the horrible thing he is, and he wishes he weren't the same exact kind of monster that was born from his father's lungs. He breathes in the same violence, the same rage, and instead of a kinship born between two people with the same rotten heart and blackened lungs, these awful creatures emerged instead. Tenko could never kill his Dad, he's not that kind of person. But Midoriya is. He's spent his entire life trying to outrun the reflection in the mirror that he hadn't realized it had already caught up to him.

And it's nice to know that despite all this—someone is proud of him. Proud of all of it. The good and the bad. That they'd go through hell to ensure he stayed the exact way he is now. Mama doesn't know it, but she's his Hero, too. Before All Might, before Kacchan, it was just him and her and a tiny apartment. And it was enough. All he ever really needed was his Mama.

When they look at Christmas lights, and follow carolers around, and watch cheesy Christmas movies, it feels right.

Things feel right.

He goes to the QEP in January. He meets so many children in need of support that it's almost overwhelming. He works with them every day, teaching volunteer courses about Quirk theory and guiding people through theirs.

In February, he and Kacchan spent Valentine's Day binging all seventeen of All Might's movies. They don't even kiss, too immersed in the story and recreating battle scenes and wrestling one another to the ground. Eventually, though, Kacchan does kiss his cheek before midnight, and spends the next few weeks floating about being the first one to kiss him on Valentine's Day. Midoriya pretends to be mad, but he can't help the flush to his face.

March comes around, and Tenko finally makes up his mind. He joins the Heroics course, and one more seat in class is full. He becomes quick friends with Jirou and Hitoshi, and they urge him to pursue psychology. Only when Midoriya drags him to the extra courses does his brother agree to take them, on track to have several college course credits completed and ready to pursue after high school. A Hero and a psychologist, eager to take care of as many kids as humanly possible.

Mama finally tells him about her and All Might in April. She likely knew his mind would be too occupied with planning a surprise party for Kacchan, and another one for Tenko. When she dropped the news, he forgot to act shocked. She was embarrassed, but not as much as All Might—uh—Toshinori, who Midoriya pulled aside to threaten his life if he so much as looked at Mama the wrong way. Everyone showed up to Kacchan's and Tenko's parties, and his boyfriend's heart rate spiked so much that there was concern he was having a heart attack. In reality, he was just very, very happy. It was nice to see him laughing.

May marks the month that Hitoshi *finally* let Denki take him out on a date. Midoriya helped him plan it, insisting a cat cafe and ramen date was the best route to go. Hitoshi told Midoriya later that he didn't mind it much, but Midoriya saw that spark return to Hitoshi's eyes in a way he promised months ago that it would. He found a reason to hang on. Midoriya is still searching.

When June comes around, the whole class goes on a beach retreat. Kota shows up, and Midoriya gets to actually meet the kid under the right circumstances for the first time. Kota called him ‘big brother’ and had insisted he’s going to be a Hero, too. Despite having a Quirk, he wears bright red, Viridant-brand shoes. Turns out, that Quirkless shoe-making brand found a lot of inspiration in Midoriya, asking to sponsor him. Those obnoxious shoes are a trademark, worn by anyone of any size, shape, color, Quirk, religion, or identity. They’re universal, shoes now made to adjust to mutated Quirked feet or a Quirkless person’s extra joint. Inclusive. Welcoming. New.

July, and he was really hoping his birthday would be forgotten. The reality is his first-ever birthday party. He cried through the whole thing like a total baby. Mama took so many pictures that her phone storage maxed out. He set one as his screensaver. It’s taken from the back of the room, all of his news friends, teachers, and family surrounding him and smiling. He doesn’t tell anyone that when he wakes from nightmares, and the footprints are scrubbed off his ceiling, he looks at those photos to calm down. To remember he is alive; he is safe. A reminder that he won, that the monsters are all gone.

Tenko finally agrees to give Himiko Ochaco’s number in August. She only had to beg for half a year until he finally relented and handed it over. The two of them work really well together despite the past bad blood. Ochaco even convinces Himiko to go into the career she’s passionate about, which is social work. She wants to get kids out of bad homes, reform the abusive foster systems, and save children from the same childhood she endured.

September is when Mirio finally comes back into Midoriya’s life. Eri has successfully restored his Quirk, is beyond pleased with herself and eating an apple straight from her tree. His friends, Nejire and Amajiki, absolutely whooped his class in a mock training battle. They exchanged contact information and train together regularly. Midoriya never gathers the strength to tell him the truth, that he let him take a bullet. He’s not sure he ever will. He used his strength to make a call to an old friend instead. When Chikara picks up the phone, and they talk for hours on end, it’s decided that they’ll meet up in Tokyo. He gets to see Chikara’s toddler, to introduce himself to his lovely wife. It reminds him of Rin.

And, finally, one year after he woke up from his coma, Midoriya is again faced with the same dilemma he had twelve months ago. This time, when he contemplates where to go with his life, it’s at a new location. His and Kacchan’s river was fun for camping and hanging around for dates, but it’s not where he needs to be right now.

It’s been… a while. It took him almost two years to work up the courage, to find the will inside him. Even then, it was feeble, difficult to follow through on. But he did it. He asked Aizawa-Sensei, and, with his new cane, hobbled over to the beautiful plot of land in a quiet part of Japan.

The wind blows a gentle October breeze. It rustles his hair, makes his funky tie catch air. Only he remains steady and standing. Even then, it’s weak, wobbly and nervous. But he’s here, he did it.

“Hey,” he says, working his way to the ground. “You were right, you know. I stayed green.”

A fresh new bouquet of flowers. Green, bright, lying atop Rin's grave. His Sensei ensured she was properly buried somewhere with a beautiful view, a Sakura tree drifting lazy leaves down atop her grave. Beside her, taking up the plot of land, is Ito. Beside him, Banri, then Sayori. The graveyard is filled with their families and friends, bones beneath wet dirt.

He spends a long time laying flowers on each and every grave. He cleans off moss from headstones, straightens fallen rock. There are no remaining people to mourn them, no one to care for their plots. So he does. He spends all day doing maintenance, talking about mundane and useless things, explaining his life and how things have changed.

"I still miss you guys," he confesses, sitting before those four graves again. "I blame myself for it all. My therapist is working on self-forgiveness and all that, but I'm not sure it's gonna stick." He reads those young ages on the tombstones. "I don't know if I can spend every day feeling like this."

He's given it thought over this year. He's had good moments—a lot of good moments. But they seem to be overshadowed by this sense of dread, of doom. He's trying, really, to get over this feeling inside him, but he can't seem to shake it. He can't seem to find that spark. He tells the graves this, and maybe his mind is playing tricks on him, because he swears it feels like they're listening. They can't, they're corpses, but that feeling of being heard settles within him. If there's an afterlife, he hopes they can hear him from it, the sound of his apologies and taste his tears.

And he feels it then. This calling, a bump in his heart, a bubble in his lungs, a speckle of paint along his ribs. The urge to move, to act, to do *something.* The spark. It's here, buried beneath abandoned dirt and the memories he can't ever recreate. This whole time, he had been looking for a reason to keep going, when that's the reason itself. If he keeps going, then no one else will get hurt. He's made sure of it, and sticking around makes the world sure of it as well.

A symbol of justice, of peace, of acceptance. He's still got so much more to do. The world isn't yet fixed—he's got to find a way to change so much more. It's not over yet; he's barely scratched the surface.

"I think," Midoriya says, standing with the help of his cane. "That I've decided to live."

He says his goodbyes, promises to visit again soon, and he leaves. He's still sad, still a tad bit too hollow, but that spark ignited once again. Now a flame, bright and glowing, begging him to save and help and do everything he can to make the world better than it was when he found it.

He's not sure what will happen, but he can't wait to see what he'll do next.

The end.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys enjoyed! I tried to line my fic up to end right when the anime ended, lol. Kind of evil, but oh well. Anyway, I am actively writing my own book which is, funny enough, about superheroes. If you're interested in it, follow me on my booktok TikTok @Lauryn.Lyne. If you just want to support me in general, I have a YouTube @LychLaura. I'll probably write another bkdk fanfiction down the line, but I've got no idea what the hell it would be about lmao.

ALSO, if you guys want a bonus chapter or alternative ending written, let me know, and I'll do my best to accommodate that! Thank you so much for reading. I hope you enjoyed it as much as I did. And thank you for the endless support on this fic. I see your comments, and the best part of my day is reading through them and laughing.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!